



PATH 01

Sell an AI playbook

You already know one job well enough to write it down. A stranger will pay to skip the guessing.

39 minute read · 8,653 words

Who this is for

Someone who can explain a single result — a week of content, a client intake, a job application pack — better than a blank chat window.

Time to first

7–21 days if you already know the job

Tools

First sale

A \$19–\$47 download bought by a person who is not you.

Cash window

\$19–\$47 first offer

Leave this alone

Google Docs or Word, Stripe Payment Link or Stan Store, one simple page, a second email to test-buy.

A 200-page 'everything AI' book, fifteen products, or waiting for a course platform.

What this actually is

Definition

A playbook is a job, written so a tired person can finish it without inventing the steps. The buyer is not shopping for inspiration. They are shopping for a sequence they can run this week. You already know one job well enough to write it down. A stranger will pay to skip the guessing.

The file is 8 to 15 chapters. Each chapter is a verb plus an object. Each chapter ends with one next action a tired person can do in 20 minutes. The first chapter is what done looks like. The last chapter is what they do next week. The middle is the work. A template or a paste-ready prompt lives in the file. Price the result, not the page count. A tight 18-page job at \$29 outsells an 80-page tour of your opinions.

What this is not

It is not a course, a community, or a 200-page everything-AI book. It is not a skill pack (that is the installable version). It is not a prompt stack (that is paste-as-you-go). It is the sequence, with prompts and templates inside it. It is not a service with a PDF attached. If you include a call, you just built Productized AI service. Keep the file at \$19 to \$47 and do not include your calendar. You are allowed to use AI to draft. You are not allowed to ship the draft. The money is in the rewrite: your examples, your order, your do-this-next at the end of every chapter.

Why this works now

Generic how-to-use-ChatGPT posts are free and infinite. The remaining gap is a named job for a named person with a named time box. Search is specific. People type 10 Google posts for a landscaper, not AI content system. Title-match is the distribution. Narrow is the moat. Models still stall. They still write a brochure when the buyer needed a caption. The playbook is the freeze of the sequence a careful person would run every time, if they had two extra hours,

which they do not. You do not need a following. You need one finished result you can explain in plain English.

Anti-pattern 1: the everything-AI book

A 200-page tour of tools and mindset is a hobby. Nobody runs chapter one on Tuesday. Cut it to one job. If you need and to name the result, you have two products. Split them. Sell the one you can finish this week.

Anti-pattern 2: shipping the draft

A pasted ChatGPT article with a cover is the fastest way to a refund. The buyer can get a draft for free. They cannot get your order, your examples, and a next action at the end of every chapter. If a chapter does not end with a next action, it is an essay. Cut it or finish it.

Anti-pattern 3: waiting for a course platform

A course platform is how people delay chapter one. You need Google Docs, a Payment Link, and ten messages. After a stranger has bought, you can put the same file on a nicer page. Not before.

The deal you keep

You keep three promises. One: a stranger can finish chapter one without you in the room. Two: every chapter ends with one next action, and the file has one real example plus one thing they can copy. Three: the checkout title matches the one-sentence offer, the price is on the page, and you have bought the file yourself from a second email. If chapter one does not survive a tired Sunday, the playbook is not a product.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

Fits if

This path fits if you have done a job more than three times and can name what went wrong the first time. That scar tissue is the product. People pay for the mistakes you already made.

You can explain a single result better than a blank chat window: a week of content, a client intake, a job application pack, a month-end close. You do not need a following. You need one finished result in plain English. You can send ten personal messages without a broadcast. You can take \$19 to \$47 without apologizing.

Skip if

Skip this path if you have never finished a result for anyone, including yourself. Write the playbook after you have a result, not as a way to avoid getting one. If you need cash this week, use a service path first (Productized AI service or Local businesses + AI), then turn the notes into this playbook. Skip if your title would be The AI Playbook with no job in it. Skip if you planned to write 80 pages of theory. Skip if you want a course platform before chapter one exists. Skip if you freeze at \$19 and want to start at \$297 with no proof.

The honest middle

If you have done the job twice and the third time is this week, capture that run as you do it. The playbook is the notes, cleaned. You are not waiting to become an expert. You are waiting to have a sequence you would hand a tired friend. You do not have to be the owner. The person who actually writes the posts or closes the month is enough if you can name what went wrong the first time.

Skills and time

Skills: name a job in one line. Outline 8 to 15 chapters as verb plus object. Rewrite a draft in kitchen-table English. Export a PDF. Make a Payment Link. Send ten messages.

Time if you already know the job: 7 to 21 days. Two evenings to outline. Four to draft. Two to rewrite and export. One evening for checkout, self-buy, and ten asks. If you only have 45 minutes a night, three chapters a night for four nights is the draft. Budget: \$0 if you already have Docs or Word and a way to take \$19.

Two-minute self-test

Answer these out loud. If you stall on two of them, this is not your first path this month.

What is the job in one line, in the buyer's words?

What does done look like as a file or a week of work, not a feeling?

What went wrong the first time you did this job?

Who is the specific person, plus one constraint?

Who are ten people you can message this week without a blast?

Can you finish an ugly draft in two weeks without research you have not done?

If you have the job, the done, the scar, and ten names, start tonight. If you only have I like AI, go finish a result first.

The buyer on the other side

A tired person who already tried the blank window. They have 20 minutes after dinner. They will pay \$19 to \$47 to skip inventing the order. They will judge you on chapter one and chapter two, not on your cover.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this before you outline

Write this sentence before you outline: I help [specific person] get [named result] in [time] using [named tools], even if [honest objection]. If you cannot fill the brackets, you do not have an offer yet.

Specific person is a job plus a constraint. Named result is a file or a week of work, not a feeling. Time is days or hours. Named tools are what they already have. Honest objection is why they have not done it. Put the sentence at the top of the Doc. Put a shortened version in the checkout title. If you need and to name the result, you have two products. Split them. Sell the one you can finish this week.

Sentences that work

I help one-person landscapers get 10 Google-ready posts in 10 days using ChatGPT and photos they already have, even if they hate writing and only have 20 minutes at night.

I help solo accountants close the month in Claude with a checklist they can rerun, even if their books are messy.

I help realtors write listing descriptions that do not sound like brochures, in one sitting, using the MLS notes they already typed.

I help freelance designers run a client intake in one evening using a form and a follow-up email they can reuse, even if they lose notes in chat.

I help career-switchers ship a job application pack (resume, three bullets, a short note) in one weekend using ChatGPT and their last three roles, even if they freeze on the summary.

Write yours in that shape. One person. One result. One time box. One even-if. Price the result, not the page count.

What they get

A PDF. Eight to 15 chapters, verb-plus-object titles, each ending with a next action. A cover that states the job. Page numbers. Your email on the last page. One template or prompt they can copy. One real example per chapter, names blurred. A 10-day or 14-day plan if the job is a sequence across days. Price \$19 to \$47 on the first file. They get the order, the examples, and the next action. They get a refund line with no speech.

What they do not get

A course. A community. A call. A 200-page book. Five bonuses. Lifetime updates you will not ship. Access to a model. A membership. Your calendar. If they want the sequence installed so the first message is raw material, that is Ship a Claude or ChatGPT skill pack, after this file has a stranger sale. If they want you to do the job, that is Productized AI service. Do not hide a service inside a \$29 PDF.

Packaging

One product, one price, one file. Stripe Payment Link or Stan. Title matches the one-sentence offer. Description is five lines: who, result, time, what is in the file, price. Filename a tired person

can find later: landscaper-10-day-content-playbook.pdf. Cover: the job, the person, the time, the price. First playbooks sell at \$19 to \$47. Raise to \$67 to \$97 when the file has templates, scripts, and a 14-day plan. Do not start at \$297.

One sentence, one product

If you need and to name the result, split. 10 posts is a product. 10 posts and a lead magnet and a Google Business setup is three products. Sell the one you can finish this week. The second file is allowed after a stranger has used the first.

What "done" looks like

Definition

The playbook is done when a stranger can finish chapter one without you in the room. That is the bar. Everything else is decoration.

Done also means: 8 to 15 chapters, each a verb plus an object, each ending with one next action. A cover that states the job. Page numbers. Your email on the last page. A template or prompt they can copy. One real example per chapter, names blurred. Checkout works: you bought it from a second email on a phone and the file opened. Ten personal messages sent. At least one person who is not you owning the file.

The fairness test

Would you sell this to a tired friend who does that job, at \$29, without a speech and without hopping on a call? If you would discount it or offer to walk them through, it is not fair yet. Fair means they can open chapter two at 9 p.m. and do a 20-minute task. Fair means the title matches the file. Fair means a refund in one sentence if it is not useful. Read a chapter to someone who does the job. If they ask so what do I do, rewrite it. If they say I can do that tonight, keep it.

The bar for the file

First chapter is what done looks like, as a file or a week of work. Last chapter is what they do next week. Middle chapters are the work. If a chapter is Why AI matters, delete it. They already bought. Every chapter: one point, one example, one next action. Working files where they can steal them: a box, a back page, a second PDF in the zip. Same words in the title, the checkout, and the first paragraph.

The bar for the checkout and the first week

One product, one price, one file. Title matches the one-sentence offer. Price on the page. Refund line on the page. You have bought it from a second email on a phone. The PDF opens. Filename is human. Ten personal messages sent, at least one person who is not you owning the file, and a note of what they used. That note becomes the next post. If nobody has the file yet, send the next three messages before you rewrite the cover.

Not-done-yet list

- A title with no job in it
- Chapters that are essays with no next action
- No template or prompt they can copy
- Examples from a different trade, or no examples
- Checkout untested
- Price hidden behind DM me
- You have not sent ten asks
- A second product started before a stranger sale
- Hype you would not say at a kitchen table
- You included a call to make it feel premium

If three of those are true, you have a draft. Keep going. The first buyer is not your editor.

Pricing that holds

Ranges

\$19 is a coffee-and-a-tip price. People will try it if the job is named. \$29 is the default first playbook if you include a template or a prompt block. \$47 is fair when there is a 10-day or 14-day plan plus scripts. Put the price on the page. Pick \$29 or \$47 and sit there until a stranger has bought. Stay in the \$19 to \$47 window on the first file. Do not do \$9 to get traction. You will attract collectors, not operators. Do not price by word count.

Why \$29 is the honest default

It is small enough that a tired person will try it to skip a Sunday night. It is large enough that you will answer a support email. If you are ashamed of \$29, you either overbuilt or you do not believe the job is real. Cut the file, or run the job yourself one more time. Round numbers. Price on the button.

When to raise

Raise after a stranger sale and a sentence from them about what they used. Then add the missing template or a 14-day calendar and move to \$67 to \$97. Raise because the file does more, not because you got bored of \$29. Add one working file, not five bonuses. Email the extra page free to people who already paid \$29. Do not start at \$297. Do not add a \$97 with a call on day one unless you mean to run Productized AI service instead.

Refunds in one sentence

If it is not useful, email me and I will refund.

You will refund almost nobody if the first chapter works. Refund with no speech. Then ask what they expected. If two people say the same thing, you fix that chapter. Refunds are cheaper than a reputation for arguing.

What you never charge

Never charge extra for lifetime updates you will not ship. Never charge a setup call inside the \$29. Never charge a second time for v1.1 when a prompt needed one extra line; email it. Never charge \$9. Never hide the price. Never price by page count.

Worked dollars

Dana sells the landscaper playbook at \$29. Day 3 she sends ten texts. Two people she knows buy that night: \$58. A stranger buys on day 11 from a before-and-after post: \$29. Three more in week 3: \$87. One refund from someone who wanted a social media agency in a PDF: minus \$29. She clarifies the title. Month 1 cash is about \$145 after the refund. That is the path. Not a launch. A named job with a working checkout. If she had started at \$297, she would have zero sales. \$29 is the door.

The first 72 hours

Day 1 morning: pick and name

Pick the buyer and the result. Write the one-sentence offer. If you have two ideas, pick the one you can finish without research you have not done. Put the sentence at the top of a Google Doc. Do not survey social media. Do not build a waitlist. One buyer, one result, one sentence. Write it on a sticky note in the buyer's words. If it takes more than one line, it is two products. Split it.

Day 1 afternoon: gather the scars

Collect the raw material you already have: old emails, checklists, prompts that worked, screenshots of a finished result. Dump it under Raw. If the pile is empty, you do not have 72 hours. Run the job this week and capture as you go. Name what went wrong the first time.

Day 1 night: outline like a tired person

Outline 8 to 15 chapters. Each chapter title is a verb plus an object: Write the three hooks. Set the checkout. Send the ten messages. Put a next action under each. First chapter: what done looks like. Last chapter: what they do next week. Middle chapters are the work. If a chapter is Why AI matters, delete it.

Paste this if you want a starting outline, then rewrite every title in your voice:

You are outlining a paid playbook, not a blog. Buyer: [person]. Result they can finish: [result]. Time: [days]. Tools they already have: [tools]. Honest objection: [objection]. Give me 12 chapter

titles as verb + object. Under each, one next action a tired person can do in 20 minutes. No hype. No mindset chapters.

Stop at midnight. You have a sentence, a pile, and an outline. That is a good day.

Day 2: ugly draft, then human

Draft ugly. Use AI for a first pass if you want, then rewrite every paragraph in the voice you would use to a friend at a kitchen table. Cut hype. Keep the steps. Leave holes marked HOLE rather than stopping to research a tool you do not use. Do not format. Do not design a cover. Words first. Keep one example per chapter from real work. End every chapter with one next action. End day 2 with a complete ugly draft, holes marked. Empty chapters are not allowed.

Day 3: rewrite, checkout, ten asks

Rewrite out loud. Add one template and one prompt block. Put the checklist on its own page at the back. If a hole needs a tool you do not use, cut the chapter. Export a clean PDF. Number the chapters. Put your email on the last page.

One product, one price, one file. Stripe Payment Link or Stan. Title matches the one-sentence offer. Buy it yourself from a second email, different browser, on a phone. If the download fails, nothing else matters. Then send ten messages to people who already know you. Not a broadcast. I wrote this for [job]. \$29. If it is useful: [link]. If not, ignore. That is the whole 72 hours.

One buyer, one result, one sentence

8-15 chapters that each end with a next action

Ugly complete draft, then a human rewrite

Working checkout, self-purchase, ten asks

The path, step by step

Step 1. Name the job on a sticky note

If it takes more than one line, it is two products. Split it. Write it in the buyer's words. 10 Google-ready posts for a one-person landscaper is a job. Content system for small businesses is a vibe. Put the sticky note at the top of the Doc.

Step 2. Write the one-sentence offer

I help [specific person] get [named result] in [time] using [named tools], even if [honest objection]. Fill every bracket. This sentence is the cover, the checkout title, and the first line of every message. Do not outline before it exists.

Step 3. Collect the raw material you already have

Old emails, checklists, prompts that worked, screenshots of a finished result. Dump it under Raw. You will mine it, not show it. What went wrong the first time is a chapter. What you do every Sunday night is the spine.

Step 4. Outline for a reader who is tired

First chapter: what done looks like. Last chapter: what they do next week. Middle chapters are the work. 8 to 15 chapters. Each title is a verb plus an object. Each has one next action a tired person can do in 20 minutes. If a chapter is Why AI matters, delete it. If you cannot name the next action, you have an essay.

Step 5. Draft ugly, words first

Do not format yet. Do not design a cover. Leave holes marked HOLE rather than stopping to research a tool you do not use. A complete ugly draft beats a perfect chapter one. If you only have 45 minutes a night, three chapters a night for four nights.

Step 6. Rewrite for voice

Read a page out loud. If you would not say it, delete it. Kitchen table, not conference stage. Short sentences. Named tools. Named times. Keep one example per chapter from real work. Blur names. Keep texture. If a paragraph could run in a motivational clip, cut it.

Step 7. Add the working files

A template, a prompt block, a checklist. Buyers pay more when they can copy, not just read. Put the checklist on its own page at the back. If the working file is in a second download, half your buyers will never open it.

Step 8. Export a clean PDF

Number the chapters. Put your email on the last page. Filename: landscaper-10-day-content-playbook.pdf. Open it on your phone. If the font is tiny or the prompt boxes break, fix the Doc, export again. Cover states the job. No twelve-page brand story.

Step 9. Build the checkout

Stripe Payment Link or Stan. Title matches the one-sentence offer. Description is five lines: who, result, time, what is in the file, price. Price on the page. Refund line on the page. One product. If the page is a menu of six ideas, cut it back to this playbook.

Step 10. Test-buy from a second email

Different browser, different email, on a phone. Confirm the file arrives and opens. If the download never arrives, fix that before you send a single ask. This step feels small. It is the whole business on day three.

Step 11. Write ten names, then send ten personal messages

Not a broadcast. People who already know you or do the job. I wrote this for [job]. \$29. If it is useful: [link]. If not, ignore. First sale is allowed to be someone you know. Which chapter did you actually do is better than Did you like it.

Step 12. After the first stranger sale, ask what they used

That sentence becomes your next ten posts. Teach one chapter, three times. Soft link. Do not write book two. Fix the first trip-up: a broken download, a prompt that needed one extra line, a chapter that assumed they had a desktop.

Step 13. Fix, version, email

If two buyers trip on the same chapter, rewrite that chapter this week. Bump a line on the last page: v1.1, date. Email the people who already bought. Do not add five bonuses. Do not redesign the cover instead of fixing the chapter.

Step 14. Raise only when the file does more

After a stranger sale and a used-chapter sentence, add the missing template or a 14-day calendar. Move new sales to \$47 or \$67. Email the extra free to people who already paid. Raise because the file does more, not because you got bored of \$29.

Step 15. Only then consider a second product

A prompt stack if they say can I just have the prompt. A skill pack if they say I want this inside Claude. A template if they want the checklist as a filled file. Not before a stranger has bought and used a chapter.

Step 16. Stop

Do not add a membership so you can delay shipping. Do not open a course platform. Do not start book two because week 3 felt quiet. Quiet is usually ten more asks and a clearer title, not a second file. Ship at the bar. Fix after the first ten asks.

A worked example

Dana, one-person landscaping companies, \$29

Dana already writes a few Google posts for her own company when she remembers. She is not a content person. She is a person who got tired of a blank chat window every Sunday night. She writes a playbook called 10 days of Google-ready posts for a one-person landscaping company. Price: \$29. File: one PDF plus a one-page caption template.

Her one sentence: I help one-person landscapers get 10 Google-ready posts in 10 days using ChatGPT and job photos they already have, even if they hate writing and only have 20 minutes

at night.

Calendar: days 1 to 21

Day 1: sticky note, dump old captions and photos into Raw, 12 chapter titles as verb plus object.
 Days 2 to 4: ugly draft. She uses a model for first passes, then rewrites at the kitchen table after dinner. She will not teach a scheduler she does not use. Day 5: rewrite out loud. She cuts a chapter on personal branding. Day 6: caption template, batch prompt, checklist. Export PDF.
 Filename: landscaper-10-day-content-playbook.pdf.

Day 7: Stripe Payment Link titled the same as the sentence. She buys it from her other Gmail on her phone. The PDF opens. Night: ten texts to owners she had swapped trailers with, a local Facebook group she already helps, her cousin who runs a lawn crew, and old clients who ask how she does the posting.

What she put in the file

Twelve chapters, each with a next action:

What done looks like — 10 posts scheduled, each with a photo, a caption, and a phone-number line.

Pull 10 photos off your phone from jobs you finished this month.

Pick three post types only: before/after, this-week offer, FAQ.

Write the three hooks you will reuse.

Turn one finished job into a before/after caption.

Write the this-week offer without sounding cheap.

Write the FAQ post that answers why does this cost that.

Paste the batch prompt and generate the other seven captions.

Put the phone number in the last line of every post. Same line, every time.

The 10-day calendar (which post, which photo, which morning).

What to do when nobody comments (you still posted; call three old clients).

What you do next week (repeat the same three types; do not invent a fourth).

She included one prompt they paste with a photo description and a price, and a caption template with blanks. She did not include a module on personal branding.

How she sold the first copies, with dollars

The text: I put a short playbook up for one-person landscaping companies that need 10 Google posts. One file, \$29, instant download. If that is useful: [link]. If not, no need to reply.

Two people she knew bought on day 7. \$58. She asked which chapter they actually did. One said chapter 5, the before/after caption. Day 11: she posted one before/after from her own yard with the last line I wrote the 10-day sequence I use. \$29. Link in bio. A stranger bought. \$29. First stranger sale. Chapter 5 became her next five posts. Two more sales in week 3: \$58. One person asked for a refund because they wanted her to post for them. She refunded \$29 with no speech. She added one line to the listing: this is a file, not a social media manager.

Week 4: she fixed the batch prompt with one extra line: do not invent a discount I did not type. She emailed v1.1 to the five people who had bought. She did not write book two. Month 1: six sales at \$29, one refund. Net \$145. Not a launch. A named job.

The mistake and the recovery

On day 9 a buyer said chapter 8 assumed they had a desktop. They work from a phone in the truck. Dana rewrote the paste steps for mobile, exported, emailed both buyers. That is v1.1. The chapter got usable in a truck. She did not add a bonus video.

Shipped artifact: a 22-page PDF, 12 chapters, caption template, batch prompt, checklist. She asks every buyer which chapter they used. Chapter 5 stays the public example. She still has not written the irrigation-estimate playbook. Nobody asked for it.

Copy you can actually send

Swap the job. Keep the constraints. Do not add hype. Paste these as they are. Fill the brackets. Send.

DM (text or email)

I put a short playbook live for [job]. One file, \$29, instant download. If that is useful: [link]. If not, no need to reply.

Post

Blank chat is expensive. I wrote the sequence I actually use for [result]. \$29. Link in bio.

This is 10 days of posts for a one-person [trade], written so you can do it after dinner. \$29. Not another AI dump.

Listing title and body

Title: [Job] in [time] — a playbook for [person], not another AI dump.

Body, five lines:

Who it is for: [person].

What they finish: [result] in [time].

What they get: a PDF with [N] chapters, a paste-ready prompt, and a checklist.

What they need: [named tools], no extra subscriptions.

Price: \$29. Instant download. Email me if it is not useful and I will refund.

Email to people who already know you

Subject: the [job] sequence, written down

I got tired of explaining this in pieces, so I wrote a short playbook. It is the order I actually use for [result], including the prompt and the checklist. \$29, one file.

If you want it: [link].

If you do not, delete this. I will not follow up.

Email after a stranger sale (ask what they used)

Subject: which chapter did you actually do?

If you bought the [job] playbook, reply with the chapter you used. I will fix anything that tripped you. If you have not started, chapter two is a 20-minute task. That is the whole point.

Reply: I can just ask ChatGPT

You can. The playbook is the order, the examples from [job], and the next action at the end of each chapter so you do not stall at a blank window. If you already have a sequence you like, you do not need this. If you keep starting over, \$29 is cheaper than another Sunday night.

Reply: I do not have time to read a book

It is [N] short chapters. Chapter one is what done looks like. Chapter two is a 20-minute task. If you cannot do chapter two this week, wait.

Reply: Can you just do this for me?

This file is the sequence. I do not include a call at \$29. If you want someone to do the job, that is a service at a different number. I will refund you if you bought thinking I would post for you.

Refund

You asked for a refund. Here it is, no speech. If a chapter tripped you, tell me the number. I will fix the file for everyone else. The refund is already processing.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Assume evenings. This is four weeks to a used playbook, not a content brand. No public launch in week 1.

Week 1: outline and ugly draft

Monday: sticky note, one sentence, ten names written down. Do not send yet. Tuesday: outline 8 to 15 chapters with next actions. First chapter is done. Last chapter is next week. Wednesday through Saturday: ugly draft. Three chapters a night if you have 45 minutes. Holes marked HOLE. Do not open Canva. Sunday: complete ugly draft in one file. Do not list 9 chapters. Keep going.

Week 2: rewrite, templates, checkout, ten asks

Monday: rewrite out loud. Cut hype. Keep one example per chapter. Tuesday: add one template and one prompt block. Checklist on the last page. Export PDF. Open it on your phone.

Wednesday: Stripe or Stan. Title matches the sentence. Price \$29. Test-buy from a second email on your phone. Thursday and Friday: ten personal messages. First sale is allowed to be someone you know. Ask which chapter they did. Saturday: one public post with a photo of the finished job, not the cover, if you are public. If you are not, send three more personal messages. Sunday: ten asks should be done. Do not redesign the cover instead. Do not add a second product this week.

Week 3: teach one chapter, three times

Three posts or emails that teach one chapter. Soft link. If you are not public, send three more personal messages instead of posts. Ask every buyer which chapter they used. Fix whatever they tripped on the same week. If refunds say I thought you would post for me, the listing is the bug. Do not write book two. Do not raise the price yet.

Week 4: fix, do not expand

Fix whatever the first buyers tripped on. A broken download. A prompt that needed one extra line. A chapter that assumed they had a desktop. Email v1.1 to people who bought. If nobody bought, send ten new asks, then look at the title. The title is usually the problem, not the prose. A 14-day calendar only if they ask. \$29 stays, or \$47 for the file-plus-calendar. Email the extra page free to people who already paid \$29. Plan a second playbook only after a stranger has used a chapter.

Quality bar

Voice

Kitchen table, not conference stage. Short sentences. Named tools. Named times. If a paragraph could run in a motivational clip, cut it. Read the first page to someone who does the job. I could do that means you passed.

Structure

Every chapter: one point, one example, one next action. Put the working files where they can steal them. Number the chapters. Use the same words in the title, the checkout, and the first paragraph. First chapter is what done looks like. Last chapter is next week. No mindset chapter.

Proof inside the file

One real example per chapter beats five generic screenshots. Blur names. Keep the texture: the actual price, the actual photo description, the bad first draft and the good second. Do not invent a dramatic client story.

Test 1: the next-action test

Open the PDF at a random chapter. If you cannot find one next action a tired person can do in 20 minutes, that chapter fails. Fix it before you advertise.

Test 2: the kitchen-table test

Read a page out loud. If you would not say it to a friend after dinner, delete it. Hype fails this test. Named tools and named times pass.

Test 3: the stranger-chapter-one test

Hand chapter one to someone who does the job. Do not hover. If they can finish it without you in the room, you passed. If they ask so what do I do, rewrite it. This is the bar this path names.

Test 4: the phone test

Open the PDF on a phone. Font readable. Prompt boxes intact. If chapter two assumes a desktop they do not have, rewrite the steps for mobile. Dana's buyer in the truck is the test.

Test 5: the claims test

No promise that the playbook replaces a license, an accountant, a lawyer, or a clinician. No guaranteed leads. Operational sequence only. Refund the person who bought a fantasy.

Below the bar

An essay with no next action. A ChatGPT paste with a cover. A title with no job. A call hidden in \$29. Five bonuses and no core file. If a tired person cannot start chapter two tonight, it is below the bar.

Metrics that matter (and vanity numbers to ignore)

Count these

Checkout works: self-purchase from a second email, file opens on a phone.

Messages sent: ten in the first 72 hours, then ten more if nobody bought.

Sales from people who are not you. One stranger sale is the real start.

Which chapter did you use answers. That sentence is your next post.

Refunds. If you get more than one in the first ten sales, chapter one is unclear or the title oversold.

Trip-ups fixed and v1.1 emailed.

Week 1

Count: sentence exists, chapters outlined, ugly draft complete. If the draft is not complete, you do not have a product yet. Do not count cover drafts.

Day 30

Count personal messages (target 10 in week 2, then a few each week). Sales. Stranger sales as a subset. Chapter-used-first. Refunds with a one-word reason. A healthy day-30: complete file, working checkout, 10+ asks, 1+ stranger sale, 0–1 refunds.

Day 90

Count v1.1 shipped (yes/no). Second product (should still be no, unless a stranger asked for the next job). Cash in the \$19 to \$47 window, totaled. If you have \$0 at day 90, the failure is usually title, unsent asks, or chapter one that does not survive a tired Sunday. It is rarely the market.

Ignore these

Landing page visits with no checkout. Follower counts. Cover polish. Word count. A playbook with 12 visitors and three sales is healthy. A playbook with 2,000 visitors and zero sales has a broken offer or a broken title.

A simple weekly log

One line a week: date, messages sent, sales, stranger sales, refunds, one buyer sentence, version number. If the buyer sentence is always empty, you are not asking. Ask.

Objections you will hear

I can get this free from ChatGPT

Plain answer: they can get a draft. They cannot get your order of operations, your examples from this job, and a next action at the end of every chapter. If they already have that sequence, they should not buy. If they keep staring at a blank window, \$29 is the sequence.

I do not know if I am qualified to write this

If you have done the job three times and can name what went wrong the first time, you are qualified for a \$19 to \$47 playbook. You are not applying to teach a university course. You are handing a tired person the notes you wish you had.

Nobody will pay for a PDF

People pay for PDFs every day when the job is named and the checkout is simple. Name the person, the result, and the time. Put the price on the page. Ask ten people.

I need a course platform / a big list / a funnel

You need Google Docs, a Payment Link, and ten messages. A course platform is how people delay chapter one. After a stranger has bought, you can put the same file on a nicer page. Not before.

What if they want a refund

You refund them. One sentence. Then you ask what they expected. If two people say the same thing, you fix that chapter. Refunds are cheaper than a reputation for arguing.

I do not have time to write a book

You are not writing a book. You are writing 8 to 15 short chapters that each end with a 20-minute task. Two evenings to outline. Four to draft. Two to rewrite and ship.

Can I just charge \$97 on day one if I include a call

You can, but you just built a service with a PDF attached. Keep the file at \$19 to \$47 and do not include your calendar. If you want to get paid this week with your time, use Productized AI service and come back.

My niche is too small

Small is the point. How to use ChatGPT sits in a pile of free posts. A 10-day content system for a one-person landscaping company is a product. Ten people who do the job are enough to start.

What if someone copies it

They might. They will not have your examples, your scars, or your next actions from this job. Ship anyway.

I should wait until it feels ready

Ready is a stranger finishing chapter one without you in the room. Ship at that bar. Fix after the first ten asks. Waiting is how the everything-AI book gets to page 80 with no checkout.

How this feeds other paths

Upstream: what you need before this

You need a result you have finished more than twice, including for yourself. If you have never finished the job, take a productized service job or a local-business week first. Capture as you go. Then write.

Products that grow out of the same notes

The playbook is often the first product because it is the sequence in your head, written down. The same notes become Niche prompt stacks (the prompt blocks, sold on their own), Ship a Claude or ChatGPT skill pack (the instructions, installed so they never paste again), and AI templates and SOPs (the checklist as a filled file). Do not split them until the playbook has a stranger sale. If they say can I just have the prompt, that is a prompt stack. If they say I want this inside Claude, that is a skill pack.

Distribution that uses the same chapters

AI-assisted short-form: each chapter is a 20-second video. Teach chapter 5. Sell the playbook. A weekly AI letter: one chapter taught, one link to the file. Your front door: a diagnostic that tells them which chapter they need, then the playbook.

Services and later products

Local businesses + AI and Productized AI service are how you get paid while the playbook is still a draft — do the job once for a nearby owner, then write what you did. A small AI membership comes after, when you have updates worth a monthly. Do not open all of those doors this month. Finish the playbook.

What not to feed yet

A membership. A 200-page book. Thirty days, one playbook, one job in the title. After a stranger uses a chapter, the next path is the one they asked for.

Mistakes that kill this path

I. Writing for entrepreneurs

That is not a buyer. Recovery this week: pick a job. Put that word in the title. Share in that room.

2. Writing 80 pages of theory

Recovery this week: cut to 8 to 15 chapters that each end with a next action. Ship the job.

3. Shipping a ChatGPT paste

Recovery this week: rewrite out loud. Add one real example per chapter. Add a next action. If you cannot, do not list it.

4. Hiding the price

Recovery this week: put \$29 on the page. Remove DM me. Send ten asks with the number in the message.

5. Launching with five bonuses and no core file

Recovery this week: ship the one file. Archive the bonuses.

6. Waiting until it feels ready

Recovery this week: apply the chapter-one test tonight. If a stranger can finish it, export and send ten asks. If they cannot, rewrite chapter one.

7. Naming it The AI Playbook with no job in the title

Recovery this week: rename. 10 days of Google-ready posts for a one-person landscaping company. Same file, new title, same \$29.

8. Building a course platform before a PDF

Recovery this week: export the PDF. Payment Link. Self-buy. Ten asks.

9. Adding a membership so you can delay shipping

Recovery this week: close the membership draft. Finish chapter 12. Ship v1.0.

10. Redesigning the cover four times

Recovery this week: a cover that states the job is enough. Send the next three messages before you touch the cover again.

11. Putting your whole catalog in the listing

Recovery this week: one product, one price, one file. Move the other ideas to a note.

12. Using someone else's examples from a different trade

Recovery this week: replace every example with one from the job you actually do. Blur names. Keep texture. If you have no examples, run the job this week and capture.

13. Assuming a desktop they do not have

Recovery this week: open your own PDF on a phone. Rewrite any step that needs a sidebar they will never open. Email v1.1.

14. Starting book two before a stranger sale

Recovery this week: close the other draft. Ask the people who already bought which chapter they used. Fix that one. Send ten new asks.

The bar, again

The playbook is ready when a stranger can finish chapter one without you in the room. Ship at that bar. Fix after the first ten asks. Do not invent a dramatic client story. Do not scrape someone else's captions.

Tools and how you actually use them

Writing

Google Docs or Word. One document. The model you already use is enough for the ugly draft. The rewrite is you. Export PDF. Open it on your phone. If the font is tiny or the prompt boxes

break, fix the Doc, export again. Filename a human can find. Reply-to on the last page. One Doc from sticky note to export.

Checkout

Stripe Payment Link or Stan Store. One product. Title equals the offer sentence, shortened. After payment, the file. You do not need a full site. Put the refund line on the page. Put the price on the page.

The second email

Create it before you launch. Buy your own product. If the download never arrives, fix that before you send a single ask. This step feels small. It is the whole business on day three.

What not to buy

A course platform. A funnel builder. Ads. A designer for a cover that hides the job. A membership tool. You are selling a \$29 PDF.

The \$0 path

Docs or Word you already have. A model free tier is enough to draft if you already use one.

Checkout: Stripe Payment Link (cost per sale) or Stan if you already have an account. Export PDF from Docs. Share with ten people you already know.

Setup order

Open a Doc. Title with the job. Paste the one-sentence offer at the top. Outline 8 to 15 chapters. Draft. Rewrite. Add the template and the prompt. Export PDF. Create the payment link with that PDF. Buy it from the second email on a phone. Then send ten asks. Do not compare six checkouts.

Ship checklist

Before anyone else sees it

One-sentence offer with all five brackets filled

Sticky note in the buyer's words, one line

8-15 chapters, verb + object titles, each ending with a next action

First chapter is what done looks like; last chapter is next week

No Why AI matters chapter

One real example per chapter, names blurred, texture kept

One prompt they can paste

One template they can copy

One checklist on its own back page

Rewrite read out loud; hype cut

Kitchen-table test passed on page one

PDF opens on a phone; font readable; prompt boxes intact

Email on the last page

Filename a tired person can find later

Cover states the job, the person, and the time

Before you send the ten asks

Checkout title matches the offer

Price on the page (\$19-\$47)

Refund line on the page

Five-line listing: who, result, time, what is in the file, price

Bought from a second email, different browser

File arrived and opened on a phone

Ten names written down

Message copied, link tested

No second product, no bonus pile

No call included in the \$29

After the first sale

Ask: which chapter did you actually use?

Fix the first trip-up the same week

Email v1.1 to people who bought

Teach one used chapter, three times

Do not start book two

Log: date, messages, sales, stranger sales, refunds, buyer sentence

Raise only when the file does more

FAQ

Do I need a big audience?

No. You need ten people who already know you or do the job, a working checkout, and a file that survives chapter one without you.

How long should it be?

Long enough that a tired person can finish the job, short enough that they will start tonight. Most first playbooks are 12-25 pages including the checklist. If you are at 80 pages, you wrote essays. Cut or split.

Can I use AI to write the whole thing?

You can use it to draft. You cannot ship the draft. The buyer is paying for your order, your examples, and your next actions. A pasted ChatGPT article with a cover is the fastest way to a refund.

What if I do not have screenshots or old emails?

Run the job once this week for yourself or for one person. Capture as you go. If you cannot run the job this week, this is not your path yet. Do a service job, then write.

Stripe or Stan?

Either. Stripe Payment Link is enough if you are comfortable with a raw link. Stan is enough if you want the page and the file in one place. Pick one tonight. Do not compare six platforms.

Should I put it on Etsy or Gumroad too?

Not in week one. Sell where you can send a link to ten people. After a stranger sale, you can add a marketplace if the title matches how people search.

What do I do after ten asks and zero sales?

Ask one of the ten: Was the job wrong, the price wrong, or the timing wrong? Then look at the title. Most first misses are a vague title. Rewrite the sentence. Send ten new asks. Do not rewrite the whole PDF yet.

Can I charge \$97 on day one if I include a call?

You can, but you just built a service with a PDF attached. If you want the playbook path, keep the file at \$19 to \$47 and do not include your calendar. If you want to get paid this week with your time, use Productized AI service and come back.

When do I write the second playbook?

After a stranger has bought the first, told you what they used, and you have fixed the trip-ups. Then only if they ask for the next job.

Is a playbook the same as a prompt pack?

No. A playbook is the sequence, with prompts inside it. A prompt stack is the prompts, with a one-page SOP for which to use when. Dana wrote a playbook because landscapers needed the 10-day order, not 200 clever lines.

How many chapters do I need?

Eight to 15. Under eight, you probably hid the work. Over 15, you probably wrote essays. If a chapter has no next action, it does not count.

What if I hate my writing voice?

Read it out loud. Cut anything you would not say after dinner. Short sentences. Named tools. You are handing notes to a tired friend.

Do I need a cover designer?

No. A cover that states the job is enough. Redesigning the cover four times is a listed mistake.

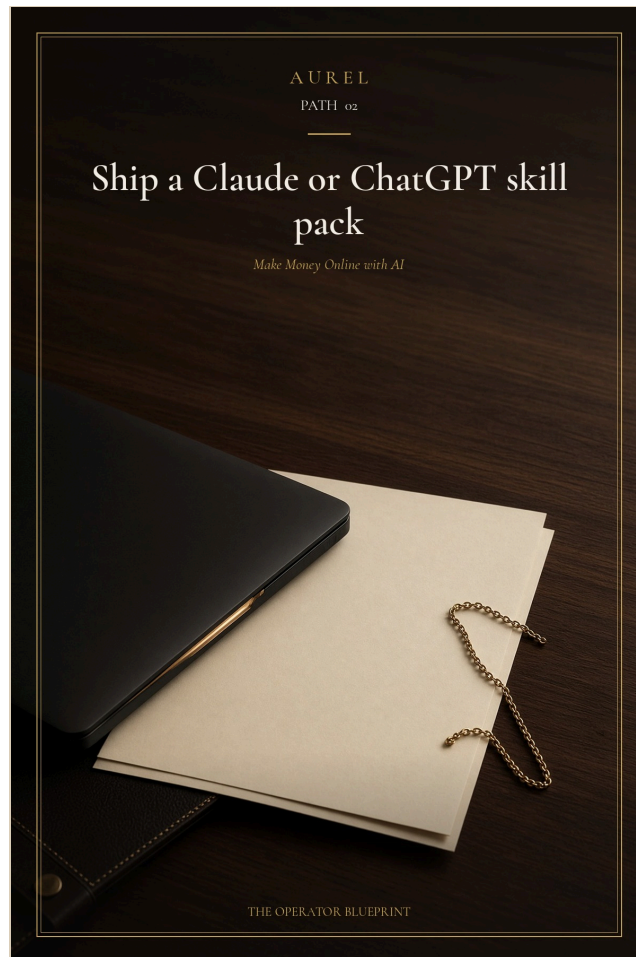
What if a buyer wants me to customize it for their company?

That is a service. Send a price or send the cheaper file. Do not hop on a \$29 call that becomes the job.

When do I raise from \$29 to \$47?

After a stranger sale, a used-chapter sentence, and one extra working file they asked for. Raise new sales. Email the extra free to people who already paid.

THE OPERATOR SUITE · PATH 02



PATH 02

Ship a Claude or ChatGPT skill pack

They already pay the model. They are paying you to stop starting from zero every Friday.

46 minute read · 10,223 words

Who this is for

People who use Claude, ChatGPT, or Gemini every week and keep rebuilding the same chat for the same job.

Time to first

3–10 days if you already run the job in a chat

Tools

First sale

One \$19 order from someone who used the model this week.

Cash window

\$19–\$39

Leave this alone

Claude Projects or Custom GPTs, a zip of the skill files, a one-page install, Stripe Payment Link or Stan.	A 200-prompt dump with no job in the title. Competing with free GitHub lists on volume.
--	---

What this actually is

Definition

A skill pack is a working stack: instructions the model follows, examples of good output, and a way to install it in under ten minutes. It is not a PDF of prompts. It is closer to a small appliance. Plug it in, get the job.

The buyer has already decided AI is useful. Their pain is the blank window. Your job is to replace that window with a named job: weekly content, invoice follow-up, meeting notes into tasks, a listing description, a study plan. They already pay the model. They are paying you to stop starting from zero.

A skill pack ships as files they can paste or upload: a system-instructions file, one sample input, one sample output, and a one-page install. If you only send a list of prompts, you shipped a weaker version of Niche prompt stacks. This path is the installable version of a job.

What this is not

You are not selling access to a model. They already pay Anthropic or OpenAI. You are not selling 200 clever lines. You are selling the first message being raw material — an overdue invoice list, a messy email thread — and the model already knowing the format, the tone, and when to stop and ask.

You are not selling a playbook. A playbook is the sequence they read. A skill pack is the appliance they install. You are not selling a Custom GPT store listing as the product. Your checkout is yours. Directories are extra, after \$19 works.

You are not selling an API app, a Zapier flow, or a Gmail connection. If you need Zapier, you wandered into Automation setups. If they want you on a call, that is Productized AI service.

Why this works now

People already have a Plus or Pro tab open. What they do not have is a job that survives Friday without rewriting the instructions from memory. Generic skills will be free from the labs. A client-follow-up skill that knows a solo bookkeeper's tone and will not invent an amount is not on the default home screen. You are selling the job, not the concept of a skill.

Models still invent numbers. They still guess a date. They still write a peppy email a bookkeeper would never send. The skill is the freeze of the instructions a careful person would type every Friday, if they had twenty extra minutes, which they do not. Title-match is the distribution. Client follow-up skill for solo bookkeepers is a product. Claude Power Pack is a mood.

Anti-pattern 1: the 200-prompt dump

A zip of clever lines with no job in the title is a toy. You cannot maintain 200. You cannot write failure modes for 200. Sell one job, installed, with a sample so they know it loaded.

Anti-pattern 2: promising every model

Build for one: Claude Projects, Custom GPTs, or Gemini Gems. Say which one on the listing. If a buyer uses the other, refund and point them at the install they would need — or do not sell it to them. Works everywhere is how you get refunds.

Anti-pattern 3: bundling 40 jobs

One job, done, at \$19, outsells a suitcase of half jobs. You cannot version 40 files. You cannot answer 40 kinds of it broke. Narrow is the product. Volume is how this path loses to free GitHub lists.

The deal you keep

You keep three promises. One: a person who did not write it can install it in under ten minutes and get a usable first output from the sample. Two: the skill will not invent named fields (amounts, dates, diagnoses). If a critical field is missing, it asks once, then stops. Three: the checkout title is the job, the price is \$19, and you have bought the zip yourself from a second

email. The buyer keeps one promise: they will run the sample first. You design the install for a tired night. If they need you on a call, it is not a skill pack yet. It is a service.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

Fits if

You use Claude, ChatGPT, or Gemini every week and keep rebuilding the same chat. You have a job you have run in a window more than twice. You can write instructions as if you will never be in the room: role, inputs, output format, quality checks, what to ask if information is missing.

You do not need to be a developer. You need to have finished the job in a chat and been annoyed that you had to re-explain it the next time. You can write a one-page install as clicks. You can record a 20-second screen. You can ask five people who already use the model. You can take \$19 without apologizing.

Skip if

Skip if you have never run the job in a model yourself. Skip if you want to compete with free GitHub lists on volume. Skip if your title would be 200 ChatGPT prompts. That market is noise, and this path loses when you play it.

If you need cash this week and you do not already live in these tools, write a playbook or take a service job first. A skill pack is fast only if the job is already in your fingers. Skip if you cannot write the install without the word repo. Skip if you want to sell a medical, legal, or financial skill that claims it is compliant. This path drafts operational writing. It does not practice.

The honest middle

You do not have to be a prompt engineer. You have to have run the job twice and hated rewriting the instructions the third time. Front-desk follow-up, recruiter shortlists, listing descriptions, meeting-notes-to-tasks: that is enough if you can name the fields you will never invent.

You are not waiting to become technical. You are waiting to have instructions you would hand a tired friend, plus a sample so they know it loaded.

Skills and time

Skills: write system instructions (role, inputs, output, stop rules). Run a real example and a broken example. Write a one-page install as clicks. Zip four files. Make a \$19 Payment Link. Record 20 seconds of screen. Send five asks.

Time if the job is already in your fingers: 3 to 10 days. Two evenings to write and test. One evening to package, checkout, and film. Two evenings to ask. Budget: \$0 if you already pay for the model and have a way to take \$19. You are not shipping an API app.

Two-minute self-test

Answer these out loud. If you stall on two of them, this is not your first path this month.

What is the job in one line, in the buyer's words?

Which tool do they already live in (Claude Projects, Custom GPTs, Gemini Gems)?

What raw material is the first message (invoice list, resume pile, MLS notes)?

Which three fields will you never invent?

Can you write the install as clicks, on one page?

Who are five people who already use the model this week?

Can you run a real example and a broken example tonight?

If you have the job, the tool, the stop rule, and five names, start tonight. If you only have I like prompts, go run a job in a window first.

The buyer on the other side

Not a prompt tourist. They already have a Plus or Pro tab open. They are a bookkeeper, a recruiter, a clinic manager, a realtor who pastes the same messy input every Friday and rewrites the instructions from memory. They will pay \$19 to never start from zero again. They will judge you on the sample run, not on your thumbnail.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this first

I help [specific person] finish [named job] in [named tool] in under [time], even if they are not a prompt person. If you cannot name the tool and the job, you do not have a skill pack. You have a vibe.

Specific person is a job plus a setting: solo bookkeeper, not finance people. Named job is the Friday task, named. Named tool is Claude Projects, Custom GPTs, or Gemini Gems. Time is minutes, not a course. Even-if is they are not a prompt person.

Sentences that work

I help solo bookkeepers turn an invoice list into send-ready follow-up emails in Claude in one paste, even if they are not a prompt person.

I help recruiters turn a pile of messy resumes into a scored shortlist in a Custom GPT in one sitting, even if they hate rewriting the instructions every Monday.

I help one-person realtors write listing descriptions from MLS notes in Claude in one paste, even if they freeze on tone.

I help clinic managers turn a messy inbox thread into a task list in Claude in ten minutes, even if they are scared the model will invent a follow-up plan.

I help freelance designers turn a messy client email into a scoped reply plus a next-step list in ChatGPT, even if they lose notes in chat.

Write yours in that shape. One person. One job. One tool. One even-if. Price the job, not the file count.

What they get

A zip: system instructions (or a Custom GPT / Claude Project recipe), a sample input, a sample output, and a one-page install they can follow on a tired night. A 20-second screen recording of blank chat versus the skill, if you have it. Price \$19. They do not get a course. They do not get a community. They get the appliance.

What they do not get

A course. A community. A setup call. A promise it works on every model. 40 jobs in one zip. Inbox connection. An API wrapper. Lifetime updates you will not ship. A medical, court, or tax claim. If they want it connected to Gmail, that is Automation setups, priced as a project. Do not promise inbox connection inside a \$19 zip. If they want you to sit with them and install it, that is Custom project setups or Productized AI service.

Packaging

One job. One tool named on the listing. One \$19 price on the page. Filename the zip after the job: bookkeeper-client-followup-claude-v1.zip. Folder: README (the install), SKILL or INSTRUCTIONS, SAMPLE-INPUT, SAMPLE-OUTPUT. Version number on the README. Checkout title is the job. Thumbnail is the screen recording still.

Do not bundle 40 jobs to justify \$49. One job, done, at \$19, outsells a suitcase of half jobs. \$29 to \$39 is fair when the install is clean, the sample is real, and you include the 20-second screen.

One job, one zip

If you need and to name the job, you have two skills. Split them. Sell the one you can test this week. The second zip is allowed after a stranger has installed the first.

What "done" looks like

Definition

Done means a person who did not write it can install it in under ten minutes and get a usable first output from the sample. If they need you on a call, it is not a skill pack yet. It is a service.

Done also means: instructions with role, inputs, output format, quality checks, and a stop rule for missing facts. A real sample input and sample output in the zip. A broken-example test: it asked, then stopped. One-page install with the actual clicks. Version number on the README. Checkout title is the job. Price \$19. You have bought it from a second email. The zip opens. You have asked five people who already use the model.

Done is not a catalog page with six other ideas. Done is not a 14-page install. Done is not a video instead of a one-pager.

The fairness test

Would you sell this to a tired friend who does that job, at \$19, without hopping on a call? If you would offer to set it up for them, it is not fair yet. Fair means they can follow the one-pager on a tired night and get the sample to match. Fair means you named the tool. Fair means you will not invent amounts, dates, or diagnoses. Fair means a refund in one sentence if it breaks or if they bought the wrong model. Write the install as clicks: where to open, what to paste, what to send first, how they know it worked. If a step is set up your workspace, you hid the work.

The install test

A person who did not write it, ten minutes, sample in, usable out. Time someone. If they need you at minute four, add a screenshot. If they need you at minute twenty because a menu is hidden on mobile, add two screenshots and bump to v1.1. Marcus's first buyer could not find Project instructions on mobile. That is the test.

The quality test

Run the skill on a real example. Save that output as the sample in the zip. Then run it on a broken example — missing amount, missing date, rude client note — and confirm it asks once and stops instead of guessing. Silent guessing is how people lose trust.

The sales test

Checkout title is the job. Price is \$19. You have bought it from a second email. The zip opens. The install PDF is one page. You have asked five people who already use Claude or ChatGPT. Done is not a catalog page with six other ideas.

Not-done-yet list

- A title with no job

- Instructions that guess at missing money or medical facts

No sample input or sample output

You have not run a broken example

Install is 14 pages or a 12-minute video

You promised it works on every model

Checkout untested

You have not asked five people who already use the model

A second skill started before a stranger sale

You included a setup call in the \$19

If three of those are true, you have a draft. Keep going. The first buyer is not your editor.

Pricing that holds

Ranges

\$19 is the default. One \$19 order from someone who used the model this week is the first sale that matters. \$19 matches I already pay for Claude; this saves me the blank window. It is low enough to try tonight and high enough that you will answer a support email.

Do not price at \$9. You will attract collectors who never install it, and you will hate the one-star too simple review from someone who wanted 200 prompts. Stay under \$39 until you have a version history and a second related skill you can bundle.

Why \$19 is the honest default

It is a Friday tax. They already pay the model. \$19 is the freeze of the instructions they rewrite every week. If you are ashamed of \$19, you either bundled 40 jobs or you do not believe the blank window is expensive. Cut to one job, or run the job yourself one more Friday. Round numbers. Price on the button. Do not DM for price.

When \$29 to \$39 is honest

Raise when you have: a 20-second screen, a real sample, failure modes in the instructions, and at least one stranger who installed it without you. That is a better product, not a different mood. Stay under \$39 until you have a version history and a second related skill you can bundle. Raise because the file does more, not because you got bored of \$19. Email v1.1 free to people who already paid.

Refunds in one sentence

If it breaks, or if you bought the wrong model, email me and I will refund.

You will refund almost nobody if the sample runs and the listing names the tool. Refund the ChatGPT buyer of a Claude skill fast and without a speech. Then make the title clearer. Refunds for the wrong model are a listing problem.

What you never charge

Never charge extra for lifetime updates you will not ship. Never add a \$97 with a setup call on day one unless you mean to run Productized AI service instead. Never charge a second time for v1.1; email it. Never charge \$9. Never promise it works on every model to justify a higher price. Never charge for a Gmail connection inside a \$19 zip.

Worked dollars

Marcus sells the bookkeeper follow-up skill at \$19. Day 3 he asks five people. Two of the five buy: \$38. A stranger buys on day 6 after he replies to a tweet about Claude inventing invoice amounts, with the result (amounts correct, tone plain) and the link in his profile: \$19. One refund from someone who only uses ChatGPT: minus \$19. He bolds Claude Projects on the listing. Week 2 he ships v1.1 with two mobile screenshots and emails both remaining buyers. He does not raise yet. Month 1: five sales at \$19, one refund. Net \$76. That is the path. Not a launch. One appliance that works.

If he had started at \$79 with no screen and no sample, he would have zero installs. If he had started at \$9, he would have collectors. \$19 is the door. After a stranger has installed it and he has the screen and the failure modes, he can raise new sales to \$29. Email v1.1 free. Do not invent a \$49 pack of 40 jobs.

The first 72 hours

Day 1 morning: pick the job and write the room

Pick one job you have done in a chat more than twice. Open a new project. Write the system instructions as if you will never be in the room: role, inputs they must paste, output format, quality checks, what to ask if information is missing. Name the three fields you will never invent. Put that list in the instructions, not in a blog post about your process.

Paste this to get a first draft of the instructions, then rewrite every line in your voice:

Write system instructions for [tool] that a tired [person] will use. Job: [job]. The user's first message is only the raw material: [what they paste]. You will return [format]. If [critical field] is missing, ask once, then stop. Do not invent numbers. Include three quality checks you run before you show the draft.

Day 1 afternoon: run a real example and a broken one

Run it on a real example. Save the output as the sample. Then run it on a broken example — missing amount, missing date, rude client note — and confirm it asks once and stops instead of guessing. If it guesses, the instructions failed. Rewrite the stop rule. Do not ship a silent guesser. Blur names. Keep texture.

Day 1 night: the one-page install

Write the install as clicks: where to open, what to paste, what to send first, how they know it worked. One page. Numbered clicks. One screenshot if a menu is hidden. A line that says you will know it worked when the sample output looks like this. If they have to watch a 12-minute video, you wrote a course. Cut it. Stop at midnight. You have instructions, two runs, and an install. That is a good day.

Day 2: package, checkout, film

README, skill file, sample in, sample out. Zip. Filename after the job: bookkeeper-client-followup-claude-v1.zip. Price \$19. Stripe Payment Link or Stan. Buy it from a second email.

Record a 20-second screen: blank chat versus the skill. Same paste, two very different first drafts. No music. No intro. The last two seconds are the \$19 line. Phone screen record is enough.

Day 3: five asks, not fifty features

Ask five people who already use Claude or ChatGPT. I built a [job] skill for [person]. \$19, ten-minute install. If you want it: [link]. If not, ignore. Do not explain the catalog of other ideas you have. Help in one thread where people complain about the job. Link stays in the profile. Do not dump the zip in a comment.

The 72-hour list

- One job, written as system instructions
- One real example output in the zip
- One broken-example test: it asked, then stopped
- One-page install a tired person can follow
- Twenty-second screen recording
- Five asks, not fifty features

The path, step by step

Step 1. Watch how the buyer actually works

If they live in email, do not build a Notion skill. If they live in Claude on a phone, the install cannot assume a desktop sidebar they have never opened. Sit with one real run of the job. Write down the raw material they paste and the file they want out.

Step 2. Write the skill so the first message is just the raw material

The skill should not need a prompt engineer on their side. If they have to write a paragraph of instructions after they install it, you failed. Role in one line. Inputs named. Output format named. Three quality checks. A stop rule for missing facts.

Step 3. Add failure modes

If the invoice amount is missing, ask once, then stop. Silent guessing is how people lose trust. List the three fields you will never invent. Put that list in the instructions, not in a blog post about your process. No be helpful filler. No claim that it replaces a bookkeeper, a lawyer, or a clinician. It drafts. They send.

Step 4. Version the file

v1 is allowed to be narrow. You will ship v1.1 after the first buyer. Put v1.0 in the README and the filename. When you fix install wording, bump it. Buyers should know they can re-download.

Step 5. Package the zip

README, skill or instructions file, sample input, sample output. That is enough. The README is the one-page install, not a manifesto. Filename the zip after the job: bookkeeper-client-followup-claude-v1.zip.

Step 6. Checkout title is the job

Thumbnail is the screen recording still. Description names the tool, the install time, and the sample. Works in Claude Projects. Ten-minute install. Sample invoice list included. Price \$19 on the page. Refund line on the page. One product.

Step 7. Record the 20-second screen

Left: blank chat, slow. Right or after: paste the raw list, get the follow-ups. No music. No intro. The last two seconds are the \$19 line and the link. The still from second 3 is the thumbnail. Phone screen record is enough.

Step 8. Sell where those users already complain

X threads, Reddit help posts, Discord. Help first. Link in profile. Do not dump the zip in a comment. Dump the result of the job, then let the profile hold the buy link.

Step 9. Five personal asks to people who already use the model

I built a [job] skill for [person]. \$19, ten-minute install. If you want it: [link]. If not, ignore. First sale is allowed to be someone you know. Ask: did the sample run?

Step 10. After purchase, a three-line email

Install, test with the sample, reply if it breaks. That reply is your product roadmap. Do not add a course. Do not add a community.

Step 11. Fix whatever the first buyer could not install

Ship v1.1. Same checkout, new zip. Email the people who already bought. Two screenshots for a hidden mobile menu is a better product than a second skill.

Step 12. Do not add a second skill until this one has a stranger sale

One appliance that works beats a store of toys. If nobody bought, the title or the tool is wrong. Ask one of the five: would you even install this? Then change the title, not the whole stack.

Step 13. Date the README

Tested on Claude, [month year]. When the model moves, run the sample again. If it breaks, fix, bump the version, email buyers. That is the job after the first sale. It is also why you do not sell 40 jobs in one zip — you cannot maintain them.

Step 14. Raise only when the file does more

After a stranger has installed it and you have the screen and the failure modes, move new sales to \$29. Email v1.1 free. Raise because the file does more, not because you got bored of \$19.

Step 15. Only then consider the next shape

A prompt stack if they want to paste instead of install. A playbook if they want the sequence written down. A template if they want the checklist as a filled file. A service if they say can you just set it up for me, at a different number. Not before a stranger install.

Step 16. Stop

Do not open a membership to avoid shipping v1. Do not add a \$97 setup call on day one. Do not start a second skill because week 2 felt quiet. Quiet is usually five more asks and a clearer title. Ship at the bar. Fix after the first install trip-up.

A worked example

Marcus, solo bookkeepers, \$19

Marcus is a solo bookkeeper. Every Friday he writes the same follow-up emails: invoice sent, invoice 7 days late, invoice 21 days late, polite close-the-loop. He used to paste a messy spreadsheet into Claude and spend twenty minutes restating the tone. He ships a Claude skill: Client follow-up for solo bookkeepers. Price: \$19.

His one sentence: I help solo bookkeepers turn an invoice list into send-ready follow-up emails in Claude in one paste, even if they are not a prompt person.

Calendar: days 1 to 14

Day 1 morning: he writes the instructions. Role: follow-ups for a solo bookkeeper. Inputs: client name, invoice number, amount, days late, last contact. Output: subject line plus a short email in plain voice. Never invent an amount or a date. If amount or days late is missing, ask once, then stop. Three tones: reminder, firm, final. Default to reminder unless days late is over 14.

Day 1 afternoon: he runs eight fake invoices, names blurred from a real week. He runs a ninth with a missing amount. The skill asks, then stops. He saves SAMPLE-INPUT and SAMPLE-OUTPUT. Night: one-page INSTALL as clicks.

Day 2: zip. Filename: bookkeeper-client-followup-claude-v1.zip. Stripe Payment Link titled Client follow-up skill for solo bookkeepers — install in 10 minutes. He buys it from a second email. The zip opens on his phone. He records 20 seconds: blank chat (write follow-ups for these invoices) versus the Project with the skill. Same list, two very different first drafts. Left one invented an amount. Right one asked.

Day 3: five asks. Two other bookkeepers in a Slack, his old firm colleague, a freelancer Discord, and a person who had tweeted Claude keeps making up invoice amounts. He does not pitch

a catalog.

What is in the zip

Four files. Nothing else. Filename: bookkeeper-client-followup-claude-v1.zip.

SKILL.txt, the whole file

This is what he pastes into Project instructions. Steal the shape. Rewrite every line for the job you actually do.

You write follow-up emails for a solo bookkeeper. You are not the bookkeeper. You draft. They send.

The user's first message is the raw invoice list. They will not write extra instructions. Do not ask them to prompt you. If the paste is not an invoice list, say so and stop. Do not switch jobs.

Inputs you expect, one invoice per line or block:

- Client name
- Invoice number
- Amount, including cents if they typed cents
- Days late, or invoice date so you can count from today
- Last contact, if they have it (what was sent and when)
- Optional one-line note from the bookkeeper

Output, for each invoice, in this order:

1. Tone used: reminder, firm, or final
2. Subject line
3. Email body, 80 to 140 words, plain voice
4. A one-line why-this-tone the bookkeeper can ignore

Tone rules:

- Just sent, or 1 to 13 days late: reminder. Assume they forgot. No threat. No per my last email.
- 14 to 20 days late: firm. Name the amount, the invoice number, and a pay-by date 7 days from today. Still polite.

- 21 or more days late: final. Still plain. Ask them to reply with a date or a problem. Do not threaten collections, lawyers, or credit reporting. The bookkeeper will decide that in person.

Voice. Short sentences. No I hope this message finds you well. No exclamation points. No just circling back more than once in the whole batch. Match these two real sentences: Invoice 1042 for \$1,240 is still open. When you have a minute, reply with a date I can put on the calendar. And: If something on this invoice is wrong, tell me and I will fix it.

Never invent amounts, invoice numbers, dates the user did not give you, payment promises the client did not make, or fees and late penalties the user did not type.

If amount or days late (or invoice date) is missing on a row, ask once for that row, then skip it. Do not draft an email with a blank or a guess. Say: Row [n]: I need [field] before I draft this one. Then continue with the rows you can finish.

Quality checks before you show the draft:

1. Every amount in an email matches the list exactly, including cents.
2. Every invoice number matches the list exactly.
3. No row with a missing amount or missing days late has an email.
4. Tone matches the days-late rule, not the mood of a note.
5. No email is longer than 140 words.

SAMPLE-INPUT.txt

Eight rows. Names blurred from a real week. Ugly on purpose. One missing amount. One all-caps note.

Row 1. Rivera Dental. INV-1042. \$1,240.00. 3 days late. Last contact: invoice sent 8/1. Note: pays slow every time.

Row 2. Holt Mechanical. INV-1048. \$680.50. 9 days late. Last contact: invoice sent 7/28.
Note: none.

Row 3. Parkside Vet. INV-1039. \$2,100.00. 16 days late. Last contact: voicemail 8/5. Note: they asked for a copy last month.

Row 4. North End Salon. INV-1051. \$315.00. 0 days late, just sent today. Last contact: invoice sent today. Note: new client.

Row 5. Quinn Roofing. INV-1028. \$4,880.00. 22 days late. Last contact: reminder emailed 8/3.

Note: OWNER IS TRAVELING, WILL PAY WHEN BACK.

Row 6. Little Oak Daycare. INV-1044. \$960.00. 11 days late. Last contact: none. Note: PO missing on their side, they still want the work billed.

Row 7. Greenfield PT. INV-1050. Amount missing. 8 days late. Last contact: invoice sent 7/30.

Note: I forgot to type the amount, do not guess.

Row 8. Harbor Bike Shop. INV-1033. \$1,075.25. 18 days late. Last contact: firm email 8/6. Note: they disputed a line last year, this invoice is clean.

He kept cents on two rows. He kept the all-caps row. He kept the missing amount. A perfect table would have made the skill look smart and fail on Friday.

SAMPLE-OUTPUT.txt

What the skill produced on that paste, after Marcus confirmed he would send rows 1-6 and 8.

Row 7 is the ask, not an email.

Row 1. Tone: reminder. Subject: Invoice 1042 for \$1,240.00. Body starts: Invoice 1042 for \$1,240.00 is still open. When you have a minute, reply with a date I can put on the calendar. Why this tone: 3 days late.

Row 2. Tone: reminder. Subject: Invoice 1048 for \$680.50. Short, plain, no pep. Why this tone: 9 days late.

Row 3. Tone: firm. Subject: Invoice 1039 for \$2,100.00 — need a date. Body names the voicemail, names a pay-by date 7 days out, offers to resend a copy. Why this tone: 16 days late.

Row 4. Tone: reminder. Subject: Invoice 1051 for \$315.00. One short thanks-and-here-it-is, no welcome-aboard paragraph. Why this tone: just sent.

Row 5. Tone: final. Subject: Invoice 1028 for \$4,880.00. Body stays plain. Asks for a date or a problem. Does not threaten. Does not scold the all-caps note. Why this tone: 22 days late.

Row 6. Tone: reminder. Subject: Invoice 1044 for \$960.00. Offers to add the PO if they send it. Does not invent a PO. Why this tone: 11 days late.

Row 7. No email. Row 7: I need the amount before I draft this one.

Row 8. Tone: firm. Subject: Invoice 1033 for \$1,075.25 — need a date. Does not mention last year's dispute. Why this tone: 18 days late.

Marcus actually sent seven of these after a human pass. He changed one subject line. He left the rest. That is the sample. Not a fantasy Friday.

INSTALL.pdf, one page

Title: Client follow-up for solo bookkeepers — Claude Projects — v1.0. Tested on Claude, [month year]. Ten minutes.

Open claude.ai on a laptop this once.

Left sidebar: Projects. If you are on a phone, open the menu; Projects may be hiding there. If you still cannot find it, use a laptop for install, then chat from the phone after the project exists.

New Project. Name: Client follow-up.

Open custom instructions / Project instructions for that project.

Paste the entire SKILL.txt. Save.

Start a new chat inside the project. Do not chat outside it.

Paste SAMPLE-INPUT.txt as the first message. Send. Do not add extra instructions.

Open SAMPLE-OUTPUT.txt. Compare amounts and invoice numbers. Row 7 must ask for the amount. It must not invent one.

If it matches, paste your own list the same way. Read every amount before you send an email. You send. The skill drafts.

If it does not match, reply to the purchase email with a screenshot. Do not fight the model for twenty minutes.

That is the whole page. Two screenshots on v1.1: the sidebar Projects item, and the custom instructions box. No twelve-minute video.

How he sold it, with dollars

Two of the five bought on day 3. \$38. A stranger bought on day 6 after he replied to that tweet with the result (amounts correct, tone plain) and left the link in his profile. \$19. First stranger sale.

The first buyer could not find Project instructions on mobile. Marcus added two screenshots to INSTALL.pdf, bumped to v1.1, and emailed both buyers. He did not start a second skill for tax organizers. Not yet.

Week 2: one more sale from the same tweet, recycled. \$19. One refund from someone who only uses ChatGPT. Minus \$19. He bolds Claude Projects in the title. Month 1: five sales at \$19, one refund. Net \$76. He asks every buyer: did the sample run? Two said yes. One said the mobile menu was the trip-up, which v1.1 already fixed.

The mistake and the recovery

The mobile install was the whole product problem in week 1. Not the instructions. Not the price. Two screenshots. v1.1. Email. He did not add a 12-minute video. He did not add a second skill. Shipped artifact: a four-file zip, a one-page install with two screenshots, a 20-second screen, a \$19 Payment Link. He still has not built the tax-organizer skill. Nobody who installed follow-up asked for it.

Copy you can actually send

Swap the job. Keep the tool name. Do not add hype. Paste these as they are. Fill the brackets. Send.

DM

I built a [job] skill for [person] who already uses Claude. Ten-minute install, \$19. If that is useful: [link]. If not, no need to reply.

Post

I wasted two hours prompting this. The skill does it in one paste. \$19.

Or, with the screen still: Blank chat vs the follow-up skill. Same invoice list. Left one invented an amount. Right one asked. \$19, install in 10 minutes. Built for solo bookkeepers. Not a prompt dump.

Listing

Title: Client follow-up skill for solo bookkeepers — install in 10 minutes.

Body:

What you get: Claude Project instructions, a sample invoice list, a sample of the emails, and a one-page install.

What you do: paste your list. Get send-ready follow-ups. It will not invent amounts.

What you need: Claude (Projects). Not a prompt engineer.

Price: \$19. Instant zip. Email me if it breaks.

Email after purchase

Subject: install, then test with the sample

Open the INSTALL page. Ten minutes.

Run SAMPLE-INPUT first. Match it against SAMPLE-OUTPUT so you know it loaded.

Then paste your own list. If it breaks, reply to this with a screenshot. I will fix the file.

Email to people who already use the model

Subject: a [job] skill, ten-minute install

I got tired of rewriting the same Claude chat every Friday, so I froze it. Instructions, a sample, a one-page install. \$19.

If you want it: [link].

If you do not, delete this.

Reply: Can't I just save a prompt?

You can. A skill pack is the instructions plus failure modes plus a sample so you know it loaded. If your saved prompt already asks for missing amounts and never invents them, you do not need this. If you rewrite the instructions every Friday, \$19 is cheaper than another Friday.

Reply: Does it work in ChatGPT?

This one is built for Claude Projects. I will not pretend it is the same in a Custom GPT. If you only use ChatGPT, do not buy this version. Refund if you already did.

Reply: Can you just set it up for me?

Yes, as a service, for a different price. This path is the zip. I will not throw a call into a \$19 product. If you want setup-for-hire, that is Custom project setups or Productized AI service.

Thread reply (help first)

I would not let it invent an amount. Ask once, then stop. Plain tone, not cute. If you want that frozen as a Claude Project, I put a \$19 zip in my profile. The stop rule is free.

Refund

You asked for a refund. Here it is, no speech. If you bought the Claude version and you only use ChatGPT, that is on my listing and I have made the tool name clearer. If the sample did not run, send a screenshot. I will fix the file for everyone else. You do not have to help. The refund is already processing.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Assume evenings. This is two weeks to a used skill, not a prompt brand.

Week 1, days 1-2: write and test

One job you already run. Write the instructions. Run a real example. Run a broken example. Save both. You can do this in two evenings after work. Do not design a landing page yet. Do not name it after yourself.

Week 1, day 3: package and checkout

README, skill file, sample in, sample out. Zip. \$19 Payment Link or Stan. Buy it from a second email. Record the 20-second screen on your phone if you have to. Filename after the job. Version v1.0 on the README.

Week 1, days 4-7: five asks, one post a day

Five personal messages. Post the screen recording once a day in one place — same clip, same offer. Help in two threads where people complain about the job. Link stays in the profile. Ask anyone who bought: did the sample run? Fix the install trip-up the same night.

Week 2: patch, then wait

Fix whatever the first buyer could not install. Ship v1.1. Email people who bought. Do not add a second skill until this one has a stranger sale. If nobody bought, the title or the tool is wrong. Ask one of the five: would you even install this? Then change the title, not the whole stack.

Week 3: teach the failure mode, three times

Three posts or emails that teach one stop rule. Soft link. Example: it asked for the missing amount instead of inventing it. End with \$19, ten-minute install, link in bio. If you are not public, send three more personal asks instead. Count: asks, sales, sample-ran, refunds and why. If refunds say wrong model, the listing is the bug.

Week 4: fix, do not expand

Date the README. Rerun the sample if the model moved. Email v1.1 or v1.2 to people who bought. Do not open a membership. Do not add a setup call to the \$19. A second skill only if a stranger asked for the next job.

Quality bar

Instructions that survive you leaving the room

Role in one line. Inputs named. Output format named. Three quality checks. A stop rule for missing facts. No be helpful filler. No claim that it replaces a bookkeeper, a lawyer, or a clinician. It drafts. They send.

The sample is real enough to trust

Blur names. Keep the ugly: a client who pays late every time, a line with a missing PO, a note in all caps. If the sample is a perfect table, the skill will look smart and fail on Friday.

Install a tired person can finish

One page. Numbered clicks. One screenshot if a menu is hidden. A line that says you will know it worked when the sample output looks like this. If they have to watch a 12-minute video, you wrote a course. Cut it.

Test 1: the install test

Hand the zip to someone who did not write it. Time them. Under ten minutes to a usable sample output, you passed. If they need you, the one-pager failed.

Test 2: the broken-example test

Missing amount, missing date, rude note. It asks once, then stops. If it guesses, rewrite the stop rule before you advertise.

Test 3: the voice test

If a buyer says it sounds like AI, the instructions need their voice. Add three sample sentences they actually send. Marcus put two real follow-ups he had already mailed (names changed) into SKILL.txt under match this tone. That killed the peppy bot voice.

Test 4: the claims test

No medical, legal, or financial claims. No skill that claims it is compliant. No this will collect the invoice. Operational drafting only. Put the limit in the instructions and on the listing. It drafts. They send.

Test 5: the model-name test

The title names the tool. The install names the clicks for that tool only. If two people refund because they use the other model, the listing failed, not the skill.

Below the bar

Prompts without install steps. A title with no job. A sample that is too clean. Instructions that guess at missing money. A 14-page install. Promising every model. If a tired person cannot run the sample in ten minutes, it is below the bar.

Metrics that matter (and vanity numbers to ignore)

Count these

Installs that produce a first output from the sample (ask: Did the sample run?)

Stranger sales at \$19

It broke emails — these are the roadmap

Time-to-install reports. If two people say it took 30 minutes, the one-pager failed

Refunds because of the wrong model. That is a listing problem. Fix the title.

Version number. If v1.0 never becomes v1.1, you are not talking to buyers.

Week 1

Count: instructions written, real example run, broken example run, zip opens, self-buy works, five asks sent. If the broken example still guesses, you do not have a product yet.

Day 30

Count asks, sales, stranger sales, sample-ran answers, break-emails, refunds-reason, version. A healthy day-30: sample runs, 5+ asks, 1+ stranger sale or at least one install without you, 0 to 1 refunds and those are listing problems you already fixed.

Day 90

Count v1.1 shipped (yes/no). Second skill (should still be no, unless a stranger asked for the next job). Cash in the \$19 to \$39 window, totaled. If you have \$0 at day 90, the failure is usually title, unnamed tool, or five asks you did not send. It is rarely the market.

Ignore these

Stars on a prompt marketplace. How many skills you listed. GitHub-style star counts. Views on the screen recording if nobody clicks the checkout. Lines of instructions. Community member counts you do not have yet.

One line a week

Date, asks sent, sales, break-emails, version number, one buyer sentence (did the sample run?). If the buyer sentence is always empty, you are not asking. Ask.

Objections you will hear

I already have a Custom GPT / a Project

Good. This is a better set of instructions plus a sample so they can test it. If theirs already does the job, they should not buy. If they keep tweaking it every week, \$19 is the freeze-frame that works.

Skills are going to be free from the labs

Some will be. Generic ones. A client-follow-up skill that knows a solo bookkeeper's tone and will not invent an amount is not on the default home screen. You are selling the job, not the concept of a skill.

I am not technical

Neither is the buyer, if you wrote the install. If you cannot write the install without the word repo, this path will hurt. Use Claude Projects or Custom GPTs, not a local install.

What if the model changes and it breaks

You version the file. You date the README: Tested on Claude, [month year]. You email v1.1 to people who bought. That is the job after the first sale. It is also why you do not sell 40 jobs in one zip — you cannot maintain them.

Can you just set it up for me

Yes, as a service, for a different price. This path is the zip. If you want setup-for-hire, that is Custom project setups or Productized AI service. Do not throw a call into a \$19 product.

Can't I just save a prompt

You can. A skill pack is the instructions plus failure modes plus a sample so you know it loaded. If your saved prompt already asks for missing amounts and never invents them, you do not need this. If you rewrite the instructions every Friday, \$19 is cheaper than another Friday.

Does it work in ChatGPT / Claude / Gemini

This one is built for [named tool]. I will not pretend it is the same in the other. If you only use the other, do not buy this version. Refund if you already did.

I need it connected to Gmail

That is Automation setups or Custom project setups, priced as a project. Do not promise inbox connection inside a \$19 zip.

Is \$19 too low if it saves a Friday every week

It is the right first price. Raise to \$29 to \$39 after a stranger has installed it and you have the screen and the failure modes. Do not start at \$79 with no proof.

What if Anthropic or OpenAI ships this exact skill

Then you sell the version that knows this job's tone and failure modes, or you move to the playbook and the service. Generic will always be free later. Specific stays yours if the sample is real.

How this feeds other paths

Upstream: what you need before this

You need a job you have already run in a model more than twice. If you have never run the job, write a playbook or take a service job first, then freeze the instructions from the scars.

Same job, other shapes

The instructions inside the skill are a Niche prompt stack if someone wants to paste instead of install. The sequence you used to build it is Sell an AI playbook. The checklist in the README is an AI template. Let the first buyers tell you which shape they asked for. Do not split until a stranger has installed v1.

Where it gets sold

AI-assisted short-form: the 20-second blank-vs-skill clip is the whole path. A weekly AI letter: one failure mode explained, link to the zip. Your front door: a diagnostic (do you rewrite the same Claude chat every Friday?) then the skill.

When it becomes a service or a membership

Local businesses + AI: install the same skill for a nearby owner and charge a setup fee. Custom project setups and Automation setups are the grown-up version for people who want it connected to their inbox. A small AI membership is how you send v1.2, v1.3 as the model changes — after the \$19 file has strangers using it. Do not open a membership to avoid shipping v1.

What not to feed yet

A GPT store listing as the first 72 hours. A catalog of six skills. Thirty days, one job, one tool in the title. After a stranger installs it, the next path is the one they asked for.

Mistakes that kill this path

I. Shipping prompts without install steps

Recovery this week: write the one-page install as clicks. Add it to the zip. Email v1.1.

2. Promising it works on every model

Recovery this week: pick one tool. Put it in the title. Refund anyone who bought the wrong one.

3. Bundling 40 jobs so none of them are good

Recovery this week: ship one job. Archive the rest. One appliance that works beats a store of toys.

4. Using other people's copyrighted prompt packs as your file

Recovery this week: stop listing it. Write the instructions from the job you actually do. The scar tissue is the product.

5. A title with no job

Recovery this week: rename. Client follow-up skill for solo bookkeepers, not Claude Power Pack. Same zip, new title, same \$19.

6. A sample that is too clean

Recovery this week: replace it with a messy real week, names blurred. Keep the missing PO and the all-caps note. Rerun. Save as SAMPLE.

7. Instructions that guess at missing money or medical facts

Recovery this week: add the stop rule. Ask once, then stop. Rerun the broken example. Do not ship a silent guesser. Invented numbers, invented legal language, a medical or legal skill that claims it is compliant: delete those claims. This path drafts operational writing. It does not practice. Put that limit in the instructions and on the listing.

8. A 14-page install or a 12-minute video

Recovery this week: cut to one page of clicks. One screenshot if a menu is hidden. Email v1.1.

9. Asking fifty people for features, or naming it after yourself

Recovery this week: stop the survey. Ask five people who already use the model to buy and install. Fix what they trip on. Rename the zip and the checkout after the job: bookkeeper-client-followup-claude-v1.zip.

10. A \$97 setup call, or a second skill before a stranger sale

Recovery this week: pull the call out of the \$19. If you want setup-for-hire, that is a different path at a different number. Close the other skill draft. Fix the install trip-up on this one. Send five new asks.

Tools and how you actually use them

Where the skill lives

Claude Projects: paste the instructions into the project. Custom GPTs: paste into the GPT builder instructions. Gemini Gems: same idea, different menu. Pick one for v1. Write the install for that one only. You are not shipping an API app. You are shipping text files a human pastes. If you need Zapier, you wandered into Automation setups.

Claude Projects, the actual clicks

Do this yourself before you write INSTALL. Write the clicks from the screen in front of you, not from memory.

Go to claude.ai. Log in. If Projects require Plus or Pro, say so on the listing. Do not sell a Project skill to a free account that cannot see the menu.

Open Projects from the left sidebar on desktop. On mobile, open the menu first.

New Project. Name it the job: Client follow-up.

Find custom instructions / Project instructions. Paste the entire SKILL.txt. Save. Do not paste SKILL into the chat. The chat is for raw material.

Do not upload SAMPLE-INPUT as a project file. Friday is a paste. The first message should still be a paste.

New chat inside the project. Paste SAMPLE-INPUT.txt. Send.

Compare to SAMPLE-OUTPUT.txt. Then paste a real list.

If Projects is not in their plan, do not sell them this zip. Refund. Or ship a Custom GPT version as a separate product after you have clicked it.

Custom GPTs, the actual clicks

Use this when your buyer lives in ChatGPT, not Claude. Do this yourself. Then write INSTALL from the screen.

Go to chatgpt.com. Log in. If creating a GPT requires Plus, say so on the listing.

On the left, GPTs, then Create. Or Explore GPTs, then Create.

Open the Configure tab, not only the chat-based Create tab. You want the Instructions box.

Name: Client follow-up for solo bookkeepers. Description: Paste an invoice list. Get send-ready emails. It will not invent amounts.

Instructions: paste the entire SKILL.txt.

Conversation starters: Paste your invoice list is enough. Do not add cute starters.

Knowledge: you may upload SAMPLE-INPUT.txt and SAMPLE-OUTPUT.txt so they can type run the sample. Still tell them to paste the sample as a message, because Friday is a paste, not a file hunt.

Capabilities: turn off web browsing if the job does not need it. Turn off image generation. This job is text.

Save. Only me while you test. Then Anyone with a link for buyers. You are not putting this in the public GPT store in week one.

Open the GPT. Paste SAMPLE-INPUT. Compare to SAMPLE-OUTPUT. The row with a missing amount must ask.

Your zip still contains SKILL.txt, SAMPLE-INPUT, SAMPLE-OUTPUT, and INSTALL. INSTALL names these clicks. Add a line: if ChatGPT moved the Create button, reply with a screenshot and I will bump INSTALL.

Gemini Gems, if that is where they live

Same idea. Gem instructions get SKILL.txt. First message is the raw list. Write INSTALL only if you actually use Gems for this job. Do not add a Gem appendix from a blog post you have not clicked. If you do not live there, do not sell there.

The zip and the page

Folder: README (the install), SKILL or INSTRUCTIONS, SAMPLE-INPUT, SAMPLE-OUTPUT. Zip it. Stripe Payment Link or Stan delivers the zip. That is the stack. Do not add a course platform.

The 20-second screen

Phone screen record is enough. Desktop is cleaner if the buyer is on desktop. Show the blank chat failing or stalling, then the skill succeeding on the same paste. No intro bumper. The still from second 3 is the thumbnail.

What not to buy

A course platform. A prompt marketplace membership. A local-install stack. Ads. A designer for a thumbnail that hides the job. A second checkout tool. You are selling a \$19 zip of text files.

The \$0 path

The model you already pay for (or the free tier, if it can hold project instructions). A text editor you already have. Zip from your file manager. Stripe Payment Link (cost per sale). Phone screen record. Five asks to people who already use the model. You do not need a new laptop, a microphone, or a developer account.

Setup order

Write the instructions in a plain file. Run a real example. Run a broken example. Write the one-page install. Zip four files. Create the payment link with that zip. Buy it from a second email. Record 20 seconds. Then ask five people. Do not set up a GPT store before the self-buy works. Do not compare six tools.

Ship checklist

Before you zip

One job in the title

One tool named (Claude Projects, Custom GPTs, or Gemini Gems)

Instructions: role, inputs, output format, quality checks, stop rules

Will not invent named fields (amounts, dates, diagnoses)

Real sample input and sample output

Broken-example test: it asked, then stopped

Three sample sentences of their voice, if a buyer would say it sounds like AI

One-page install with the actual clicks

One screenshot if a menu is hidden

Version number on the README

Filename after the job, not FINAL_v7

Tested-on line with month and year

Before you write INSTALL

You have clicked the install yourself this week, on the tool you named

The first message after install is only the raw material

You know which menu is hidden on mobile

You have a line that says you will know it worked when the sample matches SAMPLE-OUTPUT

If a step is set up your workspace, rewrite it as a click

Before you ask anyone

Zip opens on a phone

Checkout title = the job; price \$19

Tool named on the listing

Refund line on the page

Self-purchase from a second email

20-second screen recorded

Five names who already use the model

After-purchase three-line email written

No second skill, no 40-job bundle

No setup call inside the \$19

After the first install

Ask: did the sample run?

Fix the install trip-up

Ship v1.1 to people who bought

No second skill until a stranger sale

Log: date, asks, sales, break-emails, version

The night you list it

Checkout title matches the job

Tool is in line one of the listing

Link in the five messages is the live link

You bought it from a second email on a phone and the zip opened

Print the before-you-zip list. If a box is empty, that is tonight's work. Do not start a second SKILL.txt.

FAQ

Is this just a prompt pack?

No. A prompt pack is paste-as-you-go. A skill pack is installed once so the first message can be the raw material. If they want 25 separate prompts for a clinic week, that is Niche prompt stacks. If they want follow-up to live in Claude, that is this.

Claude, ChatGPT, or Gemini?

Pick the one you actually use for this job. Write for that one. Saying works everywhere is how you get refunds.

Do I need to code?

No. You need to write instructions and a one-page install. If you are building an API wrapper, you left this path.

What if Anthropic or OpenAI ships this exact skill?

Then you sell the version that knows this job's tone and failure modes, or you move to the playbook and the service. Generic will always be free later. Specific stays yours if the sample is real.

How many skills should I launch with?

One. Five asks. One stranger sale. Then a second skill only if they ask for the next job.

Can I put it on a GPT store or a skill directory?

After it works at \$19 on your own checkout. Directories are extra. They are not the first 72 hours.

What do I do when a buyer says it sounds like AI?

The instructions need their voice. Add three sample sentences they actually send. Marcus put two real follow-ups he had already mailed (names changed) into SKILL.txt under match this tone. That killed the peppy bot voice.

Is \$19 too low if it saves a Friday every week?

It is the right first price. Raise to \$29 to \$39 after a stranger has installed it and you have the screen and the failure modes. Do not start at \$79 with no proof.

What if they want it connected to Gmail?

That is Automation setups or Custom project setups, priced as a project. Do not promise inbox connection inside a \$19 zip.

Can I use someone else's skill as a base?

No. Do not use other people's copyrighted prompt packs as your file. Write the instructions from the job you actually do. The scar tissue is the product.

What do I do after five asks and zero sales?

Ask one of the five: would you even install this? Then look at the title and the tool name. Most first misses are a vibe title or a missing tool. Rewrite. Send five new asks. Do not rewrite the whole skill yet.

Should I include a setup call at \$19?

No. That is a service. Keep the zip at \$19. If you want to get paid for your time this week, use Productized AI service or Custom project setups.

How do I know the install is done?

A person who did not write it can finish it in under ten minutes and get a usable first output from the sample. Time someone. If they need you, add a screenshot. If they need a video, you overbuilt.

When do I bump the version?

When you fix install wording, add a screenshot, or change a stop rule. Put v1.1 in the README and the filename. Email people who already bought. Same checkout, new zip.

What if the buyer wants a ChatGPT version of my Claude skill?

That is a second product, after a stranger has installed this one. Do not pretend they are the same. If you build it, name the tool in the title and test it on that tool. Do not copy-paste the install clicks.

Do I need a landing page?

No. A Payment Link or Stan page whose title is the job is enough. A simple page that repeats the listing body is fine. Do not build a site instead of sending five asks.



PATH 03

Niche prompt stacks

Twenty-five prompts that finish a job beat a thousand that sound clever.

39 minute read · 8,646 words

Who this is for

Someone who knows a trade from the inside and can name the ten writing jobs that trade hates.

Time to first

5–14 days if you already know the jobs

Tools

First sale

A niche buyer who pastes the first prompt the same day and sends the result.

Cash window

\$12–\$29 per stack; \$19 is home

Leave this alone

A PDF or Notion doc, three before/after examples, Stripe Payment Link or Etsy or Stan.

Generic 1,000 ChatGPT prompt dumps, HIPAA certificates, and stacks copied from another niche.

What this actually is

Definition

A niche prompt stack is 25 prompts that finish a repeating writing job for one trade. Not 1,000 clever one-liners. Not a course. Not a model. Each prompt is a form: the buyer pastes named inputs, gets a named output in a named format, and has a one-line done check so they know it is sendable. The stack covers a month of that trade's weekly writing: texts, emails, captions, listings, lesson notes, reminders. The buyer is not collecting prompts. They are trying to get through this week's writing without sounding like a robot or saying the wrong thing.

Twenty-five that finish a job beat a thousand that sound clever. A clinic front desk with 14 reminder texts before lunch does not want a vault. They want the vocabulary of their trade, the lines that trade will not cross, and the format that actually gets sent.

What this is not

You are not selling medical, legal, or financial advice. You are not selling a promise that a model is HIPAA compliant, court ready, or tax-safe. You are not selling access to ChatGPT. They already have a tab open. You are selling writing help for repeating operational jobs, with the constraints a practitioner already lives with.

You are not selling a thousand-prompt dump titled Ultimate AI Prompt Vault. That market is dead and noisy. A stack for pediatric clinic SMS that stays human and avoids diagnosis language does not exist for free.

You are not selling a skill pack. A skill pack is installed so the first message is raw material. A prompt stack is paste-as-you-go.

Why it works now

Generic prompt packs became free the week models got good at sounding helpful. The remaining gap is not "how do I talk to a model." It is "how do I talk to this model about this job without violating the rules of this room." That gap is vocabulary, constraints, and format. Those live in a trade, not in a prompt marketplace.

Models still ramble. They still invent a follow-up plan. They still put another child's name in a waitlist text. They still write a 90-word SMS. The stack is the freeze of the instructions a careful person would type every time, if they had 20 extra minutes, which they do not. Search is specific now. People type "pediatric clinic reminder text." Title-match is the distribution. Niche is the moat.

Anti-pattern 1: the thousand-prompt dump

A zip of 1,000 prompts with no inputs, no format, and no done check is a toy. You cannot date-test 1,000. Sell 25 you have actually run.

Anti-pattern 2: clever prompts that do not match the job

A prompt that returns a three-paragraph waitlist email for a clinic that only sends SMS is a mismatch. A prompt that names another patient in a cancellation text is a liability. Sit with a practitioner. Match length, channel, and the never-say list. If you cannot name those from the inside, you have a costume.

Anti-pattern 3: compliance theater

"HIPAA-compliant prompts." "Court-ready language." "IRS-safe emails." Those phrases sell to scared people and then produce refunds. No pack of prompts is a compliance program. Operational writing around regulated fields can be fine: appointment SMS, not treatment plans; listing descriptions, not contract clauses. Know the line and print it on page one.

The deal you keep

You keep three promises. One: every prompt has inputs, output format, a hard constraint, and a done check. Two: you have run all 25 on realistic inputs and kept three before/after proofs with names blurred. Three: you will not claim compliance, diagnosis, legal outcomes, or financial

results. The buyer keeps one promise in return: they will paste real inputs and send the result. You design for that first paste. If prompt 1 does not survive a Friday afternoon, the stack is not a product.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

Fits if

You know a trade or hobby from the inside: realtors, tutors, gyms, writers, clinics, bookkeepers, wedding photographers, salon owners. You have sat in the job long enough to list the ten writing tasks people hate. You can tell a good reminder from a creepy one. You already belong to a group or forum where those people talk, and you have helped in that room without pitching. You do not need a huge audience. You need the niche word they would search, and enough respect in that room to share once without getting banned. You can write a constraint in one line: "I will not diagnose. I will not name another patient."

Skip if

Skip if your only edge is "I use ChatGPT a lot." Skip if you planned to copy someone else's stack and swap the niche word. Skip if you want to write for "everyone who uses AI." Skip medical, legal, or financial claims. Operational writing around those fields can be fine (appointment SMS, not treatment plans). Skip if you have never sent the kind of message the stack produces. Skip if you need money tomorrow — first stranger sale is often day 8 to day 14. Take a productized service job first if you need cash this week.

The honest middle

You do not have to be the owner. Front desk, assistant, listing coordinator, tutor who also runs the parent emails: that is enough inside knowledge. You do have to sit with a practitioner for an hour if that practitioner is not you. Take notes on the jobs they hate, the channel, the length, and the never-say list. Then write. Do not invent the never-say list from a blog post.

You are not waiting to become famous in the niche. You are waiting to have 25 forms that match how the week actually runs.

Skills and time

You need the niche vocabulary, a four-part form, a PDF export, a checkout, and the willingness to ask once in a room you already belong to. You do not need design, a certificate, or a following. Time if you already know the jobs: two evenings to list, three to write and run 25, one for SOP and proofs, one for checkout and ten shares. That is the 5 to 14 day window. If you do not know the jobs, research first. Do not spend 72 hours guessing a clinic week.

Two-minute self-test

Answer these out loud. If you stall on two of them, this is not your first path this month.

What is the niche word they would type into search?

What are five writing jobs that happen every week in that trade?

What channel is each job (SMS, email, listing, caption)?

What is one thing you must never say in that room?

Where is a group you already belong to, where a helpful comment would not get you banned?

Can you run 25 prompts this week on realistic inputs and keep three before/after with names blurred?

If you have the niche word, the five jobs, the never-say line, and a room, start. If you only have "I like prompts," go do a job in a trade first.

The buyer on the other side

A niche buyer who uses the first prompt the same day. They have a shift or a showing tomorrow. They will paste one input and send one message. They are tired and slightly scared of sounding cold or saying the wrong thing. They will pay \$19 to freeze the instructions they keep retyping.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this before you outline

"I help [niche person] write [repeating job] every week with 25 prompts that include inputs, output format, and a done check, even if they hate sounding like a robot."

If you cannot fill the brackets, you do not have a stack. Niche person is a job plus a setting: pediatric clinic front desk, not "healthcare." Repeating job is the week's writing, named. The even-if is the honest fear: sounding cold, saying the wrong medical thing, writing a brochure.

Title includes the niche word they would search. "25 prompts for pediatric clinic SMS and emails" is searchable. "Ultimate AI Prompt Vault" is not.

Five sentences that already work

I help pediatric clinic staff write the week's SMS and parent emails in 25 prompts with inputs, format, and a done check, even if they are scared of sounding cold or of saying the wrong medical thing.

I help solo realtors write listing descriptions and showing follow-ups in 25 prompts, even if they only have MLS notes and 15 minutes in the car.

I help independent tutors write parent updates and lesson recaps in 25 prompts, even if they freeze on tone and never know how honest to be about a rough week.

I help small gym owners write class reminder texts, no-show follow-ups, and intro-offer captions in 25 prompts, even if they hate sounding like a used-car ad.

I help wedding photographers write inquiry replies, timeline emails, and gallery-delivery notes in 25 prompts, even if they only want to be behind the camera.

Write yours in that shape. One person. One repeating job. 25 prompts. One fear.

What they get

A PDF or a Notion doc. Twenty-five prompts covering a month of the weekly jobs. Each prompt has named inputs, output format including length, a hard "I will not" constraint, and a one-line done check. A one-page SOP: which prompt when, mapped to a real week. Three before/after examples, names blurred, texture kept. A dated line on page one: "Tested on [model], [month year]." Price \$12 to \$29. Default \$19.

They get the vocabulary and the constraints, in an order that matches a real week. They get a second-pass polish prompt paired with each draft family.

What they do not get

A thousand prompts. A claim of compliance. A community. A new model. A Zoom setup call. A custom version inside their SMS tool. A HIPAA certificate. Lifetime updates you will not ship. A second niche thrown in "for value."

If they want the stack installed as a Claude Project, that is Ship a Claude or ChatGPT skill pack, after this file has been used. If they want you to sit with their clinic and write their 25, that is a productized service. Do not hide a service inside a \$19 PDF.

Packaging

One file. One title with the niche word. One price on the page. Cover: title, who it is for, what it will not do, tested-on date. Then the SOP, the 25 numbered prompts, the three proofs. Export PDF. If you use Notion, include a duplicate-this link and a PDF backup.

Do not ship a zip of 25 separate files. Copy-paste blocks that are the whole prompt. Week 4, if they ask: add a one-page weekly calendar and raise to \$29, or keep \$19 and add the extra page. Do not invent a \$49 "pro vault" with the same 25 prompts in a different font.

What "done" looks like

Definition

Done is a stranger in that trade who pastes prompt 1 the same day, sends the result, and does not email you to ask what to do next. The file is 25 complete prompts, a one-page SOP, three proofs, a dated test line, a niche-word title, and a working \$19 checkout you have bought from a second email. Done is not five marketplace listings and a brand name. If a prompt is clever but would never be sent in that trade, it is not done. Cut it.

Fairness test

Would you sell this to a tired friend who does that job, at \$19, without a speech? If you would discount it or offer a call to "walk them through," it is not fair yet. Fair means they can open prompt 3 at 9 p.m., paste four fields, and send. Fair also means you have not claimed compliance. If they say "we would never send the after," rewrite the prompt, not the screenshot.

Technical done

Twenty-five prompts. Each has inputs, output format, a constraint ("I will not..."), and a done check. A one-page SOP that maps the week: Monday reminder, Tuesday waitlist, and so on. Three before/after pairs from realistic inputs. A dated line: "Tested on [model], [month year]." Page one states the limit: operational writing only, no medical, legal, or financial claims.

You have run all 25 on real or realistic inputs. Names blurred. Texture kept: the short-notice cancellation, the parent who texts at 9 p.m., the price question you are allowed to answer. Checkout title matches the file title. Self-purchase delivers the PDF.

Not-done-yet list

- A title without the niche word

- Prompts that are slogans ("write a friendly reminder")

- Prompts with no length or channel

- No "I will not" line

- No done check

- You have not run all 25

- Before/after that are fake-clean or leak a real name

- A compliance claim on the cover or in the listing

- Checkout untested

- SOP missing, so they have 25 orphans

- You have not asked once, helpfully, in a room you already belong to

- A second niche started before a stranger used prompt 1

If three of those are true, you have a draft. Keep going. Do not list a draft and "improve it with feedback." The first buyer is not your editor.

Pricing that holds

Ranges

\$12 is for a tiny stack: 10 prompts, one job, one channel. \$19 is the home price for 25 prompts plus SOP plus three proofs. \$29 is fair if you add a one-page weekly calendar they asked for, or a second-language polish pass that a bilingual staffer still checks. Stay in the \$12 to \$29 window. This is not a \$97 course.

Default to \$19. Put it on the page. Do not "DM for price." Do not do \$9 to "beat Etsy." A \$9 file trains people to treat you like a free list. Race to a title that matches search and a first prompt they can use today, not to the bottom of the marketplace.

When to raise

Raise after a stranger has used a prompt the same day and you have added something they asked for. Then move \$19 to \$29. Raise because the file does more, not because you got bored. Add one page, not five bonuses. Do not invent a \$49 "pro vault" with the same 25 prompts in a different font.

Refunds in one sentence

If it is not useful, or if you bought thinking this was a compliance or legal product, email me and I will refund.

You will refund almost nobody if prompt 1 works and page one states the limit. Refund the HIPAA-seeker fast and without a speech. Then make the listing clearer.

Never charge for these

Never charge for a compliance certificate you cannot issue. Never charge extra for "lifetime updates" you will not ship. Never charge for a setup call inside the \$19. Never charge \$97 for

25 prompts. Never charge a second time for v1.1 when the model moved; email it if you have their address.

Worked dollars

Priya sells the clinic stack at \$19. Ten personal shares. Two group buys in week 1: \$38. A stranger on day 10 from title search: \$19. Three more in week 3: \$57. One HIPAA-seeker refund: minus \$19. Week 4 she adds the calendar after they ask, raises new sales to \$29, emails the calendar free to people who already paid \$19. Month 1 cash is about \$180 after the refund. That is the path. Not a launch. A searchable tool.

The first 72 hours

Day 1 morning: list the jobs

Sit with a practitioner, even if it is you. Write the ten repeating writing jobs in that niche. Do not open a model yet. Star the five that happen every week. Those five become the spine of the 25. If you cannot name ten, you do not have 72 hours. You have research. Call someone who does the job. Ask: what do you write every Monday, what do you send when someone cancels, what are you not allowed to say, what length actually gets sent. Leave annual jobs for a later stack.

Day 1 afternoon: write the first family

Write five prompts for the first starred job. Each prompt is a form. Paste this to draft, then rewrite it in the trade's voice:

Write a prompt for [person] who has to [job] every week. The prompt must have: (1) inputs they paste, named; (2) output format, including length; (3) a hard constraint of what it will not say; (4) a done check in one line. Kitchen-table English. No hype. No medical, legal, or financial claims.

Then rewrite every line as if you will never be in the room. Name the fields. Name the character count. Name the never-say. Name the send test. Start with the Friday-afternoon ones: reminders, no-shows, short-notice cancellations.

Day 1 night: run those five

Paste realistic inputs. Fake names. Real rhythms: a parent texting at 9 p.m., a sibling double-book, an interpreter need. If you would not send the output, rewrite the prompt, not the output. Save the best before (generic dump) and after (your prompt, sendable). Stop at midnight. You have five, not 25. That is a good day.

Day 2: the other four families

Morning: five prompts for schedule changes. Afternoon: five for after-visit admin. Evening: five for allowed FAQs, plus five polish passes (shorten to 160, warmer without cute, cut diagnosis language, second-language draft to be checked, done-check against the never-say list). Run as you go. Keep a column: prompt number, ran, sendable, rewrite note.

Day 3: SOP, proofs, title, checkout, one ask

Morning: write the one-page SOP. A table: day or trigger, job, prompt number, where it gets sent. Pull the three best before/after pairs. Blur names. Keep texture. Put "Tested on [model], [month year]" on page one with the limit line.

Afternoon: export PDF. Title includes the niche word. "25 prompts for pediatric clinic SMS and parent emails — inputs, format, done check." Price \$19. Stripe Payment Link, Etsy, or Stan. Test-buy from a second email. Open the file.

Night: one helpful ask in a group you already belong to. Answer someone's actual question with a useful line, then mention the file once in your profile or in a comment if the group allows it. Also send five personal messages to people who do the job. Do not open a second niche. Do not wait until Monday.

The path, step by step

Step 1. Sit with a practitioner and list the hated jobs

Even if the practitioner is you. Write the jobs they hate writing. Ten of them. Use their words: "the no-show text I never send because I sound mad," not "customer retention." If you are not

the practitioner, pay for 30 minutes and record the list, the channel, the length, and the never-say list. Inside knowledge is the only moat this product has. Without it you will write clever prompts that do not match the job.

Step 2. Star the five that happen every week

Those five become the spine of the 25. Five jobs times five prompts each is a month of work, including variants: 24-hour vs same-day, SMS vs email, one child vs sibling. Do not spend the 25 on annual jobs. Weekly is what they will use the same day, which is how this path defines a first sale.

Step 3. Write each prompt as a four-part form

"Paste [named fields]. I will return [output] in [format and length]. I will not [constraint]. Done when [send test]." If you cannot fill those blanks, you do not have a prompt. You have a slogan. "Write a reminder text" is free and useless. "Paste parent first name, child first name, appointment day, appointment time, clinic phone. Return one SMS under 160 characters. No diagnosis language. No 'just checking in.' Done when a tired parent could tap send." is a product.

Step 4. Pair a second-pass polish prompt with each draft family

"Tighten this. Keep the facts. Cut the fluff. Stay under 160 characters. Do not add cute warmth. Do not add a diagnosis." Pair it with the draft so they are not stuck with a first-pass robot paragraph. One polish prompt can serve a whole family.

Step 5. Run all 25 on realistic inputs

Fake names. Real rhythms. Save outputs. If you would not send it, rewrite the prompt, not the output. The product is the prompt that produces sendable work, not a hand-edited miracle. Skipping the run-through is how you discover a bad prompt after a refund.

Step 6. Keep three before/after proofs and blur the names

Before is what they would have sent, or a generic dump of the same inputs. After is what your prompt produced, sendable with little edit — if you had to heavily edit, the prompt is not done.

Names blurred. Texture kept. Do not invent clinical advice. Do not scrape a clinic's real SMS. Put the three proofs in the file, not only on the sales page.

Step 7. Date the tests on page one

"Tested on [model], [month year]." Put it on page one and next to the three proofs. Models move. If the date is six months old, run the 25 again before you advertise. This is why you sell 25 for one niche, not 1,000 for everyone.

Step 8. Write the one-page SOP

A table: day or trigger, job, prompt number, channel. Monday 24-hour reminders: prompt 1, SMS. Tuesday waitlist: prompt 6, SMS. This is the difference between a pile and a stack. Write the SOP before they ask.

Step 9. Put it in a PDF (or Notion plus a PDF backup)

PDF is simpler for Stripe and Etsy. Notion is fine with a duplicate-this link and a PDF backup. Copy-paste blocks that are the whole prompt. Numbered headings. Cover page: title with niche word, who it is for, what it will not do, tested-on date, reply-to. No twelve-page brand story.

Step 10. Title includes the niche word they would search

"25 prompts for pediatric clinic SMS and parent emails — inputs, format, done check." Not "AI magic for healthcare creators." Put the niche word first. Put the job. Put "prompts." Generic "ChatGPT prompts" on Etsy is a graveyard. "Pediatric clinic SMS prompts" is a search.

Step 11. Checkout, then buy it yourself

Stripe Payment Link, Etsy, or Stan. Sell on your site first. Marketplace second if the titles match search. One product, one price, one file. Test-buy from a second email, on a phone. Open the PDF. Put the refund line on the page. Put the limit line on the page. If the page is a menu of six ideas, cut it back to this stack.

Step 12. Ten personal shares, help first

DMs to people who do the job. One helpful comment in a group you already belong to, once. One post with the niche word. Help first: answer someone's actual question with a useful line, then mention the file once in your profile if the group allows it. Not a dump of 25 prompts in the thread. First sale can be someone you know who does the job. Ask what they used.

Step 13. Ask the first buyer which prompt they used the same day

That prompt becomes your public example. If they tripped, fix that prompt the same week and send v1.1. One used prompt is worth more than a redesign. Put their (blurred, permitted) line on the sales page: "Used prompt 3, same-day reminder, the afternoon I bought it."

Step 14. Only add a calendar or a second stack if they ask

Do not copy someone else's stack and swap the niche word. If two buyers ask "which one on Monday," you needed the SOP or the calendar. Add that page. If nobody asks for a realtor version, do not build a realtor version. Depth in one niche beats a catalog of costumes.

Step 15. Rerun when the model moves

When the model changes, run the 25 again, starting with the three proofs. If they break, fix the prompts, bump the date, email buyers if you have their addresses. The dated line is a promise. Keeping it is how a \$19 file earns a \$29 bundle later.

Step 16. Stop

Do not add a community. Do not add a \$97 course of you reading the 25. Do not open five Etsy listings with synonym titles. One stack, one title, one price, one room. When a stranger has used prompt 1 the same day, you may consider the skill-pack version of the best five. Not before.

A worked example

Priya, pediatric clinic SMS and emails, \$19

Priya has worked the front desk of a pediatric clinic. She knows the week: reminder texts, waitlist offers, cancellation messages, after-visit thank-yous, no-show follow-ups, form

reminders, weather closures, and the portal redirect. She does not write treatment advice. She writes the operational messages parents actually need.

On a Sunday in March she writes the one sentence: "I help pediatric clinic staff write the week's SMS and emails in 25 prompts with inputs, format, and a done check, even if they are scared of sounding cold or of saying the wrong medical thing." File: "25 prompts for pediatric clinic SMS and parent emails." Price: \$19. Format: PDF plus a one-page SOP.

Calendar: days 1 to 14

Day 1: she lists ten jobs and stars five. Days 2 to 4: she writes and runs 25. Eleven first drafts fail sendable: too long, too cute, or they invent a follow-up plan. She rewrites those eleven. Day 5: SOP and three proofs. Day 6: PDF, Stripe Payment Link, self-buy. Day 7: she answers a clinic-managers Facebook thread about no-show texts with two principles (no shame, one next step, no clinical content), then links her profile. She DMs five people she has worked with.

Day 8: two people from the group buy. \$38. She asks which prompt they used today. One says prompt 3, same-day reminder. Day 10: a stranger finds the listing because the title matched "pediatric clinic SMS." \$19. First stranger sale. Prompt 3 becomes the public example.

What the 25 cover

Five weekly jobs, five prompts each: appointment reminders, schedule changes, after-visit admin, front-desk FAQs the clinic is allowed to answer, and polish passes (shorten to 160, warmer without cute, Spanish draft to be checked, cut diagnosis language, never-say check). Every prompt starts with Paste: [fields]. Every prompt ends with Done when: [send test]. Every prompt includes I will not: diagnose, guess a result, promise a clinical outcome, or scold a parent.

The three proofs she kept

A reminder that sounded like a bill collector — generic model output, 52 words, "per our records you have failed to confirm." After: 21 words, child first name, time, clinic phone, no shame. A waitlist text that leaked another child's name — her first prompt draft allowed "another family cancelled." After: the prompt forbids extra names. "A time opened on Thursday at 3:30. Reply

YES if you want it." A thank-you email that invented a follow-up plan. After: the prompt forbids plans. Those three are why someone trusts the file.

The mistake and the recovery

On day 9 a buyer emails: "Prompt 11 (forms still due) told a parent the visit could not be completed if forms were missing. That is not true and it scared them." Priya had over-constrained the done check into a threat. She rewrites prompt 11 the same night: facts, one next step, no consequence she cannot stand behind. She emails v1.1 to both buyers. She adds a line on page one: "I will not invent a clinic policy." She dates the PDF "tested March 2026."

A fourth email arrives on day 12: "Is this HIPAA compliant?" She refunds \$19 with the sentence from the listing: no pack of prompts is a compliance program. She bolds that sentence on the page. That refund is a listing problem, not a product problem.

First stranger sale, dollars, shipped artifact

Shipped artifact: a 19-page PDF, SOP on page 2, prompts 1 to 25, three before/after, tested-on line, reply-to on the last page. Month 1: six sales at \$19, one refund, two people later buy the \$29 calendar bundle she adds in week 4 after they ask which prompt on Monday. Net about \$133 plus the two \$29s in week 4. Not a launch. A searchable tool. She does not start a realtor stack. She asks every buyer which prompt they used the same day, and prompt 3 stays the public example.

Copy you can actually send

Swap the niche word. Keep the constraints. Do not add hype.

Post

Generic prompt packs are free. This one is for [person] who has to write [job] every week. 25 prompts. Each one has inputs, output format, and a done check. \$19. [link]

If you already have a free list that refuses extra names and 200-character rambling, you do not need this. If you rewrite the instructions every Friday, this is the freeze.

DM

I put together 25 prompts for [niche job] — each one has inputs, output format, and a done check. \$19. If that is useful: [link]. If not, ignore.

I am not selling a model or a compliance certificate. I am selling the vocabulary and the constraints for [job].

Page hero

25 prompts for [niche job]. Inputs, output format, done check. Tested this month. \$19.

For [person] who writes [job] every week and is tired of sounding like a robot or saying the wrong thing. Operational writing only. No medical, legal, or financial claims.

Checkout

Title: 25 prompts for [niche job] — inputs, output format, done check. Tested this month.

Body: Who: [person] who writes [job] every week. What: 25 prompts, a one-page SOP for which to use when, three before/after. What it will not do: medical, legal, or financial claims. No compliance certificate. Tested on [model], [month year]. Price: \$19. Instant download. If it is not useful, or if you bought thinking this was a legal product, email me and I will refund.

Email 1 — the send

Subject: 25 prompts for [job], not 1,000 generic ones

I was tired of [person] staring at a blank text window every [day]. Each prompt tells you what to paste, what you get, and how you know it is sendable. \$19.

[link]

If the niche is wrong, delete this.

Email 2 — the proof

Subject: The reminder that sounded like a bill collector

Here is one before/after from the file. Before is a generic dump: 52 words, shame, no next step. After is 21 words, no diagnosis language. That is prompt 3. The other 24 plus the SOP: \$19. [link]

Email 3 — the quiet ask

Subject: Which prompt did you use today?

If you bought the stack, reply with the prompt number you used the same day. I will fix anything that tripped you. If you did not buy: the file is still \$19, still 25, still one niche. [link]

Refund

You asked for a refund. Here it is, no speech. If you bought thinking this was a compliance product, that is on my listing and I have made the limit clearer. If the prompts did not match how you actually send [job], tell me which prompt number. I will fix the file for everyone else. You do not have to help. The refund is already processing.

Group comment (help first)

I would not shame a no-show and I would not put clinical content in a text. One next step. Under 160 characters. If you want 25 of those, I put a file in my profile. The two principles are free: no shame, no diagnosis.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Assume evenings. This is four weeks to a used stack, not a prompt brand.

Week 1: 25 prompts and three proofs

Monday: list ten jobs, star five. Call a practitioner if the list is thin.

Tuesday through Saturday: write and run five prompts a night. Rewrite failures. Saturday night you should have 25 run. If you have 18, use Sunday. Do not list 18.

Sunday: three before/after, names blurred, SOP table drafted. A prompt you have not run is a guess.

Week 2: listing live, ten personal shares

Monday: cover page, limit line, tested-on date, export PDF. Title with the niche word.

Tuesday: checkout. Self-purchase from a second email on your phone. Fix the download if it fails. Price \$19.

Wednesday: five DMs to people who do the job. Help first. Link last.

Thursday: one helpful group comment, once, in a room you already belong to. Profile link, not a thread dump.

Friday: one public post with the niche word and the \$19.

Saturday: ask anyone who bought which prompt they used. Fix what they tripped on the same day.

Sunday: ten shares should be done. If they are not, send the remaining DMs. Do not redesign the cover instead. First sale can be someone you know who does the job.

Week 3: SOP in their hands, no second niche

If buyers ask "which one do I use on Monday," you needed the SOP. Add the one-page which-prompt-when if it was thin. Email it to people who already bought. Do not start a second niche. Repeat the public example of the prompt they used first. Rerun any prompt that produced a scared or illegal-sounding line. Count: shares, sales, prompt-used-first, refunds and why. If refunds say "I thought this was HIPAA," the listing is the bug.

Week 4: bundle only if they ask

A calendar or checklist if they ask for it. \$19 stays for the original, or \$29 for the bundle. Email the extra page free to people who already paid \$19. Update the "tested on [month year]" line if the model moved. Do not copy someone else's stack and swap the niche word. If nobody asked, keep \$19 and keep sharing the one title. Plan a second stack only after a stranger has used prompt 1 the same day.

Quality bar

Below the bar

A clever one-liner. A prompt with no inputs. A paragraph returned for an SMS channel. Extra names in a waitlist text. Diagnosis language. Shame. A title without the niche word. Fake-clean before/after. A thousand-prompt dump. "HIPAA compliant." A prompt you have not run. If a tired parent cannot paste and send, it is below the bar.

Above the bar

Paste [x]. I will return [y] in [format]. I will not [constraint]. Done when [check]. Length matches the channel. The after is sendable with little or no hand edit. Names blurred. Dated test. SOP maps the week. Page one states the limit. The first prompt survives a Friday afternoon. Sendable is not optional.

Test 1: the form test

Every prompt has the four parts. Open the PDF at a random page. If you land on a slogan, it fails. Fix that prompt before you advertise.

Test 2: the job-match test

Sit with a practitioner. If clinics send SMS under 160 characters, do not return a paragraph. If they are not allowed to name another patient, the prompt forbids extra names. If listings cannot invent granite counters, the prompt forbids invented finishes. Clever prompts that do not match the job are a listed mistake.

Test 3: the send test

Run it on realistic inputs. Would you send it? If you have to rewrite the output every time, the prompt is the product to fix. Do not ship a hand-edited miracle.

Test 4: the claims test

No medical, legal, or financial claims. No "HIPAA compliant prompts." No "this will win your case." Operational writing only. Put the limit on page one and in every clinical-adjacent prompt: "I will not diagnose, guess a result, or tell a parent to skip a visit."

Test 5: the same-day test

A buyer uses prompt 1 the same day without emailing you. That is the quality bar this path names. If they email "which one do I start with," the SOP failed. If they email "this sounds like a bill collector," prompt 1 failed. Fix this week, not in a v2 you never ship.

Metrics that matter (and vanity numbers to ignore)

Week 1

Count jobs listed, prompts written, prompts run, proofs kept (target 3), SOP exists, checkout self-buy works. If prompts run is less than 25, you do not have a product yet.

Day 30

Count personal shares (target 10 in week 2, then a few each week). Sales. Stranger sales as a subset. Which prompt number they used first. Refunds, with a one-word reason (compliance, mismatch, never-opened). Prompts that failed the run-through and got rewritten. Tested-on date. A healthy day-30: 25 run, 3 proofs, 10+ shares, 1+ stranger sale or at least one same-day use, 0 to 1 refunds and those are listing problems you already fixed.

Day 90

Count v1.1 shipped (yes/no). Calendar added only if asked. Second niche (should still be no, unless a stranger asked and you have a new inside source). Repeat buyers of the \$29 bundle. Which five prompts account for most "used first" answers — those five are the skill-pack candidates. Cash in the \$12 to \$29 window, totaled. If you have \$0 at day 90, the failure is usually title, unrun prompts, or shares you did not send. It is rarely "the market."

Ignore these

Prompt count above 25. Etsy hearts. "1,000 prompts" as a flex. Downloads of a free 5-prompt teaser that never converts. Page views from people searching "free ChatGPT prompts." Likes on a post that did not name the niche word. A competitor's vault size. Your own urge to add a community.

One-line spreadsheet

Columns: date, shares, sales, stranger sales, prompt-used-first, refunds-reason, tested-on date, notes (rewrite which #). One row a week. If the tested-on date is six months old, run the 25 again before you advertise. If prompt-used-first is always empty, you are not asking. Ask. That number is how you choose the public example and how you know the stack is a tool, not a collectible.

Objections you will hear

"There are free prompt lists everywhere."

Yes. Generic ones. This stack is the vocabulary and constraints for [niche]. If a free list already has your "I will not" line and your done check, use the free list. If it writes a paragraph a parent will not send, \$19 is the niche version.

"Is this HIPAA / legally safe?"

No prompt pack is a compliance program. These are writing aids for operational messages. Clinic policy still applies. I will refund you if you bought thinking this was a legal product. It is not. I will not sell you a "HIPAA prompt." If you need a compliance vendor, that is a different purchase.

"Can't I write my own prompts?"

You can. You are paying for 25 that already ran on realistic inputs, with before/after, and a SOP for which to use when. If you like writing prompts, write them. If you have a clinic week to get through, buy the stack.

"Will they still work next month?"

Models move. The file is dated. When they move, I run the 25 again and send v1.1. That is why I sell 25 for one niche, not 1,000 for everyone.

"Can you add clinical advice prompts?"

No. Operational writing only. That is a hard line on this path. If they need clinical content, they need a clinician, not a \$19 PDF.

"I already have ChatGPT."

Good. These prompts are the constraints and the vocabulary for [niche], not a new model. If your current prompt already refuses extra names, diagnosis language, and 200-character rambling, you do not need this. If you rewrite the instructions every time, \$19 is the freeze.

"Why would I pay \$19 when Etsy has a 500-prompt pack for \$8?"

Because you will not send 500. You will send this week's reminder. Mine is 25, run, with a SOP and three proofs, for one job. The \$8 pack is a toy. I will refund you if you open prompt 1 and it is not sendable.

"Can you make one for every kind of clinic?"

No. Pediatric front desk is the file. Urgent care is a different never-say list. Do not buy this and search-replace.

"I need you to install this in our SMS tool."

That is a custom project, not this \$19 PDF. If you want it inside a tool, that is a billed setup. I will not hide that inside the checkout.

"My manager will not let us use AI."

Then do not buy this. I am not a policy workaround. If they allow drafting with a human send, this is a draft aid.

How this feeds other paths

Upstream: what you need before this

You need inside knowledge of a trade, or a paid hour with someone who has it. If you have never finished the messages, take a productized service job first, then write the stack from the scars.

Downstream: products that are the same job in another shape

The SOP and the sequence become Sell an AI playbook. The installed version of the best five prompts becomes Ship a Claude or ChatGPT skill pack. The calendar becomes AI templates and SOPs. Do not split until a stranger has used prompt one the same day. Live drops: a dated zip when the model changes. Your front door: "which of these five weekly jobs hurts" then the stack. A weekly AI letter: one prompt taught, link to the 25.

Where the before/after go

AI-assisted short-form: one before/after per video. End card: the file is \$19, link in bio. Do not explain the other 24 in 20 seconds. Teach prompt 3. Sell the stack.

Services, carefully

Local businesses + AI and Productized AI service: sit with one clinic, write their 25, charge a project fee, then productize the generic version with names removed. Custom setups if they want it inside their SMS tool. Do not promise that inside the \$19 PDF. If a reply says "can you just do this for us," send a price or send the cheaper file.

What not to feed yet

A membership. A 200-prompt vault. Thirty days, one stack, one niche word. After a stranger uses it, the next path is the one they asked for.

Mistakes that kill this path

1. Clever prompts that do not match the job

Recovery this week: sit with a practitioner for 30 minutes. Rewrite any prompt that returns the wrong channel or length. Cut the clever one-liners.

2. Medical, legal, or financial claims

Recovery this week: delete the claims from the cover, the listing, and every prompt. Add the limit line on page one. Refund anyone who bought for compliance.

3. Copying someone else's stack and swapping the niche word

Recovery this week: stop listing it. Write from the inside or skip the niche. A costume stack produces refunds and a reputation you will not repair with a new cover.

4. A title without the niche word

Recovery this week: rename. "25 prompts for pediatric clinic SMS" not "AI magic pack." Same file, new title, same \$19.

5. Prompts with no done check

Recovery this week: add "Done when [send test]" to all 25. Rerun three. Export. Email v1.1.

6. Skipping the run-through

Recovery this week: run all 25 on realistic inputs before you send another share. Rewrite failures. Do not discover a bad prompt after a refund.

7. Before/after that are fake-clean or leaked

Recovery this week: reconstruct with fake names. Keep texture. Never put another child's name in a waitlist example. Never scrape a clinic's real SMS.

8. A thousand-prompt dump to "look like value"

Recovery this week: ship 25. Archive the rest. Value is sendable, not countable.

9. Selling to "entrepreneurs"

Recovery this week: pick a trade. Put that word in the title. Share in that room. Entrepreneurs buy vaults and do not send texts.

10. Promising HIPAA, court, or tax outcomes

Recovery this week: same as claims. Refund. Clarify. Do not argue in the review.

11. Starting a second niche before a same-day use

Recovery this week: close the other draft. Ask the people who already bought which prompt they used. Fix that one.

12. Dumping 25 prompts in a Facebook thread

Recovery this week: delete if you can. Help in the next thread with two principles and a profile link. Do not fight mods.

Ethics, restated

Do not put another child's name in a waitlist example. Do not invent clinical advice to make a proof dramatic. Do not scrape a clinic's real SMS. Blur, reconstruct, respect the room.

Tools and how you actually use them

Exact stack

A Google Doc or Word file while you draft. Export to PDF. Notion only if your buyer already lives there, plus a PDF backup. One model tab you already pay for. Stripe Payment Link, Etsy, or Stan. A second email for the test-buy. A sheet: prompt number, ran, sendable, rewrite. Do not add a prompt marketplace account in week one.

Setup order

Open a doc. Title with the niche word. Page one: who, limit, tested-on date (fill the date after the run). Write the SOP table as a skeleton. Write prompts 1 to 25 as forms. Run them in the model you will name on page one. Paste proofs. Export PDF. Create the payment link with that PDF. Buy it from the second email. Then share. Do not set up Etsy before the self-buy works. Do not buy a prompt-management app.

What not to buy

A prompt marketplace membership. A "1,000 viral prompts" pack to reskin. A HIPAA course so you can claim compliance. A designer for a cover that hides the niche word. Ads. A second checkout tool. A community platform. A course platform. You are selling a \$19 PDF.

The \$0 path

Docs or Word you already have. A model free tier is enough to run 25 if you already use one. Checkout: Stripe Payment Link (cost per sale) or Etsy if you already have an account. Export PDF from Docs. Share in a group you already belong to. You do not need Notion or a new phone.

How you run the 25

One sitting per job family. Paste realistic inputs. Save the output. If you would not send it, rewrite the prompt, not the output. Dated tests: page one gets the model name and month. When the model changes, rerun the three proofs first. If they break, fix, bump the date, email buyers if you have their addresses. Filename: "pediatric-clinic-sms-prompts.pdf" not "FINAL_v7." Reply-to on the last page.

Ship checklist

Print this. Tick it. Do not list until the file half is honest.

Before the file is a product

Niche word in the title

One-sentence offer with person, job, 25, and the even-if

Ten hated writing jobs listed from the inside

Five weekly jobs starred

25 prompts, each with inputs, output format, constraint, done check

All 25 run on realistic inputs

Failures rewritten, not hand-edited as miracles

Three before/after, names blurred, texture kept

No extra names in waitlist examples

No invented clinical, legal, or financial advice in proofs

One-page SOP: which prompt when, channel named

Second-pass polish prompts included

"Tested on [month year]" on page one

Limit line on page one: no medical, legal, or financial claims

Reply-to on the last page

Filename a human would search

Before you share

Price \$19 (or \$12 to \$29)

Price on the page, not "DM me"

Refund line on the page

Self-purchase works from a second email on a phone

PDF opens

Ten personal shares listed by name

One helpful group ask, once, in a room you already belong to

Profile or listing uses the same niche word as the title

No second niche in the cart

After the first use

Asked which prompt they used the same day

That prompt is the public example

Fixed anything they tripped on, same week

v1.1 dated if you changed more than a typo

Refunded compliance-seekers without a speech

Did not add a second niche

Spreadsheet row filled: shares, sales, prompt-used-first, refunds

FAQ

Why 25? Why not 100?

Twenty-five that finish a month of weekly jobs beat 100 clever orphans. If you have more, you probably have a second stack. Sell this one first. Default: 25, five families of five.

PDF or Notion?

Either. PDF for Stripe and Etsy. Notion if your buyer already lives there. Include the three proofs in both cases, and a PDF backup if you use Notion. Default: PDF.

Can I sell on Etsy in week one?

You can. Site first is cleaner so you can email v1.1. Etsy second if the title matches search. Default: site first.

What if I am not in that trade?

Sit with a practitioner or skip the niche. Swapping the niche word on someone else's stack is a listed mistake and it produces prompts that do not match the job. Default: skip the niche you have not sat in.

Can I include clinical or legal language?

No. Operational writing only. No medical, legal, or financial claims. If Priya's clinic stack starts drafting treatment plans, she cut those prompts. Appointment SMS, not care. Default: cut it.

Do I need before/after on the sales page?

Yes. Three. Blur names. Keep the texture. They are the reason a stranger believes this is not another free list. Default: three in the file and at least one on the page.

\$12 or \$19?

\$19 for 25 plus SOP plus proofs. \$12 if you only have one job and ten prompts. \$29 if they asked for the calendar. Stay in \$12 to \$29. Default: \$19.

What do I do when the model changes?

Rerun the 25. Fix what broke. Date the file. Email v1.1 if you can. That is why you do not sell 1,000. Default: rerun the three proofs the week the model moves.

Can I copy a competitor and change "realtor" to "clinic"?

No. Copying someone else's stack and swapping the niche word is how you ship clever prompts that do not match the job. Write from the inside. Default: do not list a costume.

Is this the same as a skill pack?

No. Prompt stacks are paste-as-you-go. Skill packs are installed. Default: this path first; skill pack of the best five after a same-day use.

How long should each prompt be?

Long enough to name inputs, format, constraint, and done check. Usually a short paragraph. Default: one copy-paste block per prompt.

Should I offer a free 5-prompt teaser?

Skip the teaser in month one. Sell the 25. Default: no teaser.

What if the group bans links?

Help with two principles. Put the file in your profile. Do not fight the mods. Default: profile link, one comment, stop.

Do I need a brand name?

No. You need a niche word in the title. Default: searchable title, your name or no name.

Can I sell this as a subscription?

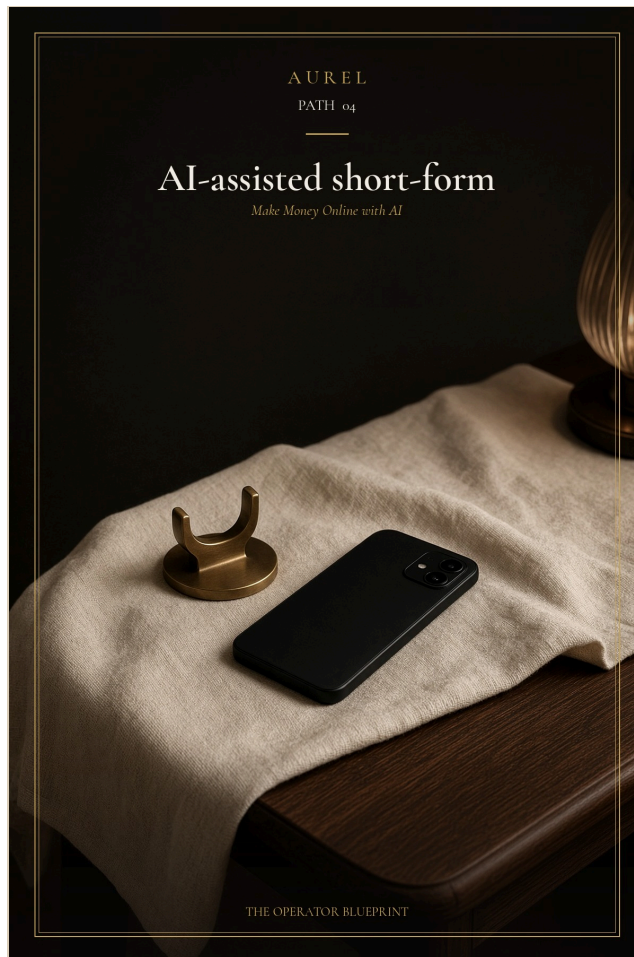
No. It is a \$19 file. v1.1 is an email, not a monthly. Default: one-time \$19.

What if nobody uses it the same day?

Ask. If they will not answer, prompt 1 or the SOP is weak. Fix prompt 1 this week. Default: fix prompt 1, do not add 75 more prompts.

Should I run ads to the listing?

Not until a stranger has bought from a title match or a personal share. Default: no ads in month one.



PATH 04

AI-assisted short-form

AI writes the outline. You say it. The offer sits at the end, every time.

36 minute read · 7,943 words

Who this is for

You can talk to a camera or screen-record, and you have one \$19 file to sell.

Time to first

14–30 days of posting on one platform

Tools

First sale

A profile visit that becomes an email or a \$19 checkout.

Cash window

Traffic to a \$19–\$47 file

Leave this alone

Phone, CapCut, one platform for 30 days, Stan or Beacons.

Five platforms. Faceless slideshows with no offer. Buying views.

What this actually is

Definition

AI-assisted short-form is 14 to 30 days of posting on one platform so a profile visit becomes an email or a \$19 checkout. Every video does one of three things: teach a small piece, diagnose a mistake, or send them to the next step. If it does none of those, it is entertainment you are not getting paid for. The offer sits at the end, every time. Same offer. Same link in the bio. You already have one thing to sell — a playbook, a skill pack, a prompt stack, an SOP. Short-form is how strangers find it.

This path is not "become a creator." It is a 30-day posting job with a file at the other end of the tap. AI writes the outline. You say it. That split is the whole method.

What this is not

Not five platforms. Not buying views. Not a 20-second tour of your whole catalog. Not waiting for the algorithm to "pick you" before you put a link in the bio. Not a faceless slideshow of quotes with no offer. Not a 3-minute origin story. Not a content business that sells the videos. The videos are the tap. The file is the drink.

You do not post AI voiceover over stock clips and call it a business. If you will not show your face, screen-record the work. Either way, a human says the words. The algorithm is not the bottleneck. Volume of honest posts is.

Why it works now

Short-form still sends strangers to a bio faster than a blog post. The window is not "go viral." The window is: a tired person watches 20 seconds of a job they recognize, hears a price, taps a link. That loop still works in 2026 because most accounts either have no offer, or they have seven

offers, or they read a press-release script. One file, spoken in a kitchen voice, at the end of every clip, is rare enough to convert.

AI is useful for hooks and outlines because staring at a blank notes app is how people skip a day. Generate twenty hooks. Speak the three you would actually say to a friend. Cut the rest. The model is a starter. You are the voice. Watchers can smell a paste. They came for a person who does the job.

Anti-pattern 1: five platforms to be safe

TikTok plus Instagram plus Shorts plus LinkedIn plus Pinterest in week 1 is how you stay at video three forever. Each app has a slightly different shape. You will spend the month on resizing and captions and never learn which five shapes earn saves. One platform for 30 days. After a stranger buys, remix the winners. Not before.

Anti-pattern 2: faceless slideshows with no offer

Silent carousels of quotes, stock footage, a caption that says "follow for more." That is a hobby with better lighting. If you screen-record the SOP and speak, that is not a slideshow. If you hide because you hate your face, use the screen. The offer still sits at the end. Faceless with no file is in the leave-alone line on purpose.

Anti-pattern 3: buying views

A cheap view on a video with no offer still converts to zero. Paid traffic before you know which shape a stranger watched is how you buy tourists. Creator ads with AI scripts is a later path, after a stranger has bought from organic posts. Do not jump-start a 30-day test with a credit card.

The deal you keep

You keep four promises. One: one platform for 30 days. Two: one file in the bio, price spoken at the end of every video. Three: AI outlines, you say it, in a voice you would use in a kitchen. Four: you read comments and turn objections into next week's scripts. The watcher keeps one promise in return: if the job is theirs, they know the next step without thinking. Same words, every time, so people who watch three videos can name the file.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

Fits if

You can talk to a camera or screen-record, and you have one thing to sell. You do not need to like how you look. You need to be willing to post 30 times on one app without switching when a post dies. You already have the file, or you will have it in week 1 (a \$19 SOP is enough). Short-form without an offer is a hobby. Short-form with a \$19 to \$47 file is this path.

You can batch two hours on a weekend. You can fix captions in CapCut. You can say "\$19" out loud without flinching. You already open TikTok, Instagram, or YouTube at night, which is how you pick the room.

Skip if

Skip if you will not press record. Skip if you planned to run five apps "to be safe." Skip if you want to buy views or followers. Skip if you have no file and no email capture — then go write the playbook, the SOP, or the prompt stack first.

If you freeze on camera, screen-record the job: the SOP, the prompt, the before/after. Your voice on the work is enough. If you will not even do that, this path will punish you for 30 days and then you will quit.

Skip if you need a sale tomorrow. This path names 14 to 30 days of posting. First stranger checkout often lands in week 2 or 3, after a handful of shapes have been seen twice. If you need cash this week, take a service job, then come back with the notes as the file.

The honest middle

Shy is allowed. Inconsistent is not. One platform, one offer, 30 days. That is the deal. You do not need a ring light, a brand kit, or a nice wall. You need a quiet room, a window, a phone, and a file that exists at checkout before video 1.

If you have two products, pick the \$19 one for 30 days. The other can wait. If you have zero products, this is not your first path this month.

Skills and time

You need: a phone that records, CapCut or the phone's trim and captions, a Stan or Beacons link, one file live, and the willingness to post on ugly days. You do not need editing skill beyond a trim and on-screen text. You do not need a following.

Time with a job: one two-hour batch on Sunday (seven to ten clips), then 10 minutes a weekday to post, pin a comment, and save objections. Thirty days on the calendar, including the days you do not feel like it. If you miss a day, post two the next. Do not restart on Monday.

Two-minute self-test

Answer out loud. Stall on two and this is not your first path this month.

What is the one file, in one line, with a price?

Which one app do you already open at night?

Can you film three 20-second videos this week: a mistake, a principle, a walkthrough?

Will you say "\$19, link in bio" at the end of all three?

If a post dies on day 4, will you still post on day 5 on the same app?

Is the checkout tested on your phone, on cellular?

If you have the file, the app, and the willingness to post 30 times, start. If you only have "I should be on TikTok," go ship the \$19 SOP first.

The watcher on the other side

They are not a fan. They are a person who does the job, watching muted on a couch. They will read the on-screen text, hear a kitchen voice if the sound is on, and decide in 20 seconds whether the file is for them. They will not hunt a menu. They will tap a bio that names one job and one price, or they will scroll.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this before you film

"Every video I post on [one platform] teaches one piece of [named job] and ends with [file name], \$19, link in bio, even if I hate how I look on camera."

If you cannot fill the brackets, you do not have an offer. You have a content hobby. The bio is the offer. Not a menu. Not "links, courses, coaching, merch." One file, one price, one link (Stan or Beacons).

Five sentences that already work

Every Instagram video teaches one piece of Friday follow-up for solo service people and ends with the 1-page SOP, \$19, link in bio.

Every TikTok shows one mistake in pediatric clinic SMS and ends with the 25-prompt stack, \$19, link in bio.

Every Short walks through one step of a landscaper's 10-day content playbook and ends with the \$29 file, link in bio.

Every Reel is a 90-second timer of filling a Notion calendar, then "the filled template is \$19, link in bio."

Every clip diagnoses one fake-sounding AI email, then points at the follow-up skill pack, \$19, same link.

Write yours in that shape. One platform. One job. One file. One price. Spoken at the end. If you need "and my course and my coaching" to feel complete, you made the bio a junk drawer.

What they get

They get 20 seconds of a job they recognize, on-screen text if they watch muted, a spoken price, and a bio that matches the end card. They get the same checkout every time. Teach a piece of the SOP, diagnose a mistake the SOP prevents, or walk through one step. Last line, spoken: "The file is \$19. Link in bio." Same words, every time.

This path does not sell the videos. It sells traffic to a \$19 to \$47 file. If you have nothing at checkout, you are posting for free.

What they do not get

A catalog. A live Q&A in week 1. A custom critique in DMs. A second product "while I have you." A community. A 3-minute origin. A free file that is only a sales letter. They get one next step. If they DM "can you just do this for me," that is a service path with a price, not a free consulting hour inside a comment thread.

Packaging

Bio: one line plus the link. Example: "The 1-page [job] SOP. \$19. I post how I use it." Pin comment on every post: "SOP is \$19. Link in bio." End card, spoken, last two seconds: "The file is \$19. Link in bio. One job, not a catalog." Caption: one sentence that repeats the hook, then the price. Three hashtags at most if the platform is picky, none if it is not.

Put the file up before day 1 of posting, even if it is ugly. You can pretty it later. You cannot retrofit an offer onto 30 videos with no link.

What "done" looks like

Definition

Done after 30 days is thirty posts on one platform, the same offer at the end, comments read, five shapes kept, and at least one profile visit that became an email or a \$19 checkout. That is the first sale this path names. Done after 72 hours is smaller: one platform, bio live, checkout tested, three videos filmed, one posted, five more batched, twenty hooks on a note.

Done is not a viral post with no link. Done is not a second platform "because this one is dead." Done is boring on purpose: volume, one file, one place.

Fairness test

Would you send a friend to your bio and trust they can name the file and the price in five seconds? If the bio is a menu, it is not fair. If the last two seconds of the video do not name the file and the price, the video failed even if it performed. If checkout is broken on cellular, nothing else is fair. Ask two watchers what they thought you sold. If they cannot name the file, your end card failed.

Technical done (72 hours)

One platform chosen. One-line offer in the bio. Checkout works on your phone. Three 20-second videos filmed (a mistake, a principle, a walkthrough). One posted today. Five more batched or scheduled. Twenty hooks on a note, three of them spoken in your mouth. On-screen text on all three. End card words decided and reused. Pin comment ready to paste.

Technical done (30 days)

Thirty posts on that one platform. Same offer at the end. At least five scripts taken from objections. Five shapes that got saves or comments, kept. The rest, retired. Captions fixed so the \$19 line is spelled right. At least one profile visit that became an email or a \$19 checkout. You asked that buyer which video they watched.

Not-done-yet list

No file at checkout

Bio is a menu

Price never spoken

No on-screen text

AI outline read word for word

Second platform opened because a post died

Offer changed in week 2

Zero batches, so every morning is a negotiation

Comments unread

Pin comment missing

Link untested on cellular

A 20-second catalog of three products

If three of those are true, you are posting, not running this path. Fix the list this week. Do not film video 41 until the bio and the end card are honest.

Pricing that holds

Ranges

You are not selling a "content package." You are pointing at a \$19 to \$47 file. \$19 SOP is the cleanest first product for this path. \$29 to \$47 if the file already has templates. Do not launch a \$97 cohort from a 20-second clip. The clip cannot hold that weight yet. Stay in the cash window: traffic to a \$19 to \$47 file.

Say "\$19" out loud at the end. People who will never buy still respect a number. People who might buy should not have to DM you to hear it. Pin a comment with the next step if the platform allows it: "SOP is \$19. Link in bio."

When to raise

Raise the file after a stranger has bought from organic posts and you have added something they used: a second template, a 14-day calendar, the three scripts they asked for. Then \$19 can become \$29 or \$47. Do not raise because a video got views. Views are not revenue. Do not raise by adding a \$97 "mentorship" in week 3. The 20-second clip still cannot hold it.

Refunds in one sentence

If it is not useful, email me and I will refund. I will not hop on a call to recap the SOP.

You will refund almost nobody if chapter one or prompt 1 works. You will refund the person who thought the video was the product. Make the end card clearer.

Never charge for these

Never charge for views you bought. Never charge a "content audit" in DMs as a way to avoid posting. Never charge for the videos themselves in month one. Never hide the price behind "link in bio, DM me." Never run ads until a stranger has bought organic and you know which shape they watched.

Worked dollars

Jordan has a one-page SOP at \$19. They post 30 times on Instagram. Views are uneven. Two posts do nothing. One 90-second timer walkthrough gets saves. A stranger buys on day 18 from the bio after watching the timer video and the three-paragraph diagnosis. \$19. Jordan asks what they watched. They say the timer. That shape becomes the next five posts. Two more checkouts in week 4, same file. Month 1: \$57 from the bio, zero ad spend, one platform. That is the path. Not a creator career. Traffic to a \$19 file.

The first 72 hours

Day 1 morning: pick the room and the line

Pick one platform. TikTok, Instagram, or YouTube Shorts — not all three. If you already spend time watching one of those apps, post there. Do not pick the "serious" platform you never open. Write the one-line offer that every video can point to. Put it in the bio with Stan or Beacons. Test the link on your phone, on cellular. If the file is not live, stop and ship a \$19 SOP today. Do not film into a dead checkout.

Day 1 afternoon: 20 hooks, then three you would say

Generate 20 hooks. Speak only the lines you would say to a friend. Paste this, then cut anything that sounds like a press release:

Give me 20 spoken hooks for a 20-second video. Buyer: [person]. File I sell: [SOP name], \$19. Each hook is one sentence I would say in a kitchen. Pattern: "Stop doing [common thing] if you want [result]." No hype. No "wait for it." No hashtags in the hook.

Circle three. Write a one-line body for each: the mistake, the principle, or the walkthrough. The last two seconds are already decided: "The file is \$19. Link in bio. One job, not a catalog."

Day 1 night: film three, post one

Film three 20-second videos: a mistake, a principle, a walkthrough. Phone on a stack of books. Window light. Same wall is fine. On-screen text for mute. Same end card. Post one today. Do not

wait until Monday. Do not buy a ring light. Do not open a second account. Do not design a brand kit. The algorithm is not the bottleneck. Volume of honest posts is.

Day 2: captions, pin, batch folder

CapCut auto-captions, then fix names and the \$19 line. Wrong captions kill trust. Pin the comment: "SOP is \$19. Link in bio." Put the other two videos in a folder named by day. Read any comments. Save objections into a note. If you have no comments yet, that is normal. You have one post.

Day 3: batch the next five

Two hours. Five more clips. Same shirt is fine. Same three types on a loop. You do not need a fourth type. Export, schedule or dump into the folder. Publish one a day starting today if you have not already. That is the 72 hours. Do not check analytics for more than five minutes. You do not have enough posts to learn anything yet.

The path, step by step

Step 1. One offer in the bio

Not a menu. Stan or Beacons, one button, one file. If you have two products, pick the \$19 one for 30 days. The other can wait. Test the link on cellular. If you cannot name the file in one line, you do not have an offer. Go back to Sell an AI playbook or AI templates and SOPs and ship the file, then return.

Step 2. A hook formula, spoken in the first second

"Stop doing [common thing] if you want [result]." Then show the better way in 15 seconds. The hook is spoken in the first second, also on-screen for people who watch muted. Other patterns that fit: "If your [artifact] looks like this, that is why [bad result]." "I timed this. [N] seconds. Then I sent it." Generate 20. Speak three.

Step 3. Pick one picture style for 30 days

Your face or your screen. Keep it. Switching from talking-head to slideshow to car-vlog trains nobody, including you. On-screen text always, for muted watchers. Lighting can be a window. Audio can be the phone mic in a quiet room.

Step 4. Batch. Two hours, ten videos

Two hours, ten videos, beats ten days of "I should post." Phone on a stack of books. Same shirt is fine. Same wall is fine. CapCut to add captions. Export, schedule or dump into a folder named by day. If you negotiate with yourself every morning, you will skip. The batch is how you stay on the 30-day clock.

Step 5. Read comments. Objections are next week's scripts

Paste them into a note, then into AI for outlines, then rewrite. "This is too simple" becomes a video that shows the mistake of overbuilding. "I do not have time" becomes a 20-second timer of you doing one step. If you have no comments yet, film the three objections you already believe: too simple, no time, I could do this myself.

Step 6. Pin a comment with the next step

"SOP is \$19. Link in bio. One job, not a catalog." Do this on every post for 30 days so you are not relying on people to read a tiny bio. If the platform does not allow pins, put the same line as the first comment you post yourself.

Step 7. Loop the three types

A mistake, a principle, a walkthrough. You do not need a fourth type in month one. Variety is how people stall. Week 3 you will repeat the two shapes that got saves. That is not boring. That is how a stranger sees the file twice and buys.

Step 8. End card, spoken, every time

"The file is \$19. Link in bio. One job, not a catalog." Same words. Boredom here is a feature. Recognition is the point. If the last two seconds do not name the file and the price, the video failed the bar even if it performed.

Step 9. Fix captions so the \$19 line is spelled right

CapCut auto-captions, then a 15-minute pass per batch. Wrong captions kill trust. Names, prices, and the job word must be correct. Phone tools are enough if CapCut annoys you.

Step 10. Post one a day. Missed days get doubled, not restarted

If you miss a day, post two the next. Do not "restart on Monday." The 30-day clock includes the ugly days. You have a job; batch on the weekend so weekdays are just tap-post.

Step 11. After 30, keep five shapes, kill the rest

Saves and comments beat views. Views without saves are tourists. Repeat the five that earned saves, with new examples. Ask the first buyer which video they watched. That shape is the spine of the next 30.

Step 12. Do not switch platforms when a post dies

Dead posts are normal. Switching is how you stay at video three forever. Five platforms is in the leave-alone line. After a stranger buys, you may remix the five winning shapes onto a second app. Not before.

Step 13. Do not explain your whole catalog in 20 seconds

If you name three products, they will buy none. One job. One price. One link. Jordan did not mention the other files. You should not either.

Step 14. Screen-record if you will not show a face

Your voice on the SOP is enough. Faceless slideshows with no offer are how people post for months and sell nothing. The offer still sits at the end. Do not use AI voice if you can say the line. It usually sounds like a press release.

Step 15. After a stranger buys, ask what they watched

Write it down. Make the next five posts that shape with new examples. Do not start TikTok on day 19. Do not change the offer. The first-sale definition is a profile visit that became an email or

a \$19 checkout. Protect that loop.

Step 16. Stop adding gear and channels

No microphone haul in the first 30. No second letter. No membership announced from a 20-second clip. A quiet room and a window. Spend after a stranger checkout if audio was the actual complaint. Plan the next 30 only after a stranger has bought or you have 30 honest posts, whichever comes first.

A worked example

Jordan, one platform, 30 days, \$19 SOP

Jordan has a one-page SOP: "Friday follow-up for solo service people" — a sequence they already use to email clients who went quiet. Price: \$19. They pick Instagram. They do not open TikTok "as well." Bio: "Friday follow-up SOP. \$19. I show the steps here." Link: Stan. Checkout tested on cellular. File is a PDF, ugly, usable.

They generate 20 hooks. They speak three:

Stop rewriting the same "just checking in" email every Friday if you want people to actually reply.

If your follow-up is three paragraphs, they are not ignoring you. They are tired.

I time this. One client, 90 seconds, send. The SOP is \$19.

Calendar: days 1 to 30

Day 1, morning: bio and Stan live. Afternoon: 20 hooks, three circled. Night: three films, one posted (the three-paragraph diagnosis). Day 2: captions fixed, pin comment, folder started. Day 3, Saturday: two-hour batch of seven more. Weekdays: tap-post one.

Week 1: seven videos, same offer. Three mistakes (the long email, the guilt tone, the missing next date), two principles (one ask, one next date), two walkthroughs (screen-record the SOP, fill it for a fake client). Analytics glance: under five minutes. Nothing to learn yet.

Week 2: comments become scripts. Someone says "this only works if you have a list." Jordan films: "You need three names, not a CRM." Someone says "AI emails sound fake." Jordan films the human pass: "Generate, then cut the smile." Seven more posts. Still Instagram only.

Week 3: repeat the two shapes that got saves — the 90-second timer and the "three paragraphs" diagnosis. Same words, new example (a photographer, then a bookkeeper). Two posts from week 1 did nothing. They stay dead. Jordan does not switch apps.

Week 4: one longer walkthrough (60 to 90 seconds) of filling the SOP, still pointing at the same \$19 checkout. No live. A longer screen-record counts. Keep posting the five shapes they are keeping.

The mistake and the recovery

On day 11 Jordan films a "value" clip that names three other files "while I have you." Saves drop. A comment says "so what do you actually sell?" Jordan deletes the catalog line from the next five scripts. End card goes back to one file, \$19. They pin the SOP comment on the catalog video so the damage is a confused bio tap, not a dead end. Recovery is same week, not a rebrand.

First stranger sale, dollars, shipped artifact

Views were uneven. A stranger bought on day 18 from the bio after watching the timer video and the three-paragraph video. \$19. Jordan asked what they watched. They said the timer. That became the next five posts. Two more checkouts in week 4: \$38. Month 1 cash: \$57. Shipped artifact on the video side: 30 posts, one style (face plus a few screen-records of the SOP), one end card, a note of objections. Shipped artifact on the product side: the same one-page PDF they already had. They did not start TikTok on day 19. They did not explain their other two file ideas in a 20-second clip. They posted the SOP, \$19, one platform.

Copy you can actually send

Swap the job. Keep the kitchen voice. Same end card every time.

Post (caption under the video)

Stop starting from a blank follow-up if you need a reply this Friday. SOP is \$19, link in bio.

DM when someone comments "link?"

Here: [link]. \$19, one page, instant. If it is not useful, email me and I will refund. I will not hop on a call to recap the SOP.

Page hero (bio)

The 1-page [job] SOP. \$19. I post how I use it.

Checkout (Stan or Beacons button)

[Job] SOP — one page, \$19. Instant download. If it is not useful, email me and I will refund.

Email 1 — they tapped the link but did not buy

Subject: The file from the 90-second video

You watched the timer. The SOP is the sequence I used in that clip. \$19. One page. [link] If that was the wrong job, delete this.

Email 2 — after they buy

Subject: Which video did you watch?

Thanks for grabbing the SOP. Reply with the video that sent you — the timer, the three-paragraph one, or something else. I will make more of that. If you trip on a step, tell me which line. I will fix the file.

Email 3 — day 20, still no stranger sale

Subject: Same file, same \$19, still one job

I have posted [N] times on [platform]. The SOP is still \$19. If you have been watching and have not grabbed it: [link]. If you already own it, reply with the line you actually sent. If this is noise, unsubscribe.

Refund

You asked for a refund. Here it is, no speech. If you thought the videos were the product, that is on my end card and I have made the \$19 file louder. You do not have to explain. The refund is processing.

Hook (spoken, first second)

Stop doing [common thing] if you want [result].

Other hooks that fit:

If your [artifact] looks like this, that is why [bad result].

I timed this. [N] seconds. Then I sent it.

Stop starting from a blank chat if you need [result] this week.

End card (spoken, last two seconds)

The file is \$19. Link in bio. One job, not a catalog.

Pin comment

SOP is \$19. Link in bio. If you want the [job] sequence without guessing, that is the file.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Assume evenings plus one weekend batch. Four weeks of posting, not a media company.

Week 1: 7 videos, same offer (daily)

Sunday or Monday, two hours: batch seven clips. Mistake, principle, walkthrough, repeat. Same end card.

Monday: post 1. Pin comment. Save the folder.

Tuesday: post 2. Read comments. Five minutes of analytics, then stop.

Wednesday: post 3.

Thursday: post 4.

Friday: post 5.

Saturday: post 6. If you are short, film two more in 20 minutes rather than skip.

Sunday: post 7. Batch the next seven if you can. Do not check analytics for more than five minutes. You do not have enough posts to learn anything yet.

Week 2: 7 more, comments become scripts (daily)

Monday: read every comment from week 1. Paste objections into a note.

Tuesday: generate outlines from those objections, rewrite, film three.

Wednesday through Sunday: post one a day. If you have no comments yet, film the three objections you already believe: too simple, no time, I could do this myself. Answer them in 20 seconds. Help first in any niche group you already belong to — not a dump of seven links.

Week 3: repeat winners

Look at saves and comments, not views. Repeat those shapes with new examples. Kill the clever ones nobody saved. Still one platform. Still \$19. Still the same end card. If you named three products in a clip, that clip is retired.

Week 4: one longer piece, same checkout

One live or one longer walkthrough pointing at the same checkout. If live terrifies you, a 60-second screen-record of the SOP filled in is enough. Then keep posting the five shapes you are keeping. Plan the next 30 only after a stranger has bought or you have 30 honest posts, whichever comes first. Do not add a Friday bonus account because you felt guilty about a dead post.

Quality bar

Below the bar

A press-release voice. "Smash that." AI outline read word for word. No on-screen text. No offer in the last two seconds. A menu in the bio. Faceless quotes. Bought views. Five platforms. A 20-second catalog. Hashtag stuffing instead of a pin comment. Checking views hourly. Starting over on Monday. A video that performed and still cannot name the file.

Above the bar

A voice you would use in a kitchen. If you would not say the line to a friend, cut it. AI outlines; you say it. On-screen text for mute. Face or screen, one style for 30 days. Offer spoken at the end. Price on the pin comment. Captions spell \$19 right. The watcher can name the file after three videos.

Test 1: the kitchen-table test

Play the clip out loud. If a line makes you wince, cut it. If you would not say "smash that" to a friend, do not say it here.

Test 2: the mute test

Watch with sound off. Can you still get the hook and the \$19? If not, on-screen text failed.

Test 3: the offer test

If the last two seconds do not name the file and the price, the video failed the bar even if it performed. Entertainment you are not getting paid for is the original warning. Put the offer on.

Test 4: the bio test

Hand your phone to someone who does not know you. Five seconds on the profile. Can they name the file and the price? If they say "you do a lot of things," the bio is a menu.

Test 5: the stranger-sale test

A profile visit became an email or a \$19 checkout. Ask which video they watched. If you have 40,000 views and zero taps, the bio or the end card is wrong. Fix those before you film video 41.

Metrics that matter (and vanity numbers to ignore)

Week 1

Count posts published (target 7), batch sessions (target 1), checkout self-test on cellular (yes/no), bio is one offer (yes/no), end card used on every clip (yes/no). Do not count followers. Do not count a view spike. You do not have enough posts to learn yet.

Day 30

Posts published (aim 7 a week, 30 in the window). Saves and comments, especially objections you can reuse. Profile visits. Link taps. Emails captured or \$19 checkouts from the bio. Which 5 shapes earned the saves. Which video the first buyer watched. A healthy day-30: 30 posts, one platform, one file, at least one profile visit that became an email or a checkout, five shapes ready to repeat.

Day 90

A second 30 on the same platform, repeating the five shapes. Remix of those five onto a second app only after a stranger bought. File still \$19 to \$47 unless you added something they used. Ad spend still \$0 unless organic already converted and you know the shape. If you have 90 posts and zero taps, the bio or the end card has been wrong for three months. Fix that, do not add a podcast.

Ignore these

Follower count as a goal. View spikes with no taps. Likes from people who will never buy. Completions on a video with no offer. How you look. Whether a stranger on the internet said you should try a different platform. Hashtag reach. "Impressions."

One-line spreadsheet

Columns: date, posts, saves, comments, profile visits, link taps, checkouts, which shape, notes (objection to reuse). One row a week. If checkouts stay zero while visits rise, the Stan page is the

bug. If visits stay zero, the end card or the hook is the bug. If posts stay under 5 a week, the batch is the bug. Fix the named bug. Do not switch apps to feel new.

Objections you will hear

"The algorithm hates me."

You have not posted 30 times. Post. Then look at saves, not at a theory about the algorithm. Switching platforms when a post dies is a listed mistake.

"I need to be on all five apps."

Five platforms is in the leave-alone line. One platform for 30 days. After a stranger buys, you can remix the five winning shapes onto a second app. Not before.

"Faceless is easier."

Faceless slideshows with no offer are how people hide. If you screen-record the work and speak, that is not a slideshow. If you post silent carousels of quotes, you are not on this path.

"I will buy views to jump-start."

Buying views is in the leave-alone line. You will get tourists and a fake sense of momentum. Organic posts that name a \$19 file convert. Paid views of a no-offer clip do not.

"I do not have anything to sell yet."

Then this is not your first path. Ship a \$19 SOP or playbook this week (Sell an AI playbook, AI templates and SOPs, Niche prompt stacks). Then post. Short-form without a file is a hobby with better lighting.

"I do not want to show my face."

Then screen-record the SOP. Your voice on the page is enough. The offer still sits at the end.

"I need more followers first."

You need a profile visit that becomes a checkout. Fifty of the right watchers beat 5,000 tourists. Do not buy followers. Post the next one.

"I do not have time."

Two hours on Sunday, ten clips. Weekdays are tap-post. If you cannot find two hours this month, this path will wait. Do not post one heroic video and disappear.

"AI voice is fine, it sounds professional."

It sounds like a press release. This path wants you to say it. If you cannot, screen-record plus your voice is the backup. AI voice plus stock clips is how you blend into the leftover pile.

"Nothing sold after 30 posts."

Check, in order: is the file live, is the price spoken, is the link working, is the bio one offer. Then look at the 5 shapes with saves. Repeat those. Ask two watchers what they thought you sold. If they cannot name the file, your end card failed.

How this feeds other paths

Upstream: what you need before this

A \$19 to \$47 file that exists at checkout. Sell an AI playbook, Niche prompt stacks, Ship a Claude or ChatGPT skill pack, AI templates and SOPs — any one file. Short-form is the tap. The file is the drink. If you have no file, this path is a hobby. Ship the file in week 1, then post.

Downstream: what you are driving traffic to

The same checkout for 30 days. Your front door can sit in the bio later: a diagnostic, email required, then the file. Not in week 1 if a Stan checkout already works. A weekly AI letter can catch people who are not ready to buy: "email for the 7-question score" as a second button only after the \$19 is converting.

What the comments become

Objections become A weekly AI letter. Walkthroughs become Long-form explainers. The winning hook becomes Creator ads with AI scripts when you are ready to pay for traffic — after a stranger has bought organic. Live drops of AI packs can be announced in the same 20-second end card.

What you do not feed yet

A small AI membership, a catalog, a coaching call. Thirty days, one file. Local businesses + AI can use the same clips as proof you can make simple videos for a nearby owner, billed as a service. That is extra, not the 30-day job.

Mistakes that kill this path

1. Posting with no offer

Recovery this week: put the \$19 file live, rewrite the bio to one line, add the end card to every clip going forward. Do not unpublish 30 videos. Pin the comment on the ones that already exist.

2. Switching platforms when a post dies

Recovery this week: stay. Post tomorrow on the same app. Dead posts are normal.

3. Using a voice you would not use in a kitchen

Recovery this week: re-record the next three with the kitchen test. Throw out "smash that" and the AI outline you were reading.

4. Buying followers or views

Recovery this week: turn the ads off. Count organic taps only. Do not buy a "boost" to soothe a dead post.

5. Explaining your whole catalog in 20 seconds

Recovery this week: one job, one price, one link. Retire the catalog clip. Pin the SOP on it.

6. Waiting for a better microphone

Recovery this week: film in a quiet room by a window. Gear is not the 30-day job.

7. Batching zero videos

Recovery this week: two hours, ten clips, this weekend. Weekdays become tap-post.

8. Changing the offer in week 2

Recovery this week: go back to the \$19 file. The other idea waits until a stranger has bought this one.

9. Reading the AI outline word for word

Recovery this week: generate hooks, speak three, throw the rest away. If a line makes you wince on playback, cut it.

10. Hashtag stuffing instead of a pin comment

Recovery this week: three tags at most, pin "SOP is \$19. Link in bio."

11. Checking views hourly

Recovery this week: one five-minute glance after post 7, post 14, post 30. Saves and comments, not views.

12. Starting over on Monday

Recovery this week: post the missed ones today. The 30 includes messy weeks.

Ethics, restated

Do not fake a testimonial in a talking-head. Do not use a client's real email on screen. Do not buy a comment pod. Do not scrape someone else's hooks and swap the niche word. The kitchen voice includes not lying.

Tools and how you actually use them

Exact stack

Phone. Front camera or screen record. CapCut for captions and a trim. One platform for 30 days: TikTok, Instagram, or YouTube Shorts. Stan or Beacons in the bio, one button, the \$19 to \$47 file. A notes app for hooks and objections. That is the original tools line. No extra apps in week 1.

Setup order

File live at checkout. Stan or Beacons button tested on cellular. Bio written as one line plus the link. 20 hooks generated, three spoken. Three videos filmed. CapCut captions fixed. Post one. Pin comment. Folder for the rest. Then batch. Do not build a desktop pipeline until you have 30 posts. Do not pick the platform you never open.

What not to buy

A ring light if your phone camera works. A microphone in the first 30. A second phone. A scheduler that costs more than the file. Ads. Followers. A brand kit. Five extra apps. A teleprompter so you can read the AI outline. Creator ads tools. Those belong to a later path.

The \$0 path

Phone you already own. Free CapCut or the phone's own captions. Instagram, TikTok, or Shorts account you already have. A free Stan or Beacons plan, or a Stripe Payment Link in the bio if that is what you already use. Window light. Quiet room. The \$19 file can be a Google Doc exported to PDF. You do not need a new domain for month one.

How you actually film

Phone on a stack of books, camera at eye line if it is your face, or screen record of the SOP. First second is the hook, also on-screen. Fifteen seconds of the job. Two seconds of offer. Export 9:16. If the first second is sharp enough to read on mute, you passed.

Ship checklist

Print this. Tick it. Do not post video 1 until the offer half is honest.

Before you post video 1

- One file live at \$19 to \$47
- Checkout tested on your phone, on cellular
- One platform chosen (the one you already open)
- Bio is one line plus the link
- 20 hooks generated; three you would actually say
- Three videos filmed: mistake, principle, walkthrough
- End card words decided and reused
- On-screen text on all three
- CapCut captions fixed, \$19 spelled right
- Pin comment text ready
- Folder named by day for the batch

Every posting day

- On-screen text for mute
- Offer spoken at the end
- Pin comment with the \$19 next step
- Captions checked
- Comments read and saved into a note
- No second platform
- No catalog in 20 seconds

After 30

- Keep 5 shapes (saves and comments)

Kill the rest

Do not switch platforms

Ask the first buyer which video they watched

Spreadsheet row: posts, saves, taps, checkouts, shape

File still the same \$19 unless they asked for more

Ads still off until a stranger bought organic

FAQ

Which platform?

The one you already open. TikTok, Instagram, or YouTube Shorts. Not all three. If you do not open any of them, this path will feel like homework. Pick Instagram if you hate TikTok's tone. Pick Shorts if you already lurk on YouTube. Then stay. Default: the app you already open at night.

Face or screen?

Pick one for 30 days. Face if you can talk. Screen if the product is the SOP or the prompt. Mixing both every other day is how you never get a recognizable shape. Default: screen-record the work if you freeze on camera; face if you can talk for 20 seconds.

How long is a video?

20 seconds is the default. 15 seconds of teaching, 2 seconds of offer. A week-4 walkthrough can be 60 seconds. Do not start at 3 minutes. Default: 20 seconds.

What if I miss a day?

Post two the next day. Do not restart the 30. The clock includes messy weeks. Batch on the weekend so weekdays are just tap-post. Default: double up, do not reset.

Do I need CapCut Pro?

No. Captions and a trim. Phone tools are enough if CapCut annoys you. Default: free CapCut or the phone editor.

Can I use AI voice?

You can, and it usually sounds like a press release. This path wants you to say it. Screen-record plus your voice is the backup if you will not show a face. Default: your voice.

What if nothing sells after 30 posts?

Check, in order: is the file live, is the price spoken, is the link working, is the bio one offer. Then look at the 5 shapes with saves. Repeat those. Ask two watchers what they thought you sold. If they cannot name the file, your end card failed. Default: fix bio and end card before video 31.

Should I buy a microphone and lights?

Not in the first 30. A quiet room and a window. Spend after a stranger checkout if audio was the complaint. Default: no gear haul.

Can I post the same video on two platforms?

Not as a way to skip the 30 on one. After 30, remix the five winners. During the 30, one room. Default: one platform.

Is this the same as Creator ads with AI scripts?

No. This is organic posting to a \$19 file. Creator ads is paid traffic later, with scripts, after you know which shape converts. Do not run ads to a video you posted twice. Default: ads off until a stranger bought organic.

What if I hate my face on camera?

Screen-record the SOP. Your voice on the page is enough. Default: screen plus voice, still one style for 30 days.

Do I need a hook every time?

Yes. Spoken in the first second, also on-screen. Default: "Stop doing [common thing] if you want [result]."

Can I change the \$19 file in week 2?

No. One file for 30 days. The other idea waits. Default: stay.

How many hashtags?

Three at most if the platform is picky, none if it is not. A pin comment beats a tag list. Default: pin comment, almost no tags.

What if comments are mean?

Steal the useful objection. Ignore the heat. Do not film a Tuesday about your feelings unless that is the job you sell. Default: save the useful line, skip the rest.

Should I go live in week 1?

No. Week 4, one longer walkthrough, only if you want. A 60-second screen-record counts. Default: no live required.

Can I use someone else's trending audio?

You can. Do not let the audio bury the hook or the \$19. Default: your voice first, trend second, never instead of the offer.



PATH 05

A weekly AI letter

A list is the one asset a platform cannot take from you in an afternoon.

73 minute read · 16,164 words

Who this is for

You can write clearly once a week. You want an asset that compounds.

Time to first

2–4 weeks to a real list

Tools

First sale

Fifty honest subscribers and one reply that is not spam.

Cash window

Sells the playbook after trust

Leave this alone

Beehiiv or MailerLite, a one-page diagnostic as the lead magnet, a form.

Daily blasts. Buying a list. Essays nobody asked for.

What this actually is

Definition

A weekly letter is a compounding asset. Platforms can nuke an account in an afternoon. They cannot take an email list you earned honestly.

This is not a blog with a subscribe button. It is an appointment. Same day. Same person. Same job. Default day is Tuesday. Default length is four hundred to seven hundred words. One named reader. One named job. If you cannot say those three things before you write, you do not have an issue yet. You have a mood.

This suite is The Operator Suite. You may brand your own letter. You may not copy this book, sell it as yours, or give it away as a lead magnet. The door is a diagnostic you wrote. The house is Tuesday. The paid file is your playbook — path 1 — after they have watched you teach.

One day, one reader, one job

Pick a day you can keep. If you cannot keep Tuesday, do not print Tuesday on the form. Print the day you will actually send. Length is a promise too. Four hundred honest words beat twelve hundred padded ones. Seven hundred is the ceiling, not a target you pad toward.

The reader is a person with a job and a constraint. A solo bookkeeper who hates the blank follow-up. A one-person landscaper who will not sit on a phone after dark. Not busy professionals. Not founders. Not anyone who uses AI.

The job is a Tuesday problem with a verb: send the follow-up, write the five posts, close the Friday loop. Two readers is two letters. Run one for twelve weeks. Widening the sentence so more people subscribe is how the issue becomes a keynote. Tight is how a tired person feels seen and replies.

Write the pairing on a sticky note above the form: every Tuesday I send one useful note to [reader] about [job]. If a stranger cannot tell whether the letter is for them, it is not for anyone yet.

The five blocks, every issue

Hook. One useful thing. One example. One ask. Signoff. That is the whole issue. Not a keynote. Not a roundup. Not three tips and a catalog.

The hook is a moment, two to four sentences. I almost sent just checking in last Thursday. I deleted it. Not a thesis on the future of the industry.

The useful thing is one claim they can use this week. Not three. Not a stack of tools.

The example is a named, slightly messy story they can steal. Fake client name. Real texture. What you cut matters as much as what you sent.

The ask is one action, or none. Teaching weeks ask for a reply or a try. The ask week names the playbook once. Some issues ask for nothing except see you next Tuesday. Never three asks.

The signoff does not change. See you next Tuesday. Then a footer with unsubscribe in plain type.

The door, the house, the paid file

The door is a two-to-four page diagnostic PDF. A scorecard or a 7-day checklist. Seven questions that change the advice. It still helps if they never buy. That is the deal you keep.

The house is the Tuesday. They join for the file. They stay because the appointment is useful. The welcome is three emails: the file at once, how to use it about two days later, what Tuesday is about two days after that. No cart in any of the three.

The paid file is path 1. A \$19 to \$47 playbook. Issues 2 through 6 teach. Issue 7, or a quieter issue once a month, points at it. You do not pitch in email one. You do not invent scarcity. A PDF does not run out.

Form on Beehiiv or MailerLite. One field besides email is plenty. First name, or the job they do. Not a 40-field application.

What this is not

Not daily blasts. Not Substack-as-identity. Not a keynote to busy professionals. Not a sales letter with a subscribe button. Not essays nobody asked for. Not a course in email form. Not a week-in-AI roundup you scraped from five other roundups. Not a community. Not a store that opens four times a year. Not buying a list. Not scraping. Not a welcome that is only a pitch. Not a free PDF that is only a sales letter. Not a second letter in month two. Not this book with your name on the cover.

You are not building a media company. You are keeping a Tuesday. If the issue needs a logo and a podcast trailer before it can leave, you have the wrong job this month.

Anti-pattern 1: daily blasts

Daily is how you become noise. You will miss a day, then two, then send a guilty catch-up and train them to skim. Weekly is the deal. Same day. Same length. Frequency is not growth. Personal invites and a forwardable door are growth. A Friday bonus is daily by accident. Kill it.

Anti-pattern 2: buying a list

Bought names do not open. They mark you as junk. One rented blast can train the inbox to treat you as spam, and you will not know until Tuesday stops landing. Fifty honest subscribers beat five thousand quiet ones. You earn the address with a useful door, not with a credit card. Scraped names are not yours. Targeted is not a loophole.

Anti-pattern 3: essays nobody asked for

Two thousand words on the future of the industry is a blog post you mailed by mistake. If they cannot use it this week, it was an essay. Four hundred honest words beat twelve hundred padded ones. The five blocks are a knife. Use them.

Why it works now, and the deal you keep

Short-form can vanish with a handle. Search can bury a post. Ads get expensive the week you need them. The inbox you earned still shows up. Tired people still open a specific subject from a person they already decided is useful.

AI made generic letters free and identical. That is the opening. A Tuesday that sounds like a press release dies in the promotions tab. A Tuesday with one scar, one named job, and one ask still gets a reply. The model may draft. You rewrite until it sounds like you. Read it out loud. The list is the asset. The playbook is how the asset pays.

You keep five promises. One: same day every week. Two: one job, one reader, five blocks. Three: the free diagnostic is useful even if they never buy. Four: the welcome is three emails that deliver the file and set the day, with no cart. Five: you do not pitch the playbook until they have heard from you enough to trust the voice. The reader keeps one promise in return: if the job is theirs, they know the next step without thinking.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

Fits if

This path fits if you can write clearly once a week and you want an asset that compounds. You do not need a following. You need one job you can talk about without inventing a persona, one reader you can describe in a sentence, and the discipline to show up on the same day.

You already explain things in messages or client notes, and people write back. You would rather have fifty names you can email than five thousand followers you cannot. You already have, or will build this month from the replies, a \$19 to \$47 playbook — the same kind of file as Sell an AI playbook. A \$19 SOP is enough to point at later. You can protect two hours for the issue, and you will send it even when it is shorter than you wanted.

You will write issue one by hand, in five blocks, before a model touches it. You will send it to ten humans this week and ask for the useful line. You will include an unsubscribe and mean it.

Skip if

Skip if you cannot keep a weekly date for four weeks. The letter dies from missed Tuesdays, not from a weak logo. Skip if you want daily growth hacks, if you plan to buy a list, or if you only write when you have a launch. Skip if you have never finished a result for anyone, including yourself. Teach after you have a scar.

If you need money this week, run a productized package first, then start the letter with the notes from that job. The letter sells after trust. Trust is not a same-week product.

Skip if you will let a model publish the whole thing. Skip if you want a community or a second newsletter in month one. Skip if you will not include an unsubscribe. Skip if you cannot name one reader and one job without adding and. Skip if your plan is to give The Operator Suite away as the lead magnet. That is off limits. Write a diagnostic for your job.

The honest middle

Shy is allowed. Inconsistent is not. You need a form, a useful door, a three-email welcome, issue one written by a human in five blocks, and ten people who will tell you the useful line. Not a brand kit.

If you have two audiences, pick one for twelve weeks. If you have zero paid files, the letter can run on the diagnostic for a month while you build the \$47 playbook from the replies. The cart can wait four weeks. It should not wait four years. If you write too slow, good. Set a two-hour cap. When the cap hits, cut, do not expand.

If you already have a playbook and no list, this is the pipe. If you already have a list of twenty friends, this is how it becomes an asset instead of a group chat.

Skills and time

You need a job in one sentence, a reader with a constraint, a one-page diagnostic, Beehiiv or MailerLite, a form, a welcome of three emails, and the willingness to send on the promised day when you do not feel like it. You do not need a designer, a following, or a custom domain in week 1.

Time with a job: two hours for issue one on a weekend, one hour to stand up the form and the three welcome emails, then two hours each week. Ten personal invites are thirty minutes. Four weeks to a real list. Twelve Tuesdays before you add a channel.

Budget: \$0 if you use the free tier of Beehiiv or MailerLite, a Google Doc exported to PDF, and a Stripe Payment Link when you ask. Do not buy a course on newsletters. Do not buy a list.

Two-minute self-test

Answer out loud. Stall on two and this is not your first path this month.

Who is the one reader, in one sentence, with a job and a constraint?

What is the one job, with a verb, that every issue will be about?

What is the one promised day, and can you keep it for four weeks?

What is the free diagnostic, and is it useful if they never buy?

What is the \$19 to \$47 file they might buy after trust — or will you build it from replies this month?

Will you write issue one by hand, in five blocks, before a model touches it?

Will you send it to ten humans this week and ask for the useful line?

Will you write your own door, and not paste this book into a PDF with your name on it?

If you have the reader, the job, the day, and the door, start. If you only have I should have a newsletter, go write the diagnostic first.

Two audiences is two letters

A bookkeeper letter and a landscaper letter are not one letter with a wider sentence. They are two appointments. Pick the one you can keep for twelve weeks. The other one can wait. Merging them is how you write for nobody and hear from nobody.

If you serve two jobs for the same person, pick the job they pay you for first. The other job is a later Tuesday, after twelve of these.

The reader on the other side

They are not a fan. They are a tired person who does the job, opening mail on a phone. They will read four hundred words if the subject named a Tuesday problem they already have. They will reply if you ask for one line, not if you ask whether they liked it. They will buy the playbook when the letter has already done six pieces of the job in front of them. They will not buy a sales letter that showed up wearing Tuesday. They will not finish a stolen book with your logo on it. Write for that person.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this before you pick a logo

I send [specific person] one [day] note that helps them [named job] in [time], even if [honest objection]. The door is a free diagnostic. The house is the Tuesday. The paid file is path 1 after they have watched you teach.

If you cannot fill the brackets, you do not have a letter. You have a mood. The form is the offer. Not a menu. One door, one weekly note, one paid file when trust exists. The specific person is the reader. The named job is the only topic. Do not split them.

Elena's filled sentence: I send solo bookkeepers one Tuesday note that helps them send the 20-minute follow-up after a client call, even if they freeze at the blank draft. The door is a 7-question scorecard. The house is Tuesday. The paid file is the \$47 sequence after they have watched her teach.

Five sentences that already work

I send solo bookkeepers one Tuesday note that helps them send the follow-up after a client call in twenty minutes, even if they hate the blank draft. Free 7-question score. The \$47 sequence waits. The letter does not.

I send pediatric clinic managers one Tuesday note that helps them write SMS that does not sound fake, even if they have four minutes between patients. Free one-page diagnostic. The \$47 prompt stack is there when they want it.

I send one-person landscapers one Tuesday note that helps them get a week of posts from job photos, even if they will not sit on a phone after dark. Free 7-day checklist. The \$47 playbook waits.

I send kitchen-table sellers one Tuesday note that helps them recap a call before they open the next tab, even if they always type just checking in. Free scorecard. The full recap sequence is \$47.

I send solo accountants one Tuesday note that helps them close the Friday loop with one recap and one date, even if their follow-up has been dying in drafts for a year. Seven questions

and a score. The \$47 file is the full sequence. The letter is free.

Write yours in that shape. One day. One person. One job. One free door. One paid file after trust. If you need and my course and my coaching to feel complete, you made the form a junk drawer.

What they get

A weekly appointment. Four hundred to seven hundred words. Five blocks: a hook they can picture, one useful thing they can do this week, one example they can steal, one ask-or-not, a signoff that does not change. A diagnostic that still helps if they never pay you. A welcome of three emails that delivers the file at once, shows them how to use it, and tells them what Tuesday will feel like. An unsubscribe that works. The same voice every Tuesday. After a handful of issues they get a calm sentence about the \$19 to \$47 playbook. Next Tuesday still arrives if they ignore it.

What they do not get

A community. A course. A daily brief. All of AI. A live Q and A in week 1. A custom critique in the reply thread as a free consulting hour. A second product while I have you. A 3,000-word origin. A free file that is only a sales letter. A pitch in the welcome. The Operator Suite with your sticker on it. If they reply can you just do this for me, that is a service path with a price, not a free project inside your inbox.

How the letter sells the playbook without becoming a sales letter

The playbook is the cash window: the \$19 to \$47 sequence, the same kind of file as Sell an AI playbook. A sales letter argues. A Tuesday demonstrates. You teach the job in pieces so the playbook becomes the obvious full sequence for people who are tired of collecting the pieces.

Issues 1 through 6 are chapters of the job. You use the same examples that live in the playbook, one per Tuesday. You do not name the cart. You do not write here is why you need this. By issue 6 they can feel the sequence filling in. The hunger is leftover work, not leftover hype.

Issue 7, or a quieter monthly issue, tells the story of the file. Then one calm sentence: if you want the full sequence, it is \$47 and yours to keep. If not, see you next Tuesday. No countdown.

The next Tuesday still arrives. If the file is not ready, keep teaching. A bad ask costs more than a late one.

Packaging

Form: one field besides email is plenty — first name, or the job they do. Headline names the door, not your bio. Button is Get the score or Send me the checklist. Not Join my world.

Welcome: three emails, not one. Email 1 delivers the file at once and names the day. Email 2, two days later, shows how to use the diagnostic with one worked score. Email 3, two days after that, tells them what Tuesday will feel like. No price in any of the three. If the file arrives tomorrow, you already taught them you are slow.

Page: form second, paid button third. Bio line: One useful Tuesday note about [job]. Free diagnostic at the link. No daily blasts. Subject a human would open. Not Newsletter #4.

The five blocks, named for the writer

Hook: two to four sentences. A moment, not a thesis. I almost sent just checking in last Thursday. I deleted it.

One useful thing: one claim they can use this week. Not three tips.

One example: a named, slightly messy story they can steal. Fake client name. Real texture.

One ask-or-not: you decide before you write. Teaching weeks ask for one reply or one try. The ask week names the \$47 file once. Some issues ask for nothing except see you next Tuesday. Never three asks.

Signoff: the same every week. See you next Tuesday. Then the footer with unsubscribe.

The door is not this book

You may brand your own letter and your own diagnostic. You may not copy this book or give it away as a lead magnet. This suite is The Operator Suite. It is not inventory. A 7-question scorecard you wrote for one job is a door. An export of this suite with your logo is theft and it is also a magnet nobody finishes. Write seven questions. Point at your playbook. That is the offer.

What done looks like

Definition

Done for the first month is not a launch. Done is fifty honest subscribers and one reply that is not spam. Honest means they gave you an email because they wanted the next Tuesday, not because a pop-up lied.

Done after 72 hours: reader named, job named, day named, diagnostic live, form live, three welcome emails delivering the file and setting the appointment, issue one written by hand in five blocks, ten humans sent it, one useful line collected.

Done after four weeks: four issues on the promised day, still teaching, still one job, a note of replies, no cart in paragraph one, and you already knew what issue 4 looked like before you wrote it.

Done after twelve weeks: twelve issues on the promised day, replies turned into issues, one quieter ask that pointed at the \$19 to \$47 file, no second letter, no daily extra. Done is not a viral issue you cannot repeat. Done is not a purchased fifty.

Fairness test

Would you send a friend to your form and trust they get a useful file in one minute, plus a letter that does not pitch in issue one? If the PDF is only a sales letter, it is not fair. If the welcome is a cart, it is not fair. If unsubscribe is hidden, it is not fair. If checkout for the \$47 file is broken on a phone, the later ask is not fair.

Ask two readers what they thought you sold. If they cannot name the job and the day, your promise failed. Hand the diagnostic to someone who does the job. If they cannot take one action this week without paying you, the door failed. Read issue one out loud. If you cannot point to the five blocks, it is not done.

Do not hover. Hand them the file. Sit in another room. Ask one question when they are done: what would you do this week, in one sentence. If they say buy your thing, you failed. If they name the free action, you passed.

Technical done (72 hours)

One reader in one sentence. One job with a verb. One promised day and a length you can keep. Diagnostic: one-page scorecard or 7-day checklist, useful if they never buy. Beehiiv or MailerLite, one form, welcome of three emails, the first of which delivers the file at once. Test from a second email: file arrives, emails 2 and 3 are scheduled, unsubscribe works. Issue one written by hand in five blocks, read out loud. Subject line a human would open. One ask at the end. Form on the same page as the offer, but second. Ten people you know received issue one.

Technical done (first month)

Fifty honest names, or a clear path to fifty from personal invites and forwards. Issues sent on the promised day. Issues 2 through 6 teach; no cart in paragraph one. At least one real reply that is not spam. Useful lines collected. Issue 4 written and sent as another teaching issue. Once, if the file is ready, a quieter issue that can point to the \$47 playbook. No list bought. No scrape. No daily extra.

Technical done (twelve weeks)

Twelve issues on the promised day. Still one reader. Still one job. One quieter ask that pointed at the \$47 file. Sales from people who had read you, counted. First buyers asked which issue made the file obvious. Still no second letter. Ads still off unless the welcome works and four issues were already in the can. The list is hosted by you.

Not-done-yet list

- No diagnostic, or the PDF is only a pitch

- Form has twelve fields

- Welcome does not deliver the file at once, or welcome is one pitch email

- Unsubscribe missing or hidden

- Issue one written entirely by a model

- Issue missing a block: no example, three asks, or a new signoff every week

- Subject line is Newsletter #1

Pitch in email one

Day promised, day missed, no note

List bought or scraped

Daily extra added in week 2

Paid file named, checkout untested

Form above a menu of six products

Zero personal invites, waiting for the algorithm

Two jobs in the reader sentence

This book exported as the magnet

If three of those are true, you have a send button, not a letter. Fix the list this week.

First sale of this path

The first sale of this path is fifty honest subscribers and one reply that is not spam. Cash from the playbook is path 1 using the letter. Count both. Do not pretend the list is failing because the \$47 did not happen on day one. Four issues on the promised day is the habit. The address is the asset. Write the date, the source, and the useful line on one row.

Pricing that holds

The letter is free

The letter is free. That is not a slogan. It is the business model. You do not charge for the appointment. You do not charge for the list. You charge for the file after the appointment has earned the right.

A free letter is how strangers become a list. A paid letter in month one is how you get twelve fans and no asset. The asset is the names you can email next Tuesday. The playbook is how those names pay you. Keep Tuesday free. Charge for the sequence. Next Tuesday still arrives either way.

Do not charge \$9 for the diagnostic and also call it free. Do not put a tripwire on a scorecard. The tripwire path is a different product. This path is a letter. Letters do not have a cover charge.

Ranges

The first paid offer inside the letter is the playbook: \$19 to \$47, theirs to keep. Not a subscription in month one. Not a \$297 cohort. The playbook is the sequence they have been reading in pieces. Buying is I want it in one file, not I was persuaded by a pitch.

A \$19 SOP is allowed if that is the file you already sell. Stay in the cash window this path names: the letter sells the playbook after trust. Do not launch a \$997 mastermind from issue three. Issues 2 through 6 should not sell. They should make the playbook obvious without naming a cart. When you finally ask, the sentence is calm: the full sequence is \$47, and next Tuesday still arrives either way.

Once a month, a quieter issue points to it. Not every Tuesday. Not a countdown. Not a fake 24-hour window on a PDF that does not run out.

When to raise

Raise the file after a subscriber has bought and you have added something they used: a second template, a 14-day calendar, the three scripts they asked for. Then \$47 can become \$67 or \$97. Do not raise because an issue got a high open rate. Opens are not revenue. Do not raise by adding a \$297 mentorship in week 3. Do not charge for the letter itself in year one. A paid letter is a later product, after the free one is a habit.

Raise because the file does more, not because you got bored of \$47. Email the extra page free to people who already paid. The sticky note changes the price. It does not add a second product in the same ask.

Refunds in one sentence

If the playbook is not useful, email me and I will refund. I will not hop on a call to recap the sequence.

You will refund almost nobody if chapter one of the file works. You will refund the person who thought the letter was the product, or who bought from issue one because you pitched too early. Make the ask quieter. Keep the door fair. Refund with no speech. Then ask which issue they thought they were buying. If two people say the same thing, that issue oversold.

The letter is free, so there is nothing to refund on the magnet. For the playbook, refund on request in the first 7 or 14 days. Put that sentence on the checkout. A fight over \$47 costs more than \$47.

Never charge for these

Never sell the list. Never rent it. Never buy someone else's. Deliverability is the business. One rented blast can train the inbox to treat you as junk. Never charge a content audit in replies as a way to avoid writing Tuesday. Never hide the \$47 price behind reply for details. Never run ads to the form until the welcome works, the diagnostic is useful, and you have at least four issues in the can.

Never pay for subscribers. Fifty names who open beat five thousand who never did. Never charge for The Operator Suite as a \$9 lead magnet. That is passing this book off as yours. It is not inventory.

A sponsorship can wait until you would run the ad even if they paid you nothing. Affiliate mentions belong below the reasoning, never above it, and only for tools you still use.

Worked dollars

Elena has a \$47 playbook: the full follow-up sequence for solo bookkeepers. The letter is free. She sends issue one to ten people. Four reply. She does not sell. Issues two through six teach. List grows to eighty-one by issue seven, from personal invites and forwards. No ads. \$0 on traffic.

Issue seven: If you want the full sequence, it is \$47 and yours to keep. If not, see you next Tuesday. Seven people buy in ten days. 7 times \$47 is \$329. One refund from someone who thought she would write their recaps. She adds a line to the checkout: this is a file, not a follow-up service. Month of the ask: \$329 from people who had already read her.

Your first fifty honest names, three \$47 sales after a quiet ask, is \$141. Ten sales is \$470. That is the path. Trust, then a file. Do not invent scarcity. A PDF does not run out.

Why you do not invent scarcity

A PDF does not run out. A 24-hour-only on a file that will still be there Thursday is a lie they will remember. Trust dies. The quiet sentence is enough: \$47, yours to keep, next Tuesday either way. No clock. No bonus that expires. No cart in the welcome. The ask issue still has five blocks. The signoff does not change.

The first 72 hours

You do not need a brand kit. You need issue one in five blocks, a form, a three-email welcome, and a free file that works.

Day 1 morning: pick the reader and write issue one by hand

Write one sentence about one person. Not entrepreneurs. A solo bookkeeper who hates the blank follow-up. If two readers appear, pick one. Write the job with a verb next to the name. Name the day. Name the length. Four hundred to seven hundred words. If you cannot keep Tuesday, do not print Tuesday.

Write issue one without a model in the room. Five blocks on paper first: hook, one useful thing, one example, one ask, signoff. Subject line: something they can picture. The 20-minute follow-up I actually send beats Welcome to the letter.

Then, if you want, run it through a model to tighten — not to inflate. Cut every sentence that sounds like a keynote. Read it out loud. Check the five blocks are still five blocks after the cut.

Day 1 afternoon: the free file

Build a one-page scorecard or a 7-day checklist. Seven questions that change the advice, or seven days that a tired person can actually do. Two to four pages. Export a clean PDF. Put your name and a reply-to on it.

The file has to be useful even if they never buy. A scorecard that tells them which step to skip this week is a door. A free PDF that is only a sales letter is a trap. If you cannot use the diagnostic yourself this week, it is not ready. Name the PDF like a human: follow-up-dying-in-drafts.pdf, not LEADMAGNET_final2.

Quiet-page test before you sleep: delete every mention of the paid file. If the PDF still stands, you passed. If it collapses, you wrote a brochure. Rewrite until one band says skip this step this week and means it.

You may brand your own diagnostic. You may not copy this book or give it away as a lead magnet.

Day 1 night: the form and the three-email welcome

Open Beehiiv or MailerLite. Create one form. One field besides email is plenty. Build a welcome of three emails, not one.

Welcome 1 goes at once: here is the file, reply with your score, I write on Tuesday about [job], unsubscribe is honest. Welcome 2 goes two days later: how to use the diagnostic this week, one worked score, still no cart. Welcome 3 goes two days after that: what Tuesday will feel like, this is not a dump of tools.

The weekly letter is a separate broadcast. Do not pause it for new people. Someone who joins Monday gets Welcome 1 Monday, the Tuesday letter Tuesday, Welcome 2 Wednesday. They get both. That is fine.

Test from a second email. Confirm the file arrives. Confirm emails 2 and 3 are scheduled. Confirm unsubscribe works. Put the form on the same page as your paid offer, but second.

Day 2: ten humans, not a launch

Send issue one to ten people you know. Ask them to reply with the line that was useful. Do not ask did you like it. Ten names in your phone. If you cannot name ten, you are not ready to buy ads. Save every useful line in a note. Those lines are issues 2 through 6.

Personal copy. Not a blast. I started a Tuesday letter for [person] who [job]. Issue one is the [specific thing]. If you want it: [form]. If you have two minutes, reply with the line that was useful. That is the whole ask.

Day 3: collect, steal the line, do not redesign

Read the replies. Circle the sentence more than one person quoted. That sentence becomes the subject of issue two.

Sketch issues 2, 3, and 4 on one page, one line each, so you know what the fourth Tuesday looks like before Thursday tries to negotiate. Issue 2 is the line they quoted. Issue 3 is the template inside the job. Issue 4 is the prompt plus the human pass, or the equivalent scar in your job. All three still teach. None of them name the cart.

Do not redesign the header. Do not add a Friday bonus. Do not open a second tool. By hour 72 you should have a live form, a working three-email welcome, issue one in ten inboxes, one sentence from a real person, and a one-page map of issues 2 through 4.

What 72 hours is not

Not a brand kit. Not a podcast trailer. Not a homepage with six buttons. Not a bought list. Not a daily extra because you felt behind. Not a model-written issue you shipped to feel done. Not a custom domain haul. Not ConvertKit plus Beehiiv plus Substack. If the door, the day, and the first issue exist, you are on time.

The hour-72 test

From a second inbox: file arrived in under two minutes. Welcome 2 and 3 are scheduled. Unsubscribe is one click and actually leaves. Issue one has five blocks you can point at. Ten names were written down and at least five were sent. Issues 2 through 4 exist as one line each. If any of that fails, you are not announcing. Fix it today.

The path, step by step

Twelve steps. Do them in order. Skipping ahead to write a better brand is how letters stay imaginary.

Step 1. Promise one specific weekly note

Name the day. Name the length. Name the person it is for. Keep it. If you cannot keep Tuesday, do not print Tuesday on the form. The promise is the product. Missed Tuesdays kill more letters than weak prose.

Write the promise where they can see it: the form, the welcome, the bio. Every Tuesday, one note about [job], 400 to 700 words. Boring is the point. A day you will miss is a lie. Change the printed day before you miss it, not after.

Step 2. Name the one reader and the one job

Write one sentence about one person. A job plus a constraint. Not busy professionals. Next to it, write the job with a verb: send the follow-up, write the five posts, close the Friday loop. If two readers appear, you have two letters. Pick one for twelve weeks.

Widening the sentence so more people subscribe is how the issue becomes a keynote. Tight is how a tired person feels seen and replies. Every issue is for that person, about that job. Put the pairing on a sticky note above the form. If a stranger cannot tell whether the letter is for them, it is not for anyone yet.

Step 3. Build the diagnostic

One page, or two to four. Scorecard or 7-day checklist. Useful if they never buy. Seven questions that change the advice, not seven that all lead to buy the file. If you cannot use it yourself this week, it is not ready.

Export a clean PDF. Name it like a human. Put a reply-to on it. The diagnostic is the door. The letter is the house. You may brand your own scorecard. You may not copy this book or give it away as a lead magnet. Quiet-page test: delete every mention of the paid file. If the PDF still stands, you passed.

Step 4. Stand up the form and the three-email welcome

Beehiiv or MailerLite. Pick one. One form. Welcome of three emails: the file at once, how to use it two days later, what Tuesday is two days after that. Test from a second email. Confirm the file arrives, the later emails are scheduled, and the unsubscribe works. One field besides email is plenty.

Put the form on the same page as the paid offer, but second. Do not split the list across two tools. Do not pause the weekly broadcast for people still in the welcome. They can get both. From-name is your first name, one word.

Step 5. Write issue one in five blocks

Hook, one useful thing, one example, one ask, signoff. Write it by hand. Then optionally tighten with a model. Publish only the version that sounds like you. Four hundred to seven hundred words. Read it out loud.

Issue one is the 20-minute version of the job, not the origin story of your career. If you cannot point to all five blocks, you are not done. AI may draft. You must rewrite until it sounds like you. If a blank chat could have written it, you have not written it.

Step 6. Write five subject lines and pick one a human would open

The 20-minute follow-up I actually send, not Newsletter #4. Steal the useful line from those first ten replies. Specific beats clever. Clever dies in a promotions tab.

Write five. Pick the one you would open on a phone at 7am. If it needs a joke to work, it does not work. If it names a feeling instead of a Tuesday object, try again. The subject is the hook's little sibling. It has to stand in a list of bills and school notes.

Step 7. Send to ten humans before you announce anything

Issue one goes to ten people you know. Personal copy. Ask for the useful line. End with one ask, not three. Was this good dies. Reply with the line you would actually send lives.

Do not post a launch thread instead of this step. The ten replies are how you learn what to write next. Audience is what the letter builds. It is not a prerequisite. If you have three asks, delete

two. The last line is the ask. Then the signoff. Then stop.

Step 8. Teach for five issues

Issues 2 through 6 are the job, in pieces. One piece per Tuesday. No cart. You are earning the seventh email. Map them before week 2: issue 2 is the line they quoted, issue 3 is the template, issue 4 is the prompt plus the human pass, issue 5 is the failure case, issue 6 is the weekly close. That map is how you know what issue 4 looks like before you write it.

If you have the \$47 playbook drafted, do not mention the price yet. Mention the problem the playbook solves, in human words. They should feel the sequence filling in. They should not feel a funnel.

Step 9. Make the quieter ask for the playbook

Once a month, a quieter issue that points to the paid file. Issue 7 can ask. If you want the full sequence, it is \$47 and yours to keep. If not, see you next Tuesday.

The ask issue still has five blocks. The hook is the story of the desktop file. The useful thing is a reminder of the sequence they already watched. The example is one chapter they already saw. The ask is the price. The signoff is unchanged. If the file is not ready, keep teaching. Do not invent scarcity. The file is a PDF. It does not run out.

Step 10. Never buy a list. Never scrape. Install a forward loop

Your deliverability is the business. Fifty names who open beat five thousand who never did. Bought names mark you as junk. Scraped names are not yours. Targeted is not a loophole.

Personal invites and a forwardable diagnostic are the growth loop. In the welcome and once a month: forward the diagnostic to one person who hates the blank [job]. No referral leaderboard. Elena grew to eighty-one this way. You can grow to fifty.

Step 11. Turn replies into issues

When someone writes I get stuck after the call, that is next Tuesday. Save every useful objection in a note. Generate an outline if you want. Rewrite until it sounds like you. Put the reply in the

hook or the example, with permission, no last name required.

If nobody replies, the ask was weak or the issue was a crowd-letter. Write to one person. Ask for one line. Send it to ten more humans. Handle can you just do this for me as a package with a price, not a free consulting hour.

Step 12. Keep the date for twelve weeks before you add anything

No daily version. No second letter. No podcast. No ads. Twelve Tuesdays. Then look at what they replied to, and only then consider a second product or a second channel.

Guilt is not a publishing calendar. A Friday bonus is how you become daily by accident. No brand kit in the first four weeks. No ads until four issues are in the can and the welcome works. The list is the asset. Host it.

A worked example: Elena's Tuesday letter

Elena, one Tuesday, one job, a \$47 file

Elena used to coordinate jobs at a small studio. She was good at the twenty minutes after a client call: recap, next step, date. When she went solo, the blank follow-up came back. She wrote the sequence down so she would stop rewriting it. That file sat on her desktop for two months. Then she started a Tuesday letter so the file would have somewhere to live.

Reader: solo bookkeepers and one-person accountants who freeze after the client call. Job: the 20-minute follow-up. Day: Tuesday. Length: about five hundred words. No daily blast, no week in AI. She named the letter after the day.

The free file is a 7-question scorecard: is your follow-up dying in drafts? A score, and one next step. Reply with your score and I will tell you which path to skip. That line is in welcome 1. She put the form above the \$47 button. Free first. Beehiiv. One field besides email: first name. Checkout tested on a phone.

The reader sentence and the door

Her sticky note: every Tuesday I send one useful note to solo bookkeepers who freeze after the client call. Score bands tell them which step to skip this week. None of the bands say buy the file. She did not wait for a logo. Follow-up is the job. AI is a tool inside one issue, later.

Questions that change the advice: Do you send a recap the same day, or does it sit in drafts? Does the first line ask how are you when you already know? Is there a date in sentence four, or three next steps and no date? A bookkeeper who scores 4 skips the first-line polish this week and just sends the recap. A bookkeeper who scores 10 picks one template and deletes the other eleven. Neither band requires \$47.

Issue one in five blocks

Hook: I almost sent just checking in on a Thursday in March. I deleted it. The person already knew me. The line made me sound like a stranger.

One useful thing: the 20-minute follow-up she actually sends, and the two lines she never skips — a recap of what they decided, and a date for the next thing.

One example: a recap after a call with a client named Mara about a month-end close. Three short paragraphs. The date in sentence four. What she cut: the how are you, the I know you are busy, the just circling back.

One ask: reply with the first line you actually sent last time.

Signoff: See you next Tuesday. Unsubscribe in plain type.

Subject: The 20-minute follow-up I actually send. She wrote five subjects. She picked the one she would open at 7am. Newsletter #1 was on the list. She deleted it.

Calendar: days 1 to 7

Day 1, Saturday morning: reader sentence and issue one by hand, five blocks on paper first. Afternoon: seven questions, PDF exported, named follow-up-dying-in-drafts.pdf.

Night: Beehiiv form, welcome of three, test from a second email. File arrived in one minute.

Unsubscribe worked.

Day 2, Sunday: send issue one to ten people she had worked with. Personal invite. Ask for the useful line. A cousin who books for a dentist. Two bookkeepers from a local group. An old studio colleague. Her sister who invoices from a kitchen table. Six more from her phone.

Day 3 through 7: four of the ten reply. Three quote the same sentence about not asking how are you in sentence one if you already know. She writes that sentence at the top of a note labeled issue two. She sketches issue 3 (the recap template) and issue 4 (the prompt plus the human pass) so Tuesday cannot become a new format. Welcome 2: a worked score of 6, skip the first-line polish this week. Welcome 3: Tuesday is follow-up, not a dump of tools.

Weeks 2 through 4, and what issue 4 looks like

Week 2, Tuesday: issue two. Subject stolen from the replies: If your first line is how are you, they are tired. Five blocks. Hook is the quoted line, with permission, no last name. Useful thing: the first line she uses instead. Example: three first lines, one dead, two alive. Ask: reply with the first line you actually sent. Ten more personal invites. Two of the original ten forward the diagnostic. List: eighteen honest names. \$0. She does not check opens for more than five minutes.

Week 3, Tuesday: issue three, the recap template. Subject: The recap I send before I open the next tab. One filled example. No pitch. A reply: I get stuck after the call. She saves it for issue five. Midweek she writes issue four so Tuesday cannot negotiate. List: twenty-six.

Week 4, Tuesday: issue four. This is the issue you should be able to see from here. Subject: What I cut from last week's prompt. Hook: the model draft that sounded like a press release. I pasted my messy notes. It smiled at me for three paragraphs. Useful thing: generate, then cut the smile. Three cuts she always makes — the we loved connecting, the please do not hesitate, the stacking of three next steps when there is one. Example: messy notes from the Mara call, the prompt, the first draft, the three cuts, the recap she actually sent. Ask: reply with one line you cut this week. Signoff unchanged. No cart. Someone replies can you just do this for me? She sends a price for a productized recap, \$150. They do not buy. She does not chase. List: thirty-four. She does not add a Friday bonus.

Issue 4 is still teaching. It is the fourth piece of the same job: not a new format, not a launch, not a recap of the month. The next scar in the sequence.

Issues 5 through 7, and the dollars

Issue five, week 5. Subject: When they go quiet after the recap. The reply from week 3 is the hook, with permission. Useful thing: one follow-up, one date, then stop. Example: a bookkeeper whose client vanished for eleven days. Ask: reply with the last line you sent a quiet client. List: forty-nine. She is one personal invite from fifty.

Issue six, week 6. Subject: The Friday loop I actually close. Still no pitch. By issue seven she has eighty-one subscribers, from personal invites and forwards of the diagnostic. No ads. \$0 on traffic.

Issue seven still has five blocks. Hook: the file sat on my desktop for two months. Useful thing: the sequence they have already watched in six pieces, named in one list. Example: the recap template plus the quiet-client issue. Ask: If you want the full sequence, it is \$47 and yours to keep. If not, see you next Tuesday. Signoff unchanged.

Seven people buy in ten days. 7 times \$47 is \$329. She asks two of them which issue made the file obvious. Both say the recap template plus the quiet-client issue. She does not change the offer. She does not start a second letter. Next Tuesday still arrives for the seventy-four who did not buy.

How Tuesday sold the playbook without becoming a sales letter

She never argued for the file. She demonstrated the job. Issues 1 through 6 were chapters. Issue 7 was a filing cabinet. The people who bought were tired of collecting the pieces. The people who did not buy still have Tuesday. That is the cash window: the letter sells the playbook after trust.

Forward loop, once a month, not every issue: If this was useful, forward the diagnostic to one person whose follow-up is dying in drafts. That is the whole growth plan. No points. No leaderboard. That is how eighteen became eighty-one.

The mistake and the recovery

On the Thursday after issue three she almost sends a value extra: a PDF dump of three other file ideas while I have you. She writes it. She does not send it. The catalog would have trained them

to wait for a store. Recovery is the delete key, same day.

Shipped artifact: seven Tuesdays, five blocks, a three-email welcome, and the same sequence that sat on her desktop. Month of the ask: \$329. Traffic cost: \$0. List hosted by her. Platforms can take a following. They cannot take those eighty-one names.

Copy you can actually send

Swap the job. Keep the calm. Same promise every Tuesday. Fill the brackets. Do not add a second product while you have them. Do not put this book in the PDF.

The one-sentence promise

I send [specific person] one [day] note that helps them [named job] in [time], even if [honest objection]. The door is a free diagnostic. The house is the Tuesday. The paid file is path 1 after they have watched you teach.

Elena's version, on the form and in the bio: Every Tuesday I send solo bookkeepers one 500-word note on the 20-minute follow-up after a client call, even if the draft has been sitting since Thursday. Free 7-question score. The letter is free. The \$47 sequence waits.

Form headline and button

Headline: Is your follow-up dying in drafts? Seven questions. A score. One next step. Free even if you never buy. The Tuesday letter comes after.

Subhead: One field. Instant PDF. You can leave in one click.

Button: Get the score.

Privacy line under the button: You are joining a short welcome and a Tuesday note about [job]. Unsubscribe is one click.

Do not use Join my world. Do not use Unlock the system. Do not use a 40-field form.

Welcome email 1 (delivers the diagnostic)

Subject: Your scorecard is here

Body: Here is the one-page diagnostic: [PDF]. Reply with your score and I will tell you which path to skip. I write once a week, on Tuesday, about [job]. One idea, one story, one ask. If that is not useful, unsubscribe. I will not be sad, and you will not hear from me again.

That is the whole email. No bio. No second PDF. No price.

Welcome email 2 (how to use it)

Subject: What a score of 6 actually means

Body: A score of 4 to 7 usually means skip the polish this week and send the recap. A score of 8 to 11 usually means pick one template and delete the other eleven. You do not have to reply. If you do, I read them. Tuesday is still the appointment. This email is just the hallway.

Still no cart. One worked score. One next step they can do tonight.

Welcome email 3 (what Tuesday is)

Subject: What Tuesday will feel like

Body: Tuesday will feel like a short note from a person who does [job], not a dump of tools and not a pitch. Four hundred to seven hundred words. You can finish it on a phone. If you joined for a week-in-AI roundup, this is not that, and unsubscribe is honest. See you on the promised day.

If this was useful, forward the diagnostic to one person who hates the blank [job]. That is the whole growth plan.

Issue 1, full five blocks

Subject: The 20-minute follow-up I actually send

I almost sent just checking in last Thursday. I deleted it. The person already knew me. We had talked at 2. The line made me sound like a stranger who had lost the notes from our own call.

After a client call I give myself twenty minutes before I open the next tab. Two lines never get skipped: a recap of what we decided, and a date for the next thing. Everything else is optional.

The how-are-you is optional. The I-know-you-are-busy is optional. The circling-back is how you become junk in a promotions tab.

Mara is a client who needed a month-end close explained in English. We talked Tuesday at 2. I almost wrote great chatting, let me know if you have questions. I did not. I sent three short paragraphs. What we decided: the close happens Friday, she sends me the two missing receipts by Wednesday noon, I send a one-page recap Thursday. What I need from her: those two receipts, not a novel. A date in sentence four: drafts Thursday at noon. I cut how are you from sentence one because I already knew. I cut please do not hesitate. I cut three next steps down to one. The recap left in eighteen minutes. She replied with the receipts at 4.

If you try this, reply with the first line you actually sent last time. Not the line you meant to send. The one that left. I read them.

See you next Tuesday.

That is five hundred words of letter, not a funnel. Hook, useful thing, example, ask, signoff. Steal the structure. Change the job. Keep the cuts.

Five subject lines

Write five. Pick the 7am phone one. These already behave:

The 20-minute follow-up I actually send

Stop asking just checking in

The recap I send before I open the next tab

A 7-question score, not another pep talk

What I cut from last week's prompt

If your first line is how are you, they are tired

The Friday loop I actually close

When they go quiet after the recap

Do not use Newsletter #4. Do not use a joke they have to be in on. Do not use a feeling with no object. Specific beats clever.

The ten-human personal ask

I started a Tuesday letter for solo bookkeepers who freeze after the client call. Issue one is the 20-minute follow-up I actually send. If you want it: [form]. If you have two minutes, reply with the line that was useful. That is the whole ask.

Send it as a text or a short email. Ten names. Not a broadcast. Not a launch thread. If you cannot name ten, you are not ready to buy ads.

The monthly quieter ask for the \$47 file

Subject: The file that sat on my desktop

Hook: The follow-up sequence sat on my desktop for two months. I used it anyway. Then I started writing Tuesdays so it would have somewhere to live.

Useful thing: You have already watched the pieces. The 20-minute recap. The first line that is not how are you. The prompt, then the three cuts. What to do when they go quiet. The Friday loop.

Example: Issue three plus issue five are chapters 4 and 7 of the file. If you have been collecting the pieces, the file is the cabinet.

Ask: If you want the full sequence, it is \$47 and yours to keep. If not, see you next Tuesday.

Signoff: See you next Tuesday.

Checkout line: [Job] sequence — the full follow-up, \$47. Instant download. If it is not useful, email me and I will refund. Next Tuesday still arrives either way.

No countdown. No 24 hours only. A PDF does not run out.

The forward line, and the unsubscribe / friend-fairness test

Forward, once a month, not every issue: If this was useful, forward the diagnostic to one person who hates the blank [job]. That is the whole growth plan. No points. No leaderboard.

Footer you actually mean: Unsubscribe any time. I write one Tuesday note about [job]. I do not sell the list. I do not send a daily extra.

Missed-Tuesday note: I missed Tuesday. Here is a short one: [one idea, one ask]. Back next week on the promised day. If this broke the deal for you, unsubscribe. I mean that.

Friend-fairness test, said out loud to a person who does the job: would you send a friend to this form and trust they get a useful file in one minute, plus a letter that does not pitch in issue one? If the answer is no, rebuild the door. If the PDF is this book with your name on it, delete that file today. Write seven questions for your job.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Assume you have a job and evenings. This is four weeks to a real list. Two hours on a weekend for issue one. One hour for the form and the welcome. Then two hours each week. By Friday of week 4 you should have sent four issues on the promised day and know what issue 4 looked like before you wrote it.

Week 1: form plus issue one

Monday evening: write the diagnostic and issue one by hand, five blocks on paper first. Two hours. Do not open a design tool.

Tuesday evening: Beehiiv or MailerLite, form, welcome of three, test the free file from a second email. Confirm unsubscribe. Confirm emails 2 and 3 are scheduled. Put the form on the page, second, paid button third.

Wednesday evening: send issue one to ten people you know with the personal invite. Ask for the useful line. Thirty minutes.

Thursday evening: collect replies. Steal the line. Sketch issues 2, 3, and 4 in one line each. Do not redesign the header.

Friday: invite three more humans if you have them. Saturday: rest the letter. If the diagnostic has a typo, fix the PDF and leave it. Sunday: outline issue two from the replies. If you have no replies

yet, write the objection you already believe: too simple, no time, I could do this myself.

Week 2: issue two plus ten personal invites

Monday evening: finish issue two in five blocks. Read it out loud. One ask. Tuesday: send on the promised day. Same length. Same person. Same signoff. Protect the send. If work runs late, cut the issue, do not move the day.

Wednesday: ten more personal invites, not a blast. If someone forwards you a kind reply, ask if you can use the line (no last name required).

Thursday: save objections into a note. Help first in any niche thread you already belong to.

Friday: do not send a bonus. Saturday: two hours if you need them, batch issue three. Sunday: rest. Count: issues sent on time (target 2), personal invites (target 20 across two weeks), replies that are not spam. Ignore follower count. Ignore open rate.

Week 3: teach one path

Monday: issue three is one chapter of the job. The template inside it. No pitch. If you have the \$47 playbook drafted, do not mention the price yet.

Tuesday: send on time. Even if it is shorter.

Wednesday through Friday: replies become a note, not a second letter. If someone asks you to do the work, send a package price or the cheaper file. Write issue four so Tuesday cannot become a negotiation. Issue four is the prompt plus the human pass: generate, then cut. Still five blocks. Still no cart.

Saturday: if the checkout for the \$47 file is live, test-buy it from a phone. Sunday: glance at unsubscribes. A few means people are reading. Zero can mean you are too bland to bother leaving.

Week 4: send issue four, then decide on the ask

Monday: finish issue four. Hook is the failure. Useful thing is the repair. Example is before and after. Ask is one line they cut. Signoff unchanged.

Tuesday: send on time. Four issues, one job, still teaching. If you have a file that works, you may write a quieter ask for a later Tuesday — not for this one unless you already taught six. Elena waited until issue seven. You are allowed to wait. A bad ask costs more than a late one.

Wednesday through Sunday: keep the cadence. Same day, five blocks, one ask-or-not. Once a month, the quieter issue with the \$47 link. No countdown clock. Do not add a Friday bonus because you felt guilty. Guilt is not a publishing calendar.

What issue 4 looks like before you write it

Issue 4 is not a recap of the month. It is not a launch. It is not a new format. It is the fourth piece of the same job. For Elena: messy notes, the prompt, the smiley draft, the three cuts. For a landscaper letter: the batch caption prompt, the one extra constraint, the caption you actually posted. For a clinic letter: the SMS that sounded fake, the two-line version, the one you sent.

If you cannot name issue 4 in one sentence this week, you do not have a job yet. You have a blog. Go back to the sticky note.

Twelve-week cadence map

Weeks 1 to 4: door, welcome, four teaching issues, personal invites, no cart.

Weeks 5 to 6: two more teaching issues. Issue 5 is the failure case they already named in a reply. Issue 6 is the weekly close. Keep inviting. Install the forward line once.

Week 7: quieter ask if the file is ready. Five blocks. One price. Next Tuesday either way. If the file is not ready, teach again and ask in week 8 or 9.

Weeks 8 to 12: stay on the date. Turn replies into issues. Count on-time sends, honest names, replies, unsubscribes, and — if you asked — playbook sales from people who had read you. No second letter. No podcast. No daily. No ads unless the welcome works and four issues were already in the can.

Week 12 review: still one reader? Still one job? Which issue did buyers name? Only then consider a second product or a second channel. The list is the asset. Host it.

If you stall

The failure is usually the day, the reader sentence, or skipping the ten humans. Not the logo. Not the market. Send a short Tuesday. Ask for one line. Invite ten more. Do not start a second letter to feel new. Do not switch tools because opens dipped.

Quality bar

Below the bar

A press-release voice. A model draft shipped unedited. Three asks at the end. A pitch in email one. Newsletter #4 as a subject. A diagnostic that is only a sales letter. Daily extras. Bought names. A missed Tuesday with silence. A 2,000-word essay they cannot use this week. A catalog of six products in the footer. Hidden unsubscribe. A joke they have to be in on. A missing block: no example, a new signoff every week, a hook that is a thesis. This book with your name on the cover.

Above the bar

A voice you would use at a table. If you would not say the line to one person, cut it. AI outlines; you write it. Five blocks, every issue. Subject a human would open. Door useful if they never buy. Same day. Four hundred to seven hundred words. They can name the job after three issues. A reply that is not spam is the quality signal, not a 60 percent open rate. The ask week still sounds like Tuesday.

The five-block test

Before you send, point at the page. Hook: a moment, two to four sentences. Useful thing: one claim, not three tips. Example: a named, slightly messy story they can steal. Ask-or-not: one action, or none, decided before you wrote. Signoff: the same as last week. If a block is missing, you are still drafting. If a block is doing two jobs, split the issue.

Test 1: the kitchen-table test

Read the issue out loud. If you would not say it to one person at a table, cut it. Hype, throat-clearing, and as you know go first. Named tools and named steps stay. If a line makes you wince, it is a paste. Cut it.

Test 2: the Tuesday test

Would this still be true next Tuesday if a model version changed? Teach the job, not the button labels of one chat window. You can name a tool. Do not marry a menu. If the issue dies when a setting moves, you wrote a changelog, not a letter.

Test 3: the AI test

If you paste the issue back into a blank chat and it could have written the whole thing, you have not written it. Add the scar: what failed, what you still do, the sentence you almost sent. That is the part they cannot download for free. One typo will not kill you. A voice that sounds like a press release will. AI may draft. You must rewrite until it sounds like you. Read it out loud.

Test 4: the use-this-week test

A good issue can be read in four minutes and used in twenty. If they cannot use it this week, it was an essay. End with one action that fits a tired evening. Four hundred to seven hundred words. If you need two thousand, you have two issues.

Test 5: the door test, and the ethics you do not skip

Hand the diagnostic to someone who does the job. Can they take one useful action without paying you? If every score band says buy the file, the questions are fake. Rebuild until one band says skip this step this week and means it. Then ask: would this welcome still be fair if they never open Tuesday? If welcome 1 is a cart, rebuild it. File first. Day second. Price later.

This suite is The Operator Suite. Passing this book off as yours is off limits. Selling this book as your own is off limits. Giving this book away as a magnet with your logo on the cover is off limits. You may brand your own letter. You may not copy this book or give it away as a lead magnet. If you are unsure whether a file you are about to publish is yours, it is not. Write seven questions for one job. That file is yours.

Metrics that matter (and vanity numbers to ignore)

What to count: sends on time, then replies

Opens lie. Different tools count them differently. Image-blocking will tell you a loyal reader never opened. A 60 percent open rate with silence is a dead letter that looks alive. A 20 percent open rate with two real replies is a letter.

Count issues sent on the promised day. That is the first metric. Count replies that are not spam. Count forwards of the diagnostic. Count honest subscribers. Count unpaid-to-paid of the playbook after the ask, and which issue the buyer names. Count unsubscribes as health, not as failure. Opens are a weather report. Replies are the crop.

Week 1

Count issues sent on the promised day (target 1), diagnostic delivered at once (yes/no), welcome of three scheduled (yes/no), unsubscribe works (yes/no), personal invites (target 10), useful lines collected (target 1), five blocks present in issue one (yes/no). Do not count open rate. Do not count a subscriber spike from a blast you have not earned.

Day 30

Honest subscribers. Fifty is the first milestone. Not a purchased fifty. Replies that are not spam. One real reply is worth more than a 60 percent open rate with silence. Issues sent on the promised day. A 4-for-4 streak beats a viral issue you cannot repeat. Unsubscribes per issue. A few means people are reading. Playbook sales from the list after the ask, if you asked. Note the issue number.

A healthy day-30: four issues on time, a live door, a three-email welcome, ten-plus personal invites, at least one real reply, checkout for the \$47 file tested, no daily extra, no bought list, issue 4 still teaching.

Day 90

Twelve issues on the promised day. Fifty honest names, or a clear reason you are short (you stopped inviting). One quieter ask that pointed at the \$47 file. Sales from subscribers who had read you, counted. Unpaid-to-paid of the playbook, counted. Replies turned into issues, counted. Forwards, counted. Still one letter. Still no scrape. Ads still off unless the welcome works and four issues were already in the can.

If you have twelve issues and zero replies, the ask at the end is wrong, or you wrote for a crowd. Fix that. Do not add a podcast.

Vanity numbers to ignore

Follower count on the platform you used to announce the letter. Daily growth charts. Open-rate panic below a number you saw in a thread. Open-rate theater. Click rates on a teaching issue with no cart. How pretty the header is. Whether a stranger said email is dead. A spike from a bought mention. Subscriber screenshots. Bought names. A list of five thousand who never opened.

If fifty people are on the list, ten open, and two reply, you have a letter. Fifty names who open beat five thousand who never did.

One-line spreadsheet

Columns: date, issue number, sent on time (yes/no), subject, invites sent, new honest subs, replies, forwards, unsubscribes, checkouts, which issue the buyer named, notes (line to reuse). One row a week. A notebook is allowed.

If checkouts stay zero after an ask while replies are real, the file or the checkout is the bug. If replies stay zero, the ask or the reader sentence is the bug. If issues miss the day, the two-hour cap is the bug. Fix the named bug. Do not start a second letter to feel new. Do not switch tools because opens dipped.

Unsubscribe as health

A few unsubscribes per issue means people are reading and deciding. Zero can mean you are too bland to bother leaving, or that nobody is opening. Over 5 percent on a teaching issue

means you asked too early or you wrote a crowd-letter. Make unsubscribe easy. Count it. Do not write a guilt form. A healthy list shrinks on purpose and grows from forwards.

Objections you will hear

I do not have an audience

You need ten people who will tell you the useful line. Audience is what the letter builds. It is not a prerequisite. Write issue one, send it to ten names in your phone, stop waiting for permission from a feed.

Email is dead

It is not. It is quiet. Quiet is why it still works. The people who say it is dead are tired of blasts. Do not send blasts. Send a Tuesday. Platforms can take a following. They cannot take a list you host.

I should wait until I have the playbook perfect

The letter can start with the diagnostic. The \$47 file can land in week 4. Waiting for perfect is how you miss twelve Tuesdays. Teach. Build the file from the replies. Elena's playbook sat on a desktop for two months. The letter is what made it leave.

People will copy me

They might copy the structure. They will not copy the scar. Teach anyway. The scar is the product inside the free issue. The sequence is what they pay \$47 for. Five blocks are not a secret. Showing up on Tuesday is.

I write too slow

Good. Slow is a filter. Four hundred honest words beat twelve hundred padded ones. Set a two-hour cap. When the cap hits, cut, do not expand. A short Tuesday that leaves on time beats a perfect one that leaves Friday. The five blocks exist so you stop at done.

What if nobody replies

Ask a better ask. Was this good dies. Reply with the line you would actually send lives. Write to one person. Letters to a crowd get silence. Letters to a name get mail. Send ten more personal invites before you decide the path is dead. If you asked three things, they will do none.

I should send daily so I grow faster

Daily blasts are in the leave-alone line. You will miss a day and train them to skim. Weekly is the deal. Growth is personal invites and a forwardable door, not frequency. A second letter in month two is daily by another name.

I need a brand kit first. Should I charge for the letter

You need issue one and a form. A header you will not redesign is enough. Elena did not wait on a logo. The ten humans do not care.

Do not charge for the letter in month one. The letter is free. You charge for the file after trust. A paid letter is a later product, after the free one is a habit. Charging for Tuesday before they trust you is how you get zero Tuesdays.

Open rates are low. I should switch tools. I should buy a targeted list

Opens lie. Image-blocking lies. Switch tools after you have a deliverability problem you can name, not after a number you saw in a thread. Count replies and on-time issues. If those are healthy, stay.

Never buy a list. Targeted is not a loophole. Bought names mark you as junk. Fifty honest names who have read you will outbuy five thousand quiet ones. Elena asked at eighty-one and sold seven. Ask calmly. Do not apologize for the price.

How this feeds other paths

The letter is the pipe

The letter is not a side hobby. It is the pipe. Everything else in the suite can pour through it later. Nothing else should replace the Tuesday. Platforms can take a following. They cannot take this

list if you host it. That is the point of the path.

Do not launch all of them week 1. Twelve Tuesdays. One file. Then look at replies.

Upstream: what you need before this

A job you can teach in pieces. A reader you can name. A door: a diagnostic and a form. Ideally one paid file worth asking for — Sell an AI playbook, AI templates and SOPs, Niche prompt stacks, a skill pack. If you have no file yet, the letter can run on the diagnostic for a month while you build the \$47 playbook from the replies. You still need the door. You do not need a membership, a chat room, or a second newsletter.

Downstream: the playbook, path 1

It sells the playbook after trust — that is the cash window on purpose. Issues 1 through 6 are chapters. Issue 7 is a filing cabinet. Email 7, or the quieter monthly issue, points at the same checkout. Your front door can sit on the same page: diagnostic first, paid button second. Not a buffet.

The \$19 to \$47 file is the house's paid room. The letter is how people walk through it without a pitch in issue one.

The door, path 21, is how strangers arrive

Your front door is the diagnostic plus the form. The letter is the weekly appointment after they join. Strangers arrive through the door. Friends arrive through personal invites. Both land on the same list. You can run both on the same page. Path 21 is how people you have never met find Tuesday. This path is the Tuesday habit and the list as an asset.

Do not pause the letter to go make clips. Do not turn the letter into a blog archive you mail by mistake. Short-form can send them to the form. Long-form explainers can be one issue, expanded, later. Not in week 1. Not instead of Tuesday.

Skill pack, templates, membership — later

The letter can sell templates when you mention the filled example you used this week. A skill pack if they say I want this inside Claude. A small membership after the free letter is a habit and the playbook has sold. Not week 1. Not as a second ask in the same issue.

A weekly letter can catch people who are not ready to buy from a 20-second clip. Keep the sticky note: one paid thing per ask. Put the second product in a later Tuesday, after this sequence of teaching has done its job.

What the replies become

I get stuck after the call becomes next Tuesday. Can you just do this for me becomes a productized package with a price, or the cheaper file. Walkthroughs become long-form. The winning subject line becomes the hook for a short-form clip after a stranger has bought. Affiliate mentions belong below the reasoning, never above it, and only for tools you still use. Do not turn Tuesday into a tool dump.

What you do not feed yet

A small AI membership, a catalog, a coaching call, a daily brief, a second letter, a podcast, ads. Twelve Tuesdays, one file. Live drops and creator ads wait until the welcome works and you know which issue made the file obvious. Local businesses plus AI can use the same issues as proof you can explain a job in plain type, billed as a service. That is extra, not the weekly job. The list stays the asset. Everything else is a guest.

Mistakes that kill this path

I. Writing for a crowd

Writing for search engines instead of one person. The inbox is not Google. Two jobs in the reader sentence is the same mistake in nicer clothes.

Recovery this week: rewrite the reader sentence. One person, one job. Write the next issue to that named person, in five blocks. Ask for one line. Send it to ten humans, not a feed.

2. Letting AI publish unedited

The first draft from a model is a pile of true-sounding sentences. Your job is to make it specific, short, and slightly uncomfortable, the way a real Tuesday is. A five-block outline from a model is allowed. A five-block paste is not.

Recovery this week: take the last issue, cut every line you would not say at a table, add one scar. Send that. Generate outlines if you want. Do not ship the outline.

3. Breaking the Tuesday promise

Changing the promise every week. Tuesday is follow-up, then Friday is branding, then you skip a week for a personal update. That is a mood board with a send button. Missed Tuesdays with silence teach them you were never an appointment.

Recovery this week: send a short note on the promised day. Then be back next week. Two misses in a row is a new habit. If you must move the day, say so once, then keep the new day.

4. Sending only when you have a launch, or sending daily

Then you are not a letter. You are a store that opens four times a year. Daily is the other face of the same mistake: you will miss, they will skim, you will send a guilty catch-up.

Recovery this week: put a teaching issue on the calendar for the next four Tuesdays. Stop the extras. Keep the one promised day. Say so once: I write on Tuesday. That is the deal.

5. Buying a list, scraping, or hiding unsubscribe

Bought names do not open. They train the inbox to treat you as junk. Scraped names are not yours. Targeted is not a loophole. Hidden unsubscribe shows up later as a deliverability problem you will blame on the tool.

Recovery this week: do not send to those names again. Start a clean form. Invite ten humans you actually know. Put unsubscribe in the footer in plain type. Mean it. Test from a second email. A few unsubscribes are health.

6. Essays nobody asked for, or a 40-field form

Two thousand words they cannot use this week. Or a form that feels like a job application. They leave. You blame the tool.

Recovery this week: split the essay. One idea per Tuesday. Four hundred to seven hundred words. If you need two thousand, you have two issues. On the form: one field besides email. Rebuild the form today. Keep the old list.

7. A welcome that is only a pitch, or pitching in issue one

They did the work of joining. You sent a cart. They leave and tell a friend you are a trap. Same family: issue one is the job, not the cart. Welcome 1 is the file. Issues 2 through 6 teach. You are earning issue 7.

Recovery this week: rewrite the welcome as three emails. File first, how to use it second, what Tuesday is third, no price in any of them. Delete the by the way I sell paragraph.

8. Changing the topic every week, or adding a second letter

Follow-up, then branding, then a personal update, then a tool dump. Or a Friday bonus in month two because you felt guilty. A second letter starves Tuesday.

Recovery this week: go back to the named job. Kill the second letter. Move any useful extra into next Tuesday. Twelve issues on that job. One appointment.

9. Fake scarcity on the playbook, or giving this book away

24 hours only on a PDF that does not run out. They will remember. Trust dies. A sales letter with a Tuesday costume is the same mistake: you argued instead of demonstrating.

Giving The Operator Suite away as a lead magnet is the other face of this. It is off limits. It also trains buyers to see you as a reseller.

Recovery this week: the quiet sentence. \$47, yours to keep, next Tuesday either way. No clock. The ask issue still has five blocks. If you exported this suite as the magnet, delete that file today. Write seven questions for your job.

10. Skipping the ten humans

Waiting for the algorithm. Redesigning the header instead of sending issue one. Zero personal invites.

Recovery this week: ten names from your phone. Personal copy. Ask for the useful line. The ten replies are the next four issues. Audience is what the letter builds. It is not a prerequisite.

Ethics, restated: do not invent a subscriber story. Do not fake a testimonial. Do not use a client's real email in a story. Do not scrape. Do not sell the list. Do not copy this book. The table voice includes not lying.

Tools and how you actually use them

Exact stack

Beehiiv or MailerLite. Pick one. Do not split the list. A one-page diagnostic as the lead magnet. A form. A welcome of three emails. Google Docs for the issue and the PDF. A notes app for useful lines and objections. Stripe Payment Link for the playbook when you are ready to ask. That is the stack.

Not ConvertKit plus Beehiiv plus Substack at once. Not a custom ESP. Not a referral leaderboard.

Setup order

Reader sentence. Job with a verb. Promised day. Diagnostic PDF from Google Docs. Form. Welcome of three that delivers the file at once. Test from a second email. Issue one written by hand in five blocks. Ten personal invites. Then the weekly date. Do not tour five email platforms. The tool you will log into beats the pretty one you will abandon.

Beehiiv or MailerLite

Either. Pick the one you will actually open on a Tuesday night. Switching later is a tax. Default: the tool you already opened this month.

In Beehiiv the welcome is an automation attached to the form. In MailerLite it is an automation on the group the form dumps into. Three emails: day 0, day 2, day 4. The weekly letter is a separate broadcast or publication. Do not pause the publication for people still in the automation. They overlap. That is fine. Test all three from a second email before you invite anyone. If welcome 1 does not attach the PDF, nothing else matters.

From-name is your first name. Not MAIL-DAEMON. Not your LLC in all caps.

What not to buy

A customer-data platform. A popup that follows people around. Five landing-page builders. Daily sending tools. Scrapers. Anything that promises you a list by Friday. A brand kit in week 1. Ads before four issues are in the can. A paid domain is optional later, not the 72-hour job. A second newsletter tool for the other audience. A custom ESP. A referral leaderboard. ConvertKit and Beehiiv and Substack at the same time.

The \$0 path

Beehiiv or MailerLite free tier. A Google Doc exported to PDF for the diagnostic. A form on a free Beehiiv landing page, or a MailerLite embedded form on a page you already have. Stripe Payment Link or Stan for the \$47 file when you ask. The letter can live in a Google Doc until you paste it into the tool. You do not need a new domain for month one. You do not need Canva for a header. Plain type, your name, the promised day.

How you actually use AI here

Draft and tighten. Not send. Not invent subscriber stories. Not write fake testimonials. If you use a model to outline issue two, you still rewrite every paragraph in the voice you would use at a table. Generate twenty subject lines. Speak only the ones a human would open at 7am. Cut the rest. Generate a five-block outline. Fill the blocks yourself. Read the result out loud. The scar is the part they cannot download for free.

AI may draft. You must rewrite until it sounds like you. If a blank chat could have written the issue, you have not written it.

What to leave on the shelf

Daily sending tools. Scrapers. Bought lists. A membership platform. A community chat. A second newsletter tool for the other audience. The list you did not earn will not open. The second tool will split the only asset this path builds. Host the list. Platforms can take a following. They cannot take this if you keep it here.

Ship checklist

Print this. Tick it. Do not send issue one until the door half is honest.

Before you send issue one

One reader, written in one sentence, with a constraint

One job, with a verb, that every issue will be about

One promised day and a length you can keep

Diagnostic: one-page scorecard or 7-day checklist, useful if they never buy

Seven questions that change the advice, not seven that all say buy

PDF named like a human, reply-to on it

Not this book. You wrote the door.

Beehiiv or MailerLite account, one form, welcome of three that delivers the file at once

One field besides email

Test from a second email: file arrives, emails 2 and 3 are scheduled, unsubscribe works

Issue one written by hand in five blocks, then tightened, then read out loud

Subject line a human would open at 7am; five drafted, one picked

One ask at the end, then the same signoff you will use next week

Form on the same page as the offer, but second

Paid button third, not a menu

\$47 checkout tested on a phone if the file is live

Ten names written down for the personal invite

Footer with unsubscribe in plain type

Issues 2, 3, and 4 sketched in one line each

No daily extra planned

No bought list

The five-block check, every issue

Hook: a moment, two to four sentences, not a thesis

One useful thing: one claim they can use this week

One example: named, slightly messy, stealable

One ask-or-not: decided before you wrote; never three

Signoff: the same as last week

Four hundred to seven hundred words

Read out loud; if you would not say it at a table, cut it

The first month

Ten people you know received issue one

You collected the useful lines

Issues sent on the promised day; 4-for-4 is the streak

Issue 4 was still teaching, still the same job

Issues 2 through 6 teach; no cart in paragraph one

Replies saved into a note

Can you do this for me got a price or a file, not a free hour

Forward ask used once, not every issue

Once, a quieter issue that can point to the \$47 playbook if the file is ready

No list bought, no scrape, no daily extra

No second letter

Spreadsheet row: date, on time, replies, new honest subs, checkouts

Header not redesigned three times

Opens glanced at once, then ignored

You may ask for money when

The free file works without you in the room

You have kept the day

They have heard from you enough that the ask is not email one

You can say the price in one calm sentence

Checkout works on a phone

The ask issue still has five blocks and the same signoff

Next Tuesday will still arrive if they ignore it

You did not invent scarcity

After twelve Tuesdays

Still one letter

Still one reader

Still one job

Ads still off unless welcome works and four issues were already in the can

First buyers asked which issue sent them

File still \$19 to \$47 unless they used something you added

List still hosted by you

No podcast, no second letter, no daily, until you looked at the replies

Friend-fairness before you share

Would you send a friend to this form? Useful file in one minute. Letter that does not pitch in issue one. Unsubscribe that works. Diagnostic you wrote, not this book. If any of those fail, you are not shipping. Fix the list tonight.

FAQ

Can I charge for the letter?

Later, maybe. Not first. The letter is free. You charge for the \$19 to \$47 file after trust. A paid letter is a later product, after the free one is a habit. Charging for Tuesday in month one is how you get twelve fans and no asset. Default: free Tuesday, paid playbook.

Can I use AI to write it?

Draft only. Outline the five blocks if you want. Then rewrite every paragraph in the voice you would use at a table. Read it out loud. If a blank chat could have written it, you have not written it. Add the scar. Default: your voice, model as a starter. Do not invent subscriber stories. Do not ship the paste.

Can I give The Operator Suite away as my lead magnet?

No. This suite is The Operator Suite. You may brand your own letter. You may not copy this book, sell it as yours, or give it away as a lead magnet. A two-to-four page diagnostic you wrote for one job is the door. This book is not a magnet. If you already exported it with your logo, delete that file today and write seven questions.

Do I need a brand kit?

No. You need issue one and a form. A header you will not redesign is enough. Elena did not wait on a logo. The ten humans do not care. Default: plain type, your name, the promised day. No brand kit in the first four weeks.

Beehiiv or MailerLite?

Either. Pick the one you will actually log into. Switching later is a tax. Default: the tool you already opened this month. Do not split the list. Do not run ConvertKit and Beehiiv and Substack at once. Do not build a custom ESP.

What if nobody replies?

Ask a better ask. Was this good dies. Reply with the line you would actually send lives. Write to one person. Send ten more personal invites before you decide the path is dead. If you asked three things, they will do none. If the issue was a crowd-letter, tighten the reader sentence. Default: one person, one line, ten more humans.

Can I send daily?

No. Daily blasts are in the leave-alone line. You will miss a day, then two, then send a guilty catch-up and train them to skim. Weekly is the deal. Same day. Same length. Growth is personal invites and a forwardable door, not frequency. A Friday bonus is daily by accident. Kill it. Default: one appointment.

Can I buy a list if it is targeted?

No. Never buy a list. Never scrape. Targeted is not a loophole. Bought names do not open. They mark you as junk. One rented blast can train the inbox to treat you as spam. Fifty honest subscribers beat five thousand quiet ones. Personal invites and a forward loop. Default: names that asked.

When do I ask for money?

After they have watched you teach. Issues 2 through 6 teach. Issue 7, or a quieter issue once a month, can ask for the \$19 to \$47 playbook. If the file is not ready, keep teaching. A bad ask costs more than a late one. Default: issue 7, one calm sentence, next Tuesday either way. Do not pitch in email one. Do not invent scarcity.

How long is an issue?

Four hundred to seven hundred words. Default: about 500, five blocks, one ask-or-not. If you need two thousand, you have two issues. Split them. Tired people finish short letters. A two-hour cap. When the cap hits, cut, do not expand.

What if I miss a Tuesday?

Send a short note: I missed Tuesday. Here is a short one. Back next week on the promised day. If this broke the deal, unsubscribe. Then be back. Two misses in a row is a new habit. If you must move the day, say so once, then keep the new day. Default: short note, then keep the printed day. Do not send a guilty double issue.

Can I add a podcast?

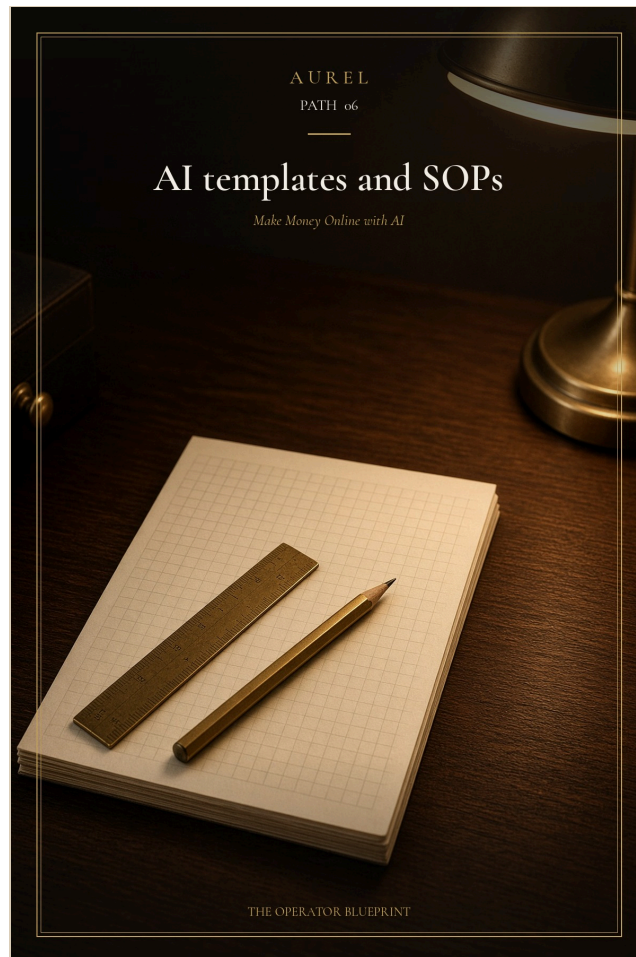
Not until twelve Tuesdays have left on time. Extra channels are how letters starve. Same answer for YouTube, daily notes, and a second letter. Default: one appointment. The list is the asset. Clips can wait. Ads wait until the welcome works and four issues are in the can.

What if I have two audiences?

You have two letters. Pick one for twelve weeks. Merging them is how you write for nobody. If you serve two jobs for the same person, pick the job they pay you for first. Default: one reader, one job, twelve issues. The other audience can wait.

Do I need a custom domain first?

No. A custom domain is not needed in month one. A real from-address helps later. Default: no domain haul in the first four weeks. Beehiiv or MailerLite, your first name in the from-line, a form, a file that arrives. The ten humans do not care what the URL looks like. They care whether Tuesday showed up.



PATH 06

AI templates and SOPs

A filled example sells. An empty grid is homework.

39 minute read · 8,655 words

Who this is for

You already run a repeatable process: intake, content calendar, invoice, weekly review. You can screenshot a filled week without leaking a client.

Time to first

3–10 days if the file already exists

First sale

A \$19 template that saves someone an afternoon. Stranger, not you, checkout worked.

Cash window

\$12–\$29 for one file, \$29–\$47 for a bundle of three that share a Tuesday

Tools

Notion, Google Sheets, Canva, and the prompt block that rebuilds the filled version from a few inputs.

Leave this alone

Empty aesthetic planners. Fifty messy files. Anything you named an OS.

What you are selling

The file is the product. The prompt that fills it is the leverage. Together they let a buyer go from zero to a working system in ten minutes. That is the promise. If it takes an hour of setup, you built software, not a template.

A template in this path is a working example of a job you already do — intake, content calendar, invoice, weekly review — plus the block at the top that rebuilds a filled version from a few inputs. The buyer should be able to duplicate, paste, and move. They should not need a course to sit down.

Definition, in one breath You sell a duplicate-ready file that already contains one honest week of work, fake names, real texture, and a prompt that regenerates a similar week from the buyer's own inputs. They pay \$19 because an afternoon is worth more than \$19. They pay to skip the blank page, not to be taught Notion.

The prompt lives in the file, at the top. Inputs in: business, audience, offer, days they can work the job, voice in one line. Output out: a table they can paste. Constraints sit in the same block: length, tone, “do not invent offers I did not type.” If the prompt is in a second download, half your buyers will never open it.

What this is not It is not an “OS.” It is not a second brain. It is not fifty nested pages. Call it what it does on a Tuesday: the weekly content calendar, the intake that does not lose notes, the invoice tracker you actually open. If you cannot say the Tuesday problem in one line, you do not have a product yet.

It is not a course with a file attached. One page of how-to with screenshots is the instruction layer. It is not software. If duplicate requires an integration or a relation you have to explain on a call, flatten it.

Why the filled example is the product Show a filled example. A blank Notion dashboard photographs well and converts poorly. People buy the picture of work already done. They do not buy the homework of naming columns. If your listing image is a lavender empty table with cute icons, you are competing with every aesthetic planner on earth, and you will lose on taste. Fake names. Real statuses. That screenshot is the ad.

Why this works now Buyers already have a model window. What they do not have is a file that tells the model what to fill, in a shape they will actually use next week. Empty templates were always a crowded street. Filled templates plus a prompt that rebuilds the week are still rare. The ten-minute promise is the wedge. A playbook asks them to read. A service asks them to wait. A template asks them to duplicate.

Three anti-patterns Anti-pattern one: the aesthetic planner. You spent a month on icons. The buyer spends a month naming columns. Taste is not a Tuesday problem.

Anti-pattern two: the OS. You nested five databases and priced it like software. The buyer wanted a calendar. They leave a review that says your OS is incomplete. They are right about the naming.

Anti-pattern three: the zip of leftovers. Fifty files, three of them filled, named FINAL_v7_USE_THIS. One clean file beats it every time.

The deal you keep You keep the promise that a reasonably tired person can get a usable filled week in ten minutes with your how-to open. You keep the file duplicable without you. You keep personal data out. You keep the prompt honest. You do not keep a membership for “lifetime updates” you will not ship. You do not keep a chat window as part of \$19.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you already run a repeatable process. You do not need to be a Notion consultant. You need a job you have done more than three times, in a tool you can duplicate without breaking.

Fits if You have a calendar, a sheet, or a form you reuse. Other people have asked “can I have that?” You can screenshot a filled week without leaking a client. You can write one prompt that returns a filled table. You can spend three to ten days cleaning a file you already live in. You can take \$19 without apologizing. You have used the file for at least two weeks. The scars are the product.

Skip if You only have a blank aesthetic you liked on Pinterest. Skip it if your process only lives in your head and has never survived a second week. Skip it if you want to ship fifty messy files and call it a pack. Skip it if you have never kept a calendar for yourself — use it for two weeks, then sell the version that has scars. Skip it if you freeze at \$19 and want to start at \$79 with no reviews. Skip it if you need the buyer on a call to explain the file. Skip it if you want to sell files and also be on retainer for every buyer. That is a service.

The honest middle Most people who stall have a file, it is messy, they are embarrassed, so they rebuild it pretty and empty. Do not do that. Clean just enough to strip personal data and delete dead tabs. Keep the statuses that sound like a human. The mess that survived two weeks is the proof. You do not need an audience of thousands. You need ten people with the Tuesday problem and a checkout that delivers the file.

Skills and time Skills: duplicate a Notion page or a Google Sheet without breaking it. Write a prompt with inputs, output format, and three constraints. Take five screenshots. Write a title that contains the job, the tool, and “filled.”

Time: three to ten days if the file exists. Day 1 is strip and fill. Day 2 is prompt and how-to. Day 3 is listing, test-buy, ten asks. If you do not already have the file, add two weeks of using it

yourself. That is inventory, not delay. Budget: \$0 if you already have Notion or Sheets and a place to take \$19.

Two-minute self-test Answer these out loud.

If you cannot, you are not ready this week.

What is the Tuesday problem in one sentence?

Which file do you already open to solve it?

Can you fill one week with fake names tonight?

Can you name three inputs the prompt needs?

Who are ten people who have this problem, that you can message without a blast?

If you have the sentence, the file, and ten names, start Day 1 this morning. If you have the sentence but no file, use the file for two weeks, then start. If you have no sentence, pick a job you already do.

The offer, named in one sentence

Write this on a sticky note: “A filled [job] template plus the prompt that rebuilds it in ten minutes, for [person] who [Tuesday problem]. \$19. Duplicate, paste, go.”

That sentence is the listing title, the first line, and the DM. If you cannot fill the brackets without a paragraph, you have two products. Split them. Sell one.

Five example sentences that work A filled weekly content calendar for a one-person shop that never knows what to post. Notion. \$19. Duplicate, paste, go.

A filled client-intake database for a freelancer who loses notes in chat. Notion. \$19. Duplicate, paste, go.

A filled invoice tracker for a tradesperson who forgets to send the second bill. Google Sheets. \$19. Duplicate, paste, go.

A filled Friday weekly-review page for a solo operator who ends the week unsure what shipped. Notion. \$19. Duplicate, paste, go.

A filled one-page invoice plus the prompt that rewrites the line items, for a designer who still sends Word docs. Canva. \$19. Duplicate, paste, go.

The job is in the title. The tool is in the title. The prompt is in the file. The price is on the button. Do not hide the tool so both Notion people and sheet people buy the wrong thing and refund.

What they get They get a file they can duplicate today. They get one filled week with fake names and real texture. They get a prompt block at the top that rebuilds a similar week from their inputs. They get a one-page how-to with screenshots: duplicate, paste inputs, run prompt, paste results, what “done” looks like. They get a personal-use license: duplicate for their work, no resale of the template as a template. They get ten minutes to a usable week if they follow the how-to. That is the product.

What they do not get They do not get a call, custom columns, you filling the week, a course, lifetime updates, a community, a second tool version inside the same \$19, or a login you control. If they write “can you just fill this for me?” that is a productized package. Send the price of the package or send the file. Do not hop on a call that becomes the job.

Packaging One file at \$19 is the default. \$12 if the job is tiny: one sheet, ten rows. \$29 if the file is clearly a week of work and the prompt is tested on two businesses.

A bundle of three related files at \$29 outsells one lonely file at \$12 if they clearly belong together. Calendar plus intake plus weekly review is a week. Calendar plus a mood board plus a habit tracker is a drawer. Related means they share a Tuesday.

A \$47 bundle of three is allowed when each file is used, filled, and documented, and at least one stranger has bought the single. Do not jump to \$47 because three sounds premium. Keep the single for sale when you launch the bundle.

The ten-minute promise If a reasonably tired person cannot get a usable filled week in ten minutes with your how-to open, you overbuilt. Delete tabs until the promise is true. Time someone. If they need you at minute four, add a screenshot. If they need you at minute twenty because of a nested relation, flatten the file. The promise is the offer. Pretty is not.

What ‘done’ looks like

Done is a \$19 template that saves someone an afternoon. Not a library. Not a mobile app. A file they can duplicate today. A stranger who is not you followed the how-to without sending you a voice note. Checkout delivered the file. That is done.

Definition of done, for this path The listing is live. The first image is the filled week. The title names the job, the tool, and “filled.” The price is \$19 (or \$12 if tiny). You bought it from a second email and the file arrived. Ten people with the Tuesday problem have been asked. The milestone is the stranger sale. The bar for shipping is the test-buy plus the ten asks. A three-file bundle at \$29 is a second done, after the first file has been used by someone else.

The fairness test Hand the how-to and the file to someone who has not seen either. Do not hover. Time them. If they have a usable filled week in ten minutes, you are fair. If they need you, you are not done. Fair also means the screenshot matches the file. Fair means personal data is gone. Fake names are fine. Real client emails are not. Fair means the license is one paragraph, not a trap. Fair means a refund if the file will not duplicate, not a debate about their taste.

Technical done - Duplicate works. Permissions do not block the buyer. The database is not locked. - The prompt is a block at the top: inputs, output format, constraints. It has been run twice on different businesses. - One-page how-to with screenshots of: duplicate, paste inputs, run prompt, paste results, what “done” looks like. - Personal data stripped. Sample person obviously fake. - Extra

tabs you have not opened in fourteen days are gone. - Readable on a phone. Editing on a phone can be ugly. Reading should not be. - File named like a human: Weekly-content-calendar-filled. Not FINAL_v7_USE_THIS. - Checkout tested. File arrives.

Not-done-yet list You are not done if the first screenshot is an empty grid. You are not done if the prompt is in a separate Google Doc they have to request. You are not done if duplicate requires you to “add them as a guest.” You are not done if you have not test-bought. You are not done if the title is “Aesthetic Content OS for CEOs.” You are not done if there are forty tabs. You are not done if you have not asked ten people. You are not done if the filled week uses real client emails. Ship the bar. Then fix what the first buyer trips on. Write that into the how-to. Do not add a tab.

How to price without guessing

First file: \$19. That is the default. \$12 if the job is tiny (one sheet, ten rows). \$29 if the file is clearly a week of work and the prompt is tested. Do not start at \$79. You have no reviews and a duplicate button.

Ranges that do not embarrass you \$12 — one sheet, ten rows, a tracker they will open. Tiny job. Still filled.

\$19 — the honest first price for a filled week plus a prompt plus a how-to. This is where almost every first file should live.

\$29 — a single file that is obviously a week of work, or a three-file bundle that shares a Tuesday, early.

\$47 — a three-file bundle after proof. Each file filled, documented, used.

Above \$47 on this path is how you accidentally start selling a course or a service. If they need you every month, that is not a template.

Why \$19 is the honest first price It is small enough that a tired person will try it to save an afternoon. It is large enough that you will not feel used when they email a question. If you are ashamed of \$19, you either overbuilt or you do not believe the afternoon is real. Cut the file, or use it yourself for another week. Do not use \$17 or \$19.99.

When to raise Raise the single from \$19 to \$29 after ten stranger sales and a how-to that no longer gets the same question. Raise the bundle from \$29 to \$47 after the bundle has sold at least three times. Quiet is usually a listing problem, not a price problem. If people buy and refund because they expected a course, your title is wrong, not your price.

Refunds in one sentence Refund on request for 7 days if the file will not duplicate or the how-to does not match the listing. Do not refund because they wanted a different tool. Name the tool in the title.

What you never charge You do not charge extra for “lifetime updates” you will not ship. You do not add a \$9 monthly for a template. You do not charge a setup call on top of \$19. Time-in-Canva is not value.

Worked dollars Chris’s calendar: \$19. Three of eight asks bought in a week. \$57. Week 2 bundle of three at \$29. Two bundle sales in ten days. \$115 in the first three weeks from one ugly file he already used. Your first ten \$19 sales are \$190 before fees. Sell ten. Then bundle. Then, with proof, \$47. Pride is not a price.

The first 72 hours

You are not inventing a system from a blank page. You are cleaning the one you already use. If you do not already use one, stop. Use a file for two weeks. Then come back to Day 1.

Day 1 morning: duplicate and name the job Open the template you already live in. Duplicate it into a clean workspace so you cannot

leak the original. Write the Tuesday problem in one sentence. If you need a paragraph, you have two products. Pick one. Rename the duplicate like a human. Weekly-content-calendar-filled. Not FINAL_v7.

Day 1 afternoon: strip and delete Strip personal data. Rename the sample person to something obviously fake: River Bakery, Lane Tutoring, Moss Plumbing. Delete every tab you have not opened in fourteen days. Forty tabs is how buyers bounce. Be cruel. You can keep a private copy of the fat version for yourself.

Day 1 night: fill one honest week Fill one real-looking week so the screenshot has texture: statuses, dates, a note that sounds like work. Statuses in plain words: draft, need photo, scheduled. Do not go to bed with an empty grid.

Day 2: the prompt and the how-to Write the prompt that regenerates a filled sample from a few inputs: business, audience, offer, days they can post, voice in one line. Put that prompt in a block at the top of the file. Include constraints: length, tone, “do not invent offers I did not type.” Run it. Paste the output. Fix the prompt until the table is usable, not until it is clever. Run it a second time on a different fake business. If both outputs look like the same billboard, add constraints.

Write one page of how-to. Screenshots of: duplicate, paste inputs, run prompt, paste results, what “done” looks like. No video required for v1. Screenshot the filled version, not the empty grid.

Day 3: listing, test-buy, ten asks Price \$19. Title: “Filled [job] template + the prompt that rebuilds it in ten minutes.” Name the tool. Your site first. Etsy if the search terms are obvious. First image is the filled week.

Buy it yourself from a second email, different browser. If the file does not arrive, nothing else matters. Then send ten messages to people who have the Tuesday problem. Not a blast. Ten names, ten notes, the screenshot, the \$19. Then stop for the day. Do not add a tab while you wait.

The path, step by step

Fourteen steps. The file comes from a job you already do. Do not reverse that.

Step 1. Name the Tuesday problem Write one sentence. “I never know what to post.” “I lose intake notes.” “I forget to invoice.” If you need a paragraph, you have two products. Split them. The sentence becomes the title and the test you use when you want to add a tab. If the tab does not serve the sentence, it does not ship.

Step 2. Start from the file you already use Duplicate the file you already open. Do not rebuild in a new tool because a thread said it was nicer. The scars are in the current file. A rebuild from zero will give you twenty tabs and no scars. If the current file is ugly, good. Ugly and used is the only aesthetic that sells.

Step 3. Build only the columns or pages that solve that Delete the rest. A content calendar needs: date, channel, hook, body, asset, status, link. An invoice tracker needs: client, date sent, amount, due, status, follow-up date. An intake needs: name, job, deadline, notes, next step. Cruelty toward tabs is kindness toward buyers.

Step 4. Fill one honest week Use fake names. Keep the texture of real work. This filled week is your listing image and your quality bar. If you cannot fill it, you do not understand the job well enough to sell the file. Fill it before you write the prompt. The prompt should match a week you would actually run.

Step 5. Put the AI prompt at the top Inputs in, filled table out. Include constraints: length, tone, “do not invent offers I did not type,” “do not sound like a billboard.” Run it twice on two different businesses. If the second run is unusable, the prompt is the product to fix, not the colors. Do not hide the prompt in a nested page.

Step 6. One-page how-to with screenshots Duplicate, paste, run, paste, done. Five screenshots. One mobile note. No video required for v1. Write it as if the reader is on a couch at 10 p.m. and will not email you. Permissions and “duplicate” are where most how-tos fail. Screenshot that click.

Step 7. Strip, export, name the file like a human Personal data gone. Fake names obvious. File name: Weekly-content-calendar-filled, or a Notion share the buyer owns after duplicate. Not FINAL_v7_USE_THIS. If they only get a view-only link you control, you did not deliver.

Step 8. Listing on your site. Etsy if the search terms are obvious Title matches the offer sentence. First image is the filled example. Tool named. Price \$19. Your site first so you own the buyer. Etsy as a search channel for jobs people already type. One checkout that works beats four that you have not test-bought.

Step 9. Test-buy. Then ten asks Different browser. Second email. Confirm they get access. Then message ten people who have the Tuesday problem. Not a blast. A note that names their problem, shows the filled screenshot, states \$19, and lets them ignore you. Ten is an evening. One hundred is a stall.

Step 10. Fix what the first buyer trips on Usually: permissions, a locked database, a prompt that assumes a tool they do not have, a how-to that skips the duplicate click. Write that into the how-to. Send the update to anyone who already bought. Do not add a tab. Treat the trip as a screenshot you forgot.

Step 11. Week 2: a three-file bundle only if they share a Tuesday Calendar plus intake plus Friday review is a week. \$29. The first file stays at \$19. Each extra file gets the same treatment: filled example, prompt at the top, one-page how-to. If you do not have two more lived-in files, sell the one.

Step 12. Use the file in public without leaking One post that shows this week's filled row, names changed. Proof the file is alive, not a launch campaign. Blur

what you must. If you cannot show a row, fake the row. Keep the texture.

Step 13. Answer the two questions buyers actually ask They will ask where to put something that does not belong in this file, or how to duplicate. Answer in the how-to. If they ask you to fill it for them, send the productized-package price or say no. Two answers, written once.

Step 14. Do not design forty tabs When you want to add a dashboard, go use the file for a week instead. New tabs are how templates become homework again. The urge to add is the urge to avoid asking more people. Ask more people. Delete more tabs.

Worked example: Chris and the filled calendar

Chris runs a one-person design practice. Every Sunday he used to stare at a blank week and then post nothing until Wednesday. He built a Notion calendar so he would stop staring. Six columns. One view for the week. A status he actually updates. After two months it was ugly and used, which is the only aesthetic that sells.

This is a three-week story with dollars, a shipped file, a mistake, a recovery, and a first stranger sale.

Week of March 3: the \$19 file He duplicated the calendar on a Monday morning. He renamed his clients to “River Bakery” and “Lane Tutoring.” He filled one week: five posts, two stories, one email, statuses in plain words (draft, need photo, scheduled). He deleted a mood-board tab he had not opened since January.

At the top he wrote a prompt:

Paste: what you sell, who it is for, the one offer this month, days you can post, how you sound in one sentence. Return: a seven-day table with date, channel, hook, body under 80 words, asset needed, status set to draft. Do not invent a second offer. Do not sound like a billboard.

He ran it on his own inputs. He edited two hooks that were cute and useless. He ran it again as River Bakery. The second run tried to invent a merch line. He added “do not invent products” and ran it a third time. Usable.

He put that filled week in the first screenshot. Title: “Filled weekly content-calendar (Notion) + the prompt that rebuilds it in ten minutes.” \$19. How-to: one page, five screenshots. No video. He listed it on his site Tuesday night. He bought it from a second Gmail. He sent eight messages Wednesday morning to people who had complained about posting.

The mistake The public duplicate was view-only unless the buyer clicked a buried “duplicate” in the top right. Two of the eight asked where the file was. One was annoyed. That is a refund-shaped moment.

The recovery Wednesday afternoon he added two screenshots to the how-to: the exact top-right duplicate click, and what the page looks like after you own it. He emailed the eight with one line: “If you already bought, here is the missing screenshot. Duplicate is top right.” He did not add a tab. He fixed the how-to the same day.

The first sales, including a stranger Three of the eight bought that week. \$57. One of the three was a stranger by one degree: a friend forwarded the note to a copywriter Chris had never met. She paid Thursday night. That is the first stranger sale. She asked where to put intake notes. Chris answered: “Not in this file. I am cleaning an intake next week. Calendar stays a calendar.”

Shipped artifact: one Notion file, six columns, one filled week, prompt at the top, one-page how-to, \$19 checkout.

Week of March 10: the \$29 three-file bundle He cleaned two other files he already used: a client intake and a Friday weekly review. Same treatment: filled example, prompt at the top, one-page how-to. Bundle of three at \$29. The calendar stayed available alone at \$19.

Two bundle sales in ten days. \$58. One more \$19 single. First three weeks, roughly \$134 before fees, from files he already lived in. He did not call it an OS. He did not add a CRM. He sold the picture of a week already done, and the prompt that rebuilds it.

The copywriter left one sentence he reused as a listing line, with permission and no last name: “I had a week of posts in the time it took to make coffee.”

Copy you can paste

Swap the job. Keep the filled promise. Do not add “OS.” Do not add “200+.”

Post, under a screenshot of the filled example This is last week’s calendar, names changed. Empty templates are homework. This one is already working. Duplicate the Notion, paste a few inputs, run the prompt at the top, paste the table. About ten minutes. \$19. Link in the reply.

DM I use this every Sunday so I stop staring at a blank week. Filled [job] template plus the prompt that rebuilds it. \$19. If that saves you an afternoon: [link]. If not, no need to reply.

Page hero Filled [job] template + the prompt that rebuilds it in ten minutes. You get a filled week, not an empty grid. Duplicate. Paste a few inputs. Run the prompt. Paste the table. \$19.

Checkout line You are buying a duplicate-ready [Notion / Sheets / Canva] file with one filled week, a prompt at the top that rebuilds it, and a one-page how-to. Personal use. No resale of the template. If duplicate fails, email me and I will refund or fix it.

Email 1 — the ask, to ten people Subject: the calendar I actually use on Sundays
You have mentioned [Tuesday problem] more than once. I cleaned the file I use and put the prompt that rebuilds a week at the top. Filled example in the first screenshot. \$19. Duplicate,

paste, go. [link]

If it is not useful, ignore this. I am not going to follow up three times.

Email 2 — after they buy, delivery plus the missing-click Subject: your file + the one click people miss

Here is the duplicate link. How-to is the first page. The click people miss: top right, Duplicate. After that you own it. Prompt is the block at the top. Inputs, then run, then paste. If duplicate fails, reply to this. I will fix it or refund.

Email 3 — three days later, only if they have not opened it Subject: one screenshot if you got stuck

If the file is still sitting there: open the how-to, do the duplicate click, stop. Do not rebuild it pretty first. Fill one week with the prompt. If you wanted me to fill it for you, that is a different thing and I will send that price.

Refund note You asked for a refund. Done — you should see it in 5–10 days depending on the processor. If the file would not duplicate, that is on me and I am also fixing the how-to. If you needed [other tool], the title names [this tool] on purpose so I do not take that money.

Bundle line Three files that share a Tuesday: weekly calendar, intake, Friday review. \$29. Each one has a filled example and the prompt that rebuilds it. The calendar is still \$19 alone if you only need posts.

Listing title Filled [job] template + the prompt that rebuilds it in ten minutes ([Notion / Sheets / Canva]).

What not to write “Aesthetic Notion dashboard for CEOs.”
“Ultimate content OS.” “200+ templates.” Those lines sell a vibe to people who will not open the file. You are selling an afternoon back.

Week-by-week

You can do the first sale inside ten days if the file already exists. Do not use week one to learn a new tool. Four weeks. Weeks 1–2 are daily. Weeks 3–4 are maintenance plus the bundle, not a redesign.

Week 1, day by day Monday: duplicate the file you already use. Write the Tuesday problem in one sentence. Strip personal data. Fake names. Delete dead tabs.

Tuesday: fill one honest week. Texture, not lorem. Screenshot that week. Start the prompt: inputs, output format, three constraints.

Wednesday: run the prompt twice on two businesses. Fix until usable. Draft the one-page how-to. Five screenshots including duplicate.

Thursday: listing on your site. Title, \$19, filled screenshot first, tool named. Test-buy from a second email. Fix delivery.

Friday: ten asks. Personal notes. Screenshot attached or linked. Then stop asking for the day.

Saturday: use your own file for real. If a column annoys you, delete it. Do not add one.

Sunday: if nobody bought, look at the listing cold. Is the first image empty. Is the title a poem. Fix those two. Do not add a tab.

Week 2, day by day Monday: two of the ten, a short follow-up only if they asked a question. If they were silent, leave them silent.

Tuesday: write down the two questions you already got. Put the answers in the how-to. Usually duplicate and “where does X go.”

Wednesday: if you already have two other lived-in files that share the Tuesday, start stripping the second file. If you do not, skip to Friday.

Thursday: third file, same treatment, or rest. Do not invent a habit tracker to complete a set.

Friday: bundle page at \$29 if the three files share a Tuesday. Single stays at \$19. Test-buy the bundle.

Saturday: one public post of this week's filled row, names changed.

Sunday: referral ask to anyone who already bought. One sentence.

Week 3 Use the file. Update the how-to if the same question arrived twice. Do not start a fourth file. Do not film a course. If you have zero sales, the screenshot is empty or you asked strangers. Ask ten more people who actually have the job. Rewrite the title to contain the job and the tool.

Week 4 Count: sales, refunds, open tickets, bundle attach. If you have three sales and zero open tickets, you are fine. Leave the file alone except for a prompt tweak. If you have thirty views and zero sales, fix the listing before you rebuild the file. Then stop for the month. A template path that gets redesigned every Sunday never collects reviews.

The quality bar

A stranger should go from purchase to a filled week in ten minutes without you. That is the bar. Pretty is optional. Clear is not.

Below the bar Empty first screenshot. Title that says OS, dashboard, or 200+. Prompt missing or sitting in a second download. Duplicate locked. Real client emails in the sample. Forty tabs. How-to is a 20-minute video and nothing else. File named FINAL_v7. Tool not named. You have not test-bought.

Above the bar Filled week in the first image. Job + tool + "filled" in the title. Prompt at the top with inputs, format, constraints, tested on two businesses. One-page how-to, five or more screenshots, including the duplicate click. Fake names, real texture. Dead tabs gone. Readable on a phone. Test-buy passed. A stranger finished in ten minutes while you sat on your hands.

Test 1 — the filled-week test Hand the how-to to someone who has not seen the file. Time them. If they need you at minute four, the how-to is missing a screenshot. If they need you at minute twenty because of a nested relation, you built software. Flatten it. Aim under ten minutes to a usable week.

Test 2 — the mobile test Open the file on a phone. Can they read the week? Can they see the prompt? Editing on a phone can be ugly. Reading should not be. Forgetting mobile is how you lose the people who buy at 10 p.m. on a couch.

Test 3 — the prompt test Run the prompt on two different businesses. If both outputs look like the same billboard, add constraints. A cute template with a lazy prompt is an empty grid with extra steps. Save both outputs as proof you ran it.

Test 4 — the naming test Call it a checklist or a calendar if that is what it is. Calling it an OS when it is a checklist trains buyers to expect a product you did not make. Read your title out loud. If it could apply to any file on Etsy, it is wrong.

Test 5 — the strip test Search the file for @, .com, phone-shaped numbers, real last names, invoice numbers. If anything real remains, you are not done. Fake names should be obviously fake. River Bakery is fine. Your actual Tuesday client is not.

What to count

Count a short list. A template business dies when you count likes and tab count.

Week 1 - Listing live, test-buy passed (yes/no) - Ten asks sent (count) - Sales of the \$19 file, including you as a test (separate the test) - Refunds and “I cannot open this” notes - Time-to-filled-week from the one person you watched

Target: rails work, ten asks out, maybe one sale. Zero sales in week 1 is normal if the asks went out Friday. Panic is not a metric.

Day 30 - Stranger sales (not you, not a spouse) - Refund rate. Over 10 percent means the listing oversold or duplicate fails. - Open tickets of the same question. Two of the same means the how-to is missing a screenshot. - Bundle attach: how many \$19 buyers take the \$29 set. - Which screenshot they linger on, if your host shows it. It should be the filled example.

A good day 30 is 5–15 singles at \$19, or fewer plus a couple of bundles. That is \$95–\$285 before fees. Not a company. Proof.

Day 90 - Repeatable listing: title, screenshot, how-to no longer getting the same ticket - Bundle at \$29 or \$47 with at least three bundle sales - Prompt updated once because a buyer called it generic, and you fixed constraints - A decision: raise the single to \$29, or leave it and spend time on a productized package for people who want you to fill it

If you are at zero, you asked the wrong ten people or the screenshot is empty. Do not start file fifty.

Ignore these for now Likes on a template aesthetic post. Number of tabs as a flex. A competitor with 4.8 stars and two hundred files. Pageviews without checkout attempts. Time spent in Canva. You are in an afternoon-saving contest.

One-line spreadsheet Date | item (single \$19 / bundle \$29) | buyer type (ask / stranger / Etsy) | refund (y/n) | ticket (duplicate / prompt / other / none) | notes

One row per sale. Five minutes a week. If you have three sales and zero open tickets, you are fine. If you have thirty views and zero sales, the screenshot is empty or the title hides the job. Fix the listing before you rebuild the file.

Objections you will hear

These are the lines you will hear. The reply is the short thing you actually send. Not a speech.

“Notion templates are everywhere and cheap.” Empty ones are. Filled ones with a prompt that rebuilds the week are not everywhere. Reply: “True for empty grids. This one is a filled week plus the prompt at the top. Screenshot is the actual week, names changed. \$19 if that saves you Sunday.”

“People will just copy the structure.” They will. You are selling time, not a secret column name. Reply: “They might. They are paying to skip the blank page and the bad prompt. That is the product.”

“I should record a course first.” No. One-page how-to. Screenshots. No video required for v1. Reply: “I am shipping the file. If ten people get stuck on the same click, I will add one short clip of that click. Not a course.”

“\$19 feels too low.” Good. Sell ten. Then offer the \$29 bundle. Then, with proof, a \$47 set. Pride is not a price. Reply: “It is low on purpose. I would rather ten people use it than one person admire a \$79 OS I have not earned.”

“What if they want it in a different tool?” Pick the one you already use. A second version is a second product. Reply: “This one is Notion. I do not have Sheets yet. Refund if you bought the wrong tool; the title names it.”

“I do not have three files.” Then sell one at \$19. The bundle is week 2, not a requirement for week 1. Reply to yourself: ship the one.

“Can you customize the columns for me?” That is a service. Quote a package or say no. Reply: “Custom columns are a separate package with a date and a price. The \$19 file is as-is. Happy to send the package page.”

“I already have ChatGPT. Why do I need your file?” Because a window is not a week. Reply: “You do. This is the file the window fills, plus the constraints so it

stops inventing a merch line. If you already have a calendar you like, ignore this.”

“Will you update it forever?” No. Reply: “I will fix broken duplicate and wrong how-to steps. I will not run a membership for a template. The license is personal use, not a support contract.”

What this path feeds

A template is a thin product that throws off thicker ones. Treat it as a door, not as the whole house.

Upstream — what you need before this path You need a Tuesday problem you have already solved in a tool you control. You need two weeks of living in the file. You need ten people you can message. You do not need a membership or an audience of thousands. If you have no file, this path is closed. Use the file. Then sell it.

Downstream — where buyers go next The letter can show this week’s filled row and link the \$19 file. The playbook can include the template as the working file at the back. People who write “can you just fill this for me?” are asking for a productized package, not a free hour. Send the price or send the file. Do not hop on a call that becomes the job.

A stranger who loved the calendar is a candidate for the \$29 bundle, then for a \$600 week where you fill it. Do not shrink the package to match the template price. They are different products. The template is the sample. The package is you.

Affiliate can sit under the prompt block: “I draft in [tool]. Review here. You do not have to buy it.” Only if you actually use it. Disclosure on that page.

What it needs, and what it does not It needs a Tuesday problem, a duplicable file, a prompt, a how-to, a test-buy, ten asks. It does not need a membership to “get all templates.” Fifty messy files is the thing to leave

alone. One file that works, then a bundle of three that belong together. When the template is converting, do not pause it to build a vault. Keep the one, keep the bundle, let the package take the people who want hands.

Mistakes that stall this path

Each one has a recovery you can do this week. Not next quarter.

1. Competing only on aesthetic Taste is not a Tuesday problem. A filled ugly calendar will outsell an empty beautiful one. Recovery this week: replace the first listing image with the filled week. Do not open Canva.
2. Shipping 40 tabs Each tab is a place to get lost. Recovery this week: delete every tab you have not opened in fourteen days. If the how-to no longer fits on one page, you are not done deleting.
3. Forgetting mobile If the week cannot be read on a phone, buyers bounce after they pay, which is the worst bounce. Recovery this week: open the file on your phone. If you cannot read the week, simplify the view.
4. No example An empty grid is homework. People do not buy homework when they are already tired. Recovery this week: fill one week tonight. Fake names. Real statuses. That screenshot replaces the mockup.
5. Calling it an OS when it is a checklist You will attract buyers who want a company, and they will tell you your checklist is incomplete. Recovery this week: rewrite the title to the job. Calendar. Intake. Invoice tracker. Publish.
6. Fifty messy files in a zip That is your leftovers. Recovery this week: pick one file. Relist it alone. Archive the zip. If you already sold the zip, email buyers the one clean file and a refund offer on the rest.

7. A prompt that generates fluff Cute hooks, invented offers, billboard tone. Recovery this week: add three constraints. Run it on two businesses. Replace the prompt block. Email existing buyers the new prompt.
8. Listing photos of mockups with no real rows Recovery this week: screenshot the filled file, not a Dribbble shot. Crop if you must. Do not decorate.
9. Hiding the tool name Both Notion people and sheet people get annoyed. Recovery this week: put the tool in the title. Refund anyone who bought the wrong one this month, without a debate.
10. Locking the database so duplicate does nothing Classic Notion foot-gun. Recovery this week: test-buy from a second email. Fix permissions. Add two screenshots of the duplicate click. Message everyone who already paid.
11. Rebuilding in a new tool because a thread said it was nicer You will lose the scars. Recovery this week: go back to the file you actually use. Duplicate that. Delete the rebuild.
12. Turning \$19 into an unpaid custom rebuild A buyer wants columns. You spend Sunday. Recovery this week: send the package price or say no. Add one line to the how-to: “Custom columns are a separate package.”
13. Waiting for a course, a brand, or 200 files Recovery this week: ship the one file at \$19 on Thursday. Ten asks on Friday. The rest is stall dressed as standards.

Tools (the ones you already use)

Notion, Google Sheets, Canva, and the prompts that generate the filled version. Pick the tool the job already lives in. Do not buy a new stack for this path.

Exact stack - The file tool you already use: Notion or Google Sheets. Canva only if they will post or print the thing. - A checkout: Stripe payment link, Lemon Squeezy, Gumroad, or the Etsy listing if search is the point. One. Test-bought. - A how-to host: a page on your site, a Notion page, or a PDF. One page. Screenshots. - A model window you already pay for or use, to run the prompt. The prompt lives in the file. - Optional: Etsy as a search channel for obvious job names.

No membership platform. No course host. No CRM. No email sequence of eight.

Setup order 1. Duplicate the lived-in file. Strip. Fill. Prompt. How-to. 2. Checkout link. Product name matches the title. Price \$19. 3. Test-buy from a second email. 4. Listing page with filled screenshot first. 5. Ten asks. 6. Etsy only after your own checkout works, and only if people search the job by name.

What not to buy A Notion consultant. A template marketplace course. Icon packs. A second brain course. Analytics beyond what the checkout already shows. A paid community for your buyers. Lifetime-update infrastructure. You will not ship weekly updates. Do not sell them.

The \$0 path Notion free or the Google account you already have. Screenshots on your phone. A Stripe or Gumroad link on a free plan until money moves. How-to as a Notion page or a Google Doc. Asks through the mail and DMs you already have. Etsy can wait. Canva can wait. You do not need a domain on day 1.

Notion Good for calendars, intakes, and reviews with a few views. Bad when you nest five relations and call it simple. Duplicate must work. Permissions must not block the buyer.

Google Sheets Good for invoices, trackers, and anything that wants a sum. Put the prompt in row 1 as a note, or on a tab named HOW-TO so it cannot be missed. Filled example on the first tab.

Canva Good when the deliverable is a thing they will post or print: a carousel, a one-pager, a simple invoice. Still show a filled example. An empty brand kit is another aesthetic trap.

The prompt Lives in the file. Inputs in, filled table out. Tested on two businesses. This is not a separate course. It is a block at the top.

Leave empty aesthetic planners and fifty messy files on the shelf.

Checklist

Tick this before you raise the price. Twenty-five is the floor. If you skip the test-buy, none of the rest matters.

File - Tuesday problem in one line - Duplicated from a file you actually use - Personal data stripped - Fake names obviously fake - One filled week with real texture - Extra tabs deleted (nothing unused in fourteen days) - Prompt at the top: inputs, output format, constraints - Prompt run twice on different inputs - Second run did not invent an offer - One-page how-to with screenshots - Duplicate-click screenshot included - Readable on a phone - File named like a human - License in one paragraph: personal use, no resale as a template

Listing - Title: Filled [job] template + the prompt that rebuilds it in ten minutes - Tool named (Notion, Sheets, or Canva) - First image is the filled example, not the empty grid - Price \$19 (or \$12 if truly tiny) - What they get / do not get in five lines - Checkout tested from a second email - File actually arrived - Ten personal asks sent - Refund rule written in one sentence

After first buyer - First trip written into the how-to - Existing buyers sent the fix - No new tab added in response to a question that belongs in another file

Week 2 (optional) - Two more related files, same treatment
- They share a Tuesday - Bundle \$29 (or \$47 when each file is proven) - Single file still for sale - Bundle test-bought

FAQ

Short answers. Default recommendation at the end of each.

Do I need to be a Notion expert? No. You need a file you already use. If you cannot duplicate it without breaking, simplify until you can. Default: sell the simple file you live in, not the nested one you saw on YouTube.

Can I sell on Etsy only? Sell on your site first so you own the buyer. Etsy if the search terms are obvious. Title like a search, not like a brand poem. Default: your checkout Thursday, Etsy after the test-buy.

Should I include a video? Not for v1. One-page how-to. Screenshots. Default: no video until the same ticket appears twice.

What if my process lives in three tools? Sell the one that hurts on Tuesday. A three-tool setup is how ten minutes becomes an hour. Default: one tool in the title, one file in the download.

Is \$29 too cheap for three files? Not if they share a Tuesday and each has a filled example. \$47 is later, with proof. Default: \$29 bundle after the single has a stranger sale.

Can I use AI to build the template itself? You can draft columns. You still have to live in the file for a week. A model will give you twenty tabs. You need six. Default: AI for the prompt output, you for which columns survive.

What license do they get? Personal use, duplicate for their work, no resale of the template as a template. Default: one paragraph on the how-to, not a PDF of terms.

Someone wants custom columns. That is a service. Quote a package or say no. Default: send the productized-package price, do not negotiate columns in the \$19 thread.

The buyer says the prompt is generic. Fix it with required inputs and a constraint list. Update the file. Send them the new prompt. Default: constraints, then resend, then stop adding features.

When do I make a second product? After the first file has a stranger sale and a how-to that no longer gets the same question. Then a related file, then a \$29 bundle. Default: one file, then a related pair, then bundle. Vault never.

How long should the how-to be? One page. Five to eight screenshots. If it is longer, you overbuilt the file. Default: cut tabs until the how-to shrinks.

Do I need a brand name for the template? No. The job is the name. Default: Filled weekly content-calendar (Notion). Not “Luna OS.”

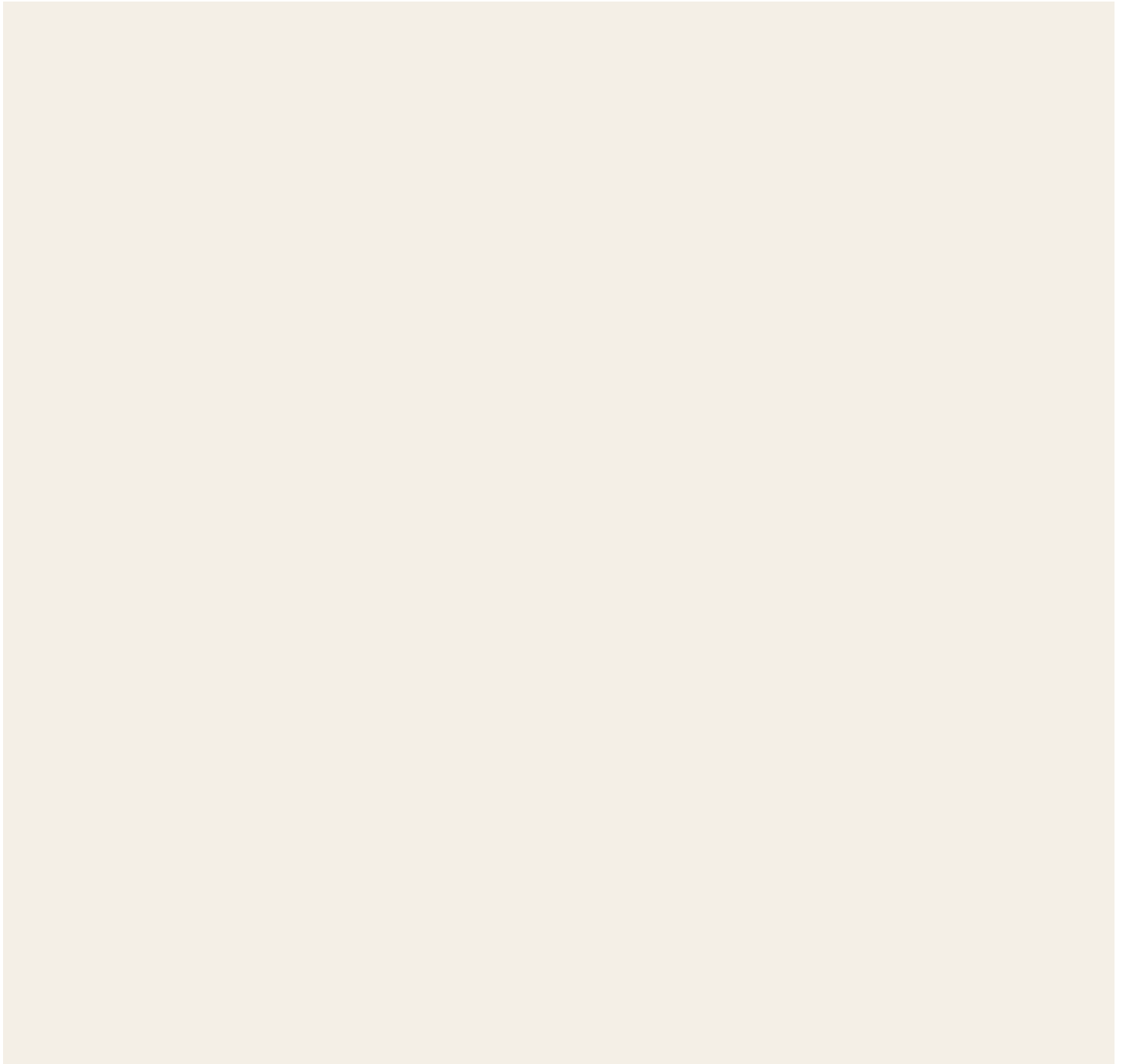
What if nobody of the ten buys? Ask two of them what was unclear. Usually the title is vague or the screenshot is empty. Default: rewrite title and first image this week, then ten new asks to people who actually have the job.

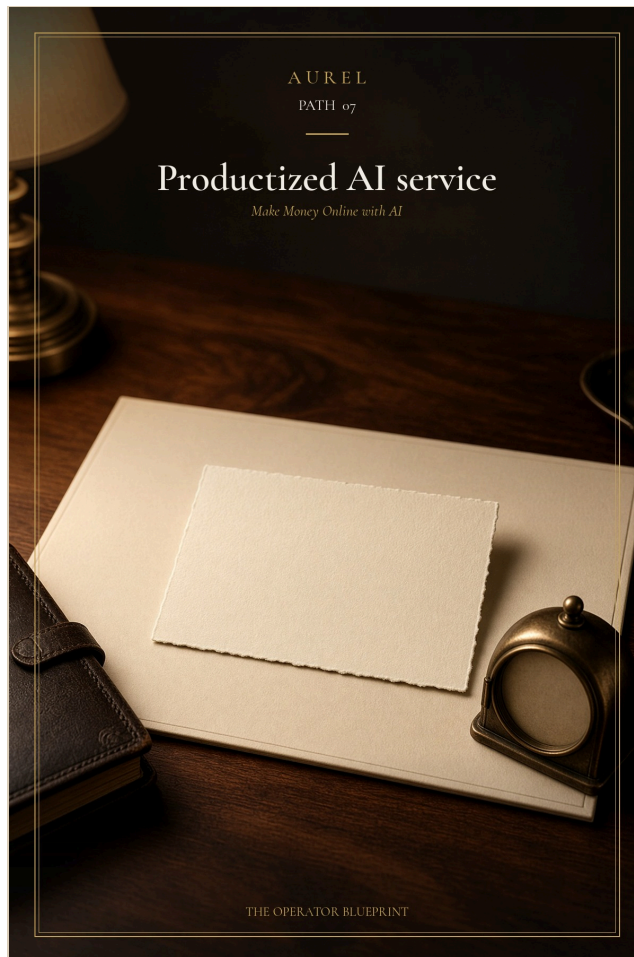
Can I sell this as a subscription? No. If they need you every month, that is a service or a membership. Default: one-time \$19 or \$29.

Should I wait until I have reviews? No. The filled screenshot is the review until you have a stranger. Default: ship Thursday.

What if Notion changes duplicate again? Update the two screenshots the week you bump into it. Default: fix on the same day you learn.

I am embarrassed by \$19. Cut the file until you believe the afternoon, or use it another week. Default: \$19, ten sales, then think.





PATH 07

Productized AI service

Do not sell hours. Sell a named package with a date on it.

37 minute read · 8,224 words

Who this is for

You can get a result for someone else in a known number of days, using AI for draft and you for quality.

Time to first

3–14 days with outreach

Tools

First sale

One paid package with a written scope. Deposit in, date on a calendar.

Cash window

\$300–\$1,500 first packages. \$600 is the honest middle.

Leave this alone

Calendly, Stripe invoice or deposit link, a one-page agreement, a kickoff form.

A menu of 12 services. Unlimited revisions. Custom everything. Free discovery hours.

Why this prints cash faster than a file

A service is slower to scale and faster to cash. If you need money this month, this path beats a playbook. You will still take notes. Those notes become the file you sell later.

Do not sell hours. Sell a named package with a date on it. Hours train people to haggle your Tuesday. A package trains them to say yes or no.

Definition, in one breath The package has a name, a deliverable, a timeline, a price, and a definition of done. “I’ll help with your AI” is not a package. “12 posts and one landing draft in 7 days for \$600” is. You can hold the second one in your hand. You can put it on a calendar. You can take a deposit against it.

You run AI internally. You edit until it sounds like them. They never see the raw model output. They get files in a folder they own, a 15-minute walkthrough, and one revision window. That is the product. The date is part of the product. Without a date it is hours with extra branding.

What this is not It is not a retainer with vague “AI support.” It is not a menu of twelve services. It is not unlimited revisions. It is not custom everything. Those are how a \$600 job becomes a \$600 relationship that eats your month.

It is not a free discovery call that becomes the job. It is not a Slack login with no wall. It is not posting for them unless that is in the named package. It is not strategy offsites, brand workshops, or “I’ll just take a look.” Looking is the job. Charge for it or send a cheaper file.

Why this works now Buyers already have a model window. What they do not have is a week of posts that match their offer, on a date, with someone else’s name on the quality. The window is free. The date and the edit pass are not. People who say “AI can do this” are right about the draft. They are wrong about the week. A package sells the week.

This path also works now because files are slow to cash and retainers are slow to start. A named 7-day package sits in the middle: money this month, a wall around the work, notes you can turn into a playbook later.

Three anti-patterns Anti-pattern one: hours. “\$75/hour, let’s see how it goes.” It goes until you resent them and they resent the clock. There is no done.

Anti-pattern two: the menu. Twelve services on a page, each one a conversation. You will explain all twelve and sell none. Narrow is how you keep the date.

Anti-pattern three: unlimited revisions until they love it. Happiness with no wall is a project without a date. One round, written, 48 hours after delivery. After that, a new package or a polite no.

The deal you keep You keep the date, or you tell them before it slips. You keep AI internal. You keep one package this week. You keep a deposit before you open a chat. You keep a folder they own. You keep one revision window. You do not keep a menu, a free hour, or a Slack that never ends. The deal is a named result by a named day for a named price.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you can get a result for someone else in a known number of days, using AI for draft and you for quality. You need one job you have finished more than twice. You need the spine to take a deposit before you open a chat.

Fits if People already ask you to “just look at this.” You can name what “done” looks like without a two-hour discovery call. You can keep a 7-day or 14-day date. You are willing to write a one-page agreement that fits on a phone. You have shipped the result for yourself — a week of posts, a landing draft, a set of emails — at least twice.

You can send ten asks to people who already trust you. You can say no to a sixth round of “quick tweaks.” You can estimate hours well enough to know the package fits in a week. You do not

need a portfolio site. You need one page, a deposit link, and a spine.

Skip if You freeze when someone asks what it costs. You want to be available for any AI problem. You cannot say no to extra rounds. You have never shipped the result for yourself. Do not sell a week of posts if you have never posted a week.

Skip it if you only want to sell files and never talk to a buyer. Use the playbook or template path. This path is faster cash because a human is in the loop. That human is you. Plan for that.

Skip it if you need a team, a brand film, or a 12-item menu before you will ask. Skip it if you will work before the deposit “just this once.” That once becomes the business.

The honest middle Most people who stall here can do the job and cannot name the package. They wait for a perfect niche, a website, a case study. The first seat is the case study. The one-pager is the website. The niche is the job you have already finished twice.

You will talk to humans. Not all day. Kickoff form, midpoint sample, 15-minute walkthrough, one revision. That is the conversation. If even that feels like too much people, this is the wrong path this month. Sell a file. Come back when you need cash faster.

Skills and time Skills: write a one-line offer. Run a kickoff form. Draft with a model. Edit until it sounds like them. Keep a date. Send an invoice. Ask for a referral in one sentence. Write a two-page SOP after job one.

Time: 3–14 days to first paid seat with outreach. Day 1 is the one-pager and the rails. Days 2–4 are ten asks. Days 5–7 (or 5–14) are the first job if someone says yes. The job itself is a week of your calendar, not a month of “when I have time.”

Budget: Calendly free tier, Stripe, a Google Doc for the agreement. Under \$50 to start if you already have a model window.

Two-minute self-test Answer these out loud.

What is the deliverable in one line, with a number on it?

How many days from deposit to folder?

What is the price you can say without coughing?

Have you shipped this result for yourself at least twice?

Who are ten people who already trust you, that you can message this week?

If you have the line, the days, the price, the two reps, and ten names, write the one-pager this morning. If you cannot name the deliverable, you do not have a package. Pick one job. Split the rest.

The offer, named in one sentence

Write this before you design a logo: “[Name of package]: [deliverable] in [days] for [price]. You get files, not a login to my brain. One revision window. Deposit holds the seat.”

Sam’s sentence is the model: 12 posts and one landing draft in 7 days for \$600. You can swap the deliverable. You cannot swap the specificity. If you cannot fit the offer on one line, you have two packages. Split them, then pick one.

Five example sentences that work 12 posts and one landing draft in 7 days for \$600. For a one-person shop that already knows what they sell.

8 client follow-up emails and a one-page FAQ in 5 days for \$450. For a tutor or coach who hates restating the same answers.

A 4-page onboarding kit (welcome, timeline, invoice, FAQ) in 7 days for \$800. For a tradesperson who still sends Word docs.

15 product descriptions and a category intro in 10 days for \$900. For a shop owner with a catalog and no time.

A 7-day content week plus a weekly review prompt in 7 days for \$500. For someone who bought a calendar template and still will not fill it.

The number is in the sentence. The days are in the sentence. The price is in the sentence. The buyer is in the next breath. If the buyer is “anyone using AI,” you will spend intake explaining

what you do.

What they get They get the named deliverable in a folder they own. They get one revision window with a clock. They get a 15-minute walkthrough. They get a date. They get your edit pass — the part a model will not do. They get a kickoff form so they do not have to perform their business on a call. They get files they keep if you disappear.

What they do not get They do not get a strategy offsite. They do not get a brand workshop. They do not get you managing their accounts. They do not get a second landing page. They do not get unlimited voice notes. They do not get posting unless it is in the sentence. They do not get a shared chat with the model. They do not get hours. Write the “not in” list on the one-pager. Buyers relax when they see the walls.

Packaging One package. One line. Deposit holds the seat. Half is clean: \$300 of \$600, or whatever your number is. The rest on delivery, before the revision window or after the walkthrough.

A first-seat discount is allowed once, if you need a named example: \$400 instead of \$600, with permission to describe the result. After that seat, full price. Do not run a sale. Do not add a second package this week because the first ten were quiet.

If they fail intake — no offer, no examples, no ability to post — send a cheaper file. Do not invent their business inside a \$600 week.

What ‘done’ looks like

Done is one paid package with a written scope. Not a maybe. Not a “we’ll figure it out on a call.” Money in, scope on a page, date on a calendar. Folder delivered. Walkthrough held. Revision window opened and closed. Referral asked. SOP written. That is a finished first seat.

Definition of done The one-pager exists. The rails work (Calendly, deposit link, agreement). Ten asks went out. A deposit arrived before you started. The deliverable is in a folder they own. They never saw raw model output. You kept the date, or you told them before it slipped. You asked for a referral the day they were happy. You wrote what you actually did so job two is faster.

The fairness test Would you buy this package with your own money if you had their Tuesday problem? If you would not, the deliverable is vague or the date is a wish. Fair also means the “not in” list was on the page before they paid. Fair means a refund of unused work if they are a bad fit, not extra scope to “make it right” while you are angry. Fair means they can open the files without you after the walkthrough.

Technical done - One-pager: who, in, out, days, price, deposit, revision clock, what they must provide - Kickoff form sent after deposit - AI run internally; edited; midpoint sample on the stated day - Folder they own (Drive, Notion, zip) - 15-minute walkthrough, not a second project - One revision window, dated - Balance collected - SOP of what you asked, which prompts you used, where you edited, how long it took

Not-done-yet list You are not done if you are still “hopping on a call to see.” You are not done if there is no deposit. You are not done if the deliverable is “help with AI.” You are not done if they have a Slack login and no date. You are not done if you skipped the SOP. You are not done if you discounted seat two because seat one felt awkward. You are not done if you have two packages on the page. Ship one. Then write the SOP. Then book the next seat at full price.

Price, deposit, and the first-seat discount

First packages live at \$300–\$1,500. Under \$300 you will attract people who want a miracle and a friend. Over \$1,500 on job one, you will invent a process during a job that is too expensive to

fumble. Sam's \$600 for a 7-day content-and-landing package sits in the honest middle: real money, finishable week.

Ranges \$300–\$450 — first-seat discount, or a smaller package (emails, a one-pager, 8 posts). Not a habit.

\$600–\$800 — the default first full-price package. A week of work you can keep. 7 to 10 days.

\$1,000–\$1,500 — after the SOP is real and you are full, or a clearly larger deliverable (onboarding kit, catalog copy). Still one package, still a date.

Above \$1,500 on this path in month one is how you freeze and over-promise. Raise later, inside the same range, or add a week of wait.

When to raise Raise after three jobs delivered on time at the current price, with an SOP that made job three faster than job one. Raise \$200 at a time, or add wait instead of money if you are full and scared of the new number. Do not raise because a thread said \$3,000 is the floor. Do not lower because a stranger flinched. Send the cheaper file to the flinch.

Refunds in one sentence If they are a bad fit after deposit and you have not started, refund in full. If you have started, keep the deposit, refund unused work, stop. Do not work angry to “make it right” with extra scope.

What you never charge You never charge hours on this path. You never charge a “discovery fee” that is actually the job unpaid. You never add unlimited Slack as a \$50 line item — that is hours with extra typing. You never take the whole \$600 after delivery with no deposit. You never discount seat two because you felt awkward on the walkthrough.

Worked dollars Sam: first seat \$450 (case-study discount), deposit \$225, balance \$225, 7 days, tutoring practice. Next seat \$600, referral from the tutor, week three. Two jobs in three weeks: \$1,050 before fees. Hours actually spent: about 9

on job one, about 6 on job two after the SOP. That is \$117/hour on job one if you insist on dividing, but you are not selling hours. You are selling a week of posts and a page. The SOP is what makes job two pay better without raising the price yet.

Your first \$600 at full price, kept on date, with a referral ask, is the milestone. Do not despise \$600. It is rent-adjacent. It is also inventory for the playbook.

The first 72 hours

You do not need a portfolio site. You need one page, ten asks, and a way to take money.

Day 1 morning: write the package on one page Who it is for. What is in. What is not. Timeline. Price. What they must provide (voice notes, old posts, offer, deadline, three examples they like, words they refuse). How many revisions (one is enough). Deposit. Where the files will live. Put your name and a start date like “next Monday if the deposit is in by Friday.”

Write it so a tired person can forward it. If you add a second package this morning, you will explain both and sell neither.

Day 1 afternoon: the rails Calendly for a 15-minute kickoff or walkthrough — not a free hour. Stripe invoice or deposit link. A one-page agreement that repeats the package page in slightly drier words. A kickoff form: assets, voice, deadline, examples they like, words they hate, the offer the posts must serve. Test the payment link with a dollar if you need to know it works.

Put the package link in the Calendly invite. If they need longer than 15 minutes, they need a different product.

Day 1 night: name the ten Write ten names. People who have asked you for help, hired you adjacent, or complained about the exact job. Not a cold list. Not a group you lurk in. Ten is an evening of messages, not a campaign. If you cannot name ten, name six and ship anyway. Do not spend the night designing a logo.

Day 2: ten asks Send the package to those ten. Personal notes. One discounted first seat only if you truly need a case, and say so out loud: “First seat \$400, I can use the result as a named example (you can say no to the name).”

When they say yes, take the deposit before you open a chat window.

Then intake. Then you start — on the date in the one-pager, not before.

Do not post a menu. Do not add a second package because the first ten were quiet by evening.

Day 3: either start, or keep the page If a deposit landed, send the form, book the 15-minute kickoff, start the clock from the deposit, not from the fifth follow-up. If nobody said yes, you still have a page. Send two more asks if you have names. Do not rebuild the offer. Three to fourteen days with outreach is the window, not three hours of hoping.

If you already know you will need the first-seat discount to get a yes this week, send that version on Day 2, once, to the person most likely to let you describe the result. Do not discount all ten.

The path, step by step

Fourteen steps. One package all the way through. If you have two, you have none.

Step 1. One package Name, deliverable, days, price. Write it so a tired person can forward it. Put the “not in” list under it. If you add a second package this week, you will explain both and sell neither. Sam’s line is enough: 12 posts and one landing draft in 7 days for \$600.

Step 2. Intake: problem, budget, ability to implement If they have no problem you can name, no budget for \$300–\$1,500, or no ability to post what you make, stop. Send them the cheaper file instead. A buyer who cannot implement will blame the posts. The form is how you learn this before you start, not during the revision round.

Step 3. Deposit, then chat Invoice or deposit link first. Kickoff after. Working before the deposit is how “quick questions” become the whole job, unpaid. Half is clean. The date starts when the deposit clears, not when they said “sounds good” in a DM.

Step 4. Kickoff form, not a 45-minute call Assets, voice, deadline, examples they like, words they refuse, the offer the posts must serve. A form beats a call you have to transcribe. The 15-minute Calendly is for questions the form did not catch, then you hang up. If they need a workshop, they need a different product.

Step 5. You run AI internally Draft in a tool they do not sit in. Edit until it sounds like them, not like a model. They never see the raw output. If a line is wrong, it is your line. Cut hype. Check facts they gave you. Match their examples. A landing draft that could belong to any business is not done.

Step 6. Midpoint check, short A screenshot or three sample posts on day 3, not a new scope. If they want a different product, that is a different package after this one. The midpoint is how you avoid using the revision round to change the offer. If they go silent, you still keep the date. Note the silence. Do not add work.

Step 7. Delivery in a folder they own Google Drive, Notion, a zip — they keep it if you disappear. No hostage login. Name the files like a human. Include a one-page “post this first” note so the walkthrough is not a treasure hunt.

Step 8. A 15-minute walkthrough Show them where things live and what to post first. Then stop. The walkthrough is not a workshop. Calendly with a hard wall. If they want another 45 minutes, that is a new package or a no.

Step 9. One revision window Written dates. “One round, 48 hours after delivery.” After that, a new package or a polite no. If you need three rounds to make it good, your midpoint check is missing or you skipped the form. Do not buy peace with extra rounds. You will teach the next buyer that the wall is fake.

Step 10. Ask for the referral while they are happy The day of the walkthrough, not a month later. One sentence. One ask. “If someone you know needs this package this month, send them the page. I have one seat left in [week].”

Step 11. Write the SOP What you asked for, which prompts you used, where you edited, how long it actually took. The second job should be faster. If it is not, you did not write the SOP. You remembered vibes. Two pages. Same week. Before you book seat two.

Step 12. Full price, no discount The first seat may have been cheaper. This one is not, unless you have a reason you can say out loud. Book the next seat before you invent package two.

Step 13. Notes toward a file Every job throws off a playbook chapter, a template, or a letter issue. Capture the prompt stack and the folder structure. Do not pause the package to write the book unless you are full. The package prints cash this month. The file can wait.

Step 14. When you are full, raise or wait Do not hire a stranger to talk to your buyers on job four. Raise inside \$300–\$1,500 or add a week of wait. A menu of twelve is still the wrong answer when you are busy. Busy is the point.

Worked example: Sam’s \$600 week

Sam writes for small service businesses on the side of a day job. People kept asking for “help with AI content.” That sentence made Sam tired. Sam named a package instead: 12 posts and one landing draft in 7 days for \$600. Files in a folder. One revision. Deposit holds the seat.

This is a three-week story with dollars, a shipped folder, a mistake, a recovery, and a stranger sale.

The one-pager (Monday) Who: a one-person shop that already knows what they sell and needs a week of posts plus a page that does not sound like a brochure. In: 12 posts (mix of short updates and two longer notes), one landing draft (headline, sections, FAQ, closing ask), one revision, 15-minute walkthrough. Not in: posting for them, a logo, a second offer, strategy calls. They must provide: offer, three examples they like, words they hate, any photos they already have, a deadline if a launch is real. Timeline: 7 days from deposit. Price: \$600. Deposit: \$300. Revision: one round, 48 hours after delivery.

Rails the same day: Calendly 15 minutes, Stripe deposit link, one-page agreement, kickoff form. Sam tested the link with \$1.

The first seat (Tuesday–next Tuesday) Sam sent the page to ten people who had asked for help. One owner of a tutoring practice said yes at \$450 as the case-study seat, with permission to describe the result without student names. Deposit \$225 first. Kickoff form the same day.

The mistake Sam drafted in a private window, then pasted three “raw-ish” samples into the day-3 midpoint email to save time. The owner replied: “This sounds like a press release. I would never say guaranteed results.” Sam had skipped the edit pass on the samples. The owner was right. That is how quality becomes a rumor.

The recovery Sam rewrote the three samples against the owner’s examples before the next morning. Cut “guaranteed.” Matched the short sentences the owner already used on their site. Sent a note: “You were right. Here are the same three, edited. I will not send you raw drafts again.” The owner stayed. Sam put “they never see raw output” at the top of the SOP in bold, because the mistake was the process, not the model.

Day 7: folder in Drive, 15-minute walkthrough, invoice for the \$225 balance. One revision on two posts (a promise that was still too strong, plus a time-of-day the owner does not run sessions).

Done. Shipped artifact: 12 posts, one landing draft, a “post this first” note, in a folder the tutor owns.

After, and the stranger Sam wrote a two-page SOP: form questions, the prompt stack, the edit pass, the folder structure. Hours actually spent: about 9, including the redo of the samples. Next job was \$600, no discount — a referral from the tutor, a bookkeeper Sam had never met. That is the first stranger sale. Deposit \$300, same 7-day clock, same folder shape. Job two took about 6 hours because the SOP existed.

Two jobs in three weeks: \$1,050 before fees. Sam still takes notes for a playbook. The package prints cash this month. The file can wait. Sam did not add a second package. Sam did not hire anyone. Sam asked for the referral on the walkthrough day, which is why the bookkeeper showed up.

Copy you can paste

Say the package. Then stop talking.

Post I have one seat this week: 12 posts and one landing draft in 7 days for \$600. Files in a folder you own. One revision. Deposit holds the seat. Not a strategy call. If you already know what you sell and you need a week that matches, here is the page: [link].

DM, to ten people who already trust you I have one seat this week for [package] at [price]. Deposit holds it. Here is what is in, what is not, and the date: [link]. If it is not useful, ignore this.

Page hero 12 posts and one landing draft in 7 days. You get files, not a login to my brain. \$600. Deposit holds the seat.

Checkout / deposit line \$300 holds the seat. The other \$300 is due on delivery, before the revision window. Kickoff form follows when the deposit clears. I start on the date in the one-pager, not before.

Email 1 — the ask Subject: one seat this week

You have asked me about [job] more than once. I put it in a package so neither of us lives in a chat window: [deliverable] in [days] for [price]. What is in, what is not, and the date are on this page: [link]. Deposit holds it. If it is not useful, no need to reply.

Email 2 — after they say yes Subject: deposit link, then we start

Sending the deposit link now. Kickoff form follows when it clears. I start on the date in the one-pager, not before. One revision, 48 hours after delivery. Folder will live in [Drive / Notion], and you will own it.

Email 3 — midpoint Subject: three samples, day 3

Here are three posts from this week's set. If a promise is too strong or a word is wrong, say so here. This is not a new scope. The rest of the folder still lands on [date].

Refund note You asked to stop. If I have not started, the deposit comes back in full. If I have started, I keep the deposit, refund unused work, and send whatever is already in the folder. I will not add scope to “make it right.” You should see the refund in 5–10 days depending on the processor.

Referral ask (walkthrough day) If someone you know needs [package] this month, send them the page. I have [one] seat left in [week]. I will treat them like I treated you.

First-seat version I am taking one discounted first seat at [lower price] so I can use the result as a named example (you can say no to the name). Same scope, same week. After this, it is [full price].

What not to write “Let’s hop on a quick call and I’ll see how I can help.” That call becomes the job. “Unlimited revisions until you love it.” That is a hostage situation with extra steps. “Custom AI solutions for businesses.” That is a menu with no date.

Week-by-week

This is a 3–14 day path if you already know the job. Treat week one as a job, not a brand launch. Four weeks. Weeks 1–2 are daily.

Week 1, day by day Monday: write the one-pager. Price, deposit, in/out, revision rule, what they must provide. Calendly, Stripe, agreement, kickoff form. Test the link.

Tuesday: list ten names. Send the first five asks. Personal notes. No public menu.

Wednesday: send the other five. One discounted first-seat note only if you truly need a case.

Thursday: if a yes arrived, deposit first, then form, then start the clock. If not, do not rebuild the offer. Use the day to fill the SOP skeleton: form questions, folder shape.

Friday: either you are in a job (draft internally, no raw output) or you send two more asks if you have names. Do not add package two.

Saturday: if in a job, midpoint samples if it is day 3. If not, rest. Do not design a logo.

Sunday: if in a job, edit pass. If not, reread the one-pager cold. Is the deliverable a number. Is the “not in” list visible. Fix those two lines only.

Week 2, day by day Monday: deliver if the date is this day, or keep drafting. Write minutes spent so the SOP is not a guess.

Tuesday: walkthrough 15 minutes. Balance invoice. Revision window starts.

Wednesday: referral ask if you forgot it on the walkthrough. SOP first draft, two pages.

Thursday: revision round if they used it. Close the window if they did not.

Friday: next seat at full price, or ten new asks if nobody is in the pipe. Do not discount because seat one felt awkward.

Saturday: notes toward a file. Prompt stack, folder structure. Do not pause to write a playbook.

Sunday: off, or one public line that names the package without a case you do not have permission for.

Week 3 Same package. Same days. Better SOP. Full price. If you want a second product, make it the playbook from the notes, not a second service that splits your calendar. If you have zero deposits after fourteen days of asks, the page is vague or you asked strangers. Rewrite the one line. Ask people who have the Tuesday problem.

Week 4 Count jobs, days-to-deposit, hours vs SOP, revision use, referrals asked vs received. If job two was not faster, the SOP is a diary. Rewrite it from the minutes. If you are full, raise \$200 or add a week of wait. Do not hire. Do not add a menu.

The quality bar

They should be able to use the files the day you hand them over, without you in the room after the walkthrough. That is the bar.

Below the bar Raw model output in the folder. A landing draft that could belong to any business. Date missed in silence. Three “quick” extra rounds. Files in a login they cannot export. No “not in” list. Kickoff was a 45-minute ramble you did not record. You posted for them as a surprise freebie and now it has no done.

Above the bar Sounds like them. Facts they gave you are checked. Date kept, or they heard before it slipped. One revision, used or expired. Folder they own. 15-minute walkthrough, then stop. Referral asked the same day. SOP written the same week. They never saw the raw window.

Test 1 — the raw-output test If you would be embarrassed to put your name under a paragraph, it does not ship. Models draft. You cut hype, check facts they gave you, and match their examples. Read it out loud. If it sounds like a press release, it is not done.

Test 2 — the date test 7 days means 7 days from deposit, not from the fifth follow-up email. If you cannot keep the date, the package is too big. Cut posts, not honesty. Tell them before the date if you must cut, with their written OK.

Test 3 — the revision test One round. Written. If you need three rounds to make it good, your midpoint check is missing or you skipped the form. Do not buy peace with extra rounds. You will teach the next buyer that the wall is fake.

Test 4 — the folder test They own it. A login you control is not delivery. If the host dies, they still have the words. Export a zip at the end even if they live in Drive.

Test 5 — the stranger-forward test Would they forward the one-pager to a peer without writing a paragraph of explanation? If not, the offer is not a package yet. Fix the sentence, not the logo.

What to count

Count jobs, not vibes.

Week 1 - One-pager live, rails tested (yes/no) - Ten asks sent - Deposits in - Days from first ask to first deposit - Hours spent on rails (should be under 6)

Target: page + ten asks. A deposit in week 1 is a win. Zero deposits is normal if asks went out Wednesday. Rebuild is not a metric.

Day 30 - Paid packages with written scope. First one is the milestone. - Days from ask to deposit. If this is over two weeks, your page is vague or you asked strangers. - Hours you actually spent versus the SOP. If job two is not faster, the SOP is a diary. - Revision use. If every job uses the round to change the offer, intake is broken. - Referrals asked vs referrals received. Asking once, on the happy day, is the whole system.

A good first month is one or two \$600-class jobs delivered on time, not twelve half-sold conversations. Cash: \$450–\$1,200 before fees is a real start.

Day 90 - Three or more of the same package, on date - SOP that a future you could follow - Full price, no discount - At least one referral seat - A decision: raise inside \$300–\$1,500, add wait, or spin a file from the notes - Still one package on the page

Day 90 cash for a serious operator: a few thousand from the same package, lumpy. If you are at zero jobs, you asked the wrong ten or the one-pager has no number on the deliverable.

Ignore these for now A public “AI agency” identity. Hour charts. A second service line. Testimonials you wrote for them. Follower counts. Proposal software you have not earned. Count cash collected and dates kept.

One-line spreadsheet Date asked | date deposit | price | hours | on-date (y/n) | revision used (y/n) | referral asked (y/n) | notes

One row per job. Five minutes after delivery. If job two hours are not down, rewrite the SOP this week.

Objections you will hear

These are the lines. The reply is what you actually send.

“Can we hop on a call first?” You can do a 15-minute Calendly after they have the one-pager, or you can send the cheaper file. A free hour is the job. Reply: “The one-pager is the call. If it still fits, deposit holds the seat and we do 15 minutes on kickoff. If you need a longer look, I can send the \$19 file instead.”

“I need a custom thing.” Custom everything is on the leave-alone list. Reply: “If your job is 80 percent this package, we run this package. If it is 20 percent, I should say no this week rather than invent a second product on your dime.”

“\$600 is a lot for something AI can do.” AI can draft. They are paying for 12 posts and a landing draft that match their offer, in 7 days, with your name on the quality. Reply: “If you want the window, you already have it. This is the week of files, edited, on a date. If that is not useful, ignore the page.”

“Can you just do hours?” No. Hours have no done. Reply: “I do not sell hours. The package is [line]. If you need something smaller, here is the file.”

“Unlimited revisions until I’m happy.” One is enough. Reply: “One round, 48 hours after delivery, written on the page. Happiness with no wall is a project without a date. I mean the wall.”

“I do not have examples or an offer yet.” Then they cannot implement. Reply: “I cannot invent your business inside a \$600 week. If you want a cheaper diagnostic or a playbook, I will send that. This package needs an offer you already have.”

“Can you post for us too?” That is a different dated package, or a no. Reply: “Posting is not in this week. If you want a posting package later, we can date it after this folder lands. I will not slide it in for free.”

“Can I pay after I see the work?” No. Reply: “Deposit holds the seat. I do not start before it clears. The rest is due on delivery. That is the whole money conversation.”

“We might need a second landing page.” Reply: “Not in this package. After we close this one, I can quote a second dated package. I will not add it mid-week.”

What this path feeds

This path is the cash pipe. The notes are the product pipe.

Upstream — what you need before this path You need a job you have finished twice. You need ten people who already trust you. You need a spine for a deposit. You do not need a team, a brand, or a menu. If you have never shipped the result, ship it for yourself this week, then sell the package next week. If you have no one to ask, this path is slow. Use the letter or the front door to find ten, or start with people who already asked you to “just look.”

Downstream — where jobs go next Every job becomes a playbook chapter, a template, or a letter issue. Sam’s 12-post week is a filled calendar someone else might buy as a \$19 file later. Referrals fill the next seats. People who cannot afford \$600 still need a door: send the cheaper file instead of shrinking the package.

Affiliate can sit in the walkthrough: “Here is the tool I draft in; you do not have to buy it.”

Disclosure if you link it. The cut is extra. The package is the engine.

When the SOP is real and you are full, raise the price inside \$300–\$1,500 or add a week of wait, before you hire a stranger to talk to your buyers.

What it needs, and what it does not It needs a named package, a deposit link, a spine. It does not need a menu of 12 services. It does not need a team in month one. It does not need you to pause cash to write the book. Keep the package. Let the file grow in the notes.

Mistakes that eat the week

Each one has a recovery you can do this week.

1. Working before the deposit Then you are a friend with a skill, and friends do not get a date on a calendar. Recovery this week: send the deposit link before the next reply. Do not open the chat until it clears.
2. Unlimited revisions Each round teaches them the first delivery was a suggestion. Recovery this week: write the window on the one-pager and in the next email. Mean it on the current job if the window has not been stated. If you already promised unlimited, finish this job, never write that sentence again.
3. A free call that becomes the job Calendly is for kickoff and walkthrough, 15 minutes, after money or after the one-pager. Recovery this week: cancel the standing “discovery” slot. Put the package link in the invite. Charge or send a file.
4. Delivering unedited AI text They can smell it. Your name is on it. Recovery this week: edit every paragraph still in draft. Add “they never see raw output” to the SOP. If a midpoint already went out raw, rewrite it today like Sam did.
5. A menu of 12 services Narrow is how you keep the date. Recovery this week: delete eleven. One package on the page. Tell anyone in conversation that this is the only seat you are selling this month.
6. Custom everything Starting two packages because you were afraid the first one was too narrow. Recovery this week: pick the one you can keep in 7 days. Park the other.
7. Disappearing into Slack so the job never ends Recovery this week: move the thread to the folder and the form. One revision window. Mute the channel after walkthrough.

8. Hosting files in a place they cannot export Recovery this week: zip the folder. Send the zip. Change the SOP so delivery always includes an export.
9. Discounting seat two because seat one felt awkward Recovery this week: next ask is full price. Say it out loud in the message. Awkward is not a reason.
10. Skipping the referral ask Recovery this week: send the one-sentence ask to anyone who already got a walkthrough. Today.
11. Skipping the SOP Then the path is a string of tired one-offs. Recovery this week: two pages. Form questions, prompt stack, edit pass, folder shape, minutes. Before you book the next seat.
12. Inventing their business because they had no offer Recovery this week: stop. Send a cheaper diagnostic or refund unused work. Do not finish a \$600 week that they cannot implement.
13. Hiring on job one Quality becomes a rumor. Recovery this week: you do the edit pass. Do not hire until the SOP is real and you are full at full price.

Tools (keep them boring)

Calendly, Stripe invoice or deposit link, a one-page agreement. That is enough to take money and a date.

Exact stack - One-pager: Google Doc, Notion, or a site page. Ugly is allowed. - Calendly, 15 minutes, kickoff or walkthrough. - Stripe invoice or deposit link. Tested with a dollar. - Kickoff form: Tally, Google Form, or the same Doc. - Folder they own: Google Drive or a zip. - Model window you already use, internal only. - A notes doc for the SOP.

No agency CRM. No proposal software. No project-management suite for one package. No shared chat with the client as the deliverable.

Setup order 1. Write the one-pager (in, out, days, price, deposit, revision). 2. Stripe deposit link. Test it. 3. Agreement that repeats the one-pager. 4. Kickoff form. 5. Calendly, package link in the invite. 6. Ten asks. 7. After job one, SOP in the notes doc.

What not to buy An agency operating system. A white-label fulfillment team. A \$99/month CRM. A contracts platform with e-sign theater for a one-page agreement. A second model subscription “for clients.” They do not sit in your window.

The \$0 path Google Doc for the page and the agreement. Stripe or even a payment link you already have. Calendar app with a 15-minute hold if Calendly feels like shopping. Google Form. Drive folder. The model you already pay for. Asks through mail you already have. You do not need a site on day 1. You need a link that takes \$300.

Calendly 15-minute kickoff or walkthrough. Not a 60-minute “discovery.” If they need longer, they need a different product.

Stripe Deposit before work. Balance before or at delivery. Do not take payment in a chat app that will not help you when a charge is disputed.

One-page agreement Repeats the one-pager: in, out, date, price, deposit, revision window, where files live, what they must provide. You are not playing lawyer. You are writing the same sentences in a form they can screenshot.

AI Internal. Draft only. You edit. No shared chat with the client as the deliverable.

Leave retainers, agency CRMs, and a stack of proposal software on the shelf until you have delivered the same package three times.

Checklist

Tick this before you start job two.

Package page - One package, one line: deliverable, days, price - Who it is for - What is in - What is not - What they must provide - One revision, with a clock - Deposit amount and what it holds - Definition of done (folder they own, walkthrough) - Start rule (clock starts at deposit)

Rails - Calendly 15 minutes - Stripe invoice or deposit link, tested - One-page agreement - Kickoff form - Folder template named like a human

First job - Ten asks to people who already trust you - One discounted first seat only if you need a case - Deposit before chat - AI internally; they never see raw output - Midpoint sample on the stated day - Delivery on the date - Walkthrough 15 minutes, then stop - Referral ask while they are happy - SOP written the same week - Next seat at full price

Quality - Sounds like them, not like a press release - Facts they gave you are checked - Zip or export they keep if you disappear - “Not in” list was on the page before they paid

FAQ

Short answers. Default at the end of each.

Can I sell two packages if they are related? Not in week one. If you have two, you have none. Deliver the same one three times. Then, maybe, a smaller file for people who fail intake. Default: one package on the page.

What if they want me to post for them too? That is a different dated package, or a no. Do not slide posting into the \$600 week for free. It has no done. Default: say no this week, quote later if you want that product.

Do I need Calendly if we already chat? Yes, or something with a hard 15-minute wall. Chat has no wall. Default: Calendly for kickoff and walkthrough only.

How do I handle a bad fit after they pay? Refund the unused work, keep the deposit if you already started and the agreement says so, and stop. Do not work angry to “make it right” with extra scope. Default: stop, refund unused, no extra rounds.

Can I use their job as a case? Ask on the form. Default to fake names. Sam’s tutor said yes to a nameless description. That is enough. Default: names off unless they tick yes.

What if I miss the 7-day date? Tell them before the date. Cut scope with their written OK, or finish and own it. Silent delay is how you pay in reputation. Default: tell them 24 hours before, in writing.

Is \$300 too low? It can be a first-seat price. As a habit it attracts people who want a friend. Default: \$600–\$800 as soon as the SOP is real.

Should I hire someone to draft? Not until you have an SOP and you are full at full price. Hiring on job one is how quality becomes a rumor. Default: you edit every line in month one.

They want unlimited Slack access. No. Folder, form, one revision window, 15-minute walkthrough. Access without a date is hours with extra typing. Default: no Slack login.

When do I turn this into a playbook? When you have notes from two jobs. The package still sells. The file is extra cash from people who will never hire you. Default: do not pause the package to write the book unless you are full.

What if nobody of the ten says yes? The page is vague or you asked strangers. Rewrite the one line so it has a number, days, and a price. Ask people who have the Tuesday problem. Default: do not add package two. Rewrite, then ten new names.

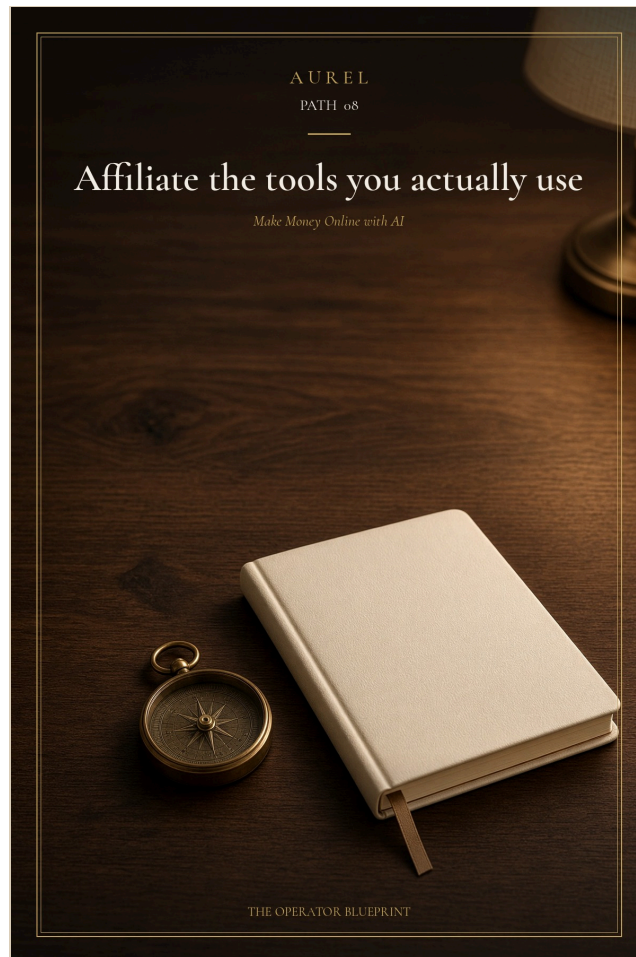
Can I take 100 percent on delivery, no deposit? No. Deposit holds the seat. No deposit is how “sounds good” never starts, or starts unpaid. Default: half up front.

Do I need a website? No. A Doc that forwards is enough. Default: one page, then a site later if you want, not as a blocker.

What license do they get on the files? They own the words you wrote for them. You own the process and the SOP. They cannot resell the package as a package. Default: one paragraph on the agreement.

Can I use their brand voice forever as a sample? Only with permission. Default: fake the names, keep the texture, ask on the form.

Should I add a retainer after the week? Not as a vague “AI support” monthly. If they want another week, sell the same package again with a new date. Default: same package, new date, not a retainer.



PATH 08

Affiliate the tools you actually use

The review must stand if the link is removed. That is the whole ethic, and the whole conversion trick.

52 minute read · 11,412 words

Who this is for

You already recommend models, hosts, editors, or shops. You can write why, not just drop a URL.

Time to first

14–45 days (cookie + trust lag)

Tools

First sale

One commission from a review a real person used.

Cash window

Varies; treat as a sidecar, not the engine

Leave this alone

Official partner programs, a simple page or newsletter, honest disclosure.

Twenty links in a thread. Tools you have never opened.

How this pays without rotting your name

Affiliate is monetization, not a traffic plan. If nobody reads you, the link does nothing. Short-form and the weekly letter bring the people. This path takes a cut when they buy a tool you would keep using if the commission died.

The review must stand if the link is removed. That is the whole ethic, and the whole conversion trick. Write as if tomorrow a lawyer strips every URL. What remains should still help a tired person decide. If what remains is empty cheer, you wrote an ad.

Definition, in one breath You publish one honest page about one tool in your actual stack. The page names who it is for, setup time, what you tried, what failed, and who should not buy. Disclosure at the top. Link below the reasoning. A date on the page. If they purchase through that link, you may earn a cut. The sentences do not change if the cut vanishes.

You are attaching a cookie to a recommendation you were already making in DMs and in the Tuesday letter. The recommendation came first. The program came second.

What this is not It is not a coupon blog. It is not twenty links in a thread. It is not a tool you opened once on a free weekend. It is not rent money. It is a sidecar on work you already do. Treat commissions as extra. If the engine is affiliate, your name will follow the payout.

It is not hiding the relationship under a hero button. It is not a fake screenshot. It is not a tool you cancelled in March and still rank in June.

Why this works now Buyers already have a model window and a pile of “best of” tabs they do not trust. What they do not have is one page from a person they

already read, dated, with a scar on it, that tells them who should skip the tool. That page outsells a glowing list because it is usable even if they never click.

People in your inbox already ask which model. Every time you answer in a DM, the answer dies in the thread. Write it once. Date it. Disclose it. Put the link under the skip rule. People who need cash on Friday should run a package. People who can wait 14–45 days can let an honest page sit.

How a cookie actually pays you A click is not money. They click your link. The program drops a cookie, or a click ID, that lives 7, 30, or 90 days. If they buy while it is alive, you may get credit. Then the commission sits in pending through the refund window. Then it clears. Then, on a payout calendar, and only if you have crossed a threshold, cash moves. A 30-day cookie plus a 30-day hold plus net-30 is how 14 to 45 days becomes two months.

Most software programs are last-click. If they read you Monday, click a Google ad Thursday, and buy Friday, the ad often gets the sale. You cannot fix that with five tracking scripts. Write the decision. Misses happen. The review still did the job. You pick the tool you still pay for, not the longest timer. The pricing section is the full chain.

Three anti-patterns Anti-pattern one: the farm. Twenty tools, twenty links, zero scars. You will spend the month joining programs and none of the month using the products. One honest page per tool you love. A second tool waits until someone who is not you has used the first page.

Anti-pattern two: the hidden cut. Disclosure in gray eight-point under a hero button. Link above the reasoning. Quiet honesty converts better than a clever fold. If you are ashamed of the relationship, do not join the program.

Anti-pattern three: the engine swap. You pause the letter and the package because a dashboard showed three pending cookies. Pending is not cash.

The deal you keep You keep the stripped-link test. You keep the disclosure at the top. You keep the link below the skip rule. You keep a date on the page. You keep official programs only. You keep tools you still pay for with your

own money. You keep one review until it has been used. You do not keep a farm, a hidden cut, a fake screenshot, or a spending plan built on a maybe.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you already recommend models, hosts, editors, or shops, and you can write why, not just drop a URL. You need a real stack. You need a place to publish one page or one issue. You need the patience for cookie lag.

Fits if You pay for a tool with your own money. You have told a friend why you kept it. You can name something that broke. You will put a disclosure at the top. You already have, or are building, a letter or a simple page where a review can live for a year. You can wait 14–45 days. You will not quit the package because a cookie might convert.

Skip if You do not use anything you would recommend with the link ripped out. You want cash this week — cookies take 14–45 days, and some programs pay later than that. You like roundups of tools you have never opened. You will not update a page when the price changes.

Skip it if you have no readers yet. Start the letter or the front door first. Affiliate does not create attention. It rides it.

Skip it if you freeze at writing “I may earn a cut” in the first screen. Skip it if you need this to be the engine. Do not schedule rent on a surprise.

The honest middle Most people who stall here already recommend a tool in DMs and think a page is a media company. It is not. One page. One tool. One disclosure. One date. The first review is the one you have been typing into chat for six months.

You need two official accounts for tools you already pay for, one written page, and six people who asked last month. Week two will feel quiet. Quiet is normal. Keep sending the letter. Check the partner dashboard once a week, not once an hour.

Skills and time Skills: write a decision, not a brochure. Name a failure without inventing one. Put a disclosure where a tired person will see it. Read the partner rules. Count cash after it clears.

Time: hours 1–8 on programs and rules. Hours 9–24 on the review. Hours 25–72 on publish and six notes. Then 14–45 days of lag. Budget: \$0 extra if you already pay for the tool and join the official program.

Two-minute self-test Answer these out loud.

Which tool do you still pay for with your own money, and would you keep paying if the program vanished tomorrow?

Can you name, in one sentence, who should not buy it?

What actually failed the first week you used it?

What would you use instead if this tool disappeared tomorrow?

Where will the page live for a year — a letter, a simple page, or both?

Who are six people who asked you about this tool last month, that you can message once?

If you have the tool, the skip rule, the scar, the alternative, a place to publish, and six names, write the page this morning. If you cannot name a failure, use the tool another week. If you have no one to tell, this path is a forest. Build the letter first.

The buyer on the other side A tired person who already has three best-of tabs open and trusts none of them. They asked you which tool because they have a Tuesday job, not because they collect software. They will judge you on whether the skip rule is real, whether setup time is in minutes, and whether you named the ugly part. They will ignore a hero button.

They are allowed to skip. Skip is a success. They are allowed to buy through a different link. The review still did the job.

The offer, named in one sentence

You are not selling the tool. You are publishing a review a real person can use, with a link underneath for the ones who decide to buy. Fill this before you write the page:

I use [tool] for [job]. Here is who it is for, how long setup took, what failed, who should not buy, and what I would use instead. If you purchase through this link I may earn a cut. The review is the same either way.

That sentence is the page, the DM, and the letter close. If you cannot fill the brackets without a paragraph, you do not know the tool yet. Use it another week. Do not join the program to soothe the blank. The buyer is a person with a Tuesday problem, not anyone using AI. If the buyer is anyone, you will write a glowing list.

What to write in the review Five parts. If one is empty, you are not ready to publish.

Setup. Minutes, not a feature table. What you actually did the first evening. Forty minutes is a number a tired person can use. Easy and intuitive is a brochure.

Who it is for. The Tuesday job plus a constraint. People who write the same kind of client note every week. Not anyone who wants to save time.

Who should skip. A real person, named by behavior. Anyone who will paste the raw output to a client. Not people who do not like quality tools. If you cannot name a skip, you have a brochure.

The ugly part. What failed. Asking it to sound more human made it sound like a brochure. Setup that took three hours counts. A feature you turned off counts. Nothing failed is a glowing list in one sentence.

The alternative. What you used before, or what you would use if this vanished tomorrow. Name it in words. Do not slap a second affiliate link on it unless you actually pay for that one too. Without an alternative, the page is a funnel with a scar pasted on.

Write those five on paper before you open a landing-page theme.

Five example sentences that work I use this model for client follow-up drafts. It is for people who write the same kind of note every week. Setup took forty

minutes. Asking it to “sound more human” failed. Do not buy it if you will paste raw output to a client. If you purchase through this link I may earn a cut.

I use this host for a Tuesday letter. It is for operators who want a list they own. Setup took a Sunday. The tagging UI annoyed me for a month. Skip it if you need a daily blast machine.

I use this editor for cutting ums out of walkthroughs. It is for people who already record. The first export was worse than the take. I stayed because the second export was the take. Skip it if you want a full course studio.

I use this form tool for kickoff questions after a deposit. Logic jumps broke on my third form. I stayed for the export. Skip it if you need a full CRM.

The job is in the sentence. The scar is in the sentence. The skip is in the sentence. The cut is in the sentence.

What they get They get a decision. They get setup time in minutes, not a feature table. They get a failure they can avoid. They get a skip rule they can use to walk away. They get a date so they know when you last looked. They get a disclosure they do not have to hunt for. They get a link they can ignore. If they finish the page and choose a competitor, you still did the job.

What they do not get They do not get a roundup of five tools you kind of used. They do not get a coupon code you invented. They do not get a guarantee the program bans. They do not get you in their setup call. They do not get a comparison spreadsheet of fifty rows.

Packaging One tool, one page. If you use two things — a model and a host — that is two pages, written weeks apart if you need the time, each with its own disclosure and its own date. Do not staple them into a stack guide in week one.

The letter is allowed to carry the review. A YouTube walkthrough is allowed to carry it, with the disclosure spoken in the first 15 seconds and written in the first lines of the description. A blog post is allowed to be the page. A Google Doc that forwards is enough. Working beats a microsite. Official is a date, a scar, and a sentence about the cut.

What ‘done’ looks like

Done is one commission from a review a real person used. Not a screenshot of a dashboard full of pending cookies. A human told you they bought because the page named the thing that was stuck, or you saw a conversion you can tie to that URL. Pending is a maybe. Cleared is done for v1.

Definition of done The page exists. The disclosure is at the top in words you would want from a friend. The structure is complete: who it is for, setup time, what you tried, what failed, who should not buy. The link sits below the reasoning. The screenshot is yours, or there is no screenshot because the program bans it. The date is a month and a year. You joined an official program and read the rules. You shared the page once with people who already asked. A commission cleared, or a stranger told you they used the page to decide.

The fairness test Would you forward this page to a friend who asked in good faith, even if they used a different link and you earned nothing? If you would be embarrassed, it is an ad. Fair also means the skip rule is real — you named a person who should not buy, and you meant it. Fair means the failure is a thing that happened, not a fake humility paragraph. Fair means if they never click, they still leave with a decision. Fair means you would keep paying for the tool if the program vanished tomorrow. If you would cancel the tool when the affiliate account dies, the page is a trap. Take it down.

The bar for the page Strip every URL. Read it. A tired person can still decide. The disclosure is in the first screen, not the footer. Setup is in minutes. The ugly part happened. The skip names a behavior. The alternative is a real option, not a threat. Month and year. One primary link, after the skip rule. Your dashboard if allowed, names blurred. No banned claims. No income promise. If the page only works with the button in it, you wrote an ad with extra paragraphs.

The bar for the money You can explain, in one sentence, how this program pays: bounty or percent, cookie length, hold, payout calendar. You count cleared, not pending, not clicks. You have not spent a pending cookie. You have not paused the letter. First cleared commission, or a stranger who used the page to decide, is the milestone. A dashboard of maybes is not.

Technical done - Official partner account, rules read, trademark notes in a doc - Disclosure at the top, not under a fold of adjectives - Who it is for, setup time, what you tried, what failed, who should not buy - Link below the skip rule. Once, maybe twice. Not in every sentence - Your own stack. Screenshot your own dashboard if the program allows it. No fake screenshots - A date. Month and year. Updated when pricing or the product changes - Shared once with people who already asked. Letter issue optional, still one link - Commissions counted when they clear, not when they pend

Not-done-yet list You are not done if the disclosure is in the footer, you have twenty pending cookies and zero sentences a friend could use, you have a best-50 farm, you have not sent the page to the six people who asked last month, or the price moved and your page still shows last year's number. Ship one honest page. Then wait. Then update. Then, maybe, tool two.

How the money actually shows up

You do not set the product price. The program does. Your job is to pick tools you already use, join official partner programs, and accept that cash is lumpy. Treat every number you have not cleared as a screenshot, not a salary. Two operators on the same program will not earn the same. Do not build a spending plan on someone else's screenshot.

How cookies and commission actually pay Four clocks, not one.

Clock one is the click. They hit your link. The program sets a cookie or a click ID. No click, no cookie. If they type the vendor's name into search and buy from an ad, you will not see it. That

is fine.

Clock two is the cookie window. Typical software: 7, 30, or 90 days. If they buy inside that window, you may get credit. If they buy on day 31 of a 30-day cookie, you get nothing. Last-click usually wins. Your Monday cookie can be overwritten by Thursday's ad.

Clock three is the hold. The commission is pending while the customer can still refund. Thirty days is common. Recurring cuts can be clawed back if they cancel inside a window named in the terms. Pending is a maybe. It is not a number you spend.

Clock four is payout. Net-30 or net-45 after the commission clears is common. Many programs also have a threshold: \$25, \$50, \$100. Under the line, nothing moves. Some pay PayPal. Some pay a bank. Some want a tax form before the first dollar. Until it clears and pays, it is a screenshot.

Clicks are vanity. Pending is a maybe. Cleared is a row in a sheet. Paid is cash. Count the last two.

30-day vs 90-day A 30-day cookie is the default on a lot of monthly seats. It is enough if your reader already wanted the tool and used your page to decide this month. It is tight if they are comparing three hosts for an annual plan. Riley's model program was 30 days. The people who converted had already asked.

A 90-day cookie covers more of the comparison. Annual plans, seats that need a team yes, tools people trial and forget. It is not a reason to pick a tool you do not use. A long cookie on a product you opened once is still a farm with better math.

A 7-day cookie means they buy this week or you miss. You still write the page. You do not spam a reminder on day 6 so the cookie lives.

Read yours. Write the number in the notes doc next to banned claims. Guessing is how you invent a 90-day story on a 7-day program.

Ranges you will actually see Bounty programs: a flat \$20–\$100 when a trial converts to paid. Common on monthly seats. One conversion is lunch, not rent.

Percent of first invoice: 20–40 percent of a month or a year. A \$20 monthly plan at 30 percent is \$6. A \$192 annual host plan at 40 percent is about \$77.

Recurring: some programs pay a cut every month the customer stays. Recurring can be clawed back if they refund. Do not spend a recurring maybe. Count it after it clears, twice.

High advertised cuts: 50 percent and up often pay on a plan your reader will not buy, or they pay on month one and vanish. Read the terms.

When cash hits the account A conversion in week 3 can clear in week 5 and pay in week 7. That is a healthy program, not a broken one. If you need rent on Friday, this is the wrong path for Friday. Run a package. Let this ride along.

Thresholds delay small bounties. Two \$20 bounties on a \$50 threshold sit until a third shows up. Read that line. Tax forms delay the first payout if you skipped them in week 1. Do the form the day you are approved.

Self-purchases and buying your own tool through your link are how people get banned. Do not test the cookie by checking out as yourself.

Worked dollars Riley's model program paid a \$20 bounty when a trial converted to the \$20 monthly plan. No recurring. Cookie: 30 days. Payout: net-30 after conversion. Week 1: page live, six notes, one letter close. About four hours, on a tool Riley already paid \$20 to use. Week 3: one conversion pending. Week 5: \$20 cleared. Week 7: \$40 cleared. Same two months, the Tuesday letter sold two \$19 files (\$38). Affiliate paid \$40. The letter and the package paid the month.

A later annual host conversion at 40 percent of \$192 is about \$77. That is a good month for this path. Do not build a spending plan on a number you saw in someone else's screenshot. Count commissions after they clear.

What you never do for a higher cut You never hide the disclosure. You never pretend you still use a tool you cancelled. You never stuff every paragraph with links. You never invent a claim the

program bans. You never switch the recommended plan because a higher tier pays more and your reader does not need it.

The first 72 hours

You are not launching a media company. You are joining two programs and writing one review. Then you wait on purpose.

Day 1 morning (hours 1–4): pick the tool and read the rules Open the stack you actually pay for. Circle two tools you would keep if every affiliate account died tomorrow. A model you draft with. A host you send with.

Join two official partner programs from the vendor's own site. Read the trademark rules and the disclosure rules. Note banned claims, screenshots, cookie length, and payout lag. If a program wants you to hide the relationship, skip it.

Day 1 afternoon (hours 5–8): structure on paper, no pitch yet On paper, not in a landing-page builder: who it is for. Setup time in minutes. What you tried. What failed. Who should not buy. If a section is empty, you do not know the tool yet. Use it another week. A setup that took three hours counts. A feature you turned off counts.

Pick the job the tool actually does for you. Riley's job was client follow-up drafts, not "AI."

Day 1 night (hours 9–12): write the review Disclosure at the top. Then who, setup, tried, failed, skip. Date it with the month and the year. Put the link after the skip rule. Once. Screenshot your own dashboard if allowed, names blurred. If screenshots are banned, use words.

Write as if the URL will be stripped tomorrow. Read it out loud. If it collapses into "it is great, click here," you wrote an ad. Cut the adjectives. Keep the scar.

Day 2 (hours 13–36): edit, publish, six names In the morning, reread cold. Add the skip rule if you went soft overnight. Publish on a simple page or

as a letter issue. Ugly is allowed. A heading, the date, the body, the link.

Write six names. People who asked you about that tool last month. Not a cold list. Six is an hour of messages, not a campaign. Do not send a blast.

Day 3 (hours 37–72): send once, then stop Send the six notes. If you have a Tuesday letter this week, the issue can carry the story — the failure, then the page — with the disclosure at the top of that issue. Share it once. Then wait.

If nobody of the six replies, you still have a page. Do not rebuild the offer. Do not join four more programs. Go back to the letter and the package. Check the partner dashboard on Day 10, not Day 3 at midnight.

What you do not do in the first 72 hours You do not join a third program. You do not cloak the URL. You do not test the cookie by buying the tool through your own link. You do not pin a best tool comment under strangers. You do not add a related prompt library you opened once. You do not schedule a week of reminder emails so the 30-day cookie stays warm. You do not pause the letter. Seventy-two hours. Then you wait on purpose.

The path, step by step

Twelve steps. One tool until the page is good. If you have two reviews in week one, you have a farm.

Step 1. Only tools in your actual stack Open the bill you already pay. If you would cancel the tool when the affiliate account dies, it does not belong on the page. Screenshot your own dashboard if allowed. Use it until you can fill the failure section without inventing.

Step 2. Join official programs only Join from the vendor's own site. No cloaks you do not understand. Read trademark, disclosure,

banned claims, cookie length, and payout schedule. If the program wants you to hide the relationship, walk out. Two programs to start.

Step 3. Pick one tool for review one A model you draft with, or a host you send with. Not both in one URL soup. Pick the one people already ask you about. Riley picked the model because the inbox kept asking. The host waited.

Step 4. Write the five parts on paper before the pitch Setup in minutes. Who it is for. Who should skip. The ugly part. The alternative. If a section is empty, you do not know the tool yet. Use it another week. Do not open a landing-page theme until those five lines exist. The alternative does not get a second affiliate link unless you actually pay for that tool too.

Step 5. Disclose at the top, in plain English Quiet honesty converts better than a hidden link. Use the FTC-style line in the copy section. I use this. If you buy through this link I may earn a cut. The review is the same either way. Do not bury it under a fold of adjectives. Do not put it in gray eight-point. Do not save it for the footer. Required is the first screen. On video, say it in the first 15 seconds and write it in the first lines of the description.

Step 6. Put the link below the skip rule After the skip rule is a good place. Once, maybe twice if there is a cheaper plan you actually think they should consider. Not in every sentence. Not in the headline. Not above the scar. People bounce when the first object they hit is a button. They stay when the first object is a decision.

Step 7. Date the page and use your own stack Month and year. A dated review is a trust machine. Updated without a date is a trick people know. When the vendor moves a price or a plan name, change the paragraph and the date in the same sitting. Screenshot your own login if allowed, names blurred. Never a fake.

Step 8. Publish on a simple page or in the letter The letter is allowed to carry the review. The page is allowed to be ugly. A Doc, a Notion page, a single site page, one issue, a blog post. Working beats a microsite. You need a URL you can paste to the six people who asked, with a disclosure they do not have to hunt for.

Step 9. Share once where people already asked Last month's DMs. The group you actually help. The letter they already open. Not a spray of best tool comments under strangers. Once. Then stop. Reminders train people to ignore you. Six personal notes is a week-one job.

Step 10. Count commissions when they clear, not clicks Pending is a maybe. Clicks are vanity. Cleared is a row in a sheet. Do not screenshot a dashboard of pendings and call it a launch. Learn this program's four clocks: click, cookie window, hold, payout. Check the dashboard once a week. Log out of the partner site on your phone.

Step 11. Update, recover, or drop When the price or the product changes, change the paragraph and the date in the same sitting. If you recommended junk, take the link down the same day, date the correction, and tell the people you sent it to. If you cancelled the tool, still-pay is no: link down this week. If the program starts asking you to hide the relationship, walk out. Leaving a rotting page up is how the name follows a payout you no longer believe.

Step 12. Add tool two only after the first page has been used Someone who is not you used it. You updated it once. Then one more tool from the stack. Still not fifty. Still not a roundup. Two honest pages a year beats twenty neglected URLs. Treat commissions as a sidecar until the list is real. Do not pause the letter. Do not pause the package. Do not build a best-50 farm while you wait. The sidecar does not get to drive.

Worked example: Riley's one honest review

Riley drafts client follow-ups in a paid model and sends a Tuesday letter from a paid host. People in the inbox kept asking which model. Riley did not drop a link in a reply. Riley wrote one page. This is a seven-week story with dollars, a shipped page, a mistake, a recovery, a stranger conversion, and a later decision not to farm.

The tool was already in the stack. Riley paid \$20 a month with a personal card and would have kept paying if every partner account died. That still-pay test is why this page was allowed to exist. The host program was joined the same Monday and then left unpublished. Two accounts. One page.

What Riley wrote Who: people who write the same kind of client note every week and are tired of restating the voice.
Not for people who need a model to invent a business.

Setup: forty minutes to a project with instructions, three good examples, and a never-do-this list. Riley said the first evening was messy. That line mattered more than a feature table.

The ugly part: asking it to sound more human, which made it sound like a brochure. The recap emails were the win. The joke post was embarrassing and got cut. The fix was pasting two real emails and saying match these, do not improve my personality.

Who should not buy: anyone who will paste the raw output to a client. Riley says that twice. The model drafts. The human sends.

The alternative: a swipe file of the last ten emails Riley actually sent, plus a timer. If the model vanished tomorrow, Riley would not open a different chatbot the same night. That sentence is why a careful person trusted the rest.

The disclosure, on top: I use this model for drafts. If you buy through this link I may earn a cut. The review is the same either way. I would keep paying for it if the program vanished tomorrow. Updated March.

The link sits after the skip rule. One link. No top 10 models. No fake dashboard. Riley's own project list, names blurred, because the program allows it.

Week 1 calendar Monday: official partner account, rules read. Cookie 30 days. Bounty \$20 on trial-to-paid. No recurring. Hold until conversion. Payout net-30. Threshold \$25. Banned-claims list in a doc. Review written that night.

Tuesday: six notes to people who had asked last month. Tuesday letter carried the joke-post failure, then the page, disclosure at the top of the issue. Personal notes. No blast. The dashboard was not open on the phone.

The six notes (Tuesday) Riley sent the page once to six people who had asked last month, and once in the Tuesday letter, below a story about the joke post that failed. Personal notes. No blast.

The mistake On Thursday Riley added a second link, to a “related” prompt library Riley had opened once on a free weekend, because the page looked thin. A reader replied: “I thought you used this weekly. The second link feels like a list.” Riley had stuffed the page to soothe loneliness. The reader was right.

The recovery Riley pulled the second link the same night. Left the model page as one tool, one scar, one skip. Sent a note to the reader: You were right. I took the extra link off. The review is the model I actually pay for. The reader stayed. Riley put one tool per page at the top of the notes.

If the prompt library had shipped, that would have been recommending junk. Recovery is the same motion, louder: link down the same day, dated note at the top, message to anyone you sent it to, no replacement tool that week to make up the money. Count on the still-pay test before the second URL exists.

What happened with dollars Week 3: one conversion pending on the \$20 monthly plan. The program paid a \$20 bounty, no recurring, 30-day cookie, net-30 payout, \$25 threshold. Riley did not spend it. Clicks that week were a handful. Clicks are not commissions.

Week 5: \$20 cleared. A second conversion the same week, another \$20 pending. Together they crossed the \$25 threshold. A third person wrote to say they skipped the tool, which Riley counts

as the page working. Skip is a success.

Week 7: \$40 cleared and paid. Two months, \$40 from the sidecar. Same window, the letter sold two \$19 files (\$38) and Riley still ran the package path as the engine. Affiliate paid lunch.

A stranger converted in week 6 from the letter archive, not from the six notes. Same \$20 bounty, 30-day cookie still valid from a click in week 5. That is cookie lag, not a traffic plan. Riley did not add a roundup to chase more strangers.

After, the update, and tool two Month 2, the host changed a plan name. Riley still had not published the host review. Riley updated the model page date and one paragraph about a new job: follow-ups for a bookkeeper referral, same match these emails trick. Still one tool.

The host review waited until someone who was not Riley had used the first page, and until Riley had updated it once. Tool two got a calendar date, not a panic. No reminder week. No did you buy. One dashboard look a week.

Riley never made the sidecar the engine. That is the part to copy. The pulled second link is the lesson.

Copy you can paste

Keep the disclosure boring. Boring is trustworthy. Fill the brackets. Do not add hype.

FTC-style disclosure in plain English Short, first screen:

I use this. If you buy through this link I may earn a cut. The review is the same either way.

That is the honesty a tired person can hear. You have a material connection: you may get paid if they buy. You say so in the same place as the recommendation, in words a normal person understands. Not a footer. Not a hover.

Longer, if the program or the law you are under wants more:

I am in the [program] partner program. I pay for [tool] with my own money and use it for [job]. If you buy through this link I may earn a commission. I do not get paid to hide problems. I would keep paying for this if the program vanished tomorrow. Last updated [month year].

Spoken, first 15 seconds of a video:

I use this tool for [job]. Some links in the description may earn me a commission if you buy. The review does not change if you never click.

Put the same sentences in the description, first lines, before the tags. A spoken line with a buried description is half a disclosure.

Page title and hero Title: I use [tool] for [job]
— who it is for, what failed, who should skip it.

Hero: I use [tool] for [job]. Setup took [minutes]. Here is who it is for, what broke, who should not buy, and what I would use instead. If you purchase through this link I may earn a cut. The sentences do not change if you never click.

Newsletter issue Put the disclosure in the first screen of the issue, not after a story they have to scroll. Then tell the failure. Then point.

I drafted this issue in [tool]. If you want the review, it is here: who it is for, setup time, what failed, who should skip. I may earn a cut if you buy through the link. The review is the same either way. If you want next Tuesday, it still arrives with no click required.

Do not make the whole issue a pitch. One idea, one story, one ask. The ask is the page, once.

YouTube description First lines, before anything else:

I use [tool] for [job]. Links below may earn me a commission if you buy. I pay for this with my own money. The review is the same if you never click. Updated [month year].

Then the link, once. Then the skip rule in one sentence. Do not lead with twenty URLs. Say the disclosure on camera in the first 15 seconds as well.

Blog open and close Open: I use [tool] for [job]. If you buy through the link in this post I may earn a cut. I would keep paying for it if the program vanished. Setup took [minutes]. Here is who it is for, what failed, who should skip, and what I would use instead. Updated [month year].

Close: If your job matches, the link is here. If it does not, keep the skip rule. I will take the link down if I stop using the tool. One primary link.

The six personal notes Subject: the page I kept meaning to send

You asked me about [tool] last month. I wrote the page I wanted to send you: setup time, what broke, who should not buy. I may earn a cut if you buy through the link. The review is the same either way. Here: [url]. If it is not useful, ignore this.

When they skip: Skip is a valid ending. That is what the page is for. If you want a different job solved, tell me the Tuesday problem. I will not invent a link.

When they ask which tool: I use [tool] for [job]. I wrote the page instead of a chat essay. Disclosure at the top. Skip rule before the link. Here: [url]. If your job is different, the skip rule is the part to read first.

I do not use [tool], so I will not review it. I can tell you what I do use for [job], with the same disclosure I would want from you. I will not add a link I cannot stand behind.

Recovery if you recommended junk Subject: I was wrong about [tool]

I told you [tool] was worth a look. I no longer stand behind that. Here is what broke: [ugly part I missed or that showed up after]. I have taken the link off the page. Do not buy it on my say-so. If you already bought and you want help picking a way out, reply. I will not point you at a replacement cookie this week.

On the page, dated, at the top: Updated [month year]: I no longer recommend this. [What broke.] The link is gone.

When you drop a program Updated [month year]: I cancelled [tool] / I will not hide this relationship / the product changed enough that the old review is a trap.

Link removed. If you landed here from an old note, do not buy through me. Here is the alternative I actually use, with no link until I write that page: [name].

What not to write Best AI tool of the year. Twenty links in a thread. I made \$12,000 in a weekend. Claims the program bans. A disclosure in gray eight-point under a hero button. Nothing failed, it is perfect. Updated with no month. Official partner of the year when you are not. A second tool stuffed in because the page looked lonely. Buy before midnight so my cookie does not expire. Any sentence you would not say to a friend after dinner.

Week-by-week

This path is slow on purpose. Plan the wait so you do not sabotage it with a farm. Four weeks. Cash may arrive in weeks 3–6. That is the cookie.

Week 1, day by day Monday: join two official programs you already use. Read the rules. Pick one tool. Structure on paper: who, setup, tried, failed, skip.

Tuesday: write the review. Disclosure on top. Link below the skip rule. Date it. Publish.

Wednesday: list six names who asked last month. Send the first three notes. Personal. No blast.

Thursday: send the other three. If you have a letter this week, the issue can carry the failure story, then the page, disclosure at the top of the issue.

Friday: reread the page cold. Is the skip rule visible. Is the disclosure in the first screen. Is there exactly one primary link. Fix those three. Do not add tool two.

Saturday: off, or one paragraph in the notes: which program, which rules, where the link lives.

Sunday: rest.

Week 2, day by day Monday: do the other path. Letter, package, file. Not a second review. Tuesday: if the letter goes out, one mention max, below a real story. Same disclosure. Wednesday: check the partner dashboard once. Do

not panic at zero. Thursday: send nothing extra. Friday: if a reader replies with a skip, thank them. If a reader says this sounds like an ad, cut adjectives the same day. Saturday: notes toward the next issue of the letter. Sunday: off.

Week 3 Cookie and trust lag live here. Keep sending the letter. Keep the package. Check the dashboard once. If a conversion pends, do not spend it. If week 3 is silent, do not join four more programs. Silent is the default.

Week 4 Count: reviews published that would stand with the link removed (target: one). Notes sent (six to ten). Clicks if shown. Commissions that cleared, not pending. First cleared one is the milestone, and it may not have happened yet.

If you have clicks and no commissions, read the review again. Often the link is above the reasoning, or you recommended a plan nobody in your audience needs. Fix the page. Do not add a roundup.

Month 2 Update the review if price, product, or your use changed. If nothing changed, add one paragraph about a new job you actually ran. Change the date only if you truly looked. Fake updated is a glowing list with a calendar.

Then, and only then, consider tool two: someone who is not you used page one, and you updated it once. Treat commissions as a sidecar until the list is real.

If the month is quiet Quiet is not a prompt to farm. Ask whether you wrote to people who had the Tuesday problem, or to a cold list. Ask whether the skip rule is real. Ask whether the disclosure is in the first screen. Fix the page. Send six new names who actually asked. Do not join a high-paying program for a tool you have not opened. Do not pause the letter. The sidecar waits. The engine works.

The quality bar

The stripped-link test is the bar. Remove every URL. Read the page. If a careful person could still decide, you are done. If the page collapses into “it is great, click here,” write it again.

Below the bar Disclosure in the footer. Link in the first sentence. No skip rule. No failure. A screenshot that is not yours. Five tools on one URL. A plan you do not use, recommended because it pays more. Twenty links in a thread. A tool you cancelled still wearing your name.

Above the bar Disclosure in the first screen. Link after the skip rule. A failure that happened. A skip you mean. An alternative. Month and year. One tool. A plan you actually pay for. Shared once with people who asked. You would keep paying if the program vanished tomorrow.

Test 1 — the stripped-link test Copy the page into a doc. Delete every URL. Read it. Can a tired person decide. If not, you wrote an ad with extra paragraphs. Add the scar and the skip. Then put the link back, once, under that.

Test 2 — the friend test Would you forward this to a friend who asked in good faith, even if they used a different link and you earned nothing? If you would be embarrassed, it is an ad. If you flinch, cut the cheer.

Test 3 — the failure and skip tests If you cannot name something that broke, you have not used it long enough, or you are hiding. Setup time that was worse than the marketing page counts. A feature you turned off counts. Nothing failed is a glowing list in one sentence. Empty failure section: do not publish. Name who should not buy. Riley's do not paste raw output to a client is a skip rule. A review with no skip is a brochure.

Test 4 — the disclosure placement test Open the page on a phone. Without scrolling, can you read that you may earn a cut. If you have to hunt, it fails. Gray eight-point fails. Footer fails. After a

hero button fails. On a video, first 15 seconds plus first lines of the description. If you are ashamed to put it there, do not join the program.

Test 5 — the still-pay test Would you keep paying for this tool if the program vanished tomorrow? If the honest answer is no, take the page down. Pass it every time you update the date. Pass it before you add tool two. Pass it the week you are tempted by a higher cut on a product you do not open.

Test 6 — the screenshot and date tests Your dashboard, if allowed. Never a fake. Never someone else's crop. If screenshots are banned, use words. Blur names. Month and year on the page. When the vendor moves a price or a plan name, the paragraph and the date change in the same sitting. A page dated last year with this year's price is a trap.

What to count

Count slow numbers. This path lies if you watch it daily. Pending is not cash. Clicks are not commissions. Commissions are not a salary.

Count these, ignore those Count: pages that would stand with the link removed. Notes sent to people who asked. Skip replies. Commissions cleared. Amount paid, after clawbacks. Last date you truly looked. Still-pay, yes or no.

Ignore: other people's disclosed income. Rankings of best affiliate offers. How many tools you could join. A 50-tool content calendar. Pending cookies as a scoreboard. Follower counts. Click count as a grade.

If you have clicks and no commissions after 45 days, read the review again. Often the link is above the reasoning or you recommended a plan nobody in your audience needs.

Week 1 - Reviews published that would stand with the link removed. Target: one - Official programs joined and rules read. Target: two accounts, one page

- People who already asked, that you actually sent the page to. Six to ten is a real week 1 - Disclosure in the first screen (yes/no) - Date on the page (yes/no)

Target: page + six notes. A conversion in week 1 is luck, not a system. Zero conversions is normal.

Day 30 - Clicks, if the program shows them, without panicking at a quiet day - Commissions that cleared, not pending. First cleared one is the milestone - Replies that say they skipped. Count those as the page working - Hours spent on a second review (should be zero) - Dashboard checks per week (should be one, not twenty)

A good first month is one honest page in the world, six to ten personal notes, and maybe \$0-\$40 cleared. \$0 cleared on day 30 is still a fine start if the notes went out. \$40 is Riley's two bounties.

Day 90 - One or two pages, each a tool you still pay for - At least one update with a real date change - Commissions counted only when they clear - Letter still sending. Package still selling. Sidecar still a sidecar - A decision: stay at one tool, add tool two, or take a page down because you cancelled the product - Still no best-50 farm

Day 90 cash is lumpy. If you are at zero pages, you joined programs and wrote nothing. If you are at twenty pages, you built a hole.

One-line spreadsheet Date published | tool | notes sent | clicks (if shown) | pending | cleared | amount cleared | last updated | still pay (y/n)

One row per page. Five minutes after a payout email. If still-pay is no, take the link down this week.

How to read a partner dashboard Clicks: people hit the URL. Not a grade. A handful after six notes is normal. Pending: a maybe inside the hold. Do not spend. Approved / cleared: it survived the hold. Row in the sheet. Paid: cash moved, threshold met, calendar ticked.

This is the only number that buys groceries. Reversed / clawed back: they refunded. Subtract it. This is why you do not spend pending.

If the dashboard will not show cookie length, it is in the FAQ you should have read in week 1. Write it on the notes so you stop guessing 90 on a 30.

Objections you will hear

These are the lines. The reply is what you actually send.

“Affiliate is sleazy.” Hidden affiliate is sleazy. A disclosure on top and a review that names failure is how people already recommend tools, with a cookie attached. Reply: “The review stands if you never click. I may earn a cut if you buy through the link. I would keep paying for this if the program vanished tomorrow.”

“I need traffic first.” Yes. This is not a traffic plan. Build the letter or the door. Then the page has somewhere to live. Reply: “I will write the page when I have six people who already asked. Until then I am sending the letter.”

“Programs take too long to approve.” Some do. Use the wait to write the review without the link, then add the URL. Do not apply to twelve programs to soothe the wait. Reply to yourself: “The sentences do not need a cookie to be useful. I will publish the decision and paste the URL when they approve.”

“What if they buy and the cookie misses?” It happens. The review still did the job. Do not add five tracking scripts to squeeze a maybe. Reply: “If the cookie misses I still wanted them to decide well. I will not install a maze to catch a maybe.”

“Can I round up five tools I kind of used?” No. That is the glowing list. One tool you love. Reply: “I review what I pay for. I will not rank tools

I opened once. If you want the one I actually use, here is the page.”

“The commission is small.” It is a sidecar. Small plus honest plus a list that already trusts you beats large plus a name you cannot reuse. Reply: “I do not run this for rent. \$20 cleared is extra. The letter is the engine.”

“Can you hide the disclosure so it converts better?”

No. Reply: “If hiding it converts better, I do not want those clicks. The disclosure stays in the first screen.”

“Will you review this tool I built if we add you to the program?”

Not if you do not use it. Reply: “I only review tools I pay for with my own money and would keep if the program died.”

“Can you put twenty links in a thread for the algorithm?” No. Reply: “One page, one tool, one link under the skip rule. A thread of twenty is a farm.”

“I bought through your link and I hate the tool.” Take it seriously.

Reply: “Tell me what broke. I will update the failure section if I missed it. If I have stopped using it I will take the link down. If I was wrong, you get the junk-recovery note, not a pep talk.”

What this path feeds — and what it needs

Affiliate rides the other paths. It does not replace them. If you treat it as the engine, you will write whatever the payout table wants, and the other paths will smell it.

Upstream — what you need before this path You need a stack you pay for. You need six people who already asked. You need a place the page can live for a year: a letter, a simple page, or both. You need a spine for a disclosure in the first screen. You do not need a review empire or twelve programs.

If you have never shipped a letter or a front door, start there. Affiliate does not create attention. If you have no one to ask, this path is a forest.

Downstream — where a good page goes next A Tuesday issue can tell the story of what failed, then point to the review. A playbook can mention the model you used, with the same disclosure. A package can include here is the tool I draft in; you do not have to buy it. The cut is extra. The trust is the asset.

People who skip the tool still trust the next page. Riley counted the skip email as the page working. That reader will believe review two. When a commission clears, do not add a farm. Add a date-check on the calendar.

What it needs It needs people. Official programs. One page. A stack you still pay for. It needs you to leave twenty-link threads alone. It needs a notes doc with cookie length and banned claims. It needs a still-pay test you will actually fail out loud. It needs the letter and the package to keep running while you wait on a hold.

What it does not need It does not need a coupon extension. It does not need a cloaked URL you cannot explain. It does not need you to pause cash to write a best-50. It does not need a review-site theme. It does not need a 90-day cookie on a tool you do not open. If the letter dies, this path dies with it.

Keep the engine Keep the letter. Keep the package. Let the cookie ride. The Operator Suite is a set of paths that feed each other. This one is a sidecar. Unbolt it and you still have a bike. Unbolt the bike and you have a coupon blog with your name on the header. When a month surprises you, bank it. Do not rebuild the week around it.

Mistakes that rot the name

Each one has a recovery you can do this week.

1. Fake screenshots Recovery this week: delete the image.
Use your dashboard if allowed, names blurred, or use words. If you already published a fake, take it down today.
2. Recommending junk, or a tool you cancelled The page becomes a trap for people who trust you. Recovery this week: still-pay test out loud. If no, remove the link the same day. Date the change. Message anyone you sent it to: I was wrong. Here is what broke. Do not buy it on my say-so. Leave the review up only as I used to, here is why I left, with the cookie gone. Do not collect a commission on a product you will not defend. Do not replace it with a different tool the same week to make up the money. A model will write a brochure if you let it: you still add the scar, the setup time, and the skip, or you do not publish.
3. Stuffing every paragraph with links That is how readers stop reading, and how some programs warn you. Recovery this week: one primary link, after the skip rule. Delete the rest.
4. Forgetting banned claims Income promises, trademark misuse, “official” language you were not given. Recovery this week: search your page for numbers you did not earn and titles you were not given. Cut them today.
5. The farm Twenty links in a thread. A best-50 farm. Recovery this week: unpublish the roundup. Keep one honest page.
6. Building this before you have a place people already look A perfect review in a forest is still a forest. Recovery this week: send the page to six people who asked, or start the letter.
7. Refreshing the dashboard hourly Pending is not cash. Hourly checks train you to sabotage the wait with a farm. Recovery this week: one calendar reminder, weekly. Log out of the partner site on your phone.

8. Recommending the higher plan because it pays more Your reader does not exist to optimize your cut. Recovery this week: recommend the plan you actually use, or the cheaper one you actually think they should start with.

9. Hiding the disclosure, or using a cloak you do not understand Gray eight-point. Footer only. After a hero button. A network that can swap the vendor later. Recovery this week: move the boring sentence to the first screen. Replace any cloaked URL with the official program link. If you cannot join official, you do not review that tool for a cookie.

10. Treating pending as rent, or leaving a rotting program up Then you will write desperate pages when it fails to clear, or you will collect cookies on a product you no longer use. Recovery this week: count cleared only. Put the spending plan back on the package and the file.

When to drop a program: you cancelled the tool. You have not opened it in 90 days. They want the disclosure hidden. They pay you to push a plan you would not buy. The merchant swapped under a network you cannot explain. You were wrong and the product is junk. Any one of those is enough. Link down this week. Sidecar, not engine.

Tools (official, few, used)

Official partner programs, a simple page or newsletter, honest disclosure. That is the stack. Boring on purpose.

Exact stack - Two official partner accounts, joined from the vendor's own site, both for tools you already pay for - One page: Google Doc published, Notion, or a single site page. Ugly is allowed - Or the letter you already send, with the review as an issue - A notes doc: banned claims, cookie length, payout lag, still-pay test - Your own login, for a screenshot if allowed - A one-line spreadsheet: published, notes sent, cleared, last updated

No review-site theme. No 40 comparison tables. No unofficial coupon extension. No cloaker you cannot explain.

Setup order 1. Pick two tools you still pay for. 2. Join both official programs. Read the rules. Write the banned list. 3. Pick one tool for page one. 4. Write who, setup, tried, failed, skip on paper. 5. Disclose at the top. Date it. Link below the skip rule. 6. Publish ugly. 7. Send six notes. 8. Calendar: dashboard once a week. Update check in 90 days.

What not to buy A review-site template. A rank tracker. A cloaking tool. A CRM for twenty programs. A course on affiliate empires. A stock photo of a dashboard that is not yours.

The \$0 path The model or host you already pay for. The official program, free to join. A Google Doc published to the web, or a Notion page, or the newsletter you already send. Mail you already have. You need a URL a tired person can open, with a disclosure they do not have to hunt for.

If you have no letter and no site, the Doc is the page. Send the Doc. Six names and a dated Doc is a start.

Official partner programs Join from the vendor's own site. Two to start, both in your actual stack. Read trademark and disclosure rules before you write a headline. If they want you to hide the relationship, you want out. The letter you already send is enough as a home for the page. Keep the disclosure at the top. Plain sentences. Not a legal poem. Not a tiny footnote.

Leave link-in-bio mazes of twenty tools, unofficial coupon extensions, and any program that asks you to hide the relationship.

Checklist

Tick this before you add a second tool.

Before you join - Tool is in your actual stack; you would keep paying without the program - Still-pay test said out loud: yes - You can name setup minutes, who it is for, who should skip, the ugly part, the alternative - You have six people who already asked, or a letter that already goes out - You are not picking this program for cookie length or advertised cut

Before you publish - Tool is in your actual stack; you would keep paying without the program - Still-pay test said out loud: yes - Official partner account, joined from the vendor's site - Rules read: trademark, disclosure, banned claims, cookie length, payout lag - Banned-claims list in a notes doc - Disclosure written at the top, first screen, not footer - Structure complete: who it is for, setup time, what you tried, what failed, who should not buy - Failure is a thing that happened, not a fake humility paragraph - Skip rule names a real person who should not buy - Link below the reasoning, after the skip rule - One primary link, maybe one cheaper-plan link you actually mean - Screenshot is yours, names blurred, or no screenshot if banned - Date on the page, month and year - No banned claims, no income promise, no fake "official" title - Page would still help if every URL were stripped

First 72 hours - One review, not a roundup - Page published on a Doc, Notion, site, or letter issue - Six people who already asked, named - Six notes sent, once, personal - Letter issue optional, still one link, disclosure at top of issue - No second tool added because the page looked lonely - Dashboard not open on your phone - You did not test the cookie by buying through your own link

When money shows up - Clicks noted without a funeral - Pending left pending - Cleared logged - Clawbacks subtracted - Paid counted only after it hits the account - Letter still sending. Package still selling - No spending plan built on a maybe

When to drop, and ongoing - Update when price or product changes; change the date in the same sitting - 90-day calendar reminder to look again - Commissions

counted when they clear, not when they pend - One dashboard check per week - Sidecar, not the engine; letter and package still running - Still no best-50 page - Tool two waits until someone who is not you used page one, and you updated it once - If you cancelled the tool, you recommended junk, they want the disclosure hidden, or you have not opened it in 90 days, link comes down this week

FAQ

Short answers. Default at the end of each.

Can I join a program for a tool I used once? No. Use it until you can fill setup, skip, ugly, and alternative without inventing. Once is a first date. A review is a relationship. Default: not until you still pay, and you can name a scar.

Do I have to say affiliate in the first line? Say you may earn a cut if they buy through the link, and that the review does not change. That is the honesty. Use the word affiliate if the program or the law you are under wants it. Quiet and early beats clever and late. On video, say it in the first 15 seconds and put it in the first lines of the description. Default: cut named in the first screen.

Newsletter, page, blog, or YouTube? Whichever you already have. Riley did a page and mentioned it in the letter. A blog post can be the page. A YouTube walkthrough can carry the same five parts, with the disclosure spoken and written. Default: one URL, then extras if they already exist.

How many links, and does 30-day vs 90-day change the page? One primary. A second if there is a cheaper plan you actually think they should consider. Cookie length does not change the sentences. Write the number in your notes. Do not pick the tool for the timer. Default: one link, after the skip rule.

What if the program rejects me? Write the review anyway without a link, or pick the second tool you already use. Rejection is not a prompt to join a shady network. If you cannot join official, you do not review that tool for a cookie. Default: sentences first, cookie second. Official only.

Can I use a model to write the review? You can outline. You still have to add the scar: setup time, what failed, who should skip, the alternative. A model will write a glowing list. That is the thing we are not doing. Default: you add the scar or you do not publish.

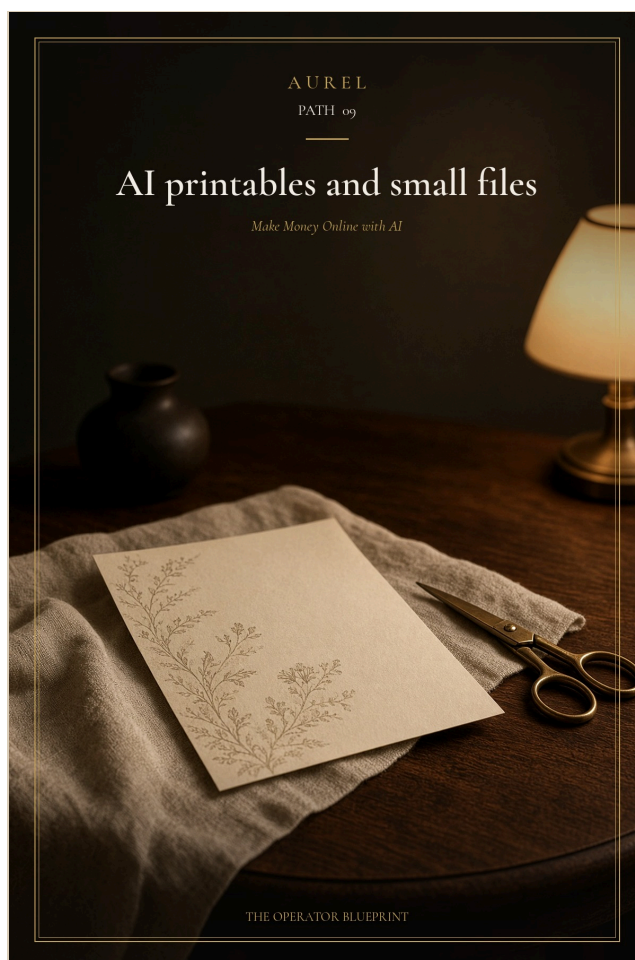
When do I add a second review, and is this rent? After someone who is not you used the first one, and you have updated it once. Then one more tool from the stack. Still not fifty. Treat it as a sidecar. Some months will surprise you. Do not schedule rent on a surprise. Default: tool two after use plus one update. Package and letter for rent, this for extra.

What if I recommended junk, or they hate the tool? Take the link down the same day. Date the correction. Tell the people you sent it to. Update the failure section if you missed it. Do not talk them into staying so you can keep a cookie. Do not add a replacement cookie that week. If you cancelled the tool, the page may stay as I left, here is why, with the link gone. Default: link down when still-pay is no, or when you were wrong.

The vendor changed pricing, or a commission clawed back Update this week. Change the date. A dated correction builds more trust than a perfect first draft you abandoned. Clawbacks are why you count cleared, twice if you need to, and why you do not spend pending. Default: same sitting, paragraph plus date. Wait until a commission would survive a refund window before you call it cash.

What if nobody of the six replies, or I want to review a free tool? The page can still sit. Ask whether you wrote to people who had the Tuesday problem, or to a cold list. Rewrite so it has a job, a scar, and a skip. Do not add a roundup. A free

tool you love can have a page with no link. Many free tools have no program. The sentences are still a gift to the letter. Default: six new names who actually asked, not twenty new programs. No program required for the sentences. Program required for the cookie.



PATH 09

AI printables and small files

Solve a Tuesday problem. Mood boards are a hobby. Trackers are a product.

51 minute read · 11,158 words

Who this is for

You can design a clean one-page tool: tracker, checklist, wall print, planner page. You live near a job someone repeats every week.

Time to first

2–10 days

Tools

First sale

Someone prints the \$9 file.

Cash window

\$7–\$12 single, \$19 bundle

Leave this alone

Canva, a home or library printer, a phone for the mockup, Stan or Etsy, AI for labels and listing copy — not for stolen art.

Generic aesthetic planners with no job. Trademarked characters. 400 listings before one file prints.

What you are selling

A printable is a page someone will actually print, fill, and pin to a wall or drop in a binder. That is the whole product. Not a vibe. Not a mood board. A tool for a Tuesday problem: what to post this week, what to pack, what to check before a client walks in.

Search language is the product title. Weekly content tracker for solo hairstylists beats Cute planner 2026 because the first one names a person and a job. The second one is wallpaper. People searching Etsy or Google at 10pm are not shopping for cute. They are shopping for a page that stops the guessing.

Definition, in one breath

You pick one repeating job. You make one page that gets filled in. You print it at home at 100 percent, actual size. You photograph the filled page on a real table with the phone you already own. You list it at \$7 to \$12 with a title a tired person would type into a search bar. AI drafts the labels and the listing copy. You rewrite both in the language of the job. You do not generate faces, brands, or copyrighted characters. You do not list a bundle until someone has printed the single.

The file is cheap. The list is the real asset. Etsy is an aisle you rent. Use it if you have no traffic. Move them to email when you can.

The repeating job is the product

A repeating job is something the same person does every week, or every Saturday, or every client. Captions for a one-chair stylist. An opening checklist for a food-truck Saturday. Lesson notes for a tutor who runs four sessions after school. A van pack list for a mobile dog groomer. If the job is a one-off, you do not have a printable. You have a poster.

One page that gets filled in is the unit. Not a 40-page undated book. A grid a pen can hit, a title that names the job, a one-line instruction in the footer. Page two is a filled week, real texture, names blurred. Empty pretty is a hobby with a PDF export.

What this is not

This is not a 40-page undated planner with empty circles and a quote about blooming. Those exist by the thousand. They photograph well and convert poorly unless you already have a following that buys your taste.

This is not a wall print of someone else's illustration, a trademarked character, or a generated face. Your layout, your words, your simple shapes. If you cannot draw, use type, lines, and a two-color palette. Clean beats illustrated when the buyer is a working stylist, not a Pinterest board.

This is not a Canva template you leave editable so the buyer can make it theirs. An editable file is a different product, a different license, and a different support load. V1 is a locked PDF they print. If they want editable later, that is a \$24 upgrade with a written license, not a free extra in the \$9 zip.

Why this works now

Home printers did not go away. Salons, classrooms, kitchens, and vans still have a wall and a clip. The people who buy a \$9 page are not waiting for an app. They want paper next to the chair, the stove, the crate of tools. Paper does not need a login. Paper does not vanish when a subscription lapses.

Search still works for a specific job. Booth renter content tracker is a query with a person behind it. Aesthetic planner 2026 is a query with a mood behind it. Mood shoppers bounce. Job shoppers print.

AI collapsed the copy cost. Labels and listing bullets used to take an afternoon. Now they take twenty minutes plus a rewrite. The rewrite is the work. A model does not know your printer. You do, after one test page.

What AI is for, and what it is not for

For: column labels in the language of the job. A first draft of the listing title and the five bullets. A one-line how-to in the footer. Alternate phrasings when Caption and Content pillar are both on the page and only one belongs.

Not for: a face, a child, a celebrity, a logo, a character, a lyric, a team mark. Not for in the style of. Not for a floral border you saw on a bestseller. Not for a 400-listing plan. Layout, print test, and a filled example are still human jobs. That is the gap you get paid for. Type and lines. If the page needs a drawing to work, the page is the wrong product.

Three anti-patterns

Anti-pattern one: the pretty empty grid. You spend six hours on a floral border and twenty minutes on the fields. The listing photo looks like a lifestyle magazine. The page, in a booth renter's hand, has nowhere to write the caption. Buyers leave a one-star that says cute but I still did not know what to post. You earned that star.

Anti-pattern two: the 400-listing sprint. You clone one Canva file into every pastel color and every vague niche without changing the job. Three related pages for one person beat four hundred cousins. Bundles come after a single prints, not as a way to look like a catalog.

Anti-pattern three: the borrowed picture. A cartoon character, a lyric, a league logo, an illustration in the style of a living artist. You will sell a few. Then the shop goes down. Type and lines are enough.

The deal you keep

You sell a \$7 to \$12 single. After someone has printed it, you sell a \$19 bundle of three related pages for the same person. You keep the customer on an email list as soon as you can. You keep the how-to page on a site you own, even if Etsy is where the first twenty sales happen. You keep the right to update the file and send v1.1 to people who already paid.

You do not keep a fantasy of \$10,000 months from one floral planner. You keep a small catalog you can name in one breath, a print-tested PDF, and a Tuesday problem you actually understand. That is the deal. It pays.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you can sit in Canva for two hours and ship a one-page tool that a stranger can fill without a video. You do not need to be a designer. You need margins, a hierarchy (title, then fields, then a one-line instruction), and the patience to print a test copy on the cheapest paper in the house.

It also fits if you already do the job on Tuesdays. A booth renter who already tracks captions on a sticky note is a better designer for this file than a person who has never stood behind a chair. Nearness to the job beats taste.

Fits if

You can name one person and one Tuesday problem in one line. You will print the page at 100 percent, actual size, and fill it with a pen. You will photograph the filled page on a real table. You will send ten messages to people who do the job. You will write a personal-use license in the footer and mean it. You can live with \$9 as a first yes, wait to bundle until the single prints, leave faces and brands off the page, and ship v1.1 the same day a buyer writes.

Skip if

Skip generic aesthetic planners with no job. Skip trademarked characters. Skip 400 listings before one file prints. Skip this if you need rent this Friday — pair it with a paid week of work (path 7 or 12) and let printables compound. Skip this if you will not touch a printer. A page you have never printed is a screen decoration. One-stars start with clipped margins. Skip this if your only idea is a 2026 dated planner in five colors. That market is a landfill. Skip this if you want AI to draw the product. Labels and listing copy only. Skip this if you freeze at \$9 and want to start at \$27 with a 40-page book and no print test, or if you need the buyer on a call to explain a checkbox.

The honest middle

If you can design but do not know a job, shadow someone for a week or pick the job you already do. Watch what they write on a sticky note. That sticky note is the page. If you know the job but Canva scares you, use a simple table, 0.5 inch margins, two fonts, one color. Ugly and fillable

beats pretty and empty. If you have three pages and zero listings, list the single, not the three. If you have 80 listings and no print test, archive the clones. Print the one you would use tonight.

Skills and time

Canva or Google Docs. A printer, home or library. A phone camera. A listing on Etsy or Stan. Ten DMs. A model window for labels and listing copy, then a rewrite. That is the stack.

Time: one evening for the page, one evening for the filled example and print test, one evening for the listing and ten asks. First sale can land the same week. If it does not, the title is wrong or you never showed the filled page. Budget: \$0 if you already have Canva free or Docs, a way to print one test page, and a way to take \$9.

Two-minute self-test

Answer these out loud. If you stall on two of them, this is not your first path this week.

Who is the person, in a job title, not a vibe?

What do they do every Tuesday that a page would stop them guessing?

Can you fill the page with a real week without inventing columns?

Will you print it tonight at 100 percent, actual size?

Will you photograph the filled page on a real table, pen in the shot?

Will you ask ten humans, not 400 listings?

Can you leave faces, brands, and copyrighted characters off the page?

Five or more yeses. Start. Four or fewer: pick a closer job or skip this path.

The buyer on the other side

A tired person who already tried a pretty planner and quit in week two. They have a wall, a clip, a booth, a van. They will pay \$9 to stop guessing. They will judge you on whether the columns match the job, whether the checkbox takes a pen, and whether the print clipped. They will print page two, copy the pace, and fill page one next Tuesday. Design for them, not for a Pinterest board.

The offer, named in one sentence

The offer has four parts and none of them are a color palette.

Person: solo hairstylist, not creatives. Job: weekly content tracker, not planner. Format: one US Letter PDF, print-ready, with a filled example on page two. Price: \$9 for the single. The \$19 bundle of three related pages waits until the single has printed.

Fill this

A one-page [job] tracker for [person], print-ready, with a filled example, \$9.

If you need and to name the person, you have two products. Split them. If you need and to name the job, you have two pages. Sell the first one. The second one is a sibling, later.

Write the sentence at the top of the Canva file. Put a shortened version in the listing title. The title is search language, not a brand name. Weekly Content Tracker for Solo Hairstylists — Printable PDF is a title a tired stylist would type. Glow Up Studio Planner is a name you liked at midnight.

Sentences that work

Weekly content tracker for one-chair hairstylists. Print it. Fill it at the chair. \$9.

Opening-day checklist for a food-truck Saturday. One page. \$9.

Lesson-note template for tutors who run four sessions after school. One page per student. \$9.

Booth-renter tax envelope tracker. Twelve months on one page. \$9.

Van pack list for mobile dog groomers. Print, laminate, wipe. \$9.

Each sentence names a person and a repeating job. None of them name a palette. If your sentence needs a cartoon to make sense, you do not have an offer yet.

What they get

One US Letter PDF, print at 100 percent. A filled example so they are not staring at empty boxes. A one-line how-to in the footer. Personal use: print as many copies as they need for their own

chair. Not a commercial license to resell your layout.

They get a version number in the footer so v1.1 can exist. They get an email you will answer.

They get a refund sentence on the listing. They get a file named like a search, so they can find it in Downloads three Tuesdays from now.

What they do not get

An editable Canva link in v1. A commercial license. A dated 2026 planner. A matching Instagram theme. A community. A video course on how to use a checkbox. A bundle of three pages on day one. Faces, brands, or copyrighted characters. Lifetime updates you will not ship.

If they want editable, that is a later SKU with a written license and a higher price. If they want you to fill the week for them, that is a service, not a \$9 PDF. If they want a 10-page undated book, they can buy someone else's landfill. You sell one page that gets filled in.

Packaging

File name: Content-Tracker-Solo-Hairstylist.pdf — not FinalFinal3.pdf. Cover of the listing is the filled page on a real table, photographed with a phone, pen in the shot. Not a mockup of a MacBook in a sunbeam. Version number in the footer so you can send v1.1. The listing title is the search. Five bullets. Personal-use line. Refund sentence. Print-at-100-percent instruction. Do not write a brand story. The page is a tool. Sell the tool.

One page, then a bundle

V1 is the single. You may sketch two sibling pages in the same week so you know they exist: a caption-starter sheet, a monthly overview, a packing list, a close-down sheet. You do not list them. You do not zip them. You do not discount the single to make a bundle look generous.

After someone has printed the single — a buyer note, a photo, a question about a column — you build the two siblings, print-test both, and list the \$19 kit. Same person. Next obvious page. Same type, same margins. If nobody printed the single, you do not have a bundle problem. You have a title problem, or a photo problem, or a job that was a mood. Fix the single. Do not add pages to a page that does not print.

What done looks like

Done is someone prints the \$9 file. Not someone likes the listing. Not someone saves it to a board. A print. Ink on paper. If you cannot imagine that, you built a mood board.

That is the only done that matters in week 1. A pretty mockup and zero prints is a hobby. A filled page on a real table, listed, asked about, and printed by someone who is not you, is a product. Harper will know which one she has by Sunday. So will you.

Definition of done

The single is done when a stranger can fill Tuesday without you talking, the PDF prints at 100 percent without clipping, and at least one person who is not you has put ink on the page. Everything else is decoration.

Done also means the title is search language, the listing photo is the filled page on a real table, and you have sent ten messages. The bundle is a later done.

The done bar for the single

Person and Tuesday problem written in one line.

Title in search language, not a cute brand name.

One-page tool with 0.5 inch safe margin.

Filled example on page two with a real week.

Print test at 100 percent, actual size, no clipping.

Checkboxes at least 0.25 inch. Fill-in lines near-black.

License: your layout, your words, no trademarked characters, no generated faces or brands.

Table photo of the printed, filled page, pen in the shot.

Test-buy from a second email, file opens, file prints.

Ten messages to people who do the job.

Version number and an email in the footer.

If three of those are missing, you have a draft. Keep going. Do not list a draft and improve it with one-stars.

Fairness test

Hand the printed page to someone who does the job. Do not explain it. If they can fill Tuesday without you talking, you shipped. If they ask where the caption goes, the columns are wrong. Fix the page, not the listing copy.

Would you sell this to a tired friend who does that job, at \$9, without a speech? If you would apologize for the checkboxes or offer to walk them through, it is not fair yet. Fair means they can pin it next to the chair tonight. Fair means a refund in one sentence if the print clipped.

Technical done

PDF exports. Fonts outlined or standard. No Canva watermarks on the paid file. File name a tired person can find. Zip only later, for the bundle. Refund policy in one sentence on the listing. An email in the footer you will answer. Print instruction: 100 percent, actual size, not fit to page. Version number so v1.1 is a real file, not a guess.

Open the PDF on your phone. Open it on a desktop. Print a second copy after the export, not only the Canva print. Exports lie. Paper does not.

Not done yet

A Canva file you have not exported. A mockup with no print test. Forty pastel clones. A shop with a cute name and zero specific titles. A bundle listed before a single has printed. A generated illustration you could not defend to a lawyer. An editable link in a \$9 zip. Those are hobbies with an Etsy password. A listing with sales and no print is not done either — ask if they printed it. If they did not, the photo lied or the columns did not match the job.

Pricing that matches a printed page

\$7 to \$12 for a single. \$19 for three related pages. That is the window. \$9 and \$19 are home. Put the number on the listing. Do not hide it behind DM me.

The window

\$7 is the floor if you are nervous and the page is one simple checklist. \$9 is the default first printable: one page, a filled example, print-tested. \$12 is fair when the how-to exists and you have ten sales. Stay in the window on the first file. This is not a \$27 undated book. This is not a \$3 race to the bottom.

The bundle is \$19, and only after the single prints. Three related pages for the same person. Not five random pastels. Not a 10-page pack. Three. If you cannot name why the second and third pages belong next to the first, they do not belong in the zip.

Why not \$27 on day one

You have no proof, no how-to, no reviews. A \$9 page is an easy yes for a booth renter. A \$27 undated book is a maybe they will not finish. Raise the single to \$12 and the bundle to \$24 when the how-to exists and you have ten sales. Do not start there.

\$27 also trains you to overbuild. You will add quote pages and covers to justify the number. Then you have a planner. \$9 keeps you honest. One page. One job. One print test.

Worked dollars

Harper lists a \$9 tracker on Wednesday. Ten DMs. One public post of the filled page. Priya buys Friday and prints it at the salon. One more single on Saturday. \$18 before fees. Not rent. Proof. The single printed.

Week 2 she adds the two siblings, lists the \$19 bundle, and the next two buyers take the kit. Month one: 14 singles, 6 bundles = \$240 before fees. A list of 20 people who printed something. That list is the asset. The \$24 how-to on Stan in month two is how the asset pays a second time. \$9 is the door. The bundle is the room next door, after someone has walked in.

What not to do with price

Do not price a one-page grid at \$29 because you spent eight hours on flowers. Do not do \$3 to race to the bottom, or \$0 with a tip jar, or 14 upsells on the thank-you page. One single. After it prints, one bundle. A commercial license later, written, \$49 or more, only if someone asks twice.

Do not discount the single to \$5 because week 2 was quiet. Quiet is usually the title, the photo, or the ten asks you did not send. Do not price by hours. Eight hours of floral work does not make a \$29 product. It makes a \$9 product with a worse margin.

Refunds

Refund on request. Keep the policy to one sentence. A fight over \$9 costs more than \$9. If they could not print, that is your export. Fix the file, refund, send v1.1 to everyone.

If they wanted a service, refund and clarify the listing: this is a file, not a social media manager. Do not invent a commercial SKU in the refund email.

When to raise

After ten sales and a how-to page: \$12 single, \$24 bundle. After a commercial request twice: add that SKU, written, \$49 or more. Never raise by adding empty pages. Never raise because you got bored of \$9. Email v1.1 free to people who already paid \$9. Do not charge them again for a wider column.

The first 72 hours

Seventy-two hours is enough to list one page. It is not enough to build a shop. It is not enough to generate a catalog. One repeating job, one page that gets filled in, one print test, one table photo, ten asks. That is the whole window.

Hours 1-8: pick the job and sketch

Write the person and the Tuesday problem on a sticky note. One line. If it needs a slash, you have two people. Pick one. Sketch the columns on paper. If you cannot sketch it on a napkin, Canva will not save you.

Fill a sample week on the sketch with a real pen, from a real week you remember. If you have to invent columns to make the week fit, you are guessing the job. Shadow someone or pick a job you already do. Stop at hour 8 with a sticky note and a sketch you can fill. Do not open Canva until the sketch fills.

Hours 9-16: build the one page

Open Canva. US Letter. 0.5 inch margins. Title the job, not your brand. Fields a pen can hit. Checkboxes at least 0.25 inch. Black or near-black for fill-in lines. Light gray disappears on paper. Two fonts. One color besides black. Hierarchy: title, fields, one-line instruction in the footer.

Draft labels with AI if you want. Rewrite every label. Caption, not content pillar. Client first name, not persona. The model does not stand behind the chair. You do. Do not generate a border, a face, a logo, a character, or a floral. Type and lines.

Hours 17-24: fill, print, photograph

Fill page two with a real week. Invented data looks invented. Blur a name if you must. Keep the texture: the actual caption length, the actual yes/no on the photo, the actual Thursday that went sideways.

Print at 100 percent, actual size, not fit to page. Home printer or library. Fill it with the pen you actually own. If type hits the edge, fix the margin. If a checkbox is tiny, enlarge it. Print a second copy after the fix. This step is the product.

Photograph the filled page on a real table. Overhead, even light, pen in the shot. Phone camera. That photo is the listing image. Not a mockup generator. Not a MacBook in a sunbeam.

Hours 25-48: listing copy, license, export

Write the listing. Title in search language. First line that names the job. Five bullets. Personal-use line. Refund sentence. Print-at-100-percent instruction. Use AI for a first draft of the title and bullets if you want. Rewrite until it sounds like a person who does the job, not a listing template.

Footer of the PDF: personal use, print for your own chair, no reselling the PDF, your email, version number (v1.0, date). No trademarked characters anywhere. No generated faces. No brand marks.

Export PDF. Name the file like a search: Content-Tracker-Solo-Hairstylist.pdf. Open it on your phone. Print a copy of the export. If anything clips, fix the margin before you list. Confirm there

is no Canva watermark on the paid file. You may sketch two sibling pages in a private file. You do not list them. The bundle waits.

Hours 49-72: test-buy, ten messages, one post

Test-buy from a second email. Etsy or Stan, whichever you listed on. File arrives. File opens. File prints. If the download fails, nothing else matters. Fix it before you send a single ask.

Then ten messages to people who do the job. Not a broadcast. I made a one-page tracker for [job] because I was tired of sticky notes. You do this every week. If it is useless, tell me. If it is useful, it is \$9. [link]. One public post of the filled page, not the empty grid. Ask for a reply, not a follow.

Do not run Etsy ads. Do not clone the file into 40 colors. Do not list the bundle. If someone asks a question that means the columns are wrong, that fix is v1.1, and it belongs after a human has used the page.

What you do not do in 72 hours

You do not name a shop with a pun. You do not generate 12 pastel clones, buy a mockup pack, stretch Letter to A4, or prompt a cute mascot. One page. One listing. Ten asks. A print. That is a good 72 hours.

The path, step by step

Twelve steps. Stop at the one you have not done. Do not skip the print test. Do not skip the ten asks. Do not jump to the bundle.

Step 1. Name the person and the Tuesday problem

One line. Solo hairstylist who never knows what to post this week. If the line needs a slash, you have two people. Pick one. Write it on a sticky note. Put the sticky note at the top of the Canva file. Search language starts here: the person and the job will become the listing title.

Step 2. Sketch one page that gets filled in

Columns on paper. Idea, photo, caption, posted is a tracker. Pack, check, done is a list. If you cannot fill a sample week without inventing a column, you are guessing the job. The sticky note they already use is a better product than a Pinterest grid.

Step 3. Build the page in Canva

US Letter. 0.5 inch safe margin. Hierarchy: title, fields, one-line instruction. Two fonts, one color besides black. Checkboxes a pen can hit, at least 0.25 inch. Fill-in lines near-black. Draft labels with AI if you want. Rewrite every label in the language of the job. Do not generate faces, brands, characters, or a floral you saw on a bestseller. Type and lines.

Step 4. Fill page two with a real week

Blur a name if you must. Keep the texture. Empty grids do not sell. Filled grids sell. If you cannot fill a real week, you do not know the job yet. Do the job once this week, capture as you go, then fill the page. Invented data photographs like invented data.

Step 5. Print test at home at 100 percent

Actual size, not fit to page. Home printer or library. Fill it with a pen. If type hits the edge, fix the margin. If a checkbox is tiny, enlarge it. Print a second copy after the fix. Do not list before this.

Step 6. Photograph the filled page on a real table

Phone camera. Overhead, even light, pen in the frame. That photo is the listing. A lifestyle mockup is optional and later. Do not use a mockup generator as the only image. Buyers are shopping for a page they will put on a table. Show them a table.

Step 7. Write the listing title like a search

Weekly Content Tracker for Solo Hairstylists — Printable PDF. First line names the job. Five bullets. Personal-use line. Refund sentence. Print-at-100-percent instruction. AI can draft this. You rewrite it. If you delete every adjective (cute, aesthetic, glow), the title should still name a person and a job. If it does not, it is a mood board.

Step 8. License, export, test-buy

Footer: personal use, print for your own chair, no reselling the PDF, your email, version number. Your layout, your words. No trademarked characters, generated faces, or brands. Export PDF. Filename like a search. Test-buy from a second inbox. Open. Print. No Canva watermark. If the download fails, fix that before a single ask.

Step 9. List the \$9 single

Etsy if nobody knows you. Stan or Stripe on a page you own, same file. Both, aisle first, if you have no traffic. Price \$7 to \$12, default \$9. One listing. One photo of the filled page. Do not list the bundle. Do not list five colors. Do not run ads.

Step 10. Send ten messages and one public post

Ten people who do the job. Personal notes, not a blast. One public post of the filled page, not the empty grid. First sale is allowed to be someone you know. Ask if they printed it. Printed is the metric.

Step 11. Ship v1.1 after the first buyer note

If two people ask where a column is, or one person who used it says the posted column is too narrow, you move the column. Export. Bump the footer to v1.1, date. Email everyone who already paid. Do not take it personally. That note is the product improving. A one-star is what you get if you ignore it.

Step 12. Bundle only after a single prints

Someone printed the \$9 file. Then two sibling pages for the same person. Same type, same margins, same print test, same filled examples. \$19 for three related pages. Do not invent a new niche. After ten sales or 21 days, decide one change: title, columns, or the filled photo. Fix the one that prints, not a catalog that does not.

Worked example: Harper and the hairstylist tracker

Harper cuts hair two days a week and hates posting. She already fills a sticky note with this week's ideas: a before-and-after, a product she actually used, a Friday hours reminder. That sticky note is the product. She needs it to stop ripping.

Harper, the sticky note, the chair

The person is a one-chair stylist. The Tuesday problem is what to post this week. Harper copies the columns off her own note: idea, photo (yes/no), caption draft, posted (date), what happened. Five columns. One week. A title at the top. A one-line footer: Fill this on Monday. Pin it at the chair. Take the photo before you wash the color out.

She almost titled the file Glow Up Content Planner 2026. She wrote that on a scrap, looked at it, and crossed it out. Nobody at the chair searches for glow up. They search for what to post, hairstylist, weekly. Search language. She wrote Weekly Content Tracker for Solo Hairstylists on the next scrap and kept it.

What she shipped

A one-page weekly content tracker for one-chair hairstylists. Page two: her own week, filled, with a blur on a client first name. The Thursday caption was too long and she wrote too long in the what-happened column. That texture is why Priya believed it.

She did not ship the bundle on day one. She sketched a 12-caption-starter page in salon language and a monthly overview, then closed the file. The single had to print first.

She printed the tracker on the library printer for \$0.20. Photographed it on the break table with a black pen. Listed on Etsy Wednesday night. Title: Weekly Content Tracker for Solo Hairstylists — Printable PDF. First line: Stop guessing what to post this week. One page. Print it. Fill it at the chair. Price: \$9. No ads. No pastel clones.

The 72 hours

Wednesday 7pm: sticky note, napkin sketch, a real week filled on paper. Wednesday 9pm: Canva. Two fonts. Near-black lines. Labels drafted by a model, rewritten: Caption, not Content pillar. Thursday lunch: print test at the library. Checkbox too small. Enlarged. Printed again.

Thursday night: filled page two, photo on the break table, listing, test-buy from her other email. The PDF opened. The export printed.

Friday: ten DMs to stylists she actually knows, plus one post in a booth-renter group she had helped in. The post was the filled page, not the empty grid. The caption was the first line of the listing, plus \$9. No floral mockup. No I am so excited to share.

What happened, with dollars

Friday 4pm: a stylist named Priya buys the \$9. Saturday morning Priya texts a photo of the page taped next to her mirror, two boxes already filled. That photo is the whole business. Someone printed it. It is a product, not a hobby.

Saturday: one more single from a woman in the same group. \$18 before fees. Harper's first-week cash is small. Harper's first-week fact is large: ink on paper in a salon that is not hers.

She does not list the bundle on Saturday. She waits. Priya's photo is the green light, not a feeling.

What almost broke it

She almost used a floral Canva template that ate the margins. The library print saved her. The first test clipped the footer. She pulled the grid in, killed the flowers, printed again. She almost listed before printing, because the screen looked fine. The printer is the editor. She almost generated a cute scissors illustration in the style of a popular artist she follows. She deleted the prompt. Type and lines. She almost sent a broadcast to 80 people. She sent ten notes instead. Priya was number four.

v1.1 after Priya's note

Sunday night Priya emails: the posted column is too narrow for a date. Harper widens it, shortens the what-happened column by a hair, exports v1.1, emails both buyers. Subject: your tracker, slightly less annoying. That is quality. That is also how you do not get a one-star.

The listing photo stays the original break-table shot. The file behind the listing is v1.1. She does not remake the brand. She moves a column.

Monday she builds the two sibling pages she had sketched. Caption-starter sheet: 12 first lines in salon language. Monthly overview: four weeks, same columns, smaller. Print-tests both. Fills both with a real month. Lists the \$19 bundle Tuesday of week 2. Title: Hairstylist Content Kit — Weekly Tracker + Captions + Monthly Overview. The next two buyers take the kit.

Ninety days, and the product-or-hobby test

41 sales. 19 of them bundles. A \$24 how-to on her own Stan page that Etsy never sees. An email list of 28 people who printed something. Not a brand empire. A Tuesday product that prints. Harper still cuts hair. The files pay for the software and a Friday off.

The test she uses, and the test you should use this week: did someone print it? Priya printed it. Then 40 other people printed it. That is a product. A pretty mockup and zero prints would have been a hobby. Harper would have known by Sunday of week 1 either way. She listed one tracker. That is how you know.

Copy you can paste

Swap the job. Keep the constraints. Do not add hype. Fill the brackets. Send. The listing title is search language. The post is the filled page. The DM is one job, one price, one link.

Listing title

Weekly Content Tracker for Solo Hairstylists — Printable PDF

Other titles in the same shape:

Opening Day Checklist for Food Truck Saturdays — Printable PDF

Lesson Notes for After-School Tutors — One Page Printable

Van Pack List for Mobile Dog Groomers — Printable PDF

If you delete Printable PDF and the title still names a person and a job, you are close. If what remains is Studio Planner 2026, start over.

Listing first line and bullets

Stop guessing what to post this week. One page. Print it. Fill it at the chair. A filled example is on page two.

One US Letter PDF, print at home at 100 percent, actual size

Built for one-chair stylists, not agencies

Columns for idea, photo, caption, posted

Includes a filled example so you are not staring at empty boxes

Personal use. Print as many copies as you need for your own chair

Bundle title (only after the single prints)

Hairstylist Content Kit — Weekly Tracker + Captions + Monthly Overview

First line for the bundle: Three pages for the same chair. The weekly tracker you may already have, plus a caption-starter sheet and a monthly overview. \$19.

Post (filled page, not a mood)

I printed the page I actually use at the chair. One week of posts, no guessing. \$9. Link in comments. If you want the empty floral version, this is not that.

DM to ten people who do the job

I made a one-page tracker for [job] because I was tired of sticky notes. You do this every week. If it is useless, tell me. If it is useful, it is \$9. [link]

Checkout blurb

\$9 for the tracker. Personal use. Refund if you ask. Print at 100 percent, actual size. Page two is a filled week so you can see the pace.

Note after purchase

Your file: [link]. Print at 100 percent, actual size. Page two is a filled week so you can see the pace. If a column is wrong for your chair, reply. I update these.

Follow-up, same thread: Did you print it? If a column fought you, tell me which one. I will fix the file for everyone. That question is how v1.1 happens.

Refund reply

Done. Refunded. If the print clipped, that is on me — tell me the printer and I will fix the margin for everyone.

Replies: editable, or a team license

V1 is a locked PDF you print. Editable Canva is a different file, a different license, and a different price. I do not include it in the \$9 zip. If two people ask, I will list it as a \$24 upgrade. Until then, print it.

Personal use: your chair, your copies. Not a license to resell the PDF or to hand it to a staff of twelve as your product. If you need commercial rights, that is a separate SKU with a written sentence, and it is not \$9. If that SKU does not exist yet, it does not exist. I will refund you if you bought thinking it did.

What you do not write

Cute planner magic. Boss babe. Unlimited commercial license in a \$9 file. A promise it will grow your Instagram. Generated-art language. In the style of. A brand story. A countdown. The page is a tool. Sell the tool.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Assume evenings. This is four weeks to a printed page and, if it earns it, a bundle. No 400-listing sprint. No ads in week 1. No public launch party.

Week 1, day by day

Monday: person, problem, napkin sketch. Fill a sample week on paper. Do not open Canva if the sketch will not fill.

Tuesday: one page in Canva. Labels rewritten. No generated art. Stop at a page you would pin next to your own chair.

Wednesday: filled example, print test at 100 percent, photo on a real table. If it clips, fix and print again. Listing title in search language. Export. Test-buy from a second email.

Thursday and Friday: ten DMs and one public post of the filled page. First sale is allowed to be someone you know. Ask if they printed it.

Saturday and Sunday: answer humans. Do not clone colors. Do not list a bundle. Do not run ads. If someone printed it, you have a product. If nobody printed it, you have a hobby with a listing. Either way, you will know.

Week 2: v1.1 and, only if it printed, the bundle

Answer every question like a person. If two people trip on the same column, or one person who used it sends a note, ship v1.1. Email everyone who paid. Count prints and questions, not listing views.

If someone printed the single, build the two sibling pages. Same person. Next job. Print-test both. Filled examples. List the \$19 bundle. One more share in the same room.

If nobody printed it, do not build the bundle. Change the title to search language. Replace the listing image with the filled page if you used a mockup. Send ten new asks. The job in the title is usually the problem, not the prose.

Start the how-to draft this week either way. A few paragraphs on the same job, on a page you own. This is how Etsy buyers become a list.

Week 3: teach the page, do not add a catalog

One post or email that teaches one column. Soft link. Example: the what-happened column is where you write too long, not where you perform. If you are not public, send three more personal messages instead of posts.

Invite Etsy buyers off the aisle with a next page is on my list line inside the PDF, if you have sales. If you have no sales, still do not add 40 listings. One job. One title. Ten more asks.

Week 4: decide, do not sprawl

Decide: same person, next Tuesday problem, or stop. A second job is allowed after the first has a how-to and a handful of sales. Same grid, new language, new filled week, new print test.

Default: week 4, not day 2. If nothing moved in 21 days of honest asks, quit the title, not by opening a second shop.

After

A small catalog you can name in one breath. Monthly v1.x if a column dates. That is maintenance. The path is not a 400-listing factory. The how-to page, the list, and the next related page for the same person are the compounding. Pretty clones are not.

The quality bar

Quality is a page a tired person can fill at the chair without you in the room, printed at 100 percent, no clip, no tiny checkbox, no light-gray line that vanished. Taste is optional. Fillable is not.

Specs that keep you out of one-star land

Black (or near-black) for all fill-in lines. Light gray disappears on paper.

Checkboxes at least 0.25 inch. Pens are thicker than cursors.

0.5 inch safe margin. Printers eat edges.

Print at 100 percent, actual size, in the listing instructions.

Fonts large enough to read at arm's length on a wall.

No watermarks on the file they paid for. Previews may be marked. The product may not.

Version number and an email in the footer.

Filename a tired person can find.

If you skip the print test, you are guessing every one of these. Paper is the review you give yourself.

The filled page is the quality

Empty pretty is below-bar. Filled, printed, photographed on a real table is above-bar. If you would not pin your own page next to the chair, do not list it.

Page two is not a decoration. It is the instruction manual. A stranger copies the page. If page two is fake-clean — every caption perfect, every box ticked — it reads as a mood board. Keep one Thursday that went sideways.

What you do not generate

No faces. No children. No celebrities. No brand marks. No league logos. No cartoon characters. No lyrics. No in the style of a living artist. No recreation of a bestseller's floral. AI is for labels and listing copy, rewritten. The shop's name is attached to the file. Type and lines do not get you a takedown. A generated princess in a salon does.

If the page needs a drawing to work, the page is the wrong product. Pick a different Tuesday problem.

Canva Pro photos are not yours to sell unless the license says they are. When unsure, do not. Your type is enough.

Test 1: the napkin test

Columns make sense on paper before Canva. If you cannot fill a week on a napkin, you cannot fill it in a PDF.

Test 2: the print test

100 percent, actual size, home or library. No clip. Checkbox takes a pen. Lines are visible. Do this on the export, not only inside Canva.

Test 3: the stranger test

Someone who does the job fills it without you talking. If they ask where the caption goes, the columns are wrong. Fix the page.

Test 4: the table-photo test

The listing image is the filled page on a real table, pen in the shot, taken with a phone. If the only image is a mockup, you are not ready.

Test 5: the quiet-title test

Delete every adjective (cute, aesthetic, glow, magic, undated). The title should still name a person and a job. If it does not, it is a mood board.

License

Your layout, your words, no trademarked characters, no generated faces or brands, no Canva Pro photos you do not have the right to sell. Personal use in the footer. Commercial only as a separate SKU with a written sentence, \$49 or more, only after someone asks twice. Editable Canva is a later SKU, not a free extra in the \$9 zip.

What to measure

Vanity is listing views. Money is conversion and refunds. The only week-1 metric that tells you the truth is a print. Someone put ink on the page, or they did not. Hearts on Etsy cannot tell you that.

Count these

Print tests you did yourself (yes/no, 100 percent, actual size).

Listing live, title in search language, photo of the filled page on a table.

Ten asks sent.

Sales of the \$9 single.

Prints: ask Did you print it? A sale that never prints is a soft no.

Questions that mean the columns are wrong.

v1.1 shipped (yes/no).

Bundle listed only after a print (yes/no).

Refunds, with a one-word reason (clipped, wanted-editable, wanted-a-service, never-opened).

Week 1

Listings live: one. Print tests done. Ten asks sent. Sales. Questions. Prints. If you have a pretty mockup and zero prints, you have a hobby. Write that down. Do not soothe it with a second listing.

Day 30

Conversion rate on the listing (a few percent is real). Refunds (over 10 percent means the photo lied or the print clipped). Emails captured. Bundle attach rate, if the bundle exists (if nobody takes the \$19, the siblings are not related). v1.1 sent. How-to draft started.

A healthy day-30: one job, one single that has printed, a v1.1 if anyone tripped, a bundle only if the single printed, 0 to 1 refunds you already fixed. A shop with 80 listings and \$40 is the anti-pattern. Keep the three that print.

Day 90

A catalog you can name in one breath. A how-to that ranks or an email list. Repeat buyers. Cash in the \$7 to \$12 and \$19 window, totaled. If you have 400 listings and \$40, you ran the anti-pattern. If you have \$0, the failure is usually title, unsent asks, or a photo of an empty grid. It is rarely the market.

Ignore these

Hearts on Etsy. Pinterest impressions. Follower count. Time in Canva. How many fonts you tried. How many pastel clones you could make. Mockup-generator output. A shop that looks busy. Pending Etsy ads.

Spreadsheet

One line a week is enough:

date | title | source | \$9 or \$19 | printed (y/n) | refund | question | email captured | version

If the printed column is always empty, you are not asking. Ask. If the question column repeats the same column name, that is v1.1, this week, not a new listing.

Objections you will hear

You will hear these from yourself first. Then from a friend who sells 400 listings. Then from a buyer who wanted a different product. Answer them once, in this file, so you do not argue them in a comment.

Etsy is too saturated

Shops with huge catalogs still win on the specific titles, not the pile. Weekly content tracker for solo hairstylists is not competing with cute planner 2026. It is competing with a sticky note. Saturation is what people say when they do not want to pick a job.

I cannot draw

Good. Type, lines, two colors. The job is the art. A drawing you generated is a liability. A checkbox a pen can hit is a product.

I need 400 listings to get traffic

You need one title a human would search and ten asks. 400 listings is how you hide a bad page. Traffic to a mood board is still a hobby. One print is a business.

People want editable Canva

Some do. That is a later SKU with a license. V1 is a locked PDF they print. Editable is support, versioning, and people breaking your grid. Charge more, later. Do not include it in the \$9 zip because you are afraid of a no.

AI should generate the art

Not for a file you sell. Labels and listing copy, rewritten. Not stolen styles. Not a character. Not a face. Not a brand. Your shop's name is attached. If the page needs a drawing to work, pick a different page.

\$9 is too cheap to bother

\$9 is a yes. The bundle and the list are the business. A \$47 empty planner is a no. You are not too good for a printed page. You are too early for a \$27 book.

I will run ads on day one

Not in week 1. Ten asks and a specific title first. Ads on a generic planner light money on fire. Ads on a title nobody would search do the same. Prove a print organically. Then, maybe, a small ad on that exact title.

US Letter is wrong for my country

Sell the size your person prints. Default: one size you have printed, then the other when a buyer asks twice. Do not stretch Letter to A4. Rebuild the margin. A stretched grid is a one-star about clipping, written in a different paper size.

Nobody will pay for a PDF they could make in Canva

They could. They will not, on a Tuesday at 10pm, when they need the columns to already exist. They are paying to skip the guessing. If they already have a page they like, they should not buy.

I should wait until I have a shop name and a brand kit

You should wait until the page prints. A shop name is not a product. Harper listed under her own name and a search title. The brand kit can wait until someone who is not you has ink on the page.

What this path feeds next

Printables are a front door, not a dead end. Cheap files make a list. The list buys a playbook (path 1), a skill pack (path 2), a live drop (path 17), or a how-to you host. Do not open every door this month. Get a print first.

Upstream: what you need before this

You need a job you understand. You do not need a following. You do not need a playbook first, but a playbook makes the how-to easy. You need a printer, a phone, and ten names. If you have never done the job, do not invent the columns. Shadow, or pick the job you already do, or skip this path for a service week and come back with scars.

Downstream: the same person, the next product

How-to page / newsletter (path 5) for the same person. The next page is on my list line inside the PDF is the move off Etsy.

Templates and SOPs (path 6) if they want the digital version of the same job: a Notion or Sheet that does what the paper did.

Productized service (path 7) when they ask you to fill the week for them. That is a different number. Do not hide it inside \$9.

Membership (path 14) only after they already print your pages and come back. A membership for people who never printed the \$9 file is a chat you will resent.

The how-to is the real second product

After the single prints, write the how-to on a site you own. How I fill the Monday page at the chair. Four hundred words. One photo of the filled page. A link to the \$9 file and, if it exists, the \$19 bundle. Etsy does not own that page. The list that page builds is the asset the aisle cannot take.

Harper's \$24 how-to on Stan is this. Etsy never saw it. The 28 people who printed something did.

Services that grow out of a page that prints

If two buyers ask you to fill the week, you have a productized service: a Monday caption pack, delivered as a filled page. Price it as work, not as a file. Custom layout is a small project, quoted,

not a \$5 tweak. Do not take custom in week 1.

Never

A replica of someone else's planner catalog. A shop of trademarked characters. A funnel that withholds the PDF until they sit through a webinar. A second niche on day 2. Generated art so the listing looks like a brand. The next path is the one the people who printed the page asked for.

Mistakes that kill this path

These are not personality flaws. They are skips. Each one has a recovery you can do this week.

1. Generic aesthetic planners with no job

Recovery this week: rename to a person plus a Tuesday. Rebuild columns from a sticky note a real human uses. Kill the quote about blooming.

2. Trademarked characters, generated faces, borrowed brands

Recovery this week: delete the listing today. Keep type and lines. If you already sold a few, refund, take it down, do not argue with the platform. The shop's name is attached.

3. 400 listings before one file prints

Recovery this week: archive the clones. Print-test the one you would use. List that one. Send ten asks. Do not unarchive anything until that one prints.

4. Listing photo of an empty pretty grid

Recovery this week: fill it, print it, photograph it on a real table tonight, pen in the shot. Replace the listing image before you send another ask.

5. Light gray lines and tiny checkboxes

Recovery this week: black lines. Checkboxes at least 0.25 inch. Re-export. Print. Email v1.1 to anyone who already paid.

6. Fit to page in the instructions

Recovery this week: write 100 percent, actual size. If they already clipped, refund, fix the margin, send the new file.

7. Bundling before a single prints

Recovery this week: unlist the bundle. Leave the \$9 single. Ask the buyers if they printed it. Build siblings only after a yes.

8. Editable link in a \$9 zip

Recovery this week: lock v1. Remove the Canva link. Sell editable later, written license, higher price. Email the people who got the link and tell them personal use still holds.

9. Canva Pro photos, watermarks, ads on day one, or FinalFinal3.pdf

Recovery this week: remove photos you cannot sell. Confirm the export has no watermark. Pause the ads. Ten asks. Specific title. Rename the file like a search. Test-buy so the new name is what they download. Your type is enough.

10. Skipping the print test, or ignoring the first buyer note

Recovery this week: library printer, tonight. 100 percent, actual size. Fix what clips. Add an email and a version number to the footer. Answer the note. Ship v1.1. The screen always looks fine. A one-star is what you get if the posted column stays too narrow and you never hear it.

Someone prints the \$9 file. That is the path. A pretty mockup and zero prints is a hobby. Fix toward a print. Do not fix toward a catalog.

Tools — only what you need

Canva, a home or library printer, a phone for the mockup, Stan or Etsy, AI for labels and listing copy — not for stolen art. That is the stack. Everything else is delay.

Design

Canva free is enough. US Letter. 0.5 inch margins. Two fonts. One color besides black. Google Docs with a table is the \$0 path. InDesign is not required. You are making a page a pen can hit, not a brand system.

Export PDF. Open it on a phone. Print the export. If the font is tiny or the checkbox collapsed, fix the file, export again.

Print

Any printer. Library is allowed. 100 percent, actual size. One test page is cheaper than one one-star. Print the sketch, print the Canva draft, print the export. Paper is the editor. If you do not have a printer at home, the library is the tool.

Selling

Etsy for the aisle. Stan or Stripe Payment Link for a page you own. Both, aisle first, if nobody knows you. After the first twenty sales, invite them off Etsy with a next page is on my list line inside the PDF. Do not wait for a full site. A Stan page whose title matches the listing is enough.

AI, used narrowly

One model window you already use. Labels. Listing title. Five bullets. Footer how-to. Alternate column names. Then you rewrite. You do not generate faces, brands, copyrighted characters, or florals in the style of anyone. You do not ask it for a 400-listing plan. You do not ship the first draft of the listing.

Delivery and the second email

The platform's download. Test from a second email. Do not gate the PDF behind a webinar. Create the second email before you list. Buy your own product. If the download never arrives, fix that before you send a single ask.

Do not add yet

A mockup generator subscription. A trademark lawyer for a cute name. A 400-listing uploader. Ads. A course on Etsy SEO. Pinterest management software. Canva Pro so you can delay the print

test. A mascot. An A4 version you have not rebuilt. An editable SKU. A commercial SKU. Those wait until a stranger has printed the \$9 file.

The \$0 path

Google Docs table. 0.5 inch margins. Library print. Phone photo on a real table. Stripe Payment Link or Stan if you already have it. Ten DMs. A free-tier model for labels, rewritten. That can produce the first \$9 without Etsy. You do not need a new laptop.

Setup order

Sticky note. Napkin sketch, filled. Canva or Docs, one page. Labels rewritten. Filled page two. Print test. Table photo. Listing title in search language. Footer license and version. Export. Filename like a search. Checkout. Test-buy from a second email. Ten asks. v1.1 after a human note. Bundle only after a print. Do not reorder this to put the shop name first.

Checklist

Print this. Tick it with a pen. If a line is unchecked, that is the next evening. Do not list a draft.

Before you open Canva

- Person and Tuesday problem written in one line
- Napkin sketch of one page that gets filled in
- A sample week filled on the sketch without inventing columns
- You would pin this next to your own chair
- No faces, brands, or copyrighted characters in the plan

Before you list

- One-page tool in Canva (or a Docs table) with 0.5 inch safe margin
- Title in search language, not a cute brand name
- Labels rewritten in the language of the job

Filled example on page two with a real week

Print test at 100 percent, actual size, no clipping

Checkboxes at least 0.25 inch

Fill-in lines near-black, not light gray

Table photo of the printed, filled page, pen in the shot

License: your layout, your words, no trademarked characters

File named like a search, not FinalFinal3.pdf

Version number and an email in the footer

No Canva watermark on the paid file

No generated art, no Canva Pro photos you cannot sell

Before you send ten asks

Test-buy from a second email, file opens, file prints

Listing first line names the job

Five bullets, personal-use line, refund sentence

Print at 100 percent, actual size, in the instructions

Price \$7 to \$12, default \$9, on the page

Ten names written down

Bundle is not listed yet

After the first sale

Ask: did you print it? Which column fought you?

v1.1 if a column is wrong, emailed to everyone who paid

How-to page started, even as a draft, aimed at the same job

Bundle of two sibling pages only after a single prints

Spreadsheet: date, title, \$9 or \$19, printed, refund, question

You still would pin this page next to your own chair

Stop-doing

No ads until a specific title converts

No 400 pastel clones

Commercial license is a separate SKU or does not exist yet

A4 only after someone asks twice, rebuilt, not stretched

Do not list the bundle because week 2 felt quiet

FAQ

Do I start on Etsy or on my own site?

If nobody knows you, Etsy is the aisle. List the \$9 single, and put the same file on a Stan or Stripe page. After the first twenty sales, invite them off Etsy with a next page is on my list line inside the PDF. Default: both, aisle first. Do not wait for a full site to list the page.

US Letter or A4?

Sell the size your person prints. US-heavy jobs: Letter first, A4 as a second file if you can keep the grid honest. Do not stretch Letter to A4. Rebuild the margin. Default: one size you have printed, then the other when a buyer asks twice.

Can I sell a fillable PDF they type in?

Yes, later. V1 is print. Fillable fields break on half the phones people open Etsy on. If you add fillable, keep a print version in the zip. Default: print only until someone asks twice.

How many listings before I quit?

One job, one single, ten asks, one how-to draft. Give that 21 days. If nothing moved, the job in the title is wrong or you never showed the filled page. Quit the title, not by opening listing forty. Default: do not add the bundle until the single prints.

What about commercial licenses for other sellers?

A separate SKU, written, \$49 or more, only after someone asks twice. Do not bundle commercial rights into \$9. Default: personal use only.

Is a wall print a printable in this path?

If they will pin it and use it, yes. If it is a quote about blooming, no. Default: a tool they fill, then a wall version of the same job if it earns it.

Should I watermark the preview?

The listing image is the filled page on a real table. You may mark a preview PDF. Never mark the file they paid for. Default: photo of the print, unpaid file clean.

What do I do when a buyer wants a custom version?

Quote a custom as a small project (path 20 or 7), not as a \$5 tweak. Default: no custom in week 1. A second SKU if two people ask for the same change. v1.1 is a fix for everyone, not a custom for one.

Can I use Canva Pro photos, or AI images, in a file I sell?

Read Canva's license. When unsure, do not. Type and lines do not get you a takedown. Do not generate faces, brands, or copyrighted characters. Do not prompt in the style of a living artist. Default: no stock photos and no generated art in v1.

How do I handle refunds?

Refund if they ask. Fix the file if the print clipped. One sentence on the listing. Default: refund, then v1.1 to everyone. A fight over \$9 costs more than \$9.

Should I run Etsy ads?

Not in week 1. Ten asks and a specific title first. Default: organic plus DMs until you have a conversion and a print. Ads on a generic planner light money on fire.

When do I add a second person, or a bundle?

Bundle: after the first single has printed, two sibling pages for the same person, \$19. Second person: after the first job has a how-to and a handful of sales, or after 21 days of honest asks. Same grid, new language, new filled week, new print test. Default: week 4 for a second person. No bundle on day 1.

Can I sell the same file on Etsy and on my site?

Yes. Same PDF. Different customers. Keep the version number in the footer so you update both. Default: both, aisle first.

How do I price a 10-page pack?

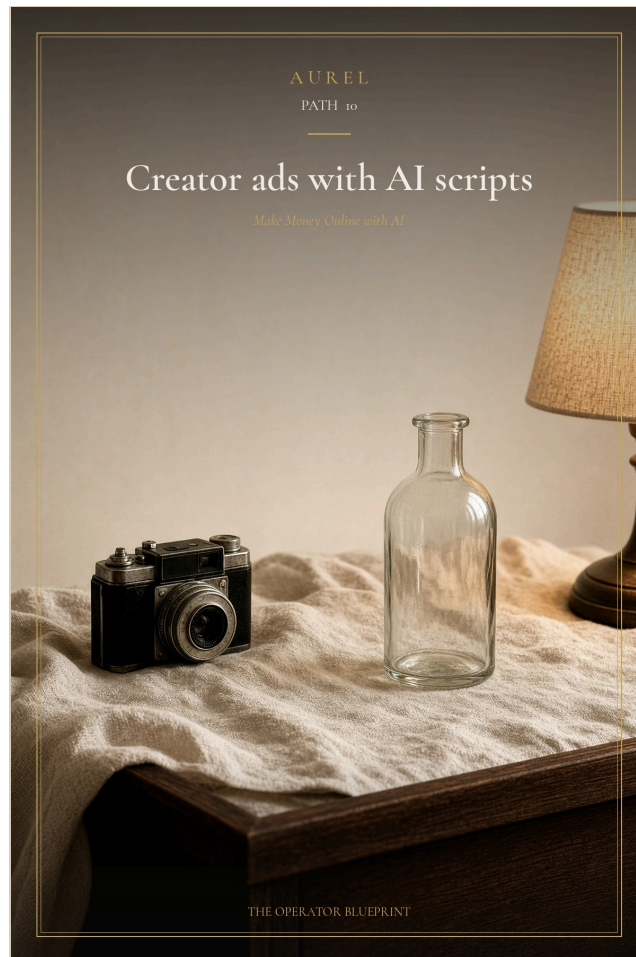
Do not, on day one. Three related pages at \$19 is the pack, and only after the single prints. A 10-page undated book slides you back into generic planner land. Default: one page, one job, then three pages for the same job.

What if I hate Canva?

Google Docs, a table, 0.5 inch margins, export PDF. Ugly and fillable beats pretty and empty. Default: the tool you will actually open tonight.

How do I know if this is a product or a hobby?

Someone printed it, or they did not. A pretty mockup and zero prints is a hobby. A filled page on a real table, listed, asked about, and printed by someone who is not you, is a product. List one tracker this week. You will know by Sunday. Default: believe the print, not the mockup.



PATH 10

Creator ads with AI scripts

Brands need simple product videos. You do not need to be famous. You need to be clear.

39 minute read · 8,655 words

Who this is for

You are comfortable on camera. You can hold a product and talk.

Time to first

7–21 days

Tools

First sale

One paid brief for two videos.

Cash window

\$150–\$800 for a first two-video pack

Leave this alone

Phone, CapCut, a rate card, AI for script outlines only. Working for exposure. Promising virality.

What you are selling

Definition

UGC-style ads are not influencer fame. They are short product videos a brand can run as ads or organic posts. Demo, list, stitch, talking-head. Fifteen to thirty seconds. Vertical. You on camera, product in hand, a sentence a person would actually say in a store aisle.

The buyer is a small brand that cannot hire a studio and does not want another polished TV spot. They want a video that looks like a customer. You are that customer, on purpose, with a script you can say without blinking at a teleprompter.

AI drafts the script outline. You throw away anything you would not say out loud to a friend while chopping onions. If the model writes a line about a revolutionary garlic press transforming your weeknight ritual, that line dies. I used to smash garlic with a knife and a prayer. This thing takes four seconds. That stays.

You do not need to be famous. You need to be clear. A sample ad for a product already on your shelf is your portfolio. Two samples beat a nine-page media kit with follower screenshots. Brands who pay \$400 for two videos are not buying your audience. They are buying files they can load into Ads Manager this week.

What this is not

This is not a promise that the ad will go viral. You cannot promise that. Anyone who asks you to guarantee ROAS on day one is asking you to lie or to become their media buyer. You are the creator of the asset. Media buying is a second package, later, if you even want it.

This is not working for exposure, free product, or we will tag you. Free product is not a brief. A paid pack is a brief. If you want the product, buy it and film a sample. Then send the invoice path, not the barter path.

This is not a faceless slideshow with stock clips and an AI voice. Brands hiring this path want a person holding the thing. Faceless ads exist. They are a different product. Do not mix them on the same rate card. This is also not a retainer on day one. Two videos. One pack. A date.

Why this works now

Small brands still need ads that look like a person. Studio spots feel like 2014. Influencer retainers feel like a second rent. A \$400 two-video pack sits in the gap: cheap enough to expense, specific enough to run this week. Warm email to a brand you already buy from still cuts through marketplace \$50 videos. You are not bidding. You are a customer with a camera and a deadline.

AI collapsed the outline cost. Hook, problem, demo, proof, ask used to take an hour of staring. Now it takes ten minutes plus a rewrite in your mouth. The rewrite is the work. If you ship the model's sentences, you will sound like every other creator they already tried. Phones are good enough. 1080p vertical, a window, captions. The quality bar moved from cinematic to clear.

Three anti-patterns

Anti-pattern one: the fame pitch. You lead with follower counts, a media kit, and a promise that this will blow up. The brand wanted files. You sold a lottery ticket. They either decline or they hire you and then blame you when the ad does not print money. Sell the files. Leave the lottery.

Anti-pattern two: the marketplace race. You wait for a platform to send brands. You bid \$75 against people who will do it for \$40. You learn to work cheap and stay quiet. Five emails to brands you already use is the channel until you have cases.

Anti-pattern three: the hostage script. You read the AI outline word for word, eyes flicking off camera, mouth in a shape no human uses in a kitchen. Rewrite until you can say it while walking to the sink. If you stumble, the line is too long. Cut it.

The deal you keep

You keep two sample ads in one niche, a \$400 pack on a page, a deposit before you shoot, one revision in writing, and no virality promise anywhere. You keep claims you can stand behind. You keep files named like an adult, delivered in a folder they own.

You do not keep a fantasy of becoming the face of a national brand in month one. You do not keep unpaid collabs. You do not keep a twelve-item menu before two samples exist. Kitchen-tool product videos. Two files. Seven days. That is the deal. It is smaller than the influencer version. It pays.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

Fits if

This path fits if you are comfortable on camera. Not love being an influencer. Comfortable. You can hold a product, talk for twenty seconds, and not apologize to the lens. A kitchen, a window, a phone is enough. You do not need a ring light army.

It also fits if you already buy in a niche: kitchen tools, skincare you actually use, hardware in the garage, a software login you open every morning. The niche is the drawer you already have. Samples from that drawer are honest. Samples from a niche you are faking will sound like a press release. You can say a price out loud. You can send five emails this week. You will take a deposit before you shoot.

Skip if

Skip it if you hate being on camera and were hoping the model would generate a face. Faceless slideshow ads exist. They are a different product. This path is you, a product, a sentence.

Skip it if you want to wait for a marketplace to send you brands. Those platforms take a cut and train you to bid against people who work for \$50. You will email five brands you already use.

Skip it if you will promise virality to close the deal. Sell the files, the deadline, and one revision. Not a lottery ticket.

Skip it if you need rent this Friday. Time to first is 7–21 days. Pair this with a service week if cash is tight. Do not take product-only. Skip it if you will not pick a niche, or if you freeze at sending five notes. The emails are the business.

The honest middle

Shy is allowed. Mute is not. You can talk to the product instead of the lens on sample one. You still need to be willing to be seen. If you have a page and no emails, you do not have a business yet. You need two honest clips and five brands who already sold you something.

Skills and time

Skills: hold a product, speak twenty seconds, trim a clip, burn captions, write a six-line email, take a deposit. Time: two evenings plus five emails. First paid brief can land inside 7–21 days. The seven-day clock starts when the thing arrives. Budget: \$0 if you already have a phone and two products. A ring light is later, after a brand has paid.

Two-minute self-test

Answer out loud. Stall on two and skip this path this month.

Can you hold a product and talk for twenty seconds without apologizing?

What drawer do you already buy from, named as a niche, not a vibe?

Will you film two sample ads this week for products you own?

Can you say two videos, one revision, seven days, \$400 without flinching?

Will you send five emails to brands you already use, this week, not after a media kit?

Will you refuse exposure, free product, and a virality clause?

Six yeses. Start. Four or fewer: pick a closer niche, get on camera tonight, or take a different path.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this before you film

Write this on the rate card before you film: Two product videos, one revision, seven days, \$400. Vertical files you can run. Samples on this page.

That is the whole offer. Not a menu of 12 packages. Not a 20-video retainer. Two videos. One pack. A date.

If you cannot name the niche in the sentence — two kitchen-tool product videos — you do not have an offer yet. I make UGC is a category. Categories do not get replies.

Offer sentences that already work

Two kitchen-tool product videos, 15–30 seconds, vertical, one revision, seven days from product-in-hand. \$400. Samples on this page.

Two skincare-on-a-real-face videos for the product I already use. Captions on. One revision. Seven days. \$400.

Two hardware-in-the-garage demos, product in the first two seconds, files you can run this week. \$400.

Two talking-head plus demo clips for a software login I actually open. No fake dashboard. \$400.

Two videos for your new SKU in the same niche as my samples. Deposit holds the week. \$400.

Write yours with a niche a brand will recognize. Do not write short-form content for growing brands. That is a cloud. A cloud does not get a wire.

What they get

Deliverable: two 15–30 second vertical videos (9:16), captions burned in, raw clips optional if you want to upsell later.

Process: they send the product facts and claims they can actually make. You script, shoot, edit. They get one round of notes. You deliver files, not a login to your brain.

Timeline: seven days from product-in-hand (or from the day they ship it to you) to files in a folder.

Price: \$400 for the first two-video pack in kitchen tools. The cash window for a first pack anywhere in this path is \$150–\$800. Start where you can say the number without flinching, then raise.

One revision window, 48 hours, written notes. After that, new work is a new invoice.

Files named like an adult. Folder they own. No watermark. No your-logo end card unless they paid for a brand frame.

What they do not get

A virality guarantee. A ROAS number. Media buying. A 40-minute discovery call that becomes free consulting. Unlimited rounds. A 12-hook testing matrix inside \$400. Your audience. A usage-rights fight. You on a monthly retainer before you have delivered once.

They also do not get medical claims, fake urgency you know is false, or a line about doctors hating this. If they need that, they need a different vendor.

Packaging

One page. Two embedded samples. The rate card line. Three add-ons: 72-hour rush +\$150, extra revision +\$75, extra video in the same shoot +\$150. Deposit link. Brief form. Email you actually check.

Do not build a Figma palace. Do not list 12 packages. Two videos, one price, one niche. Then a rate card add-on. Then a retainer. In that order.

What done looks like

Definition

Done is a paid brief, not a sample sitting in your camera roll. The first sale is one brand saying yes and paying a deposit for two videos.

Done for a pack is two finished vertical files a muted stranger can follow, a 3-second hook that names the job, claims you can stand behind, one revision round in writing, files named like an adult, deposit taken before you shoot, balance on delivery. You are not a bank.

Done for the business, week one, is smaller: two sample ads live on a page with the \$400 pack spelled out, five emails sent. If those five are not sent, you do not have a business. You have homework.

The fairness test

Hand the two files to someone who does not know the brand. Phone, muted, vertical. Can they name the product and the job in three seconds? If they cannot, the hook failed. Can they follow the captions without squinting? If they cannot, you stacked three lines. Would you say the script in a store aisle? If not, you shipped a press release.

Fairness also means the brand can load the files this week. No watermark. No missing captions. No 400 MB monsters. Folder. Names. Done. Fairness means you did not promise views. The page does not say this will go viral. You sold files. That is what arrived.

Technical done (week 1)

- Niche picked from a drawer you already have
- Two sample ads shot and edited, 15–30 seconds, captions on
- Rate card: two videos, one revision, seven days, \$400
- Rush, extra revision, extra video written as add-ons
- One page with samples, price, deposit link
- Brief form live: facts, claims you will not make, examples they like
- Five emails sent to brands you already buy
- No virality promise anywhere on the page

Technical done (a paid pack)

- Deposit in before you shoot
- Product in hand, or a written date they will ship
- Script said out loud. AI lines you would not say are gone
- Two vertical mp4s, 15–30 seconds, product in the first two seconds
- Captions a muted viewer can follow, one short line at a time
- No medical claims, no fake urgency, no statistic you invented
- Files named Brand-Product-A-hook1.mp4 and Brand-Product-B-demo.mp4
- Folder they own, no watermark
- One revision window, 48 hours, written notes

Balance paid

Ask for the next SKU and one referral, sent while they are happy

Not done yet

Samples in camera roll, no page

Page live, zero emails

Yes from a brand, no deposit, you already shot

Make it pop accepted as a revision note

Third round inside the same \$400

Media buying promised so they would say yes

Product-only accepted as payment

A claim on camera the brand cannot defend

If three of those are true, you are busy, not running this path. Fix the list this week.

Pricing the two-video pack

Ranges

Cash window: \$150–\$800 for a first two-video pack. Alex's kitchen-tool pack sits at \$400. That number is high enough to filter hobby brands who want free content, and low enough that a six-person company can expense it without a board meeting.

\$150–\$250 if you have zero samples and need a first paid case. Say it is a founder rate for the first two brands, then it becomes \$400. Write the date you will stop discounting. Do not live there.

\$400 is the default once two samples exist. Two videos, one revision, seven days. Rush in 72 hours: add \$150. Extra revision: \$75. Extra video in the same shoot: \$150. Raw clips folder: \$50. Write those add-ons on the rate card so they do not become a conversation.

\$600–\$800 when you have three paid brands in the same niche and a folder of ads that ran. Do not jump there on day one. You have no proof yet. A monthly four-video retainer, first Friday:

\$700–\$1,200 after you have delivered three packs without drama. Not before.

Worked dollars

Alex lists \$400. Five emails. One yes on day 9. 50% deposit = \$200 before the product ships. Product arrives day 12. Shoot Saturday. Deliver Monday. One revision: last six seconds, messy sink. Balance \$200. Pack cash: \$400. Time from first email to files: 16 days. Inside the 7–21 day window.

Next six weeks: the juicer owner forwards the page. Two more kitchen brands, same pack, same \$400. One takes the extra-video add-on at \$150. Three-pack cash: \$1,350. Not rent in a coastal city. Proof. The niche is now a sentence you can say at a market stall.

If Alex had taken product-only on pack one, cash is \$0 and a juicer they did not need. If Alex had said \$150 forever, three packs = \$450 and a trained cheap buyer. The \$400 is the point.

Rush example: brand needs files Friday, it is Tuesday, product is in hand. $\$400 + \$150 = \$550$. The extra is the calendar, not more work on the lens.

Ten-video week: that is a different package. 10 videos, two revision rounds, 14 days, \$1,600, 50% deposit. Do not say yes at \$400.

What you never do

You never work for exposure. You never take we will send you the product and a coupon code as payment. You never promise a CPM, a ROAS, or a view count. You sell files. If they want you to run the ads too, that is a second package with a second price, and you should not sell it until you have delivered the files once.

You never hide the number behind DM me for rates. The page says \$400. Deposit 50% to hold the week. Balance on delivery. Pick one rule for when balance is due. Put it on the page.

Refunds in one sentence

If I miss the deadline without a product delay on your side, you get the deposit back or I finish at no extra fee. You pick. I do not refund because the ad did not go viral. I sold files.

When to raise

After three paid packs in the same niche, \$500. After a folder of ads that actually ran, \$600–\$800. After a repeat brand asks for a monthly four-pack, quote the retainer. Do not raise because one video got comments. Comments are not a case.

The first 72 hours

Film two sample ads. Edit. Put them on a simple page with a package: two videos, one revision, a deadline, a price. Send the page to five small brands you already use. Do not wait to be discovered on a marketplace.

Hours 1–8: niche, hooks, voice memos

Pick the niche from your own shelf. Kitchen tools if that is your drawer. Take two products you already own. Write three hook options each. Speak them into a voice memo. Keep the ones you would say in a store. Throw out the ones that sound like a banner ad. Ask the model for six hook outlines, then cut anything you would not say while chopping onions. The model is a starter. Your mouth is the filter.

Hours 9–24: shoot and a first export

Shoot by a window. Phone vertical. Product in frame in the first two seconds. One take that is good enough. Then a second angle: demo the tool actually working. Audio: dishwasher off, hood fan off. Edit in CapCut: captions, a light crop, 20 seconds, no trending audio you do not have the rights to. Export 9:16. Watch it muted. If you cannot follow it, fix the captions before you build a page.

Hours 25–48: the page and the rate card

A one-page site or a Notion page: two embedded samples, the rate card line, a deposit link, an email. Headline names the niche. Kitchen-tool product videos. You get files, not a follower pitch. Write the three add-ons. Write the brief questions. Write the claims-you-will-not-make box. Test the deposit link from a second device. Two videos and a number. No 900-word about page.

Hours 49–72: five emails, not a media kit

Send five notes to brands you already buy from. I made two kitchen-tool videos as samples. I can do two for [product] in seven days for \$400, one revision. Page: [link]. That is the 72 hours. No media kit. No waiting.

Pick brands you can name without a spreadsheet of 200. The citrus juicer with 12,000 followers. The mill seller in the cupboard. Not Amazon house brands. Not a giant with a 14-step vendor portal. Follow-up is day 4, not hour 70. Do not build a marketplace profile instead of sending the five.

The path, step by step

Step 1. Rate card before more gear

Starter pack: two videos, one revision, seven days, \$400. Rush fee. Extra revision. Extra video. Put it on one page. If you cannot say the number out loud, the number is wrong or you are not ready to send email.

Step 2. Niche you already buy in

Kitchen tools, software, skincare, hardware. One. Stay there until you have repeat clients. A sample from your own shelf is honest. A sample from a niche you searched this morning will sound like it. Pick the drawer.

Step 3. Two sample ads, not a PDF about your media kit

Film a demo and a talking-head for products you own. Brands hire from video. They do not hire from a bio. Fifteen to thirty seconds. Captions on. Product in the first two seconds. One sample looks like a hobby.

Step 4. Page with the pack spelled out

Two embeds. The sentence. Deposit link. Brief form. That is the page. Test it on a phone. If the deposit link 404s, you are not ready to email.

Step 5. Five emails to brands you already use

Six lines. The page. A still from one sample. No attachment pack. No we should hop on a call. Send them in one sitting. If you cannot name five brands you already buy, your niche is a mood, not a drawer.

Step 6. Brief intake, a form, not a 40-minute discovery call

Product facts. Three claims they can legally make. Claims you will not make. Two example ads they like (not make it viral). Ship-to address. Deadline. Send the form first. Fifteen minutes after the deposit is allowed. Before money is not.

Step 7. Deposit before you shoot

50% holds the week. Do not start a script for a maybe. Do not buy \$200 of inventory on a maybe. If they stall on the deposit, they were not a brief.

Step 8. Script in your mouth

AI outline: hook, problem, demo, proof, ask. Then rewrite until you can say it while walking across the kitchen. Record a voice memo. If you stumble, the line is too long. Cut fake urgency and any claim the intake forbade.

Step 9. Shoot

Window light. Phone at eye height. Product in the first two seconds. Do the job on camera — press the garlic, peel the orange, click the software. Two or three takes per hook is enough. Twenty takes is how you miss the deadline.

Step 10. Edit

CapCut is enough. Captions. Cut the breath you took before the sentence. End on the product name and the one action. Stay off music you cannot license. Silence plus the room plus your voice is legal and human.

Step 11. Deliver vertical files they can run

9:16, under 100 MB if you can help it, no watermark, no your-logo end card unless they paid for a brand frame. Named. Folder they own. Send the delivery note with the 48-hour revision window in the same message.

Step 12. One revision window

Written notes, 48 hours, one round. Make it pop is not a note. Swap the first line for the one about the dishwasher is a note. After the window, new invoice. If they send a novel, pick two changes and name the rest as a \$75 extra round.

Step 13. Ask for the next SKU and one referral

While they are happy. If the juicer has a sibling product, I can shoot it in the same setup for \$150 extra next week. Then: Who else in kitchen tools should see the samples? Do this the day they say the files work.

Step 14. Stay in one niche

The second brand is easier when you can say I already shot a press, a peeler, and a juicer. Crossing into dental ads because someone asked is how you restart from zero. The niche is the asset.

Step 15. Raise or productize

After three paid packs, \$500. After a folder of work, a monthly four videos, first Friday retainer. Not before you have delivered once without drama. Do not raise because you bought a light.

Step 16. Leave the marketplace alone until the five emails have had a chance

A profile on a UGC app is allowed later, when you have a pack and a rate and you will not bid \$50. It is a trap as your only channel. The five emails are the work.

Worked example: Alex and the \$400 kitchen-tool pack

Alex cooks most nights in a small apartment kitchen. No studio. A window over the sink. A drawer of tools bought over a few years. That drawer is the niche. Alex did not pick kitchen tools because of a trend report. Alex picked them because the garlic press was already there.

The two samples

Sample 1, garlic press: 18 seconds. Hook: I used to mince garlic with a knife and it made the whole board smell for days. Demo: clove in, squeeze, peel the leftover skin, rinse. Last line: Four seconds, and the board stays clean. No music fight. Captions on.

Sample 2, silicone spatula: 22 seconds. Hook: If your spatula melts on the pan, that is not a personality, that is a bad tool. Demo: scramble, scrape, hold it against the edge. Last line: This one does not smell like burnt rubber. I checked.

Both shot in one evening. Edited the next morning in CapCut. On a one-page site with this line: Two product videos, one revision, seven days. \$400. Samples on this page. Deposit link under the sentence.

Calendar with dollars

Day 1, evening: niche picked, three hooks per product spoken into a memo, two kept. Day 2, after work: window shoot, two products, six takes total. Day 3, morning: CapCut, captions, two exports. Night: page live, \$400 pack, deposit link tested. Days 4–7: five emails, one per night so they actually went out. No marketplace profile.

The five emails: not Amazon house brands, not All-Clad. A citrus juicer company with 12,000 Instagram followers. A board-scraper shop. A mill seller. Two spatula companies. Each note was six lines, the page link, and a still from the garlic-press ad. No media kit.

Day 8: silence. Alex did not rebuild the page. Day 9: the juicer brand replied. They had a new hand juicer. They wanted two ads: one demo, one why I switched from a cheap press. They asked if Alex could also run the ads and get us views. Alex said no to the media buying, yes to the \$400 pack, 50% deposit. \$200 in on day 9. Product arrived on day 12. Seven-day clock starts at in-hand: files due day 19.

Day 13: brief form back. Three true facts. One claim they must not make: no clinically proven juice yield. Two example ads they liked, both demo-heavy. Day 14: script outline from the model. Alex cut three fake-urgency lines and the yield claim. Voice memo in the kitchen. Two lines still too long. Cut.

Day 16, Saturday: shoot. Same window, same phone, juicer in the first two seconds. Day 18, Monday: deliver two vertical files, named, folder they own. One revision requested: they wanted the sink less messy in the background. Alex reshot the last six seconds that night. Day 19: revised file in the folder. Balance \$200. Pack total \$400.

Elapsed from first email to files: 16 days. Time to first paid brief: inside the 7–21 day window. Cash: \$400, zero ad spend, zero marketplace cut.

What happened next

Alex did not become famous. Two more kitchen brands hired in the next six weeks because the juicer owner forwarded the page. Same pack. Same \$400. Same niche. One took the extra-video add-on at \$150. Three-pack cash: \$1,350. Alex almost titled the page UGC creator for hire, almost said yes to running the ads, almost took the juicer as payment. The rate card saved the number. The drawer saved the niche.

Ninety days

Seven paid packs in kitchen tools. Two repeats from the juicer brand. Still no marketplace profile. Still no virality line on the page. The business is files, a niche, and emails. That is enough.

Copy you can paste

Swap the niche. Keep the kitchen voice. Do not add a virality line.

1. Rate card line

Two product videos, one revision, seven days. \$400. Samples on this page.

2. Add-ons, same card

72-hour rush: +\$150

Extra revision round: +\$75

Extra video in the same shoot: +\$150

Raw clips folder: +\$50

3. Email to a brand you already buy from

Hi [name] — I already use [product]. I make short product videos brands can run as ads. Two samples here: [link]. I can do two videos for [their product] in seven days, one revision, \$400. 50% to hold the week. If the timing is wrong, ignore this.

4. Follow-up, four days later, one line

Looping this to the top in case it got buried. Samples still here: [link]. Two videos, seven days, \$400. No need to reply if it is a next-quarter thing.

5. Page headline and sub

Kitchen-tool product videos. You get files, not a follower pitch.

Two 15–30 second vertical videos. One revision. Seven days from product-in-hand. \$400. I do not promise views. I deliver files you can run this week.

6. Brief questions (send as a form)

Product name and the URL

Three facts that are true

Any claim I must not make

Two ads you like (links)

Where to ship the product, or a date I can film what I have

Deadline, if it is not seven days from in-hand

7. Delivery note

Files are in this folder. Two vertical mp4s, captions on. One revision window, 48 hours, written notes. After that I am glad to do another round as a \$75 add-on. I do not run the ads unless we quote that separately.

8. Decline media buying

I can make the two videos. I cannot run your ads or promise a ROAS. If you want files this week, the \$400 pack is the thing. If you need a media buyer, that is a different vendor. Happy to stay in my lane.

9. Decline product-only

I buy my own samples. A paid brief is a paid brief. If the product needs to ship for the shoot, I take 50% to hold the week, then you ship. I do not swap the invoice for a box.

10. Ask for the next SKU

If [product] has a sibling SKU, I can shoot it in the same setup for \$150 extra as a third video, or as a new two-pack at \$400 next week. Same captions, same folder habit. Want me to hold a day?

11. Referral ask

Glad the files worked. Who else in [niche] should see the samples? A name and an email is enough. I will not say you sent me unless you want that.

12. Revision window closed

The 48 hours are up and the pack is closed. I can do another round as a \$75 extra revision. Send written notes and I will quote a turnaround. No rush fee unless you need it inside 72 hours.

Week-by-week

Assume evenings plus one weekend shoot. You can have a job. This is not a studio calendar.

Week 1: two samples and five emails

Day 1: pick the niche and the two products on your shelf. Speak hooks. Throw out banner-ad lines.

Day 2: shoot by the window. Product in the first two seconds. Dishwasher off.

Day 3: edit, captions, page with the \$400 pack, deposit link tested.

Days 4–7: five emails to brands you already buy. Do not build a marketplace profile instead of sending the five. Do not film a third sample in a second niche. Done bar for the week: two live samples, a number on a page, five sends.

Week 2: follow-up and a sixth brand if needed

One follow-up, four days later, one line: Looping this to the top in case it got buried. Samples still here: [link]. If someone says maybe next quarter, ask if they have a sibling SKU now.

If you have zero replies, send five more in the same niche. Change the subject line to the product you already use. Check that the page loads on a phone. Do not switch to skincare on day eight. The niche is the asset. The emails are the work.

If a yes arrives: deposit, form, wait for the box. Do not script a full ad for a brand that has not paid.

Week 3: deliver the first paid brief

Deposit, intake, script in your mouth, shoot, edit, files. One revision. Ask for the next SKU and one name. Do not start a skincare sample while you wait. Do not say yes to running the ads to keep them happy.

Protect the seven days from in-hand. If the box is late, the clock has not started. Tell them that in one sentence. Write down what broke: audio, sink, a claim you cut. That list is week 4's checklist.

Week 4: stay in the niche

Second pack at the same \$400, or founder-rate closed. Four videos in your folder is a portfolio. Forty half-finished ideas is not.

If you have no paid brief yet: ten total emails in the same niche, page still one offer, samples still the same two. Improve a hook if it sounded like a press release. Do not add a \$97 coaching call to the page.

If you have two yeses: deliver both without stacking them on the same Saturday unless they are the same setup. Raise nothing yet. The retainer talk waits until three clean deliveries.

The quality bar

Clear beats cinematic. A stable phone, a window, and a sentence you would say in a store will outperform a shaky dolly shot with a script you cannot pronounce.

Picture and sound

Product in the first two seconds. If they have to wait for the brand, they swipe.

Face or hands, plus the tool doing the job. Talking-head with the product off-screen is a podcast.

Audio you can hear on a phone speaker. A \$20 lav or a quiet room. The dishwasher is off.

Captions. Most people watch muted. If the caption is the whole script in three giant lines, it is unreadable. One short line at a time.

Vertical 9:16. No letterboxing you forgot to crop. No watermark. No trending audio you do not own.

Claims

You do not make medical claims. You do not make this will change your life in 7 days claims you know are false. You do not invent a statistic. If the brand sends a claim you would not repeat to a friend, you send it back. The ad is their legal problem and your name on camera. Both matter. Fake countdown clocks are the same family. Cut them.

Human

If you would not say it in a store aisle, it does not go in the video. AI outlines. You speak. A little mess in a real kitchen is trust. A fake marble island with a product still in the shipping tape is not.

Voice-memo test: if you cannot walk and talk it, it is not ready.

Five tests this week

Mute test: watch both samples with sound off. Can you follow the job?

Three-second test: can a stranger name the product by second three?

Store-aisle test: would you say this to a person next to you at the shelf?

Claims test: is every fact on the intake, not in the model's imagination?

Phone-speaker test: play it in a kitchen, not on studio headphones. If you cannot hear you, they cannot hear you.

If two fail, do not email five brands yet. Fix the files. The page cannot save a hostage script.

What to measure

You are selling packs, not views. Measure the business you control.

Week 1

Emails sent. Five is the floor. Zero emails means zero briefs, no matter how good the garlic press ad is.

Page loads on a phone. Deposit link works.

Samples exist, 15–30 seconds, captions on.

A paid-brief cycle

Replies and yeses. A 20–40% reply rate on warm brands you already buy from is normal. Cold marketplace bids will be worse. Stay warm until you have cases.

Days from yes to deposit. If this is more than three, you are hopping on calls instead of sending a button.

Days from product-in-hand to files. Target seven. If it is 18, your revision process or your shoot block is sloppy.

Revision count. One is the package. Two means your brief missed the claims list. Three means you are training them to use you as an art department.

Pack cash collected. Deposit plus balance. Not promised. Collected.

Day 90

Repeat rate. The goal is a second SKU from the same brand, not a new niche. One repeat in the first five clients is a real business.

Referral count. One forward from a happy brand beats twenty marketplace bids.

Niche concentration. If more than one of five packs left the drawer, you are restarting.

Add-on attach. If nobody takes rush or extra video, that is fine. If everyone demands extra rounds inside \$400, your window copy is weak.

Ignore

Follower count. Views on the sample. Likes on a public post of the garlic press. Time spent shopping for lights. A brand's ROAS. You did not buy the traffic. You made the file. If they insist on performance as your metric, ask for a screenshot later as a favor, not a warranty.

Spreadsheet

date | brand | niche | pack \$ | deposit in | in-hand date | files sent | revisions | balance in | next SKU asked | referral asked

Objections you will hear

Can you do it for product only?

No. Working for exposure is the thing to leave alone. You can buy the product and film a sample. Their product in the mail is not a salary. If they push, send the rate card line again and stop explaining.

We need this to go viral.

You cannot promise that. You can promise two clear videos in seven days. If they need a virality clause, they need a different vendor, or they need to run paid ads. Do not meet in the middle with I will try to make it trendy.

We already have a UGC platform.

Good. Those platforms are full of \$50 videos. Your page is two samples in their exact niche and a human email. Some brands still want that. If they do not, next email.

Can we hop on a call?

Maybe a 15-minute walkthrough after the deposit. A 40-minute let us explore call before money is the job. Send the brief form first.

Our last creator made medical claims and we got flagged.

Put the claims-you-will-not-make box on the intake. Write it: I will not say anything you cannot stand behind. Then keep that promise on camera even if a marketing intern wants punchier.

\$400 seems high for two TikToks.

They are not TikToks. They are product videos a brand can run. Two samples are on the page. If \$400 is wrong for them, \$150 for exposure is wrong for you.

Can you also run the ads / set up the pixel / write the landing page?

No inside this pack. That is a second quote, and you should not sell it until the files have shipped once.

We need ten videos by Friday.

That is a different package. Quote it: 10 videos, two revision rounds, 14 days, \$1,600, 50% deposit. Do not say yes at \$400. Do not say yes at all if you cannot shoot that volume without wrecking another deadline. A no with a real quote is cleaner than a late yes.

Can you make it more on-brand / use our jingle / wear our hat?

If they send a hat, maybe. If they send a jingle they do not own, no. If more on-brand means a studio set you do not have, the samples already showed the kitchen. You sell the kitchen.

We will pay after we see how it performs.

No. Deposit to hold the week. Balance on delivery. Performance is their media plan. You sold files.

What this path feeds next

A finished pack is a case. Cases feed a \$19 playbook and a skill pack of the outlines you actually used. Do not sell those until you have delivered paid work. Selling scripts you have never shot is a different kind of fiction.

The same niche becomes a retainer: four videos a month, first Friday, one price. Local brands in your town who sell kitchen tools will hire you faster than a national name. Walk in with the two samples on your phone.

Repeat SKUs from one brand are the cleanest growth. Same kitchen, same light, new tool. \$150 extra in the same shoot, or a new \$400 pack. That is how \$1,200 months happen without a new niche.

What this does not feed: a personal brand built on promising you can make anything viral. Keep the page boring and specific. Kitchen-tool product videos. Files in seven days.

What this feeds badly: jumping into faceless AI ads, then into media buying, then into a UGC course, before three packs exist. One niche. Files. Then the \$19 outline pack if people ask how you script. Then a retainer. In that order.

Mistakes that kill this path

1. Medical claims and fake urgency

Clinically proven on a garlic press. Doctors hate this. A countdown you know is false. You will get a brand flagged and you will not get the second SKU. Recovery: cut the line before export. If it already shipped, send a clean cut the same day. Do not argue that it was punchy.

2. Unlimited rounds

One revision is a package. Open-ended until we love it is a second job you forgot to price. Recovery: one sentence, the window is closed, extra round is \$75. Do not gift a third round because you feel awkward. Awkward is cheaper than a trained bad client.

3. Waiting for a platform to send you brands

Marketplaces train you to race to \$75. Five emails to brands you already use is the channel. Recovery: close the app. Send five notes this week. You can return to the marketplace after three paid packs, at your rate, not theirs.

4. Working for exposure

Free product is not a brief. A tag is not a deposit. Recovery: if you already shot for a box, write it off as a sample you chose to make and never do it again. Change the page so the next brand cannot go there.

5. Reading the AI script like a hostage

If you cannot say it in the kitchen, it does not go in the ad. Recovery: voice memo walk. Cut every stumble. Reshoot twenty seconds, not the identity. The model can draft. It cannot stand in your kitchen.

6. Promising virality

You do not control distribution. Sell the files. Recovery: if you already promised it in an email, reply once: I cannot guarantee views. I can deliver the two files on the date. If they need a clause, refund the deposit and leave. Staying is how you get blamed for Ads Manager.

7. A 12-item menu before two samples exist

Two videos, one price, one niche. Then a rate card add-on. Then a retainer. In that order.

Recovery: delete the menu. Leave the \$400 pack. You can add rush and extra video as three lines, not twelve packages.

8. Shooting before the deposit

You are not a bank. Recovery: pause. Send the deposit link. If they ghost, you lost time, not a week of editing. If the product is already in your house, it sits until money sits.

9. Switching niches on day eight

Silence is normal. Skincare will not save a kitchen page that never got ten emails. Recovery: five more emails, same drawer. Change the subject line to the product you use. Do not film a serum “to have options.”

10. Accepting make it pop as a note

That note will eat the revision window and still not be done. Recovery: ask for one concrete swap — first line, background, a claim to cut. If they cannot name one, you are done. Ship the files you have.

11. Music you do not own

Trending audio can get an ad pulled. Recovery: export a silent-plus-voice cut the same day. Tell the brand why. Do not argue that everyone uses it. Everyone gets ads taken down too.

12. Saying yes to ten videos at two-video prices

Recovery: send the 10-video quote. If they already think you said yes, unsaid it in writing the same day. A late no is better than a missed seven-day promise to someone who already paid.

Tools

The stack that is enough

Phone. Vertical. Clean the lens. 4K if it will still export a reasonable file; 1080p is fine for ads. You do not need a cinema camera for a spatula.

CapCut. Captions, cuts, export. Stay off music you cannot license. Silence plus the room plus your voice is legal and human.

A rate card. One page. Pack, rush, extra revision, extra video. Not a Figma palace.

AI for script outlines only. Hook, demo beats, a list of claims to avoid. Then your mouth. Then the throw-away pass.

A simple page. Carrd, Notion, Stan, a Google Doc with two unlisted YouTube or Vimeo embeds. Deposit via Stripe. Email you actually check.

A cheap lav or a quiet room. Optional tripod. Window. That is the studio.

A folder habit. Brand-Product-A-hook1.mp4. Not FinalFinal3.mp4. They own the folder on payment.

The \$0 path

Phone you already own. Window. Two products in the drawer. CapCut free tier. A Notion page. A Stripe or Stan link you already have, or an invoice you send by email with a deposit sentence if you must start uglier. Voice memos on the same phone. Five emails from the address you already use.

You do not need a new domain this week. You do not need a marketplace subscription. You do not need a lighting kit. \$0 is allowed until a brand has paid. Then a \$20 lav if audio was the actual complaint.

What to leave alone

Leave the marketplace apps alone until five organic emails have had a chance. Leave the ring-light shopping cart alone until a brand has paid. Leave the AI-avatar tools alone. This path is your face and a product. Leave the 12-app stack. CapCut and a page.

When to spend

After a paid pack: lav if the kitchen is noisy. Tripod if your arm is the problem. A simple contract template you reuse. Not a camera body. The \$400 pack does not require a new identity.

Checklist

- Niche picked from a drawer you already have
- Two products you own chosen for samples
- Three hooks spoken per product, banner-ad lines thrown out
- Two sample ads shot, 15–30 seconds, product in first two seconds
- Captions on, one short line at a time
- Mute test passed
- Store-aisle test passed: you would say this in a shop
- Rate card: two videos, one revision, seven days, \$400
- Rush +\$150, extra revision +\$75, extra video +\$150 written
- One page with samples, price, deposit link
- Deposit link tested from a second device
- Brief form: facts, claims you will not make, examples they like
- No virality promise anywhere on the page
- Five emails to brands you already buy
- One follow-up four days later
- Deposit before you shoot
- Script said out loud, AI lines you would not say are gone
- Claims from the intake only, no invented statistics
- Vertical files delivered, named, no watermark, folder they own
- One revision window, 48 hours, written notes
- Balance collected
- Ask for the next SKU sent

One referral asked while they are happy

What broke written into a shoot checklist

Stay in the niche for the next pack

Marketplace profile not built instead of emails

No product-only deals accepted

No media buying inside the \$400 pack

FAQ

Do I need followers?

No. Brands paying \$400 for two videos are buying files they can run. Followers are a bonus if you have them. They are not the product. Two samples in the niche beat 40,000 followers in a different niche.

Should I join a UGC marketplace?

You can later. Do not wait on one. Those platforms are useful when you already have a pack and a rate. They are a trap when they are your only channel and the bids start at \$50. Five emails first.

Who pays for the product?

For samples, you do. You already own it. For a paid brief, they ship it or you invoice a product budget. Do not buy \$200 of inventory on a maybe. Deposit first, then shipping.

How long should each video be?

15–30 seconds for v1. Some placements want 6 seconds later. You can cut a 6-second hook from a 20-second file if you shot a clean first line. Do not deliver a 90-second story and call it an ad.

What if I freeze on camera?

Talk to the product, not the lens, for the first sample. Demo-heavy videos hide a shy face. You still need to be willing to be seen. If you cannot, this is the wrong path.

Can I use AI to generate the spokesperson?

Not for this path. Brands hiring UGC want a person. AI is for outlines. You are the mouth.

What about music?

Skip it unless the brand sends a track they own. Trending audio can get an ad pulled. Voice, captions, the sound of the tool — enough.

Do I need an LLC and a contract?

A one-page agreement is enough for pack one: deliverable, timeline, price, revision, claims, who owns the files (they do, on payment). Deposit via Stripe. The agreement cannot wait.

How do I handle a brand that wants 10 videos this week?

That is a different package. Quote it: 10 videos, two revision rounds, 14 days, \$1,600, 50% deposit. Do not say yes at \$400 if you cannot shoot that volume without wrecking another deadline.

What if the first five emails go nowhere?

Send five more in the same niche. Change the subject line to the product you already use. Check that the page loads on a phone. Do not switch to skincare on day eight.

Do I need to be pretty / young / a certain size?

You need to look like a person who would buy the thing. Real kitchens convert. If a brand wants a model, they will say so. Your samples already showed your face. That is a filter. Use it.

Can I batch four brands in one Saturday?

Only if the products are in the same niche and you have deposits from all four. Two brands in a day is a stretch for week one. Four is how files get sloppy and claims slip. Protect the seven-

day promise.

Who owns the files?

They do, on payment. You may keep samples on your page unless they paid extra for exclusive use. Write ownership on the pack page so it is not a fight on day 19.

Should I watermark the samples?

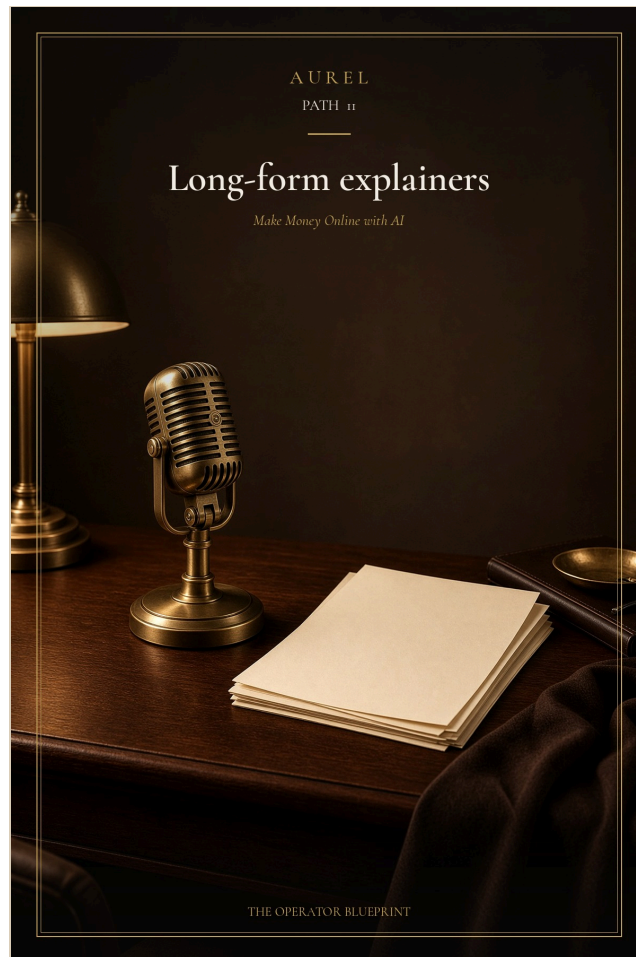
A small end card on the public sample is fine. Do not watermark the paid files. Do not put your logo over their product. They bought the asset, not a demo of you.

What if they hate the hook after I followed the brief?

One revision. Swap the first line if they name the line. If they hate the whole concept, check the form: did they send example ads? If yes and you matched, you are inside the pack. If you ignored their examples, reshoot. That one is on you.

Is \$400 too low / too high?

It is the default once two samples exist. Sit at \$400. Raise after three packs. Do not auction yourself in the first reply.



PATH 11

Long-form explainers

Eight honest minutes on the question they already type. Soft ask at the end.

51 minute read · 11,142 words

Who this is for

You can explain a job without rushing. You can sit still for a recording.

Time to first

30–60 days of one video a week

Tools

First sale

A video that produces a click to your offer.

Cash window

Supports the \$19–\$47 file

Leave this alone

YouTube, a cheap mic, a doc outline, AI for research notes you will verify.

Daily uploads with no point. Copying someone else's series.

What you are selling

Definition

Short-form borrows attention. Long-form can keep it. A video that fully answers a search question earns the right to mention your playbook at the end. That is the path: eight honest minutes on the question they already type, a soft ask at the last 45 seconds, one link in the description.

You are not selling the video. YouTube's ad money on a new channel is a rounding error. You are selling the click to a \$19–\$47 file that does the job the video just taught. The video is the proof. The file is the cash window. It exists to explain a job and point at a file, not to become a creator career.

What this is not

This is not a daily vlog, a second channel for fun, or a copy of someone else's series. This is not a 14-minute origin story with a how-to title. This is not a teaser that withholds the steps so they have to buy. Teach the whole small job. The file is the written version, not the missing half.

It is not Shorts with a longer runtime. It is not a podcast with a webcam. It is not a course funnel with a free video on top. One video a week, one question, one offer. Boring on purpose. Boring ships.

Why this works now

People still type how-to questions into YouTube: a job, a tool, a pain. How to close month-end in Claude without invented numbers. What to paste when the receipts are a mess. Those queries are a tired person trying to finish something tonight.

Generic AI explainers are free and infinite. The remaining gap is a named job for a named person, taught in kitchen-table English, with a file at the end that is the same sequence written

down. Search still pays that shape. You need one question they already type, one outline you can film Friday night, and a link that works on a phone Saturday morning.

Anti-pattern 1: daily uploads with no point

Daily with no offer is a second job that pays in comments. This path is one honest video a week for eight weeks. If you miss a week, you record two the next. You do not post a 40-second nothingburger so the calendar has a checkmark. Feed search titles and kept promises. Ignore the rest.

Anti-pattern 2: copying someone else's series

Their series is their scar tissue. Copying the thumbnail colors does not copy the reason a bookkeeper stayed for eight minutes. Watch what already ranks so you know the question. Then answer it in your order, with your screen, with your file.

Anti-pattern 3: a channel with no cash register

A beautiful explainer with nowhere to go is a hobby with a microphone. The \$19–\$47 file must exist before video one, or in the same 72 hours. One link. Not a Linktree with twelve buttons. Not a maybe-later cohort. If you cannot name the file, you are building a diary. Diaries do not pay for the cheap mic.

The deal you keep

You keep five promises. One: eight honest minutes on a search question they already type. Two: the title, the thumbnail, and the first 20 seconds agree, and the video pays them off. Three: you teach the whole small job, then a soft ask once. Four: AI is for research notes you will verify, not for facts you cannot show. Five: one video a week for eight weeks, same offer, no daily empty uploads. They keep one promise in return: if the job is theirs, they know the next step. The next step is the file, or they leave having been taught. Only one of those is the first sale.

Eight minutes is the default

Eight honest minutes is enough for a small job. Twelve if the job needs a screen recording. Twenty only if you are actually teaching twenty minutes of work. Sit still. Cheap mic. Face the window. Talk like a person at a table. Film Friday night. Publish Saturday morning. Measure the click to the offer, not the weather of views.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

Fits if

This path fits if you can explain a job without rushing. You can sit still for a recording. You already have, or can finish this month, a \$19–\$47 file that the video can point at. Without the file, long-form is a hobby with a microphone.

It also fits if you have patience measured in weeks, not hours. Time to first is 30–60 days of one video a week. Search is slow. A video that answers a real question can send clicks for years. It will not send them on Tuesday because you posted on Monday. You do not need to like how you look. You need to publish eight minutes of your own voice eight times.

Skip if

Skip it if you cannot sit through eight minutes of your own voice. Record a test. If you hate it so much you will not publish, pick short-form or a written how-to. The camera is not mandatory for a living. It is mandatory for this path.

Skip it if you want daily uploads with no point, if you planned to copy someone else's series because theirs has views, or if you need cash this week. Use a service path. Come back when the \$19 file exists and you can spare one recording block a week. Skip it if you need a studio and a theme song before video one can leave the house. You will not last eight weeks.

The honest middle

Shy is allowed. Inconsistent is not. One channel, one file, one video a week. You do not need four lights, a brand kit, or a nice wall. You need a quiet room, a window, a cheap mic, a doc outline, and a file that exists at checkout before you hit publish.

If you have two products, pick the \$19 one for eight weeks. If you have zero products, this is not your first path this month. Write the playbook, even ugly, then sit down. You do not have to become a YouTuber. You have to teach one job well enough that a stranger trusts the PDF.

Skills and time

Skills: name a search question in the buyer's words. Outline eight minutes as promise, three beats, demo, recap, soft ask. Sit still and talk. Cut dead air. Write a title that is the query. Make a five-word thumbnail that reads at phone size. Paste chapters and one link into a description. Pin a comment. Set one end screen.

Time: one evening to pick the question and outline. One Friday night to record. One Saturday morning to edit, thumbnail, and publish. Then 20 minutes in Studio a week later. Eight weeks on the calendar. If you miss a week, two the next. Budget: \$0 extra if you have a phone and a quiet room. A cheap USB mic is the one purchase that usually pays.

Two-minute self-test

Answer these out loud. Stall on two and this is not your first path this month.

What is the search question, in their words, not yours?

What is the \$19–\$47 file, in one line, with a working link?

Can you outline eight minutes tonight: promise, three beats, demo, recap, soft ask?

Will you film Friday night and publish Saturday morning even if the lighting is boring?

If video one gets 90 views and zero sales, will you still record video two next week on the same job?

Can you sit through eight minutes of your own voice without deleting the file?

If you have the question, the file, and the willingness to publish eight times, start. If you only have I should start a channel, go finish the playbook first.

The watcher on the other side

A tired person who typed a question. They are not browsing for a personality. They are trying to finish a job tonight: close the month, paste the messy receipts, stop the totals from drifting. They will give you 20 seconds. If you name the result of staying, they will give you eight minutes. If you teach the job, they might click the \$19 file so they do not have to rewind you next month. They will not stay for your origin. They will leave if the title promised a complete job and the video is a teaser.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this before you outline video one

Write this sentence before you outline: I answer [search question] in eight minutes for [person], then I point at [file] for \$19. Example: I answer how a one-person bookkeeper closes the month in Claude, then I point at the \$19 month-end playbook.

If you cannot name the search question, you do not have a video. If you cannot name the file, you are building a channel with no cash register. Do both on paper before you buy a light.

The on-camera offer is one sentence, same every video: If you want the one-page version plus the prompts, the \$19 playbook is in the description. Soft. Once. After you have actually taught the job.

Sentences that work

I answer how a one-person bookkeeper closes month-end in Claude without invented numbers, then I point at the \$19 close playbook.

I answer what to paste into Claude when a client's receipts are a mess, then I point at the \$19 receipt-to-close file.

I answer how a one-person cleaner plans a week of posts in 20 minutes, then I point at the \$19 caption playbook.

I answer how a freelancer runs a Friday follow-up without rewriting the same email, then I point at the \$19 SOP.

Write yours in that shape. One question. One person. One file. One price. If you need and to name the file, you have two products. Split them. Sell the one you can point at this Saturday.

What they get from the video

A complete small job, taught. The result named in the first 20 seconds. Three beats they can follow. A demo on the actual screen of the tool. A recap they could screenshot. A soft ask they can ignore. Chapters in the description. Tools listed. One link. An end screen with that same link. A pinned comment with the URL.

They get to leave having been taught. The file is for people who want the checklist, the prompts, and the 10-day sequence without rewinding you.

What they do not get

A withheld step. A part two for a job that fits in one video. A hard sell at minute one. A 90-second bio. A merch drop. Five affiliate links. A countdown. Fake scarcity. A Linktree junk drawer. A \$297 cohort pitched from video three. A second channel in the end screen. Daily Shorts instead of the explainer.

Packaging: the video versus the file

The video is free and complete. The file is the same sequence written down: checklist, prompts, a filled example, maybe a 10-day or 14-day plan. \$19 is the default. \$47 if the file includes the prompts, a filled example, and a 14-day plan.

One product, one price, one link. Stan, Stripe, or your own page. Title of the checkout matches the sentence you say on camera. Test the link on a phone, on cellular, before you publish. If the download fails, the eight minutes were a favor you did for free.

One sentence, one file

The on-camera line does not change for eight weeks. Same file. Same price. Recognition is the point. If you swap the offer every video, nobody can remember what you sell. After a stranger has bought from a video, you may add a \$47 version of the same job. Same channel. Same weekly video. New link, said once.

Where the ask lives

Last 45 seconds of the video, spoken. First lines of the description, written. Pinned comment, same sentence plus the URL. End screen, one button. That is four places and still one ask. Do not put the ask in the first 20 seconds. Do not skip it at the end because you felt shy. Teach. Then point.

What done looks like

Definition

Done for a single video: a stranger can search the question, click your title, stay past 20 seconds, finish the job you promised, and see one clear next step. Chapters in the description. Tools listed. The offer once. An end screen with one link, not eight.

Done for the path: eight videos in eight weeks, same offer, titles written like searches. Then you double down on the three that earned description clicks or comments. A click that bought the \$19 file is the first sale. Views without a click are a nice crowd. They are not the first sale.

The video is done when you would send it to a tired friend who does that job, tonight, without a speech.

Done for a single video

Title equals the search question. Thumbnail is five words or fewer, readable at phone size, honest about the job. First 20 seconds name the result of staying. The middle teaches three beats and shows the demo on screen. Recap is short. Soft ask is once, last 45 seconds. Cheap mic, sit still, facts verified. Published. Link works on a phone. Pinned comment live. End screen set. That is done for Saturday morning.

Done for the path (eight weeks)

Week 1 published. Weeks 2 through 8 on the calendar like a shift. Same file. Same on-camera sentence. New search question in the same job family each week. Comments stolen as outlines. After eight, three winners marked. Those shapes get repeated. The formats that died in silence

get retired. You have not started a second channel, added a second offer, or gone daily. You can name which video produced a click.

The done bar on the file side

The playbook must exist and the link must work on a phone. Test it. If the description link is a Linktree with twelve buttons, you do not have a soft ask. You have a junk drawer. One link. The \$19 file.

Checkout title matches the sentence you say at 8:00. Price on the page. Refund line on the page. Filename a tired person can find later. You have bought it yourself from a second email. If the download never arrives, nothing else about the video matters.

Fairness test

Would you play this for a tired friend who does that job, at 9 p.m., without hopping on a call to explain it? If you would say skip to 3:40, the first 20 seconds failed. If you would say the good part is in the PDF, you cheated the eight minutes. Fair also means they can ignore the file and still have been taught. Withholding the steps to force the click trains YouTube and humans to skip you.

Not-done-yet list

- A title with no search question in it

- A thumbnail you cannot read at arm's length

- First 20 seconds that are a bio

- A job teased for part two that fit in one video

- Facts you did not verify

- No offer, or a hard sell at minute one

- A description with no chapters and five links

- End screen is a grid of eight old videos

- File link untested on a phone

- Sitting in drafts until you feel ready

Daily empty uploads planned as a substitute for the weekly explainer

A second channel because the first one feels tainted

If three of those are true, you have a draft. Finish it Saturday morning. Do not list a draft and improve it with comments you have not earned.

The Saturday-morning bar

Morgan should be able to film Friday night and publish Saturday morning. If your process needs a color grade, a motion intro, and a weekend of doubt, it is not a process you will keep for eight weeks. Cut until Friday-to-Saturday is true. Honest minutes beat produced minutes. A kept promise beats a studio you visit twice a year.

What the video is allowed to sell

Ranges

Cash window: this path supports the \$19–\$47 file. It is not a \$2,000 course funnel in month one. The video teaches a small job. The file is the job written down with templates.

\$19 is the default ask at the end of an eight-minute explainer. \$29 if the file includes a filled example. \$47 if it includes the prompts, a filled example, and a 14-day plan. Do not pitch a \$297 cohort from video three. You have no series yet. They have no reason.

Do not do \$9 to get traction. You will attract collectors who never run chapter one. Do not hide the price behind DM me. Say \$19 out loud. Put it in the description. Put it on the checkout.

Why \$19 is the default ask

It is small enough that a tired bookkeeper will try it to skip next month's rewind. It is large enough that you will answer a support email. If you are ashamed of \$19, you either overbuilt the file or you do not believe the job is real. Cut the file, or run the job yourself one more time on camera.

The video already taught the job. The \$19 is for the written sequence, not for access to you. If they want you to do the close, that is a service at a different number. Do not hide a call inside \$19.

When to raise

Raise after a stranger has bought from a video and told you what they used. Then add the missing template or a 14-day calendar and move new sales to \$47. Email the extra page free to people who already paid \$19. Raise because the file does more, not because video five felt quiet.

Do not raise because you got bored of saying \$19. Do not add a \$97 pro vault with a live call unless you mean to run a service path instead. Same channel. Same weekly video. Clearer file.

YouTube ads are a sidecar

YouTube ad revenue is a sidecar, not the plan. Do not wait for 1,000 subscribers to monetize. You monetize from video one with the link. The platform's ads are gravy if they ever arrive.

A new channel's RPM is a rounding error. Plan as if ads will never show up. If they do, they do not change the offer, the weekly block, or what you measure. Click to the file still wins.

What you do not sell in the video

You do not sell a second channel, a merch line, or a vague work-with-me. You do not stack five affiliate links under an eight-minute tutorial. One offer. If an affiliate tool is truly used on screen, disclose it and keep it below the playbook link. The playbook is the reason you sat down.

You do not sell a membership from video two or a newsletter as the primary ask. You do not sell gear. A cheap mic in the corner of the frame is fine. A 12-minute haul of lights is a different channel.

Worked dollars

Morgan sells the month-end playbook at \$19. Video 1 goes up on a Saturday. Week 1: 90 views, two description clicks, zero sales. Week 5: video 1 has 400 search views, 11 description clicks, two \$19 sales. First stranger sale from a video: day 36. \$38 that week. If she had pitched \$297 at

minute one, she would have zero sales. If she had posted daily with no file, she would have a streak and an empty register.

Price on camera, once

Say the number. Whispering the product and hiding the price is how people click, stall on the page, and leave. If you want the one-page version plus the prompts, the \$19 playbook is the first link in the description. That is the whole pitch. Then stop talking. Let the end screen do the rest.

The first 72 hours

The weekend this is built for

The first 72 hours are a Thursday-to-Saturday job. Pick the question. Outline eight minutes. Record Friday night even if the lighting is boring. Publish Saturday morning. End with one link. Write the title like a search, not a brand campaign. Make a thumbnail that reads at phone size.

Do not spend the 72 hours shopping for lights. Do not draft four videos to batch a month before you have uploaded one. Video one live is the whole point of the weekend.

Hours 1–8: pick the question they already type

Open YouTube and Google. Type the job. Read the titles that already rank. Write five questions in their words, not yours. How to close month-end in Claude without it inventing numbers is a question. AI tips for bookkeepers is a vibe. Pick the question you can answer without a week of research.

The test: would they type this at 9 p.m. with receipts on the desk? If no, pick again. Write the one-sentence offer at the top of a doc. Watch the first three ranking videos at 1.5x. Note what they promise, where they stall, and what they never show. Steal the language of the query, not their jokes. Stop. That is a good first evening.

Hours 9–16: outline on a doc, not in your head

Outline: promise, three beats, demo, recap, soft ask. Write it as chapters with rough times: 0:00 promise, 0:40 beat 1, 3:00 beat 2, 5:00 beat 3, 6:30 demo on the actual screen, 7:30 recap, 8:00 soft ask.

Ask a model for counter-arguments and a chapter list. Paste: Buyer is [person]. Question is [query]. File is [name] at \$19. Give me an eight-minute outline: promise, three beats, a screen demo, recap, soft ask. List what a skeptic would say at minute four. No hype. No invented statistics. Verify anything that looks like a fact. Delete invented numbers. If a beat is why AI matters, delete it.

Hours 17–24: Friday night, record

Cheap mic. Face the window. Notes on the desk, not a teleprompter novel. Talking head for the promise, the recap, and the ask. Screen for the demo and any beat that is a tool. You are allowed to be boring. You are not allowed to be false.

Record the eight minutes in one or two takes. If you cough, pause and start the sentence again. You will cut the cough later. Do not film four videos. Film this one. Stop at 8:45 even if you have more to say. Extra talk is how the recap dies.

Hours 25–48: Saturday morning, edit only what you must

Dead air, the cough, the 40-second ramble. That is the edit. Jump cut the stalls. Leave the kitchen table in the shot. You do not need a motion intro.

Thumbnail: five words, readable on a phone, your face or the result, not a collage. Title = the search question. Description = chapters, tools, one link near the top and again at the end. End screen = one button, the playbook. Pinned comment = the same sentence plus the URL.

Open the checkout on your phone, on cellular. If the file does not arrive, fix that before you publish. Then publish. Saturday morning. Not next Saturday.

Hours 49–72: leave it up, then listen

Do not start a second video until this one is live. Follow up once in the community tab with a single line and the same link, if you have a tab. Answer comments that argue with the method.

Those are video two. Do not refresh Studio every twenty minutes. Views on day one are not the metric. Keep next Friday on the calendar.

What you refuse in the first 72 hours

A second channel. A daily Shorts plan. A gear haul. A title that is a brand campaign. A thumbnail with eight words. A description with twelve links. An origin story. A statistic you cannot show. A batch of eight videos in a format you have not published once.

Video one live, link working, next Friday booked. That is a complete 72 hours.

The path, step by step

Step 1. Pick the question they already type

Open YouTube. Type the job. Read the autocomplete and the titles that already rank. Write five questions in their words. Pick one you can answer Friday night without a week of research. Put the recording block on the calendar like a shift. If you miss a week, you record two the next. You do not open a second channel to reset.

If the question is not a search they would type, it is a brand campaign. Kill it. How to close month-end in Claude as a solo bookkeeper is a question. AI Tips That Will Change Your Practice is a campaign. You are an answer.

Step 2. Outline: promise, three beats, demo, recap, soft ask

Write it in a doc. First 20 seconds: the result they get by staying. By the end of this you will have a close checklist you can run tomorrow, including the prompt that asks for missing numbers instead of inventing them. Then three beats, each a verb plus an object. Then the demo on the actual screen. Then a recap they could screenshot. Then the \$19 ask, once, last 45 seconds.

AI can draft this. You reorder it so a tired person can follow. If the job does not fit in eight to twelve minutes, it is two videos with two titles, not a cliffhanger.

Step 3. Verify every fact

If the model invented a statistic, it does not go in the video. If you have not run the prompt on screen, you do not claim it works. Say I do not know that number on camera if you do not. Primary source, your own screen, or it stays out.

Step 4. Title is the search question

How to close month-end in Claude as a solo bookkeeper beats anything with change your life in it. Include the job, the tool, and the pain if it fits. Write five titles. Pick the one you would type. After you publish, you may test a second title if click-through is sad and impressions exist. You may not rewrite the channel name because video one was quiet.

Step 5. Thumbnail that is search-honest

Five words or fewer. High contrast. One idea. Readable with the phone at arm's length. Your face or the result, not a collage, not a lie the video cannot pay off. STOP fake totals is honest if the video shows how to stop fake totals. You will not believe this is a lie even if the video is good.

Step 6. Record talking-head plus screen

Talking head for the promise, the recap, and the ask. Screen for the demo and any beat that is a click path in the tool. Picture-in-picture is optional. Four-camera switching is delay. Face a window. Mic within a foot of your mouth. Sit still. Talk. Notes on the desk, not a novel. Phone mics in a quiet room can work for video one. Echoey kitchens cannot.

Step 7. Edit only what you must

Dead air, the cough, the ramble. No copyright music. No stolen clips. No 40-second intro sting. Export. Watch once on your phone with the sound on. If you cannot hear the \$19 line, the ask failed. CapCut or the YouTube editor is enough.

Step 8. Description: chapters, tools, one link

Timestamps. The \$19 link once near the top and again at the end. Tools you actually used. One sentence that is the offer, not a biography. A tired person who listened in the car should be able to open the description, tap the first link, and buy. If they have to hunt, you built a junk drawer.

Step 9. Pin a comment with the same link

Same sentence you said at 8:00, plus the URL. If you want the one-page version plus the prompts, the \$19 playbook is here: [link]. Pin it on every video for eight weeks. Reply to real method arguments. Do not sit in a 40-reply thread. The argument is next week's outline.

Step 10. End screen is one link to the file

Not a grid of eight old videos and a subscribe animation that eats the ask. One button, the playbook. A subscribe box is allowed as a second element only if it does not cover the ask. Set it before you publish. Test that the button goes to the checkout, not to a trailer or a dead page.

Step 11. Publish one video a week for eight weeks

Saturday morning is the default. Film Friday night. Publish before you start the rest of the weekend. Do not sit in drafts until you feel ready. Same offer every week. New search question in the same job family. Four videos is a start. Eight is a pattern. Ten is when you double down.

Step 12. After eight to ten videos, double down on clicks, not on vibes

Mark the three that earned description clicks, saves, or comments that argued with the method. Repeat those shapes. Same structure, new question. Kill the formats that died in silence. Do not start a second channel or a second offer. Do not go daily because a video got lucky on browse. Search compounds on a name, not on a network of empty accounts.

Worked example: Morgan and the \$19 playbook at the end

Morgan, the file, the qualification

Morgan is a solo bookkeeper who already sold a \$19 playbook: a month-end close sequence for one-person bookkeepers using Claude, with the prompts and a checklist. Sales were friends-and-friends. Search was not sending anyone. Morgan could explain the job without rushing and could sit still for a recording. That is the whole qualification.

The one sentence: I answer how a one-person bookkeeper closes month-end in Claude without invented numbers, then I point at the \$19 close playbook. Channel name is boring and searchable. Not a vibe. Not a second personality.

Checkout already worked on a phone. Filename: month-end-close-claude-playbook.pdf. Price on the page. Morgan had bought it from a second email. That is why long-form was allowed this month.

The weekly machine

One video a week, eight to ten minutes, cheap USB mic, kitchen table, window on the left. Talking head for the open, the recap, and the ask. Screen recording for the prompt and the checklist. Every video ended on the same sentence: If you want the checklist and the prompts in one file, the \$19 playbook is in the description. No countdown. No fake scarcity.

Recording block: Friday 8 p.m. to 9:30 p.m. Publish block: Saturday 8 a.m. to 9:30 a.m. Thumbnail, description, pin, end screen, publish. Then the rest of Saturday is not YouTube. That is how the eight weeks actually happen.

Video 1, Friday night to Saturday morning

Title: How to close month-end in Claude without it inventing numbers. Thumbnail: STOP fake totals in four words plus Morgan's face, high contrast, readable at arm's length. First 20 seconds: what done looks like — a close checklist with gaps flagged, not filled with guesses. Then the three-step job. Screen demo of the prompt that asks for missing numbers instead of inventing them. Recap. Soft ask at 8:10.

Outline Morgan actually used:

0:00 By the end you will have a close checklist you can run tomorrow that flags gaps instead of inventing totals.

0:40 Beat 1: paste the trial balance as-is, tell Claude not to fill holes.

3:00 Beat 2: the prompt that asks one missing number at a time.

5:10 Beat 3: the one mistake — letting it round a GST line because it sounded confident.

6:40 Demo: Morgan runs a messy sample on screen, shows the invented total, then the fixed prompt.

7:40 Recap in four lines.

8:10 If you want the checklist and the prompts in one file, the \$19 playbook is in the description.

Morgan asked a model for skeptic lines at minute four. The model invented a statistic about bookkeeper error rates. Morgan deleted it. Edit on Saturday morning: two coughs, one ramble. Thumbnail in five minutes. Description with timestamps, tools, the link at the top and the bottom. Pinned comment. End screen: one button. Publish at 9:12 a.m.

Videos 2, 3, and 4

Video 2: What to paste into Claude when the client's receipts are a mess. Same offer. Same table. The demo is a pile of photo receipts and a paste order. Video 3: The month-end prompt that asks one question at a time. Video 4 came from a comment on video 1: a bookkeeper who argued about GST. Title: Why your AI close keeps drifting off the trial balance.

Each one a search question. Each one a complete small job. None of them a trailer for a course. One explainer. One Friday. One Saturday.

What happened, with dollars

Week 1: 90 views, two description clicks, zero sales. Morgan did not panic-rewrite the thumbnail on day two and did not start a second channel.

Week 2: a comment from a bookkeeper who argued about GST. That argument became video 4. Still no sale from the videos. One friend bought after a text; Morgan did not count it as a stranger sale.

Week 5: 400 views on video 1 from search, 11 description clicks, two \$19 sales. First stranger sale from a video: day 36. Inside the 30–60 day window. UTM on the link showed youtube-v1. \$38 that week from people Morgan had never met. Studio said suggested traffic was almost nothing. Search was doing the work. Morgan ignored a YouTube email about posting more often.

After ten, double down

By video 10, three titles had earned comments and watch time: the inventing-numbers video, the receipts video, and the trial-balance video. Morgan repeated those shapes for the next month instead of inventing a travel vlog. New questions, same spine: promise, three beats, demo, recap, \$19 ask. Description clicks, not vanity views, told her which shapes to keep.

Month 2 cash from the channel was not a living. It was the \$19 file finally arriving from search instead of from friends. Not a creator career. A front door that stays open while Morgan does the actual books.

The mistake and the recovery

On video 3 Morgan talked for 90 seconds about how she became a bookkeeper. Average view duration fell off a cliff at 0:22. She did not delete the video. She trimmed the bio in the YouTube editor, moved the promise to 0:00, and wrote the rule on a sticky note: no origin in the first 20 seconds. Video 4 opened on the GST drift. Watch time recovered.

She almost added a second link to a newsletter in the description of video 5. She did not. One link. The \$19 file. Shipped artifact: ten search-titled videos, one cheap mic, one playbook, a pinned comment that never changed, and a Saturday morning habit. First stranger sale from a video on day 36. Copy the shape, not the niche, unless you also close books.

Copy you can paste

Swap the job. Keep the constraints. Do not add hype. Fill the brackets. Publish.

Title formulas (search, not campaign)

How to [job] in [tool] without [pain they already have]

What to paste into [tool] when [messy input]

Why your [result] keeps [failure], and the fix in 8 minutes

The [job] prompt that asks one question at a time

Write five. Pick the one you would type at 9 p.m. If it sounds like a billboard, throw it out.

First 20 seconds

By the end of this you will have [named artifact] you can use [timeframe]. I will show the three steps, the one mistake I still see, and then a file if you want the checklist. If you only want the video, that is enough. Stay for the steps.

Do not start with hey guys or a 90-second bio. Name the result of staying. Then start the first beat.

Soft ask at the end (last 45 seconds)

If you want the one-page version plus the prompts, the \$19 playbook is the first link in the description. It is the same sequence I just walked through, written down so you do not have to rewind me. If the video was enough, good. Use it.

Say the price. Then stop. Let the end screen be the button. Do not add a countdown. Do not add only this week.

Description block

Playbook (\$19): [one link]

0:00 What done looks like

0:40 Step 1

3:00 Step 2

5:20 The mistake

7:10 Recap

8:00 The \$19 file

Tools on screen: [names]

I use [tool]. If I mention an affiliate later it will be disclosed. Today the only ask is the file.

If it is not useful, email me and I will refund.

Paste that. Change the times after you edit. Keep the link at the top. A tired thumb should not have to scroll past your life story.

Pinned comment

If you want the checklist and the prompts in one file, the \$19 playbook is here: [link]. Same sequence as the video, written down. If the eight minutes were enough, use them.

Pin it on every video for eight weeks. Same words. Recognition is the point. After video 1 you may add one community-tab line: Posted the eight-minute close. Link in the new video, same \$19 file. Once. Not a daily community streak.

Thumbnail text (five words or fewer)

STOP invented numbers

Paste the messy receipts

One question at a time

Trial balance keeps drifting

Gaps flagged, not guessed

High contrast. One idea. Your face or the result. If you cannot read it with the phone at arm's length, it is decoration. If the video cannot pay off the five words, it is a lie.

End screen

One element: the playbook. Button text: \$19 playbook. Duration: last 20 seconds, overlapping the spoken ask. No grid of eight old videos. No merch. No subscribe animation that covers the button. If YouTube forces a second slot, a subscribe box is the only extra. The file still gets the better corner.

Replies you will actually send

When they argue with the method: You are right that [their constraint] changes the paste. I will show that version next week. The \$19 file still has the checklist I used today. If you already have a close you like, you do not need it. Then actually make that video. Do not win the thread. Steal the outline.

When they ask you to do the job: This video is the sequence. The \$19 file is the written version. I do not include a call at \$19. If you want someone to close the month for you, that is a service at a

different number. I will refund you if you bought thinking I would do the books.

Bio line

I teach one job per video. \$19 playbook in the description. One file, not a catalog.

Week-by-week

This is eight weeks of one video, not a content brand. Film Friday night. Publish Saturday morning. Same file the whole way.

Week 1: pick, outline, film, publish

Monday or Thursday: pick the question they already type. Write the one-sentence offer. Outline promise, three beats, demo, recap, soft ask. Ask a model for counter-arguments. Verify. Delete invented numbers.

Friday night: cheap mic, window, talking head plus screen. One or two takes. Saturday morning: cut dead air, thumbnail of five words, description with chapters and one link, pinned comment, one end screen. Publish. Do not batch four videos before you have uploaded one. Sunday: put next Friday on the calendar.

Week 2: same offer, new question in the family

Read the comments from video 1. One of them is the outline. If there are no comments, use the second question you wrote in week 1. Same file. Same on-camera sentence.

Follow up on video 1 in the community tab with a single line and the same link. Once. Film Friday. Publish Saturday. Do not change the channel name. Do not add a newsletter link.

Week 3: thumbnail pass, not a rebrand

Third video. Same spine. Improve the thumbnail on video 1 if impressions exist and click-through is sad (under 2%). Do not rewrite the whole channel. Do not replace the title with a joke.

Look at where people leave. If they leave at 25 seconds, the first 20 seconds did not name a result. Fix that on video 3. Do not blame the algorithm yet. You barely have search data.

Week 4: a month of titles

Fourth video. You now have a month. Look at comments, average view duration, and description clicks, not vanity views. Repeat the shape that earned the most clicks or comments next week.

If nobody clicked the offer, check in this order: does the link work on a phone, is the ask actually in the last 45 seconds, is the file named in the description, is the title a real search. Then record video 4 on the same job. Giving up at video three is how this path dies.

Weeks 5–6: search starts, stay boring

This is where Morgan's first stranger sale showed up. Do not celebrate by going daily. Do not celebrate by launching a second file. Do not pivot into vlogs.

Two more search questions in the same family. Steal objections. Teach the whole small job each time. Watch Studio for traffic source: search versus suggested. If search is carrying you, keep writing titles like searches. If suggested is carrying a video that got no clicks, do not clone the clickbait. Clone the video that earned a checkout.

Weeks 7–8: protect the weekly block

Seventh and eighth videos. Same offer. You are allowed to be tired of your own sentence. Say it anyway. If you missed a week, record two this week. Do not open a second channel because this one feels slow. Slow is the hallway.

After eight weeks: mark three winners

List every video with description clicks, comments that argued, and average view duration versus length. Circle three. Those shapes get the next four weeks. Do not delete video one because it only got 90 views in week one. Search still arrives. Do not add a second file until the first one is the only link you are willing to say out loud. You may cut one 30-second piece from a mistake section after four long videos exist. The weekly explainer stays.

What not to add in these eight weeks

A second channel. A merch line. A \$297 cohort. A daily upload streak. A membership. A gear haul. A title voice that is not a search. Anything that makes Friday night plus Saturday morning impossible to keep. One name. One file. One weekly block.

The quality bar

Voice

Kitchen table, not conference stage. Short sentences. Named tools. Named times. If a paragraph could run in a motivational clip, cut it. If you would not say it to a friend after dinner, do not say it to a lens.

Honest minutes beat produced minutes. A kitchen table, a cheap mic, and a kept promise will outlast a studio intro you cannot sustain every week. Notes are fine. A novel is not.

Picture and sound

Sit still. Face a window. Mic within a foot of your mouth. If the fridge is loud, unplug it for ten minutes. You do not need four-camera switching. You need words a tired bookkeeper can follow.

Talking head plus screen is the default. Face for promise, recap, ask. Screen for the demo. Phone mics in a quiet room can work for video one. Echoey kitchens cannot. A microphone haul in week 1 is delay.

The promise

Title, thumbnail, and first 20 seconds agree. The video pays them off. If the title says how to plan a week of posts for a one-person cleaning company and the video is a 14-minute origin story, you lied. They leave. You do not get the click. You do not get the \$19.

Facts

You verify. The model drafts an outline and lists counter-arguments. If a number did not come from you, a primary source, or a screen you can show, it stays out. Run the prompt on screen

before you claim it works. If it failed once, show the failure and the fix.

The ask

Soft, once, after the job is taught. Hard sells at minute one, or a missing ask at minute eight, both fail. Teach. Then point. Same sentence every week. Price spoken. Link in four places: spoken, description, pinned comment, end screen. Still one ask.

Four tests before you publish

Friday-night test: can you film this Friday and publish Saturday morning? If the process needs a colorist and a weekend of doubt, it will not survive eight weeks. Arm's-length test: if you cannot read the five thumbnail words at arm's length, it is decoration. 20-second test: play only the open for someone who does the job; if they cannot name what they will have by the end, rewrite it. Whole-job test: a stranger should be able to finish the small job from the video alone. Fair means the file is convenient, not mandatory.

Below the bar

A title with no search in it. A thumbnail collage. A bio for the first 90 seconds. A withheld step. An invented statistic. Daily empty uploads. A description junk drawer. An end-screen grid. A \$297 pitch from video three. Copyright music. Sitting in drafts. If a tired person cannot use the job tonight, it is below the bar.

What to measure

Count these

A video that produces a click to your offer is the first sale unit. Views are the weather.

Click-through on the title and thumbnail. If impressions exist and CTR is under 2%, the search language is weak or the thumbnail is wallpaper.

Average view duration versus length. If they leave at 25 seconds, the first 20 seconds did not name a result. If they stay and bounce at the ask, the ask is too hard or the file is unclear.

Description clicks. YouTube Studio shows them. Zero clicks and a thousand views means the offer is invisible or untrusted.

\$19 sales attributed to the week a video went up. Crude, good enough. UTM on the link if you can.

Comments that argue with the method. Those are video outlines. Count them. Answer them on camera, not in a 40-reply thread.

Traffic source: search versus suggested versus browse. This path is search. Suggested is gravy.

Click to offer, not vanity views

A hundred search views and four description clicks is a healthy video. Ten thousand browse views and zero clicks is a crowd on the sidewalk. Do not clone the sidewalk. Clone the door. Ask the first stranger buyer which video they watched. That shape is the spine of the next month.

When to ignore the algorithm

Ignore post every day. Ignore you should be on Shorts instead. Ignore emails that tell you to post more often when you have not published eight honest videos. Ignore subscriber count until the file is selling. Ignore a spike of suggested traffic on a video that earned no checkout.

Pay attention to search titles, description clicks, and whether the link works. Pay attention to where they drop in the first 20 seconds. Pay attention to method arguments in the comments. The algorithm is a matching machine. Give it a title that matches a query and a video that keeps the promise. Then leave it alone.

Week 1

Count: question written, outline exists, video published, link works on a phone, pinned comment live, end screen set, next Friday booked. Views on day one do not count as a score. If the video is still in drafts, you do not have a week 1.

Day 30

Count videos published (target 4). Description clicks. Comments that argue. CTR once impressions exist. Sales from the week a video went up. A healthy day-30: four search-titled

videos, a working link, at least a few description clicks. First stranger sale may still be in the hallway. Time to first is 30–60 days.

Day 60

Count eight videos. Three winners marked. At least one stranger sale, or a clear reason why not (title is not a search, ask missing, link broken, file unclear). If you have \$0 and two videos, you did not run the path. You visited it.

Ignore these

Daily upload streaks. Subscriber vanity. A comment that says great energy. Watch hours as a flex. RPM before you have the sidecar, and even then. A second platform's view count. A video with 2,000 views and zero clicks has a broken offer or a buried link.

A simple weekly log

One line a week: date, title, duration, impressions, CTR, average view duration, description clicks, comments that argue, sales, traffic source that dominated. If description clicks are always empty, the ask is missing or the link is dead. If CTR is sad after impressions exist, fix the title and the five words. Do not fix it by posting daily.

Objections you will hear

Long-form is dead. Only Shorts work.

Shorts borrow attention. They can send people here. They are not a replacement for eight minutes that answer a search question. Search still pays the file. Shorts without an offer pay in noise. After you have four long videos, you may cut a 30-second piece from the mistake section. Same offer in the pinned comment. Do not replace the weekly explainer with only Shorts.

I need better gear first.

You need a cheap mic and a question. Lighting can be a window. Gear shopping is a delay costume. Phone mics in a quiet room can work for video one. Spend after a stranger checkout if

audio was the actual complaint. A microphone haul in week 1 is how people never publish.

I should post every day to feed the algorithm.

Daily uploads with no point are the leave-alone. One honest video a week, done, beats seven sketches you are ashamed of. The algorithm is a matching machine, not a pet. Feed it search titles and kept promises. Ignore the hunger narrative. Morgan ignored the post-more email. Search still sent the two sales.

What if someone copies my series?

They might copy the titles. They cannot copy the way you close a month or plan a week. Teach the whole job anyway. The file still has the prompts. Being copied is a tax on being useful. Pay it by staying specific.

I do not have a playbook yet.

Then this path is early. Write the \$19 file first, or in the same 72 hours as video 1. A channel with no register is a diary. A simple PDF is enough: checklist plus prompts. Do not build a 12-week course to justify sitting down.

My voice sounds weird.

Everyone thinks that. Sit still. Talk. Publish video one. You will hate it. Video four is less painful. Giving up at video three is the mistake this path is famous for. If you freeze on camera, lean on the screen and keep your voice.

I will batch a month so I do not have to think.

You can record two on a good day. Do not batch eight before you have uploaded one. You will learn from comments. Batching a dead format is efficient waste. Film Friday. Publish Saturday. Let week 2 be smarter than a folder of eight untested opens.

Nobody watches eight minutes anymore.

People searching a how-to will stay if you pay off the title. They will not stay for a tour of your setup. Eight honest minutes is the default because the job fits. If they leave at 25 seconds, your open failed. That is a rewrite, not a verdict on the internet.

I am not a YouTuber.

Good. This path wants a person who can explain a job without rushing and sit still for a recording. The video is a front door for a file. You need eight Saturdays, not a creator career.

What this path feeds next

The library is the asset

The ten videos are a library. Three of them become Shorts with the same offer. The comments become newsletter issues. The outlines become chapters in a \$47 version of the file.

A video that ranks is a front door you do not have to stand in. People will still arrive in six months. That is why you do not delete video one because it only got 90 views in week one. Protect the library. Do not rebrand it into a vlog.

Short-form, after four long videos

Cut a 30-second piece from the mistake section. Same offer in the pinned comment. Do not replace the weekly explainer. Use Shorts as a tap, not as a new career, and only after a stranger has clicked the file.

The letter and the \$47 file

Comments that argue are issue ideas. The three winning outlines are chapters you can tighten into a \$47 version: prompts, filled example, 14-day plan. Email the extra free to people who already paid \$19. Do not start the letter as the primary ask in week 1.

Leads you did not ask for

If a local owner comments, that is a lead for a productized week. If a brand asks you to make product videos, do not pivot the channel into UGC ads. Keep the explainers. If they ask you to do the job, that is a service at a different number. Refund anyone who bought the \$19 thinking you would close their month.

What this feeds badly

Five more channels. A daily upload habit. A membership announced from video three. A course platform. A merch line. A second personality. One name. One file. One weekly block. Let the rest of the suite take the overflow.

A ranking how-to that you then bury under a rebrand is how people throw away the only compounding they had. Do not throw it away because you got bored of saying \$19.

Keep the door up

When a later path is working — a letter, a skill pack, a local week — the long-form video still sits there sending strangers. You filmed it once. It keeps pointing at the file. Do not delete it to look new.

Mistakes that kill this path

Clickbait the video cannot pay off

A title about a complete job and a video that is a teaser. They will not buy the \$19 file from someone who already cheated the eight minutes. Search-honest titles and thumbnails are the product the algorithm and the human both see. If you lie there, nothing else in the video can save you.

Reading a script like a hostage

Notes, not a novel. If you cannot say it to a person across a table, do not say it to a lens. A teleprompter wall of text is how people sound like a press release. Kitchen-table English is the quality bar. Record a test. If you hate it because you sound stiff, you are reading. Talk.

No offer, or a junk-drawer offer

A beautiful explainer with nowhere to go. Soft ask, one link. A Linktree with twelve buttons is not a soft ask. Five affiliates under an eight-minute tutorial is not a soft ask. Missing the ask because you felt shy is how a thousand views become zero dollars.

Giving up at video three

Time to first is 30–60 days of one a week. Video three is still the hallway. The path is famous for this quit. Put Friday on the calendar. Publish Saturday. Check the title against a real search. Check that the link works. Record video four on the same job.

Daily uploads with no point

A streak of empty videos is the thing to leave alone. Copying someone else's series. Starting a second channel because the first one feels tainted. Inventing a statistic because the model sounded confident. All of these feel like work. None of them teach the job or sell the file.

Teasing part two for a job that fits in one video

Teach the job. If there is a bigger job, it gets its own search title next week. Cliffhangers belong to entertainment. How-to searchers treat them as a broken promise. You will not get the click. You will not get the \$19.

Origin story in the first 20 seconds

They typed a question. Answer it. Origin can be one sentence later if it earns a fact. Morgan lost watch time at 0:22 by talking about becoming a bookkeeper. She trimmed it. Put the sticky note on the desk: promise first.

Measuring vanity views and obeying the algorithm email

Views without description clicks are weather. Post-more emails are not a strategy. If you chase suggested traffic with a daily habit, you will drop the weekly explainer, which is the only thing this path sells. Ignore the algorithm until you have eight search-titled videos and a click log.

Gear, music, and a second channel

A studio you cannot sustain. A copyright track that kills the video that was about to rank. A clip you do not own. Skip them. Your voice, your screen, your cheap mic. A second file in the description trains them to freeze. A second channel is how you stay at video three forever, twice.

Tools

YouTube, one channel

Search titles. Studio for CTR, duration, description clicks, traffic sources. Community tab once a week at most. Do not spread the same eight minutes across four platforms in week 1. You can upload the file elsewhere later. One name. One weekly block.

YouTube is the default because how-to search still lives there. Do not pick a host because a thread said the algorithm is nicer. Pick the place a tired bookkeeper already types the question.

A cheap mic and a quiet room

A wired lav or a simple USB mic. Phone mics in a quiet room can work for video one. Echoey kitchens cannot. Mic within a foot of your mouth. Unplug the fridge if you have to. Sit still. Face a window. Optional cheap light. Optional cheap stand for the phone.

You do not need four cameras. You do not need a mixer. You do not need a studio subscription to explain month-end.

A doc outline, plus AI for notes you verify

Google Doc or paper. Chapters with timestamps after you edit. AI for research notes you will verify, for counter-arguments, for a title list, for a skeptic at minute four. Not for facts you cannot show. Not for a script you will read like a hostage.

Paste the outline prompt from the first 72 hours. Reorder by hand. Delete invented numbers. That is the whole AI stack for this path.

Talking-head plus screen

Phone or laptop camera for the face. Screen recording for the tool. CapCut or the YouTube editor for jump cuts. Picture-in-picture is optional. If you freeze on camera, screen plus voice is enough for the demo. Keep the talking head for the ask so they know a person stands behind the \$19 file.

The \$19–\$47 file and a working link

Stan, Stripe, your site. Test on a phone, on cellular. One link. UTM if you can: youtube-v1, youtube-v2. Checkout title matches the sentence you say on camera. Refund line on the page. Filename a human can find.

If the download fails, the eight minutes were unpaid teaching. Fix the register before you film video two.

What you do not need

A second channel. A scheduling suite. Copyrighted music. A brand kit. A lighting haul. Analytics tools beyond Studio for the first eight weeks. A Linktree. Anything that makes Friday night plus Saturday morning harder.

Checklist

Before you film

- \$19–\$47 file exists and the link works on a phone

- One search question written in the buyer's words

- One-sentence offer at the top of the doc: I answer [question] for [person], then I point at [file] for \$19

- Eight-minute outline: promise, three beats, demo, recap, ask

- AI notes verified, invented statistics deleted

- First 20 seconds written so they name the result of staying

Friday night blocked, Saturday morning blocked

No second channel, no second file, no daily plan

While you film

Cheap mic within a foot of your mouth, or a phone in a quiet room

Window or cheap light, sit still

Talking head for promise, recap, ask

Screen for the demo

Notes, not a novel

Whole small job taught, no part-two tease

Soft ask once, last 45 seconds, price spoken

Before you publish Saturday morning

Edit only dead air, coughs, rambles

Title equals the search question

Thumbnail reads at phone size, five words or fewer, search-honest

Description: chapters, tools, one offer link at the top and the bottom

Pinned comment: same sentence plus the URL

End screen is one link to the file

Checkout tested on cellular

No copyright track, no stolen clips

After it is live

Published. Not sitting in drafts

Next Friday on the calendar

One community-tab line at most, same link

Comments that argue saved as outlines

Description clicks checked a week later, not an hour later

One video a week for eight weeks

After eight to ten, three winners marked to repeat

Algorithm emails ignored

No daily empty uploads

The one-page weekend

Thursday: question plus outline. Friday night: record. Saturday morning: edit, thumbnail, description, pin, end screen, publish. That is the whole machine. If a step makes that weekend impossible, cut the step, not the Saturday.

FAQ

How long should the video be?

Eight honest minutes is the default. Twelve if the job needs a screen recording. Twenty only if you are actually teaching twenty minutes of work, not stalling. People searching a how-to will stay if you pay off the title. Default: eight minutes, last 45 seconds for the ask.

Do I need to show my face?

It helps trust. It is not required if the job is a screen and your voice is clear. Talking-head plus screen is the default: face for promise, recap, and ask; screen for the demo. Pick one mix and keep it for ten videos. Default: face plus screen.

Can I batch a month in a day?

You can record two on a good day. Do not batch eight before you have uploaded one. You will learn from comments. Batching a dead format is efficient waste. Film Friday. Publish Saturday. Default: one live video before any batch.

Shorts as well?

After you have four long videos. Cut a 30-second piece from the mistake section. Same offer in the pinned comment. Do not replace the weekly explainer with only Shorts. Search lives on the long one. Default: explainers first, Shorts later, never instead.

What if I have no playbook?

Write it this week, even ugly. The video can sell a simple PDF: checklist plus prompts. That is enough for \$19. Without the file, this path is a hobby with a microphone. Default: file in the same 72 hours as video 1.

Should I tell a long origin story?

No. First 20 seconds are the result. Origin can be one sentence. They typed a question. Answer it. Morgan lost watch time at 0:22 on a bio and trimmed it. Default: promise first, origin almost never.

How do I pick the next title?

Search plus comments. The question people ask under video 1 is video 2. The failure they confess is video 3. After eight to ten, repeat the three that earned description clicks. Default: their words, same job family.

What about copyright music and clips?

Skip them. Your voice, your screen, your cheap mic. A stolen track can kill the video that was about to rank. No hauls, no movie clips, no someone else's B-roll. Default: silence or room tone under the talk, nothing you do not own.

When do I change the offer?

When the \$19 file has buyers who ask for the next layer. Then a \$47 version, same channel, same weekly video, new link. Not a new channel. Not five files in the description. Not a \$297 cohort from video three. Default: same \$19 sentence for eight weeks.

I published three videos and nothing happened. Now what?

That is the hallway. Time to first is 30–60 days of one a week. Check titles against real searches. Check that the link works. Check that the ask is in the last 45 seconds. Record video four on the same job. Giving up at video three is how this path dies. Default: video four, same file.

Do I need a fancy camera?

No. A phone, a window, a cheap mic. Sit still. Spend after a stranger checkout if audio was the complaint. Gear shopping is a delay costume. Default: phone plus cheap mic.

Should I post every day for the algorithm?

No. Daily uploads with no point are the leave-alone. One honest video a week for eight weeks. If you miss a week, two the next. Default: one a week.

Can I use AI to write the script?

Use it for the outline, the counter-arguments, and a title list. You verify every fact. You say the words. If the model invented a statistic, it does not go in the video. Notes, not a novel. Default: AI for research notes you will verify.

Where does the link go?

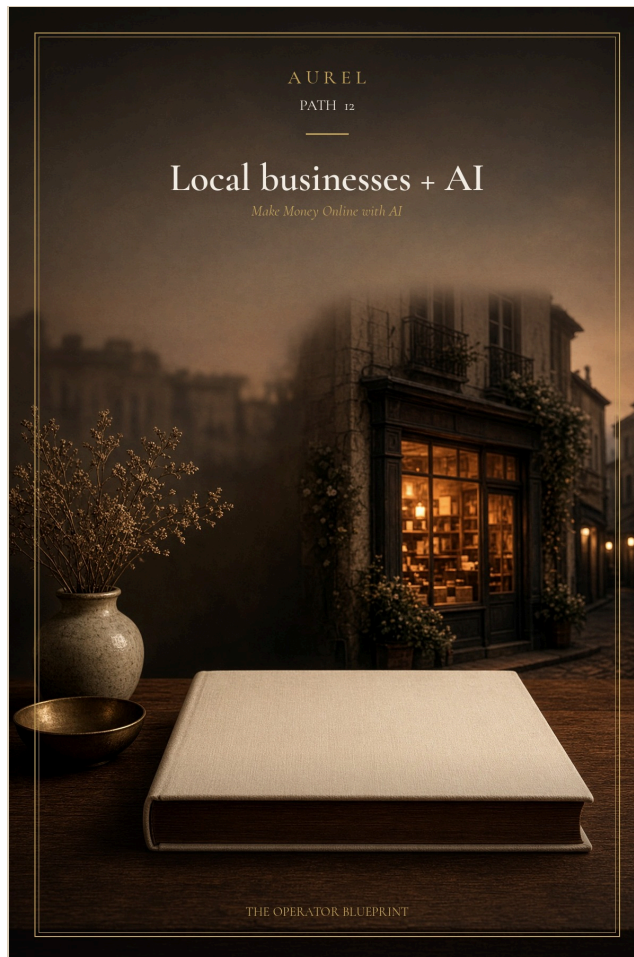
Spoken in the last 45 seconds. First lines of the description and again at the end. Pinned comment with the URL. End screen, one button. Four places, one ask, one \$19–\$47 file. Not a Linktree. Test on a phone. Default: one link, four doors.

When do I ignore the algorithm?

When it asks for daily empty uploads. When a suggested spike has no checkout. When an email tells you to post more often before you have eight honest videos. When subscriber count is trying to become the score. Pay attention to search, description clicks, and the first 20 seconds. Default: search titles and click-to-offer, not weather.

Do I need chapters and an end screen on video one?

Yes. Timestamps in the description. One end-screen button to the file. They take ten minutes on Saturday morning and they are how a tired person finds the door. Default: chapters plus one end screen, every video.



PATH 12

Local businesses + AI

Nearby owners still need pages, replies, and simple videos. Cash while digital compounds.

39 minute read · 8,675 words

Who this is for

You live near businesses that still get customers from Google, word of mouth, or a dusty site.

Time to first

3–14 days of walking and writing

Tools

First sale

One local yes and a deposit.

Cash window

\$400–\$2,000 packages

Leave this alone

A one-page PDF of the package, Stripe or e-transfer, your phone, a notes app for the ban list.

City-wide 'we do all AI' agencies. Twelve-month retainers sold before one Friday.

What you are selling

The definition

A named week of work for a nearby owner. Not a 12-month AI transformation. Not a city-wide agency. A package with a date on it: an AI-drafted page plus five posts, delivered by Friday. You edit every draft before they see it. You are the quality, not the model.

Nearby owners still need pages, replies, and simple videos. They get customers from Google, word of mouth, or a dusty site that still says opening soon from 2019. They do not need your philosophy about large language models. They need a page that tells a human what the gym costs and five posts that do not sound like a robot moved to town.

You walk in or email with a one-page PDF. Price so one yes covers the week. Cash while digital compounds: this path pays now. The notes from the job become a playbook you can sell later to people not in your town. Do not reverse that order. Do not build the playbook instead of walking.

What this is not

This is not we do all AI for every shop from the highway to the river. That sentence makes you look like a vendor who will vanish. One trade at a time. One package. One week. The first yes is allowed to be a small job. A 12-month retainer is a conversation after they have Friday's files in hand.

This is not a website rebuild, a rebrand, or an ads account. Those are different PDFs at different numbers. If they ask for those on the walk-in, you write the number later. You do not expand the \$800 pack in the hallway.

This is not a chatbot you bolt onto their site and walk away from. Owners do not want to babysit a widget. They want copy they can paste and posts they can publish. Keep the product dumb and dated.

Why this works now

The model drafts a first page in twenty minutes. That was a \$2,000 copywriter week five years ago, and it still looks like a first draft. The gap is the edit: local facts, local claims they can stand behind, a voice that sounds like the owner at the front desk. Most people selling AI locally skip the edit. You do not. That is the whole edge.

Owners already know their site is embarrassing. They have been meaning to fix it since the last New Year promo. Your job is not to convince them the internet exists. Your job is to put a Friday and a number on paper so the meaning-to stops being a story.

Google still sends people to a page with hours, a service list, and a phone number. Five posts still keep a Facebook page from looking abandoned. The tools got cheaper. The owner's Tuesday did not.

Three anti-patterns

Anti-pattern one: the city-wide agency. You print a deck, rent a logo, and pitch every trade in a 40-mile radius. You spend a month on positioning and zero days on a hallway. Leave that alone.

Anti-pattern two: the free trial page. You rewrite their home section as a gift so they can see your quality. They now have your Friday. You have a maybe. The SAMPLE rewrite from public info is the sample. Deposit starts theirs.

Anti-pattern three: the 12-month AI retainer sold on day one. You do not know their approval speed. They do not know your Friday. A retainer is a second PDF after one delivered week. Not before.

The deal you keep

You keep the week cash. You keep the notes. You keep the referral on the same street. You do not keep a 12-month hostage relationship, a city-wide brand, or a reputation for writing claims they cannot stand behind. If those three stay clean, this path compounds. If any one of them breaks, the coffee shop will hear about it before you walk the next block.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This fits you if

This path fits if you live near businesses that still get customers from Google, word of mouth, or a dusty site. You can walk into a gym or a cleaner's office without melting. You can write a clear page in English a tired owner will recognize as their shop, not as a template from a different city.

You do not need to be a marketer of record. You need a package, a printer or a phone PDF, and the nerve to follow up the next day. Introverts can email. The work is the same: ten names, five asks, one follow-up.

It also fits if you already know one trade's words. You used to clean houses. You still lift at the independent gym. You have a cousin who runs a two-van shop. Those nouns are the product. Start where you already have phrases.

Skip this if

Skip it if you want to be a city-wide we do all AI agency. That is the thing to leave alone. You will spend a month on a pitch deck and zero days on a hallway.

Skip it if you cannot tell the owner no when they ask you to invent a claim they cannot legally make. Dentists, gyms, and cleaners all have lines. You will not be the person who writes guaranteed 20 lb loss or hospital-grade kill of every pathogen because the model sounded confident.

Skip it if you need to hide behind DMs with strangers in other countries this week. This path is local on purpose. The bus fare is part of the method.

Skip it if you cannot edit. If your plan is paste the model output into their WordPress and invoice, stop. The owner will smell it. So will the next owner on the street.

The honest middle

If you can write but you freeze at a front desk, email the five. Walking still wins in small towns. Mix it. The path is visit or email, not wait to be discovered. If you can walk but you cannot write,

this is not your path until you can sit with a draft for two hours and cut the fake lines.

If you have never sold anything in person, the first five visits are practice, not a verdict. The PDF does the talking. You leave it. You follow up tomorrow. That is the whole social skill.

Skills and time

You need: a clean one-page PDF, the ability to rewrite a home section in a doc, a 20-minute kickoff, an edit pass that kills illegal claims, and a Friday walkthrough that lasts fifteen minutes. You do not need ads knowledge, a design degree, or a CRM.

Time: 3 to 14 days to the first deposit if you actually walk. The week of delivery is 6 to 12 hours of real work if the kickoff was tight. If it is taking 20 hours, the kickoff missed the facts or you are decorating.

Block four afternoons in week one for visits. Block two evenings for the first paid draft. Do not also launch a playbook, a newsletter, and a second trade. One street. One pack.

Two-minute self-test

Answer yes or no. No essays.

Can I name ten businesses in one trade within a 20-minute drive?

Can I write a services page a tired owner would recognize as their shop?

Will I say no to a claim they cannot stand behind?

Will I ask for a deposit before I draft?

Will I follow up the next day without rewriting the PDF?

Four or five yeses: print the PDF this morning. Three: email is allowed, but walk two anyway.

Two or fewer: this is not your path this month. Sell a file or take a remote productized week instead.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this in before you print

Write it on the PDF in a font they can read without glasses: [Page / Google profile / five videos] plus [five posts / five videos] this week. Deposit today, files Friday. [\$400–\$2,000].

If you cannot fill those brackets, you have a vibe, not a pack. Taylor's version is the default: Page plus five posts this week. Deposit today, files Friday. \$800.

Five sentences that work

Page plus five posts this week. Deposit today, files Friday. \$800. For independent gyms that still have a 2019 New Year graphic up.

Google Business rewrite plus five posts this week. Deposit today, files Friday. \$500. For two-van cleaners who only live on Facebook.

Services page plus five phone videos this week. Deposit today, files Friday. \$1,200. For the shop with two locations and a manager who will not write captions.

Home page plus five posts this week. Deposit today, files Friday. \$400 founder rate, expires [date]. For your first paid week only, written on the PDF so it cannot creep.

Move-out landing page plus five posts this week. Deposit today, files Friday. \$800. Same pack, narrower page, same Friday.

Each sentence names the artifact, the count, the week, the money, and who it is for. If you need and also a logo to make it feel complete, you have two products. Split them.

What they get

One page: home or services, written from their facts, edited by you, in a doc or CMS they already use.

Five posts: captions plus a photo brief, or five simple videos from your phone if that is the pack you named.

One round of notes, 24 hours, written.

A 15-minute walkthrough on Friday so they know which button to press.

A written ban list of claims you will not make, so they cannot later say you forgot to promise the moon.

What they do not get

Ads spend. A new logo. A 12-month content calendar. A new website platform unless they already asked and you priced it as a different job. A chatbot. A ranking guarantee. Unlimited rewrites. You do not sell a retainer until you have delivered once.

If they want those, you write a second PDF later. You do not stuff them into Friday for free to close the hallway conversation.

Packaging

One page. Printed and on your phone. Headline, what is in, what is out, Friday, price, deposit, your phone, two sentences of proof if you have any. A sample rewrite from public info, marked SAMPLE, counts as proof.

Do not make a brochure. Do not make a deck. Do not make a contract that looks like a law firm. A one-page agreement lives behind the PDF: deliverable, date, price, claims, who owns the copy (they do, on payment). The PDF sells. The agreement protects Friday.

Name the pack the same way every time. If you call it a content sprint on Monday and a page package on Wednesday, they will wait. Same nouns. Same number. Same Friday.

What done looks like

The definition

Done for the path: one local yes and a deposit. Not a maybe. Not send me something. Money in, date on the calendar.

Done for the week: Friday files they can use without you in the room. The page is in their voice, with their hours, their price range if they allow it, their real service list. The five posts are

scheduled or sitting in a folder with the image brief. You did not paste raw model output. You cut the claims they cannot make.

Fairness test

Read the page out loud in their doorway voice. If you would be embarrassed to hand it to a customer who already knows the shop, it is not done. If a competitor in the next town could paste it onto their site with two nouns swapped, it is not done. If the owner has to ask which file is the page, it is not done.

Would you pay \$800 for this folder if you ran their shop? If the honest answer is not yet, keep editing. Do not invoice hope.

Technical done

Deposit received before you draft.

Kickoff: 20 minutes or a form. Facts, photos they can send, phrases they hate, examples of posts they do not hate, a written ban list.

Drafts they never see until you have edited.

Page in a format they can paste: Google Doc, Word, or directly in the CMS they already use.

Not a Figma they cannot open.

Five posts named by day, each with caption, photo brief, and any link they should include.

Friday delivery in a folder they own, plus the walkthrough.

Balance paid.

A referral ask the same day: Who else on this street should hear this?

A Monday check-in text. Then you stop hovering.

Not-done-yet list

If any of these are true, you are not done. Keep going or name the miss.

Handshake, no deposit.

Raw model output in their Messenger.

Hours missing, parking missing, real service list replaced with synergistic solutions.

A claim on the page they cannot stand behind.

Files in your Google Drive with sharing set to private.

No walkthrough, just a Dropbox link at 11pm Thursday.

No referral ask because it felt awkward.

Ghosting after the posts go up.

Unlimited rewrites still open, Friday never closed.

If you ghost after the posts go up, it is not done. It is a one-star story the next owner will hear at the coffee shop.

Price so one yes covers the week

The range

Cash window: \$400–\$2,000 packages. Taylor's page plus five posts this week sits at \$800. That number should cover your hours, your walking, and the fact that you cannot sell Friday twice.

\$400–\$500 is a founder pack if you need the first case and you will write that on the PDF as a first-seat price with a date it expires. \$800 is the default once you have one sample page made from public info. \$1,200–\$2,000 when the page is a full services rewrite plus five videos, or when the owner has two locations.

Do not invent \$3,500 because a course said premium. You have no proof yet. Do not invent \$150 because you are nervous. Nervous is not a price.

When to raise

Raise after one delivered Friday and a sentence from the owner you can use (with permission). Then the next PDF is \$800 if you started at \$400, or \$1,200 if you started at \$800 and the next job is videos or two locations. Raise because the pack does more or because you have a local sample, not because you got bored.

A retainer, later, can be \$1,200 a month for four posts a week. That is a different PDF. After. Not on the walk-in.

Refunds in one sentence

If the files are not usable as specified on the PDF, you refund the unused half and they keep whatever was already delivered that meets the spec. You do not refund a change of mind after Friday's walkthrough. Deposit is to start, not a souvenir.

Never charge for these

Never charge for a handshake draft. Never charge to think about it. Never charge for claims you refused to write. Never charge a percentage of their revenue. Never charge ads spend you are not running. Never charge a 12-month lump on day one.

Never charge \$0 as a trial. Free is a price. It trains the street.

Worked dollars

One \$800 yes is the week. After a 50% deposit you have \$400 in the account on day one of the job and \$400 on Friday. Two \$800 jobs in a month is \$1,600. A later \$1,200 retainer on one of them is a second till, not a replacement for walking.

A \$400 founder week plus a \$800 second week is \$1,200 in fourteen days if you actually follow up.

Do not discount to win the street. One \$800 yes is the week. Two \$300 maybes is a mess. Local means you might see them at the grocery store, which is why a clean PDF and a clean invoice matter more, not less.

The first 72 hours

Write the one-pager. List ten businesses. Visit or email five. Follow up the next day. The first yes is allowed to be a small job.

Day 1 morning

One trade. Taylor starts with cleaners, then walks gyms with the same pack. You start with one. Learn ten phrases they use: booth, membership freeze, move-out clean, drop-in. Read five Google reviews in that trade. Steal the customers' nouns, not the owners' slogans.

Write the PDF: headline, what is in, Friday, \$800, deposit, your phone, two sentences of proof if you have any (a sample page from public info counts). Print ten at the library or at home. Put the PDF on your phone too.

Pick the ten names. Real businesses, open, in a cluster you can walk or drive without a pilgrimage. Not your friend's Etsy shop in another state. Map them. Morning cleaners. Mid-morning gyms. Do not mix in a dentist yet.

Day 1 afternoon

Build one sample from a real local site that is dusty. Rewrite their home section in a doc. Watermark SAMPLE. Strip fake claims. Put the real cross-street in if it is on the site. You will show it, then offer to do theirs properly with their facts. Do not pretend you already work there.

If you cannot finish the sample in three hours, the page is too ambitious or you are decorating. Home section only. Not the whole site.

Day 1 night

Rehearse the walk-in line out loud once. I am not selling a 12-month thing. One page, five posts, this week, \$800. The PDF is one page. Can I leave it with you? Then stop rewriting it. Sleep.

Day 2

Visit or email five. Walk-in: the line, the PDF, the sample if they ask. You are not pitching for twenty minutes. You are leaving paper. Email: six lines, the PDF, the sample, a Friday date you can actually hit.

Cleaners in the morning because owners are on site. Gyms at 10:30, between classes, not at 5pm when the desk is a riot. Do not visit at lunch and call it a day. Five means five.

Write what happened in the notebook: name, who you spoke to, what they said, follow-up date. That notebook is the CRM.

Day 3

Follow up the next day. In person or one line: I can still start this week if the deposit lands today. Friday files either way. Do not add a second package. Do not redesign the PDF. Walk the next five if the first five were silent.

If someone said later, put a date. If someone said no, ask who else on the block would want Friday files. If someone said send me something, you already did. The PDF is the something. Ask for the deposit or close the thread.

By hour 72 you have: a PDF, a sample, ten names, five asks, five follow-ups in motion. You do not have a brand. You do not have a second trade. You do not have a playbook. You have a week's worth of motion toward one local yes.

The path, step by step

The twelve moves

One trade. Learn their language. Cleaners, gyms, dentists, trades. Pick one. Read five of their Google reviews. The words customers use are the words on the page. They actually showed up is a better headline than synergized cleaning solutions. Write ten phrases on a card and keep it in the bag with the PDFs. You will sound like you live here, because you do.

The named week on one PDF. Page plus five posts this week. Deposit today, files Friday. \$800. Print ten copies. Phone PDF for the ones who will not take paper. Headline in a font they can read without glasses. What is in, what is out, your phone. If the PDF is three pages, it is a brochure. Cut it.

A sample made from public info. Their dusty site, rewritten in a doc, SAMPLE across it. Then: I can do yours properly with your facts. Do not pretend you already work there. Do not use their logo as if you were hired. The sample is a demonstration of the edit, not a sneak delivery.

Ten names, five visits or emails. Hallway, front desk, or the contact form they ignore. You are not a city-wide blast. You are a person on this street. Cluster the names so four visits fit in an afternoon. Shoes that can do that afternoon are a tool.

Follow up the next day. One time, clearly. Owners are busy, not coy. If they say no, ask who else on the block would want Friday files. If they say later, put a date. If they say the nephew does Facebook, use the nephew line from the objections section and leave. Zero follow-ups is how nice PDFs die on a counter.

Deposit. Kickoff. Money, then a 20-minute fact pull: hours, services, prices they will print, photos, phrases to ban, claims they must not make. Write the bans down. Read them back. If they want hospital-grade and they do not have the certificate, the ban list gets that line. Do not start a draft on a handshake.

Draft with the model. Edit like you live here. AI can draft. They never see the raw pass. Cut fake urgency. Cut medical or chemical claims. Put the real cross-street in the copy. Put the real parking note. Put the real name of the owner if they want it. If the model added eco-certified and they are not, you cut it. That cut is the job.

One round of notes, 24 hours, written. They get a folder or a doc, not a live Google Doc you are still typing in. They reply once, in writing, inside a day. Then you ship. Unlimited is how Friday never comes. Put the round on the PDF so this is not a surprise.

Deliver Friday. Folder they own. Page in a format they can paste. Five posts with the photo brief. Fifteen-minute walkthrough. Balance paid before or at the walkthrough, as the PDF said. File names a human can read. Posts in the order of the week. Then you leave.

Ask for a referral to the next owner on the same street. Same day. If this saved you a headache, who else should I walk to before I go home? Write the name in the notebook before you start the car. Walk that name the same week if you can. A referral from a delivered Friday beats ten cold gyms.

Do not ghost. A text on Monday: Any post you want swapped? One check-in. Then stop hovering. You are not their staff. Hovering trains them to treat \$800 as a junior employee. Ghosting trains the coffee shop. One text is the line.

Notes from the job become a playbook. The phrases, the claims you refused, the kickoff questions. That file can sell to cleaners in other towns. Later. After cash this week. Only then, a second week or a retainer. Same pack for the gym two doors down, or a monthly at a written rate. Not a 12-month contract sold on day one. Not a new trade on the other side of the city until this street has seen you deliver.

Log the claims you refused. A running list. This is how you stay out of trouble and how the playbook later teaches. When the next owner asks for guaranteed results, you already have three true lines ready.

Keep the street small until three Fridays exist. Three delivered weeks in one trade is a local reputation. One delivered week and a jump to dentists across town is how you start over at zero, with a thinner sample.

Worked example: Taylor walking gyms and cleaners

Who and where

Taylor lives in a town where the highway gyms have new paint and the independent ones have a Facebook page last updated for a New Year promo. The cleaners are busier than they look. Taylor is not an agency. Taylor has a phone, a one-page PDF, and a week to fill. No following. No case-study site. A library card for the prints.

Calendar, week of the 3rd

Monday morning: PDF written. Page plus five posts this week. Deposit today, files Friday. \$800. In: one services or home page, five posts (caption plus what to photograph), one round of notes. Out: ads, logos, a new website builder. Taylor printed twelve PDFs at the library. Listed ten cleaners and eight gyms, then circled the ten closest cleaners because mornings are when those owners are on site.

Monday afternoon: sample. A rewrite of a cleaner's public home page, SAMPLE watermark, fake claims stripped. The public page said hospital-grade and eco-certified. Taylor cut both. The sample said bonded, move-outs take a day, we text an ETA. Three hours, not a whole site.

Tuesday: four cleaner walk-ins before noon. Two not in. One polite no, nephew does Facebook. One take-the-PDF. Tuesday afternoon: two more, plus two emails to the ones who hide behind a form. Notebook: names, what was said.

Wednesday: follow-ups. One owner not in again. One still thinking. The take-the-PDF owner from Tuesday is in the office. That is the first yes.

The first yes and the artifact

A two-van cleaning company. The owner had been meaning to fix the site for a year. The sample looked like her shop instead of a national franchise. She asked if Taylor could also promise hospital-grade in the copy. Taylor said no: I will not write a claim you cannot stand behind. I will write that you are bonded, that move-outs take a day, and that you text an ETA. \$800. 50% today.

E-transfer on the van hood: \$400. Kickoff in the office: 18 minutes, a list of services, three photos from her camera roll, a ban list. Ban list: hospital-grade, eco-certified, guaranteed same-day, anything medical. Hours, parking in the alley, the real name of the second van.

Shipped artifact: a one-page services rewrite in a Google Doc she could paste into the existing Wix, plus five posts in a folder named by weekday. Posts: a before-and-after (with permission), a move-out checklist, a what we will not do post that built trust, a hiring post for a third van, a Friday availability. Photo briefs a person with a phone could shoot in ten minutes.

The mistake

Taylor drafted Monday night of the job week. The model added eco-certified again and a fake urgency line about slots filling up. Taylor almost left the urgency because it sounded like marketing. Caught it on the morning edit. Also almost sent the draft in Messenger at 10pm so she could see progress. Did not. They never see the raw pass.

Second mistake, smaller: the first walk-in on Tuesday used a twenty-minute pitch. The owner's eyes left. After that, Taylor used the one line and left the PDF. Shorter is the product.

Recovery and the stranger sale

The \$400 deposit was the first stranger sale. Not a cousin. Not a friend who felt sorry. A two-van owner Taylor had not met on Monday. Elapsed from first print to deposit: 6 days. Inside 3–14.

Delivered Thursday night, walkthrough Friday. Balance \$400. Asked for a referral before leaving. The owner named a gym two streets over whose manager also cleaned for her once. Taylor walked the gym the same Friday with the cleaner as the intro, not as a secret. Second pack, same \$800, gym language swapped in (drop-in, freeze, no contract shame). Deposit the following Tuesday: another \$400 in, another Friday on the calendar.

Taylor did not sell a 12-month retainer. Did not open a city-wide AI shop. Notes went into a doc that later became a \$19 playbook for cleaners in other towns. The week's cash was the \$800. The playbook was the compound. The street still had eight names unvisited. That was the next week, not a rebrand.

Copy you can paste

One-pager headline (page hero)

Page plus five posts this week. Deposit today, files Friday. \$800.

One-pager body

You get a services page written from your facts, plus five posts you can publish this week. I draft with AI. I edit every line before you see it. You get one round of notes. You do not get a 12-month contract, a new logo, or claims you cannot stand behind.

50% to start. Files Friday. Walkthrough Friday. Balance on delivery.

Walk-in line

I am not selling a 12-month thing. One page, five posts, this week, \$800. The PDF is one page. Can I leave it with you?

DM or text if they already have your number

Quick note — I still have a Friday this week for a page plus five posts at \$800, 50% to start. PDF is one page. If the timing is wrong, ignore this. If a neighbor should see it, tell me who.

Checkout / invoice line

\$800 — page plus five posts this week. 50% (\$400) due to start. Balance (\$400) due Friday before walkthrough. Deliverable as named on the one-page PDF. One round of written notes, 24 hours. Claims we will not make are on the kickoff list.

Email 1 — cold, six lines

Hi [name] — I rewrote a sample from your public page (attached, marked sample). I can do yours properly with your facts this week: one page, five posts, \$800, deposit today, files Friday. If the timing is wrong, ignore this. If a neighbor should see it, tell me who.

Email 2 — follow-up the next day

Hi [name] — I can still start this week if the deposit lands today. Friday files either way. The PDF and the sample are in the last email. No 12-month contract. If it is a no, a name on this street helps more than a maybe.

Email 3 — after delivery, referral

Hi [name] — files are in your folder and the walkthrough is done. If this saved you a headache, who else on this street should I walk to before I go home? One name is enough.

Refund line

If the files are not usable as specified on the PDF, I refund the unused half and you keep whatever already meets the spec. A change of mind after Friday's walkthrough is not a refund. Deposit starts the week. Email me the miss in one paragraph and I will answer the same day.

Kickoff questions (hand them or read them)

Hours, service list, anything you will not do

Prices that are allowed on a page

Claims I must not make

Three photos I can use

Phrases you hate

Where the page actually lives (WordPress, Squarespace, Facebook only)

Week-by-week

Week 1 — daily

Monday: PDF. Sample page from public info. Ten names. Price on the paper. Print. Map the cluster.

Tuesday: five visits or emails. Notebook after each. Do not redesign the offer between visit two and visit three.

Wednesday: follow up the first five. Walk or email the next five if the first five were silent. Still the same PDF.

Thursday: more follow-up. If a deposit lands, kickoff the same day or the next morning. If not, do not invent a second pack.

Friday: last follow-ups of the week. If you have a job, draft after kickoff, not before. If you do not have a job, list the next ten in the same trade for week 2. Do not add dentists. Do not build a website for yourself.

Saturday: optional. Rewrite the sample if five people said they did not get it. One change. Not a rebrand.

Sunday: off, or the Monday text if you already delivered. Do not spend Sunday on a logo.

Week 2 — daily

Monday: if a job is live, edit pass and ban-list check. If not, five more visits in the same trade.

Monday check-in text only if last week's Friday already happened.

Tuesday–Wednesday: draft, edit, one round of notes if they returned them. Visit the referral if you have one.

Thursday: folder ready. File names a human can read. Do not dump five raw captions into Messenger.

Friday: delivery, walkthrough, balance, referral ask. Walk the named owner the same afternoon if they are two streets over.

Saturday–Sunday: notes into a doc: phrases, claims refused, kickoff questions. That is the seed of the later playbook. Not the playbook. Seed.

If the first yes was a cleaner, the second walk is a gym or the next cleaner, not a dentist in another town.

Week 3

Same pack, full price if you discounted. Write the SOP: kickoff questions, ban list, delivery folder template. A Monday check-in text, then you stop hovering. Second or third Friday on the calendar. Do not hire a walker. Do not open a second marketplace. Do not record a course about local AI.

If two owners asked for videos, that is a second PDF at \$1,200, not a surprise inside \$800.

Week 4

Notes into a playbook draft for people not in your town, or a monthly PDF for the owner who already has Friday files. Do not sell the retainer to a stranger who has not seen you deliver. Do not hire two subcontractors and call yourself an agency.

Count: deposits this month, Fridays delivered, referrals asked, referrals walked, claims refused. If deposits are zero, the PDF is mush or you only visited friends. Fix the ask, not the brand. Then walk ten more.

The quality bar

You are the quality, not the model. If they can tell a chatbot wrote the page, you undercharged their trust and overcharged their Friday.

Below the bar

Raw model output. Fake urgency. Hours missing. A stock photo of a city that is not this one. Revolutionizing the wellness space. Guaranteed body-fat numbers. Hospital-grade with no certificate. Five captions dumped into Messenger at 11pm Thursday. Files they cannot open. A walkthrough you skipped. Ghosting on Monday. A page a competitor could steal with two nouns swapped.

If two files from two different shops of yours could be swapped without anyone noticing, you are selling a template, not a local page. That is below the bar even if the grammar is clean.

Above the bar

Real hours. Real cross-street. Real parking. Real name of the owner if they want it. Service list they actually offer, including what they will not do. Claims cut. Photo briefs a person with a phone can shoot in ten minutes (van in the driveway, 3pm light, no logo overlay). Folder they own. File names a human can read. Posts in the order of the week. Fifteen-minute walkthrough. Monday text. Referral ask. Notes saved.

Above the bar also means you refused a line and offered three true ones. That refusal is part of the product.

Five tests before you send Friday

Doorway test. Read the page out loud as if you are the owner at the desk. Would they say this?

Swap test. Could the gym two towns over paste this with two nouns changed? If yes, add facts until no.

Claim test. Every adjective has a fact behind it, or it is gone.

Folder test. A tired person can find the page and the Monday post without you on the phone.

Walkthrough test. You can teach the publish button in fifteen minutes. If you cannot, the files are in the wrong format.

Fail any one and you are not done. Keep editing. Do not invoice a fail.

What to measure

The first sale is one local yes and a deposit. Measure movement toward that, then toward Friday.

Week 1

Names on the list vs visits or emails. Ten and five is the 72-hour bar.

Follow-ups sent the next day. Zero follow-ups is how nice PDFs die on a counter.

PDFs left. If you talked to five and left zero paper, you pitched instead of leaving the product.

Deposits. Zero or one. One is the path working. Zero is information, not a personality failure.

Day 30

Days from first walk to first deposit. 3–14 is the window. At day 15 with no yes, the PDF is mush or you only visited friends.

Fridays delivered. One is a business. Zero with lots of conversations is a hobby.

Hours from kickoff to Friday files. If it took 18 hours of drafting, your edit pass is too precious or the kickoff missed the facts. Target 6–12.

Referral asked, referral given. One name from a happy Friday is worth ten cold gyms.

Claims you refused. Log them.

Dollars in after refunds. \$400–\$1,600 in month one is a working local path. \$0 with 40 conversations means the price never hit the paper.

Day 90

Delivered weeks in the same trade. Three is a reputation. One is still a start.

Repeat or retainer. Zero is fine. A retainer sold before one Friday is a miss even if the dollars look good.

Playbook notes complete enough to ship later. Not shipped instead of walking.

Second trade: only if the first street is actually done with you, not because you got bored.

Ignore

Brand awareness on the street. Likes on their posts, unless they paid you to run ads, which they did not. Your own follower count. Time spent on a personal website. Number of trades you could theoretically serve. Feelings after a no.

One-line spreadsheet

Date, business, trade, visit or email, follow-up date, result (no / later / deposit), amount in, Friday date, referral name, claims refused (short). That is the whole CRM. If a row has no follow-up date and no result, you dropped it. Fix the row this week, not next quarter.

Objections you will hear

The replies

My nephew does Facebook. Good. This is one page and five posts this week, then you are gone. Nephew can keep the page. You are not replacing their family. You are clearing a backlog.

Can you just show me a free sample on our account? No. Doing the work free as a trial is a mistake this path does not survive. The SAMPLE rewrite from public info is the sample. Deposit starts theirs.

We need to go viral. You are not promising that. You are promising Friday files. If they want ads, that is a different pack and a different number.

\$800 is a lot. One yes covers the week. A cheap website someone never finished already cost them more. If \$800 is wrong, \$400 founder-rate with an expiry date is allowed once. \$0 is not a price.

Put that we are the best in the city / hospital-grade / guaranteed results. No. You will not make claims the owner cannot legally make. Offer three true lines instead.

Can you start and we will pay Friday if we like it? No. Deposit today. Files Friday. Like-it is what the revision round is for, not what payroll is for.

We already have a guy. Good. This is a named week, then I leave. If the guy is delivering Fridays, you do not need me. If the site still says opening soon, I can clear this backlog.

Send me a proposal. The PDF is the proposal. One page, \$800, Friday. If they need a ten-page RFP, they are not this pack. Wish them well and walk the next name.

Can you also do a logo / ads / a new website? Those are different PDFs. This week is the page and the five posts. I can price the rest after Friday if you still want it. I will not stuff it into \$800.

I have to ask my partner. Fine. I will leave two PDFs. I can start this week if the deposit lands by [day]. After that the next Friday I can hit is [later date].

We tried a marketing company and they vanished. That is why this is one week, a deposit, files on Friday, and a walkthrough. You will have the files in a folder you own.

What this path feeds next

Upstream — what has to exist first

You. A town. Ten names. A PDF. You do not need a following, a playbook, or a podcast. If you already sold a playbook to people in other towns, this path is still walking, not DMs.

If you cannot write a page, go do one unpaid rewrite for yourself on a public site and see if you can sit through the edit.

Downstream — where the notes go

Cash this week is the point. Compound is the notes.

The kickoff questions and the claims you refused become a \$19 playbook for cleaners or gym owners you will never drive to. The five-post structure becomes a template you can sell. A local yes who is happy is a case study (with permission, real name, real town).

The same street becomes a retainer after one delivered week. The same pack becomes five videos instead of five captions if they have a phone and a doorway. Do not turn it into a city-wide agency. The next path is a product, not a headcount.

If you also make printables, the cleaner's move-out checklist can be a \$9 page. If you also do long-form, how independent gyms explain drop-ins is a video. Feed those after Friday, not instead of walking.

What not to feed

A city-wide agency. A staff of walkers. Ads for your local AI brand. A second trade while five names sit unvisited. Those starve the street.

Mistakes that kill this path

Ten-plus, and the recovery this week

Doing the work free as a trial. They now have your Friday. You have a maybe. Recovery: stop. Send the PDF. SAMPLE from public info only. If they already have a free page, invoice the posts or walk away. Do not finish the rest unpaid.

Making claims the owner cannot legally make. You will both wear that copy. Recovery: cut the lines today. Send a corrected file. Write the ban list if you skipped it. Apologize once, in writing, without a speech.

Ghosting after the posts go up. The coffee-shop review writes itself. Recovery: Monday text this week, even if Friday was two weeks ago. Then stop hovering. One text is the repair.

Selling a 12-month retainer before you have delivered once. You do not know their approval speed. They do not know your Friday. Recovery: convert it to one named week plus a conversation after. Refund the unused months if you already charged them. Eat the awkward.

City-wide we do all AI positioning. One trade, one pack, one street. Recovery: pick the trade today. Reprint the PDF with one noun. Walk that noun.

Starting the draft before the deposit. Recovery: pause the draft. Send the invoice. If they balk, you learned the job was a maybe. Better now than on Thursday.

Starting a second trade in another town while five local names sit unvisited. Recovery: put the other town on a list dated month 3. Walk the five this week.

Letting them see raw model output. Your name is on the walk-in. The model does not walk in. Recovery: never again. If they already saw it, send the edited version the same day and name what you cut.

Redesigning the PDF after every no. The no was about timing, nephew, or money, not your font. Recovery: lock the PDF for ten more visits. Change the sample, not the business.

Unlimited rewrites. Friday never comes. Recovery: one round, 24 hours, then \$150 for another. Put it on the PDF this afternoon.

Visiting only friends. Friends will be kind and slow. Recovery: ten names you do not eat dinner with. Walk five of them.

Pitching for twenty minutes. Eyes leave. Recovery: the one line, the PDF, the leave. Practice it once out loud tonight.

Hiring someone to walk for you before three Fridays. Recovery: cancel the hire. You need the language.

Tools

The exact stack

A one-page PDF of the package. Headline, in/out, Friday, \$800, deposit, phone. Printed and on your phone. Google Docs or Word, export PDF. Library printer if you need it.

Stripe Payment Link or e-transfer. Whatever the owner already trusts. Invoice with the week's date on it.

Your phone. Camera for samples, maps for the ten names, email, a notes app for the ban list. Five videos, if that is the pack, are also the phone.

A doc for drafts. You write. They receive a clean file, not a chat log.

The model, privately. Drafts only. Never a login you share with the owner as the product.

A notebook or one spreadsheet: the one-line CRM from the metrics section.

A one-page agreement: deliverable, date, price, claims, who owns the copy (they do, on payment).

Setup order

Today: the doc, the PDF, the sample. Today or tomorrow: the payment method, tested with \$1 to yourself if Stripe, or a confirmation you can receive e-transfer. This week: the notebook and the ten names. The model login you already have. Do not buy a new one.

What not to buy

A CRM in week one. A list of ten in a notebook is a CRM. A team. A walker. A new laptop. A city-wide domain. An ads budget for your personal brand. A course on local SEO. A chatbot product you resell. Business cards before the PDF. The PDF is the card.

The \$0 path

Docs, a free Stripe Payment Link or e-transfer, the library printer, the phone you have, the model you already use, walking shoes, a notebook from the dollar aisle. That is enough to take a deposit this week. Do not let paperwork delay the hallway. Do not skip the agreement once money moves.

Checklist

One trade chosen

Ten phrases learned from reviews

One-pager PDF: page plus five posts this week, \$800, deposit today, files Friday

What is in and what is out, written

Sample rewrite from public info, marked SAMPLE

Fake claims stripped from the sample

Ten names on a list, mapped in a cluster

Payment method that an owner already trusts

One-page agreement ready

Five visits or emails in the first 72 hours

Follow-up the next day, one line

Notebook row for every name

Deposit before any draft

Kickoff facts in 20 minutes

Written ban list for claims

AI draft edited by you

They never see the raw pass

One round of notes, 24 hours, written

Friday folder they own, human file names

Photo briefs a phone can shoot in ten minutes

Walkthrough, fifteen minutes

Balance on delivery

Referral ask: next owner on the same street

Monday check-in text

No ghosting and no hovering

Notes saved for a later playbook

Claims-refused log updated

No 12-month retainer sold before one delivered week

No second trade until this street has seen you deliver

Self-test from the who section, honestly answered

FAQ

Gyms or cleaners first?

One trade first. Taylor walked cleaners in the morning because owners were on site, then used a referral into a gym. If you have a membership or a mop, start where you already know the words. Same PDF shape. Different nouns. Default: start with the trade whose owners are physically there in the morning.

What if they have no website, only Facebook?

The page is a Facebook services post or a Google Business profile rewrite. Name it on the PDF so they are not expecting a custom domain. Still \$800 if the work is the same. If it is truly smaller, \$400 and still a Friday. Default: call it Google plus five posts and price \$500 unless the rewrite is a full services page.

Do I need insurance or an LLC?

A one-page agreement: deliverable, date, price, claims, who owns the copy (they do, on payment). Deposit. Local rules on business licenses vary. Do not let paperwork delay the first five visits. Do not skip the agreement. Default: agreement plus deposit this week, paperwork this month, not the reverse.

Can I do this by email only?

Yes if you will actually send five and follow up. Walking still wins in small towns. Mix it. The path is visit or email, not wait to be discovered. Default: walk the cluster you can reach in twenty minutes, email the rest.

What about dentists and medical trades?

Same pack, tighter ban list. You do not write clinical promises. If you are not willing to cut lines, skip that trade. Default: do not start here. Earn two cleaner or gym Fridays first.

How do I handle an owner who wants endless rewrites?

One round, 24 hours, written notes. Then \$150 for another round. Put it on the PDF. Unlimited is how Friday never comes. Default: the PDF says one round before they pay.

Should I hire someone to walk for me?

No. Not until you have delivered three Fridays. The walk is how you learn the language. A hired body with your PDF is the agency you were told to leave alone. Default: your shoes.

Can the five posts be videos?

Yes if the PDF says so. Five simple phone videos, same \$800 or \$1,200 if you are also on camera. Do not surprise them with captions when they expected video, or the reverse. Default: captions plus photo brief at \$800 until someone asks for video, then a second PDF.

What if the first ten say no?

Follow up once. Ask for a name. Walk the next ten in the same trade. Change the sample, not the whole business. Day 14 with zero deposits means the ask is fuzzy or you never mentioned the price on the paper. Default: lock the PDF, new sample, next ten, same trade.

When do I sell the playbook?

After one paid week, when the notes are real. The playbook is for owners you will not drive to. It does not replace the walk this month. Cash while digital compounds — in that order. Default: notes in week 2–4, playbook after three Fridays, not instead of Friday three.

What if I freeze at the front desk?

Email is allowed. Leave the PDF with the desk if the owner is out. Follow up tomorrow. The social skill is the one line, not a TED talk. Default: print anyway, walk two, email the rest.

Do I need a website for myself?

No. The PDF is the site. A sample doc is the portfolio. Build a site after three Fridays if you want a place to send the playbook buyers. Default: no site in week 1.

How do I take payment if they will not use Stripe?

E-transfer, invoice, even a check if that is how the two-van shop pays vendors. Local means you meet them at the rail they already use. Log it. Do not start on a handshake because their

processor is annoying. Default: whatever they already trust, receipt the same day.

What if the owner wants me to log into their WordPress and just do it?

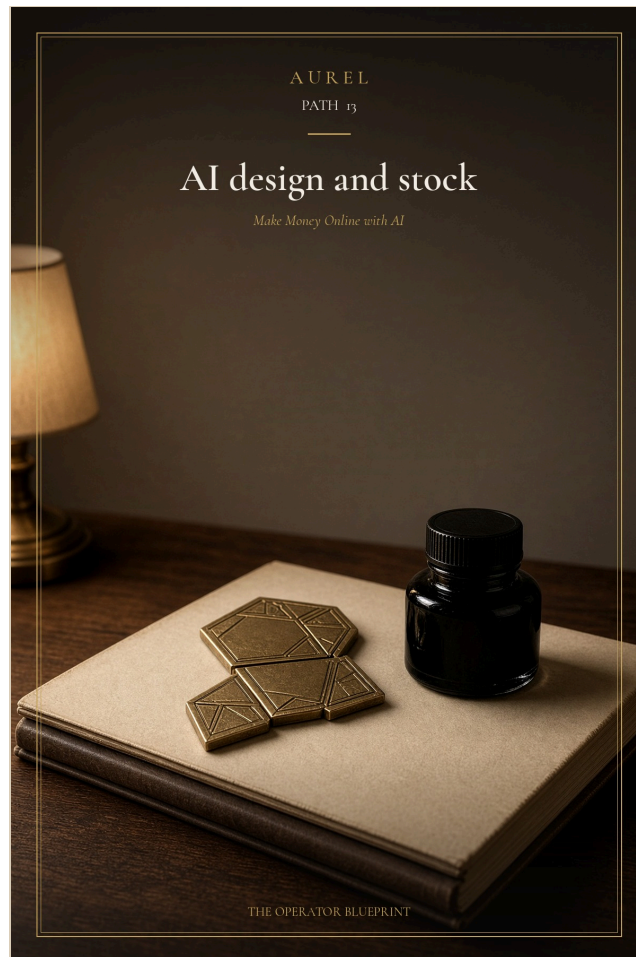
Price that as the same pack if you can finish by Friday, or as \$1,200 if it is a real CMS slog. Get the login after the deposit. Default: deliver a paste-ready doc unless they ask for in-CMS and you priced it.

Can I do this in a big city?

Yes. The cluster is a neighborhood, not the metro. One trade, ten names within a 20-minute ride, same PDF. Default: pick a main street and walk it like a town.

What if I already have a remote productized offer?

Keep it. This path is cash this week from people you can walk to. Do not merge the PDFs. Default: local PDF in the bag, remote page on the internet, no mashup.



PATH 13

AI design and stock

A library, not a lottery ticket. One style, many variations.

36 minute read · 7,832 words

Who this is for

You can produce a coherent set of icons, patterns, or simple graphics.

Time to first

30–90 days to meaningful payout

Tools

First sale

A first payout, however small, that proves the account works.

Cash window

Slow then compounding

Leave this alone

Your design tool, one marketplace, a license you actually read, a 90-minute weekly block.

One upload and waiting. Unlicensed copies. Raw unedited dumps if the marketplace forbids them.

What this actually is

The definition

A stock library is a catalog you add to on a schedule. Not a lottery ticket. Not a shop you open once. One style. Many variations. Buyers search for a job — line icons for a budgeting app, a seamless pattern for packaging, a simple pack for a slide deck — and they pick the set that already looks like it belongs together.

You are selling files a stranger can drop into a project this afternoon. Consistent line weight. A palette that does not fight itself. Names that match how people search. A cinematic hero image that took six hours will sit unsold. Sets that look like a product get downloaded.

AI is a draft engine, not a dump chute. Some marketplaces restrict raw model output. Even when they allow it, buyers can smell unedited generations: warped type, patterns that do not tile, icons on three different grids. Clean, vectorize, or redraw until the file is yours and the set looks like one person made it on purpose.

The money is slow, then compounding. Month one is an account and a handful of sets. Month three is a small payout that proves the pipes work. Month six is a library that earns on a Tuesday you did not open the laptop. If you need rent this month, this is the wrong path. If you can give it ninety minutes a week for a season, it starts to behave like a quiet second till.

What this is not

This is not a brand identity studio. You are not designing a logo system for a named company. You are stocking a drawer a stranger will open when they type a job.

This is not a printable shop. Printables solve a Tuesday problem on paper. Stock solves a file problem inside someone else's project. Different buyer, different file, different license.

This is not a generation showcase. A thread of 80 pretty images is a hobby account. A 20-file outline set on a 24px grid is a product. If you only enjoy the novelty of the prompt, you will go cold when the work is cleaning nodes.

Why this works now

Search still works. A junior designer still types budget app icon at 11pm. A baker still needs a tile that does not seam. The flood is real and it is mostly dumps: mixed styles, broken hands, unlicensed marks, titles like My Art 3. Coherence is scarce. Scarce is what gets picked.

The model can list subjects and sketch a wallet. It cannot hold a 2px stroke on a 24px grid across 40 files unless you make it. That hold is the job. The tools got faster at the draft. The buyer still pays for the set that behaves in Figma.

Marketplaces still pay. Slowly. Per download or per listing. You do not need a following if the keywords match the job. You need a family of files and a weekly block that does not vanish after week two.

Three anti-patterns

Anti-pattern one: one upload and waiting. You refresh the dashboard. You call it a business. The catalog cannot compound on a single listing. The weekly block is the product until the library catches up.

Anti-pattern two: unlicensed copies. Bank marks, teams, cartoon characters, celebrity likeness, photoreal people you cannot release. This is how accounts get banned. Banned is not a setback. It is the end of the shelf.

Anti-pattern three: a new style every Saturday. You feel creative. The catalog feels random. Buyers who grabbed finance will not come back for neon 3D coins. Pick three rules and get bored on purpose.

The deal you keep

You keep the style. You keep the weekly block. You keep the license you actually read. You do not keep a fantasy of a viral pack replacing a business, a five-marketplace empire in month one, or

files you cannot point to as yours. If those stay clean, the library can earn on a Tuesday. If any one of them breaks, you have a folder of pretty liability.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This fits you if

This path fits if you can hold a visual language for more than one evening: 2px stroke on a 24px grid, floral patterns that share one leaf, three colors and rounded corners. You do not need a degree. You need a finish standard — cousins, not strangers from different apps.

It also fits if you are patient with search. Nobody is waiting for your drop. Buyers type a job months from now and your set is sitting there. That is the bet.

It fits if you already open a design tool without a pep talk. Figma, Illustrator, Inkscape, Affinity. If you only generate, you can still fit, but only if you will add a vector tool this week and redraw. Generating 80 images is not the skill. Making 12 files that look related is.

Skip this if

Skip it if you need cash in fourteen days. This path's first sale is a payout in 30–90 days, and that payout might be \$12. Take a service path if rent is the problem. Feed this catalog on Saturday mornings.

Skip it if your plan is one upload and a refresh of the dashboard, or if you will not read a contributor license.

Skip it if you only enjoy generating novelty and go cold when the work is cleaning nodes, checking a tile seam, or writing the same keyword list again.

Skip it if you will not kill a set. Sentiment is how dead themes sit for a year.

The honest middle

If you already sell printables, this is a cousin. Printables solve a Tuesday problem on paper. Stock solves a file problem inside someone else's project. You are stocking their drawer, not

teaching them. You can run both. Do not mash them into one listing.

If you have drawn the same wallet icon three times for freelance, you already have a set. The path is packaging, not talent. If you have never exported an SVG, you will learn that this week or you will skip this path.

Skills and time

Skills: hold three style rules, clean a vector, tile-test a pattern, write a search-shaped title, read a license, sit a 90-minute block when last week is still in review.

Time: 90 minutes a week, same day, named on the calendar. First 72 hours is heavier: account, license, first 8–12 files. After that, the block is the business. Daily dashboard checking is not work. It is a hobby that eats the next tray.

A season is 12 weeks of blocks. Miss three in a row and the library starts to rot. Plan the season before you pick a second marketplace.

Two-minute self-test

Answer yes or no. No essays.

Can I write three style rules and obey them on 12 files?

Will I read a contributor license end to end this week, including the AI section?

Can I wait 30–90 days without calling the path dead?

Will I sit a 90-minute weekly block even when nothing has sold?

Will I unpublish a set I liked if it does not move after 60–90 days?

Four or five yeses: pick the marketplace this morning. Three: this can be a Saturday cousin to a cash path, not your only till. Two or fewer: skip it this quarter. You will hate the wait and skip the block.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this before you open a canvas

Write this before you open a canvas: [number] [style] [asset type] for [the job], commercial use, consistent grid. If you cannot fill those brackets, you have a mood board, not a set.

Number is 8–12 to start, 20–40 when it is a working set, 80–120 only when it is truly one system. Style is the three rules. Asset type is icons or patterns or simple illustrations, not a mix. The job is who drops this into what. Commercial use is the license you actually offer. Consistent grid is the promise that two files side by side look like one author.

Five sentences that work

24 outline icons for personal-finance apps, 24px grid, 2px stroke, SVG + PNG, commercial use.

12 seamless bakery patterns for packaging, 12-inch tile, 300 dpi, commercial use.

16 simple food illustrations for meal-prep decks, three-color palette, transparent PNG, commercial use.

20 outline icons for small-clinic software, 24px grid, 2px stroke, SVG + PNG, same family as the finance set.

8 seamless botanical tiles for soap labels, 12-inch, 300 dpi, three-color palette, commercial use.

Cute stickers pack vol. 4 is a mood. Line icons for a habit tracker UI is a search. People type the job.

What they get

A folder that drops into Figma, Canva, or Illustrator and behaves. SVG plus PNG for icons. Source tile plus JPEG or PNG for patterns. A license line that matches the marketplace. Previews that are not the working files. File names a stranger can sort. One style across the set.

On Adobe Stock they get a download at the library's price. On Creative Market, Etsy, Gumroad, or your own site they get the zip you promised at the number you set.

What they do not get

Not a brand identity. Not a custom mascot. Not a course. Not custom colors on request inside a \$12 listing. Not app files. Not a font. Not an exclusive unless you signed one. Not photoreal people. Not a trademarked mark.

One style across the catalog is the advantage: pack two in the same stroke is an easy second download. Scattershot styles read as noise.

Packaging

Title: job, style, count, format. Description: the fill-in-the-blank sentence, what is in the zip, what is not, a pointer to a sibling pack. Keywords: 20–40 nouns a buyer would type. Zip matches the listing. Mockup optional: one app screen or one jam jar, not a cinematic shop film.

Do not glue three unrelated dumps into a mega pack. A mega pack is one system, 80–120 files, same three rules. If you cannot say the system in one breath, it is not a mega pack. It is a flea market.

What done looks like

The definition

Done for the first 72 hours is not a payout. It is one marketplace account submitted, one coherent set of 8–12 files live or in review, search-shaped titles, and a 90-minute weekly block on the calendar with a name.

Done for the season is a first payout, however small. Twelve dollars proves the account and the pipeline. It does not prove a business. The habit does.

Fairness test

Hold two files at arm's length. If a stranger would not guess they belong together, the set is not done. Would a junior designer expense \$12 of this without a meeting? If the honest answer is they would mix three other packs instead, keep cleaning. Coherence is the bar. Clean vectors are the floor.

Would you drop this into a real project this afternoon and not fight the grid? If no, it is not done.

Technical done

Every file shares line weight, corner radius, and palette. Two files side by side should look like one author.

Names are boring: icon-budget-wallet.svg, not FinalFINAL2.

SVG plus a PNG preview at the size they ask for, usually 1000px or 2000px.

Patterns tile. A 4-up test with no seam, dark background and light.

Nothing trademarked, no photoreal people you cannot license, no characters you do not own.

Title has job, style, count, format. 20–40 keywords. Zip matches the listing.

License and AI rules checked. Disclosure filled if they ask.

Weekly block named on the calendar.

Review queues are not your pause button. The weekly block still happens.

Not-done-yet list

Account not submitted.

License unread.

80 generated images, 0 cleaned vectors.

Three styles in one folder.

Pattern that seams at 2x2.

Title: Cute pack vol. 4.

Keywords stuffed with aesthetic and viral.

Trademarked bank mark in the wallet icon.

No weekly block on the calendar.

Four marketplaces, zero live sets.

Checking payouts daily, producing weekly never.

A mega pack that is three unrelated dumps zipped together.

Pricing and the cash window

The range

On Adobe Stock and similar libraries you do not set the price. You earn a royalty per download. Volume, metadata, and a style that keeps getting picked are the job. On Creative Market, Etsy, Gumroad, and your own site, you set the number.

If you set the price:

Small set, 8–12 icons or 4 patterns: \$8–\$14.

Working set, 20–40 icons or 8–12 patterns: \$19–\$29.

Mega pack that is truly one system, 80–120 files: \$39–\$49. Do not glue three unrelated dumps together.

A \$9 set a junior designer can expense without a meeting beats a \$79 studio system with no proof. Bundles of three related packs at \$29–\$39 outsell a lonely \$12 file if they belong together.

Quinn's first listing was \$12 for 10 files, then 20 files still at \$12, then a 40-icon finance mega pack at \$29. That ladder is the default.

When to raise

Raise a listing when you add real files, not when you get bored. 10 files at \$12 can become 20 at \$12 or 40 at \$29. New sibling jobs stay at \$12 until they prove. Do not jump a dead set from \$12 to \$29 to make it feel premium. Dead at \$12 is dead at \$29.

After a payout and a returning buyer, a bundle of three siblings at \$29–\$39 is the raise that usually works. Exclusive higher royalty is a later trade, not a day-one move.

Refunds in one sentence

If the zip does not match the listing — missing format, broken tile, files that do not open — refund and fix or unpublish. Taste is not a refund. A buyer who wanted custom colors is a custom job, not a chargeback.

Never charge for these

Never charge for a custom recolor inside a \$12 listing. Never charge for a font you do not license. Never charge as if this were a brand identity. Never charge \$79 for 8 files with no proof. Never charge nothing and call it a loss leader to a library that does not have a second product yet.

Never expect month-one rent from this path. That expectation is how you quit in week two.

Worked dollars

Do not expect month-one rent. 30–90 days to a meaningful payout. Meaningful at first is \$20–\$80. Weekly uploads and a kill window on dead sets: month four through six can look like \$150–\$400 in a decent month. That is not a promise. That is what a coherent library tends to do when the keywords match jobs.

Quinn: week 6, \$14. Month 4, \$190. Eight coherent listings, one style. A beautiful set named My Art 3 earns zero at every price.

A \$12 set downloaded twice is \$24 and a proof. A \$0 dashboard with forty unpublished experiments is a hobby folder. Count payout events, not feelings.

The first 72 hours

The 72 hours is the account and the first set. Not a shop with forty listings.

Day 1 morning

Pick one marketplace. Creative Market or Etsy if you want to set the price. Adobe Stock if you want search you do not have to find. Read the contributor license and the generative-AI rules end to end. Note whether raw output is forbidden, must be labeled, or must be redrawn. If you will not read the license, stop. You are about to upload a liability.

Write the fill-in-the-blank offer. Pick one job you can picture: a founder making a budget app, a baker mocking up a jam label. Write three style rules: stroke, grid, palette. Put them on a sticky. Quinn's: outline icons, 24px grid, 2px stroke, no fills except a 4px dot for on states.

Day 1 afternoon

Make 8–12 files, not 80. If you use a model, generate extra, then redraw or vectorize the keepers. The model can list subjects (wallet, piggy bank, receipt, chart). You draw them on the grid. Export SVG plus PNG. Tile-test any pattern at 2x2 and 4x4, dark and light.

If you cannot finish 8 files in an afternoon, the style is too complex or you are decorating. Cut the decoration. Ship 8 clean.

Day 1 night

Name the files like a stranger would sort them. icon-budget-wallet.svg, not FinalFINAL2. Write the title: job, style, count, format. Draft 20 keywords. Do not upload yet if you are tired. Tired uploads miss fields.

Day 2

Submit the account if you have not. Fill every profile field they ask for. Upload the set. Fill every listing field. Do not skip keywords. Do not skip the AI disclosure if they have one. Do not refresh the review page.

Put a 90-minute weekly block on the same day next week. Name it upload block. Same hour. Same day. If you cannot name it, you will skip it.

Day 3

Start the sibling set in the same stroke. Ten more finance icons, or e-commerce in the same grid. Do not start a new aesthetic. Do not open a second marketplace. Do not build a landing page. Do not record a YouTube about your shop.

Then close the laptop. Review queues are not your pause button and they are not your hobby. The next work is Saturday's block, not Friday's refresh.

By hour 72 you have: one marketplace, license read, 8–12 files, three written rules, a search-shaped title, a weekly block on the calendar, a sibling started. You do not have a brand. You do not have forty listings. You have a shelf.

The path, step by step

The twelve-plus moves

One style. Ten variations. Write the three rules before you draw: line weight, grid, palette. Ten files that obey them beat thirty that wander. Put the rules on a sticky you can see from the chair. If a file breaks a rule, it is not in the set. It is a different Saturday.

Name the job of the asset. Who is dropping this into what? A founder making a budget app. A baker mocking up a jam label. The job decides the content. Do not start with things I like to generate. If you cannot name the person and the project, you are making a mood board. Mood boards do not search.

Pick one marketplace and read the license. One. Four sites in month one means four profiles and zero compounding. Read AI clauses, exclusivity, and how they want files labeled. Save the PDF. Highlight the AI section. If raw output is forbidden, your process is redraw, not dump.

Make the file yours. Clean, vectorize, or redraw. No trademarks, no celebrity faces, no photoreal people you cannot license. Disclose AI when they ask. Auto-trace is a start, not a finish. Nodes get cleaned. Strokes get unified. The grid gets obeyed.

File hygiene. Same artboard. Same export. Names a stranger can sort. SVG plus PNG for icons; source tile plus JPEG or PNG for patterns. Zip it the way the listing promises. If you promised 20 SVG + PNG, the zip has 40 files, not 19 and a note.

Keywords that match the job. 20–40 terms a buyer would type. Budget app icon, not aesthetic. Front-load the title with the job and the style. Steal nouns from what already ranks, not from poetry. Keep a keyword sheet: listing, title, keywords, date uploaded, date of last review.

Upload a small coherent set. Eight to twelve files. Live is better than complete. Do not wait for a real shop. Do not wait for a custom domain. The aisle is the marketplace. Your site is a later home.

Weekly upload block. Ninety minutes, same day. Finish or start one set, export, title, upload. Sit the block even if last week is still in review. Name it on the calendar so it is not a vibe. Miss

it once, sit it the next week. Miss it three times and you already quit.

Read what already sells, then fill a gap. Sort by best-selling. Notice jobs that are thin in your style. Fill the gap. Do not trace the winner. Do not copy their files. Copy the job: they sell clinic icons and you have none; you draw clinic icons in your stroke.

Kill sets that do not move after a fair window. 60–90 days with views and no downloads is a signal. Unpublish. Double the theme that moved. If it had no views, rewrite title and thumb once before you kill it. Do not kill on day 9. Do not keep a dead theme for a year because you liked making it.

Build a family, not a flea market. Pack 2 and pack 3 are siblings of pack 1. Buyers come back for the matching stroke. Quinn's finance buyer came back for the clinic pack because the stroke matched. That return is the compound. A new aesthetic every week resets the compound to zero.

Review monthly, not hourly. One date a month: payout, top three, bottom three, next three jobs. Daily checking eats the upload block. Write the monthly number in a note. Then close the dashboard.

Seasonal variants of a set that already sells. Tax-season finance in January. Back-to-school in July. Wedding in spring. Same stroke. New job. Do not invent a new style for the season. Dress the family.

Second marketplace only after a payout on the first. Not before. Five empty shops is five places to refresh. Exclusivity is a later trade: sometimes a higher royalty for not selling the same files elsewhere. Do not sign that away on day one.

A worked example: Quinn's weekly icon set

Who

Quinn is not a studio. Quinn has Figma, a Saturday morning, and three rules on a sticky: outline icons, 24px grid, 2px stroke, no fills except a 4px dot for on states. No following. No shop film. A day job that pays rent. This path is the Saturday.

Calendar

Week 1 Saturday: Quinn picks Creative Market, reads the contributor terms including the generative-AI section, and does not dump raw output. A model helps list subjects (wallet, piggy bank, receipt, chart). Quinn draws ten icons on the grid. Title: 24px outline icons for personal finance apps — 10 files, SVG + PNG. Price: \$12. Keywords from what already ranks: budget app, fintech, wallet icon, expense tracker UI. Account submitted. Upload block named for every Saturday 9:00.

Nothing sells in week 1. Quinn does not refresh earnings. The review queue takes six days. Quinn does not open a second marketplace while waiting.

Saturday week 2: ten more finance icons, listing updated to 20 files, still \$12. Same sticky. Same export preset.

Week 3: a sibling set, e-commerce, same stroke, new listing, \$12. Cart, tag, box, star. Still not a 3D experiment.

Week 4: first monthly review. Account live. Views on finance: a handful. Downloads: zero. Quinn does not panic. Produces into the local folder for week 5.

The shipped artifact

The live listing zip: 20 SVG, 20 PNG at 1000px, names like icon-budget-wallet.svg, a one-line license note matching the marketplace, a preview sheet of the 20 on a 24px grid. Not a cinematic mockup. A grid that proves the stroke.

Later artifact: a 40-icon finance mega pack at \$29, same family, built from the two finance trays plus twenty more.

The mistake

Week 5, Quinn got bored and spent the block on a cute 3D coins experiment. Different style. Different grid. Uploaded it because the renders looked expensive. Also almost used a bank mark on the wallet because it looked professional. Caught the mark. Shipped the coins.

Recovery and the first stranger sale

Week 6: a \$14 payout. Two finance downloads, one e-commerce. Not rent. Proof the account and the files work. First stranger sale: someone Quinn has never emailed, never DMed, never met. A \$12 set. The pipe works.

Week 8, one dashboard look: finance 140 views / 4 downloads; e-commerce 90 / 2; cute 3D coins 200 views / 0. Quinn unpublishes the coins. The next four Saturdays double the outline family: wellness, calendar, small-clinic, and the 40-icon finance mega pack at \$29.

Month 4: eight coherent listings, one style. A buyer who grabbed finance comes back for the clinic pack because the stroke matches. Monthly payout \$190. Quinn still does not check the dashboard on weekdays.

What Quinn refused: trademarked bank logos, photoreal hands, four marketplaces at once, and skipping Saturday because nothing is selling yet. The habit was the product until the library caught up. The coins taught the kill window. The sticky taught the family. The \$14 taught that the pipe is real and that rent still comes from the day job.

Copy you can paste

Listing title (page hero)

24px outline icons for personal finance apps — 20 SVG + PNG files, 2px stroke

12 seamless bakery patterns for packaging — 12-inch tile, 300 dpi, commercial use

Listing description

[Asset] for [job]. [N] files in one style: [stroke / grid / palette]. Formats: [SVG, PNG]. Commercial use for [what you allow]. Not included: custom colors, app files, or a font. Pair with [sibling pack] if you need the same stroke for [related job].

Checkout line

\$12 — 20 outline icons, 24px grid, 2px stroke, SVG + PNG, commercial use as stated. No custom recolors in this listing.

Post when a set goes live

I needed a wallet icon that did not look like a different app from the chart icon. So I drew a 20-file outline set on a 24px grid and put it on [marketplace]. \$12. Same stroke on every file.

DM if someone asks where you get icons

I got tired of mixing three packs in one screen. I make outline sets on one grid and upload weekly. Finance is live, clinic is next. Link: [url]. \$12. No custom inside that price.

Email 1 — to a designer who already knows you

I put a 20-file outline set for budget apps on [marketplace]. 24px, 2px stroke, SVG + PNG, \$12. If you have been mixing packs in one UI, this is the same stroke on every file. If it is not useful, ignore this.

Email 2 — sibling set

Same stroke as the finance icons: 20 outline icons for small-clinic software, \$12. If you grabbed finance, this will drop in next to it. [url]

Email 3 — after a payout, to nobody; this is your monthly note to self, also usable as a quiet post

Month [n]: [X] sets live, one style, payout \$[n]. Still Saturday 90 minutes. Still not a studio. Next three jobs: [a], [b], [c].

Refund line

If the zip does not match the listing — missing format, files that do not open, a pattern that does not tile — email me and I will refund and fix or unpublish. Wanting a different style or a custom recolor is not a refund. That is a separate job.

Keyword seed (finance)

budget app icon, fintech UI, outline wallet, expense tracker, savings goal, invoice icon, 24px line icon, bank card outline, SVG icons, transparent PNG

Week-by-week

Week 1 — daily

Monday: pick the marketplace. Read the license, including AI. Write the offer sentence. Write three style rules.

Tuesday: 8–12 files. Redraw. Export. Tile-test if patterns.

Wednesday: titles, keywords, names. Account submitted. Do not build a landing page.

Thursday: upload. Fill every field. Weekly block on the calendar, named, same day forever.

Friday: start the sibling in a local folder. Close the payout page if you opened it.

Saturday: this is the block day if you picked Saturday. If the first set is already up, sit the block anyway. If not, finish the upload.

Sunday: off. Do not redesign the three rules.

Week 2 — daily

Monday–Friday: day job, or the cash path that pays rent. Do not open five marketplaces. Do not check review.

Saturday (or your named day): second tray, same style, same job or a sibling. Upload or update the listing. Still do not check payouts more than once.

Sunday: keyword sheet updated. Date uploaded written. Close it.

If week 1 is still in review, produce into a local folder so week 3 is an upload, not a panic.

Week 3

Third set. The three style rules should feel boring. Boring is the point. One-line catalog promise: Outline icons, 24px, 2px stroke. Write that on the sticky if it is not already there.

Still no landing page. Still no second marketplace. Still no 3D experiment unless that is the three rules, which it is not if you started outline.

Week 4

First monthly review. If the account is still in review, do not panic-open a second marketplace. Produce into a local folder so week 5 is an upload. Count sets live (or ready). Count hours in the block. If you skipped two blocks, the path is already slipping. Sit week 5 even if you are embarrassed.

Weeks 5–8. One block every week. At week 8, look at views and downloads. Unpublish the all-views-no-takes set. Double the one that moved: more files, a \$29 mega pack, or a matching pattern in the same palette.

Weeks 9–12. Stay in the family. Three more sibling jobs. If a payout landed, put the number in a note, not a passive income thread. Every week after: same day, same 90 minutes. Seasonal variants of a set that already sells (tax-season finance in January). Do not skip the block three weeks in a row. Libraries rot in silence.

Quality bar

Hold two files at arm's length. If a stranger would not guess they belong together, the set is not done. Coherence is the bar. Clean vectors are the floor.

Below the bar

Warped type. Broken hands. Patterns that seam. Five styles in one folder. A 24px set with a 22px rebel. Stray nodes from a bad auto-trace. Wallet that is a blob at 16px. Zip missing the PNG you promised. Title: My Art 3. A bank mark. A photoreal face you cannot license. Raw dumps labeled as a pack. A mega pack that is three unrelated folders.

If they can tell you generated 80 and zipped 12 without looking, you are below the bar even if the marketplace allowed the upload.

Above the bar

Clean nodes. Strokes consistent. One grid. Patterns tile at 2x2 and 4x4, dark and light. Contrast works at 16px. Exports match the listing. Names searchable. Sibling packs share the three rules. Keywords are jobs. AI labeled when they ask. You can point to why you may sell this.

A table mockup is nice. A cinematic shop film is not required. Time belongs in the files.

Five tests before you upload

Arm's-length test. Two files. One author or not.

16px test. Open the PNG at the size a UI will actually use. If it blobs, simplify.

Tile test. 2x2 and 4x4, dark and light, for any pattern. No seam, no orphan motif on the edge.

Zip test. Unzip on a second computer or a second folder. Count matches the listing. Names sort.

Rights test. No logos, no team marks, no inspired-by characters, no photoreal faces without a release. AI disclosure honest.

Fail any one and you are not done. Keep cleaning. Do not upload a fail and hope the review queue is the filter. You are the filter.

What to measure

Measure a library, not a feeling.

Week 1

Account submitted. Binary.

License read, AI section highlighted. Binary.

Sets live or in review. Target: 1.

Files in the first set. Target: 8–12, one style.

Weekly block named on the calendar. Binary.

Second marketplace opened. Target: 0.

Day 30

Sets live. If this is not rising most weeks, you have a hobby folder.

Blocks sat. Target: 4.

Views per set. Title and thumb are findable.

Downloads. May still be zero. That is allowed inside 30–90.

Family share. How many of your last sets share the three style rules. Target: all of them.

Day 90

First payout date, even if \$8.

Downloads per set after a fair window.

Conversion: downloads / views. 4% where 1% is common: double that theme. 0.1% with lots of views: kill it.

Earnings per 90-minute block. \$40 after four blocks vs \$0 — the math is done talking.

Monthly payout total. Not daily.

Family share of last six sets. Under 4, you are drifting into a flea market.

Sets killed. If this is zero and you have dead themes, you are collecting, not running a library.

Fair window: 60–90 days before you kill a set that had a real chance. Do not kill on day 9. Do not keep a dead theme for a year because you liked making it.

Ignore

Daily earnings. Follower count. Likes on a process video. Number of marketplaces. Aesthetic novelty. Other people's generation showcases. A cinematic shop film you have not made.

Passive income as a label.

One-line spreadsheet

Date uploaded, listing title, marketplace, price or royalty, files in set, views, downloads, conversion, last review date, keep or kill at day 90, family (yes/no). One row per listing. Monthly tab: payout. If you cannot fill views and downloads without opening the dashboard daily, you are using the sheet as a slot machine. Fill it on the monthly date.

Objections you will hear — including from yourself

The replies

The market is flooded with AI art. Flooded with dumps. Not flooded with coherent 24px outline sets for clinic software. You compete with files that match one job and one grid.

Stock does not pay. Single uploads do not. Libraries pay slowly. Need \$3,000 this month? Take a service path. Feed a catalog weekly and it is a second till.

They will reject AI work. Some will. Read the license in hour one and redraw. Label when they ask. Do not argue with a terms page.

I am not a designer. Then this path is only yours if you will learn a grid and a finish standard. Generating 80 images is not the skill. Making 12 files that look related is.

I should be on five marketplaces. After a payout on one. Not before. Five empty shops is five places to refresh.

Someone will steal the files. Watermark previews. Sell a clean zip a serious buyer wants. Theft is not why most accounts earn zero. Silence is.

Nothing sold in two weeks, so it is dead. Two weeks is not the window. 30–90 days after live. Review queues can eat two weeks by themselves. Sit the block.

I need a cinematic shop and a brand before I upload. Time belongs in the files. One grid mockup is enough. A shop film is a delay costume.

I should wait until I have 40 listings. Eight to twelve files live beat forty in a local folder. Live is how you learn what search does. The folder does not learn.

My friends say stock is dead. Your friends are not the junior designer typing budget app icon at 11pm. The search bar is the customer. Not the group chat.

What feeds this path

Upstream

This path eats jobs, not mood boards.

You need a design tool you will open, a license you will read, and 90 minutes a week you will not skip. You do not need a following. You do not need a playbook sold. You do not need a local Friday, though a local Friday can feed subjects (the cleaner's van icon, the gym's freeze icon).

If you cannot export SVG this week, that is the upstream skill. Learn it on file one.

Inside the marketplace

Best-sellers in your category. Search suggest. Gaps: demand with few coherent sets in a simple style. Seasonal calendar: tax, back-to-school, holidays, wedding.

Outside

App Store screenshots in a niche you know. Slide decks people present. Packaging on a shelf. The question is always: what file is missing from this person's project?

From your week. If you drew the same wallet icon three times for freelance, that is a set. If a client asked for simple food icons that are not clip art, that is a listing title.

Downstream

A family of packs. A \$29 mega pack. A bundle. A second marketplace after a payout. Your own site as a second home after strangers already buy. Printables that use the same palette, sold as a

different product, not stuffed into the stock zip. A playbook later: how to keep a 24px outline family, sold to people who want the method, not the files.

What does not feed it

Other people's generation showcases. Trend accounts that change aesthetic every Friday. Cold ads to a \$12 set in month one. A Discord for your shop with no listings. Keep a note titled jobs I can draw on a Saturday. Twelve jobs is a quarter of a catalog. Two moods and no jobs is a Pinterest account.

Mistakes

Ten-plus, and the recovery this week

One upload and waiting. The catalog cannot compound on a single listing. Recovery: sit the weekly block this week. Start the sibling. Stop refreshing payouts. The block is the business.

Unlicensed copies and trademarked logos. Bank marks, teams, cartoon characters, celebrity likeness. This is how accounts get banned. Recovery: delete the file today. If it is live, unpublish. Do not argue. Read the license again tonight.

Raw unedited dumps. Warped type, broken hands, patterns that do not tile, five styles in one folder. Buyers refund. Platforms penalize. Recovery: unpublish. Redraw 8 files that obey the three rules. Re-upload as a new coherent set.

Photoreal people you do not have rights to. Generated faces still carry risk. A simple graphic path does not need them. Recovery: cut every face this week. Replace with icons or patterns. Stay in the simple graphic lane.

Expecting a viral set to replace a business. One pack will not. A family of packs, uploaded weekly, might pay a bill. Recovery: write the 12-week block calendar today. Rent still comes from the other path until day 90 says otherwise.

New style every Saturday. You feel creative. The catalog feels random. Recovery: put the three rules back on the sticky. Next four sets obey them. The 3D experiment stays unpublished.

Keyword stuffing and poetic titles. Name the job, the style, the count, the format. Recovery: rewrite the live titles this week. 20–40 real nouns. Cut aesthetic and viral.

Checking payouts daily. A hobby that eats the next tray. Recovery: one monthly date on the calendar. Log out on weekdays. Sit the block instead.

Four marketplaces in month one. Four profiles, zero compounding. Recovery: pick the one that is furthest along. Pause the rest. Produce for that shelf.

A mega pack that is three unrelated dumps. Recovery: split them. Price the coherent one. Kill or hold the rest until they have a family.

Skipping the block because last week is in review. Review is not a pause button. Recovery: produce into a local folder this Saturday. Week 5 is then an upload, not a blank.

Keeping a dead theme for a year because you liked making it. Recovery: 60–90 day look this month. Unpublish the all-views-no-takes set. Double the one that moved.

Tools

The exact stack

One design tool you already open. Figma, Illustrator, Inkscape, or Affinity. If you only generate, add a vector tool this week. Buyers want files that scale.

One marketplace. Creative Market, Etsy, Adobe Stock, or the library whose license you read. Add a second after a payout.

The license, saved, highlighted. AI section, exclusivity, disclosure, prohibited content.

A keyword sheet. Listing, title, 20–40 keywords, date uploaded, date of last review.

Export presets. SVG and PNG at their preview size. A tile test board if you make patterns.

A calendar reminder named upload block. 90 minutes, same day.

Optional: a vectorizer you control, a small mockup of an app screen or a jam jar.

Not optional: the license, and a finish standard you can say in one breath.

Setup order

Hour one: marketplace chosen, license read. Hour two: three rules on a sticky, job named.

Afternoon: files in the design tool you already have. Day two: account, upload, calendar block.

Do not buy a new computer to ship ten outline icons.

What not to buy

A new computer. A second marketplace in week one. A shop theme. A cinematic mockup bundle of 200 scenes. A course on passive stock. A trademarked font you will embed illegally. A CRM. A Discord. Stock photo credits for photoreal people you should not be selling. Four generative subscriptions. You need one draft engine you already have and one vector tool.

The \$0 path

Inkscape or Figma's free tier. A marketplace with free contributor signup. The license PDF. A spreadsheet for keywords. A calendar app you already have. A model you already use, for subject lists, not for dumps. Library computer if you have to. That is enough to get 8 files into review this week. Paid seats and mockup packs wait behind a payout.

Checklist

Three style rules written

One job named (person plus project)

One marketplace picked

License read end to end, AI section highlighted

Raw-output rule noted (forbidden, labeled, or redraw)

8–12 files that share the job, not a vibe

Every file obeys the three rules

Vectors cleaned, no stray auto-trace nodes

Patterns tiled at 2x2 and 4x4, dark and light

Small-size (16px) test passed

No trademarks, no unlicensed people, no characters you do not own

Names searchable, not FinalFINAL2

SVG plus PNG (or the formats they ask for)

Zip matches the listing

Title has job, style, count, format

20–40 keywords that are nouns a buyer types

AI disclosure filled if they ask

Account submitted

Weekly 90-minute block named on the calendar

Sibling set started in the same stroke

Keyword sheet row created

Second marketplace not opened

Monthly review date set

Kill window understood: 60–90 days

Self-test from the who section, honestly answered

No dashboard on weekdays

Payout (when it comes) written in a note, not a thread

FAQ

How long until a payout?

Plan on 30–90 days after the first set is actually live. Review queues can eat two weeks. A first payout of \$8–\$20 is a working pipe, not a verdict on talent. Default: date the 90-day mark on the calendar the day the set goes live, not the day you had the idea.

Can I use a model?

As a sketch tool if the marketplace allows it and the file still meets their rules. Many want disclosure. Some restrict raw output. Read this week's terms. Redraw so the grid, the nodes, and the rights are yours. Default: model lists subjects, you draw on the grid.

Which marketplace first?

The one whose buyer you can picture. Designers who pay \$12–\$29: Creative Market or Etsy. Huge search, tiny per-download pay: Adobe Stock. One shelf until a payout. Default: Creative Market if you want to set the price and you can picture a junior designer. Adobe Stock if you want search and will accept royalty math.

How many files in a first set?

8–12. Enough to look like a product. You can grow a listing later or ship a mega pack when two small sets have sold. Default: 10, like Quinn, then grow the same listing to 20 before you invent a mega pack.

Do I need to be exclusive?

Not at the start. Exclusivity is a later trade: sometimes a higher royalty for not selling the same files elsewhere. Do not sign that away on day one. Default: non-exclusive until a payout exists and you can read the trade with a number in hand.

What if my account is rejected?

Fix the reason they named. Produce into a local folder so you have something to upload when you are approved. Do not open four more accounts in a panic. Default: one appeal, local folder, same marketplace.

Is this passive income?

No. Delayed income. Work is front-loaded into weekly blocks. Sales can arrive on a Tuesday you spent elsewhere. Stop feeding the library and it fades. Default: call it a library, never call it passive.

Own site or marketplace?

Marketplace is the aisle. Own site is a good second home after strangers already buy. Do not build the aisle before you have a product. Default: marketplace first, own site after a payout.

What do I do with a set that will not sell?

After 60–90 days with views and no downloads, unpublish. If it had no views, rewrite title and thumb once before you kill it. Default: one title rewrite at day 30 if views are near zero, kill at day 90 if downloads are still zero with views.

Can I mix icons, patterns, and photos?

Not at first. One asset type, one style, many jobs. Quinn's outline family is easier to grow than a shop that sells neon 3D, watercolor florals, and laptop photos. Default: icons or patterns, not both, until six live sets share the rules.

Can this replace rent?

Not in month one. Maybe a bill in month four through six if the family is coherent and the blocks happened. If you need rent this month, take a service path and keep Saturday for the library. Default: second till, not first.

What if I hate cleaning nodes?

Then this path will fail. The finish standard is the product. Default: skip this path, or spend one Saturday learning to clean 8 files until you know if you can stand it.

Should I watermark the working files?

Watermark previews. Sell a clean zip. A watermarked SVG is a broken product. Default: preview sheet with a light mark, zip clean.

How do I handle a custom request on a \$12 listing?

No inside \$12. Point to a freelance rate or a productized pack. Put the reusable subject into next Saturday's sibling if it fits the family. Default: one sentence no, one link to the listing, one note

on the jobs list.

Do I need mockups?

One simple grid or one object (app screen, jam jar) is enough. A 200-scene mockup bundle is a delay. Default: grid sheet in week 1, object mockup after a payout if you want.

What if the license changes?

Read it again the month it changes. If they ban what you have been doing, stop doing it, label or redraw as they now ask, unpublish what they now forbid. Default: calendar reminder to skim the AI section once a quarter.



PATH 14

A small AI membership

The vault must stay useful if they never attend a call.

36 minute read · 7,993 words

Who this is for

You can show up monthly with updated workflows after the one-time product has sold.

First sale

Three members who stay past month one.

Time to first

After you have buyers

Cash window

\$9-\$19/month

Tools

Leave this alone

Stripe subscriptions or Stan, a simple member page, dated file names, a calendar reminder for the monthly note.

A \$99/month room with nothing inside. Launching this before the one-time product has sold.

What this actually is

The definition

A small membership is a vault that stays useful if they never attend a call. That sentence is the whole design. Updates. New templates. A monthly workflow when the models change. Not your personality, unless you can keep that promise on a tired Thursday in February.

Members already bought the one-time file — the playbook, the prompt stack, the template pack — and the tools moved. A setting changed. A prompt that used to work got mushy. The membership is the living layer on top of a product that already earned trust.

This is a second product. It is not a way to avoid finishing the first one. A \$99 room with a Discord and a promise is a leak. A \$9 vault with three real files and a cancel button that works is a quiet till.

Cancel anytime. Earn the next month. Those two rules keep you honest. Live is optional garnish. The vault is the meal. Price sits in a band a person can keep without a meeting with themselves: \$9–\$19 a month.

What this is not

This is not a community. Ten quiet downloaders beat a hundred lurkers in a dead chat. If you want a group, that is a different path.

This is not a mastermind. There is no inner circle, no \$99 energy, no fake countdown on an infinite folder.

This is not a way to hide the one-time file so the only door is a card on file. People who only want the file should still be able to buy it and leave.

This is not custom work at \$9. A member who wants captions written for their shop is a productized job, not a vault member.

Why this works now

The tools move. Models shift. A prompt that shipped in March gets mushy in August. Buyers already email did this still work after the update. You are answering that for free in a messy inbox, forever, or you put the answer in a dated file and charge \$9 for the living layer.

A person who already paid \$19–\$47 for your file can keep \$9 without a story. They are not shopping for a new guru. They are shopping for the version that still runs.

Cancel that works is part of why it works. Subscription fatigue is real. Easy cancel is how a serious \$9 survives next to a pile of \$29 rooms people resent.

Three anti-patterns

Anti-pattern one: launching this before the one-time product has sold. You will pitch strangers a living layer on a book they never bought. No context, no trust, no honest invite list.

Anti-pattern two: a \$99 room with nothing inside. High price does not create value. It creates refunds and a room you dread. Earn \$9 first. Raise when the archive is fat.

Anti-pattern three: making calls the product. They will miss the call. You will miss the call. The vault should have been enough. If attendance is the only way to get the value, you built a calendar, not a membership.

The deal you keep

You keep the vault useful. You keep cancel easy. You keep selling the one-time file. You do not keep a guilt form, a fake scarcity counter, custom work inside \$9, or a silent charge after you vanish. If those stay clean, three people will still be there on day 45. That is the first real sale of this path.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This fits you if

This path fits if you already have buyers of a one-time file and you can name, in one sentence, what those buyers still need after they finish the PDF. It fits if you already update your own workflows when the tools move, and writing that down would take a morning, not a new personality.

It also fits if you can stand a monthly rhythm: a dated note, a new file, a short list of what changed. If you vanish for eight weeks, you should already have decided how you refund the unused month.

It fits if people already email you the same question twice. That repeated question is next month's file. You are holding the membership in your inbox.

Skip this if

Skip it if the one-time product has not sold. Skip it if you want a membership so you do not have to ship a finished file. Skip it if the only offer is community and a chat that goes quiet at 4pm. Skip it if they must attend a call for the thing to be worth \$9. They will not attend. They will still want the file.

Skip the \$99 version until people already stay at \$9. High price does not create value. It creates refunds and a room you dread.

Skip it if you hate writing a monthly note. A quarterly bundle sold as a one-time update pack is allowed. Recurring billing is a promise. Do not make it if you will resent it in February.

The honest middle

If the file is selling and you already send update emails for free, you are running a membership at \$0. Put the cancel button on it and charge \$9. That is the whole move.

If the file is not selling, go sell the file. This path does not start in week 1 of your business. It starts after you have buyers.

If you can keep a folder but you cannot keep a Zoom, do not list a Zoom. Avery knew February would be tired. No calls on the page. That was the honest middle, and it worked.

Skills and time

Skills: name the gap the PDF cannot cover, ship three files before anyone is charged, write a monthly note with two headings, decline custom work inside \$9, test cancel from a second email, refund without a speech if you vanish.

Time: a morning to open the vault. Two hours on the first Tuesday of each month to rerun the workflow and write the note. Replies in a 48-hour weekday window. Not a second job. Not a Discord you check at 11pm.

If two hours a month feels impossible, do not open it. The charge will continue. The vault will not.

Two-minute self-test

Answer yes or no. No essays.

Has the one-time file sold to people who are not me?

Can I name what members get that the file does not, in one sentence?

Can I put three real files in a folder this week, named by job and date?

Will I write a monthly note on a tired Thursday in February?

Will I let them cancel in two clicks without a guilt form?

Four or five yeses: build the vault this week, invite buyers only. Three: you may be one file sale away; go sell the file. Two or fewer: skip this path. A quarterly paid update pack is allowed instead.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this in before you open a platform

Write this on a card: \$9 a month for the updates the [book / stack / template] does not get. New workflow when the tools change. Cancel anytime. If you cannot say what the updates are, you do not have an offer.

The brackets are the product. Book, stack, or template they already bought. Updates are dated workflows, new templates, the monthly note. Cancel anytime is on the page, not in your head.

Five sentences that work

\$9 a month for updates the landscaping content playbook does not get. New workflow when the tools change. Cancel anytime.

\$9 a month for the dated prompt stack when the model gets mushy. New checklist each month. Cancel anytime.

\$9 a month for seasonal templates the \$27 file never had. Winter, spring, tax, back-to-school. Cancel anytime.

\$19 a month for the back catalog: six months of workflows plus the new one. Cancel anytime. Grandfather the first members at \$9.

\$9 a month for the client-follow-up workflow, rewritten when the tools move. Three files in the vault on day one. Cancel anytime.

If the sentence is about your energy, your space, or your community, start again with files.

What they get that the file does not

The dated workflow for this month's model behavior — what broke, what you changed, the prompt or SOP that replaces last quarter's version.

New templates or checklists that did not exist when they bought the file.

A short archive they can search on a Sunday, not a chat scroll.

Optional: a monthly office-hours slot if you can keep it when you are tired. If you cannot, do not list it.

A vanish rule: if you go quiet for 30 days without a note, they get the unused month back.

What they do not get

Not a second brain on Slack. Not custom work inside the \$9. Not you hiding the one-time product so the only door is a subscription. The file stays for sale. People who only want the file

should still be able to buy it and leave. Not a Discord they have to live in. Not a call they have to attend. Not an inner circle.

Packaging

One member page. What they get. What they do not. Price \$9. Cancel anytime. Vanish/refund rule. Three files listed by name, date, and job, already in the folder. Checkout line: \$9/month for updates the book does not get. Three files in the vault on day one. Cancel anytime. If I vanish, you get the unused month back.

Invite existing buyers first, with a true sentence. Public listing only after buyers have joined. The original file stays on the site with one line pointing at the vault as a second product, not a replacement.

What done looks like

The definition

Done for launch is not a hundred members. Done is:

- The one-time file has sold to real buyers.

- You wrote what members get that the book does not.

- Three items are in the vault before anyone is charged. Not coming soon.

- Price is \$9–\$19. Checkout works. Cancel is one or two clicks, not a guilt form.

- You invited existing buyers first, with a true sentence.

Done for the first season is three members who stay past month one. Ten people who cancel on day 28 means the vault was a teaser. Three people still there on day 45 means you earned the second month.

A month is done when the note went out: what changed in the tools, what file you added, where it lives. If you hosted a call, a recording or the written version is in the vault within 48 hours. If you did not host a call, the vault still got the file. The call was never the product.

Fairness test

Open the vault as a member would, on a Sunday, with no Zoom on the calendar. Can they run something this month? If no, you are charging for a room. Would you keep \$9 of this if you were them and you never liked calls? If the honest answer is I would cancel, add the file now, not on day 31 after they leave.

Technical done

Three vault items live, named YYYY-MM-job, not Update!!

A two-line index: file, date, job.

Stripe or Stan subscription, one product, one price.

Cancel tested from a second email. Two clicks.

Vanish/refund rule on the page.

Invites sent to existing buyers, not a public circus.

Monthly note on a calendar, same week, same two headings.

The one-time file still for sale.

Not-done-yet list

File has not sold.

Vault is a roadmap.

Welcome video promising the files.

Cancel takes a support ticket.

Discord is the product and it is quiet.

Calls listed, vault empty if they miss one.

\$99 for three PDFs and a smile.

Public launch to strangers with no invite list.

Custom captions being delivered inside \$9.

Monthly note skipped, charge still ran, no refund offered.

Fake 12 spots left on an infinite folder.

Pricing and the cash window

The range

\$9–\$19 a month. \$9 is the default. \$19 is for a vault that already has a back catalog — six months of workflows, not three PDFs and a smile.

A person who already paid \$19–\$47 for your file can keep \$9 without a story. \$29 starts to feel like another product they have to justify. \$99 is a different business: more support, more presence, more ways to fail them. Do not collect \$99 for a Discord you check twice a week.

Annual can wait. If you offer it, 10 months for the price of 12 is plenty — \$90 for the year at the \$9 level. Do not discount monthly to fill seats. There are no seats. There is a vault.

When to raise

Raise for new members when the archive is fat: six-plus dated workflows, not three files and a hope. Grandfather the first ones at \$9. Do not raise to make up for churn. Churn means the vault did not earn the second month. Fix the files.

Do not start at \$19 to look serious. Serious is three files and a cancel button. \$19 from day one is allowed only if the back catalog already exists. Otherwise \$9.

Refunds in one sentence

Cancel anytime, unused month refunded if you vanish for 30 days with no note and no file; mistaken joins refunded once without a speech; custom-work seekers refunded and pointed at a package. You do not refund a month they had access to files they did not open.

Never charge for these

Never charge \$99 for an empty room. Never charge for a Discord that is the product. Never charge a setup fee on top of \$9. Never charge extra to cancel. Never hide the one-time file so the

subscription is the only door. Never keep charging after you skipped the note and added no file. Never charge for custom captions inside the membership.

Worked dollars

Three members at \$9 is \$27 a month. That is a signal, not rent. Ten is \$90. Thirty is \$270, which starts to pay for the morning you spend on the note. Avery in month 4: fourteen members, about \$126 a month. Enough to pay for the morning and to stop giving updates away in a messy inbox.

The cash window opens after you have buyers. Charge on the same date. Send the update in the same week. If you cannot support more people, cap it. Scarcity should be your calendar, not a fake 3 spots left on a folder.

Avery's first week: five joined, one canceled on day 6 (wanted custom captions, refunded, pointed at a productized service). By day 45, three still there. That matched the first-sale line. The \$27 playbook stayed on the site. New buyers are the only honest top of funnel.

The first 72 hours

Do not spend 72 hours touring community platforms. Spend it on the vault and the sentence.

Day 1 morning

Open the one-time file. List what it cannot do after a model change. List questions buyers already asked. Circle three items you can finish this week: a revised prompt, a new checklist, a one-page what broke in [month] workflow. Those three are the vault.

Write the offer sentence on a card. \$9 a month for the updates the [file] does not get. Cancel anytime. If you cannot fill the file name, stop. You do not have a first product.

Day 1 afternoon

One member page. What they get. What they do not. Price \$9. Cancel anytime. Refund the unused month if you vanish — write that down. Stripe or Stan. Do not tour five community tools. The dumbest tool you will keep beats the pretty one you will abandon.

Name the three files like jobs: 2026-08-workflow-client-follow-up, not Update!!. Start the first of the three if it is not already written.

Day 1 night

Buy the membership from a second email. Cancel it. If cancel takes a support ticket, you built a trap. Fix the trap before anyone else pays. Then stop decorating the page.

Day 2

Finish all three vault items. A two-line index: file, date, job. Put them in the folder a member will actually open. No welcome video promising a roadmap. No Discord. No countdown.

Draft ten invite notes to people who already paid. Personal. Not a blast with merge tags you have not checked. Name the most useful of the three files in the note.

Day 3

Send the ten invites. Not a public launch. The book stays as it is; this is the living layer; \$9; cancel anytime; here are the three files. Point joins at the three files, not at a future call.

If someone asks for custom, decline inside the membership and name the other path. If someone joins by mistake, refund. Do not chase.

By hour 72 you have: gap list, \$9, working cancel, three vault items with job-shaped names, invites to existing buyers only. You do not have a community. You do not have a hundred members. You have a vault a Sunday downloader can use tonight.

The path, step by step

The twelve-plus moves

Sell the one-time file first. Membership is a second product for people who already trust you. If path 1 has not sold, go back. A vault with no buyers is a folder you will resent. The file is how new members appear later, too. Keep selling it forever.

Write what members get that the book does not. Dated workflows, new templates, the monthly note. If the paragraph is about your energy or your space, start again with files. Put the sentence on the member page. If you cannot say it in one breath, you do not have an offer.

Vault first, calls optional. Build the folder as if nobody will ever attend a Zoom. If you add a call later, the recap lands in the vault within two days. If you are tired, skip the call and write the file. Never make attendance the only way to get the value.

Three items in the vault before the door opens. Not a roadmap. Not a welcome video promising the roadmap. Three files they can use tonight. Named by job and date. Indexed. If you only have two, you are not open. Finish the third this week.

Price \$9–\$19 and make cancel easy. Test it yourself from a second email. Write the vanish/refund rule on the page so you are stuck with your own standard. If cancel takes a ticket, you built a trap. \$9 is the default. \$19 waits for a fat archive.

Invite existing buyers first. Ten personal notes. Public launch only after three people have stayed, or at least paid without asking wait, what is this. A public circus to strangers is how you collect day-7 cancels and a reputation for empty rooms.

A monthly note with two headings. What changed in the tools. What file you added. Date it. Under a page. Miss it twice and you are running a ghost charge. Same week every month. Avery used the first Tuesday and two hours. Steal that.

Answer in the vault, not in private exception. A good question becomes a file everyone gets. Custom work belongs in a paid project, not inside \$9. If you answer one person in a long private thread, you just trained them that \$9 buys a junior employee.

Cap when your calendar says so. If you cannot read the replies or you are slipping the note, close new signups. A fake counter is a trick. A real cap is a number you can host. For a folder-only vault the number can be high. For a vault plus replies it might be 30.

Keep selling the one-time file. Do not hide it to milk the subscription. The file is how new members appear. Mention the vault once after they have the file, not as a popup on page one.

Earn month two on purpose. At day 20, look at the vault as a member would. Is there a reason to stay besides inertia? If not, add the file now, not on day 31 after they cancel. Inertia is not a

business. The second charge is the product working.

Review stay-rate at day 45. Three members still there is a working path. A pile of day-7 cancels means the listing overpromised. Fix the files. Do not raise the price to make up for churn. Do not invent a community to paper over an empty folder.

Keep a running log of tool changes. Model updates, UI moves, a setting that used to be default. The monthly note writes itself from that log. If you abandoned the job the file teaches, the vault will rot. Run the system yourself or close the door.

Decline the live critique inside \$9. Offer a one-time package at the freelance rate. Put the reusable part of their question in next month's file. The vault stays a vault. Avery did this in month 4 and kept fourteen members without becoming a junior employee.

A worked example: Avery's \$9 vault

Who

Avery sold a \$27 playbook: a 10-day content system for one-person landscaping companies. Forty-ish buyers. Then the model started ignoring the keep it local, no corporate voice constraint. Buyers emailed. Avery answered the same reply for free, forever. No following worth mentioning. A file that had already earned trust. That is the only honest start.

Calendar

Week 0: confirmed the file had sold. Listed the inbox questions. Circled three items.

Week 1, Monday: offer sentence on a card. \$9/month for updates the book does not get. Cancel anytime. Member page on Stan. Cancel tested from a second email. Vanish rule written.

Week 1, Tuesday–Wednesday: three vault items finished. (1) the revised prompt stack tested that week, (2) a one-page what changed in the tools this month note, (3) a seasonal winter checklist the original file never had. Named by month and job. Two-line index.

Week 1, Thursday: twelve invite notes to existing buyers only. No Discord. No calls on the page. Avery knew February would be tired.

Week 1, Friday: five joined. One asked for a live critique in the first email. Avery said no inside the \$9.

The shipped artifact

The vault on day one: three files a landscaper could run that night. The revised prompt stack with the local-voice constraint restated in blunt lines. The dated what-changed note naming the mushy behavior. The winter checklist the \$27 file never had. No video. No chat. A folder.

Later artifact: six monthly workflows, two extra checklists, the first-Tuesday note every month. The \$27 file still on the site.

The mistake

Avery almost listed a monthly Zoom because it felt more like a real membership. Almost opened a Discord. Almost hid the \$27 file so people would have to join to get the new stack. Caught all three. Smaller miss: one of the twelve notes sounded like a launch, not a living layer. That buyer asked wait, did I already pay for this? Avery answered with the truth: the file is the job as of a date; the vault is the continuation.

Day 6 cancel: a member who wanted custom captions. Avery had not said not custom loudly enough on the page. Refunded, pointed them at a productized service, did not chase. Then added one line to the page: custom work is a separate package.

Recovery and the first stranger-to-stay sale

The first sale of this path is not the first join. It is three members who stay past month one. Five joined the first week. One canceled day 6. By day 45, three were still there. That matched the first-sale line. They were existing buyers, not cold ads. One of them had never opened the monthly email and still had the file in the vault. That is the design working.

On the first Tuesday of each month Avery spent two hours: rerun the core workflow on a real landscaping example, write what broke, drop a file named by month and job. Members who never opened the email still had the file.

Month 4: six workflows, two extra checklists, fourteen members, about \$126 a month. Enough to pay for the morning and to stop giving updates away in a messy inbox. A member asked for a live critique. Avery said no inside the \$9 and offered a one-time package at the freelance rate. The vault stayed a vault.

What Avery refused: a \$99 inner circle, a fake countdown, hiding the playbook, and a call schedule that would collapse the first week a job ran long.

Copy you can paste

Page hero

\$9 a month for updates the book does not get. New workflow when the tools change.
Cancel anytime.

Checkout line

\$9/month for updates the book does not get. Cancel anytime.

Post (only after buyers have joined)

The [file] is a one-time buy. This membership is the update layer: monthly workflow when the models change, new templates, cancel anytime. Built for people who already use the file.
\$9/month. Three files in the vault today.

DM to an existing buyer

You already have [file name]. The tools already moved. I am keeping a \$9 vault with the dated workflows the PDF cannot get. Three files are in there today, including [name the most useful one]. Cancel anytime. If I disappear, I refund the unused month. The original file stays yours either way.

Email 1 — invite to an existing buyer

You already have [file name]. The tools already moved. I am keeping a \$9 vault with the dated workflows the PDF cannot get. Three files are in there today, including [name the most useful one]. Cancel anytime. If I disappear, I refund the unused month. The original file stays yours either way.

Email 2 — monthly note

Subject: [Month] vault — what changed, what I added

What changed in the tools: [one paragraph, named model or setting].

What I added: [file name, job it does, where it sits].

What I am not doing this month: [a call / a new niche / custom reviews].

Good questions become next month's file. Custom work is a separate package.

Email 3 — after they buy the one-time file (once, not a popup on page one)

You have the [file]. If you want the living layer — dated workflows when the tools move, \$9/month, cancel anytime — it is here: [url]. The file you just bought stays yours either way.

Refund line

Cancel in two clicks from the billing portal. If I go quiet for 30 days without a note, email me and I refund the unused month. If you joined wanting custom work, I will refund this month and send the package link. I will not hide the button. I will not make you write an essay.

Vanish policy, on the page

Cancel in two clicks from the billing portal. If I go quiet for 30 days without a note, email me and I refund the unused month. I will not hide the button.

Week-by-week

This path does not start in week 1 of your business. It starts after the one-time file has sold.

Week 0 (gate)

Confirm you have buyers and a list of questions they already asked. If you do not, stop and go sell the file. Do not tour platforms. Do not name a community. The gate is real.

Week 1 — daily

Monday: three vault items outlined. Member page drafted. \$9. Vanish rule written.

Tuesday: files finished, named by job and date. Index written.

Wednesday: Stripe or Stan live. Buy from a second email. Cancel. Fix the trap if there is one.

Thursday: ten invite notes to existing buyers. No public thread. No Discord. No countdown.

Friday: send the ten. Point joins at the three files. Decline custom. Refund mistaken joins.

Saturday: if someone joined, make sure they can open the folder without emailing you. If they cannot, that is the only work.

Sunday: off. Do not add a call because the weekend felt quiet.

Week 2 — daily

Monday: point any new joins at the three files. Do not add a fourth yet unless a real question landed.

Tuesday–Thursday: day job, or the file still for sale. Mentions of the vault only to people who already have the file.

Friday: if someone asks for custom, decline inside the membership and name the other path. Put the reusable part of the question on a list for week 3's file.

Saturday–Sunday: off, or one sentence reply in the 48-hour window you already chose. Not a weekend desk.

Week 3

First monthly note even if it has only been three weeks — pick a cadence (first Tuesday) and hit it. Add one file that came from a real question. Same two headings: what changed, what I added. What I am not doing this month, if you need a third line to kill a rumor about calls.

Week 4

Look at cancels. If everyone left, the vault was a teaser. Fix the files before you invite more. If three stayed, you have a path. Count members, notes shipped (binary), files added (one is enough). Do not raise the price. Do not open Discord to save it.

Weeks 5–8. Same Tuesday. Same two headings. Keep selling the one-time file. Mention the vault as a second product, not a replacement. Cap if replies turn into unpaid consulting.

Month 3. Count members, stay-rate past day 45, and whether the vault would still be useful if you never hosted a call. If yes, keep \$9. If you now have six-plus dated workflows, you may test \$19 for new members and grandfather the first ones.

Quality bar

The bar: a member who never attends a call still got something they can run this month. If that is false, you are charging for a room.

Below the bar

A Discord that is dead, billed monthly. A welcome video and a roadmap. Update!! as a file name. Cancel buried in a form. The one-time file hidden. Custom captions delivered to one member and nobody else. A call they had to attend to get the prompt. A skipped note and a charge that still ran. Fake 12 spots. \$99 for three PDFs and a smile. Vibes in the monthly note (lots of exciting changes) instead of a named tool and a named break.

Above the bar

Three real files on day one, named by job and date. A monthly note that names tools, not vibes. The follow-up prompt started hedging; here is the blunt version beats lots of exciting changes. Cancel works without a performance. The one-time product remains for sale and remains true. A

48-hour window on weekdays. Custom deliverables get a no and a link to a package. Recap in the vault within 48 hours if a call happened. Vanish rule honored.

Five tests before you charge anyone

Sunday test. Open the vault with no calendar. Can a tired person run something tonight?

Name test. Every file is YYYY-MM-job. If you see Update!!, rename it.

Cancel test. Second email, two clicks, no ticket.

Sentence test. Can you say what members get that the book does not, in one breath?

February test. Will you still write the note on a tired Thursday? If no, do not open the door. A quarterly paid update pack is allowed instead.

Fail any one and you are not done. Keep building the folder. Do not collect \$9 on a fail.

What to measure

Week 1

One-time file has sold. Gate. If no, stop.

Invites sent to existing buyers. If this is zero, you launched to the void.

Three vault items live. Binary.

Cancel tested. Binary.

Joins from those invites. Five from twelve notes is a warm file.

Day 30

Members who had a chance to see the folder.

Day-7 cancels. A pile means the listing overpromised.

Monthly note shipped on time. A binary. Missed notes predict churn.

Files added. One is enough. Zero is a ghost charge.

Custom requests inside the \$9. If they rise, your copy is fuzzy or you are too available.

Revenue after refunds. Do not screenshot gross joins.

Day 90

Members who stay past month one. Three is a working vault. This is the first sale.

Day-45 stay-rate. Stayers divided by people who had a chance to be charged twice. Under 40% means the vault did not earn the second month.

Notes shipped on time across three months. Three of three, or you are slipping.

Files in the archive. Six-plus dated workflows is when \$19 for new members is even a conversation.

Cap hit or not. If you are doing custom to keep people, you already needed a cap.

Ignore

Discord online count. Likes on the announcement. Number of strangers who saw a public launch. Call attendance. Feelings about members who never log in. They paid for access, not for your feelings about engagement. They may log in the month something breaks. Measure stay-rate, not nag-rate.

One-line spreadsheet

Date joined, source (invite / file page / public), amount, cancel date if any, reason if they said it, notes shipped while they were a member (count), files added that month. Monthly tab: members, stay-rate past day 45, revenue after refunds, note shipped (yes/no). If a row is a join with no invite and no file purchase behind it, you launched to the void. Stop doing that.

Objections you will hear — including from yourself

The replies

I should charge \$99 so people take it seriously. People take files seriously. They take a \$99 empty room as a mistake. Earn \$9 first. Raise when the archive is fat.

I need a community for this to work. You need a vault. Ten quiet downloaders beat a hundred lurkers in a dead chat. If you want a group, that is a different path.

Buyers will be mad updates were not in the original file. Tell the truth: the file is the job as of a date. The vault is the living layer. You sold a complete file and you are offering a continuation.

Nobody wants another subscription. True for bad ones. False for \$9 that saves them from re-solving a broken prompt every time a model shifts. Easy cancel respects the fatigue.

I will launch this to grow my audience. Backwards. The audience of buyers already exists. A membership with no file behind it is a chat room with a card on file.

What if I cannot keep it up? Then do not open it. Or open it with the vanish rule already on the page. A clean refund is better than a silent charge.

I should include a Discord so it feels alive. Only if you will moderate it on a schedule and it is extra, not the product. Most \$9 vaults are better as a folder. Alive is a dated file, not a green dot.

Wait, did I already pay for this? The file is the job as of a date. This is the living layer. \$9. Cancel anytime. The original file stays yours either way.

I want you to review my captions every month. No inside the \$9. Here is the package. The reusable part of your question will show up as a file if it helps everyone.

Can I pause instead of cancel? If your tool has a pause, fine. Do not build a guilt maze. Cancel is enough. They can come back. The archive will still be there if you kept shipping.

What feeds this path

Upstream

The one-time file. New buyers are the only honest top of funnel. Mention the vault once after they have the file, not as a popup on page one.

You also need a job you still run. If you abandoned the system the file teaches, you cannot date a workflow. The membership is the dated version of what you already had to fix.

Buyer questions. Inbox, checkout comments, does this still work. Each repeated question is next month's file. If nobody asks anything, you may need a clearer file, not a membership.

What feeds the monthly note

Tool changes. Model updates, UI moves, a setting that used to be default. Keep a running log. The monthly note writes itself from that log.

Your own weekly work. A real example, rerun, what broke. Avery reran the landscaping workflow on a real example every first Tuesday. That is the note.

Downstream

A fatter archive. \$19 for new members, grandfathered \$9 for the first ones. A productized package for custom work that the vault keeps attracting. Seasonal one-time packs that also live in the vault. A playbook about the job, still for sale. Not a \$99 inner circle. Not a staffed community.

Printables or templates that started as a member file can become a \$9–\$19 one-time for non-members later. Members already have them. Do not yank files to resell them. Add, do not subtract.

What does not feed it

Cold ads to a \$9 vault. Affiliate blasts. Join the movement threads. Other people's mastermind screenshots. A public launch before the file has sold. Hiding the file to force the subscription. Those starve the only honest funnel: buyers who already trust you.

Mistakes

Ten-plus, and the recovery this week

Charging for a Discord that is dead. A quiet folder is a product. A quiet chat is a ghost town you billed. Recovery: turn the chat off or make it extra. Put this month's file in a folder with a name a Sunday person can find. Refund anyone who joined for the chat if the chat was the pitch.

Never updating. The charge continues. The vault does not. Recovery: ship a note this week even if it is late. If you skipped 30 days, refund the unused month without making them write an essay. Put the next note on a calendar.

Hiding the one-time product so you can milk a subscription. You starve the only source of members who already trust you. Recovery: put the file back on the site today. One line pointing at the vault as a second product.

Launching before the file has sold. You will pitch strangers a living layer on a book they never bought. Recovery: close signups. Go sell the file. Reopen when you have an invite list of buyers.

Making calls the product. They will miss the call. You will miss the call. Recovery: write the recap into the vault within 48 hours. Take calls off the page if you cannot keep them. The file is the product.

Fake scarcity. 12 spots on an infinite folder. People learn. Recovery: delete the counter. If you need a cap, use a real number you can host and close the door when you hit it.

Answering custom work inside \$9. You train members to treat the vault as a junior employee. Recovery: one no this week, one package link, one reusable question filed for next month. Add a line to the page: custom work is a separate package.

A guilt cancel. Two clicks. You earn the next month with files, not with friction. Recovery: test cancel from a second email today. If it takes a ticket, fix the trap before the next join.

A \$99 empty room. Recovery: drop to \$9 or close it. Refund the difference for the unused month. Fill three files before anyone new is charged.

Public circus in week 1. Recovery: stop the thread. Invite ten buyers instead. Ignore the stranger comments.

Skipping the February note because you are tired. That is the whole test. Recovery: skip the call if you listed one, write the file anyway. A short dated workflow beats a charming apology.

Removing people who never log in because it hurts your feelings. They paid for access. Recovery: leave them. Measure stay-rate, not nag-rate. They may log in the month something breaks.

Tools

The exact stack

Stripe subscriptions or Stan. One product, one price, one portal where they can cancel without emailing you a plea.

A simple member page. A logged-in folder, a locked Notion page, a Stan membership, a Circle space you actually update. The dumbest tool you will keep beats the pretty one you will abandon.

Dated file names. YYYY-MM-job. Searchable in six months.

Your existing email list of buyers. Not a new platform.

A calendar reminder for the monthly note. Same week, same two headings.

A running log of tool changes. A note file, not a feeling.

You do not need a mobile app, a points system, or a course platform. You do not need Zoom if you are not hosting.

Setup order

Confirm the file has sold. Write the sentence. Build three files in the tool you already write in. Then pick Stan or Stripe, not the reverse. Test buy. Test cancel. Then invites. If you already sold the file on Gumroad or Stan, use their membership add-on if cancel stays easy. Moving people to a new login in week 1 is a way to lose them before they see the three files.

What not to buy

A community platform you will not moderate. A mobile app. A points system. A course platform. Zoom if you are not hosting. A countdown app for fake scarcity. A second email tool. A CRM. A \$99/month community stack to collect \$9. Ads to a vault with no file behind it.

The \$0 path

A locked Google Drive or Notion page you already have, plus Stripe's free subscription on a Payment Link or Stan's free tier if you qualify, plus the email list of buyers you already have, plus

a calendar reminder. That is enough to charge \$9 and deliver three files this week. Paid community software waits until the vault is boring and full, which is the point, and even then you may never need it.

Checklist

- One-time file has sold to people who are not you
- You can name what members get that the file does not
- Gap list from the file and from real questions
- Three vault items live, named by job and date
- Two-line index: file, date, job
- Price \$9–\$19, default \$9
- Cancel tested from a second email
- Vanish/refund rule on the page
- Calls optional; vault useful either way
- No Discord required for the product
- No fake scarcity counter
- Existing buyers invited first, ten notes
- No public circus in week 1
- File remains for sale
- Checkout line matches the offer sentence
- Monthly note on the calendar, same week, same two headings
- One new useful file per month, even if short
- Custom asks declined inside the \$9
- General answers filed in the vault
- Cap ready if you cannot support more people
- Day 20: vault checked as a member would
- Day 45: stayers counted

Three past month one treated as the first real sale

Revenue counted after refunds

Self-test from the who section, honestly answered

February test passed (you will still write the note)

No \$99 empty room

No hiding the one-time product

FAQ

Do I need a membership if my file is selling?

Only if buyers still need something after they finish it — usually because tools move or seasons change. Do not invent a subscription to look like a real business. Default: if the same question shows up twice in your inbox, you need the vault. If it does not, you need a better file or a different path.

Can I launch the membership and the file on the same day?

You can. You should not. You will split your finish energy and have no honest invite list. Sell the file. Answer the follow-up questions. Then open the vault. Default: file first, vault after buyers exist.

What if I hate writing a monthly note?

Then do not open a membership. A quarterly bundle sold as a one-time update pack is allowed. Recurring billing is a promise. Default: skip this path, sell a dated update pack when the tools actually move.

Should I include a Discord?

Only if you will moderate it on a schedule and it is extra, not the product. Most \$9 vaults are better as a folder. Default: no Discord.

How do I handle a member who wants custom work?

Refund if they joined by mistake. Otherwise: no inside the membership, here is the package. Put the reusable part of their question in the vault. Default: refund the mistaken join, package link for the rest, one line added to the page.

What if the tools do not change that month?

Ship anyway. A seasonal file, a tighter SOP, a filled example you did not have in the book. Silence is the failure, not a quiet month in the industry. Default: one seasonal or tighter file, still a note with two headings.

Can I charge \$19 from day one?

If the vault already has a back catalog, yes. If it has three files, start at \$9. Grandfather early members when you raise. Default: \$9 until six dated workflows exist.

What counts as vanishing?

You skipped the monthly note and added no file, and 30 days passed. Charge still ran. Refund the unused month without making them write an essay. Default: 30 days, unused month, no speech.

How many members is too many at \$9?

When you cannot keep the note on time or you are doing custom work to keep people. For a folder-only vault, that number can be high. For a vault plus replies, it might be 30. Default: cap when the note slips or custom starts; 30 is a working number for replies.

Do I remove people who never log in?

No. They paid for access, not for your feelings about engagement. They may log in the month something breaks. Measure stay-rate, not nag-rate. Default: leave them.

What if I already have a community?

The vault is still the product. The chat is extra. If the community is the only value, you are on a different path and \$9 will not hold when the chat goes quiet. Default: folder first, chat optional, never reverse.

Can I use this to replace freelance?

Not at three members. Thirty at \$9 is \$270. That is a till, not a firm. Keep the productized package for custom work. Default: second till, after the file, beside freelance, not instead of it in month one.

Should I offer annual?

After monthly works. 10 months for the price of 12 is plenty. Do not discount monthly to fill seats. Default: monthly only until day-45 stay-rate is healthy.

What if a member forwards the files?

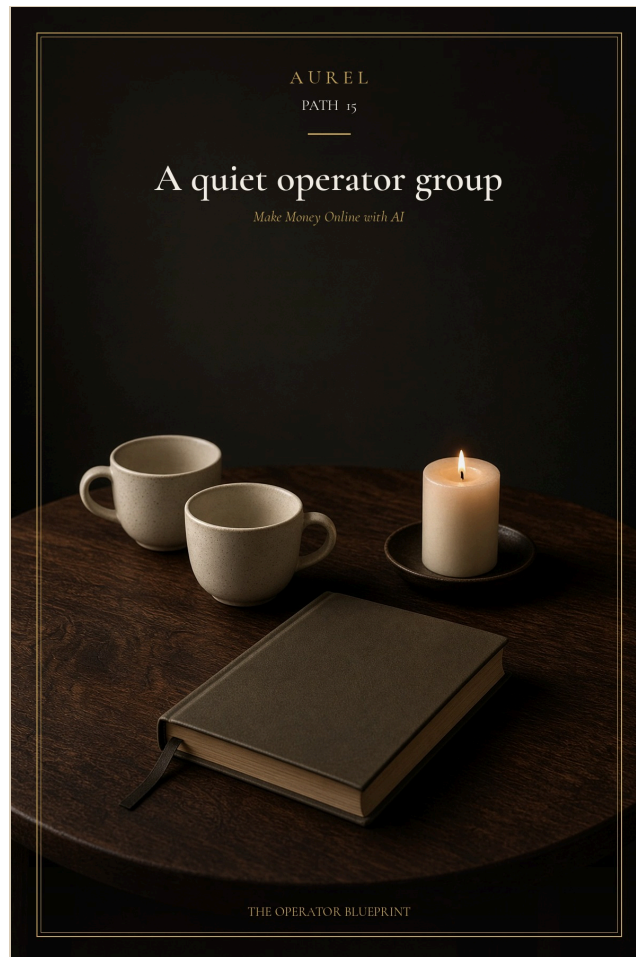
Watermark if you must. Write the license in one line. A \$9 vault will leak a little. Most churn is unused access, not theft. Default: one-line license, do not build DRM, keep shipping so staying is easier than stealing last month's note.

How do I mention this on the file's sales page?

One line, after the buy: optional living layer, \$9/month, cancel anytime. Not a popup. Not a bundle that hides the one-time price. Default: one sentence under the buy button, full pitch only in the post-purchase email.

What if I want to close it?

Honor the vanish rule. Refund unused month. Leave the archive up through the paid period. Do not ghost. A clean close is a reputation. A silent charge is a story they will tell. Default: one email, refund unused, door closed, file still for sale.



PATH 15

A quiet operator group

Ten people who return next week beat a hundred lurkers. Host a table, not a stadium.

39 minute read · 8,671 words

Who this is for

People already ask you how you work. You can host a small room without turning it into a second job.

Time to first

1–3 weeks

Tools

First sale

Ten people who come back.

Cash window

Application or a \$9–\$19 desk fee; supports the product

Leave this alone

Circle, Skool, or a chat you actually moderate. A three-question form. A calendar reminder.

A free group that becomes your unpaid homework. A 500-person Skool with a pitch on Tuesdays.

What this actually is

The definition

A quiet operator group is ten people who return next week. It is a room with one rule — useful or kind — and one weekly thread with a real question, not a motivational poster. Members already do the work. They already ship something. They come back because the thread makes next week easier, not because you posted a tip.

The community supports the product. It is not the whole business on day one. People already buy your file or your package and they keep asking how you actually run the week. The group is where those questions sit in public so you stop rewriting the same paragraph in DMs. It is also where members show their work to each other, which you cannot fake with a broadcast.

You host. You do not guru. Hosting means you post the thread on the same day, you answer the first replies like a person who read them, you remove noise, and you spotlight member work instead of your pitch. If the room dies the week you skip, it was never a community. It was a broadcast with extra steps.

What this is not

It is not a platform. It is not a stadium. It is not a free Slack that fills with "good morning" and Notion affiliate links. It is not a mastermind you staff with calls, homework, and a slide deck. It is not a Facebook group you opened because a thread said community is a moat.

It is not a course with a chat attached. If they need a sequence, sell the file. If they need you to run the job, sell the package. The group is the room around those things, not a replacement for them.

It is not a lead magnet. "Join my free community" under every post is how you collect lurkers who treat operators as a free help desk. The door is an application or a small fee. The room stays

small on purpose.

Why this works now

Operators are drowning in giant rooms. A 8,000-person Skool has a feed, a course tab, a Tuesday pitch, and three people actually talking. The rest is noise with a login. People who already run a thing will pay a desk fee, or fill three lines, to sit at a table where a reply can be seen.

AI made the beginner questions cheaper to ask and more expensive to answer. Every free group is now a firehose of "what prompt do I use." A quiet room with a shipping test at the door keeps that firehose outside. You answer operating questions once, in public, for people who already did the work.

DMs do not scale. The same three questions after every \$19 sale will eat your evenings. Put the answers in a weekly thread. Point buyers who are clearly operators at the door. Keep the file public for everyone else.

Three anti-patterns

Anti-pattern one: the open link. Two hundred people join. Three post. You mop pitches and unedited model dumps. Recovery: close the link this week. Application or \$9. Write the rule. Remove the loudest tourist.

Anti-pattern two: the content calendar inside the group. Daily tips, a module, a live on Tuesdays. Members stop talking because you filled the air. Recovery: kill every extra channel. One weekly thread. Spotlight their work.

Anti-pattern three: the group as the business. You admit anyone who pays and you pitch twice a week. Operators leave. Recovery: sell the file and the package for money. Measure return visits, not MRR, until the room is real.

The deal you keep

You keep a table of ten, a clock, and a mop. They keep a room small enough that a specific artifact can be seen. You will not turn their Tuesday into a webinar. They will not treat the room as a help desk for work they have not started.

Money is secondary on purpose. An application or a small fee keeps tourists out. The fee supports the product. Quality over size. If you cannot read the room, you built a leak.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

Fits if

This path fits if people already ask you how you work — not "how do I get started in AI," but "how did you run that weekly upload block" or "what did you tell the client who wanted unlimited revisions." You have a point of view specific enough that ten operators would rather talk near it than sit in a giant free Slack.

It fits if you can host a small room without turning it into a second job. Same day each week. Thirty to sixty minutes of presence. A rule you will enforce. You do not need to be magnetic. You need to be on time and unwilling to let spam sit.

It fits if a product already exists: a file, a package, a vault. The group supports that product. Buyers already paid you, or peers already watch how you run the week. You are inviting, not advertising.

It fits if you can say no at the door. The first noisy member is a test. If you freeze, the room learns the rule was decoration.

Skip if

Skip it if nobody asks you anything yet. Build the file or the package first. A group with no shared work is a book club that never read the book.

Skip it if you want a free group to "build community" around a product you have not shipped. You will spend evenings answering homework for people who will never buy.

Skip it if you cannot remove a person. Skip a 500-person Skool with courses and a pitch on Tuesdays. That is a media company. This path is ten operators and a thread.

Skip it if you need this to pay rent this month. Use the package path. Come back when the product is selling and the DMs are repetitive.

Skip it if you hate reading other people's work. Hosting is reading. If you only want to broadcast, write a letter.

The honest middle

You have eight people who already DM you operating questions, a \$19 file that sells a few times a month, and one evening a week. Invite the eight, add two peers, post a real question on a named day. If you have forty buyers and no time, still start at ten. Point extra people at the public product.

Skills and time

You need: a written rule, a door, a calendar, the nerve to delete a post. You do not need video, a curriculum, or a personality brand.

Time: thirty to sixty minutes on thread day. Ten minutes on two other days to remove noise and spotlight one artifact. If it is more than two hours a week, you opened extra channels or you admitted too many people. Close them.

Two-minute self-test

Answer yes or no. Do not hedge.

In the last 30 days, have at least five people asked you how you run a specific piece of work?

Do you have a product (file, package, vault) that already sold to a stranger?

Can you name a day you will post a thread for the next eight weeks?

Will you remove a person who pitches after one private warning?

Can you host for under two hours a week without resenting it?

If you have five yeses, invite ten this week. If question 1 or 2 is a no, go back to the file. If question 3, 4, or 5 is a no, this path will become a second job you hate. Pick a letter or a package instead.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill-in-the-blank

Write this on a card before you pick a tool: "[N] operators who already [named job]. One weekly thread on [day]. Useful or kind. Door is [application / \$X desk fee]. The [file or package] stays public. This room is not a course."

If you cannot fill the brackets, you do not have an offer. You have a vibe.

Five sentences that work

Ten bookkeepers who already send AI-assisted follow-ups. Tuesday thread. Useful or kind. \$9 a month. The \$19 stack stays on the page.

Twelve solo realtors who already write listings. Thursday thread. Application: what you shipped in 30 days. No pitching. The \$29 pack is public.

Ten operators who already run a named package. Monday thread. \$19 a year desk fee. Host reads. Member work gets the spotlight.

Eight local-business operators using the same playbook. Wednesday thread. Three-line application. \$0, but you must name a thing you shipped.

Ten people who already sold a file. Sunday night thread: what you refused this week. \$9. The vault is separate.

What they get

A room small enough that a reply can be seen.

One weekly thread with a real operating question: what did you ship, where did it break, what are you running next week.

A host who reads. Not a content calendar of tips.

Spotlight on member work. Your product is in the bio, not in every post.

A rule that is enforced. Pitching belongs in a named thread, if at all.

A door that keeps tourists out, so the people inside are already running something.

What they do not get

They do not get you on demand. They do not get a mastermind you cannot staff. They do not get a promise that this group is a business model by itself. They do not get daily engagement, a leaderboard, homework, or a certificate. They do not get custom work inside the desk fee. Custom work is the package, priced and dated.

If they cannot name a thing they shipped, they are not an operator yet. Point them at the public product. Do not admit them so the member count looks healthy.

Packaging

Two honest doors.

Application: three questions. What are you actually running? What did you ship in the last 30 days? Will you show up on [day]? Read the answers. Reply within two days. A polite no is part of the product.

Small fee: \$9–\$19 a month or a \$29–\$49 annual desk fee. Either one is enough to make a person think once before joining. Checkout is a payment link with a note field for the three answers, or a form then a \$9 link. Do not build a 12-step onboarding.

One space. One pinned post with the rule, the rhythm, and where the product lives. One weekly thread. Optional: one classifieds post a month. That is the whole package. If you need a course tab to feel legitimate, you are building path 14 by accident.

What done looks like

Definition

Done for the first 72 hours: the rule is written, ten people are invited, the first weekly thread is a real question, and you answered the first replies like a host.

Done for the first sale of this path: ten people who come back the next week. Not ten signups. Ten humans who posted or at least showed up in the thread twice. A Skool with 80 silent members and one weekly broadcast from you is a newsletter with extra login friction.

A healthy month is four threads, a stable ten to twenty people, and a room you can still read in twenty minutes. If you need a community manager in month one, you admitted too many people or you never wrote the rule.

Fairness test

Would a member who shipped something last week, and who can only spend fifteen minutes in the room, still get value? If yes, you are done enough. If they have to watch a replay, complete a module, or wait for your office hours, you built a course and called it a group.

Would you still host if the fee were \$0 this month? If the only reason you posted is to justify \$19, you will over-talk. Host because the thread is useful. Let the fee keep tourists out.

Technical done

Tool exists. One space. Members can post.

Pin is up: rule, day, what this is not, where the product lives.

Door works: form answers arrive, or \$9 checkout delivers access the same day.

You can remove a post and a person without a support ticket to the platform.

Calendar reminder for thread day, same hour, repeating.

A private note template for first-offense noise.

Not-done-yet list

Logo, banner, brand kit, welcome video. Not done-yet. They do not make ten people return.

A public landing page with countdown numbers. Not done-yet. You are inviting, not launching.

Daily channels, voice rooms, a leaderboard, gamification. Not done-yet. They make silence louder.

A curriculum inside the group. Not done-yet. That is a membership vault or a course.

Ten signups who never posted. Not done. Ten who come back is the line.

Your product pitch in the first three posts. Not done. The about page holds the link.

A week is done when the thread went up on the same day it always goes up, noise was removed the day it appeared, at least one member's work got a spotlight that was not your funnel, and you did not pitch unless someone asked.

Pricing and the cash window

Ranges

This path's cash window is application or a small fee; it supports the product. The group is not the studio. The file, the package, or the vault is the studio. The group keeps operators close and keeps you from drowning in DMs.

Two honest doors:

Application, \$0. Use this if your product already sells and you want a tight room. Free still needs a door. An open link is how you get tourists.

Small fee. \$9–\$19 a month, or \$29–\$49 for a year. Enough to pay the Circle or Skool invoice and to make a person think once. Not enough that you start performing to justify a high-ticket container.

Worked dollars, month one, ten people: \$0 if applications, or \$90 if ten paid \$9, or \$190 if ten paid \$19, or \$290–\$490 if they paid a year up front. Fine. Measure return visits, not MRR, until the room is real.

Circle or Skool may cost \$29–\$99 a month. A \$9 desk fee on ten people covers a cheap plan. If the tool costs more than the fee brings in, use a chat you already live in, or keep applications at \$0 and let the product pay the tool.

When to raise

Raise the desk fee when the room is full and you have a wait, not when you feel underpaid. Full means you cannot read the room in twenty minutes, or the original ten no longer get seen. Then you either cap and keep \$9, or you open a second table at \$19 with a sharper job.

Do not raise to \$49 a month because a thread told you community is high-ticket. \$49 a month is a membership with files, or a service with a date. This path is a desk fee.

Annual at \$29–\$49 is a convenience for people who already returned for a month. Offer it after month two, not as a launch stunt.

Refunds in one sentence

Refund the unused month if they ask in the first seven days and they barely posted; after that, cancel at period end and keep the door honest.

Never-charge

Do not charge \$199 a month for "access to me" in a group you check on Sundays. Do not sell \$2,000 masterminds with a slide deck. If you want high-touch, that is a service package with a name and a date.

Do not charge extra for "founding member" theater. Do not charge to apply. Do not charge for the weekly thread as a pay-per-call. Do not upsell a course inside week one.

Worked dollars against the product

If the fee starts to outrun the product, you will admit anyone who pays, and the operators will leave. Keep the file at \$19–\$47 and the package at \$300–\$1,500. Let those pay you. Let \$9 keep the room clean.

Time to first: 1–3 weeks if people already ask how you work. You are inviting, not advertising. If you need ads to fill ten seats, you do not have a group.

The first 72 hours

Do not spend this window designing a logo. Write the rule. Invite ten. Post.

Day 1 morning: the rule and the door

Write one rule: useful or kind. Add the specifics you will enforce: no pitching in the weekly thread, no dumping raw AI text as "value," no dunking on other members' work. Put it in a note you will pin.

Pick the door. Three application questions or a \$9 checkout with a note field. Write the three questions now: What are you actually running? What did you ship in the last 30 days? Can you show up on [day]?

Pick the tool you will moderate: Circle, Skool, or a chat you already live in. One space. Create it this morning. Do not tour five platforms.

Day 1 afternoon: the invite list

List twelve people who already ask you how you work. Buyers, peers, two people slightly ahead of you. Not "my whole list." Write names, not segments. If you cannot name twelve, name eight. Eight is enough to start. Do not pad with lurkers to make a round number.

Draft the invite once. Personal first line for each: the specific question they asked you. Then the room sentence. Then the door. Send five this afternoon.

Day 1 night: pin and calendar

Pin the rule. Put next week's thread day on the calendar, same hour, repeating. Write the first thread question in a draft: "What did you ship in the last seven days, and where did it get stuck?" Do not post it until people are in. Sleep.

Day 2: send the rest, process the door

Send the remaining invites in the morning. When applications arrive, read them the same day. Yes to people who named a shipped thing and can do the day. No to people who want to recruit, who have not shipped, or who ask if they can pitch their SaaS. Use the no script. Do not "maybe" them into the room.

If you chose \$9, send the payment link after the yes. Access the same day they pay. If they pay and cannot name a shipped thing, refund and point them at the file.

Set up the space: one channel or one feed for the weekly thread, one pin, no extra rooms. If the tool forces extra tabs, ignore them.

Day 3: the first thread, then host

Post at the hour you promised. A question you would ask a colleague. Pin the rule again if the tool buries it. Do not post your product.

Answer the first replies with follow-up questions, not advice dumps. "What did you refuse in order to ship that?" is a host move. A 400-word lecture is a guru move.

Remove anything that breaks the rule the same day. A wall of unedited ChatGPT: delete, DM the rule, let them stay once. A stealth pitch: private note. A pile-on: stop it in public, short.

By hour 72 you have: rule written, ten invites (not a public blast), first thread as a real question, first replies answered like a host, noise removed same day, next week on the calendar.

The path, step by step

Step 1. Confirm people already ask

Open your DMs, email, and comments from the last 30 days. Count operating questions, not compliments. If the inbox has no "how did you do X," you are early. Ship the product. Collect the questions. Then host.

Step 2. Write the rule in the words you will reuse

Useful or kind. Pitching has a place or it has no place. You will remove noise the same day. Put this at the door and in the pinned post. If you cannot enforce a line, do not write it. One rule with three specifics beats a twelve-rule constitution nobody reads.

Step 3. Application or a small fee so tourists stay out

Three questions or \$9. Say no to people who cannot name what they shipped in 30 days. The no is the product as much as the yes. Stay in the desk-fee band or stay at \$0 with a real door. \$199

will force you to perform.

Step 4. Invite ten, not a hundred

Ten operators who return will teach you how to host. A hundred lurkers will teach you how to broadcast. Write names. Send personal notes. Ten is a table. Start there even if forty people would say yes.

Step 5. Pick a tool you will actually moderate

Circle, Skool, or a chat. One space. Pick the tool you will open on thread day without a password hunt. Test that you can pin, mute, and remove. A pretty ghost town is worse than a boring group chat that is alive.

Step 6. Same weekly rhythm

Same day. Same hour. Same kind of question. People should guess when the thread appears. Put it on a repeating calendar. If you miss twice, you trained them to stop looking. Rhythm is the product they can feel without a pitch.

Step 7. First thread is a real question, not a motivational poster

"What did you ship, where did it break" beats "Let's crush it this quarter." Ask about an artifact or a decision: a title, a refusal, a number, a scope line. Write the question the night before so you do not type a vibe at 9:02.

Step 8. Answer the first replies like a host, not a guru

Hosts ask a better next question. Your product link lives in the about page. One specific note plus one question is the shape. If four people reply, four host replies. If you only answer the person you like, the others learn they are furniture.

Step 9. Spotlight member work, not your pitch

Once a week, lift a specific thing a member did: a listing title, a package name, a kill decision. Quote it. Say what you noticed. Members copy what you celebrate. Celebrate artifacts and they

bring artifacts.

Step 10. Remove noise the day it appears

One person dominating, a stealth pitch, a pile-on, a raw model dump. Private note first if they might not know. Public removal if they knew. Same day. If you wait a week, the culture slides. The mop is the job.

Step 11. Keep the group in service of the product

When someone is a fit for the file, the about page is enough. New buyers who are clearly operators can get an invite after they have used the file. The file stays public. The room stays small.

Step 12. Cap when you cannot read the room

Twenty is a lot if you are one person. Add in fives, not in fifties. If hosting time jumps past two hours, close new seats. Point extra people at the public product. Do not "scale community."

Step 13. Install a pressure valve for pitches

If members need to offer work, one monthly classifieds post. First stealth pitch: private note. Second: remove the post. Third: remove the person. Write this in the pin so you are not inventing policy when you are annoyed.

Step 14. Watch what happens when you skip a week

Skip once on purpose after the room has a rhythm. If it dies, it was a broadcast. If two members start the thread without you, you have a community. Then come back and keep hosting anyway — they still need a janitor and a clock.

A worked example: Cameron's ten operators

Cameron sells a \$19 prompt stack for solo bookkeepers and a \$600 package that turns a messy inbox into a week of follow-ups. People already DM the same three questions after they buy.

Cameron is tired of typing the answers and does not want a free Facebook group that turns into homework.

Week 0, Sunday night

Cameron writes the rule on a sticky: useful or kind. No pitching in the weekly thread. Then a \$9 a month Circle space — a desk fee, not a transformation. Application is three lines: what are you running, what did you ship last month, can you show up Tuesdays. Circle plan is \$39 a month. Ten times \$9 covers it if they stay. Cameron lists twelve people: eight buyers of the stack, two peers who also productized bookkeeping work, two clients from the \$600 package. Not the email list. Twelve names.

Week 1, Monday–Tuesday

Monday morning, ten personal invites. Two applications get a polite no — one has not shipped anything ("I'm exploring AI"), one wants to recruit for a crypto thing. The no is the product as much as the yes. Ten join. Two of the twelve never reply. Fine.

Tuesday at 9am, the thread: "What did you ship last week, and what did you refuse?" Four people reply the first day. Cameron answers each with one specific note and one question. Does not drop a coupon. A fifth person pastes a wall of unedited ChatGPT "value." Cameron deletes it, DMs them the rule, and lets them stay. They post like a human the next week. That is the recovery: same-day mop, one warning, no speech.

Week 2

Same Tuesday, 9am. New question: "Which number did you actually look at — invoices sent, replies, stay-rate — and what did it change?" Six replies. Cameron spotlights one member who killed a \$200 extra round and wrote it into their intake. Not a testimonial for the \$600 offer. Hosting time: 40 minutes Tuesday, 8 minutes Thursday to delete a job-ad comment from a guest who found the invite link. Cameron rotates the link. Mistake: left the invite link in a public tweet on Monday. Recovery this week: kill the tweet, new link, application-only from here.

Week 3

Empty chairs: two of the ten went quiet. Cameron sends three more personal invites from the same kind of list, not a landing page. One joins. Member count is eleven. A member names a package on the thread instead of an hourly shrug. Cameron spotlights that. Cash this week: \$99 in desk fees (eleven times \$9). Product cash is separate: two \$19 stacks and one \$600 deposit from a stranger who is not in the room.

Week 4

A lurker emails: they used the refuse question to turn down a bad job. That is a return. Cameron counts returning humans, not hearts. Nine of eleven posted or reacted with a sentence. Monthly classifieds: one post, three offers, no stealth pitches in the thread. Review: Cameron can still read the room in twenty minutes.

Week 6, the skip test

Cameron skips a Tuesday on purpose (a client deadline) and says so on Monday. Two members post the question anyway. The room did not die. Member count is still eleven. Fee is \$9. Circle invoice is covered. The \$19 stack still sells to people who are not in the room. The group did not become the business. It stopped the DMs from being the business.

First stranger sale of the path is not a desk fee. It is the eleventh member — a bookkeeper who bought the stack in week 2, used it, applied with a shipped week of follow-ups, and came back the next Tuesday. The desk fee is \$9. The win is the return.

What Cameron refused: a free open link, a public launch thread, a leaderboard, daily prompts, measuring success by "247 members," a \$199 "inner circle," and going live every Tuesday inside the group.

Copy you can paste

Swap the job, the day, and the fee. Keep the calm. Do not add an origin story.

Public post

I am opening a small room for people already running this work — not a free-for-all, not a course. Ten operators. One weekly thread on [day]. Useful or kind. Door is three lines: what you are running, what you shipped in 30 days, whether [day] works. [Fee if any]. If you are still shopping for a first product, the [file] is the better door: [link].

DM

You asked me [the specific question they asked]. I am putting that kind of question in a small Tuesday room so I stop rewriting it in DMs. Ten operators. Useful or kind. If you want in: reply with what you shipped in 30 days and whether Tuesdays work. [Fee if any]. If you would rather just have the file, it is still \$[price] here: [link].

Page hero

Ten operators. One weekly thread. Useful or kind. Not a course. Not a free Slack. Application is three lines or a \$9 desk fee. The [file] stays public for everyone else.

Checkout / door line

\$9 a month. Desk fee, not a transformation. Cancel anytime. You get a Tuesday thread and a host who reads. You do not get me on demand. If you have not shipped something in 30 days, buy the [file] first.

Email 1 — the invite to a buyer

You already bought [file]. You asked [question]. I am hosting a small operator room for people already running this — ten seats, Tuesday thread, useful or kind, \$9. If you want it, reply with one sentence of what you shipped this month. If not, the file still works and I will not follow up about the room.

Email 2 — thread day reminder, members only

Tuesday thread is up: [question]. Fifteen minutes is enough. Bring an artifact or a decision, not a vibe. Rule still stands. See you in the room.

Email 3 — the quiet no, after they apply

Thanks for writing. This room is for people already running a thing and shipping monthly. The better door for you right now is [the public file / the package]. If that changes, apply again with something you shipped. No hard feelings.

Refund

Refunded the unused month. The room is still there if you apply later with something shipped. The [file] stays on the page either way.

The door questions

What are you actually running right now (file, service, catalog, job)?

What did you ship in the last 30 days? One sentence is enough.

Can you show up on [day] for a weekly thread, even if you only read?

Weekly thread starters

What did you ship last week, and where did it get stuck?

What did you refuse this week, and what did that protect?

Which number did you actually look at — downloads, stay-rate, invoices — and what did it change?

The rule, pinned

Useful or kind. No pitching in this thread. No raw model dumps as "value." No dunking. If you need to offer a paid thing, ask the host first or wait for the monthly classifieds post. Noise gets removed the same day.

First-offense private note

I removed that post. The rule is useful or kind, and no pitching in the weekly thread. One warning. Next time I remove the person. If you want to offer work, wait for classifieds on [date].

Glad you are here if you want to talk about what you shipped.

Week-by-week

Assume you have a job and evenings. This is four weeks to ten people who return, not a community company.

Week 1, daily

Day 1: write the rule. Choose application or \$9. Stand up one space. Pin a draft of the rule. List twelve names.

Day 2: send five personal invites in the morning, five at lunch. Process any applications the same night. No public blast.

Day 3: send the last two if needed. Confirm the tool: pin, remove, notify. Put thread day on a repeating calendar. Draft the first question.

Day 4 (thread day): post on time. Host the first replies. Remove noise same day. Do not pitch.

Day 5: ten minutes. Spotlight one artifact if one exists. Quiet otherwise.

Day 6–7: do not add channels. If someone has not accepted, one bump, not three.

Week 2, daily

Day 8: same question shape, new words. Post on time. Host.

Day 9–10: ten minutes to mop and to answer a follow-up. Spotlight member work, not your file.

Day 11: count returning humans. Write the number down. Ten who came back is the only metric this week.

Day 12–14: if chairs are empty, write three more names of the same kind. Do not open a landing page. Do not add a voice room to "boost engagement."

Week 3

If you have empty chairs, send three more personal invites. A quiet no to a misfit is better than an eleventh tourist.

Same day, same kind of question. If silence is real, ask one member what would make the thread useful. Do not fill the hole with your content calendar.

Optional: one classifieds post if people are sneaking pitches. One post. Then back to the thread.

Week 4

Monthly review, twenty minutes: returning humans, hosting hours, noise removed same day (yes/no), product still selling (yes/no). Cap if you cannot read the room.

Classifieds (optional) in one post, not in every thread. Skip-week test is for after the room has a pulse — week 6, not week 4.

Weeks 5–12

Same rhythm. Skip one week on purpose only after the room has a pulse. If it dies, tighten the host habit. Cap when you cannot read the room. Point extra people at the public product.

Quality bar

If you cannot read the room, you built a leak. That is the quality bar.

Below-bar

Thread is late or skipped without a name.

First replies get an auto-thank-you or nothing.

Rule is broken for a week while you "think about how to handle it."

Your pitch appears more often than member work.

New people cannot see, in one pin, what this is and what it is not.

Questions are posters: "How are we showing up this week?"

Replies are vibes: "This. So good."

You cannot name ten returning humans. You can name a member count.

Above-bar

The weekly thread is on time.

The first replies get a human host, not an auto-thank-you.

The rule is enforced the same week it is broken, usually the same day.

Member work is visible more often than your pitch.

New people can see, in one pinned post, what this is and what it is not.

Useful means a specific artifact or decision: a title, a refusal, a number, a scope line.

Kind means you can disagree without a performance.

Ten returning people. You can still read the room in twenty minutes.

Five tests

Test 1, the stranger pin. Hand the pinned post to someone who is not in the group. Can they tell what to post, what not to post, and when the thread goes up? If not, rewrite the pin tonight.

Test 2, the fifteen-minute member. Could a busy operator get value in fifteen minutes this week? If they need a replay, you built a course.

Test 3, the skip week. After a pulse exists, skip once. If nobody posts, you had a broadcast. Recovery: shorter questions, more host replies, fewer seats.

Test 4, the mop clock. Did noise sit overnight? If yes, the culture is already sliding. Recovery this week: same-day rule, private note template, remove the repeat offender.

Test 5, the product still sells. If the group is busy and the file is quiet, you may have turned operators into an audience of free advice-seekers. Recovery: put the product in the bio only, stop answering beginner questions, tighten the door.

Size and energy

Ten returning people is success. Eighty silent people is a metric you bought. Add seats only when the current ones still get seen. If hosting is more than two hours a week, close the extra channels.

What to measure

Week 1

Invites sent (target 10–12 personal, not a blast).

Door decisions: yes, no, pending. Pending should hit zero by day 3.

Thread posted on the promised day (binary).

Replies that are artifacts or decisions, not vibes (count them).

Noise removed same day (binary).

Hosting minutes (target under 90 this week including setup).

Day 30

Returning humans next week. The first-sale number. Count people, not pageviews. Ten who come back beats eighty who signed up.

Four threads, on time (4/4 or you have a rhythm problem).

Desk-fee cash if you charge: ten times \$9 is \$90. Write it. Do not confuse it with product revenue.

Product support: are DMs down? Are file buyers still buying?

Hosting time per week. If it climbs past two hours without a fee that justifies it, you are over-serving. Cap or simplify.

Day 90

Stable ten to twenty. Cap status.

Skip-week test done once: broadcast or community.

Stay-rate on the fee: still paying after month two.

At least one member-started thread.

Product still the studio: file and package revenue vs desk fees. Desk fees should not be the plan that pays rent.

Ignore

Do not measure member count as success. Do not measure online-now dots. Do not measure hearts on the announcement or how many platforms you are on.

One-line spreadsheet

Date | thread posted (Y/N) | returning humans | artifact replies | noise same-day (Y/N) | host minutes | desk-fee cash | file/package cash | notes (one sentence)

One row a week. If you need a dashboard, you are avoiding the thread.

Objections you will hear — including from yourself

"I should keep it free so it grows."

Free without a door becomes unpaid homework. Application or a small fee is how operators self-select. Return visits are the point, not growth. Reply: "Growth of lurkers is a leak. Ten who return is the line. The door stays."

"Ten people is too small to matter."

Ten people who ship and talk to each other will change their week. A hundred lurkers will not. You are hosting a table, not a network-effects startup. Reply: "I am not building a platform. I am hosting a table. Ten is the product."

"I need daily engagement."

You need a Thursday. Daily engagement is how you get spam, pitches, and a second job. Operators have work. Reply: "The room is weekly on purpose. Daily is a feed. Feeds turn into classifieds."

"What if nobody replies?"

Wrong ten, or you posted a poster, or it is day one. Wait. Two personal nudges, not a guilt speech. If week 3 is still silence, ask one member what would make the thread useful. Do not fill the hole with your content calendar. Reply to yourself: "Silence wants a better question, not more empty rooms."

"Someone will steal my ideas."

Share how you run the week. Keep the paid files paid. People who steal prompts were never going to buy. Reply: "The file is paid. The week is talk. I am not hosting a vault in the chat."

"A bigger creator already has a community."

You are not competing with their 8,000-person Skool. You are offering a table for ten people who do a specific job. That table can be yours at 40 members of audience, not 40,000. Reply: "Their stadium is not my table. The job is specific. The ten already ask me."

"Can I just add everyone who bought the file?"

No. Checkout is not a character test. Some buyers are tourists. Invite after they have used the file and asked an operating question. Reply: "The file is public. The room is a door. Buyers who shipped can apply."

"What if a member wants a call with you?"

That is a package, dated and priced. The group is not a back door to unpaid hours. Reply: "Happy to do that as [named package] in [week]. The room stays the thread."

"Should I do video so it feels premium?"

No. Calls turn a quiet group into a calendar product. If members ask, try a single optional hour a month and put notes in the thread. Reply: "Optional hour, notes in the thread. No, it is not the product."

What feeds this path

Upstream — what must exist first

People who already ask how you work. Buyers, a few peers, the client who started productizing after they watched you. This is the only feed that matters in week 1.

A product that already sold: file, package, or vault. The group supports that product. If path 1, 7, or 16 has not produced a stranger sale, you are early. Go back.

The weekly thread itself, once it exists. Good questions produce next week's questions. "What did you refuse" will feed a month of scope talk.

Downstream — what this feeds

The product. Operators in the room still buy the next file and the next package. They also name what is missing, which becomes the next version, not a custom exception inside \$9.

Your DM load. Answers live in the thread once. You paste a link to last Tuesday instead of rewriting the paragraph.

Member work. Spotlights create a culture of bringing artifacts. Artifacts attract more operators. That is the flywheel. Pitches attract pitchers. That is the leak.

A future membership vault (path 14) if you already have files to update. A future live drop (path 17) if the room wants a walkthrough of a new pack. Date it. Do not mash them in month one.

What does not feed it

"Join my community" under every post. Facebook group imports. Affiliate swaps. A scraped list of "entrepreneurs." Those feeds fill rooms with people who collect rooms. If you have to go hunting among strangers who do not know your work, you are early. Go back to the file.

Job boards. Crypto recruiters. "Opportunity" posters. Ban the pattern at the door. One space. If they will not open the tool on Tuesday, they were not going to be operators in a second app either.

Mistakes

1. A free group that becomes your unpaid homework

Open link, no door, you answering beginner questions at 11pm. That is a badly priced service. Recovery this week: close the link. Application or \$9. Point beginners at the public file. Write the no script and use it twice.

2. Free-for-all spam

Unmoderated threads become pitches, job ads, and AI-generated "good mornings." You own the mop. Recovery this week: pin the rule, delete this week's noise the same day, private-note the loudest person, remove them if they knew.

3. Pitching every day

They joined a room of operators, not a webinar sequence. Your about page can hold a link. Recovery this week: one bio line, zero pitch posts, one spotlight of member work.

4. Letting one person dominate

The loudest member becomes the culture. Recovery this week: private note. Then a limit ("one artifact per thread"). Then a removal if they cannot share air.

5. Measuring success by member count

Eighty silent accounts is a leak with a vanity number. Ten who return is the line. Recovery this week: count returning humans. Write that number. Stop posting the member count.

6. Motivational posters as threads

Adults can smell it. Ask about work. Recovery this week: replace the next prompt with "What did you ship, and what did you refuse?" Post it on time.

7. Adding channels to fix silence

Silence wants a better question, not more empty rooms. Recovery this week: archive the extra channels. One thread. Ask one member what would be useful.

8. Admitting people who have not shipped

They will treat operators as a free course. Say no at the door. Recovery this week: audit the last five admits. If two have not shipped, they go back to the file with a kind note and a refund if they paid.

9. Making the group the whole business on day one

Then you have to over-admit and over-pitch to pay yourself. Let the product pay. Let the group support it. Recovery this week: write product revenue and desk fees on one line. If desk fees are the plan, go sell a package.

10. Waiting for a perfect platform

You stall on Circle versus Skool versus Discord while the ten people who already ask you go cold. Recovery this week: pick the chat you will actually open. Invite ten. Post Tuesday.

11. A public launch with countdown numbers

You optimize for signups. You get tourists. Recovery this week: kill the landing page. Personal invites only until ten return.

12. Freezing on the first removal

The room learns the rule was decoration. Recovery this week: remove one piece of noise today. Send the private note. Do it before dinner.

Tools

Exact stack

Circle, Skool, or a chat you actually moderate. Pick the one you will open on thread day. A pretty ghost town is worse than a boring group chat that is alive.

A form or checkout as the door. A payment link with a note field, Stan, a three-question form. Read three answers or collect \$9 before they enter.

A calendar reminder for thread day. Same day, same hour.

A pinned post with the rule, the rhythm, and where the product lives.

A notes doc: invite list, yes/no log, weekly question drafts, hosting minutes.

Email or DM for invites. Not a broadcast tool. Ten personal notes.

Setup order

Write the rule in a doc.

Write the three door questions.

Create one space. Turn off extra modules if you can.

Pin the rule.

Stand up the form or the \$9 link. Test it from a second email. Confirm you can grant access and cancel.

Calendar reminder, repeating.

Then invite. Not before.

What not to buy

You do not need a course module, gamification, a custom app, a community manager, a webinar platform, or Circle's expensive tier until ten people are real and you hit a wall that actually matters.

The \$0 path

Application at \$0. A free Slack or Discord with one channel if you will moderate. A Google Form for the three questions. A calendar reminder. A pinned first message. This is enough for ten people. Upgrade when the chat is messy and the \$9 fee will cover the invoice. Choose the tool you will host.

Checklist

Before you invite

- People already ask how you work (count of five or more in 30 days).
- A product already sold to a stranger (file, package, or vault).
- One rule written: useful or kind, plus what you will remove.
- Door chosen: application (3 questions) or a small fee.
- Tool chosen: one you will moderate.
- Invite list of 10–12 names, not a segment.
- No script written for people who have not shipped.
- Pin draft written: what this is, what it is not, day, rule, where the product lives.
- Calendar reminder set, repeating, same hour.
- You can remove a post and a person in the tool you picked.

First 72 hours

- Ten personal invites, not a public blast.
- Applications read the same day.
- At least one polite no sent (if a misfit applied).
- First thread is a real question.
- First replies hosted.
- Noise removed same day.
- Product not pitched in the thread.
- Next week's same-day reminder on the calendar.

Every week

- Thread on time.
- Spotlight member work, not your pitch.

Read the room in twenty minutes.

Hosting minutes logged.

Returning humans counted.

If you cannot read the room, stop admitting.

Every month

Count returning humans, not signups.

Classifieds (optional) in one post, not in every thread.

Cap when hosting exceeds a sustainable hour count.

Product cash vs desk-fee cash written on one line.

Skip-week test once the room has a pulse: broadcast or community?

Door still requires a shipped thing in 30 days.

FAQ

How is this different from a membership vault?

The vault is files. The group is people. A vault should work if they never attend a call. A group only works if humans return. Do not charge \$9 for a dead chat and call it a vault. Default: sell the vault as path 14 if you have updates; use this path for operators who already run the work.

Can the group be free?

Yes, with an application. Free with an open link is the unpaid-homework trap. If you go free, your "no" at the door has to be stronger. Default: \$0 plus three questions until ten return, then decide if \$9 is worth the invoice.

What should I charge if I charge?

\$9–\$19 a month, or a \$29–\$49 year, to support the product and keep tourists out. If you need more money, sell the package or the file. Default: \$9.

How do I pick the ten?

People who already ask you operating questions and who have shipped something in 30 days. Mix of buyers and a couple of peers. Skip the person who only wants to network. Default: eight buyers, two peers.

What if a member is kind but never useful?

Kind is allowed. If the chat starts to drown the thread, steer: "Bring one artifact next week." Readers can stay in a room of ten. They cannot stay if there are a hundred of them. Default: readers stay at ten; they go if you scale.

Do I need video calls?

No. Calls turn a quiet group into a calendar product. If members ask, try a single optional hour a month and put notes in the thread. Default: no calls in months 1–3.

When do I add more than ten?

When the original ten still get seen and you can still read the room. Add in fives. Cap when your hosting time jumps. Default: cap at twenty as one person.

What if my product is the group?

Then you are running a different business. This path assumes the group supports a product that already exists. Day one, the group is not the whole business. Default: ship a file first.

How do I handle pitches from members?

Pinned rule. First offense: private note. Second: remove the post. Third: remove the person. Monthly classifieds are a pressure valve if you want one. Default: that sequence, no exceptions for "value."

How fast should I launch?

1–3 weeks from the moment you have ten names. Do not wait for a perfect platform. Wait for the rule, the door, and the first question. Default: invite this week if the self-test is five yeses.

Circle or Skool or Discord?

The one you will open on thread day. Skool is fast. Circle is cleaner if you already pay for it.

Discord works if you mute everything except one channel. Default: the chat you already live in until \$9 covers a real tool.

What if two members start selling to each other?

Classifieds once a month, host-approved. If they turn the weekly thread into a marketplace, mop it. Default: one classifieds post.

Can I run this as an email circle?

Yes. Ten people, one weekly prompt, reply-all or a shared doc. Default: only if you will actually read every reply.

What if I get 40 applications in a week?

Yes the ten who shipped. No the rest with a pointer to the file. Default: cap. Do not raise the fee to slow demand.

Someone is useful and cruel.

Private note once. Removal if they dunk again. Talent is not a hall pass. Default: remove.

I skipped two Tuesdays. Now what?

Say so. Post this week's real question. Default: restart the clock this week; do not rebrand the community.



PATH 16

Freelance, then productize

Charge the rate now. Build the product from the notes. Stop reinventing the job.

36 minute read · 7,872 words

Who this is for

You already do AI work for money and you are tired of quoting from scratch.

Time to first

You may already be here

Tools

First sale

A second similar job at a cleaner scope.

Cash window

Your current rate, then a named package, then a cheaper file

Leave this alone

Whatever you already invoice with, plus a growing checklist in one doc.

Random gigs forever. No notes. Quitting service before the notes exist.

What this actually is

The definition

You already do AI work for money. Someone asks what you charge. You shrug an hourly number, or you write a custom proposal that eats an evening, or you say yes to a job that does not look like the last one because variety feels like growth. This path is the decision to stop reinventing the job.

Take the last job you did well. Write the steps as a checklist the night you deliver. After three similar jobs, the package writes itself. That package is path 7 — a named service with a date and a price. The checklist is path 1 — a playbook a stranger can run without you.

Charge the rate now. Build the product from the notes. You do not pause income to "work on the business." You take similar work on purpose, you write it down, and you send a package name the next time someone asks what you charge.

What this is not

It is not a rebrand. It is not a new website. It is not quitting clients this month to "only sell digital products." It is not a 12-item menu of everything AI. It is not a course about productizing, taught before you have three similar invoices.

It is not undercharging because the draft arrived in twelve minutes. AI made it faster. That is what they are buying. Speed is the offer, not a reason to discount.

It is not collecting interesting gigs so your portfolio looks wide. Variety feels like growth. It is usually stalling.

Why this works now

Clients already want AI-assisted work: posts, listings, research briefs, internal SOPs, follow-up sequences. They do not want to learn the tools. They want a dated result. You already have invoices. Those invoices are a product hiding in messy naming.

The model got faster. Your judgment did not get cheaper. A job that used to take a day now takes three hours if you have a stack. That surplus is the package. If you keep billing hours, you donate the surplus. If you name the result and the days, you keep it.

Notes compound. One night-of-delivery doc becomes a one-pager, then a package, then a \$19–\$47 file. Skip the notes and you will still be quoting from scratch in December, only more tired.

Three anti-patterns

Anti-pattern one: random gigs forever, no notes. You are as good at quoting from scratch in month six as you were in month one. Recovery this week: open last three invoices, circle similar ones, write shared steps tonight.

Anti-pattern two: pause income to build the file. The file will be theoretical. You will have no proof and no cash. Recovery this week: take the next similar yes. Write it down. Outline the file after the third job, not instead of the second.

Anti-pattern three: a cafeteria of twelve services. If you have twelve, you have none. Recovery this week: pick the shape you would repeat. Name that one. Decline the rest or refer them.

The deal you keep

You keep charging. You keep writing the steps the night you deliver. They get a named result, a date, a price, one revision. You do not invent a unique process per client. Their facts are unique. The job is not.

The conversion is the point: freelance cash now, package next, file when the checklist is boring. Do not skip a layer because a thread said "productized" is more respectable.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

Fits if

This path fits if invoices already exist. You have done AI-assisted work for other people — posts, listings, research briefs, internal SOPs — and you can open a folder of paid jobs. You are tired of quoting from scratch. You may already be here.

It fits if you can tell the truth about which jobs were similar. Same kind of input, same kind of output, roughly the same number of days. A realtor listing pack and a dentist listing pack can be similar. A realtor listing pack and a custom chatbot are not.

It fits if you will write notes the night you deliver. The notes are the whole conversion. If you will not write them, you will still be shrugging rates in six months.

It also fits if you already run a productized package: raise when the waitlist appears, and spin the checklist into a file. You are on step 9.

Skip if

Skip it if you have never been paid. You cannot productize a fantasy. Skip it if you refuse to write notes. Skip it if you want to stop service this month and "only sell digital products." The honest road is three similar jobs, a named package, then a cheaper file of the job without you in the middle.

Skip it if every job you take is a new species on purpose. That is a custom-projects path. This path needs a repeating shape.

Skip it if you will not send a named price. If you need two hours and a slide deck to say \$750, you are still performing uniqueness.

The honest middle

You have four messy invoices, two of which look alike if you squint, and you still say "it depends" on calls. Circle the two. Make the next yes match them. You do not need a niche retreat. You need a sticky note with the job name and a paste for "what do you charge?"

If you have one invoice, that one is the circle. The first sale of this path is the second similar job.

Skills and time

Skills: notice similarity, write steps, say a number, take a deposit, decline off-shape work. You already know the job. You are missing the name and the notes habit.

Time this week: two hours to circle invoices, write shared steps, and name the package. Then twenty minutes the night of every delivery. Do not rebuild the website. Do not switch invoicing tools.

Two-minute self-test

Answer yes or no.

Can you open at least one paid invoice from AI-assisted work in the last 90 days?

Would you be willing to do that shape of job again next week?

Will you write notes the night you deliver, in the same doc, every time?

Can you say a package name and a price out loud without coughing?

Will you decline (or refer) a flattering gig that does not teach the package?

If 1 or 2 is no, get one paid job first, or use a productized-service path with a named offer this week. If 3, 4, or 5 is no, this path will stall in the shrug. Fix the habit, then name the package.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill-in-the-blank

When they ask your rate, name the package, not an hourly shrug.

The sentence: "[Named result] in [N days] for [price]. You get [files]. One revision. You provide [inputs]. Deposit [50%] holds the week."

"I can help with AI" is not an offer. If you need a paragraph of hedging, it is still a shrug.

Five sentences that work

12 posts and one landing draft in 7 days for \$600. You get files, not a login to my brain. You provide voice examples and facts on day one.

8 listing descriptions plus a Google Business week in 5 days for \$450. One revision. Deposit 50%.

Inbox to 15 follow-up emails in 10 days for \$750, built in your voice. Out: sitting in your Slack.

10 product descriptions and a collection-page draft in 6 days for \$550. You provide SKUs and photos. One revision window of 5 days.

Month-end close checklist run with you in 3 days for \$900. You provide the books. I return a dated packet you own.

What they get

A named result, a date, files they own, a short walkthrough, one revision window. They get your judgment on their facts. They get speed they cannot buy from a blank chat window.

What they do not get

Unlimited rounds. Extra channels. A chatbot. A brand deck. You on Slack all week. Strategy as a bonus. Raw model output. A custom species of job dressed up as the package.

The service package is you in the middle. The product version is the job without you, priced lower. They do not have to buy the file. You do not refuse paid work while you "wait to productize."

Packaging

You do not invent this on a branding retreat. You circle the similar invoices, write the shared steps, and name what you already delivered. One page: in, out, timeline, price, inputs, revision rule, deposit. Ugly is fine.

Clock starts when inputs arrive, not when they said yes. Deposit before you open the chat. 50% to start. Delivery in a folder they own.

The file comes later: \$19–\$47, same steps, no you in the middle. Mention it after delivery and to people who cannot afford the package. Do not hide the package to force the file.

What done looks like

Definition

Done for the first 72 hours: last three invoices open, similar ones circled, shared steps written, package named, and that name sitting in a note you will paste the next time someone asks what you charge.

Done for the first sale of this path: a second similar job at a cleaner scope. Not a bigger job. A cleaner one. Same shape as the last, written scope, deposit, one revision, a date. If you still said "sure, I can also do the chatbot and the brand voice and the ads," you smiled. You did not productize.

A job is done when the night-of-delivery notes exist in the same doc you always use: steps, prompts you reused, what they failed to provide, how long it actually took, what you will refuse next time.

A package is done when you can send it without opening a blank proposal. Name, deliverable, timeline, price, inputs, revision rule. One page. The product version is later. This path's finish line is the named package and the habit of notes.

Fairness test

Could a past client read the one-pager and know exactly what they get, when, and what they must provide? If they would still ask "so what do you actually do," it is not done.

Would you take a second job at this scope without dreading it? If the scope still includes "and whatever else comes up," you have not productized. You have renamed the shrug.

Technical done

One running notes doc, dated entries.

Prompt stack under the steps where you used them.

One-pager in a shareable doc.

Deposit link that matches the invoice tool you already use.

Paste on your phone for "what do you charge?"

A written out-list: the extras you will not do inside this price.

Not-done-yet list

A new website. Not done-yet. Past clients will read a Google doc.

A CRM, a scheduler, a course platform. Not done-yet.

Twelve packages. Not done-yet. One until the paste is automatic.

The \$27 file before the second similar job. Not done-yet. The file will be a guess.

Hourly with a smile because they asked. Not done. That is the old job.

Working before the deposit. Not done. The "quick call" became the job.

Pricing and the cash window

Ranges

The cash window is your current rate, then a package. You do not cut your rate to "make it productized." You stop pretending every job is unique.

If you already charge \$75 an hour, and a job eats 8 hours including the smiling and the revisions, the package is not \$200 because AI drafted fast. The package is \$600–\$900 with a date, or whatever math matches the last invoices plus a little for the cleaner scope. Speed is what they buy. You keep the surplus.

First packages in this suite's service path often live at \$300–\$1,500. A 3-day listing pack can be \$400. A 10-day follow-up system can be \$900. A 14-day content-plus-page can be \$1,200. Write what is in and what is out so the number has a spine. Deposit before you open the chat. 50% to start.

If you have been undercharging, do not leap to \$5,000 because a thread told you to. Average the last three similar invoices. Round up to a number you can say without coughing. That is v1.

When the checklist is boring because you have run it three times, price the file at \$19–\$47. Cheaper than hiring you. That is the point. It does not replace the \$600 until you want it to.

When to raise

Raise when a waitlist appears — meaning someone has to wait a week or you are turning people away. Add 15–30%. Keep the scope. Do not add more deliverables to justify the raise.

Raise also when the notes show the job is heavier than the old invoices implied. If every job leaks six extra hours of Slack, either the out-list is weak or the price is wrong. Fix the out-list first. Then raise.

Refunds in one sentence

Refund the deposit only if you have not opened their inputs; after work starts, finish or keep the deposit and hand over whatever is already in their folder.

Never-charge

Do not charge a "discovery fee" that becomes the whole job for free. Do not charge \$49 for a package that eats two days — that is a file price on a service calendar. Do not charge extra mid-job because you forgot to write the out-list. Do not discount because AI was fast. Do not work the second half on a promise.

Worked dollars

Drew's second similar job: \$750, 50% deposit \$375 before chat, delivered in 6 days, notes that night. After three jobs, raise to \$900 because a fourth had to wait a week. File at \$27. Two file sales in a month while inside a paid week: \$54 extra, not a reason to kill the \$900 week.

Your v1: average of last similar invoices, rounded up. Say it once on a call so you do not fold.

The first 72 hours

You are not building a new brand. You are opening invoices.

Day 1 morning: circle

Open the last three invoices, or the last five if three is too thin. Circle the similar ones. Similar = same kind of input, same kind of output, same-ish days. If none are similar, circle the one you would be willing to do again, and treat the next yes as the second data point. Write the names of the jobs on a sticky: "listing packs," not "misc AI help."

Do not open a new Notion palace. One doc. Title it with the job name.

Day 1 afternoon: shared steps

From the circled jobs, write the shared steps in that doc. Intake, inputs you needed, the AI draft pass, the edit pass, the delivery folder, the walkthrough, the revision window. Put the prompts you reused under the step where you used them. This doc is the company.

List what they failed to provide. That list becomes intake. List what they talked you into. That list becomes "out."

Day 1 night: hours and a number

Write how long each circled job actually took, including smiling and revisions. Average it. Multiply by your real hourly if you must, then round up to a package number you can say. Put the number on the sticky next to the job name. Sleep on it. Do not discount it overnight.

Day 2: name and one-pager

Name the package like a result: "7-day listing pack." Write what's in, what's not, timeline, price (from the invoices, rounded up), what they must provide, one revision, 50% deposit. The one-pager is a Google doc. Ugly. Fine.

Put the name in a note on your phone. Practice saying it out loud once so you do not fold on a call.

Make sure the deposit link you already use still works. Do not switch billing tools this week.

Day 3: paste and two sends

The next time someone asks "what do you charge?" you send the package, not an hourly shrug. If nobody is asking this week, send the one-pager to two past clients who already liked the work. Subject: "This job has a name now." One paragraph. Link to the one-pager. No apology for the old rate.

By hour 72: last invoices open, similar ones circled, shared steps in one doc, package named, one page, paste ready for the next "what do you charge?"

The path, step by step

Step 1. Open the last three invoices and circle the similar ones

If you cannot find similarity, you have been collecting gigs. The next yes should look like the best of those jobs, not a new species. Write the job name on a sticky. If you only have one invoice, circle that one and aim the next yes at the same shape.

Step 2. Write the steps the night you deliver

Same day, while the mess is still in your head. Tomorrow you will only remember the win. The product lives in the missing inputs, the prompt that worked, the extra round they talked you into. If you skip this night, you skipped the path. The invoice is the job. The notes are the company.

Step 3. Notes in the same doc after every job

One running file. Dated entries. Do not start a new Notion palace per client. Date, client type, what they provided, what they skipped, steps you actually ran, prompts you reused, hours start to finish, what you will refuse next time, one line you could sell as a file.

Step 4. Prompts you reused go in a stack

If you typed it twice, it belongs in a block you can paste. That stack becomes part of the package and, later, part of a file. Leave them in chat history and you will rewrite them badly under deadline.

Step 5. Name the package

Result, days, price. Stop the hourly shrug. Practice saying it out loud once so you do not fold on a call. "8 listings and one page draft in 7 days for \$750" is a name. "AI content help" is a weather report.

Step 6. Write what's in, what's out, the date, the deposit

One revision is enough. Unlimited revisions is how packages die. They must provide voice, examples, and access on day one or the clock does not start. Deposit 50% before you open the chat. Put this on one page you can reuse twenty times.

Step 7. Send that name the next time someone asks what you charge

Even if the one-pager is ugly. A named package is cleaner than a charming email. If they are not a fit for this shape, say so and point them at the file or a no. Do not write a custom proposal "just this once." Just this once is how the shrug returns.

Step 8. Stop saying yes to work that does not teach the product

A flattering weird gig will pay once and steal the notes week. Refer it or decline. If you take one on purpose, call it tuition, cap the hours, and do not let it rename the package.

Step 9. After three similar jobs, the package writes itself

You are not guessing scope. You have dates and hours. Tighten the one-pager. That package is path 7. The checklist is path 1. Stop custom proposals for this shape of work.

Step 10. Raise the package price when the waitlist appears

Waitlist means delay or a no because you are full. Add 15–30%, keep the scope. Do not add more deliverables to justify the raise. Politeness is how packages get fat and unprofitable.

Step 11. Make the product version: the job without you in the middle

Price it lower. Let it sell while you sleep. Do this after the checklist is boring, not instead of the next paid job. The file is the steps, prompts, examples, and definition of done. It is not a memoir

about your clients.

Step 12. Do not undercharge because AI made it fast

They bought speed and judgment. If a job that used to take a day now takes three hours, you did not become cheaper. You became a better package. Keep the price. Shrink the timeline if you want, on purpose, as part of the offer.

Step 13. Deposit before the chat, clock on inputs

Working before the deposit trains them that the "quick call" is the job. Starting before inputs arrive trains you to invent their facts. Both kill the checklist because the job never has a clean start.

Step 14. Keep taking packages until you choose not to

The file does not require you to quit service. Two \$27 sales are not a reason to decline a \$900 week. Choose later, on purpose, when the file is actually carrying weight.

A worked example: Drew names the package

Drew has been "doing AI stuff" for six months. Invoices: \$400 to rewrite a dentist's Google posts, \$650 to draft listing copy for a realtor friend, \$300 to "just help with ChatGPT" for a cousin's bakery, \$800 for another realtor's listings plus a landing page. Drew quotes from scratch every time.

Tuesday night, the circle

Drew circles the two realtor jobs and, after a pause, the dentist posts. Same shape: messy facts in, a week of public-facing copy out. The bakery cousin is not circled. Sticky note: "do not take cousin work."

Shared steps go in one doc that night: intake, folder of inputs, draft pass, human edit, delivery in a Google doc they own, 15-minute walkthrough, one revision window of 5 days. Reused prompts get pasted under the draft step. Hours: the \$650 job was really 11 hours with extras. The \$800 job

was 9 hours with a cleaner intake. Drew averages toward 10, multiplies by a \$75 habit, and rounds to \$750 instead of \$400 because speed is the offer.

Wednesday, the name

Drew names it: 8 listings and one page draft in 7 days for \$750. Out: ads, chatbots, unlimited rounds. Deposit 50%. The one-pager is a Google doc. Ugly. Fine. Paste goes on the phone.

Thursday, the shrug test

An acquaintance asks what Drew would charge "to help with AI." Drew pastes the package name instead of "I usually do \$75 an hour." The acquaintance is not a realtor. Drew says this package is for listings and a page. Two hours saved. No custom proposal.

Week 2, first sale of the path

The next realtor who asks gets the same paste. They say yes. Deposit \$375 lands before the chat. Drew does not open Slack until the MLS notes and three example listings arrive. Delivers in 6 days, writes the notes that night (they always forget parking details; add that to intake). That is the first sale of this path: a second similar job at a cleaner scope.

Mistake: Drew almost added "a week of Instagram" as a smile. Caught it because the out-list was on the one-pager. Recovery: "That's out of this package. I can point you at the playbook when it exists, or we keep the listings and the page."

After the third listing-pack job

Drew raises to \$900 when a fourth has to wait a week. The checklist is boring enough to become a \$27 playbook. The file sells twice in a month while Drew is inside a paid week: \$54. The hourly shrug is gone. The cousin still wants "a little help." Drew sends the playbook link.

What Drew refused: a new website, a 12-service menu, pausing paid weeks to design a cover, undercharging because Claude drafted in twelve minutes, and the bakery-shaped work that would have taught nothing.

Copy you can paste

Swap the result, the days, and the price. Keep the spine.

Public post

I do not bill a pile of hours for this anymore. It is a named package: [result] in [N] days for [price]. You get [files], one revision, and a short walkthrough. You provide [inputs] on day one. Deposit holds the week. One-pager: [link].

DM, when they ask what you charge

I can do [named result] in [N] days for [price]. Files you own, one revision, walkthrough. You send [inputs] before I start. 50% deposit holds the seat. Here is the one-pager. If you need something else, I probably will not take it — I can point you at the [file] if it exists.

Page hero

[Result] in [N] days. You get files, not a login to my brain. \$[price]. One revision. Deposit 50%.

Checkout / deposit line

50% now holds the week. Clock starts when [inputs] arrive. Balance before I send the folder. One revision window of 5 days after delivery. No Slack retainer inside this price.

Email 1 — to a past client

You already paid me for [old job]. That work has a name now: [result] in [N] days for [price]. Same shape, cleaner scope, one revision. If you need it again, the one-pager is here. If not, no need to reply.

Email 2 — inputs are late

The week is held by the deposit, but the clock has not started. I need [list] before I open the draft. If that is not coming this week, we pick a new start date or I refund the unused deposit.

Email 3 — delivery

Folder is yours: [link]. Walkthrough is [15 minutes, date]. One revision round, grouped notes, inside 5 days. After that the job is closed. Notes I will use next time are on me, not on you.

Refund

I have not opened your inputs, so the deposit is back. If you want this package later, same one-pager. If the shape changed, I probably cannot take it.

Scope block for the one-pager

In: [deliverables]. Out: [the usual extras — extra rounds, extra channels, strategy decks, sitting in their Slack]. Timeline: start when inputs arrive, end on date. Price: [amount]. Deposit: 50% before I open the work. Revisions: one round within 5 days of delivery.

Notes template, the night you deliver

Date. Client type. What they provided / what they skipped. Steps I actually ran. Prompts I reused. Hours start to finish. What I will refuse next time. One line I could sell as a file.

Decline that teaches the product

This sounds like a custom build, and I am not taking those. If you want [the named package], I have a seat in [week]. If you want to run it without me, the [playbook / stack] is [price] and it is the same steps.

Raise, when they wait

The package is [new price] starting [date]. Same scope. I am booking [N] weeks out. Deposit still holds the slot.

Week-by-week

Assume you have a job and evenings. This is four weeks to a second similar job and a paste, not a new brand.

Week 1, daily

Day 1: open last three to five invoices. Circle similar ones. Sticky with the job name.

Day 2: write shared steps in one doc. Paste reused prompts under the step. List missing inputs and extras you regretted.

Day 3: name the package (result, days, price). Draft the one-pager: in, out, deposit, one revision.

Day 4: put the paste on your phone. Practice saying the price out loud. Test the deposit link you already use.

Day 5: send the one-pager to two past clients. Do not rebuild the website.

Day 6–7: if someone asks what you charge, send the package. If not, do not invent a random gig so you feel busy. Clean the notes doc.

Week 2, daily

Day 8–9: next conversation uses the paste. Take a deposit before the chat. Clock starts when inputs arrive.

Day 10–12: run the job if you have one. Human pass on every deliverable. They never see raw model output.

Day 13: deliver in a folder they own. Walkthrough. One revision window with a date.

Day 14: notes in the same doc the night you deliver. Prompts you reused go in the stack. That night is non-negotiable.

Week 3

Tighten what's in and what's out from the last job's leaks. If you got burned by extra rounds, the one-revision line gets bolder, not politer. Send two more past-client notes if the calendar is empty. No to work that does not teach the package.

Week 4

If you have two similar jobs, you have the first sale of this path. If you have three, stop custom proposals for this shape. Sketch the product version from the checklist — but do not disappear from paid weeks to design a cover. If a waitlist appeared, raise 15–30% and keep the scope.

Weeks 5–8

Every week you deliver anything: notes that night. When the checklist is boring, ship the cheaper file. Mention it after delivery and to people who cannot afford the package. Keep taking packages until you choose not to.

Weeks 9–12

One package until the paste is automatic. A second package is how you end up quoting from scratch again. Review hours per package vs price. If the surplus disappeared, tighten scope or raise. Do not add three new deliverables so you feel polite.

Quality bar

They never see the raw model output. That is the floor. AI drafts. You edit. Quality is your name, not the model's.

Below-bar

Hourly shrug or a custom proposal that ate an evening.

Work started before deposit or before inputs.

They received unedited model text.

Unlimited rounds, or "quick tweaks" with no date.

Delivery in your Google account, not a folder they own.

No notes the night of delivery.

Second job is bigger and fuzzier than the first.

You said yes to a chatbot "while you're in there."

Above-bar

Written scope before work. Deposit before chat.

Inputs listed. Clock starts when they arrive.

Human pass on every deliverable. Facts checked. Voice matches their examples, not "an AI that heard of their industry."

Delivery in a folder they own. A 15-minute walkthrough. One revision window with a date.

Notes the night you deliver, in the same doc.

Similarity is real, not branded. You can say in one sentence what matches across the circled jobs.

The package name is a result plus a date plus a price.

You declined at least one job that would have felt like growth and would have taught nothing.

Five tests

Test 1, the paste. Can you send the package in under five minutes from "what do you charge?" If this is still two hours, you do not have a package. You have a ritual.

Test 2, the stranger one-pager. Could a tired client know in, out, date, price, inputs, revision without a call? If not, rewrite tonight.

Test 3, cleaner scope. Does the second similar job have fewer side quests than the first? If it is bigger and fuzzier, you went the wrong direction.

Test 4, the night notes. Binary. If you skipped, you skipped the company. Recovery this week: write last job's notes from memory tonight, then never skip again.

Test 5, the no. Did you decline off-shape work this month? If this is zero, you are still collecting gigs. Recovery: write one decline this week using the script.

Cleaner scope means fewer extra rounds and fewer "while you're in there." That is the quality of the path, not a prettier logo.

What to measure

Week 1

Invoices opened and similar ones circled (count).

Shared steps written (binary).

Package named with a number (binary).

Paste sitting on the phone (binary).

One-pagers sent to past clients (target 2).

Day 30

Similar jobs in a row. Two is the first-sale line.

Proposal time. Minutes from "what do you charge" to a sent package. If this is still two hours, you do not have a package.

Hours per package vs price. Know the number.

Revision count. More than one as a habit means your definition of done is soft or your intake is weak.

Notes completed the night of delivery (binary, every job).

Nos to off-shape work (if zero, you are still collecting gigs).

Day 90

Three similar jobs. Package is real. Custom proposals for this shape should be zero.

Waitlist days. When people wait, raise.

Product-version shipped or outlined from a boring checklist.

Product-version sales, separate from package revenue. Do not kill a \$900 week because a \$27 file feels more "scalable" on a slide.

Surplus still exists (price minus hours times your floor rate).

Ignore

Do not measure how many different industries you have touched. That is a stalling trophy. Do not measure proposal win rate on custom work you should not have bid. Do not measure

"personal brand" posts this week.

One-line spreadsheet

Date | job shape | price | deposit date | hours | revisions | notes same night (Y/N) | off-shape nos | waitlist days | file sales | one sentence

One row per job. If you need a CRM to see the streak, you are avoiding the doc.

Objections you will hear — including from yourself

"Every client is unique."

Their business is unique. The job is not. Eight listings and a page is eight listings and a page. Unique belongs in their facts, not in your process. Reply: "Your facts are yours. The steps are the package. That's how it stays on time."

"I will productize after I quit clients."

You will have no notes, no proof, and no cash. Charge now. Notes tonight. File later. Reply to yourself: "The notes are the company. Quitting first is a fantasy with a cover."

"AI made it fast, so I should charge less."

They are buying the speed. Keep the price. Offer a shorter timeline if you want the speed visible. Reply: "The result is dated and edited. The speed is why you hire me. The number stays."

"A package will make me miss interesting work."

It will. That is the trade. Interesting work that never repeats is a class you pay for with your calendar. Take one on purpose once a quarter if you must. Reply: "I take one weird job a quarter as tuition. This week is the package."

"I need a new website first."

You need a one-pager and a paste. Reply: "The Google doc is the page until strangers I do not know are buying."

"What if they want hourly?"

You can say no. If a trusted client insists, cap the hours and still write the steps. Do not live there. Reply: "I do not bill a pile of hours for this. It's [package]. If hourly is required, I am not the person."

"I only have one invoice."

Circle that one. Aim the next yes at the same shape. The first sale is the second similar job. Reply to yourself: "One is a start. The next yes matches it."

"They asked me to add just one more thing."

That is how packages die. Reply: "That's out of this package. We can date a separate week at [price], or we keep this scope."

"I am scared to lose them if I name a real number."

A client who only exists when the scope is fog is not a client you can productize around. Reply: "The number is [price]. Deposit holds the week. If that is not a fit, I will not force it."

"Should I productize two jobs at once?"

Later. One package until the paste is automatic and the notes are boring. Reply to yourself: "Two packages is the shrug in a trench coat."

What feeds this path

Upstream — what must exist first

The last jobs. Invoices, emails, folders, Slack threads. Mine them before you invent a niche. If you have never been paid, this is not your first path. Get one paid result, then come back.

The night-of-delivery doc. Every entry feeds the one-pager and, later, the file. Skip a night and the feed dries up.

People who already paid you. They are the easiest second similar job. "If you need this again, it has a name now."

Downstream — what this feeds

Path 7, the named package, once three similar jobs exist. Path 1, the playbook, once the checklist is boring. Path 2 or 3 if the reused prompts are the product. Path 15 if operators start asking how you run the week.

The questions inside the job. "Can you also..." is how you learn what to put in "what's out." Intake gets sharper. The package gets kinder to you.

Prompts you reused. They are a stack waiting to happen. Do not leave them in chat history.

What does not feed it

Job boards that want a new species every time. "Happy to help with anything AI." Those feeds train the shrug. When a week has no freelance work, the feed is still the doc. Clean it. Send two past clients the one-pager. Do not fill the week with a random gig so you feel busy.

A niche-picking Twitter poll. A new logo. A second service "so I have a funnel." One shape. Repeat it.

Mistakes

1. Random gigs forever. No notes

You will be as good at quoting from scratch in December as you were in March, only more tired. The notes are the path. Recovery this week: open last three invoices, start the running doc tonight, write the last job from memory.

2. Custom work that never repeats

It feels like a portfolio. It is a stall. If it does not teach the package, it is a no. Recovery this week: decline or refer one off-shape ask. Use the decline script.

3. Undercharging because AI made it fast

Speed is the product. Keep the rate. Tighten the days if you want. Put the days on the package. Recovery this week: rewrite the one-pager at last-invoice-average rounded up. Send that number next.

4. Working before the deposit

The "quick call" becomes the job. Recovery this week: deposit link in the paste. Do not open the work folder until it lands.

5. Unlimited revisions

Then there is no definition of done, and the checklist cannot be written because the job never ends. Recovery this week: one round, grouped notes, 5-day window, on the one-pager in bold.

6. Building the file instead of taking the second similar job

The file will be theoretical. Take the job. Write it down. Then productize. Recovery this week: pause the cover design. Send two past clients the package.

7. A menu of 12 services

If you have twelve, you have none. One package. Not a cafeteria. Recovery this week: pick one shape. Hide the rest. Name it.

8. Clock started before inputs arrived

You invent their facts, then you revise forever. Recovery this week: write "clock starts when [inputs] arrive" on the one-pager. Email anyone in flight whose inputs are missing.

9. Switching tools instead of writing steps

New CRM, new scheduler, new invoicing app. The bottleneck is the notes. Recovery this week: keep the old invoice tool. Write the steps.

10. Adding deliverables when you raise

You feel polite. You destroy the surplus. Recovery this week: raise 15–30% or do not raise. Scope stays. Say that out loud.

11. Letting a cousin job rename the business

One bakery, one chatbot, one "just help me understand AI." Recovery this week: sticky note of what you will not take. Send the file link instead.

12. Skipping notes because the job went fine

Fine jobs still have steps. Recovery this week: twenty minutes tonight. Date the entry. Paste the prompts.

Tools

Exact stack

Whatever you already invoice with. Stripe, HoneyBook, an invoice PDF, Venmo with a paper trail. Do not switch billing tools this week.

A growing checklist in one doc. Google Doc, Notion, a notes app. One. Dated. Ugly.

A one-page agreement. Scope, date, price, deposit, one revision, what they provide. You can reuse this 20 times.

A deposit link. Same as the invoice tool. 50% before the chat.

The prompt stack you actually reused, sitting under the step where it belongs.

A phone note with the paste for "what do you charge?"

Setup order

Open invoices. Circle similar.

Create the one running doc. Write shared steps.

Paste reused prompts under steps.

Write the one-pager.

Confirm the deposit link works (send \$1 to yourself if you must).

Put the paste on the phone.

Then send. Not a new website first.

What not to buy

You do not need a new CRM to productize. You do not need a scheduler until people are actually booking. You do not need a course platform to turn the checklist into a \$27 file — a PDF and a payment link will do when the time comes. You do not need a proposal tool that writes five pages of fog. You do not need a brand kit.

The \$0 path

Invoice PDF or a payment link you already have. Google Doc for notes and the one-pager. Phone notes for the paste. Email for sending. A folder they own (Google Drive or email attachments). This is enough for the second similar job. Buy Stan or Stripe later if you do not already have them. The bottleneck is not software. It is writing the steps the night you deliver and sending a name instead of a shrug.

Checklist

This week

Last three invoices open. Similar ones circled.

Job name on a sticky (not "misc AI help").

Shared steps in one doc.

Reused prompts pasted under the step.

Package named: result, days, price.

What's in / what's out / deposit / one revision.

One-pager exists and is shareable.

Paste saved for "what do you charge?"

Deposit link tested.

Two past clients sent the one-pager.

Price said out loud once.

Every job

Deposit before the chat.

Clock starts when inputs arrive.

They never see raw model output.

Facts checked. Voice matches their examples.

Deliver in a folder they own.

Walkthrough booked.

One revision window with a date.

Notes in the same doc the night you deliver.

Reused prompts copied into the stack.

One line written that could become a file.

After three similar jobs

Stop custom proposals for this shape.

No to work that does not teach the product.

Raise when people wait (15–30%, same scope).

Outline the cheaper file from the boring checklist.

Ship the file without quitting the paid package.

Spreadsheet row per job: price, hours, revisions, notes Y/N.

FAQ

I only have messy one-off jobs. Can I still start?

Yes. Circle the one you would repeat. Make the next yes match it. The first sale of this path is the second similar job, not a perfect history. Default: circle one this week, aim the next ask at it.

What if I am not sure I want to keep doing service?

Keep doing it long enough to write the notes. Three similar jobs. Then the file can carry more of the weight. Quitting before the notes exist leaves you with neither cash nor a product. Default: three jobs, then decide.

How is this different from the productized service path?

That path assumes you can name the package this week and sell it. This path is for people already in the messy middle of freelance. You convert what you have. The destination — a named package — is the same room. Default: use this path if invoices exist and names do not.

Should I put the package on a fancy page?

A one-pager is enough until strangers you do not know are buying. Past clients will read a Google doc. Do not stall on Webflow. Default: Google doc this week.

How many revisions is one?

One round of grouped notes inside a dated window, usually 5 days. Not a drip of "quick tweaks" for a month. Put that in the one-pager. Default: one round, 5 days, grouped.

What goes in the product version vs the package?

The product version is the steps, prompts, examples, and definition of done — the job without you. The package is you running those steps on their mess, with judgment and a date. Default: package first, file after the checklist is boring.

The client wants hourly and I am scared to lose them.

Name the package once. If they still want hourly, cap the hours and the extras, or let them go. A client who only exists when the scope is fog is not a client you can productize around. Default: name it once, then no.

When do I raise the price?

When someone waits, or when you are full, or when the notes show the job is heavier than the old invoices implied. Add 15–30%. Do not add three new deliverables so you feel polite. Default: raise at the first wait.

Can I productize more than one job?

Later. One package until the paste is automatic and the notes are boring. A second package is how you end up quoting from scratch again. Default: one.

AI did 80% of the draft. Is charging \$750 honest?

If you edited, checked facts, matched voice, owned the result, and saved them a week in the blank window, yes. You are not selling keystrokes. You are selling a dated result they can use. If you are shipping unedited model text, fix the quality bar before you worry about the number. Default: edit or do not send.

What if nobody asks this week?

Send the one-pager to two past clients. Do not take a random gig to feel busy. Default: two notes, then wait.

Do I need a contract lawyer?

A one-page scope with deposit, date, out-list, and revision window is enough for this price band. If a client wants a 20-page MSA, that is a different job. Default: one page you reuse.

Should I hire a VA to run the package?

Not until the checklist is boring and you can still stand the quality bar. Default: you run it through job three.

What if inputs never arrive?

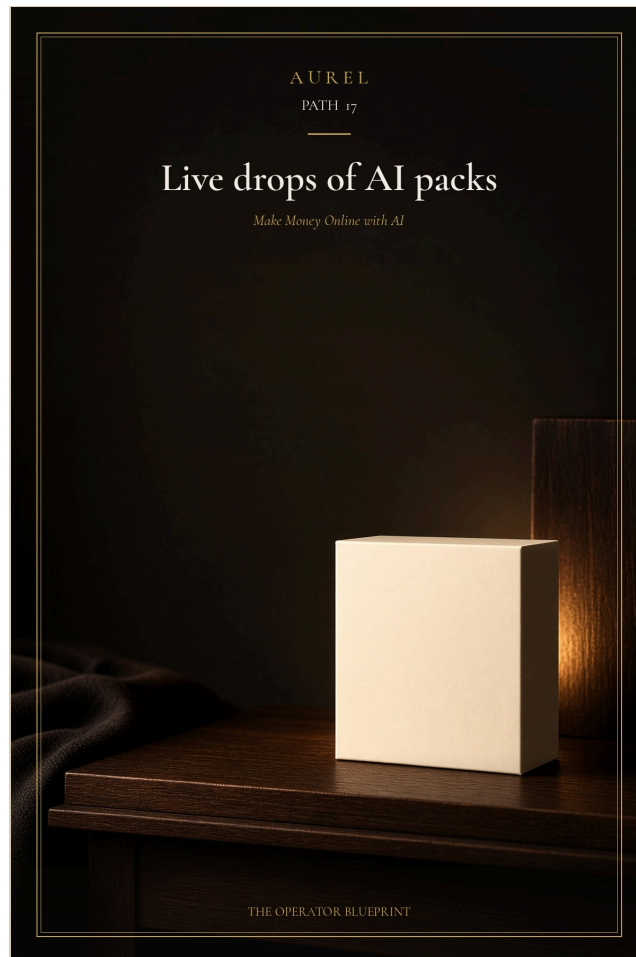
Deposit holds or refunds per your sentence. Clock never started. Do not chase forever. Default: one reminder, then a new date or a refund of unused deposit.

Can the file replace me this quarter?

Sometimes. Not on purpose in week one. Default: sell the file beside the package, not instead of the next \$750 week.

How long should a package take me?

Whatever the last three similar jobs actually took, minus the extras you now refuse, plus a human edit. Write the number. If it is 14 hours at \$750, you have a \$50-ish hour after smiling. Raise or tighten. Default: know the hours before you brag about leverage.



PATH 17

Live drops of AI packs

A time, a file, a link in the bio. Scarcity must be real.

36 minute read · 7,840 words

Who this is for

You have a finished pack and a time you can go live without freezing.

Time to first

Same day as the live if the file is ready

Tools

First sale

A live session that produces at least one checkout.

Cash window

Burst sales of the \$19–\$47 file

Leave this alone

TikTok Live, Instagram Live, Stan, a rehearsed first two minutes.

Fake countdown timers. Going live with nothing to sell. Daily lives until nobody cares.

What a live drop actually is

The definition

A live drop is a date, a file, and a checkout. You announce a time. You go live for about twenty minutes. You show the pack on screen. People buy while you are still talking. That is the whole machine.

It is not a webinar. It is not a masterclass. It is not an hour of origin story before a slide that says "link in bio." You are not teaching a course. You are holding up a finished thing and letting people take it.

What this is not

It is not a talk show. It is not an accountability theater for a pack you have not exported. It is not a fake "only three left" on a PDF you can copy forever. It is not dual-streaming four platforms while you fumble one URL. It is not going live every day until the algorithm likes you.

It is not a \$197 workshop with worksheets and a bonus coaching call. If you want high-ticket, that is a different path. This path is a \$19–\$47 file plus a twenty-minute show.

Why live still converts a file

A \$29 pack on a quiet page asks the buyer to trust a stranger and a screenshot. A live drop lets them watch you open the file, click around, and answer one question out loud. Trust happens in public. That is why a plain pack can outsell a prettier one on a dead landing page — the live is the proof.

AI packs are easy to fake in a carousel. They are hard to fake with a screen share. You open page one. You run one example. You show the edit. That is more proof than a designed ad.

Live also forces a date. Dates make tired people decide. A quiet page waits forever. A Thursday at 7 does not.

What scarcity is allowed to mean

Scarcity is a date, a cohort, or a version. "I walk through this file Thursday at 7. After that you can still buy the pack on the page, but you miss the walkthrough." That is honest. "Only three left" on a digital file you can copy forever is a lie. People who buy from you once will remember the lie.

A version is also real. "This is the April pack. The next rewrite ships in six weeks." A cohort is real. "Twelve people get the live Q&A with this purchase. After twelve, the file is still for sale, the room is closed." Pick one form of scarcity. Write it down. Keep it.

If the pack is not finished, you do not have a drop. You have a promise, and promises do not check out.

Three anti-patterns

Anti-pattern one: fake stock. Countdown stickers, "2 spots," a price that "dies at midnight" when you will sell the same file on Saturday. Recovery this week: delete the sticker. Write the real date. Keep the price.

Anti-pattern two: going live with a draft. You promise a zip you have not exported. Checkout fails. Recovery this week: export, phone-check, test-buy from a second email. Then announce.

Anti-pattern three: daily lives. You train people to ignore you. Recovery this week: one dated Thursday. Next drop when you have a new version, a new sample, or a new audience. Not tomorrow.

The deal you keep

You keep a time, a finished file, and an honest scarcity line. They get a demo they can see and a checkout that delivers tonight. You will not invent a shortage. They will not get a course they did not buy.

The live is the event. The page is the store. Both exist the same night.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

Fits if

This path fits if you already have a finished pack from an earlier path: a playbook, a skill pack, a prompt stack, a template bundle. You can talk for twenty minutes without freezing. You have one platform where at least a few dozen people already watch or follow you. You do not need a huge audience. You need a time, a file, and the nerve to press Go Live.

It fits if you can demo the product with your screen, not just describe it. It fits if you can keep a Thursday. If you cancel lives, this path will embarrass you.

It fits if you have sold the file quietly, or you could, and you want a burst instead of a drip. If you need cash this week and the file is ready, this is one of the fastest paths in the suite.

Skip if

Skip it if the pack is not done. Skip it if you cannot be on a screen share without your voice leaving. Skip it if you only have a fake countdown and no real date. Skip it if you have never tested the checkout from a second email.

Skip it if both TikTok and Instagram are empty and you have no private list. This is not your first path. Finish path 1, 2, 3, or 6. Get a small audience on one platform. Then drop.

Skip it if you will discount live because the room is small. Holding the number is the job.

Skip it if you need a webinar funnel, a wait-room video, and an on-air producer to feel ready. Those are for people who already sell out rooms. You are dating a Thursday.

The honest middle

You have a \$29 PDF that sold two copies from a quiet page, forty people who watch your Stories, and a Thursday night you will not cancel. That is enough. Sage's first useful room was eleven. Yours can be smaller.

If you have a pack and no audience, sell quiet first. Two stranger sales prove delivery. Then drop.

Skills and time

Skills: finish a file, keep a clock, share a screen, say a URL slowly, end on purpose. You do not need a personality brand. You can be a voice and a cursor.

Time: one evening to freeze the product and write the two-minute card. One day of two announcements and five DMs. Twenty minutes live. Thirty minutes after for the store page and notes. Then you stop.

Two-minute self-test

Answer yes or no.

Is the pack exported, named like a human, and openable on a phone?

Have you test-bought the checkout from a second email and received the file?

Can you name a day and hour in the next seven days you will not cancel?

Can you demo the first three pages without hunting eight folders?

Will you hold the price if only three people show up?

If 1 or 2 is no, finish the pack and the pipe. If 3, 4, or 5 is no, pick a quiet page this week, not a live. A cancelled live costs more trust than a quiet week.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill-in-the-blank

Write this before you pick a thumbnail: "Thursday 7pm I show the [named pack]. Twenty minutes. Link in bio. \$[price]. After the live the walkthrough is gone; the file stays on the page."

That sentence is the offer. Everything else is decoration. If you cannot say it in one breath, you are stacking too many bonuses.

Five sentences that work

Thursday 7pm Eastern. I walk through the realtor listing pack on my screen. Twenty minutes. \$29. After that the walkthrough is over; the pack stays on the page.

Saturday 10am. I open the bookkeeper follow-up stack, run one inbox example, and leave. \$19. Link in bio the whole time.

Wednesday 8pm. Skill pack for solo dentists: ten posts, three examples, one-page install. \$39. Twelve people get the live Q&A; then the room closes, file stays.

Friday noon. April version of the listing pack. I show what changed. \$47. Next rewrite is six weeks out.

Tonight 7. Template bundle for Google Business posts. Twenty minutes, \$29, instant download. Miss the live, still buy the zip.

What sits in the sentence

A day and a clock time in the buyer's timezone, or a timezone named out loud.

A file with a job in the title, not "my AI pack."

A price they can hear once and remember: \$19, \$29, \$39, or \$47.

A reason to show up live that is not fake stock.

What they get

The pack. Instant download. A twenty-minute walkthrough if they show up. Answers about the file, not about your life story. A store page afterward if they miss it.

What they do not get

A 40-minute bonus training. A private podcast. "I'll also critique your account." A membership. An automation setup. A surprise course at minute sixteen. A discount because they asked in the comments.

Packaging

The drop is the pack plus the twenty-minute show. If you want a higher ticket, that is a different path. Keep this one boring and buyable.

Checkout title matches the pack. Price is visible. File delivers. Bio link is live at least 24 hours before. Short URL on paper so you can say it.

Pick one scarcity: date, cohort, or version. Write it on the card. Do not mix all three in one breath.

What done looks like

Definition

Done is a live that produces at least one checkout from someone who is not you. The replay or the static page is up within two hours of ending. The link still works the next morning. You wrote down what people asked, what they bought, and what confused them.

If zero people bought, it is still a finished live if you showed the product and the link worked. You do not declare the path dead after one quiet Thursday. You also do not go live again tomorrow to chase the feeling.

Fairness test

Could a tired person who joins at minute four still tell what the file is, what it costs, and where to buy it? If not, you lectured. If yes, you dropped.

Would a buyer who paid during the live have the file before they went to bed? If delivery waits until morning, you are not done. Fix the pipe before you sleep.

Is the scarcity line still true the next morning? If you said the walkthrough was tonight-only and then you stay live until 8:15 because a friend was driving home, you taught them your dates are decoration.

Technical done

File exported. Filename human. Opens on a phone.

Checkout test-bought from a second email. File arrived.

Bio link live. Short URL on paper.

First two minutes on a card, rehearsed twice out loud.

Day, clock, timezone on a calendar you will keep.

Second device on the order screen.

Static page or pinned post template ready to publish the same night.

Not-done-yet list

A talking-head intro sequence. Not done-yet. Test the checkout.

Dual-stream, wait-room, webinar platform. Not done-yet.

Fake timer, "ONLY 2 SPOTS," a price drop in minute eighteen. Never done.

A second product added because the room went quiet. Not done. One file.

Replay as a requirement. Nice if you have it. The static page is required.

Going live with a folder of notes. Not a drop. A promise.

The live itself, done: you started within two minutes of the announced time. You showed the file in the first three minutes. You said the price and the URL out loud at least four times. Twenty minutes, maybe twenty-five if questions are real. Then you leave.

Pricing

Ranges

The cash window is a burst of the \$19–\$47 file. Live does not magically make a \$197 pack feel cheap. Live makes a small file feel urgent and clear.

The numbers that hold up:

\$19 if the pack is thin and this is your first public drop.

\$29 if it is a complete job: prompts plus examples plus a one-page how-to. This is the default.

Sage sells here.

\$39 if you include a filled sample the buyer can copy.

\$47 if the pack already sold quietly and you are using the live as a version event, not a rescue.

Worked dollars: Sage, \$29, one Wednesday pre-sale, four during the live, one overnight. Six packs in two days. \$174. Room of eleven. That is a real first drop, not a stadium.

When to raise

Raise when you introduce a version that actually added examples, not because you turned a camera on. If the pack already sells at \$19 on the page, keep \$19 or ship a \$29 version with a filled sample. Do not raise only for the live.

After three drops, if live checkouts are real and the page also sells, you may sit at \$39. Do not leap to \$97 because a comment asked for a course.

Refunds in one sentence

If the file does not arrive or you showed a different product than they paid for, refund the same night; if they bought the right file and just changed their mind, refund on request inside 7 days and do not haggle on live.

Never-charge

You never run a fake "only 3 left at this price." You never drop the price in minute eighteen because the room is small. You never add a \$9 upsell on the fly. You never charge a "live ticket" for a digital file you will sell on the page tomorrow at the same price unless the ticket is clearly the walkthrough and the file is separate — and even then, this path stays simpler: one price, walkthrough expires, file stays.

Do not discount live. "Live special \$9" trains people to wait for you to panic. If you want a live-only extra, make it the walkthrough, not a cheaper file. The file price stays. The show expires.

Worked dollars against the week

Hold the number. Four checkouts at \$29 is \$116 during the live. Chasing two more by cutting to \$9 teaches the room that waiting works. The burst is the point. The page sells the rest of the

week at the same price.

The first 72 hours

The first 72 hours assume the pack is already a file you can attach. If it is not, stop and finish the pack. Do not announce a live for a folder of notes.

Day 1 morning: freeze the product

Export the final PDF or zip. Name the file like a human: "Realtor listing pack v1.pdf," not "FINAL_final2." Test-open it on your phone. Write the one-sentence offer. Pick the price. Confirm the Stripe or Stan checkout. Buy it yourself from a second email. If that fails, nothing else in this chapter matters.

Fix the page that looks broken at phone size. If checkout title does not match the pack name, fix it now.

Day 1 afternoon: the first two minutes on a card

Write, on paper you can glance at: hello and how long you will be here; what the file does in one job-shaped sentence; share screen, open the first page, click two things; price and where the link is, said slowly.

Rehearse that out loud twice. Standing up. Do not memorize a speech for minute three through twenty. Human is allowed after the open. The open is not allowed to ramble.

Put the short URL on the same card. Pin-comment draft too.

Day 1 night: calendar and bio

Set the day, clock, timezone on a calendar you will keep. Put the checkout in the bio now. People who cannot attend still need a door. Do not hide the link until you are live. Sleep.

Day 2: announce twice, not twelve

Post the time once in the morning, once in the evening. Example: "Thursday 7pm. I show the file. Link in bio. Twenty minutes." Direct beats a story sticker that expires while they are at dinner.

Tell five people directly. "I'm walking through the listing pack Thursday at 7. Twenty minutes. \$29. If that's useful, I'll drop the link when I go live." If someone asks for the link now, send the checkout. The live is not the only door. It is the event.

Do not post twelve countdowns. Two public, five direct.

Day 3: the live and the landing

Hour before: water, charger, Do Not Disturb, link copied, screen ready, second device on orders, notifications off except the platform you are on.

Go live on time. If three people are there, you still start. Demo. Repeat the link. End around minute twenty.

Within two hours: a static page or a pinned post. "Pack is on the page. Walkthrough was tonight." Write three questions you got, one thing you fumbled, the next date or the decision that there is no next date yet. Delivery issues fixed before you sleep.

By hour 72: finished file named like a human, checkout test-bought, first two minutes on a card rehearsed twice, two public announcements, five direct asks, live of twenty minutes, store page the same night.

The path, step by step

Do these in order. Skipping the checkout test is how you host a room and then apologize.

Step 1. Finish one pack

One file, one job, one price. Export, open on a phone, fix the page that looks broken at that size. If you cannot attach it tonight, you do not have a drop. Go back to path 1, 2, 3, or 6. Accountability theater is how you go live with nothing to sell.

Step 2. Set a start time you can keep

Thursday 7pm is a classic. If you work evenings, pick Saturday 10am. Write the timezone. Lock the hour on a calendar. If you cancel dates as a habit, this path will cost you more trust than it makes. Keep the calendar or pick another path.

Step 3. Build the checkout

Title matches the pack. Price is visible. File delivers. Test-buy from a second email. Watch the file arrive. Test on cellular, not only wifi. If this fails, stop. Nothing else matters.

Step 4. Write the first two minutes

Card, not a script deck. Include the screen share in minute two, not minute twelve. Hello, how long, what the file does, open it, price, where the link is. Rehearse twice standing up. The rest can be human.

Step 5. Put the link in bio and in a note you can paste

If you fumble the URL on live, the moment dies. Have a short link written on paper. Pin draft ready. Bio live at least 24 hours before.

Step 6. Announce twice in public and five times in private

Forty-eight hours out, then two hours out. The two-hour reminder fills a small room. Direct DMs to people who already know the job beat a broadcast to strangers. Do not add a 600-word caption that hides the time.

Step 7. Stage the desk

Charged device. A second device on the checkout. Notifications off except the platform you are on. Optional \$20 tripod so your demo is not a ceiling fan. Water. Do Not Disturb. The file already open, not buried in eight folders.

Step 8. Go live on time

If three people are there, you still start. Waiting ten minutes for a crowd teaches the three that you do not respect the clock. Start within two minutes of the announced time. You can be a

voice and a cursor. You do not need to fake a crowd.

Step 9. Demo, do not lecture

Open the file. Scroll. Fill one example live if you can do it in three minutes. Answer questions about the pack, not your life story. Show the product more than you show your face talking about the product. Do not read comments for ten minutes while the screen is your wallpaper.

Step 10. Repeat the link and the price out loud every three minutes

Pin it. Say it like a person: "Link is in the bio, it's \$29, it delivers as soon as you pay." Four times minimum in twenty minutes. People join late. Minute four should still make sense.

Step 11. Close on purpose

At minute twenty, recap what they get, where to buy, and that you are ending. Stay two minutes for last questions. Then leave. Staying until the last person leaves turns a shop into a hangout. Hangouts do not check out.

Step 12. Same night, stand up the store

Replay if you have one. Otherwise a static page: what the pack is, who it is for, price, buy button, "the live walkthrough was [date]." Write the three questions you got. Those become your next post. Fix delivery before you sleep.

Step 13. Do not drop again on adrenaline

Friday Sage does not go live again. You will want to. The algorithm is not the customer. Date the next one when there is a new version, a new sample, or a new audience. Four to six weeks is a rhythm. Tomorrow is a leak.

Step 14. Count, then decide

Peak concurrent, checkouts during plus two hours, page checkouts the rest of the week, questions asked more than once. If you cannot keep dates, stop this path. If live checkouts

are zero three times and the page also sells zero, the problem is the pack or the audience, not the lighting.

A worked example: Sage on Thursday at 7

Sage finished a \$29 pack on Tuesday night. It is a listing-description stack for solo realtors: twenty-five prompts, three before-and-after listings, a one-page install. PDF plus a short text file. Not a course. A pack.

The date is the product

Sage picks Thursday 7pm Eastern. Twenty minutes. Instagram Live, because that is where the realtor acquaintances already watch Stories. Stan checkout already works — Sage test-bought it last month when the pack sat on a quiet page and sold two copies. Those two copies prove the file delivers. The live is for the rest.

Scarcity is the date. Sage writes: "I walk through the listing pack Thursday at 7. After that, the pack stays \$29 on the page. The walkthrough does not." No fake stock. No "only 5 left." The version is v1. Sage will rewrite when realtors actually use it, not because a timer hit zero.

The card and the asks

Tuesday, Sage writes the first two minutes on a yellow pad: "Hey — it's Thursday, I'm here twenty minutes. This is the listing pack I use when a new property hits the MLS and I have twelve minutes before the client wants copy. I'll share my screen, open the PDF, and run one address through the first prompt. Link is in the bio. \$29. It delivers immediately."

Sage rehearses that twice in the kitchen. Wednesday: morning Story and evening feed post, same core sentence. Five DMs to agents Sage has actually helped. One person asks for the link now. Sage sends Stan. That buyer pays \$29 Wednesday night. The live is not the only door. It is the event.

Thursday 7pm

Phone on a cheap tripod. Charger in. Do Not Disturb except Instagram. Stan open on a tablet. Bio already has the checkout. Pinned comment ready.

At 7:00 Sage goes live with eleven people. Not eleven thousand. Sage does not wait. The card gets through minute two. Screen share. A real listing Sage has permission to show, address blurred. First prompt. Ninety seconds of output. Sage reads two sentences, cuts the fluffy one, shows that edit. That is the demo.

Every three minutes: "Bio has the link. \$29. You get the PDF tonight." Someone asks ChatGPT or Claude. Sage answers: both, the install page says how. Someone asks for a discount. Sage says no, nicely. At minute nineteen Sage recaps and ends.

The burst and the recovery

Four checkouts during the live. One more overnight. Wednesday's early buyer makes six packs in two days. \$174. Sage puts a static post up at 7:40. Friday Sage does not go live again.

Mistake: Sage almost stayed live until 8:15 because a friend was driving home. Caught it. Ended. Recovery: the friend bought from the static page at 8:22. The date stayed real.

What Sage refused: a countdown sticker that said "3 left." A \$9 upsell on the fly. Dual-streaming TikTok. Adding a second product because minute twelve went quiet. Copy the shape, not the niche, unless you also write listings.

Copy you can actually send

Use these as they are. Swap the pack name, the price, the day. Do not add three paragraphs of your origin.

Public post

Thursday 7pm. I show the file. Link in bio. Twenty minutes.

Longer caption: Thursday 7pm Eastern. I walk through the [job] pack on my screen. Twenty minutes, then I leave. \$29, instant download. After the live the walkthrough is over; the pack stays on the page.

DM

I'm walking through the [job] pack Thursday at 7. Twenty minutes, \$29. If that's useful, I'll have the link in my bio when I go live. If you want it now, here: [checkout]. If not, no need to reply.

Page hero

[Named pack] for [job]. \$[price]. Instant download. I walk through it live on [day, time]. After that the walkthrough is gone. The file stays.

Checkout line

\$[price]. Instant download of [filename]. The live walkthrough is [day] only. The file is yours either way. Refund if it does not arrive.

Email 1 — 48 hours out

Thursday 7pm Eastern I show the [job] pack on my screen. Twenty minutes. \$[price], link in bio the whole time. After the live you can still buy the pack; you miss the walkthrough. If you cannot come, the page is already live: [link].

Email 2 — two-hour reminder

Going live at 7. Twenty minutes. I show the pack, not a slide deck. Link will be in the bio the whole time.

Email 3 — after the live

The walkthrough was tonight. The pack is still \$[price] on the page: [link]. Next live is not tomorrow. I'll date the next one when there is a new version worth showing.

Refund

File should have arrived at [email]. If it did not, I just resent it. If you want the money back instead, it is already on the way. I do not haggle the price on live.

The pinned comment

Pack is \$[price] — link in bio — delivers the file as soon as you pay. This walkthrough is tonight only.

The two-minute card (read, then demo)

Hey — it's [day], I'm here twenty minutes. This is the [job] pack I use when [specific moment]. I'll share my screen, open the file, and run one example. Link is in the bio. \$[price]. It delivers immediately.

What you do not post

Do not post "ONLY 2 SPOTS." Do not post a fake timer. Do not write a 600-word caption that hides the time. Do not post "live special \$9."

Week-by-week if you have a job

You do not need a free month. You need three evenings and a Thursday you will not cancel.

Week 1, daily

Day 1: finish the pack. Export. Phone-check. Checkout. Test-buy from a second email. Write the one-sentence offer and the two-minute card. Rehearse twice standing up.

Day 2: announce in the morning and the evening. Five DMs. Bio link live. Calendar locked.

Day 3: go live at the time you promised. Twenty minutes. Static page the same night. Delivery issues fixed before you sleep. Three questions written down.

Day 4: do not drop again. Answer buyer questions. Fix the one page of the PDF that two people could not find.

Day 5–7: ship a quiet v1.1 if it is a real fix, not a reason to go live. Count live checkouts vs page checkouts. Rest.

Week 2, daily

Day 8: one post that teaches a piece of the pack without giving the whole file away. Soft link to the store page.

Day 9–10: answer remaining buyer questions in public if they help the next caption.

Day 11: count sales from the page versus the live. Write the numbers.

Day 12–14: if the live carried it, date the next drop four to six weeks out, not next Thursday. If both live and page are zero, the problem is the pack or the audience. Do not buy a light.

Week 3

Only schedule a second live if you have a new version, a new sample, or a new audience.

Repeating the same twenty minutes every week trains people to ignore you. A drop is an event because it is rare.

Use the three questions from week 1 as captions. Keep the store page up. Do not add a membership from the leftover adrenaline.

Week 4

Review: did you keep the date? Average live checkouts. Page checkouts in the following seven days. If you cannot keep dates, stop this path. If you kept the date and sold nothing three times, fix the pack or the room, not the lighting.

Next drop is dated only when there is a reason. Four to six weeks is plenty.

The quality bar

The bar is simple. A tired person who joins at minute four can still tell what the file is, what it costs, and where to buy it.

Below-bar

File does not open on a phone, or checkout fails on cellular.

You start late. You wait for "more people."

Twelve minutes of lecture before the screen share.

URL lives only in your head. You fumble it.

Fake timer, fake stock, price drop in public.

You stay on until the last person leaves.

Delivery fails and you sleep anyway.

You go live daily, or you cancel twice.

You add a second product because the room went quiet.

Above-bar

The file opens. The first page states the job.

The checkout works on a phone.

You can demo without hunting through eight folders.

The first two minutes are rehearsed. The rest can be human.

You show the product more than you show your face talking about the product.

You answer product questions. You do not fake a crowd.

You start on time even if the room is small.

Price and link every three minutes. End around minute twenty.

Buyers get the file before you sleep.

Scarcity line is still true in the morning.

Five tests

Test 1, the minute-four joiner. Mute yourself, watch a recording or a rehearsal, join at minute four in your head. Do you know the file, the price, the URL? If not, cut the open.

Test 2, the second-email buy. You already did this, or you did not. If not, do it tonight. Recovery this week: test-buy, fix delivery, then announce.

Test 3, the clock. Did you start within two minutes of the time on the announcement? If not, you taught them your times are decoration. Recovery: the next date is kept or you stop this path.

Test 4, the honest scarcity. Read the announcement the next morning. Is it still true? If you extended, discounted, or restocked a lie, write a true sentence and use only that.

Test 5, the one-file rule. Did a second offer appear because the room was quiet? If yes, you slipped. Recovery: one file on the page. The rest waits for a DM.

If you catch yourself designing a talking-head intro sequence instead of testing the checkout, you have already slipped. Come back to the file and the time.

What to count

Count a few numbers. Do not build a dashboard.

Week 1 / drop day

Peak concurrent viewers. For a first drop, 8–40 is a real room. Do not compare this to people with a million followers.

Checkouts during the live plus two hours after. That is the burst. First-sale line: at least one from someone who is not you.

Checkout test (binary) before you announced.

Started on time (binary).

Screen share in first three minutes (binary).

Questions asked more than once. That is the next caption, or a fix in the file.

Day 30

Checkouts the rest of the week from the static page. That tells you if you have a store or only an event.

Kept the date (binary). Cancelled lives poison this path.

Delivery failures (should be zero).

Price held (binary). If you discounted in public, write it down as a miss.

v1.1 shipped only for a real fix, not as an excuse to go live again.

Day 90 / after three drops

Write down: average live checkouts, average page checkouts in the following seven days, and whether you kept the date. If you cannot keep dates, stop this path. If live checkouts are zero three times and the page also sells zero, the problem is the pack or the audience, not the lighting.

Cadence: drops four to six weeks apart, each with a reason.

Ignore

Ignore likes on the announcement. Ignore whether a stranger from a Facebook group said they would come. Ignore your heart rate. Ignore a view count that includes people who stayed for four seconds. Ignore dual-stream vanity. Ignore "the algorithm wants daily."

One-line spreadsheet

Date | kept clock (Y/N) | peak viewers | live+2h checkouts | page checkouts 7d | price held (Y/N) | delivery fails | three questions | next date or none

One row per drop. If you need a funnel dashboard, you are avoiding the demo.

Objections you will hear — including your own

"Nobody will show up."

Maybe. You still go live at the time you announced if even one person is there. A cancelled live teaches your small audience that your times are decoration. Reply to yourself: "I demo for three. I keep the date. The page still goes up."

"I hate being on camera."

Share the screen. Pin the product. You can be a voice and a cursor. Rehearse the two minutes so you are not staring at your own face looking for a personality. Reply: "They came for the file. The cursor is enough."

"Live selling is slimy."

Fake stock is slimy. A date and a demo are a shop hours sign. You are allowed to say the price out loud. You are not allowed to invent a shortage. Reply: "The walkthrough expires. The file stays. That is a shop sign, not a trick."

"I'll go live when I have more followers."

Eight people who already trust you will buy more than eight hundred cold viewers. Get the pack right. Date the drop. Reply: "Eleven is a room. Two quiet sales already proved delivery. Thursday stands."

"Someone asked for a discount on the live."

Say the price again. Offer the static page if they need to think. Do not negotiate in public. If you made a real error in the file, refund, do not haggle. Reply: "It's \$29. Link in bio. If you need to think, the page stays."

"What if they buy and want a course?"

You sold a pack. Point them to the page. A setup session is path 20, priced separately, not a surprise at minute sixteen. Reply: "This is the pack. Setup is a different product with a date. I can send that after."

"What if the checkout breaks during the live?"

Have the URL on paper. Have a backup payment link. If both fail, stop selling, take names, deliver by hand that night. Fix the pipe before you announce another Thursday. Reply: "I'm stopping the buy button until it works. If you comment your email, you get the file tonight."

"Should I go live every day to feed the algorithm?"

No. Date the next one when you have a reason: a new version, a new sample, a real cohort. Reply: "A drop is rare on purpose. Daily is how people learn to ignore me."

"Can I use a fake timer if everyone does it?"

No. Scarcity is a date, a cohort, or a version. Fake stock on a digital file is how you teach buyers to ignore you. Reply: "I will not lie about a PDF."

"What if only my mom shows up?"

You demo. You keep the date. You still put the store page up. Sage's first useful room was eleven. Yours can be smaller. Reply: "Three is a room. I start."

What this feeds — and what feeds it

Upstream — what must exist first

Live drops are not a first path. They are an amplifier. You need a pack from path 1, 2, 3, 6, or 9. A live with nothing to sell is a talk show. Finish the file. Then drop it.

A checkout that already delivered at least once. Quiet sales are the proof. If you have never test-bought, you are early.

One platform where a few dozen people already watch. Not two. One.

Downstream — what this feeds

The static store. People who missed Thursday still need a button.

Your list, if you collect emails on the checkout. Do not build a 12-email sequence before you have a live that works.

Proof. A screen recording of you opening your own product is more useful than a designed ad. That clip can become a caption, a page header, or the next announcement.

Questions from the live become posts and, if they repeat, a v1.1 of the file.

A service path, later, in the DMs, for the buyer who asks for you to run it. Not in minute twelve.

What not to chain on night one

Do not launch a membership from the live. Do not pitch an automation setup. Do not read a menu of twelve offers. One file. After the burst, you can point a buyer who asks for more toward a service path — in the DMs, not in minute twelve.

Do not chain a second live on Friday. Adrenaline is not a calendar.

Mistakes that kill a drop

Lying about stock. Reading comments and never showing the product. Going live daily until nobody cares. Those three still kill it. Here is the rest, with recovery this week.

1. Going live with a draft

Promising a zip you have not exported. Recovery this week: export, phone-check, test-buy. Cancel any announced live that has no file. Re-date after the pipe works.

2. Changing the price mid-live

The room is small, so you panic to \$9. Recovery this week: hold \$29. If you already dropped it, do not do it again. Write the number on the card.

3. Adding a second product because the room went quiet

Now nobody knows what to buy. Recovery this week: one file on the page. The rest waits.

4. Starting late / waiting for more people

You teach the three that the clock is decoration. Recovery this week: start within two minutes even if the room is one person.

5. Lecturing for twelve minutes before the screen share

They came for the file. Recovery this week: screen share in minute two. Put it on the card.

6. Fumbling the URL

It lived only in your head. Recovery this week: short link on paper, pin ready, bio live 24 hours before.

7. Staying on until the last person leaves

The night becomes a hangout. Recovery this week: recap at minute twenty, two minutes of questions, leave.

8. Fake countdown timers and "only 3 left"

Fake stock on a PDF. Recovery this week: delete the sticker. Scarcity is the date, the cohort, or the version. Write one true sentence.

9. A live every day, or a live you cancel twice

Cadence mistakes. Recovery this week: one dated drop. If you already cancelled, apologize once, pick a date you will keep, or stop this path.

10. No store page afterward

Anyone who hears about it on Friday has nowhere to go. Recovery this week: static page or pinned post within two hours of ending, even after a quiet room.

11. Delivery fails and you sleep

Trust dies overnight. Recovery this week: fix before you sleep. Resend. Refund if you cannot deliver.

12. Dual-streaming a first drop

Two comment threads, two bios, one confused host. Recovery this week: one room. One link.

13. Announcing before the checkout works

You host a room and then apologize. Recovery this week: test-buy first, announce second. Always that order.

Tools — only what you need

You need a place to go live, a place to get paid, and a card for the first two minutes.

Exact stack

TikTok Live or Instagram Live. Pick the one where your people already are. Do not dual-stream a first drop. One room, one comment thread, one bio link. YouTube Live is fine if that is your actual home. Zoom is a meeting, not a drop, unless you already sell into a private list and sent a calendar hold.

Stan, Stripe Payment Link, or Gumroad. One product. The link must be short enough to say out loud. Test on cellular, not only wifi.

A charger. A second screen or a tablet for orders. A notes app with the URL and the price.

Optional: a \$20 tripod so your demo is not a ceiling fan.

Paper card for the first two minutes.

Setup order

Export the pack. Phone-check.

Checkout. Test-buy from a second email.

Write the two-minute card. Rehearse twice.

Bio link live.

Calendar the hour.

Announce twice public, five direct.

Stage the desk. Then go live.

Static page the same night.

What not to buy

Do not add a webinar platform, a registration funnel, a wait-room video, or an on-air producer. Those are for people who already sell out rooms. You are dating a Thursday. Do not buy lights, a second camera, or a stream deck for drop one. Do not buy ads to fill a first room of eleven.

The \$o path

Phone you already have. Instagram or TikTok you already have. A Stripe or Stan or Gumroad link you already used for the quiet page. Paper for the card. A stack of books as a stand if you have no tripod. Free pinned post as the store. This is enough. Sage's tripod was cheap, not required. The bottleneck is the finished file and the kept time.

Checklist

Print this or copy it into a note. Check boxes in order.

Pack is exported and opens on a phone

Filename is human

First page of the file states the job

One price, written: \$19, \$29, \$39, or \$47

Checkout title matches the pack

Checkout test-bought from a second email; file arrived

Tested on cellular, not only wifi

One-sentence offer written

Scarcity line is a date, a cohort, or a version (one)

First two minutes on a card, rehearsed twice out loud

Short URL written on paper

Day, clock time, and timezone on a calendar

Bio link live at least 24 hours before

Two public announcements: 48 hours out, 2 hours out

Five direct messages to people who already know the job

Device charged, Do Not Disturb on, second device on the order screen

File already open, not buried in folders

Start on time even if the room is small

Screen share in the first three minutes

Price and link said every three minutes

End around minute twenty

Static page or pinned post up within two hours

Delivery issues fixed before you sleep

Three questions written down

No second live scheduled on adrenaline

Spreadsheet row: peak, live checkouts, page checkouts, clock kept

FAQ

How long should I stay live?

Twenty minutes. Twenty-five if questions are about the file. Not an hour. Default: twenty, then leave.

What if only three people show up?

You demo for three. You keep the date. You still put the store page up. Sage's first useful room was eleven. Yours can be smaller. Default: start anyway.

TikTok or Instagram?

Whichever already has your people. If both are empty, this is not your first path. Build a pack and a small audience on one platform, then drop. Default: one platform you already open.

Do I have to show my face?

No. Show the file. A stable screen and a clear voice beat a nervous talking head that never shares the product. Default: screen first, face optional.

Can I use a fake timer if "everyone does it"?

No. Scarcity is a date, a cohort, or a version. Fake stock on a digital file is how you teach buyers to ignore you. Default: date only, unless you have a real cohort cap.

Should I go live every day to feed the algorithm?

No. Date the next one when you have a reason: a new version, a new sample, a real cohort. Default: four to six weeks, with a reason.

What if the checkout breaks during the live?

Have the URL on paper. Have a backup payment link. If both fail, stop selling, take names, deliver by hand that night. Fix the pipe before you announce another Thursday. Default: stop selling, deliver by hand, fix, then re-date.

Do I need a replay?

Nice if the platform gives you one. Not required. The static page is required. The live is the event. The page is the store. Default: page same night, replay if cheap.

Can I drop a pack I did not finish because "the live will hold me accountable"?

No. Finish the pack first. Accountability theater is how you go live with nothing to sell. Default: export, test-buy, then announce.

What should I charge if my pack already sells at \$19 on the page?

Keep \$19, or use the live to introduce a \$29 version that actually added examples. Do not raise the price only because you turned a camera on. Default: keep \$19 unless the version is real.

What if someone wants a discount in the comments?

Say the price again. Offer the page if they need to think. Do not negotiate in public. Default: no discount, ever, on live.

Zoom or Instagram Live?

Instagram or TikTok if the people already watch there. Zoom only if you have a private list and a calendar hold. Default: the app they already open.

Can I sell a \$197 pack on a first live?

Live does not make a high ticket feel cheap. Default: \$19–\$47. High ticket is another path.

What if I freeze on camera?

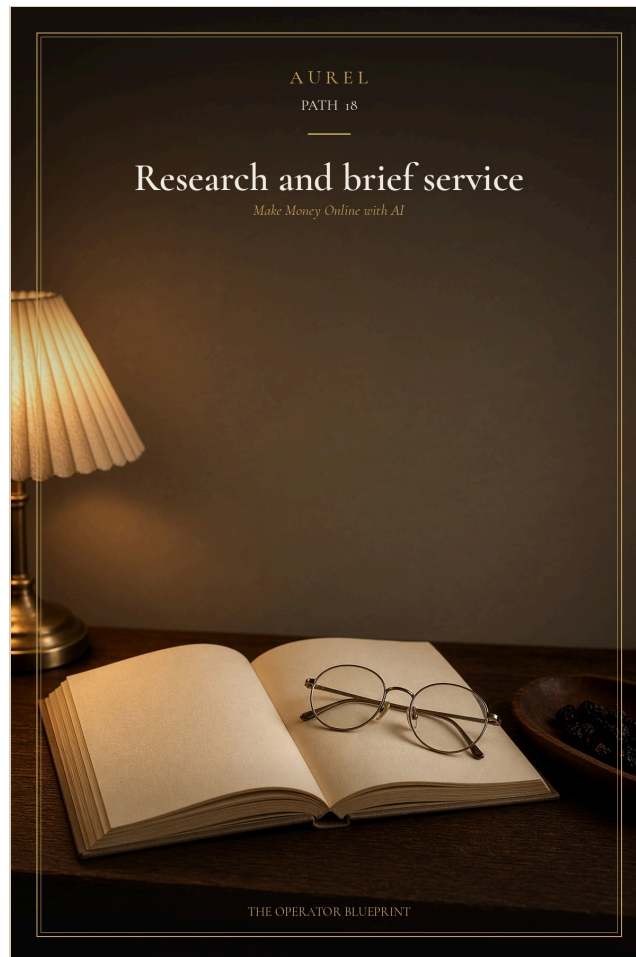
Card for two minutes, then screen share. You can be a voice and a cursor. Default: rehearse twice standing up; share the file by minute two.

How many DMs is too many?

Five direct asks to people who know the job. Not fifty cold pitches. Default: five.

When is the next drop?

When there is a new version, a new sample, or a new audience. Not tomorrow. Default: date it four to six weeks out, or do not date it yet.



PATH 18

Research and brief service

A messy question in. A two-page brief out. You verify what the model cannot know.

39 minute read · 8,656 words

Who this is for

You can turn a pile of tabs into a decision someone can use this week. You already know which sources in your niche lie.

Time to first

3–10 days

Tools

First sale

One paid brief delivered on time to a person who is not you.

Cash window

\$150–\$600 per brief

Leave this alone

Docs, a five-field order form, Stripe Payment Link, a sources policy, dated screenshots.

Claiming the model knows everything. Publishing unreviewed facts. Turning a \$300 brief into an unpaid project.

What this actually is

A research brief is a paid decision file. A messy question comes in. Two pages go out in 48 hours. The pages say what you found, what you verified, what is still unknown, and the next step a human can take this week. One revision is included. The clock is part of the product.

Anyone can paste a question into a model. What they get back is a confident first draft with an unknown number of invented citations. You sell the check. You are not a search engine with a nicer font. You are the person who will write "I could not verify this" in plain type, then still recommend a next step that does not depend on a fake number.

The product is judgment. The model is a junior researcher who works fast and lies when bored. You keep the job of saying which numbers can stand in a meeting. If you cannot say that out loud, you are selling a paste, and a paste does not hold a \$300 price.

What a brief is not

It is not a white paper. It is not a twelve-page literature review. It is not "I will go deep on your whole market." Executives do not read twelve pages. Operators do not need a seminar. They need a decision, on a date, with the holes labeled.

It is not consulting by the hour. It is not sitting in their Slack. It is not interviews you did not quote in the scope. It is not building the thing you recommended. The moment you start implementing, you have left this product and entered a project you forgot to price.

It is not a newsletter issue with their name swapped in. The paid file is private, dated, and written for one decision.

Why this works now

Models made first drafts cheap and citations untrustworthy at the same time. The people who would have spent a Saturday on twenty tabs now spend twenty minutes on a chat window, then still do not know which sentence they can repeat to a partner. That gap is the brief.

The gap is larger in niches where a wrong number has a cost: a clinic changing software, a contractor picking a supplier, a shop choosing a POS. Those buyers already pay for speed. They will pay more for a file they can forward without you on the call.

You do not need a following. You need three people who already ask you "what should I do about X?" and a template that forces a recommendation. The market is not "AI research." The market is one named decision with a date on it.

Three anti-patterns

The first anti-pattern is the unreviewed dump. You paste the model output, add a cover, and call it verified. That is how this path dies in public. One hallucinated citation in a file with your name on it is enough.

The second is the endless research project. You take a week because you want to be thorough. Thorough without a clock is a hobby. The 48-hour box is what makes the file a product instead of a rabbit hole.

The third is scope creep into doing the work. They ask you to "just hop on and help implement." You say yes because the brief felt small. A \$300 file becomes a \$3,000 job you did at \$300. The brief recommends. It does not build.

The deal you keep

You keep a short clock, a short file, and a spine in the "do not know" section. You keep a sources policy written before the first paid job. You keep one revision that means clarify or correct, not "now also write the strategy deck." You keep the right to recommend a next step that is not you. That deal is the business. Everything else is a different path with a different number.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if people already ask you "what should I do about X?" and you already open twenty tabs before you answer. You can tell a primary source from a blog that copied a blog. You can say "I do not know" without feeling like you failed. You can write two tight pages in a working day after the sweep.

You do not need a research degree. You need a niche where you already know the landscape: a trade, a software category, a local market, a regulation you have had to live with. The niche is what makes verification fast.

This fits you if

You have a niche where you already know which publications, filings, vendors, and forums are worth opening.

You can write two tight pages in a working day after the sweep, without padding.

You will check the citations. Not some of them. The ones you present as fact.

You can name three people who have asked you for this kind of help in the last year.

You would rather recommend a next step than own the whole project.

Skip this path if

Skip it if you want to publish unreviewed model output under your name. Skip it if you freeze when a number cannot be confirmed. Skip it if you would rather build the whole project than recommend a next step. Scope creep into doing the work is how a \$300 brief becomes a \$3,000 job you forgot to price.

Skip it if you cannot yet name three people who already ask you for this kind of help. Do a productized service or a playbook in a job you know, then offer briefs to the same people. Skip it if you need cash tomorrow morning. Three to ten days is honest.

The honest middle

If you have done this kind of sweep twice for free, in email threads you never billed, this is the product hiding in those threads. Capture the last one as a two-page sample with fake names.

You are not waiting to become an analyst. You are waiting to put a clock and a price on work you already do badly for free.

If you have only done it once, do the next one as a paid \$150 case with a written sources policy. One file. On time. Then lock the fee.

Skills and time

You need a working day you can protect twice a week. The sweep and the write are four to eight hours inside a 48-hour window. You also need twenty minutes to send three offers, and the nerve to start the clock only when intake and payment are both in.

Writing skill here is short sentences and a recommendation that is a verb plus an object plus a time. If your natural mode is a twelve-page memo, this path will feel like cutting. That cut is the product.

Two-minute self-test

Answer these out loud. If you cannot, this is not your path this month.

Name one niche where you already know the sources that lie.

Name three people who have asked you "what should I do about X?" in the last year.

Name one decision those people actually have to make in the next 30 days.

Say, in one breath, what you will not do as part of a \$300 brief.

Say what you will write when a key number cannot be confirmed.

If all five have answers, write the template today. If two are blank, pick a different path or go get the missing reps before you charge.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this and put it on the order form: "48-hour brief for [named person] on [named decision].

Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$[price]. One revision included."

That is the whole offer. If you cannot fit it on a sticky note, you are selling a retainer. The named person and the named decision are what keep you out of "I research anything." The clock, the page count, and the revision rule are what keep you out of unpaid follow-up.

Five sentences you can copy

48-hour brief for independent clinic owners deciding whether to switch schedulers. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$300. One revision included.

48-hour brief for one-person HVAC shops picking a dispatch tool before the heating season. Two pages. Verified, unknown, next step. \$300. One revision.

48-hour brief for a shop owner choosing a POS this quarter. Two pages. What I opened, what I could not confirm, what to do this week. \$300.

48-hour brief for a solo accountant deciding whether to move a client book onto a new practice platform. Two pages. Sources checked. \$450 if you send the current contract clause.

48-hour brief for a contractor comparing two material suppliers on lead time and published pricing, not on a sales call. Two pages. \$300.

Write yours with a person you can text. Do not write "busy professionals" or "leaders." Those are not buyers. A clinic owner with two front-desk people giving notice is a buyer.

What they get

Intake: the decision they must make, the deadline, what they already tried.

A sweep with a model, used as a map, never sent.

Your verification pass against sources you named in advance.

Two pages delivered in 48 hours from a complete intake, not from the first vague email.

A recommended next step that is a verb, an object, and a time.

A "do not know" section that is specific.

One revision window of 48 hours after delivery. Revision means clarify or correct, not a second question.

What they do not get

Building the thing. Sitting in their Slack. Monitoring a topic for a month. Interviews you did not quote in the scope. A deck. A workshop. A second topic folded into the first file. Unlimited email until they "feel ready." If they need those, that is a different package with a different number.

They also do not get your working dump, your prompt, or a promise that the recommendation will make them money. They get a defensible file on a date.

Packaging

One product. One price on the form. Payment before the clock. 48 hours starts when intake is complete and the payment is in, whichever is later. Delivery is a PDF or Doc they own, filename with topic and date.

Do not bundle four briefs for the price of three in month one. Do not add a "strategy call" that becomes the whole job. If you want a 20-minute walkthrough after delivery, write it as an extra at \$75 or include it once, in writing. Do not let a call replace the file.

A rush under 24 hours is a different package: same two pages, add 50 percent, only if you actually have the hours. A second topic is a second brief.

What done looks like

Done is a two-page file the buyer can forward without you on the call. It has a recommended next step that a human could take this week. It has a "do not know" section that is specific, not theatrical. Sources that are stated as fact have been opened by you. The clock was kept. The revision window is stated in the delivery email. Then the job is closed unless they buy another brief.

Done is not "I sent a thoughtful email." Done is a file they own, in their inbox, inside 48 hours of a complete intake, with a name they can find in six months.

The fairness test

Hand the brief to someone who does not know the buyer. In three minutes they should be able to say: the decision, the recommendation, the biggest uncertainty. If they cannot, you wrote an

essay. If they can, the buyer can forward page one to a partner without a decoder.

Fairness also means the price and the clock matched what they bought. A 48-hour brief delivered on day four is not done. It is a late file plus an apology. A two-page product padded to seven pages is not "more value." It is a failure of the product you sold.

Technical done

PDF or Doc they own, in their inbox, inside 48 hours of a complete intake.

Filename with the topic and the date, not "brief_final_v3."

Six headings present: decision, found, verified, do not know, next step, one thing I would not do.

Every fact in the verified section has a source you opened, with enough to reopen it: title, publisher, date, URL.

Recommendation is a verb plus an object plus a time.

One revision if they ask inside the window. Then closed.

Not done yet

You started on a voice note and the decision is still mush.

A number in the verified section lives only in a model dump.

"Do not know" is empty, or it says "more research needed" with no object.

The next step is "consider exploring options."

You are waiting to "add a few more sources" past the clock.

They asked a second question and you started writing it into the same file for free.

You have not restated the revision window in the delivery email.

The file is still in your drafts because you want it to feel smarter.

If any of those are true, you do not invoice the feeling. You finish the file or you stop the clock in writing and refund. There is no third option called "almost."

Pricing

The cash window is \$150–\$600 per brief. Robin sells at \$300. That is the number to copy until you have proof you are slow or uniquely sourced. Put the number on the form. Do not hide it behind "let us hop on a call."

Ranges

\$150 if this is your first paid brief, the topic is one you already know, and you need a case. Discount once. Then lock the fee.

\$300 for a standard 48-hour, two-page, one-revision brief with named sources. Default. This is Robin. This is you.

\$450–\$600 if they need you to include a small set of primary documents they provide (filings, a competitor's pricing page, a contract clause) and the decision is time-sensitive inside their week. Still two pages. Still 48 hours. The extra money is the extra verification, not extra paper.

Do not charge hourly. A slow reader should not earn more than a fast one for the same two pages. Do not charge \$50. That price buys a paste, and they will treat it like one. Do not charge \$2,000 for two pages in month one. You have no cases and you will freeze.

When to raise

After three on-time briefs at the current fee, if you are turning work away or the decisions got heavier. Raise \$300 to \$450, or \$450 to \$600. Raise because the calendar is full or the verification is harder, not because a compliment felt good. If you discounted the first to \$150, the second is \$300. No story.

Refunds in one sentence

If the file is late without a written clock change, or a stated fact was not opened at the source, you refund. You do not refund because they disliked the recommendation.

Never charge for these

Never charge for "I'll look at it and we can see." That is the brief. Never charge a discovery fee that becomes a free brief. Never charge for a second topic inside the first file. Never charge a monthly "research retainer" until five briefs have landed on time. Never charge to sit in Slack. Never charge \$49 so you can be sloppy.

Worked dollars

Robin's first paid brief: \$300 in, about five hours of real work inside a 48-hour clock, two of them verification. The buyer was not buying hours. They were buying a decision file before October 1. Three \$300 briefs in a month is \$900 around a job. Five at \$300 is \$1,500. Worked dollars go up when you stop discounting and stop turning briefs into projects.

The first 72 hours

You do not need a website. You need a template, a fee, and three people who already ask you what to do. The 72 hours are for those three things, not for a brand.

Day 1 morning: the brief template

Open a two-page Doc with locked headings:

Decision on the table

What I found

What I verified (with sources)

What I do not know

Recommended next step

One thing I would not do

Write a one-paragraph sources policy under the template: sites you will use, sites you will not, and the rule that an unchecked number is not a fact. If you will not use Reddit as a source, say so. If a trade journal is in, say so. If vendor marketing pages are allowed only as "vendor claims," say so. This paragraph is what you will point at when someone wants a citation you refuse.

Do not design a cover. Do not pick a logo. Headings and a policy. If the headings feel tight, good. They are supposed to.

Day 1 afternoon: the order form and the number

Five fields only: name, email, the decision they must make, the deadline, what they already tried. Price on the form. \$300. Payment before you start the clock. 48 hours starts when intake is complete and the payment is in, whichever is later. State working days if you will not run the clock over a weekend. Write it before they pay.

Use Tally or Google Form plus a Stripe Payment Link. Buy your own form from a second email if you need to see the confirmation. You do not need a proposal tool. You do not need a scheduling link that turns into a free consult.

Day 1 night: the three names

Write three names. Not a cold list. People who already lean on you. Next to each name, write the decision you think they actually have. If you cannot name a decision, you do not have an offer for that person this week. Go to bed with the three lines, not with a content calendar.

Day 2: three offers, then a sample if you need one

Send the sentence to those three. Not a newsletter. Not a launch. A message.

"I turned the way I already help you into a 48-hour brief. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$300. If you have a decision this month, I'll take one."

If nobody has a live decision, offer one discounted first seat at \$150 to get a case, to the person whose decision is closest. Deliver that one on time. Then lock the price. A late free brief teaches the wrong lesson.

If you have never written a two-pager in this shape, spend Day 2 afternoon writing a sample on a decision you already made, with fake names. You do not send it as the paid file.

Day 3: intake discipline and a closed loop

If someone said yes, collect payment, then the intake. Do not start on a voice note. Incomplete intake does not start the 48 hours. Reply with the five fields and wait.

If nobody said yes, send the same sentence to two more people from the same pile, or pick a different path on Friday. Do not rewrite the offer six times in 72 hours. Do not add a blog. The action is asks plus a template that can take a yes.

The path, step by step

Do these in order. The clock is part of the product. Skipping verification to "make the date" is how you ship fiction. Skipping the date to "verify more" is how you ship a hobby.

Write the two-page template and the sources policy. Lock the six headings so you cannot wander. Name sources you will use and sources you refuse. If you cannot name sources you refuse, you are not ready to charge for verification. The policy is one paragraph, not a legal memo.

Put \$300 on a one-page offer. Intake fields, turnaround, one revision, what is out. Payment link above the fold. Working days stated if they matter. The page is allowed to be ugly. It is not allowed to be vague. Test-buy from a second email so you know the confirmation arrives.

Ask three people who already ask you "what should I do about X?" Offer one discounted first seat if you need a sample, then never discount without a reason you can say out loud. Direct messages. The sentence is the message. If they reply with a different job, sell a different path or say no.

On a yes: collect payment, then the intake. Do not start on a voice note. Incomplete intake does not start the 48 hours. If they pay and the decision field says "help with marketing," write back: "I need the decision, the deadline, and what you already tried. Clock starts when those are in."

Sweep with a model. Prompt it for a map: claims, names, numbers, competing views. Dump that into a working doc you will not send. Ask for disagreements, not just a summary. The dump will be confident and partly wrong. Your job in this step is coverage, not truth.

Verify. Open the sources. Check the numbers. Kill anything you cannot confirm. Move the rest to "do not know" or cut it. Date the screenshots for prices and claims that might move. If a vendor page is the only home of a number, it is a vendor claim, not a fact. If a Reddit thread is the only home of a horror story, cut it.

Write two pages in your voice. Short sentences. The recommendation sits near the top, not after a tour of the landscape. You may be wrong. You may not be fuzzy. Put the decision in the first five lines so a partner who only reads page one still gets the job.

Fill "do not know" with specifics. "I could not find 2025 market share from a primary filing. Vendor blogs claim 18 percent. Treat as unverified." If the recommendation depends on an unverified number, change the recommendation.

Fill "one thing I would not do." This heading exists so you take a side. "I would not sign an annual on a sales call this week." A brief that will not say no is a summary. Summaries are free.

Deliver inside 48 hours as a file they own. Filename with topic and date. Restate the revision window in the email. Restate that a second question is a second brief. Do not attach the sweep dump.

If they revise, you clarify or correct. You do not add a second question. If they want the second question, sell brief two. If they want you to implement, quote a different path. Close the window when it closes.

After delivery, ask one thing: which sentence they used. That sentence becomes your next outbound line. If they used nothing, ask what they needed that was missing. Usually it is a clearer next step, not more pages.

After three on-time briefs, raise from \$150 (if you discounted) to \$300, or from \$300 to \$450 if demand is real and your calendar is full. Do not stay at \$150 because discounting feels kind. Raise because the calendar is full, not because a compliment felt good.

Only after five on-time briefs may you consider a monthly watch, and only as a named retainer with a named topic. Most operators should not. Stacking single briefs is cleaner.

Keep a folder of dated screenshots and a one-line log: date, buyer type, decision, fee, on time or not, sentence they used. A sheet with five rows is enough. Fill the row before you send the next ask.

Stop or split if a brief keeps turning into a project. Fix the offer sentence and the "what is out" line before you take another dollar. The path dies when you become their cheap project manager.

A worked example: Robin's \$300 brief

Robin helps independent clinic owners who keep asking whether they should buy a new scheduling tool. Robin is not a software vendor. Robin has sat through four of these decisions in two years and is tired of rewriting the same email. That email thread is the product, unpriced.

Monday: template, policy, form

Robin spends Monday morning on the six headings and a sources policy. In: vendor pricing pages, vendor status pages, state board rules Robin already knows, one trade journal. Out: Reddit as fact, Facebook group anecdotes as fact, "HIPAA compliant" badges without a BAA. Unchecked numbers are not facts. Monday afternoon Robin puts \$300 on a Tally form with five fields and a Stripe link. Monday night Robin writes three names.

Wednesday: three asks

Wednesday morning, Robin messages three clinic owners: "48-hour brief. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$300. One revision. Clock starts when I have the decision, the deadline, and payment."

One ignores. One says they might think about it in the fall. One replies. Decision: stay on the current scheduler or move to Tool B before October 1, because two front-desk people just gave notice. They already tried a vendor demo and a Facebook group thread. They pay \$300 Thursday at 9:12am. Intake is complete at 9:40. Clock ends Saturday 9:40am.

Thursday: sweep, then verify

Thursday, Robin uses a model to sweep: feature lists, pricing pages, two complaint patterns, HIPAA claims. That dump is ugly and stays private. Then Robin opens sources. Pricing is confirmed on both vendor pages, screenshots dated. A "HIPAA compliant" badge on Tool B's homepage is marketing copy; Robin cannot find a BAA sample without a sales call, so that goes in "do not know." A Reddit thread claiming Tool B lost appointments for a 200-provider group is one anonymous post — not a fact. Cut.

Robin almost makes the first real mistake of the job here. The model cites a 2025 uptime number with a neat URL. Robin pastes the URL, the page 404s, and the temptation is to leave the number in with "source: vendor." Robin deletes the number. "Do not know" gets a line: cannot verify Tool B's uptime for 2025 from a primary status page; vendor says "99.9 percent" on a marketing URL only. That delete is the product.

Friday: two pages, not seven

Robin writes two pages, not seven. Page one: the decision, the recommendation (stay through October, run a 14-day parallel on Tool B with one provider, do not cut over during staffing loss), the three verified differences that matter for a two-person front desk. Page two: sources, the "do not know" block, one thing Robin would not do (sign an annual on a sales call this week).

The "do not know" section, copied:

Cannot verify Tool B's uptime for 2025 from a primary status page; vendor says "99.9 percent" on a marketing URL only.

Cannot confirm BAA language without a sales call. If HIPAA is the reason to switch, that call is the next step, not a cutover.

No independent review of Tool B's SMS reminders in this state. Vendor blog only.

Saturday: delivery, then a revision that stays a revision

Saturday 8:10am, the PDF lands. Filename: "Scheduler-stay-or-move_brief_18Apr.pdf." Revision window until Monday 8:10. The owner asks one clarifying question: what "parallel" means in hours. Robin adds four sentences. Job closed. \$300. Time on the clock: about five hours of real work, two of them verification.

The owner also asks, in the same email, whether Robin can "just set up the parallel this week." Robin says no. That is a project. Robin offers to quote it as a different job or to leave the next step as written. The owner stays with the file. Robin does not work the weekend for free to seem helpful.

The first stranger sale

The clinic owner forwards page one to a partner at a second clinic. The partner emails Robin on the following Tuesday. Different scheduler, same staffing problem, deadline in September. Robin sends the same offer at \$300. They pay. Intake is complete Wednesday noon. Robin delivers Friday morning. No discount. That is the first stranger sale: \$300, on time, from a forward, not from a friend who wanted to be nice.

Robin notes the case, locks the fee at \$300, and does not write a twelve-page version "to be thorough." The sentence the first buyer used — "do not cut over during staffing loss" — becomes the next outbound line.

Copy you can actually send

Use these. Swap the topic. Do not add a biography. Do not add "AI-powered." The buyer already knows models exist. They are buying the check.

Post

I turned the way I already help [people] into a 48-hour brief. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, the next step. \$300. One revision. Clock starts when intake and payment are in. If you have a decision this month, the form is here: [link].

DM

You keep asking me what to do about [X]. I turned that into a fixed job: 48-hour brief, two pages, sources checked, a "do not know" section so we do not pretend. \$300, one revision. If you have a decision this month, I'll take one.

Page hero

A messy question in. A two-page brief out. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. 48 hours. \$300.

Checkout line

\$300. Two pages. 48 hours from complete intake and payment. One revision in the next 48 hours (clarify or correct, not a second question). Payment starts the job. Working days: [days].

Email 1, the ask

Subject: 48-hour brief on [X]

You keep asking me what to do about [X]. I made it a product so I stop rewriting the same email. 48-hour brief. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$300. One revision. If you have a decision with a date this month, reply with the decision, the deadline, and what you already tried. I'll send the payment link.

Email 2, intake complete

Subject: Clock starts [date/time]

Payment is in. Intake is complete. The 48 hours ends [date/time]. You will get a two-page file: decision, what I found, what I verified, what I do not know, next step, one thing I would not do. I will not send the working dump. One revision if you ask within 48 hours of delivery.

Email 3, delivery

Subject: Brief on [decision] — revision window until [date/time]

Attached: two-page brief on [decision]. I verified the items in section 3. Section 4 is what I still do not know — please do not treat those as facts. Recommended next step is on page one. One revision if you send it within 48 hours. After that, a new brief is a new order.

Refund email

Subject: Refund for [decision] brief

The file was [late / contained an unverified fact stated as fact]. I am refunding the \$300. You do not need to reply.

What you do not write

"AI knows everything." "Comprehensive report." "I'll keep looking until you are happy." "Let me hop on a call and we can see." Those sentences are how you work for free and ship fiction.

Week-by-week if you have a job

You can do this around a job if you protect two evenings and one weekend block. The goal of the first month is three on-time briefs, not a brand.

Week 1

Day 1: template plus sources policy plus \$300 form. Test the payment link. Write three names.

Day 2: three offers in the morning. If you have never written this shape, write a fake-name sample in the evening from a decision you already know. Do not take a second brief until the first has a home.

Day 3: follow one non-reply with a single line, not a new pitch. If a yes arrives, collect payment, then intake. Start no clock on a mushy email.

Day 4: if a brief is live, sweep and verify. If not, send two more asks from the same pile. Do not build a website.

Day 5: write and deliver if the clock demands it. If you have no buyer, stop adding features to the form. The form is fine. The asks are the work.

Day 6–7: deliver one on time, even if the first is \$150. Then lock the fee. Restate the revision window. Close the job. Do not spend Sunday inventing a retainer.

Week 2

Day 8: if the first buyer used a sentence, put that sentence in your next three asks. If they did not, ask what they needed that was missing — usually it is a clearer next step, not more pages.

Day 9: ship that as a template change, not as unpaid extra work. Tighten "recommended next step" so it is always a verb, an object, and a time.

Day 10–11: two more asks, or a second paid brief at full price. Same intake rules. Same clock.

Day 12–14: deliver the second on time or spend the weekend on verification, not on a new offer. Two on-time files beat a redesigned page.

Week 3

Take a third brief at full price or stop. Three on-time deliveries is enough proof. Do not add a monthly retainer. Speed and a spine in the "do not know" section are the goal.

If week 3 is empty, the problem is usually the ask list, not the template. Write five names who have a date in the next 30 days. Message those.

Week 4

If you have three on-time briefs: raise if the calendar is full, or stay at \$300 and take one more. Log fees, hours, on-time rate, sentence used. If you have fewer than two: pick a different path or go back to people who already ask you. Do not spend week 4 on ads.

The quality bar

A brief is good when a skeptical reader can see the seam between verified and guessed. Pretty language does not cover a fake citation. Length does not cover a missing next step.

Below the bar

A number you did not open, stated as fact.

A hallucinated URL, even once.

Empty "do not know," or "more research needed" with no object.

A recommendation that is a mood: "consider exploring options."

Twelve pages to look serious.

Clock missed, no written change.

Second question absorbed into the first fee.

Voice that sounds like a model: "In today's rapidly evolving landscape."

Sources you listed and did not open.

A file the buyer cannot forward without you explaining it.

Above the bar

Two pages. Six headings. Recommendation on page one.

Every verified number reopened at the source, dated if it can move.

"Do not know" you could defend to a hostile partner.

Next step a human can take this week without you.

One thing you would not do, named.

On time. Filename with topic and date.

Revision that clarifies, then closed.

Kitchen-table sentences.

Five tests before you hit send

The stranger test. A person who does not know the buyer can say the decision, the recommendation, and the biggest uncertainty in three minutes.

The open-the-link test. Every fact in section 3 has a source you opened in this job, not last year in your head.

The fake-number test. If the key number vanished, would the recommendation still stand? If not, the number belongs in "do not know" or the recommendation changes.

The verb test. The next step is a verb plus an object plus a time. "Stay on Tool A through October 1. Run a 14-day parallel." Not "look into options."

The clock test. The file is in their inbox inside the window you sold. If it is not, you do not send a draft and hope. You say you are late, you refund or you finish with their written OK, and you fix the process.

If you fail one test, you are not "basically done." You fix the file or you do not send it.

What to count

Count a short list. If you need a dashboard, you are avoiding the asks.

Week 1

Template exists: yes or no.

Sources policy written: yes or no.

Form live at \$300: yes or no.

Asks sent: target 3–5.

Paid briefs accepted: target 1.

On-time delivery: yes or no. This is the first-sale definition.

Ignore followers, impressions, and how clever the sweep sounded.

Day 30

Briefs delivered: target 3.

On-time rate: target 3/3. One late is a process bug. Two late means you sold a clock you do not keep.

Average fee. If you are still at \$150 after three, you are discounting as a personality trait.

Hours of real work per brief. Expect 4–8. If you are at 14, your niche is too wide or you are writing twelve pages.

Sources opened versus sources the model proposed. If you opened fewer than half, you are not verifying.

Whether they used the next step inside two weeks. A yes is a case. A no is a template problem or a bad-fit buyer.

Revision that tried to become a second question: count them. More than one per job means intake is soft.

Day 90

Briefs in the log: 6–10 is a real practice around a job. 1–2 means this stayed a hobby.

Stranger sales (not friends): at least 2.

Fee: \$300 or \$450, not \$150.

On-time rate at or above 80 percent.

One sentence from a buyer you reuse in outbound.

Zero retainers unless five briefs were on time and you named the pages.

If day 90 is empty, stop. Do not "rebrand the research desk." Go to a path with people who already pay you, or admit you will not send the asks.

Ignore

How clever the model sounded in the sweep. Page count past two. Time you spent choosing a font. Compliments that are not a used sentence.

One-line spreadsheet

Date | buyer type | decision in five words | fee | on time Y/N | hours | sentence they used | second question attempted Y/N

That is the whole system.

Objections you will hear — including your own

Reply once. Do not hold a seminar in the thread.

"Can't they just ask ChatGPT?"

They can. They will still have to check it. You are selling the check, the cut, and a next step they can defend in a meeting. If they want the paste, they should not hire you.

"Two pages feels thin for \$300."

Twelve pages they will not read is thinner. Price the decision, not the paper weight. Robin's clinic owner forwarded one page-one paragraph to a partner. That is use. If they want a literature review, that is a different product you probably should not sell.

"I might miss something."

You will. That is why "do not know" exists. Missing something and labeling it is professional. Missing something and stating it as fact is how this path dies. Your job is a defensible file on a date, not omniscience.

"They want me to just hop on a call."

A call without a brief becomes the whole job, unpaid. Offer the brief. If they want a 20-minute walkthrough after delivery, price it as \$75 or include once, in writing. Do not let the call replace the file.

"What if they want the whole project?"

Say no, or sell a different package. A brief that turns into implementation without a new quote is how you train them to ignore your scope. "I can quote that as a project. The brief stays \$300 and ends when the file lands."

"I do not have a niche."

Then you will be slow and worse. Start where you already know which sources lie. If you cannot name that place, skip this path. A generalist research shop is a fantasy that loses to a paste.

"\$300 is too high for four hours of work."

They are buying the turnaround, the cut, and the nerve to recommend. Do not add eight hours of padding to feel fair. That makes a worse file.

"What if they hate the recommendation?"

You refund late files and unverified facts stated as fact. You do not refund a recommendation they dislike. They bought judgment.

"Can you just keep looking until we know?"

No. The product is 48 hours and two pages. If they need more, they buy brief two on a tighter question.

"My industry is too specialized. Nobody will pay."

Specialized is the point. Generic "market research for founders" is where you compete with free. Stay narrow.

What this feeds — and what feeds it

Briefs sit next to other operator paths. They are not a funnel slide and they are not a bait-and-switch into a \$5,000 project they did not ask for. Recommend. Then wait to be asked.

What feeds a brief practice

People who already ask you for judgment: clients from a productized service, readers of a newsletter, buyers of a playbook who now have a live decision. A local business you already wrote posts for. A freelancer who already trusts your taste.

Cold traffic can work later. First sales come from three names you can text. If those three names do not exist, go do a path that creates them, then come back.

Your own last unpaid email thread is also feedstock. If you have already written the same "here is what I would do" message four times, that message is a brief wearing unpaid clothes.

What a brief feeds

A productized service, if the next step is work they want you to do. New quote. New scope. New number.

A playbook, if three briefs repeat the same structure. The template becomes a \$19–\$47 file with the client details stripped.

Custom project setups, if the recommendation is "configure the tool," not "I will configure it this afternoon for free."

Automation setups, if the next step is a named machine (form to draft, reminder, report). Quote path 19 separately.

Trust for a later retainer you still should not sell in week one.

What not to feed

Do not use a brief as a hook to upsell a project in the delivery email. The delivery email delivers. If they ask, you quote. If they do not ask, you log the sentence they used and you send the next outbound. Do not feed a public newsletter with their numbers unless they said yes in writing.

Mistakes that kill this path

Hallucinated citations. Briefs that refuse to recommend. Scope creep into doing the whole project. Those three still kill it. The rest kill it more slowly.

Ten mistakes and the recovery this week

Starting the clock on a vague email. Recovery: stop. Write "Clock has not started. I need the decision, the deadline, and what you already tried." Do not sweep until those exist.

Delivering twelve pages to look serious. Recovery: cut to two pages before you send. Move extra into your private dump. If it will not fit, it did not earn a sentence.

Leaving "do not know" empty because it felt like weakness. Recovery: add three specific holes before send. If you cannot name three, you have not verified.

Publishing the brief as a public post with the client's numbers in it. Recovery: take it down today. Apologize in writing. Do not wait to see if they noticed.

Claiming the model "knows everything." Recovery: delete that line from every page and DM. Replace with the offer sentence.

A second revision, then a third, because you did not close the window. Recovery: send "The revision window ended [date]. A new question is a new brief at \$300." Then stop typing.

Undercharging at \$49 so you feel like you can be sloppy. Recovery: next brief is \$300. You do not raise later "once you feel ready." You lock it now.

Pasting a URL you did not open into a footnotes list. Recovery: delete the line. Open the source or move the claim to "do not know." That reflex is the whole ethic.

Turning the recommendation into "I will come do it." Recovery: rewrite the next step so a human who is not you can take it. If they want you, quote a different path.

Taking a second brief before the first has landed. Recovery: finish the live one. A late first file poisons the second ask.

Using Facebook anecdotes as facts. Recovery: cut them. If a pattern matters, label it "unverified complaints in [place]" inside "do not know."

Weekend clocks you cannot staff. Recovery: put working days on the form today. Do not surprise them with Monday math after a Friday charge.

If you catch yourself in any of these, the recovery is this week, not "when things calm down." The path is small enough to fix on a Thursday night.

Tools — only what you need

The stack is boring on purpose. Three clients do not need a pipeline. They need you to open the links.

Exact stack

Google Docs or Word for the two-page file. Export PDF.

Tally or Google Form for intake. Five fields.

Stripe Payment Link at \$300.

The model you already pay for, used as a sweep. Not sent.

A browser. The actual source pages.

A folder of dated screenshots for numbers that might move.

A one-paragraph sources policy.

Email. Their inbox is the delivery system.

A simple sheet: the one-line log from the metrics section.

Setup order

Template Doc with six headings.

Sources policy paragraph.

Stripe link.

Form pointing at the link, price visible.

Test-buy from a second email.

Three names in a note.

Screenshot folder, empty, ready.

Then you send asks. Not before.

What not to buy

Do not buy a "research agent" stack, a scraping farm, a citation tool you do not understand, or a CRM. Do not buy a proposal platform. Do not buy a new domain to look like a firm. Do not add Notion if Docs already works.

The \$0 path

Docs, a Google Form, and a payment link you already have. The model you already use. Free email. The \$0 path is allowed for the first brief. It is not an excuse to skip the sources policy or the clock. If you have no payment tool, invoice and wait for the transfer before the clock.

Checklist

Two-page template with the six headings, including "do not know" and "one thing I would not do"

Sources policy written: in, out, unchecked numbers are not facts

Offer sentence on one page: 48 hours, two pages, \$300, one revision

Intake fields: decision, deadline, what they already tried

Working days stated if the clock does not run weekends

Payment before the clock

Clock starts only when intake is complete and payment is in

Test-buy of the form from a second email

Three names who already ask you "what should I do about X?"

Model for sweep, private dump, never sent

Every fact opened at the source

Dated screenshots for numbers that can move

Vendor claims labeled as vendor claims

Reddit and group anecdotes not used as facts

Recommendation is a verb, an object, and a time

"Do not know" has specific holes, not a mood

Filename has topic and date

Delivered inside 48 hours

Sweep dump not attached

Revision window restated in the email

Second question = second brief

After delivery: one sentence they used, written down

First discount, if any, is once. Then the fee is locked

One-line spreadsheet row filled

No implementation without a new quote

No public post with their numbers

Access to nothing of theirs except the documents they sent for this brief

Late file: refund or written clock change, no third path

FAQ

Why 48 hours and not a week?

A week becomes a research project. 48 hours forces a decision-sized file. If they need a week of interviews, that is not this product. Default: keep 48 hours on working days, written on the form.

What if intake arrives at 6pm Friday?

State your working days on the form. "48 hours on business days" is allowed if you write it before they pay. Do not surprise them with Monday math after a Friday charge unless the form said so. Default: write the days before the first dollar.

Do I show my working?

No. They get two pages. The sweep dump stays yours. Showing the raw model output trains them to skip you next time. Default: never attach the dump.

Can I use the brief as public content?

Not with their numbers, names, or quotes, unless they said yes in writing. You may rewrite a generic version weeks later if nothing identifying remains. Default: sample with fake names only.

What if I cannot verify the key number?

Put it in "do not know." Change the recommendation so it does not depend on a fake number. That section is why they trust you. Default: never promote an unverified number into a fact to make the file feel finished.

Is \$300 too high if I only spend four hours?

No. They are buying the turnaround, the cut, and the nerve to recommend. If four hours feels guilty, look at the value of the decision, not your typing speed. Default: \$300 until three on-time briefs say otherwise.

Should I offer unlimited email follow-up?

No. One revision. Then a new brief or a different path. Default: 48-hour revision window, clarify or correct only.

What if they want citations in academic form?

Give enough to reopen the source: title, publisher, date, URL. You are not submitting a journal article. You are making a decision defensible. Default: reopenable sources, not a style guide.

Can I do this without a niche?

You can try. You will be slower and worse. Start where you already know which sources lie. Default: one niche you can name in five words.

When do I raise the price?

After three on-time briefs at the current fee, if you are turning work away or the decisions are heavier. Not after one compliment. Default: \$300 to \$450, not a leap to \$2,000.

Do I need a website?

No. A form, a sentence, and three asks. Default: no site in week one.

What if they send a 40-page dump of files?

Name the three documents you will open. The rest is out. That is the \$450–\$600 version. Default: do not pretend you read forty pages in 48 hours.

Can I hire a researcher?

Not for month one. Default: you open the links.

What if the model invents a source that looks real?

You open it. If it 404s, you delete the claim. This will happen. Default: no citation you did not open.

Should I record a walkthrough of the brief?

Only as a \$75 extra, in writing. The product is the file. Default: file only.

What if I am late?

Tell them as soon as you know. Refund, or finish with their written OK on a new time. Default: refund a silent late.

Can this become my whole business?

Five to ten briefs a month around a job is a real number. Default: stack briefs, do not hire a desk.



PATH 19

Automation setups

A named setup that still runs a week later. Not "I'll automate your company."

36 minute read · 7,873 words

Who this is for

You can connect a model to email, a sheet, or a form without setting their building on fire. You have built at least one of these for yourself.

Time to first

7–21 days

Tools

First sale

One paid setup that still runs a week later without you in the Slack.

Cash window

\$400–\$2,500 named setups

Leave this alone

Make, Zapier, n8n, or native Claude/ChatGPT connectors. A form they already use. A runbook page. Open-ended retainers with no named job. God-mode logins. Sending without a human check on day one.

What this actually is

You sell a named machine. Lead form to draft reply. Weekly report to Slack. Invoice reminder that waits for a human. The name is the product. "I'll automate your company" is how you vanish into their operations and never send a second invoice.

A setup is done when it still runs a week later without you in the Slack. You hand off a one-page runbook. You support it for 14 days. Then it is theirs, or they buy a new named package.

The work is not "adding AI." The work is design, least privilege, tests with fake data, an off switch a tired owner can find, and a week of drafts that did not embarrass them. If you cannot write the before and after on one line, you do not have an offer. You have a hobby with logins.

What this is not

It is not an operations overhaul. It is not a retainer that says "automations as needed." It is not sitting in their inbox as a junior assistant. It is not rebuilding their website so leads "capture properly" unless they paid for that as a different job.

It is not a Zap you click together on a sales call and walk away from. A \$20/month tool with no owner is cheaper than you and worse. You are selling the named job, the tests, and two weeks of you on the hook.

It is not sending mail, posting, or charging without a human check on day one. Native buttons without a runbook are how a junior sends a wrong quote at 6am.

Why this works now

Forms, inboxes, and sheets already sit in every small shop. Models made a decent first draft cheap. What those shops do not have is a pipe that drafts in their voice, waits for a tap, and can be paused on a Thursday without calling a developer. That pipe is the setup.

Owners are tired of tools they turned on and then feared. They have been burned by a message that went out wrong, or by a workspace nobody owns. Trust is the actual product. The first time an automated message goes to the wrong person, they will not remember your cleverness. They will remember that you had no off switch.

You do not need an agency site. You need one machine you can demo on your own accounts, a price, and two people with messy inboxes.

Three anti-patterns

The first anti-pattern is god-mode. You take admin access "to do it right" and become the person who resets 2FA. Least privilege is slower on Tuesday and cheaper for the rest of the year.

The second is automating a process that has never been done manually. If they have never replied to a lead by hand, you are not automating a job. You are debugging a fantasy. Make them do it twice on paper, or pick a different machine.

The third is the unnamed retainer. "I'll hop in the workspace." That sentence has no done. Fourteen days of break-fix on a named flow has a done. "Automations as needed" is a salary they forget to pay.

The deal you keep

You keep one named flow, scoped to named tools, in writing. You keep a human check on anything that sends, posts, or charges until they ask in writing to remove it. You keep a one-page runbook with the off switch in the first paragraph. You keep a 14-day support window, then you leave extra access. You keep the right to quote a second machine as a second job. That deal is the business.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you can connect a model to email, a sheet, or a form without setting their building on fire. You have built at least one of these for yourself. You can draw the flow on one page. You know what least privilege means, even if you learned it the embarrassing way.

You will write a runbook. People who hate documentation should pick a different path. The runbook is not extra. It is half the product. A machine nobody can pause is a liability with your name on it.

This fits you if

You already use Make, Zapier, n8n, or a native Claude or ChatGPT connector for a real job, not a tutorial.

You can explain an off switch in two sentences.

You will test with fake data you own, never with their real customers.

You can sit through a twenty-minute walkthrough without turning it into a webinar.

You have two people who have complained, in your hearing, about a form that dumps into a void.

Skip this path if

Skip it if you want an open-ended retainer with no named job. Skip it if you have never tested with fake data. Skip it if you need god-mode logins to feel useful. Skip it if the process has never been done manually.

Skip it if you need cash this week. A brief or a productized service is faster. This path takes 7–21 days to a first paid setup because access, testing, and the runbook are the work. A demo on your laptop is not a first sale. The first sale is a machine that still ran on day 8.

Skip it if you will not write a one-page runbook. If documentation feels beneath you, you will ship a clever branch you cannot explain, and you will get an 11pm text in week three.

The honest middle

If you have a Make scenario for your own leads that has run for a month, that is the product. Record eight minutes of it. Price it. Offer it to two people. You are not waiting to become an "AI ops" firm. You are waiting to name the machine and put a deposit on it.

If you have only built tutorial zaps, build one on your own form this week. Fake names. Approval on. Runbook. Then sell that shape. Do not learn a new tool on their dime.

Skills and time

You need evenings for the demo and the one-pager, then a build week that can absorb access delays. The build itself is often two or three focused sessions. The calendar time is longer because they are slow with logins. Plan for that. Support days are break-fix, not a second job, but you must be reachable for 14 days.

You need to talk about permissions without flinching. "I need the form, the one inbox or label, and the one sheet. Not your Google admin." If that sentence feels rude, this path will train you into god-mode.

Two-minute self-test

Answer these out loud. If two are blank, skip this path this month.

Name one machine in one line, with a before and after.

Name the off switch in two sentences.

Name the tool you can demo this week on your own accounts.

Name two people with a messy inbox or a form that dumps into a void.

Say what you will not access, even if they offer the admin password.

If all five have answers, record the demo today. If the off switch is fuzzy, you have nothing to sell yet.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this before you open Make: "Named setup: [trigger] to [result] with your approval. Tools: [named]. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$[price]."

Kai's sentence is the default: "Named setup: form to draft reply with your approval. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750." Yours can swap the machine. Keep the shape. If it needs a paragraph, split it into two products and sell one.

Five sentences you can copy

Named setup: Tally or Typeform to Gmail draft with your approval. Make plus Claude. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750.

Named setup: weekly sheet of closed jobs to a Slack post every Monday 8am. Zapier plus their existing sheet. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750.

Named setup: unpaid invoice in Stripe or their sheet to a draft reminder in Gmail, never sent until they tap. \$750.

Named setup: new Google review to a draft reply in a Doc, with approval before anything posts. \$750.

Named setup: job application form to a row in a sheet plus a Slack ping, no auto-reject, human next. \$1,200 if the sheet is already a mess.

Write yours with a trigger they already have. Do not write "AI operations for growing teams." That is not a machine.

What they get

One named flow, scoped to named tools, in writing.

A one-page diagram before you build.

Tests with fake data you own.

Human approval on anything that sends, posts, or charges, until they ask in writing to remove it.

A one-page runbook: how to pause, how to know it broke, who to ping during the 14 days.

A twenty-minute walkthrough where they pause it once with you watching.

Fourteen days of break-fix after handoff. Then a new package if they want more.

What they do not get

Rewiring their whole company. Unlimited extra zaps. Sitting in their inbox as a junior assistant. Keeping their passwords in your password manager forever. Sending without approval on day one. A new CRM as a prerequisite. A second language, a second brand, or a Slack fork "while we are in there." If they want a second machine, it is a second quote.

They also do not get you on call after day 14 unless they buy a check-in. Watching it is how you become unpaid ops.

Packaging

One named machine. Price on a one-pager. 50 percent to start, 50 percent on handoff. Tools named. What is out named. Support end date named.

Do not sell a \$99 special that cannot pay for the runbook. Do not quote one price for "all the zaps they might want." Do not throw in a website rebuild. If they need a form that does not exist, you may stand up a Tally form as part of the \$750 if you write it in the scope. That is still one machine, not a digital transformation.

What done looks like

Done is a setup that still runs on day 8 without you poking it. The client can pause it without calling you. The runbook is in a folder they own. Your access is the least they needed, and you have a calendar reminder to remove yourself after the support window if they do not need you.

Done is not "the zap turned green on my laptop." A demo on your accounts is a sales asset. The first sale is their machine, in their tools, still drafting a week later.

The fairness test

You do not log in "just to check." They send you a screenshot or a sample output from the week. If it failed silently, the runbook failed. You fix that inside the 14 days as support, then you write the failure into the runbook so it does not stay tribal knowledge.

Fairness also means they can pause it. If they cannot find the toggle without you, you are not done, even if the drafts look pretty. Fairness means the diagram matches what you built. A clever branch you did not draw is a gift they did not ask for and a bug you will own at 11pm.

Technical done

Diagram, runbook, and tool logins they control.

Off switch labeled in the first paragraph of the runbook, with a screenshot.

Fake-data tests saved.

Human approval on send, post, or charge.

They paused it once in front of you.

Support end date in writing. Not "I'm around."

Remaining invoice sent at handoff.

Day 8: they confirm it ran. Day 14: extra access removed.

Not done yet

You are still in their Google admin.

Approval is off because it "felt smoother."

The runbook is a 19-page novel, or it does not exist.

You tested by mailing a real customer.

They have not paused it themselves.

A password lives in a Google Doc titled "logins."

You added Slack "while you were there" without a quote.

Day 8 is quiet because you are afraid to ask, and you keep peeking.

Support quietly became a new feature.

If any of those are true, you do not call it shipped. You finish the handoff or you stop and refund the unused part. There is no "I'll watch it for a bit."

Pricing

The cash window is \$400–\$2,500 for named setups. Kai charges \$750 for form-to-draft-reply with approval, runbook, and 14-day support. Copy that until you have a reason not to. Put the number on the one-pager.

Ranges

\$400–\$500 if the flow is one trigger, one model call, one destination, and you already built it for yourself. First paid job only. Then move up.

\$750 for the default: form or inbox in, draft out, human approval, runbook, 14 days. This is Kai. This is you unless the tools are uglier.

\$1,200–\$2,500 if there are three tools, a messy existing sheet, or a compliance reason you have to move slowly. Still one named machine. Not a department.

Do not sell hourly "I'll hop in the workspace." Do not sell a retainer that says "automations as needed." Do not sell a \$99 special. They are not buying a zap. They are buying design, least privilege, tests, a runbook, and two weeks of you on the hook.

When to raise

After three setups that survived day 30, if you are turning work away or the tools got uglier. Raise \$750 to \$1,200 for messy sheets and three-tool jobs. Stay at \$750 for the clean form-to-draft you can now do in two sessions. Raise because the job is heavier, not because you bought a new tool.

If you charged \$500 once for a friend case, the next one is \$750. No story.

Refunds in one sentence

If it never ran on their accounts, or you cannot hand them a pause they can use, you refund. You do not refund because they dislike a draft the model wrote; that is why approval exists.

Never charge for these

Never charge to "look at their ops and see." That is a discovery you will not productize in month one. Never charge for a second flow inside the first fee. Never charge a monthly "I'll watch it" until several named setups have survived day 30, and even then name the hours and the machines. Never charge extra for the runbook. The runbook is the product. Never keep their tool bills inside your fee. They pay Zapier. You say that on the one-pager.

Worked dollars

Kai's first paid setup: \$750 in (\$375 to start, \$375 on handoff), a week of calendar time, maybe six to ten hours of real work including the walkthrough and runbook. Day 8 the drafts were still landing. That is the sale.

Three \$750 machines in a month is \$2,250 if you can staff the support windows without stacking three day-14s on the same Friday. Two at \$1,200 because the sheet was a mess is \$2,400 with more grinding. Worked dollars go up when you stop discounting the runbook and stop staying after day 14 "in case."

The first 72 hours

Do not hunt a client on day one. Demo on your own accounts first. A machine you cannot pause on your own login is not a product.

Day 1 morning: pick one setup and draw it

Form to draft reply is the cleanest first machine. You already understand email. The approval step is obvious. Draw it on one page: form submit, Make or Zapier, model with a voice doc, Gmail draft (not send), human taps Send. Circle the off switch. If you cannot draw the off switch, you do not collect a deposit later.

Write the voice rules in twelve lines, not a brand book. "Six sentences max. No 'excited to potentially explore.'" That file is what you will hand a client to edit.

Day 1 afternoon: build it on your accounts

Build it on your own form, your own inbox, a dummy customer name like "Test River." Submit four times. First drafts will be too long. Cut the voice doc. Save the fake-data tests. Put approval on. Practice pausing the scenario. If you cannot pause your own scenario, you have nothing to sell.

Day 1 night: record eight minutes

Record your screen: form submit, draft appears, you approve, mail would send. Stop the recording before you philosophize. Eight minutes. This is the sales asset. You will send it to two

people, not to the internet as a course.

Day 2: price and a one-pager

Write the sentence. \$750. Tools named: for example "Typeform or Tally, Gmail or Outlook, Claude or ChatGPT, Make or Zapier." One page: in, out, approval, runbook, 14 days, what is not included. Payment: 50 percent to start, 50 percent on handoff. They pay their tool bills. You say that on the page.

Do not design a logo. Do not pick an agency name. Sentence, tools, price, deposit.

Day 3: two offers, not ten

Send it to two people with messy inboxes. Not ten. Two who have complained in your hearing. "You said the lead form dumps into a void. I set up form-to-draft-reply with your approval. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750. I can demo on my accounts this week." Attach or link the eight-minute recording if they want proof.

If they want a different machine, you may swap the name only if you can demo that one too. Do not invent a custom empire because they sounded excited. If both say no, send the same sentence to two more from the same pile on Friday. Do not spend Day 3 rewriting the offer into "AI operations."

The path, step by step

Do these in order. Building before the diagram is how you ship a clever knot. Collecting access before the deposit is how you work for free.

Name the machine in one line. If it needs a paragraph, split it into two products and sell one. "Form to draft reply with your approval" is a name. "Make their ops run on AI" is not. Write the before and the after. If you cannot, you are not selling yet.

Diagram on one page before you build. Trigger, tools, approval, destination, off switch. If you cannot draw the off switch, do not collect a deposit. The diagram is what you will paste into the invoice and the runbook. Keep it ugly and true.

Scope the tools in writing. "Make plus Gmail plus Claude" is a scope. "Whatever we need" is how invoices die. Name the form, the inbox or label, the model, the automation tool. They pay those bills. You say so.

Take a deposit. Then request access. Least privilege: the form, the one inbox or label, the one sheet. Not their Google admin. Not their personal inbox if a label will do. Write the access list in the same email as the invoice. If they send the admin password anyway, refuse it.

Build in a test environment. Fake names, fake emails you own, a dummy Slack channel. Never test by mailing their real customers. Submit four times. Save the runs. If the first drafts are wrong, you fix the voice doc, not the customer's reputation.

Put a human check on anything that sends, posts, or charges. They can ask to remove it later, in writing, after they have seen a week of drafts. If they want send-without-check on day one, you still run a week of approvals first. That is the deal.

Write the runbook: how to pause, how to know it broke, where the logs live, what "looks wrong" means in one example, who you are until day 14. One page. Screenshots of the toggle. A 19-page novel is how nobody pauses it.

Walk them through it live, twenty minutes, not a lecture. They pause it once with you watching. If they cannot pause it, you are not done. They submit one real or friend inquiry while you watch. A draft lands. They edit a sentence. That is the handoff moment.

Handoff in a folder they own. Invoice the rest. Calendar the 14-day end date and a day-8 check. Put the support end date in the runbook and in the email. Not "I'm around."

Support for 14 days is break-fix and small clarifications, not new features. A new branch in the flow is a new quote. Write down every change you made. That list is either a runbook update or a quote for setup two.

Day 8: they confirm it ran. You do not log in "just to check" unless they cannot send a screenshot. If it failed silently, you add a simple alert: an email when a run errors, or a daily count in a sheet. Then you write that into the runbook.

Day 14: you ask if they want a second named setup. If not, remove extra access you no longer need. Leave them as admin of their tools. Do not stay "in case." Watching it is unpaid ops.

Only then write an SOP for yourself so the second client is faster. Do not productize a setup you have never kept alive for a week. The SOP is your notes, not a course.

After three living setups, decide whether \$750 still matches the hours. If messy sheets ate you, the next messy one is \$1,200. If form-to-draft is now two sessions, keep it at \$750 and take more of them.

Keep a one-line log: date, machine name, fee, day-8 ran Y/N, support touches, still running at day 30. That log is how you know whether to raise, tighten scope, or stop. A sheet with five rows is enough. Do not buy a CRM for three clients.

Stop selling if a machine dies after you leave and you respond by moving back in. Fix the runbook and the off switch. If you cannot leave, you did not sell a setup. You sold a dependency.

A worked example: Kai's \$750 form-to-draft

Kai helps a three-person studio that takes project inquiries through a Tally form. The form currently emails everyone, and replies happen two days later, or not. The owner asked Kai to "put AI on our intake." Kai refused that sentence and sold a named setup instead.

Week minus one: demo on Kai's accounts

Monday, Kai draws form to Gmail draft with approval. Tuesday, Kai builds it on a personal Tally form and a dummy label. Dummy name: "River Test / never-use-this@kai.example." First drafts are too long. Voice doc gets a line: "Six sentences max." Wednesday, Kai records eight minutes. Thursday, Kai writes the one-pager at \$750, half to start. Friday, Kai messages two people. One is the studio owner who already complained.

The one-pager Kai sent

Named setup: form to draft reply with your approval. Tally to Gmail draft (not send) via Make. Claude writes the draft from a 12-line studio voice doc. You click Send. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750. Half to start. You pay Make and Claude. Out: Slack, CRM, a second language, sending without approval.

The owner pays \$375. Kai asks for: Tally editor access, a Gmail label "Leads-drafts," and a shared Doc with three good replies they liked last year. Not the whole Google org. Not the client's personal inbox.

Build week, and the mistake

Monday: diagram. One page. Form submit to Make to Claude (voice doc plus form fields) to Gmail draft in the label to human sends. Off switch: a Make scenario toggle, circled in red, screenshot in the runbook.

Tuesday: fake data. Four submits. Drafts improve. Then Kai almost ships the first real mistake. The owner is eager and forwards a live inquiry "to try it." Kai has not turned on the draft-only path in the studio's Make yet. A send step is still live from a copy-paste. Kai catches it because the test email is Kai's. Kai deletes the send module, locks draft-only, and writes in the runbook: never connect a send step in week one. That catch is the product. Testing on a real customer would have been the end of the path.

Wednesday: walkthrough, twenty minutes. Owner pauses the scenario and unpauses it. Kai watches. Owner files a real inquiry from a friend's form. Draft lands. Owner edits one sentence and sends. Kai invoices the remaining \$375.

The runbook, what it actually says

How to pause: Make, scenario "Lead drafts," toggle off. Screenshot. How to know it broke: no draft in the label within ten minutes of a test submit. How to test: a form password Kai set, used only for tests. Who to ping until [date 14 days out]. What Kai will not do after that date without a new package: add Slack, add a second language, wire it to the CRM.

Day 8 and day 14

Day 8 the owner forwards three drafts that went out. One was too stiff; Kai tightens the voice doc inside support, not as a new product. Day 14 Kai removes Tally access, leaves the owner as Make admin, and asks if they want invoice reminders as a second named setup at \$750. Owner says later. Kai does not stay in the workspace "in case." The machine still runs. That is the first paid sale: \$750, still drafting on day 8.

The first stranger sale

Two weeks later the studio's bookkeeper mentions Kai to a two-person shop with a Typeform that dumps into a shared inbox. Kai sends the same one-pager. They pay \$375. Different form tool, same machine name. Kai demos the eight-minute recording, swaps Tally for Typeform in the diagram, and does not invent a CRM. Handoff on a Thursday. Remaining \$375. Day 8 they forward two drafts. That is the first stranger sale: \$750, on time, from a name Kai did not already work with. Kai still does not offer a retainer.

Copy you can actually send

Use these. Swap the machine. Do not add "AI-powered ops." Do not add a biography.

Post

You said the lead form dumps into a void. I set up form-to-draft-reply with your approval so nothing sends until you tap it. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750. I can demo on my accounts this week.

DM

Named setup: form to draft reply with your approval. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750. Half to start. I will not take admin access. I will not send without your tap. If the form is a mess, send me two sentences about what happens now.

Page hero

A named machine. Form to draft. Your approval. A runbook you can pause. 14 days of support. \$750.

Checkout line

\$750. 50 percent to start, 50 percent on handoff. In: one form, one draft destination, one model, human approval, one-page runbook, 14 days of break-fix. Out: extra tools, extra flows, sending without approval, retainers. You pay your Zapier or Make bill.

Email 1, the ask

Subject: Form to draft reply — \$750

You said the lead form dumps into a void. I set up form-to-draft-reply with your approval so nothing sends until you tap it. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750. Half to start. I can demo on my accounts this week. If you want a different named machine, say the trigger and the result in one line.

Email 2, deposit in

Subject: Access list for [machine name]

Deposit is in. I need only: [form editor], [one inbox or label], [voice doc]. Not admin. I will diagram on one page, test with fake data I own, then walk you through a pause. Support ends [date] after handoff. New branches are a new quote.

Email 3, handoff

Subject: [Machine name] is yours — support until [date]

Folder: diagram, runbook, voice doc. Off switch is the first paragraph of the runbook. You paused it with me on [date]. Remaining invoice is attached. Day 8 I will ask for a screenshot that it ran. Day 14 I remove extra access. Break-fix until [date]. New features are a new quote.

Refund email

Subject: Refund for [machine name]

The setup never ran on your accounts / you cannot pause it without me. I am refunding [amount]. I will remove my access today. You do not need to reply.

What you do not write

"I'll automate your ops." "Unlimited zaps." "Set and forget forever." "I just need admin access to everything." Those sentences are how this path becomes a second unpaid job.

Week-by-week if you have a job

You can do this around a job if you protect two evenings in week 1 and a build block in week 2. Support is 14 days of being reachable, not 14 days of building.

Week 1

Day 1: pick the machine. Draw the off switch. Build the demo on your accounts. Fake data.

Day 2: record eight minutes. Write the \$750 one-pager. Test that you can pause your own scenario.

Day 3: two offers to people with messy inboxes. Send the recording if they ask.

Day 4: follow one non-reply with a single line. Do not rewrite the offer into a retainer.

Day 5: if a yes arrives, send the invoice for 50 percent. Do not request access before the deposit.

Day 6–7: if no yes, two more asks from the same pile. Do not start a website. Do not learn n8n if you already demo in Make.

Week 2

Day 8: deposit in. Access list, least privilege. Diagram in their folder.

Day 9–10: build on fake data. Approval on. No real customers.

Day 11: runbook. Screenshot of the toggle. Support end date written.

Day 12: twenty-minute walkthrough. They pause it. They see one draft. Invoice the rest.

Day 13–14: calendar day 8 and day 14 of the support window. Do not start a second client in the same week unless the first machine is already drafting.

Week 3

Support window. Break-fix only. Write down every change. Voice-doc tweaks are support. Slack and CRM are quotes. Day 8 of their machine: they send a screenshot. If it failed silently, add a

simple alert and put it in the runbook.

Week 4

Day 14: extra access removed. Ask once about a second named setup. If the first machine still runs, you may repeat the offer to two more people. If it does not run, you do not sell a second one. You fix your process. Log fee, day-8, support touches.

The quality bar

The bar is a machine a non-technical owner can pause, and a week of drafts that did not embarrass them. Clever is how you get an 11pm text in week three.

Below the bar

No diagram, or the diagram does not match the build.

No off switch, or they cannot find it.

Approval off on day one.

Tested on a real customer.

Admin access "because it was easier."

Runbook missing, or a 19-page novel.

Secrets in a shared Doc titled "logins."

Silent failure with no way they would know by tomorrow.

You still in the workspace after day 14 with no package.

A second flow shipped "while you were there."

Above the bar

One named machine. Tools named. Deposit taken.

Fake-data tests saved.

Approval on.

One-page runbook, screenshots of the toggle, support end date.

They paused it once in front of you.

Day 8 it ran without you poking it.

Day 14 extra access gone.

Simple alert if a run errors.

New features quoted, not gifted.

Five tests before you call it shipped

The pause test. They turn it off and on without you typing.

The fake-data test. Four submits to addresses you own. No real customer on the thread.

The match test. Diagram equals build. No surprise branches.

The day-8 test. They send a sample from the week. You did not log in to go fishing.

The leave test. You can remove extra access on day 14 and the machine still runs, because they own the tools.

If you fail one test, you are not "basically done." You fix it or you do not invoice the rest.

What to count

Count a short list. Module counts are vanity. Clients do not buy modules. They buy a named job that does not catch fire.

Week 1

Demo exists on your accounts: yes or no.

Off switch works on your login: yes or no.

One-pager live at \$750: yes or no.

Asks sent: target 2–4.

Deposits: target 1. A demo is not a sale.

Day 30

Setups handed off: target 1–2.

Day-8 ran without you: yes or no. This is the first-sale definition.

Real drafts or actions in week one. Zero means the trigger is wrong or they stopped feeding the form.

Support touches in 14 days. More than five usually means the runbook is thin or you sold a process they do not actually run.

Average fee. If you are stuck at \$400 after three, you are discounting the runbook away.

Extra access removed on day 14: yes or no.

Day 90

Machines still running at day 30 — ask once, do not babysit. Target: most of them.

Stranger sales: at least 1.

Fee at \$750 or \$1,200, not \$400.

Zero open retainers unless machines are named and hours are capped.

One SOP you actually reuse.

If day 90 is empty, you demoed and did not ask, or you asked people with no form and no inbox pain. Stop building tools. Send the sentence.

Ignore

How many modules the scenario uses. How "AI" the landing page sounds. Time spent choosing between Make and Zapier after you already have a demo. Compliments that are not a day-8 screenshot.

One-line spreadsheet

Date | machine name | fee | deposit date | handoff date | day-8 ran Y/N | support touches | day-14 access removed Y/N | still running day 30 Y/N

That is the whole system.

Objections you will hear — including your own

Reply once. Do not hold an architecture review in the thread.

"Can't they just turn on ChatGPT in the inbox?"

They can turn on a lot of things. They hired you so it drafts in their voice, waits for approval, and can be paused. Native buttons without a runbook are how a junior sends a wrong quote at 6am.

"\$750 feels high for a zap."

They are not buying a zap. They are buying design, least privilege, tests, a runbook, and two weeks of you on the hook. A \$20/month tool with no owner is cheaper and worse.

"They want it to send automatically."

Not on day one. Run a week of approvals. If they still want send-without-check, get it in writing, add a holdout (never mail a list they did not just submit), and keep the off switch obvious.

"I need admin access to do it right."

You need the least access that makes the named machine work. Admin access is how you become the person who "also" resets everyone's 2FA. Refuse god-mode.

"What if it breaks after day 14?"

They have the runbook. They can pay for a new package. You may sell a \$150 check-in. You may not pretend you are on call forever because you feel responsible for software they own.

"Can't you just do all our zaps?"

That is three machines or a \$2,500 scope with a written diagram. Default to one flow. You can stack later. One price for "all the zaps they might want" is how invoices die.

"We don't have a form."

Then the named setup is not form-to-draft. Sell a different named machine, or stand up a Tally form as part of the \$750 if you write it in the scope. Do not wander into a website rebuild.

"I don't write runbooks."

Then this is not your path. The runbook is half the product. A machine nobody can pause is a liability. Write one page or pick a different offer.

"Can I keep access so I can watch it?"

Not after day 14 unless they buy a check-in package. Watching it is how you become unpaid ops.

"What if the model writes a bad draft?"

That is why approval exists. Tighten the voice doc inside the 14 days. If they want a whole new tone for a second brand, that is a new quote.

What this feeds — and what feeds it

Keep the machine named. The minute you become "our automation person," you are on a salary they forget to pay.

What feeds a first automation job

A productized service client who is drowning in a form. A local business you already wrote posts for. A brief (path 18) whose next step was "configure the pipe," quoted separately. Yourself — the demo on your accounts is the sales asset. Cold "automation agency" ads are not how a kitchen-table operator gets job one.

People who already pay for Make, Zapier, or a model, and stall on the blank scenario, are easier than people who need you to sell them the whole stack.

What a living setup feeds

A second named machine for the same client, quoted separately. Invoice reminders after lead drafts. Slack after email. Always a new sentence.

A custom project setup (path 20) if they also need the model configured, not just the pipes.
New quote.

Notes that become a playbook or a template for a narrower audience, later, after you have done it three times.

A \$150 check-in, named, after day 30, if they ask. Not an open retainer in week two.

What not to feed

Do not feed a hosted-automation business where the scenario lives in your account. If you leave, the machine should not. Do not feed a staff workshop into the \$750. Do not use the runbook as a lead magnet with their voice doc still in it.

Mistakes that kill this path

God-mode logins. No off switch. Automating a process that has never been done manually. Leaving secrets in a shared doc. Those still kill it. The rest kill it more slowly.

Ten mistakes and the recovery this week

Starting to build before the diagram and the deposit. Recovery: stop. Draw the page. Send the invoice. Do not touch their tools until half is in.

Testing on real customers. Recovery: disconnect send. Rerun on fake addresses you own. If a real person got mail, say so, apologize, and put draft-only in the runbook today.

Skipping the approval step to look advanced. Recovery: turn approval on before the next run. Tell them why. A week of drafts is the deal.

A runbook that is a 19-page novel, or missing. Recovery: one page tonight. Pause, broken, logs, support end date. Screenshot of the toggle.

Support that quietly becomes new features. Recovery: send "That is a second machine. I can quote \$750." Then stop building it inside the first fee.

Staying in their workspace after day 14 "just in case." Recovery: remove extra access today. Offer a named check-in if they panic. Do not linger.

Quoting one price for "all the zaps they might want." Recovery: split the list into named machines. Sell one. Park the rest.

A password in a Google Doc titled "logins." Recovery: rotate the password. Move it to a password manager they own, or sit with them while they type it. Then delete the Doc.

Automating a job nobody does by hand. Recovery: pause the build. Have them do the job twice manually. If they will not, cancel and refund unused.

Taking admin because they offered it. Recovery: drop to the form, the label, the one sheet. Write the access list again. Refuse the rest.

Silent failure with no alert. Recovery: add an error email or a daily count. Put it in the runbook this week.

Learning a new automation tool on their dime. Recovery: finish this job in the tool you can demo. Learn the other one on your accounts next month.

If you catch yourself in any of these, the recovery is this week, not after you "stabilize the client." The client is not stabilized. The scope is.

Tools — only what you need

Pick one automation tool and get good at it. Make, Zapier, or n8n. Native Claude or ChatGPT connectors are enough for some jobs and better when the client already pays for them.

Whichever you can demo this week on your own accounts wins. Do not learn a new tool on their dime. If they already pay for one, prefer that.

Exact stack

One automation tool you can demo.

A form they already click (Tally, Typeform, native).

An email box or Slack channel they already live in.

A Doc for voice and the runbook.

Loom or a phone recording for the eight-minute demo and the walkthrough.

Stripe for the deposit and the rest.

A password manager they own. Not a shared Doc.

A calendar reminder for day 8 and day 14.

Setup order

Demo on your accounts, including pause.

Eight-minute recording.

One-pager at \$750, deposit language, tool bills are theirs.

Two asks.

Deposit, then access list.

Diagram in their folder.

Build on fake data.

Runbook, walkthrough, handoff.

Day 8, day 14.

What not to buy

Do not sell them a new CRM as a prerequisite. Do not rebuild their website to "capture leads properly" unless they paid for that as a different job. Do not buy an "AI agent platform" to look current. Do not buy a second automation tool so you can put logos on a page. The named setup uses what they already click.

The \$0 path

Use native connectors they already pay for (Gmail plus ChatGPT, or Claude plus a Google Sheet). A free Tally form. A free Make or Zapier tier if the volume fits, with the limit written down so nobody is surprised. Loom on a free plan, or your phone. Stripe or the payment tool you already

have. The \$0 path is for the demo and maybe job one. It is not an excuse to skip the runbook, the approval step, or the deposit.

Checklist

- Machine named in one line, before and after
- One-page diagram includes the off switch
- Tools listed in the quote
- They pay their Zapier or Make bill, written
- 50 percent deposit before access
- Least privilege, not admin
- Access list in the same email as the invoice
- Fake data tests saved, four submits
- Human approval on send, post, or charge
- Voice or rules doc they can edit
- Runbook: pause, broken, logs, support end date
- Screenshot of the toggle in the runbook
- They pause it once in front of you
- Twenty-minute walkthrough, not a lecture
- Handoff folder they own
- Remaining invoice at handoff
- Day 8 check: it still ran
- Simple alert if a run errors
- Day 14: extra access removed
- New features = new quote
- No secrets in a shared Doc
- No testing on real customers

Process has been done manually at least twice

Calendar for day 8 and day 14

One-line spreadsheet row filled

Second machine is a second sentence

You can leave and it still runs

FAQ

Make, Zapier, or n8n?

Whichever you can demo this week on your own accounts. Do not learn a new tool on their dime. If they already pay for one, prefer that. Default: the tool in your eight-minute recording.

What if they do not have a form?

Then the named setup is not form-to-draft. Sell a different named machine, or stand up a Tally form as part of the \$750 if you write it in the scope. Do not wander. Default: one machine, written.

Do I include the Zapier bill in my fee?

No. They pay their tool bills. You say that on the one-pager. Your \$750 is design, build, runbook, 14 days. Default: their accounts, their bills.

Can I keep access so I can "watch it"?

Not after day 14 unless they buy a check-in package. Watching it is how you become unpaid ops. Default: extra access removed on day 14.

What if the model writes a bad draft?

That is why approval exists. Tighten the voice doc inside the 14 days. If they want a whole new tone for a second brand, that is a new quote. Default: approval stays on.

Is \$750 too much for a first client who is a friend?

Charge \$500 once if you need a case, then \$750. Free is how friends get a machine you cannot afford to support. Default: \$750 after one discounted case.

Should I sell a monthly retainer?

Not until several named setups have survived day 30. Even then, name the hours and the machines. "Retainer for automations" is the leave-this-alone line. Default: named setups only in month one.

What if they want Slack, email, and the CRM in week one?

That is three machines or a \$2,500 scope with a written diagram. Default to one flow. You can stack later.

How do I handle API keys?

In their account. Not in yours. Not in a chat log. If a key leaked into a screenshot, rotate it before you go to bed. Default: their password manager.

When is the first sale "real"?

When the setup still runs a week later. A demo on your laptop is not a first sale. Kai's first sale was the studio's drafts on day 8. Default: day 8 yes.

What if they ghost after the deposit?

You still have the diagram and the access list. Email once. If access never arrives, the clock on your build does not start, and you keep the deposit for the week you held, or you refund if you wrote a different rule. Default: write the rule on the one-pager before the first dollar.

Do I have to be on Slack with them?

No. Email is enough. A shared Doc for the runbook is enough. Slack is how support becomes a second job. Default: email plus the runbook folder.

Can I use their live leads as tests?

No. Fake names, fake emails you own. Default: never.

What if Make's native Gmail connector is enough and they do not want a model?

Then the machine might be form to labeled draft with a template, no model. Same product shape, maybe \$500–\$750. Do not force a model into a job that is a template. Default: name the job, not the model.

How long until I can productize this as a template?

After three living setups of the same machine. Generic runbook, no client voice docs. That is a later path. Default: do not sell a template of a setup you have run once.



PATH 20

Custom project setups

They want Claude Projects or Custom GPTs configured, not a lecture.

34 minute read · 7,538 words

Who this is for

Someone drowning in a blank project who will pay for a working one. You have already made a project you actually reuse.

Time to first

3–10 days

Tools

First sale

One setup a stranger can use without you in the room.

Cash window

\$97–\$297 per setup

Leave this alone

Claude Projects or Custom GPTs, a five-minute walkthrough recording, a \$197 button.

Selling access to a model you do not own. Keeping the project in your account so they have to stay.

What they actually buy

They buy instructions, files, and three starter chats that already work. You intake their actual job. You install it in an account they own. You test it. You record a five-minute walkthrough. You leave. They never need your login.

You are not reselling Claude. You are not reselling ChatGPT. You are selling configuration. Say that out loud so nobody is confused, including you. If your business requires them to keep using a project inside your account, you have built a hostage, not a product.

A blank project is a blinking cursor with extra steps. A configured one knows the job, the tone, the files it may use, and the three first prompts that produce something they recognize. The buyer should be able to open it on Thursday night and get a usable draft without writing a system prompt from scratch.

What this is not

It is not a course on prompt engineering. It is not a second brain with forty folders they will never open. It is not you wrapping someone else's model in a thin login screen and charging rent. Anthropic and OpenAI already sell the model. You sell the setup.

It is not a monthly "I host this for you." It is not training their whole staff. It is not connecting ten tools. If they want pipes into email, that is path 19, quoted separately. If they want you to run the job every week, that is a productized service, different number.

It is not a \$20 prompt they have to paste every time. A prompt they paste is not a project. Instructions plus files plus three working threads is a small appliance. Price the appliance.

Why this works now

The tools shipped a blank box and called it a product. People paid for the subscription, opened a project, and stared. They have watched a YouTube video. They have not configured the thing

for the job they actually do on Thursday. That gap is the \$197 setup.

You do not need a following. You need five people who already pay for the model and have said some version of "I never know what to put in the custom instructions." Cold strangers who will not pay for Claude will not pay you fairly either. You are not also selling them the model.

The work is short on purpose. Twenty minutes of intake. Instructions they can read. Three starters. Five minutes on video. A seven-day tweak window. Then you leave. The shortness is what makes it a product instead of a consulting engagement wearing a GPT.

Three anti-patterns

The first anti-pattern is hosting. They want it in your account so they do not have to pay for Claude. The answer is no. That is selling access to a model you do not own, plus a liability you cannot explain to a lawyer. Configure theirs. Leave.

The second is the second brain. You upload forty files "to be thorough." They never open the project again because it feels like a filing cabinet they did not ask for. Three starters they will run this week beat a knowledge base they will not maintain.

The third is mixing their confidential files into a sample you keep. Loading a client list into a project "to be helpful," or keeping copies "for the portfolio," is how you get a story you do not want. Follow their policy. When in doubt, do not upload. Paste per chat.

The deal you keep

You keep ownership in their account. You keep instructions they can edit without you. You keep three named starters that already return a draft a human would edit. You keep a five-minute walkthrough, not a webinar. You keep a seven-day tweak window that means instructions and starters, not a second job. You keep the right to delete their files from your machine on hand-off. That deal is the business.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you have already made a project or a custom GPT for yourself that you actually reuse. People around you have said some version of "I never know what to put in the custom instructions." You can sit in someone else's job for an hour without needing to become their employee.

You will hand the project over. Your name does not need to stay in the admin field. If you need their login after day eight, you did not hand off.

This fits you if

You can write instructions a tired person can read, not a wall of role-play.

You will hand the project over. Your name does not need to stay in the admin field.

You can record five minutes on a screen without turning it into a webinar.

You have five people who already pay for Claude or ChatGPT and stall on the blank box.

You can follow a data policy, including "do not upload that."

Skip this path if

Skip it if you planned to sell access to a model you do not own. Skip it if you want to keep their files in your account so they "have to stay." Skip it if you will load confidential client files into a model against their policy because it is easier. Skip it if you have never finished a project for your own job — do that first, then sell the shape.

Skip it if you freeze at the idea of asking five people. The page and the five asks are the path. A sample nobody sees is a hobby.

Skip it if you wanted to bundle automations, staff training, and a hosted GPT into \$197. That is a week of work at a setup price. Split it or pick a different path.

The honest middle

If you have a project you open every week for your own job, that is the sample. Record five minutes. Put \$197 on a page. Ask five people who already pay for the model. You are not waiting to become a prompt engineer. You are waiting to install the shape in an account that is not yours.

If you have only played with custom instructions once, configure one for a job you know this week. Fake files. Three starters. Then sell that job, not twelve industries.

Skills and time

You need one evening for the sample and the recording, one evening for the page, and five asks. Delivery is often one sitting plus the recording: intake, install in their account while they click, test a starter, send the walkthrough. The seven-day tweak window is one small change, not a redesign.

Writing skill here is short, editable instructions. If your natural mode is a 2,000-word role-play, this path will feel like cutting. That cut is the product. They should be able to change one line without breaking the rest.

Two-minute self-test

Answer these out loud. If two are blank, skip this path this month.

Name one job you have already configured a project for, that you still open.

Name five people who already pay for the model and stall on instructions.

Say, in one breath, that they own it and you do not keep a login.

Say what you will refuse to upload.

Record, in your head, the five minutes: open, starter, add a file, tweak one line, who owns it.

If all five have answers, build the sample today. If you cannot say they own it, you are about to build a hostage.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this and put it on the page: "I configure the [Claude Project or Custom GPT] for [named job]. You own it. Walkthrough included. \$[price]."

Jules uses: "I configure the project for your job. You own it. Walkthrough included. \$197." Keep it. The number can move inside \$97–\$297. The ownership cannot. If you need "and" to name the

job, you have two setups. Sell one.

Five sentences you can copy

I configure a Claude Project for solo bookkeepers who write collection and scheduling emails. You own it. Three starter chats. Five-minute walkthrough. \$197.

I configure a Custom GPT for one-person realtors who write listing descriptions from MLS notes. You own it. Walkthrough included. \$197.

I configure a Claude Project for a shop owner who drafts weekly Google posts from photos they already have. You own it. \$197.

I configure a Custom GPT for a solo accountant's month-end client questions, with a do-not-invent-a-balance rule. You own it. \$197.

I configure a Claude Project for two related jobs — listing draft and email follow-up — still in one project, picky tone, \$297.

Write yours with a job they will run this week. Do not write "a second brain for founders." That is a filing cabinet.

What they get

A 20-minute intake: the jobs, the files they are allowed to add, the tone.

Custom instructions they can read and edit.

Up to a small set of files they provide and approve.

Three starter threads that already return a decent first draft.

A five-minute walkthrough recording.

One tweak window of seven days. Tweak means instructions and starters, not a second job.

The project in their account. You leave.

What they do not get

Your Claude login. A monthly "I host this for you." Training their whole staff. Building a forty-file knowledge base they will not maintain. Connecting ten tools. Unlimited instruction rewrites.

A guarantee that the model will never change. If they want pipes into email, that is path

19, quoted separately. If they want you to run the emails each week, that is a service, different number.

They also do not get you as owner. Viewer for seven days if it helps them sleep. Then you leave.

Packaging

One job. One price on a button. \$197 default. What they must provide: the job, three tone samples, files they are allowed to upload, any data policy. What they own: the project. Stripe or Stan. Buy the button yourself from a second email so you know the confirmation works even if the "product" is a scheduled setup, not a zip.

Do not catalog twelve industries on the page. Do not add a membership around a setup you have done once. Do not throw automations into the \$197 so you work a week for a setup price.

What done looks like

Done is a setup a stranger can use without you. They open their own project. They click starter one. They get a draft they could send after a human edit. They know how to add a file and how to tweak a line of instructions because the walkthrough showed both.

Done is not pretty instructions in your account. Done is not a 40-minute training. Done is use-without-you, in their login, with your access removed.

The fairness test

Log out. Have them log in. Watch them run starter two without you typing. If they cannot, the walkthrough failed or the starters are cute instead of useful. Fix it inside the tweak window.

Fairness also means they can edit a line without breaking the rest. Instructions they are afraid to touch are a brochure. Fairness means files they consider confidential followed their policy, not your curiosity. Fairness means you are not the owner on day eight.

Technical done

Project created in their account. They clicked the buttons.

Instructions they can read and edit. Role, inputs, output shape, missing-info rule, do-not-invent rule.

Only approved files, dated, small.

Three named starter threads that already work.

They ran a starter without you typing.

Five-minute walkthrough delivered.

Seven-day tweak window in writing.

Your access removed. Their files deleted from your machine.

Not done yet

The project lives in your account "until they get set up."

Starter one needs a paragraph of extra prompting.

Instructions are a 2,000-word role-play.

You uploaded a client list they whispered about.

They have not run a starter without you.

Walkthrough is twelve minutes because you built too much.

You kept a copy of their phrases "for the portfolio."

They asked for a second job and you started it inside the \$197.

You are still admin after day eight.

If any of those are true, you do not call it handed off. You finish the install in their account or you stop and refund. There is no "I'll host it for now."

Pricing

The cash window is \$97–\$297 per setup. Jules charges \$197. That is the default button. Put it on the page. Do not hide it behind "DM me for a custom GPT."

Ranges

\$97 if you need the first case and the job is one you could configure in an hour. Once.

\$197 for a standard job: intake, instructions, three starters, five-minute walkthrough, one tweak window. Copy Jules.

\$297 if they have several file types, a tone that is actually picky, or two related jobs in one project (for example "listing draft" and "email follow-up") still inside one setup.

Do not charge \$20. That is a prompt, not a configuration. Do not charge \$1,000 unless you are also doing automations and a staff workshop, which is a different quote with a different name. Do not charge \$19/month for access to a GPT in your account. That is the leave-this-alone line.

When to raise

After five setups at \$197, if you are turning work away or the jobs got pickier. Move some work to \$297. Stay at \$197 for the clean one-job install you can now do in a sitting. Raise because the file types and tone got heavier, not because you added a membership.

If you charged \$97 once for a case, the next one is \$197. No story.

Refunds in one sentence

If they cannot run a starter in their own account without you, you refund. You do not refund because they dislike a draft the model wrote after they used it; you tweak instructions inside seven days.

Never charge for these

Never charge to host the model. Never charge rent on your login. Never charge for a forty-file dump they will not maintain, as if volume were quality. Never charge extra for the walkthrough. The walkthrough is the product. Never bundle path 19 automations into the \$197. Never charge \$20 so you can be sloppy.

Worked dollars

Jules's first paid setup: \$197 in, twenty minutes of intake, one screen-share install in Mara's account, a five-minute recording Jules already had, one three-line tweak in the window. That is

a sitting plus a recording. Five of those in a month is \$985 around a job. Three at \$297 because the tone was picky is \$891 with more grinding. Worked dollars go up when you stop hosting, stop overbuilding, and press \$197 instead of \$97 after the first case.

The first 72 hours

You do not need a catalog. You need a sample for a job you know, a \$197 button, and five asks.

Day 1 morning: a sample for a job you know

Build a sample project as if you were the client. Pick a job you have done: weekly posts, listing copy, invoice reminders, a study plan, follow-up emails. Write instructions in plain language. Role, inputs, output shape, what to ask if information is missing, what never to invent. Add one sample file you are allowed to use — fake names. Create three starter chats that already work. Name them in human language: "14-day reminder," not "prompt 1."

Day 1 afternoon: record five minutes

Open, pick a starter, add a file, change one instruction line, say who owns it. Do not record forty minutes. If you need twelve, you built too much. Cut a starter or a file until five minutes tells the whole story. This recording is the sales asset and, later, most of the hand-off.

Day 1 night: nothing else

Do not design a logo. Do not outline a course. The sample and the five minutes are the day's work. Go to bed with a project you would actually reuse.

Day 2: the \$197 button

One page. Sentence at the top. What they get. What they must provide (job, tone samples, files they are allowed to upload). What they own. Stripe or Stan at \$197. Buy it yourself from a second email so you know the confirmation works even if the "product" is a scheduled setup, not a zip.

Write the intake questions on the same page or in a form: the job (one primary), three examples of a tone they like, files they are allowed to add, any policy about data. "Do not send

confidential files you would not want in the model."

Day 3: five asks

Ask five people who complained about custom instructions. Direct messages, not a launch. "I configure the project for your job. You own it. Walkthrough included. \$197. If you want one, I'll send the intake." Do not explain five other services. Hand off so they never need your login.

If someone says they do not pay for Claude, do not argue. If someone wants you to "just write the emails each week," that is a service, different number. If someone says yes, schedule the install after they can log in. You do not sell them your account.

The path, step by step

Do these in order. Installing in your account "for now" is how you never leave. Uploading files they did not approve is how you get a story you do not want.

Pick the platform they already pay for. Claude Project or Custom GPT, not both, not a new app you invented. If they use both, pick the one for this job. Do not configure two for \$197. If they do not have a paid account, they need one. Send the signup link. Schedule the setup after they can log in.

Intake: the jobs (one primary), the files they are allowed to add, the tone in three samples they like, and any policy about data. Write it down. If they cannot name a job, sell them a cheaper pack instead. A 20-minute call or a clear form. Live is faster for hand-off. Jules uses twenty minutes live plus the recording.

Create the project in their account, or create it in yours only as a draft and copy the text over while they watch. They click the buttons. They own it. Screen share. You dictate, they paste. This is slower than you doing it in your login, and that slowness is the point.

Write instructions they can read. Role, inputs, output shape, what to ask if information is missing, what never to invent. Short. Under a page. They should be able to edit a line without breaking the rest. If you need four pages, you are writing a playbook and calling it a project.

Add only the files they approved. Do not scrape their Drive. Do not upload a client list they whispered about. Dated. Small. When in doubt, do not upload. Paste per chat. Write that in the intake.

Build three starter threads that already work: the three jobs they will actually open this week. Name the threads in human language. Not edge cases. Not "tell me about yourself." If starter one needs a paragraph of extra prompting, you failed the configuration.

Test with a real example they provided, or a fake one if policy says so. If the output is fluff, cut the instructions, do not add a fourth file. Leave something out on purpose once so you can see the missing-info rule fire. That is a quality check, not a trick.

Record a five-minute walkthrough: where it lives, how to run a starter, how to add a file, how to tweak one instruction, who owns it. Show the off-ramp: how they edit you out of the instructions later. If you already recorded the sample, add a 40-second ending: "this is yours, I'm not in the account."

Hand off. Confirm they can run it without you. Start the seven-day tweak window in writing. You may stay as invited viewer for seven days. You are not the owner.

One tweak, if they ask. Instruction and starter fixes. Not a redesign. Not a second project. Not "also build my content engine." Write that down.

Leave their account. Delete any copies of their files that landed on your machine. If you need their login after day eight, you did not hand off. Go back and finish.

After the first stranger uses it without you, write the intake as a form so job two is faster. Do not add a membership around a setup you have done once. The form is five fields, not a quiz.

After five setups, look at the log. If they never opened it two weeks later, you overbuilt or you sold to someone who wanted a course. If you are stuck at \$97, press \$197 and live with fewer yeses.

If three clients needed the same shape, that generic version (no client files) can become a skill pack, sold as a file. Different product. Do not mix a custom setup with a shared GPT you rent out.

Keep a one-line log: date, job, fee, they ran a starter without you Y/N, tweak was actually a second job Y/N, still opening it two weeks later. Ask once. Do not babysit.

Stop if you are still hosting, still admin, or still holding their files. Fix ownership this week. The path is configuration, not tenancy.

A worked example: Jules at \$197

Jules keeps hearing the same sentence from independent bookkeepers: "I opened a Claude Project and then I just... stared at it." Jules is not selling bookkeeping. Jules is selling a configured project for client follow-up emails.

Monday: the sample

Jules makes a project titled "Follow-up emails — sample." Instructions: you write collection and scheduling emails for a solo bookkeeper; you never invent a balance; you ask for the amount if it is missing; tone is plain, no "just circling back" stacks; max eight sentences. One sample file: a fake aged-receivables list with made-up names. Three starters: (1) 14-day reminder, (2) 30-day firmer note, (3) scheduling next month's close. Jules records five minutes. The \$197 button goes on a page Tuesday.

Tuesday: the button, then five asks

Jules buys the page from a second email. Confirmation arrives. Jules messages five bookkeepers who already complained. Two ignore. One says "I don't pay for Claude." Jules does not argue. One wants Jules to "just write the emails each week." That is a service, path 7, different number. One says yes: Mara, two days a week in her own books, already pays for Claude, hates the blank project.

Wednesday: intake, twenty minutes

Jobs: follow-up on unpaid invoices, and a short "what I need from you for month-end" note. Files Mara is allowed to add: her template phrases, not her real client spreadsheet. Policy: no client names in the project until Mara pastes them per chat. Tone: Mara forwards three emails she was proud of. Jules writes instructions from those, not from a persona Jules invented.

Wednesday, still: install in Mara's account

Screen share. Mara creates the project. Jules dictates, Mara pastes. Three starter chats Jules types while Mara watches, then Mara re-runs starter one on a fake invoice. It asks for the amount because Jules left it out on purpose. That is the quality check. Walkthrough recording is the same five minutes Jules already had, plus a 40-second ending: "this is yours, I'm not in the account."

Mara pays \$197. Tweak window through the next Wednesday.

The mistake, and the recovery

Jules almost makes the first real mistake after the call. Mara's three proud emails are sitting in Jules's downloads folder, and Jules's hand wants to keep them "as a tone sample for the next bookkeeper." That is their voice, not a generic pack. Jules deletes the folder the same afternoon. The fake receivables list stays in Jules's sample project. Mara's phrases do not. If Jules had kept them, the first stranger sale would have been built on a file Jules did not own.

Mara asks, inside the window, to soften starter two. Jules changes three lines. That is a tweak. Mara also asks whether Jules can "stay as admin so I don't break it." Jules says no. Viewer until next Wednesday. Then Jules leaves. Ownership is the product.

The first stranger sale

Mara mentions Jules in a bookkeeper group chat, without sharing the project. A stranger, Len, already pays for Claude, writes the same follow-ups, and buys the \$197 button on a Thursday. Intake is a form Jules wrote after Mara. Install is Friday screen share. Len runs starter two without Jules typing. \$197. No discount. Jules is not in the account on Monday. That is the first stranger sale: a working project in someone else's login, used without Jules in the room.

Jules does not keep a copy "for the portfolio" with Len's phrases in it. Jules shows the fake receivables list when people ask for a case.

Copy you can actually send

Use these. Swap the job. Do not add a lecture. Do not add "access my GPT."

Post

I configure the project for your job. You own it. Three starter chats that already work, and a five-minute walkthrough. \$197. I don't keep a login.

DM

You said you never know what to put in the custom instructions. I'll set up the project in your account for [job], with three starter chats that already work, and a five-minute walkthrough. \$197. You own it. I don't keep a login.

Page hero

A working Claude Project (or Custom GPT) for one job. Not a lecture. Not my account. \$197.

Checkout line

\$197. Intake, instructions you can edit, up to a small set of files you approve, three named starters, five-minute walkthrough, seven days for one tweak. You own the project. You need your own Claude or ChatGPT subscription. I am not selling the model.

Email 1, the ask

Subject: I'll configure the project — \$197

You said you never know what to put in the custom instructions. I'll set up the project in your account for [job], with three starter chats that already work, and a five-minute walkthrough. \$197. You own it. If you want one, reply with the job, three tone samples, and any files you are allowed to upload. Do not send confidential files you would not want in the model.

Email 2, intake booked

Subject: Setup on [date] — you will click the buttons

We will use your account. You create the project. I dictate, you paste. Bring: the job, three examples of a tone you like, files you are allowed to add. I will not take ownership. Walkthrough is five minutes. Tweak window is seven days after hand-off.

Email 3, hand-off

Subject: It's in your account — tweak window until [date]

It's in your account. Starters are named. Walkthrough is here: [link]. You have seven days for one tweak on instructions or starters. After that, a new job is a new setup. I am not in the account. Delete any files I should not have; I have deleted copies on my machine.

Refund email

Subject: Refund for [job] setup

You cannot run a starter in your account without me. I am refunding the \$197. I have removed any access I had. You do not need to reply.

What you do not write

"Access my GPT, \$19/month." "I'll host your brain." "Upload everything you have." Those are the leave-this-alone line and a policy problem.

Week-by-week if you have a job

You can do this around a job if you protect two evenings and one 45-minute screen share. The goal of the first month is three setups a stranger can use without you.

Week 1

Day 1: sample project for a job you know, tested, plus the five-minute walkthrough. Fake files only.

Day 2: page with a \$197 button. Test-buy from a second email. Intake questions on the page.

Day 3: three asks to people who already pay for the model.

Day 4: two more asks. Do not design a catalog of twelve industries.

Day 5: if a yes arrives, schedule intake after they can log in. Do not start in your account.

Day 6–7: deliver the first paid setup if the calendar says so, or rest. Do not start a "hosted GPT" idea because someone asked.

Week 2

Day 8–9: install in their account. They click. They run a starter without you typing. Walkthrough sent. Tweak window in writing.

Day 10: delete their files from your machine. Write the intake as a form.

Day 11–14: one tweak if they ask. Viewer access ends. You leave. Two more asks if you have no second buyer.

Week 3

Two more asks, or a second paid setup at \$197. Same ownership rules. If nobody buys, the job is too vague or you asked strangers who do not already pay for the model. Sell to people who already have the subscription. You are not also selling them Claude.

Week 4

Third setup or stop. Log fees, "ran without you," tweaks that were actually a second job. If three clients needed the same shape, note it for a later skill pack with generic files. Do not mix that pack with this custom setup. Ask once whether they still open the project. If they never opened it, you overbuilt or you sold a course to a person who wanted a lecture.

The quality bar

The bar is use-without-you. Pretty instructions that nobody runs are a brochure. Volume of knowledge files is not quality. Jules's bookkeeper project used phrases, not a dump of five years

of returns.

Below the bar

Project in your account.

2,000-word role-play they are afraid to edit.

Starters that only work if you are typing.

A 40-minute "training" instead of a five-minute walkthrough.

Confidential files they did not approve.

Forty folders they will never open.

Selling access to Claude as if you were the vendor.

Automations bundled into the \$197.

Copies of their files on your machine after hand-off.

You still admin after day eight.

Above the bar

Their account. They clicked.

Instructions under a page: role, inputs, output, missing-info, do-not-invent.

Three named starters that produce a draft a human would edit.

Approved files only, small, dated.

Five-minute walkthrough that shows ownership and how to edit you out.

They run a starter without you typing.

Seven-day tweak, then closed.

Your access gone. Their files gone from your machine.

Five tests before you leave

The log-out test. You are not in the room. They run starter two.

The edit test. They change one instruction line and it still works.

The missing-info test. You leave a number out. It asks. It does not invent.

The file test. Nothing in the project that they did not approve.

The five-minute test. The walkthrough is five minutes. If you need twelve, you built too much.

If you fail one test, you are not handed off. You fix it inside the sitting or inside the tweak window. You do not "stay as admin until they are comfortable." Comfort is them clicking, not you owning.

What to count

Count a short list. File counts are vanity. Jules used phrases, not a dump.

Week 1

Sample project tested: yes or no.

Five-minute walkthrough recorded: yes or no.

\$197 button test-bought: yes or no.

Asks sent: target 5.

Paid setups: target 1. A sample in your account is not a sale.

Day 30

Setups handed off: target 3.

They ran a starter without you: yes or no. That is the first-sale definition.

Tweak requests that are actually a second job. Those mean intake was soft.

Time from intake to hand-off. Target: inside a week, often one sitting plus the recording.

Average fee. If you are stuck at \$97 after five, press \$197 and live with fewer yeses.

Your access removed: yes or no.

Day 90

How many still open the project two weeks later — ask once. If they never opened it, you overbuilt or you sold a course.

Stranger sales: at least 1.

Fee at \$197 or \$297, not \$97.

Zero hosted GPTs.

Intake lives in a form.

One note about a generic skill pack, if three clients needed the same shape. Not built yet unless the custom work is boring in a good way.

If day 90 is empty, you asked people who do not pay for the model, or you never sent the five asks. Stop adding files to the sample. Send the sentence.

Ignore

How many knowledge files you uploaded. How long the instructions are past one page. Time spent naming a "studio." Compliments that are not a starter they ran.

One-line spreadsheet

Date | job in five words | fee | they ran starter without you Y/N | tweak was second job Y/N | access removed Y/N | still opening it two weeks later Y/N

That is the whole system.

Objections you will hear — including your own

Reply once. Do not hold a prompt-engineering seminar in the thread.

"They could watch a YouTube video."

They could. They have not. You are selling a configured job in their account in a week, not a lecture.

"Isn't this just writing a prompt?"

A prompt they have to paste every time is not a project. Instructions plus files plus three working threads is a small appliance. Price the appliance.

"They want it in my account so they don't have to pay for Claude."

No. That is selling access to a model you do not own. They need their own subscription. You configure it. If they will not pay the model, they will not pay you fairly either.

"What about confidential files?"

Follow their policy. When in doubt, do not upload. Paste per chat. Write that in the intake. Loading their client list into a project "to be helpful" is how you get a story you do not want.

"Can I productize one project and sell access to many buyers?"

That is a skill pack (path 2), with generic files, not their confidential ones. Different product. Do not mix a custom setup with a shared GPT you rent out.

"Is \$197 too low?"

It is a setup, not a month of service. If they want weekly-run work, sell path 7. If the setup is truly two jobs and picky files, \$297. Do not raise to \$1,000 for instructions.

"Can I do this over email only?"

Yes, if they write a clear intake. Live screen share is faster for hand-off. Jules uses twenty minutes live plus the recording. Default: live for job one.

"They want me to stay as admin."

No. Viewer for seven days if it helps them sleep. Then you leave. Ownership is the product. If they are afraid to click, the walkthrough failed. Fix the walkthrough, do not take the keys.

"What if the model changes next month?"

You guarantee a working configuration at hand-off and one tweak week. After that, they own the maintenance, or they buy another setup. You do not guarantee output quality forever.

"I don't have five people who pay for Claude."

Then this is not your first path this month. Sell a playbook or a service to people you already know, then offer setups to the ones who already have the subscription.

What this feeds — and what feeds it

Hand off. The best compliment is a week of silence because they are using it.

What feeds a \$197 setup

People who already pay for Claude or ChatGPT and stall on the blank project. Buyers of a skill pack who want it installed. Service clients who keep asking you to "just set up the GPT." Your own sample and walkthrough. A brief (path 18) whose next step was "configure the tool," quoted separately.

People who do not pay for the model are not feedstock. You are not the vendor.

What a setup feeds

Skill packs, if three clients needed the same shape. Generic version, no client files, sold as a file.

Automations, if they then want the project to draft from a form. New quote. Path 19.

A productized service, if they want you to run the job, not own the tool.

Another \$197 setup for a second job, after the first is in their account and used.

Not a hosted model business. That is the thing you leave alone.

What not to feed

Do not feed a membership that is actually access to your account. Do not feed a staff workshop into the \$197. Do not use their files as the next sample. Do not turn the seven-day tweak window into a weekly run of the job.

Mistakes that kill this path

Keeping the project in your account. Loading their confidential files into a model against their policy. Overbuilding a second brain they will never open. Those three still kill it. The rest kill it more slowly.

Ten mistakes and the recovery this week

Keeping the project in your account. Recovery: copy the text into theirs on a screen share today. Remove yourself. If they will not pay for the model, refund and stop.

Loading confidential files they did not approve. Recovery: delete from the project and from your machine today. Tell them. Paste-per-chat from now on.

Overbuilding a second brain. Recovery: cut to three starters and the files they will use this week. Archive the rest. Re-record five minutes.

Writing instructions they are afraid to edit. Recovery: cut to under a page. Role, inputs, output, missing-info, do-not-invent. Have them change one line with you watching.

Starters that only work if you are typing. Recovery: log out. Watch them run starter two. Rewrite the starter until they can.

A 40-minute "training" instead of a five-minute walkthrough. Recovery: record five minutes tonight. Send that. Do not schedule a webinar.

Selling access to Claude as if you were the vendor. Recovery: take the page down. Refund anyone in your account. Configure theirs or stop.

Bundling automations into the \$197. Recovery: finish the setup only. Quote path 19 separately. Do not keep building pipes inside this fee.

Keeping copies of their files "for examples." Recovery: delete them today. Use your fake sample for the portfolio.

Staying admin after day eight because they asked. Recovery: drop to viewer, then leave. Fix the walkthrough if they are scared. Do not take the keys.

Asking people who do not pay for the model. Recovery: rewrite the five names. Only subscribers. You are not selling Claude.

Discounting to \$20 because it "felt like a prompt." Recovery: next button is \$197. A prompt they paste is not this product.

If you catch yourself in any of these, the recovery is this week. Ownership and files do not wait until you "have a process."

Tools — only what you need

Claude Projects or Custom GPTs. One. The five-minute walkthrough: QuickTime, Loom, or your phone pointed at the screen, as long as they can hear you and see the clicks. Configure the tool they already open.

Exact stack

Claude Projects or Custom GPTs, whichever they already pay for.

A page with a \$197 button (Stan, Stripe Payment Link, Gumroad — one).

An intake form: job, tone samples, files allowed, policy notes.

Stripe or Stan. Test-buy from a second email.

A calendar slot of 45 minutes if you do intake live, or the form if they write clearly.

Screen share for the install (their tool, not yours).

A place to send the five-minute recording they own.

Setup order

Sample project for a job you know, tested.

Five-minute walkthrough.

\$197 button, test-confirmed.

Intake questions written.

Five asks.

Live install in their account.

They run a starter.

Walkthrough sent, tweak window in writing.

Access removed, their files deleted from your machine.

What not to buy

Do not build a native app. Do not resell API access. Do not stand up a team workspace they do not need. Do not buy a "GPT store" plan that is actually you hosting. Do not add an automation platform inside this fee. Do not buy a course on prompt empires.

The \$0 path

A Claude or ChatGPT account you already pay for, used only to build the sample, never to host theirs. A Google Doc as the "page" with a payment link you already have. Loom free, or your phone. A Google Form for intake. The \$0 path is allowed for the first setup. It is not an excuse to host them in your login or to skip the walkthrough.

Checklist

- Sample project for a job you know, tested
- Fake files in the sample, no client data
- Five-minute walkthrough recorded
- \$197 button on a page, test-confirmed
- Five asks to people who already pay for the model
- Intake: job, tone, allowed files, data policy
- They have their own paid account before you start
- Project created in their account
- They click the buttons
- Instructions they can read and edit, under a page
- Missing-info rule and do-not-invent rule

Three named starter threads that already work

No confidential files they did not approve

They run a starter without you typing

Walkthrough delivered

Seven-day tweak window in writing

Tweak means instructions and starters, not a second job

Your access removed

Their files deleted from your machine

You said out loud: you are not reselling the model

No \$19/month access to your GPT

Automations quoted separately if they ask

One-line spreadsheet row filled

Viewer, if any, ends on day eight

Portfolio uses the fake sample only

FAQ

Claude Project or Custom GPT?

Whichever they already pay for and open. If they use both, pick the one for this job. Do not configure two for \$197. Default: their daily tool.

What if they do not have a paid account?

They need one. You do not sell them yours. Send the signup link. Schedule the setup after they can log in. Default: no install until they can click.

Can I do this over email only?

Yes, if they write a clear intake. Live screen share is faster for hand-off. Jules uses twenty minutes live plus the recording. Default: live for the first three jobs.

How long should instructions be?

Short enough they will edit them. Usually under a page. If you need four pages, you are writing a playbook (path 1) and calling it a project. Default: under a page.

What goes in the three starters?

The three jobs they will actually run this week. Not edge cases. Not "tell me about yourself." Named, boring, useful. Default: three jobs they named in intake.

Is \$197 too low?

It is a setup, not a month of service. If they want weekly-run work, sell path 7. If the setup is truly two jobs and picky files, \$297. Default: \$197 until five setups say otherwise.

What is the tweak window for?

Instruction and starter fixes. Not "also build my content engine." Write that down. Default: seven days, one tweak.

Can I show their project as a case study?

Only with permission, and never with their files. Show your sample instead. Jules shows the fake receivables list. Default: fake sample only.

Do I guarantee output quality forever?

No. Models change. You guarantee a working configuration at hand-off and one tweak week. After that, they own the maintenance, or they buy another setup. Default: no forever.

What if they ask me to stay as admin?

No. Viewer for seven days if it helps them sleep. Then you leave. Ownership is the product. Default: leave.

Can I keep a copy of the instructions I wrote?

The generic shape, yes. Their tone samples and files, no. Default: delete their materials from your machine on hand-off.

Should I configure both Claude and ChatGPT?

Not for \$197. One platform, the one they open. A second platform is a second setup at \$197 or a \$297 two-job quote, written. Default: one.

What if they want forty knowledge files?

No. Small set they will maintain. A second brain they will never open is a mistake, not a bonus. Default: only approved, small, dated files.

Can this replace a productized service?

No. This is configuration. Running the job every week is path 7. If they ask you to stay and write the emails, quote the service. Default: do not run the job inside the setup fee.

When do I turn this into a skill pack?

After three clients needed the same shape. Generic files. No confidential anything. Different page, different product. Default: not after one setup.



PATH 21

Your front door

A useful diagnostic. Email required. The follow-up sells path 1. Strangers become a list.

51 minute read · 11,184 words

Who this is for

You finished any earlier path. You need people you have never met.

Time to first

Same week you publish the form

Tools

First sale

The first email from someone you have never met.

Cash window

Feeds every other path

Leave this alone

A form, a PDF scorecard, MailerLite or Beehiiv.

A free file that is only a sales letter. Passing this book off as yours.

What the door actually is

Definition

A front door is a useful diagnostic. Seven questions. They get a score and one next step. You get an email. The free file is useful even if they never buy. That is the deal you keep.

This suite is The Operator Suite. You may brand your own scorecard. You may not copy this book, sell it as yours, or give it away as if you wrote it. Build your door. Point it at your playbook.

The door is seven questions a tired person will finish on a phone, a two-to-four page PDF that still helps if they never pay you, and a 5-7 note sequence that teaches, then asks. Friends and DMs got you the first sales. The door is how people you have never met join that line without you hunting each one by hand.

What it is not

It is not a 14-page free guide that is a sales letter with a checklist slapped on page 13. It is not this suite with your name on the cover. It is not a 40-field form that feels like a job application. It is not a fake score that always says you need my \$47 file.

If they can tell, in two minutes, that the PDF only exists to sell, you built a flyer. Flyers do not earn replies from strangers. Diagnostics do. It is not a webinar, a 12-email course, or a community. Those can come later.

Why email is required

A stranger who takes a score and disappears was never going to buy this week. That is fine. The door still has to be fair: they get the file instantly. You get a way to teach for a few notes, then ask. No hostage PDF. No we will send it someday. Instant, then a sequence that earns the ask.

Email is not a trick. It is the only address you control. A like, a follow, a comment — those live on someone else's platform. When the algorithm changes, you have nothing. The list is the asset this path builds. The score is how you earn the address without lying. Require the email. Include an unsubscribe. Both.

Why a diagnostic beats a PDF dump

People will not finish a 40-page free book they did not ask for. They will finish seven questions if each one feels like it is about them. A score gives them language for a problem they already have. That language is what they carry into the paid playbook later.

A dump of chapters from a book you did not write is theft and it is also bad marketing. Nobody finishes it. The scorecard you actually wrote for one job will outperform a stolen encyclopedia every week of the year.

Seven is the number because it is enough to change the advice and short enough to finish on a phone. Five can work. Forty cannot. Multiple choice only.

Why this works now

Attention is expensive. Ads into a sales page with no list behind it burn cash. AI made generic lead magnets free and useless. The remaining gap is a diagnostic that uses the language of one job. AI readiness quiz is wallpaper. Seven questions for a one-person landscaping company that wants a week of posts is a door. Strangers already took a dozen quizzes that spat out 94 out of 100 and a pitch. Three honest bands and one free action still feel like a person.

Anti-pattern 1: the brochure

Page one is your bio. Page two is a story. Page three is a pitch. The score is a sticker. Recovery: delete pages one through three. Lead with the band meanings and one free action. Your name belongs in the footer as a human, not as a keynote on page one. The PDF is a diagnostic, not a memoir.

Anti-pattern 2: the hostage file

Enter your email and we will send it in 24 hours so we can nurture you. They already did the work of answering. Pay them immediately with the file. Nurture after they have it.

Instant means on the thank-you screen and in the first email. Not check your promotions tab in a few hours while we wait to look hungry. If your tool cannot attach a PDF on submit, link the file on the next screen and send the same link in note 1. Two minutes, not two days.

Anti-pattern 3: passing this book off as yours

You export this suite, slap your logo on the cover, and call it a magnet. That is passing this book off as yours. It is off limits. It also trains buyers to see you as a reseller. Write a scorecard. Point at your playbook. That is the work. If you are unsure whether a file you are about to publish is yours, it is not. Write seven questions for one job. That file is yours.

The deal you keep

They get a real next step they can do this week without paying you. You get an email and permission to send a short sequence. You do not get a right to spam daily, sell them twelve things in note one, or republish someone else's book. If you cannot keep that deal, do not publish the form.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you finished any earlier path. You have something to point at — usually path 1, a playbook — and you need people you have never met. Friends and DMs got you the first sales. The door is how strangers join that line without you hunting each one.

Fits if

You can write seven questions that change the advice. If every answer leads to buy my file, the questions are fake.

You can write a two-to-four page PDF that still helps if they never pay you. You will set up a 5-7 note sequence before you buy a single ad. You already have a named paid next step with a live checkout you have test-bought from a second email. You will require an email and include an

unsubscribe. Both. Not one. You will write your own scorecard, not paste this book into a PDF with your name on it.

Skip if

Skip it if you have nothing to sell yet. A door into an empty house is a hobby. Skip it if you planned to republish this suite as your lead magnet. Skip it if you will not include an unsubscribe. Skip it if you want a list more than you want to be useful — that motive leaks onto page one.

Skip it if you need cash this week. Send ten more personal messages for the file you already have. The door is a stranger machine. It is not a substitute for asking people who already know you.

Skip it if you will not test delivery from a second inbox. A form that looks live and never sends the PDF is how you teach strangers to ignore you.

The honest middle

If the playbook is 80 percent done and the checkout works, you may write the questions now and finish the PDF on the same weekend. You may not launch the form pointing at a playbook you have not exported.

If you have a skill pack and no playbook, the door can point at the skill pack. Pick one paid thing. Write it on a sticky note so the sequence does not wander into a buffet.

If you have done the job for two local owners and you have notes, those notes are the playbook. Finish that file. Then the door. You do not need a following. You need one paid next step, seven honest questions, and a room you already help enough to share once.

Skills and time

You need seven multiple-choice questions, a scoring key, a two-to-four page PDF, a form in Tally or Beehiiv, and 5-7 short notes. None of that is code. You need a second email so you can take the form as a stranger. You need a friend who does the job, for the fairness test.

Time: two evenings for questions plus PDF, one evening for the form and the test, one evening for the sequence. Share once the next morning. If you only have 40 minutes a night, spread that same work across seven nights. Do not buy ads to skip the writing. Budget: \$0 if you use Google Docs, a free form, and a free MailerLite or Beehiiv tier.

Two-minute self-test

Answer these out loud. If you stall on any of them, you are not ready for the door this week.

What is the paid file or service a stranger would buy after the sequence? Name the title and the price.

Can a friend take one useful action from a two-page PDF without paying you? What is that action, in one sentence?

Will you write the 5-7 notes before you share the form? Yes or no.

Are you willing to require an email, and to let them leave in one click? Yes or no.

Will you write your own scorecard, and not paste this book into a PDF with your name on it? Yes or no.

Five yeses. Then start Day 1. Four or fewer: finish the missing piece first.

The stranger on the other side

They are not a fan. They found a post in a group, or a link under a comment you left that actually helped. They have four minutes on a phone. They will finish seven questions if the first one sounds like their Tuesday. They will bounce at question two if you got cute. They will buy later only if the free action worked. Write for that person. Not for a marketer who collects magnets.

The offer, named in one sentence

Seven questions. A score. One next step. Free even if you never buy.

That is the public offer. The private truth: the sequence teaches, then sells path 1. Both can be true if the PDF is real.

Fill this before you outline

I help [specific person] see [named situation] in seven questions, and I give them [one free action] even if they never buy. The paid next step is [playbook title] at [price].

If you cannot fill those brackets, you do not have a door. You have a vibe. Specific person is a job plus a constraint. Named situation is something they already feel on a Tuesday. One free action is a 20-minute task that does not need a card. Paid next step is one product, one price. Not a buffet.

Put the filled sentence at the top of the Doc that will become the PDF. If you need and to name the person or the paid thing, you have two doors. Pick one.

Sentences that work

Seven questions for one-person landscapers who want a week of posts. A score. One action you can do tonight. Free even if you never buy the 10-day file.

A 7-question AI-readiness scorecard for solo bookkeepers. Instant PDF. One close-the-month action that does not require a new subscription.

Clinic front-desk diagnostic: seven questions, a score, one reminder-text you can send this week. No pitch on page one.

For tutors who freeze at lesson notes. Seven questions. A band. One template to try on Thursday. The paid pack is later, if you want it.

Trades AI scorecard. Seven questions. One next step. Built for people who hate forms and will bounce if this feels like a trap.

Write yours in that shape. One person. Seven questions. One free action. One paid file named, not pitched on page one.

What they get

Seven questions, scored honestly.

A PDF that explains the score in plain language and gives one next step they can do this week without paying you.

Instant delivery. The file is in the thank-you email or the next screen, not in a queue you will get to.

A short sequence they can leave in one click.

Three bands, not a fake 94 out of 100. A sentence per band a skeptical friend would accept.

What they do not get

They do not get this suite. They do not get a fake 94 out of 100. They do not get a 40-page book you copied. They do not get daily pitches. They do not get a webinar they have to sit through to see the score. They do not get a community invite in note 1. They do not get The Operator Suite with your sticker on the cover.

Packaging

The public name is a scorecard for a job, with your name, not the name of this book. Example: Trades AI scorecard — Noor. Two to four pages. Your email in the footer as a human. Year on the cover. A sentence that the file is free even if they never buy.

Filename a tired person can find later: trades-ai-scorecard-noor.pdf. Cover states the job, the seven questions, and that it is free. No fake 94 in a circle.

The four layers

The form is the product's front. The PDF is the gift. The sequence is the relationship. The playbook is the ask. Keep those four layers in that order.

If you reverse them — ask on the form, pitch in the PDF, teach never — you built a flyer with extra fields. Strangers can tell. They leave at question two, or they take the file and mute you. Keep the order. The ask waits for notes 5-7.

The public name of the door is a job plus the word scorecard plus you. Do not put this book's title on their PDF. Do not put this book's chapter list in their magnet. Do not give this book away as if you wrote it.

What done looks like

Definition

Done is the first email from someone you have never met, sitting in a tool you control, with a score attached, and a PDF they already received. The sequence exists. Unsubscribe works. The paid playbook is linked in a later note, not in the first paragraph of the free file. The scorecard is a file you wrote, not this suite with a sticker on it.

The fairness test

Give the PDF to a friend and tell them not to buy anything. If they can still take one useful action this week, the door is honest. If they cannot, you wrote a sales letter and called it a scorecard. Rewrite until the friend has a next step that does not require a card.

Run the test twice. Once with a friend who does the job. Once with a friend who does not. The first friend should nod. The second friend should still understand the action even if they will never do it. If the second friend is lost, the PDF is inside-baseball. Plain it out.

Do not hover. Hand them the file. Sit in another room. Ask one question when they are done: what would you do this week, in one sentence. If they say buy your thing, you failed. If they name the free action, you passed.

Technical done

Form live. Email required. Seven questions. No 40 fields.

PDF attached or linked immediately on the thank-you screen and in note 1.

Confirmation they expect. From-name they recognize.

Sequence of 5-7 notes drafted, not I will write them when people join.

Unsubscribe one click, tested.

Path 1 checkout test-bought from a second email. The sequence must not point at a dead button.

You filled the form as a stranger from a second inbox and received the file in under two minutes.

Privacy line under the button, one sentence: you are joining a short sequence, you can leave in one click.

Not done yet

A Google Doc of questions with no scoring key. A PDF that mentions the paid file more than the free action. A sequence outline with no actual sentences. A plan to write the notes after the first ten people join. Those are sketches. Sketches are not a door. A tagging architecture, a webinar date, an ad account — those wait.

The first-sale definition on this path

The first sale is the first email from someone you have never met. Cash from the playbook is path 1 using the door. Count both. Do not pretend the list is failing because the \$29 did not happen on day one. The address is the win this path is built to get. Write the date, the source, and the score band on one line.

The second-inbox night

Before you share, open a browser you do not usually use. A second Gmail. Fill the form as if you were suspicious and tired. Submit. Start a timer. The file should be on the next screen. Note 1 should arrive. The PDF should open on a phone. Unsubscribe should be one click and should actually leave. Click the playbook link in note 5 as a draft — the checkout should take a test-buy you already did.

If any of that fails, you are not done. Fix it before one stranger sees the form. A broken first impression is expensive. You will not get that stranger back.

Pricing — the door is free, the house is not

The door is free

The cash window is not a price on the PDF. The door feeds every other path. You do not charge for the seven questions. Free means free. Useful means useful without a receipt. If you cannot stand that, this is not your path this month. Go sell the playbook with ten more personal messages.

Do not charge \$9 for the scorecard and also call it free. Do not put a tripwire on a diagnostic. The tripwire path is a different product. This path is a door. Doors do not have a cover charge.

Where money shows up

Path 1 playbook, usually \$19-\$47, asked for in note 5, 6, or 7 after you have taught.

Later: a service, a setup, a drop. Not in the first email.

Optional: a \$97-\$197 live walkthrough of their results, sold as itself, after they already have the PDF. Do not hide that inside the magnet.

The sequence may sell one named thing. Write that thing on a sticky note. If note 6 starts selling a second product, you wandered. Put the second product in a later letter, after this sequence ends.

Worked dollars

Twenty strangers finish the form in a month. Sequence is live. Two buy the \$29 playbook. That is \$58, which is not the point. You now have twenty addresses you can tell about a Thursday drop, a skill pack, or a setup. The next 90 days is where the door pays. If you judge this path on week-one cash, you will kill it and go back to hunting DMs.

If one of those twenty replies SETUP and you do a \$147 configuration, the door just paid for the month. That reply only happens if the PDF was useful and note 7 was a human.

What you never charge for here

Do not sell this suite as a \$9 lead magnet. That is passing this book off as yours, and it is also the wrong price for a book you do not own. This suite is The Operator Suite. It is not inventory. Do not charge for the sequence. Do not charge to unsubscribe. Do not charge to hear their score.

Refunds

The door is free, so there is nothing to refund on the magnet. For the playbook the sequence sells, refund on request in the first 7 or 14 days with no speech. Put that sentence on the checkout. A fight over \$29 costs more than \$29.

If they bought thinking the free action would be done for them, refund and fix the listing. If they only wanted the PDF, they already have it. That was always free.

When to raise the paid next step

Raise the playbook from \$19 to \$29 when ten strangers have bought it through the door. Raise to \$47 when the file has templates and a 14-day plan. Do not raise the door. The door stays free.

Raise because the paid file does more, not because you got bored of \$29. Email the extra page free to people who already paid. The sequence's sticky note changes the price. It does not add a second product.

A \$97-\$197 live hour of their results is allowed after they have the PDF, sold as itself. Mention it once in note 7 as SETUP only if you actually offer it. A fake SETUP is how you spend Thursday on discovery calls you did not price.

The first 72 hours

Day 1 morning: the sticky note

Write the paid next step on a sticky note. Title and price. That is the only thing the sequence is allowed to sell. If you cannot name it, stop. Finish the product. A door into an empty house is a hobby, and hobbies do not get sequences.

Day 1 late morning: seven questions that change the advice

Write seven questions that change the advice. Not flattery. Each answer should send them toward a different next step: a playbook, a skill pack, do not buy anything yet — finish one job, or talk to a person, not a file.

Draft them as multiple choice. Free text is how you get novels and never score them. If two answers never change the PDF, delete one question and merge them. Read them out loud. If you would not answer them on a phone in a van, they are too cute.

How you know a question changes the advice: write the free action for answer A and for answer B. If those two sentences are the same, the question is a decoration. Are you an ambitious entrepreneur does not change anything. Do you have one offer a stranger can buy this week without a call does. Yes points at a pack. Not yet points at write the offer sentence this week, do not buy a course.

Sit with a person who does the job, or with your own last month of notes. Ask what actually changes the next step. Hours available. Saved project or blank chat. One offer or not. Where customers find them. Those change the band. Motivational mood does not.

Day 1 afternoon: the scoring key and three bands

Zero to two points per question. Three bands, not twelve. Example: 0-5 still-setup, 6-10 ready-for-a-pack, 11-14 ready-but-inconsistent. Write one sentence per band that a skeptical friend would accept. Fake precision (you are 73.4 percent AI-ready) is a toy. A fake 94 out of 100 is a flyer. Three bands is a diagnosis.

Put the key on page one of the PDF so they can audit you. Test the key with two fake answer sheets before you export. Sheet one should land in still-setup. Sheet two should land in ready-for-a-pack. If both land in the same band, three of your questions do not diagnose. Fix them this afternoon, not after ten strangers all score 8.

Day 1 night: the two-to-four page PDF

Two to four pages. How scoring works. What each band means. One action per band that does not require paying you. Your name. The year. A sentence that the file is free even if they never buy. Your email in the footer as a human, not as a funnel.

Page one: title, your name, the year, how the 0-2 scoring works, the three band ranges. Page two: what each band means, and the free action for each. Page three: one worked example of a free

action, with the actual words they can reuse. Page four, if you need it: a small template, the deal in one line, your email.

Do not paste chapters of this suite. Do not put a fake 94/100 at the top. Export from Google Docs. Print it or open it on your phone. If type hits the edge, fix the margins tonight.

Quiet-page test before you sleep: delete every mention of the paid file. If the PDF still stands, you passed. If it collapses, you wrote a brochure. Rewrite the free actions until they stand alone.

Day 2: form live

MailerLite, Beehiiv, or Tally into either. Fields: first name optional, email required, the seven questions. Thank-you page includes the PDF now. If the form tool wants company size, budget, phone, mailing address — decline. Seven questions plus email. That is the whole form.

Put a one-sentence privacy line under the button: you are joining a short sequence, you can leave in one click. Put the form above the paid button on your page. The door is the first thing a stranger sees. The playbook is the second.

From-name is your first name, one word. Not MAIL-DAEMON. Not your LLC in all caps. A person they will recognize when note 2 arrives.

Day 2 night: the stranger test

Test as a stranger from a second email. Confirm the file arrives in under two minutes. Confirm the PDF opens on a phone. Confirm unsubscribe is one click and actually leaves. Confirm the thank-you page does not bury the file under a button labeled resources.

If delivery takes five minutes, that is a bug. Fix from-address, fix the automation, run the test again. Two passing runs. Then sleep.

Day 3 morning: the 5-7 note sequence

Write 5-7 notes before anyone joins. You will not write them later. You will panic and paste a pitch. Draft them in the tool.

Note 1: here is your file, read the band, do the action. Unsubscribe reminder.

Notes 2-4: teach. One job, one example, one mistake. No paid link unless they ask.

Notes 5-6: the playbook exists, price, link. A customer sentence if you have one.

Note 7: last time the link will be in the sequence, plus a quiet SETUP reply option if a human setup is truly the better fit. Unsubscribe reminder again.

Spacing: note 1 instant. Note 2 the next morning. Notes 3-4 every other day. Notes 5-7 with a day of air between them. Then silence until you have something useful. Daily blasts train them to skim, then to leave.

Day 3 afternoon: share once

Share it once in a place you already help people. One post, one comment, one email to people who already know you. Do not buy ads. Do not spray five platforms. Watch whether anyone finishes the seven questions. If they abandon at question two, the questions are too cute or too many.

Reply to the first stranger like a person. One sentence. Not a six-link kit. The 72 hours end when a human who is not you has the file.

The path, step by step

Step 1. Name the paid thing the door will sell

Usually path 1. Write the title and the price on a sticky note so the sequence does not wander into a buffet. If you cannot name it, stop. Finish the product. One paid thing. One price.

Step 2. Write seven questions that diagnose, not flatter

Sit with a person who does the job and ask what actually changes the next step. If two answers never change the PDF, delete one question and merge them. Multiple choice only. Seven is enough to change advice and short enough to finish on a phone. Read them out loud. If you would not answer them in a van, they are too cute.

Step 3. Write a scoring key with three bands you could defend

Zero to two points per question. Three bands, not fake precision. Example: 0-5 still-setup, 6-10 ready-for-a-pack, 11-14 ready-but-inconsistent. One sentence per band a skeptical friend would accept. Put the key on page one of the PDF so they can audit you. Run two fake answer sheets. If both land in the same band, rewrite three questions.

Step 4. Write the PDF so the free next step is real

Two to four pages. How scoring works. What each band means. One action per band that does not require paying you. Example: Run one recurring job in a saved project this week. Do not buy a second subscription. If the free action is buy my file, you failed the fairness test. Keep rewriting until a friend can act without a card. Print it. Open it on a phone. Fix the margins.

Step 5. Brand the scorecard as yours

Title, your name, the job, the year. This suite is The Operator Suite. You may brand your own scorecard. You may not copy this book, sell it as yours, or give it away as if you wrote it. A two-to-four page diagnostic you wrote is the product. This suite is not.

Step 6. Build the form and hook it to a real list tool

Email required. Instant file. No 40 fields. No company size, budget, phone, mailing address. First name is optional. Seven questions. A one-sentence privacy line under the button: you are joining a short sequence, you can leave in one click. MailerLite, Beehiiv, or Tally into either. Tag the score band if you can do it without a science project. If you cannot, send one sequence to everyone and mention bands in the PDF only. Do not delay launch for a tagging architecture.

Step 7. Write 5-7 notes before anyone joins

Teach, then ask. Note 1 is the file, the band, the action, and an unsubscribe reminder. Notes 2-4 teach: one job, one example, one mistake, no paid link. Notes 5-6 ask for the playbook: price, link, a customer sentence if you have one. Note 7 is a quiet close or a single SETUP mention if a human is truly the better fit, plus unsubscribe again. Draft them in the tool. You will not write them later.

Step 8. Test delivery and the path to checkout from a second email

Fill the form as a stranger. File in under two minutes, on the thank-you screen and in note 1. PDF opens on a phone. Unsubscribe is one click and actually leaves. Then test-buy the paid checkout from that same second email. Click every link in the sequence as if you were tired and suspicious. The sequence must not point at a dead button. Fix the from-name so it looks like a person.

Step 9. Put the form above the paid button and share once

A stranger who hits the page should see the diagnostic first. Share once where you already help. One post. One room. Not five platforms before you know delivery works. Do not buy ads. Watch whether anyone finishes question two. If they drop, the questions are the bug, not the room.

Step 10. Reply to the first stranger like a person

One sentence that proves you read their score or their reply. Not a six-link kit. Not an auto-responder that says circle back. This is how a list starts feeling like a room. If they scored 8, say so, and point at the free action in their band. Then stop typing.

Step 11. After ten subscribers, read where they drop

Question two? The questions are cute. Thank-you page? Delivery is buried. Note 5? You asked too early or you were boring. Fix the drop. Do not buy a new tool. Do not add a webinar because the PDF felt thin. The PDF is thin on purpose. Teach in the notes.

Step 12. Ads only after the sequence exists — and keep a one-line sheet

Only then consider a small ad budget. Sequence first. Ads on an empty sequence buy you unsubscribes you paid for. Send ads to the form, never to the paid button, until the form-to-email rate is something you can live with. Keep a one-line spreadsheet: date, source, score band, opened note 1, clicked playbook, bought, replied. Thirty rows is enough to see the truth. A dashboard before thirty people is costume jewelry.

A worked example: Noor's 7-question door

Noor finished a \$29 playbook: a 10-day content system for solo trades. Friends bought it. Strangers did not know Noor existed. Noor needed a door, not a second book. Noor is the operator building a door. Noor did not write this suite. The scorecard is hers. The Operator Suite is not.

The situation

The playbook worked for people who already trusted Noor. The checkout was live. A second Gmail had already test-bought it. What was missing was a stranger. Noor had helped in a Facebook group for solo trades for a year — answers, not pitches. That room was the share, later. First: seven questions, three bands, a four-page PDF, a sequence written before anyone joined. Sticky note: 10-day content system for solo trades, \$29.

The seven questions, and why each one

Each is multiple choice. Each changes the band. Noor sat with last month's DMs and asked what actually changed the advice she gave.

In the last 30 days, how many times did you actually finish a job with AI, not just open a chat? (0, 1-3, 4+). Zero is still-setup. This stops the person who thinks opening a chat counts as a system.

Do you have one offer a stranger can buy this week without a call? (yes / not yet). Not yet: write the offer sentence, do not buy a course. Yes: a pack can help.

Where does a new customer usually find you? (word of mouth, Google, Instagram or TikTok, they don't). They don't is a different next step than Google.

What happens after someone messages you? (you reply yourself, a form, nothing for days). Nothing for days is operations. A content pack will not fix a silent inbox.

Have you saved a prompt or a project you reuse, or do you start from a blank chat every time? (saved / blank). Blank is expensive. Middle-band free action: save one project and run it on a real job by Friday.

How many hours a week can you give this, honestly, with the job you already have? (under 2, 2-5, 6+). Under 2 means pick one platform, not five.

If a file told you the next step, would you rather have a pack to run yourself, or a person to set it up? (pack / person). This is how note 7 knows whether SETUP is honest. Some people should not buy a file.

Scoring and the three bands

Noor scores 0-2 points per question. Bands: 0-5 still-setup, 6-10 ready-for-a-pack, 11-14 ready-but-inconsistent. The PDF gives one action per band. Still-setup: write the offer sentence this week, do not buy a course. Ready-for-a-pack: run one saved project on a real job by Friday. Ready-but-inconsistent: pick one platform for 14 days. None of those actions require \$29. That is the deal Noor keeps. Three bands, not a fake 94.

The four-page PDF

Page one: Trades AI scorecard — Noor, the year, how 0-2 scoring works, the three ranges. Page two: the three band meanings and the free action for each. Page three: a worked example of the saved-project action, with the actual prompt Noor uses on one finished job, names blurred. Page four: the deal in one line (free even if you never buy), Noor's email as a human, no pitch above the fold.

Quiet-page test: Noor deleted the one line that mentioned the \$29 file. The PDF still stood. A friend who runs a lawn crew took the still-setup action without paying.

The form and the sequence

Email required. PDF on the thank-you page and in note 1. Noor brands it Trades AI scorecard — Noor — a scorecard, not this book. Tally into MailerLite. First name optional. Seven questions. Privacy line under the button. From-name: Noor.

Notes, drafted in the tool on Thursday morning before the share: (1) here is your file, read the band, do the action, unsubscribe is at the bottom; (2) a one-job example from the playbook, no pitch; (3) why blank chat is expensive, still no pitch; (4) a mistake: posting on five platforms; (5) the playbook exists, \$29, link; (6) a customer sentence from a friend who used day 3; (7) last time the link will be in the sequence, plus a SETUP reply option, plus unsubscribe again.

The week it ran

Monday night: questions and scoring key. Two fake answer sheets. One landed at 3, one at 9. Good. Tuesday night: PDF, four pages, printed on the kitchen table, margins fixed. Wednesday: Tally into MailerLite, test from a second Gmail, file arrived in 40 seconds. Unsubscribe worked. Thursday morning: sequence drafted in the tool. Thursday 11am: one post in a Facebook group for solo trades Noor had helped in for a year, no pitch except the form.

A stranger named Dell finishes the form on Thursday 4:12pm. Score 8, ready-for-a-pack. Note 1 goes out at once. Noor writes Dell one sentence: Score 8 — do the saved project on one real job before you open another tab. Dell does the saved-project action on Friday and replies already did. Note 5 sells Saturday morning. Dell buys the \$29 file Saturday 9:41am. Noor never ran an ad.

What almost broke it

Question 3 originally had six options including a joke. Two people dropped there in the first hour. Noor cut it to four options. Delivery originally linked the PDF under a button labeled resources. Dell's cousin (test inbox) missed it. Noor put the file above the fold on the thank-you page and in the first sentence of note 1. A fairness-test friend said page three was starting to feel like a brochure. Noor cut it back to one worked example.

Ninety days later

First email from someone Noor had never met: Thursday 4:12pm. That is the first sale of this path — the address, not the \$29. The \$29 is path 1 working through the door. Count both.

64 emails from strangers. 7 playbook sales through the sequence. 1 SETUP reply that became a \$147 evening. Unsubscribe rate 3 percent. Score-band mix: some still-setup, most ready-for-a-pack, a few ready-but-inconsistent. Noor still has not run an ad. The door is a form, a file, and notes that teach. That is the whole machine.

Copy you can actually send

Swap the job. Keep the constraints. Do not add hype. Fill the brackets. Send.

The public line

Seven questions. A score. One next step. Free even if you never buy.

The post

I made a short AI-readiness scorecard for [your people]. Seven questions, a score, one thing to do this week. It is useful if you never buy from me. Link: [form].

The shorter post and the DM

Shorter post: Seven questions for [job]. You get a score and one next step. Email required. File is instant. You can leave any time.

DM to someone who already knows you: I built a 7-question scorecard for [job]. Thought of you because of [specific thing they said]. It is free. If it is not useful, ignore me. [form]

Sales page hero

Find out where you actually are with AI for [job]. Seven questions. A score. One next step you can do this week even if you never buy. Start here: [form]

Put that above the paid button. The playbook listing can sit below. A stranger should hit the diagnostic first.

Checkout blurb for the playbook the door sells

This is the 10-day file the scorecard points at. If the free action was enough, you do not need this. If you want the full sequence, it is \$29. Refund if you ask in 14 days.

Note 1 (instant)

Your scorecard is here: [PDF]. Read the band with your score. Do the one action this week. I will send a few short notes. You can leave any time — unsubscribe is at the bottom.

That is the whole note. Do not add a bio. Do not add a second PDF. Do not add the paid link.

Notes 2-4, teach

Note 2: One job. Here is how I run [specific task] without a blank chat. No link to anything paid. If you already did this week's action, reply with the word DONE and I will leave you alone until the next note.

Note 3: Why a blank chat is expensive for [job]. One mistake I made. One constraint you can paste. Still no pitch.

Note 4: A mistake: posting on five platforms, buying a second subscription, writing 40 questions. Pick one. The free action in your PDF is still the assignment.

Notes 5-7, the ask

Note 5: If you want the full sequence I use for [job], it is a \$29 playbook: [link]. If the free action in the PDF is enough, stay with that. Either is fine.

Note 6: A sentence from someone who used day 3. Then the same link. Then a reminder they can leave.

Note 7: Last note in this set. Playbook is still here: [link]. If you want a human setup instead, reply with the word SETUP and I will tell you the price. If not, I will write when I have something useful. Unsubscribe anytime.

If you do not offer a human setup, delete the SETUP sentence. Do not invent a service in note 7.

Refund reply, and what you do not write

Refund (for the playbook, not the door): Done. Refunded. Keep the file if you already downloaded it. If the scorecard was the useful part, that was always free.

Do not paste chapters of this suite into your PDF. Do not put a fake 94/100 at the top. Do not forget the unsubscribe. Your scorecard is yours. This book is not. The public line is seven questions, a score, one next step, free even if you never buy.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Assume evenings. This is four weeks to a working door, not a content brand. No ads in week 1. No webinar in week 2. No second magnet in week 3.

Week 1

Day 1: sticky note, seven questions, scoring key, two fake answer sheets, PDF draft.

Day 2: PDF export, fairness test with a friend, form live, test as a stranger, fix delivery.

Day 3: 5-7 notes in the tool, share once where you already help.

Day 4: reply to humans. Do not add a webinar. Do not open a second platform.

Day 5: read drop-off. Cut a cute question. Move the PDF above the fold if people miss it.

Day 6: one more share in the same room, or a personal email to five people who already trust you. Not ads.

Day 7: count emails from strangers, not likes. If zero, the share was in the wrong room or the first line of the post was a pitch.

Week 2

Reply to humans. Fix the question people skip. Do not add a webinar. Count emails from strangers, not likes on the post. Rewrite note 1 if the click rate on the PDF is embarrassing. Rewrite note 5 if nobody clicks the playbook and you asked in note 2 by accident.

If you have a job, this week is 30-40 minutes a night: ten minutes of replies, twenty minutes of one fix, ten minutes of not touching it.

Week 3

If ten people finished the form and the sequence is live, you may share again or spend a small amount on ads to the form — not to the paid button. If fewer than ten, the share was weak or the questions feel like a trap. Tighten the PDF's free action. Do not buy traffic to a flyer.

Tag score bands if you still have not, only if it is easy. Otherwise leave it. Teaching one sequence to everyone is allowed.

Week 4

Read the spreadsheet. Form starts versus finishes. Unsubscribes. Playbook clicks. Replies. One genuine reply is worth twenty silent opens.

Decide one change, not five. Either a question, or the PDF action, or the note 5 sentence. Ship the change. Do not rebuild the brand.

If the door produced emails and no cash, that is still this path working. Path 1 cash may land in month two. Keep the sequence. Do not panic-add a webinar.

After week 4

A monthly share in the room you already help. A monthly PDF tweak if a question is dated. That is maintenance, not a new product. The door is not a content calendar. Do not write a second scorecard for a second job until thirty strangers have finished the first. Later products get later notes, after this sequence ends.

If zero strangers wrote back

The failure is usually the room, the first line, or question two. Not the market. Not the logo. Share in the place you already help, with a first line that is the seven questions, not your bio. Cut a cute option. Run the stranger test again. Send five personal emails to people who already trust you. Then wait a week. Do not buy ads to diagnose a flyer. Fix the flyer first.

The quality bar

The bar is a file that still helps if they never pay, and a score that would change if they answered honestly.

Voice

Kitchen table, not conference stage. Short sentences. Named job. Named next step. If a paragraph could run in a motivational clip, cut it. Read page one out loud. If you would not say it, it does not ship.

Questions

They change the advice. Are you an ambitious entrepreneur does not. Do you have one offer a stranger can buy this week does.

Below-bar: five questions that all output you should buy my course. Above-bar: seven questions a practitioner would recognize as their Tuesday. Multiple choice. Four options or fewer. No jokes in the options. No free text on v1.

PDF

Two to four pages. Band meanings. One free action each. Your name. The year. No pasted chapters from someone else's book. You may brand your own scorecard. You may not copy this book and sell it as yours.

Below-bar: 14 pages, your origin story, a fake 94, a pitch on every page. Above-bar: they can do the action tonight with the PDF and nothing else. Margins that survive a phone. Filename a human can find.

Sequence

Teaches first. Asks later. Unsubscribe always. Instant file, always. 5-7 notes, written before anyone joins.

Below-bar: note 1 is a 1,200-word pitch. Above-bar: note 1 is the file, the band, the action, a way out. Notes 2-4 have no paid link. Notes 5-7 have one paid thing, the one on the sticky note.

Ethics you do not get to skip

This suite is The Operator Suite. Passing this book off as yours is off limits. Selling this book as your own is off limits. Giving this book away as a magnet with your logo on the cover is off limits. Building a door that points at your playbook is the work.

You may quote a sentence of this path in your own words. You may not export the suite. If you are unsure, you already know.

Five tests you can run this week

Friend fairness test: they can act without paying. Two friends if you can — one who does the job, one who does not.

Stranger delivery test: second inbox, file in under two minutes, PDF opens on a phone.

Unsubscribe test: one click, actually leaves.

Scoring test: two different answer sheets produce two different bands and two different actions.

Quiet-page test: delete every mention of the paid file from the PDF. If the PDF still stands, you passed. If it collapses, you wrote a brochure.

Fail any one of those and you are not sharing yet. These are not vibes. These are pass or rewrite.

Below the bar

A fake 94 out of 100. A 40-field form. A 14-page sales letter. This suite with your name on the cover. Note 1 as a pitch. No unsubscribe. Delivery tomorrow. Ads on day one. Questions that always output the same band. If a tired stranger cannot finish seven questions and do one free action this week, it is below the bar.

What to count

First week

Form starts versus finishes. If half leave, you have too many questions or they smell a quiz trap.

Emails from people you have never met. That is the first sale of this path.

Whether the PDF link is clicked. If not, delivery is buried.

Time from submit to file in the test inbox. Over five minutes is a bug.

Unsubscribe works, yes or no. If no, you are not counting anything else yet.

After 30 subscribers

Unsubscribe rate. Over 5 percent on the sequence means you asked too early or you were boring. Under 1 percent and zero clicks can mean nobody is reading — check the from-name. Playbook click from notes 5-7. A few percent is real. Fifty percent means you only invited fans.

Replies. One genuine reply is worth twenty silent opens.

Score-band mix. If everyone lands in the same band, the questions do not diagnose.

Thirty is enough to see a pattern. Ten is enough to see a drop. Do not wait for a hundred to fix question two.

Day 90

Stranger emails total.

Playbook sales that can be traced to the sequence.

SETUP replies, if you offer a human.

Cost of ads, if any, versus emails. If you paid \$80 for 4 emails, the post in the room you already help was cheaper. Stop the ads. Fix the door.

Unsubscribe rate across the whole sequence, not one note.

What to ignore

Likes on the post. Follower count. Time on page. Heatmaps. Open-rate vanity if your tool lies. A brand awareness story. Ignore anything that is not an email, a reply, or a checkout. A door with 12 form finishes and 3 genuine replies is healthier than a post with 400 reactions and zero emails.

The one-line spreadsheet

date | source | score band | note1 clicked | playbook clicked | bought | replied

That is the whole dashboard. Thirty rows. A notebook is allowed. Fill it the day they join, not in a monthly panic. If the source column is always ads and unsub is ugly, stop the ads.

Ads math

Ads are allowed after the sequence exists, delivery works, and a handful of strangers have finished the form. Send them to the form. Cost per email is the number. If a weekend in the room you already help produced more emails than \$80 of ads, the ads are the sick part. Kill them. Fix the door. Do not raise budget on a flyer.

Objections you will hear — including your own

People will not give an email

Some will not. They were not going to buy this month. The people who want the score will. Do not open the PDF to the whole internet and then wonder why you have no list. Email required is the deal. Unsubscribe is the other half of the deal. Both.

A free file should be a 40-page guide

No. Long and useless is still useless. Seven questions and a tight PDF beat a stolen book with your logo.

Can I just upload this suite as the magnet

No. This suite is The Operator Suite. You may not copy this book, sell it as yours, or give it away as if you wrote it. Write a scorecard for your people. Point at your playbook. A stolen encyclopedia is theft and it is also a magnet nobody finishes.

I should run ads on day one

Not before the sequence exists. Paid traffic into silence is how you learn to hate lists. Ads after delivery works, a handful of strangers have finished, and the notes are live. Ads to the form, never to the paid button, until you can live with the form-to-email rate.

Fake scores convert better

They convert once. Then they tell friends. Your name is small. Keep it clean. Three bands you can defend will still be on your computer in a year. A fake 94 will be a screenshot in a group chat.

What if they only want the free thing

Good. You kept the deal. Some of them buy in three months. Some never do. That is allowed. A list of people who used a free action is worth more than a list of people who feel tricked.

I do not have a list to share with

You have a room you already help, or you do not have a door yet. One group, one comment thread, five personal emails. That is a share. A cold ad account is not a share. If you have never helped in a room, go help for a month. Then the form.

Beehiiv is too much

Then MailerLite. Then Tally into either. The tool is not the path. If you stall on tools, you are avoiding the questions. Write the questions on paper first. Pick a tool on Day 2, not on Day 1 at noon.

I will write the notes when people join

You will not. You will panic and paste a pitch. Write the notes on Day 3, before the share. 5-7. Teach, then ask.

GDPR, privacy, my cousin in the EU

Say what they are joining, in one sentence, under the button. Include unsubscribe. Do not buy lists. Do not scrape emails out of comments. That is the whole compliance program for a seven-question scorecard.

What this feeds — and what feeds it

The door is last for a reason. It feeds every other path and it needs one of them first. Friends and DMs are how the first playbooks sell. The door is how strangers join that line. If you build the door first, you have a porch on an empty house.

What must exist

A paid next step, almost always path 1. Optionally a service or a setup if the diagnostic band says person, not file. The sequence should not invent a product you have not shipped.

A skill pack (path 2), a prompt stack (path 3), or a productized service (path 7) can be the paid next step if that is what you actually sell. Pick one. Write it on the sticky note. Test-buy it from a second email before the form goes live.

What the list then feeds

Playbook sales without you DMing.

Later drops (path 17): you can tell a list about a Thursday live without begging the algorithm.

Research briefs, automations, custom projects — only as a reply offer, not as note 1.

A newsletter if you want one. The door can be the same form. The letter is a Tuesday. The door is how they arrived.

A quiet operator group (path 15): you invite people who already shipped, not lurkers who wanted a free PDF.

The list is the asset. Everything else is a later sentence to people who already have a reason to open you.

What the door must never feed

A replica of this suite with your name on it. A free file that is only a sales letter. A purchased list. Those rot. This suite is The Operator Suite. It is not a magnet, not a white-label, not inventory. Your scorecard is the magnet. Your playbook is the house.

Upstream

If you have no playbook, this path is closed. If you have no checkout, this path is closed. If you have never sold to a person who knows you, sell to them first. The door is for strangers. Strangers are later.

Pick one paid next step

The sticky note holds one title and one price. If you have a playbook and a skill pack, the door points at one. The other can wait for a later note, after this sequence ends. One next step. Named. Priced. Live.

Mistakes that kill the door

Buying ads before the sequence exists. A 40-field form. Fake scores. Forgetting the unsubscribe. Those still kill it. The rest, with recovery this week:

1. A PDF that is only a sales letter

Recovery: run the quiet-page test tonight. Delete every paid mention. Rewrite until the free action stands alone. Two to four pages. One action per band. Fairness-test a friend tomorrow.

2. Passing this book off as yours

Selling this book as your own, or giving it away as a magnet with your logo, kills the door and your name. This suite is The Operator Suite. Recovery: delete that file today. Write seven questions for your job. You will be late. You will also still have a name.

3. We will send the file in 24 hours

A drip trick. They already answered. Recovery: put the PDF on the thank-you page tonight, and in the first sentence of note 1. Instant means under two minutes, not someday.

4. Asking for the sale in paragraph one of the free file

Recovery: move the ask to notes 5-7. The PDF keeps the band and the free action. The sticky note keeps the paid thing in the sequence, not on page one.

5. Daily blasts

Recovery: 5-7 notes, then silence until you have something useful. Note 1 instant. Then air. Daily is how you become noise, then a statistic in the unsub column.

6. Questions that always output the same band

Recovery: two fake answer sheets this afternoon. If the band does not change, rewrite three questions. Flattery is not a diagnostic. Do you want to grow is not a question.

7. Sharing on five platforms before you tested delivery

Recovery: one room. Test inbox first. Second Gmail, phone, timer. Two passing runs. Then one share. Platforms two through five wait until strangers finish the form.

8. From-name that looks like a robot

Recovery: your first name, one word. Not MAIL-DAEMON. Not the LLC. A person they will open tomorrow.

9. Tagging architecture that delays launch

Recovery: one sequence for everyone. Mention bands in the PDF. Launch. Tag later if it is easy. Thirty strangers do not need HubSpot.

10. A webinar bolted on because the PDF felt thin

Recovery: the PDF is thin on purpose. Teach in the notes, not on Zoom. Two to four pages, 5-7 notes. If the free action is real, thin is a feature.

If you catch yourself rewriting the PDF to mention the paid file more than the free action, you slipped. Put the paid file back in notes 5-7.

Tools — only what you need

A form, a PDF scorecard, MailerLite or Beehiiv. That is the stack.

The stack

Nothing else is required for v1. Google Docs to write. A form to ask. A list tool to send 5-7 notes and to honor unsubscribe. A checkout you already have from an earlier path. A second email to

test. A phone to open the PDF.

Form

Tally, the Beehiiv form, or MailerLite's. Email required. Seven questions. Thank-you with the file. Tally is the \$0 path if you already have a place to host the PDF. Decline company size, budget, phone, mailing address. First name optional. Privacy line under the button.

PDF

Google Docs export. Two to four pages. Your name, the year, a sentence that the file is free even if they never buy. Print one page. If the margins fail, fix them before you share. Open it on a phone. Filename: job-scorecard-yourname.pdf. No Canva rabbit hole. A cover that states the job is enough.

Sequence

5-7 notes in the same tool. Plain text is fine. No twenty-pixel buttons in every paragraph. From-name is your name. Note 1 is automated on submit. The rest are a simple delay. You do not need a journey builder with twelve branches.

Checkout for the paid next step

Stripe Payment Link or Stan. Test-buy from a second email. The door does not replace this. The door points at it in notes 5-7. If the checkout is not live, the door is closed.

Do not add yet

Do not add a webinar platform, a quiz app with 14 branches, or a CRM. Thirty strangers do not need HubSpot. They need a file and a way out. Do not add a popup that fights the form.

The \$0 path

Google Docs. Tally free. A MailerLite free tier or Beehiiv free tier. Stripe Payment Link for the playbook. That is enough to get the first stranger email. Buy tools after thirty people, not before.

Setup order

Sticky note. Seven questions on paper. Scoring key. PDF in Docs. Fairness test. Export. Form. Connect the list tool. Note 1 delivers the file. Notes 2-7 drafted. Stranger test from a second inbox. Unsubscribe test. Checkout test. Then share once. Do not compare six form builders on Day 1. Write the questions first.

Checklist

Before you write a question

- You finished an earlier path; the paid next step exists
- The paid next step has a live checkout you have test-bought
- Sticky note with the one paid thing the sequence may sell, title and price
- You can name the free action in one sentence
- You are writing your own scorecard, not exporting this suite

Before the form goes live

- Seven questions that change the advice
- Scoring key you can defend to a skeptical friend
- Three bands, not fake precision, not a fake 94
- Two fake answer sheets land in two different bands
- PDF with one free action per band
- PDF still works if every paid mention is deleted
- You did not copy this book into the PDF
- You did not put your name on this book and call it a magnet
- Your name, the year, and free even if you never buy on the PDF
- Filename a human can find; PDF opens on a phone

Before you share

Email required, not 40 fields

First name optional

Privacy line under the button, one sentence

Instant delivery, tested from a second inbox, under two minutes

File is on the thank-you page and in note 1

Unsubscribe works, tested, one click

5-7 notes written before you share widely

Teach first, ask later (notes 5-7)

From-name is a human

Form sits above the paid button

After the first stranger

Shared once where you already help

No ads until the sequence exists

First stranger email treated like a person, one sentence

Spreadsheet: date, source, band, clicks, bought, replied

Drop-off read after ten finishes; one fix, not five

Ads, if any, point at the form, not the paid button

The rule, in one block

This suite is The Operator Suite

You may brand your own scorecard

You may not copy this book, sell it as yours, or give it away as if you wrote it

The public name is a scorecard for a job, with your name, not the name of this book

FAQ

Do I have to use seven questions?

Seven is enough to change advice and short enough to finish on a phone. Five can work. Forty cannot. Default: seven, multiple choice.

What if I do not have a playbook yet?

Do not build the door. Finish path 1, or another path with a named next step. An empty house does not need a nicer porch.

Can I brand the scorecard with my business name?

Yes. You may brand your own scorecard. You may not copy this book, sell it as yours, or give it away as if you wrote it. The public name is [Job] scorecard — [you]. This suite is The Operator Suite. Those are different objects.

Can I give this suite away as my lead magnet?

No. This suite is The Operator Suite. You may not copy this book, sell it as yours, or give it away as if you wrote it. A two-to-four page diagnostic you wrote for one job is the door. This book is not a magnet. If you already exported it with your logo, delete that file today and write seven questions.

MailerLite or Beehiiv?

Whichever you will actually open. Beehiiv if you also want a public letter. MailerLite if you want simple forms. Both handle unsubscribe. Use that feature. Default if you stall: Beehiiv, one form, one sequence.

Should the PDF include my prices?

A line at the end is allowed: If you want the full 10-day file, it lives here. The body of the PDF should still work with that line deleted. That is the quiet-page test. If the PDF collapses without the price, you wrote a brochure.

How fast is instant?

On the thank-you screen and in the first email. Under two minutes in a test inbox. Not check your promotions tab in a few hours while we wait to look hungry.

What is the first sale on this path?

The first email from someone you have never met. Cash from the playbook is path 1 using the door. Count both. Do not pretend the list is failing because the \$29 did not happen on day one.

Can I sell the diagnostic as a \$9 product?

Then it is not this path. This path is a free door. If you want a paid score, that is a small file on another path, and you still need a free door later. Do not charge \$9 and also call it free.

What about GDPR and consent?

Say what they are joining, in one sentence, under the button. Include unsubscribe. Do not buy lists. Do not scrape emails out of comments. That is the whole program for a seven-question scorecard.

When do I add ads?

After the sequence exists, delivery works, and a handful of strangers have finished the form. Until then you are paying to learn that your PDF is a flyer. Send ads to the form, never to the paid button. If \$80 bought you four emails, the room you already help was cheaper. Stop. Fix the door.

Can I use a Typeform quiz with 14 branches?

You can. You should not, for v1. Seven questions, one sequence. Branches are how you never launch. Tag bands later if it is easy. Do not delay the stranger test for a branching tree.

How long should the PDF be?

Two to four pages. If you need eight, you are writing a playbook. Sell that. Do not give a playbook away as a scorecard and then wonder why nobody buys the playbook.

Can I send the sequence from Gmail?

Not if you want unsubscribe and a straight face. Use a real tool. The \$0 tiers exist. From-name is still your first name. The tool is what makes leave in one click true.